

A NOVEL

THE TRANSLATOR

ANUVADAK



GAJENDRA THAKUR

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Author: Gajendra Thakur

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CHAPTER I

MITHILA'S TRANSLATOR

In that village in Mithila, where the first sound of dawn rose not from a dog's bark but from the faint tremor of water placed on the tulsi altar, Shashank Jha was spending his final night. At daybreak he had a train to Delhi. The villagers said his studies were finished; now he would look for a road to a livelihood. But within himself Shashank knew he was not going merely in search of work. He was going in search of language - and, with language, a new grammar for his fate.

He had graduated in the Navya-Nyaya of Gangesha Upadhyaya. His teachers said Shashank possessed a subtle mind. He did not merely hear a sentence; he opened it up. Within a statement he could distinguish subject, object, qualifier, delimitor, relation, absence, and expectancy. Once the village pandit had laughed and said, 'This boy does not look at the body of a statement; he counts its bones.'

But counting bones does not fill a stomach. His father carried an old debt, the roof of the house leaked in the rains, and there was the fear that his younger sister's education might stop. Shashank had a degree, but in Delhi's marketplace language carried more currency than certificates. One day he saw a notice: Chinese-speaking translator wanted; work in the National Capital Region. His eyes caught on that line and would not move.

China, to him, had been a history book, reports from the border, and the cardboard box of some cheap machine. But the thought that thousands of Chinese people might be living around Delhi, speaking their own language in factories, restaurants, offices, markets, and homes, opened a new city inside him.

His mother asked, 'What will you do in Delhi?'

'Translate,' Shashank said.

'Translate whom?'

'Those who do not understand. Those who understand but cannot say it. And those who speak but are hiding something, too.'

His mother did not understand the last sentence. Shashank did not fully understand it either. But a student of Navya-Nyaya knew that every human sentence travels on two planes: what has been said, and the context constructed to make that saying possible. Perhaps his work in Delhi would be to join those two planes.

That night he set three books apart: his notes on the Tattvachintamani, a beginner's Chinese conversation book, and a cheap notebook in which was written: No inference without perception. His teacher had given him the line, but Shashank turned it into a maxim for earning his living. First see, then connect. First the word, then the intent. First the person, then the desire.

At dawn, when he reached the station to catch the train, two or three young men from the village teased him. 'Going to become Chinese?' Shashank laughed it off, but somewhere inside, it hurt. When one is poor, even the act of dreaming becomes other people's amusement. He thought to himself: one day they will hear that Shashank Jha speaks to Chinese people in Delhi in their own language. One day his voice will no longer be a translation, but a door.

The first direct shock on reaching Delhi was language. On the platform, tongues seemed to cut across one another and race away like strips of iron. Bhojpuri, Punjabi, Haryanvi, English, broken Hindi, the sharp rush of Chinese over telephones - all at once. For the first time Shashank understood that language was not only words. It was gait, the tilt of a neck, the pause in a pair of eyes, and the length of a silence.

He lodged in a cheap room in Paharganj. By day, notices for work; in the evening, railway routes; at night, books. Within a few days he understood that Chinese could not come to him from paper alone. It needed a throat, breath, friction with living people. Then he heard of a short course at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. It followed a three-book method: sound, sentence, conduct. His hand trembled as he paid the fee, but he told himself: this is not an expense; it is the first investment in evidence.

In class, the teacher said, 'In Chinese, if the tone changes, the meaning changes.' Shashank did not laugh. Navya-Nyaya had already taught him that when the delimitor changes, the object itself changes. Chinese tone and Mithila's logic seemed like unsuspected relatives.

Three weeks later he went to the Red Fort. Among the tourists he began looking for Chinese faces. At first he hesitated. Then he approached a family and said, 'Hello. Do you need any help?' His Chinese pronunciation was incomplete, but his smile was genuine. The child laughed; the father answered slowly. Shashank understood half and inferred the rest. At the end of the day there were two hundred rupees in his pocket and ten new words in his mind.

That afternoon at the Red Fort brought him his first lesson: translation is not a trade in words; it is the beginning of trust. The person who gives you his language also gives you his vulnerability. That vulnerability can be protected. It can also be sold.

A Chinese student gave him the address of the Tao temple in Pitampura. The temple was small, but inside were incense, wood, the muted sound of a bell, and characters written across the walls. It was there that he met Juliana. She was the principal practitioner; in her eyes was the stern stillness of a teacher.

After listening to his pronunciation, Juliana said, 'You are learning words, not breath.'

Shashank flushed. 'How does one learn breath?'

'First give up haste,' she said. 'Language does not come by being seized. It comes when you make room for it.'

The sentence stayed inside Shashank. Navya-Nyaya had taught him how to seize; Juliana began to teach him how to let go. Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan by day, the Red Fort in the evening, the Tao temple on weekends. Slowly, his tongue began to catch the tones. The directness of standard Chinese, the rise and fall of the speech of Canton, the politics of greeting, the dignity of silence - he wrote it all down.

One night, back in his room, he wrote in the notebook: 'Words are evidence, but the speaker is part of the evidence too.' Then he stopped. The sentence was beautiful, and beautiful sentences are dangerous. They feel like truth, even when they are only half true.

Delhi was still innocent to him. He did not know that behind the gleaming gates of Noida's companies ran dark corridors of small repair contracts, cash payments, calls from gangsters, foreign vendors, live-gambling systems, other people's accounts, hawala, and clandestine currency exchange. He did not know that one day, with the edge of his logic, he would learn the art of throwing dust into the eyes of the law.

That night there was only this: a young man of Mithila, three books, a handful of Chinese words, and the door of a future that, once opened, shows a person his true shape.

Shashank turned off the light. Outside, Delhi was awake. Inside, Gangesha's method and the tones of Chinese touched hands for the first time.

CHAPTER 2

THE LESSON OF THREE BOOKS

To Shashank, the classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan was less a schoolroom than a laboratory. A long table ran through its centre, a blackboard stood at the front, and an alphabet chart was pasted to the wall. The teacher opened each sound slowly, as though an invisible instrument had been placed inside the throat. Shashank sat in the first row, pen poised, eyes steady.

The first book was about sound. From the very beginning it broke Shashank's pride. In Maithili he could hear the slightest curve of a vowel; in Sanskrit sutras he knew the distinction between long and short; but Chinese tone commanded him to step back and look again. The same sound rising meant one thing, falling another, bending and returning a third. A word ceased to be a fixed substance before him; it became movement.

He wrote: 'Tone is a delimiter.' Then it occurred to him that this was not merely linguistics but a rule of life. A person says the same thing, yet change the tone and the intention changes. In courtroom testimony, in bargaining at a market, in a friend's promise, in an enemy's threat - tone, too, has its own law.

The second book was about sentences. It contained brief exchanges: asking the way, asking a price, ordering food, telling the time, introducing oneself. His classmates memorised words; Shashank memorised situations. When saying which sentence should one meet another person's eyes? Where should one bow? Where should one remain silent? He began to understand that a translator stands not merely between two languages, but between two kinds of reserve.

When the class ended, he remained standing beside the teacher. 'If the words are right but the feeling is different, what should a translator do?'

The teacher smiled. 'Then you are not a servant of words, but a servant of context. But be careful: do not add falsehood in the name of context.'

That day the sentence rose to the head of his notes: servant of context, not an author of falsehood. Shashank did not know that later in life this line would stand as a witness against him.

The third book was about conduct. Courtesy in a dining room, forms of address in business, respect for elders, distance with strangers, the rhythm of a bargain. In this book there was less language and more of the human being. One lesson said that custom required a gift to be refused twice before it was accepted. Shashank thought how often civilisation dresses desire in a veil.

After evening fell, he left the class and caught the bus to Mandi House. Beyond the window, Delhi's dust, smoke, lights and crowds streamed past. The teacher's voice echoed in his ears: rising, falling, level, turning. He listened to the speech of the passengers and drew its tonal map in his mind. The insistence of the paan seller, the policeman's command, the student's laughter, the tired woman's silence - each travelled carrying a different meaning.

At night in his room he opened all three books and arranged them in order. First sound, then sentence, then conduct. His training in Navya-Nyaya had taught him to ask for the sequence of evidence in every lesson. Sound was perception, sentence was testimony, conduct was inference. If all three agreed with one another, meaning became stable. If there was a gap anywhere, there was doubt.

A few weeks later, a Chinese guest came to the class. He did business in India. The teacher asked Shashank to give a brief introduction. Shashank rose. His palms were damp, but his voice was steady. He gave his name, his village in Mithila, his studies, and his reason for learning the language in Delhi. The guest listened closely and asked, 'How long have you been learning?'

Shashank answered. The guest did not laugh. He said, 'You know few words, but you listen well.'

To Shashank, this praise was worth no less than money. In that moment he understood that the first virtue in learning a language is not speaking but listening. One who can listen will, one day, learn to speak as well. But one who only wants to talk is not a translator; he is a caller in the marketplace.

Outside the classroom his classmates gathered around him. Someone asked, 'How did you pick it up so quickly?' Shashank said simply, 'Do not catch the words. Catch the reason for the words.' Everyone laughed. He remembered the village pandit again. The boy who counted the bones of a statement would remain the same in Delhi.

That night he decided to go to the Red Fort. A language learned from books is like a lamp made of glass: it shines beautifully, but the first gust can put it out. He needed wind. Living people, living errors, living embarrassment.

The following Sunday he stood on the outer road by the Red Fort. Tourists with cameras hanging from their necks, children selling flags, food carts, police, sunlight, dust, and the red walls of history. He kept watching the Chinese groups. He approached the first group, but the words lodged in his throat. The second group moved on. The third time he remembered his teacher's sentence: abandon haste; give space.

He made a gentle gesture of greeting and said in Chinese, 'Would you like a guide?' An elderly man looked at him. A woman smiled. A teenager raised his phone as though he wanted to record Shashank's pronunciation. Shashank's ears burned, but he stood his ground.

The elderly man asked a simple question. Shashank understood half of it. What he did not understand, he asked the man to repeat. That request was his first victory. Earlier he would have filled an empty space with inference; now he accepted the empty space. Navya-Nyaya says that to admit doubt is not an insult to knowledge; it is its beginning.

By noon he had walked with three groups. The Red Fort had been familiar to him before, but today he saw it through a translator's eyes. Shah Jahan, the Diwan, cannons, the flag, independence, empire - searching for a Chinese equivalent for each word, he saw that history too changes in translation. One country's pride can become another country's question.

As the day declined, a Chinese student gave him the address of the Tao temple in Pitampura. 'Juliana is there,' the student said. 'She does not teach language as if it were only words.'

Shashank wrote the address on a piece of paper. He did not know that the woman bearing that name would try to correct his ambition more than his tongue. Nor did he know that an ambition refined, if joined to greed, ceases to be an instrument and becomes a weapon.

That night he opened the three books again. Sound, sentence, conduct. At the top of the page he wrote: 'A translator's sin is born not in words, but in purpose.' Then he stared at the sentence for a long time. Outside was the city's clamour. Inside, meaning was slowly spreading its limbs.

CHAPTER 3

MITHILA TO DELHI 3

The lesson of the three books was settling onto Shashank's tongue, but in Delhi the pocket is examined before the tongue. The last week of the month had arrived. The rent on his Paharganj room was still unpaid, the next fee at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan stood before him, and whatever he earned from two or four days of guiding at the Red Fort dissolved into bus fares and food. At night he began writing accounts in his notebook beside his Chinese words. The language of numbers was simple: more was going out than coming in.

After class that day he noticed a small sheet of paper pinned to the notice board: young man wanted with elementary knowledge of Chinese; work would involve understanding documents, speaking on the telephone, and clarifying payment-related terms. The pay was almost three times what he made from a day's guiding. Shashank did not tear down the notice; he merely copied the telephone number into his notebook. The student inside him asked, What kind of work is it? Hunger answered, Go and see first.

The next afternoon he reached a small office. The nameplate was plain. Inside were two desks, a computer, a printer, and bundles of paper. An Indian young man asked him to sit. After a while a Chinese man joined them on speakerphone. He spoke rapidly; Shashank caught half, and for the other half asked him to repeat himself. By now such requests were no longer a source of embarrassment. They had become method.

The questions began like ordinary questions of trade - where the payment would arrive, through which channel, why the account bore a different name, and what name would appear on the receipt. From time to time the Indian young man said, 'You only explain the language. We will look after the accounts.' Shashank kept listening.

On a sheet lying on the desk, arrows had been drawn. Money moved from the customer first into a payment gateway, from there into several small accounts, then into cash or another channel. Some of the accounts were not in the office's name. At one point the word 'wallet' appeared, at another 'exchange', at a third yet another wallet. Shashank's eyes began, by instinct, to look for sequence.

'Do all these accounts belong to the company?' he asked.

The Indian young man laughed. 'They belong to people who work with us. Every business needs convenience.'

'Who is the real owner of the money?'

For a moment the young man's laughter stopped. 'Are you a translator or an auditor?'

Shashank fell silent. His question proved no crime; the answer proved no innocence either. In Navya-Nyaya, doubt has its proper place. What was directly present was only this much: the paper showed accounts under different names; it showed money travelling from one place to another; the name of the true beneficiary was not clear. Everything beyond that was inference.

The Chinese man on the phone asked about a term the Indian side was calling a 'mule account'. Shashank hesitated for a moment, then explained it in simple language: an account held in one person's name but used to move another person's money. As he gave the definition, his own voice sounded strange to him. A word itself was innocent; its moral weight came from the purpose to which it was put.

Then came 'payment gateway'. Shashank called it a payment door - the technical channel through which a customer's payment reaches a merchant. After that came the word 'hawala'. This time he was more careful. He described it as an old system in which money handed over in one place is matched by an equivalent payment elsewhere through a chain of trust outside formal banking routes. Finally a question arose about 'layering' in cryptocurrency. He said the term could mean moving funds through a succession of digital wallets and exchange points in order to obscure their source. He placed particular stress on 'could mean'. It was not his task to declare a crime merely from seeing a sheet of paper.

The Indian young man grew irritated. 'Why all this caution? Just translate it directly.'

Inside Shashank rose his teacher's sentence from the classroom - a servant of context, not an author of falsehood. He said, 'A direct word is possible. But where the meaning is uncertain, the mark of uncertainty has to remain.'

'The client wants work, not marks.'

The sentence was brief, but something fell away inside Shashank. For the first time in Delhi he understood that a translator's gift did not merely open language; sometimes it could make a curtain. If a 'borrowed account'

became a 'convenience account', if 'obscuring the source' became 'fund management', the facts did not change - but the listener's mind could.

Just then the office door opened and a young man came in. He was thin, with an old shoulder bag and the alertness in his eyes by which one Maithil abroad can recognize another from a distance. He had come to collect some papers from the Indian young man. Hearing Shashank's accent, he stopped.

'Are you from Mithila?'

For the first time in that office, Shashank relaxed. 'Yes.'

'Where from?'

Within a few sentences they had exchanged villages, studies, and the story of his coming to Delhi to learn the language. The young man said his name was Mrinal Karna. In Delhi he did whatever work came his way with small offices - accounts and papers, computers, a little help with translation. He had no permanent job either, but he understood the city's gair better than Shashank did.

Mrinal saw the diagram of arrows on the table. The smile faded from his face. He did not pick up the sheet; he looked at it only from a distance. 'Is this your work?'

The Indian young man cut in. 'He's the translator. He's only explaining the words.'

Mrinal looked at Shashank. 'Explaining words is fine. But don't put your name on any of these papers. Don't sign blank paper. And don't let them use your bank account either.'

The office suddenly filled with silence. In a hard voice the Indian young man said, 'Nobody asked you for advice.'

Mrinal remained calm. 'Nobody did. But I heard Maithili, so I said it.'

Two impulses stood facing each other inside Shashank. One said: take the money, stop asking questions; you are not the criminal, only the translator. The other said: when you can see a link, to deny its existence is itself a kind of statement. In Navya-Nyaya, proof of what is absent may come later; for now, preserve the limits of what is present.

He asked the Indian young man, 'Will I have, in writing, only the work of translation? No payment will pass through my account?'

The young man said, 'It's difficult to work with a man who has so many rules.'

'Then let it remain difficult.' Shashank's voice was not very loud, but for the first time it sounded separate from his hunger.

He got up and left. Half a day was gone, and he received no payment. The moment he stepped outside, his decision felt less like courage than stupidity. There was little money in his pocket even for the bus; the room rent was unpaid. Standing by the roadside, he wondered how long principles last on an empty stomach.

Mrinal came out behind him. 'Tea?'

Shashank wanted to refuse, but without waiting for an answer Mrinal walked toward a nearby stall. Two small glasses arrived. In the steam of the hot tea, Shashank's humiliation slowly softened.

Mrinal asked, 'You've studied Navya-Nyaya, haven't you? I can tell from the way you speak.'

Shashank was startled. 'How?'

'You state the boundary more than the answer - this was seen, this was not; this was said, this is not proved. Ordinary people do not make so many distinctions.'

For the first time, Shashank laughed openly. 'People in the village used to make fun of me for that habit.'

'In Delhi that habit will sometimes save you and sometimes trap you.' Mrinal blew across his tea. 'Here people make the story before they have the evidence. Police, client, proprietor, neighbour - everyone makes his own story. If you do not keep apart what you actually saw, someone else's story will climb onto your head.'

Shashank's ear caught on the word 'story'. In the school of Navya-Nyaya, he had practised keeping fact apart from assertion; Delhi was beginning to show him that a person's reputation, too, could be made or unmade by the force of a statement.

Mrinal told him that it was not right to see an unusual chain of payment and instantly call it a crime. A small trader's circumstances, inconvenience, difficulty with foreign payments - there could be many reasons. But if the names on the accounts, the true owner of the money, and its purpose were deliberately kept obscure, caution was necessary. 'An accusation is one thing, suspicion another, evidence a third,' he said. 'Mix the three, and the innocent will be trapped while the guilty get away.'

Shashank looked at him closely. This young man was no student of jurisprudence, yet life had taught him the same distinctions. Friendship sometimes begins not with the length of an acquaintance, but with the trustworthiness of a single sentence.

Mrinal took money from his pocket for two bus tickets. Shashank stopped him at once. 'No. I have enough.'

'All right. Then tomorrow the tea is on you.'

There was no humiliation of charity in that small sentence, only a proposal of equality. Shashank accepted the money. In that moment he felt that for the first time in Delhi someone had looked at him not as a poor student but as a human being with possibilities.

They walked together along the road. Mrinal asked why he was learning Chinese. At first Shashank gave the ordinary answer - for work. Then, after a while, he said, 'Language narrows the distance between people. And when the distance narrows, you can also see what they are hiding.'

Mrinal smiled. 'Then be careful. People do not like the person who sees what they have hidden.'

That night, in his room, Shashank opened his notebook beside the three books. Today he wrote fewer Chinese words and more distinctions:

Perception - accounts under different names; several stages in the payment chain; the true beneficiary unclear.

Inference - accounts in other people's names could be used to move money.

Accusation - illegal movement of funds. As yet unproved.

Possibility of false accusation - to see only a complex payment arrangement and call it a crime.

Established fact - today, only this much: the office papers showed an opaque structure, and Shashank left the work and walked out.

Beneath the final line he wrote one name - Mrinal Karna. Then he wrote nothing beside it. Friendship belonged to no category of proof; it would be wrong to imprison it inside a definition.

After a while his eyes returned to the word 'layering'. Layer upon layer, laid down to hide the source of money. Suddenly he felt that human beings did much the same - hunger under ambition, ambition under argument, argument under language, language under courtesy. In the end it became difficult to know where the original desire lay.

He closed the notebook. Today he had stepped away from suspicious work; that did not make him pure. On the contrary, for the first time he understood that such structures existed, and that language could become a means of entry into them. Knowledge itself was not a fall, but the road toward falling was no longer misted over before him.

Outside, Delhi's night was awake again. Footsteps sounded beyond the door of the room, a vehicle horn somewhere in the distance, the steady burr of the fan overhead. Before turning out the light, Shashank remembered his teacher's sentence - a servant of context, not an author of falsehood.

Beside it, tonight, came Mrinal's sentence - accusation apart, suspicion apart, evidence apart.

Between those two sentences Shashank's Delhi was slowly taking shape. For now, friendship was saving him. Later, that same friendship would question him, restrain him, and perhaps become as hard as enmity on the day Shashank himself began to change the meanings of his own words.

CHAPTER 4

MITHILA TO DELHI 4

The following day, to repay his debt of tea to Mrinal, Shashank himself took him to a roadside stall near Mandi House. They were standing with glasses in their hands when Shashank's phone rang. It was a message from a teacher he knew at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: three days of language assistance were required - foreign travel, a business meeting in Macao, and translation between the Chinese and Indian sides during a computer presentation. The fee was large enough for Shashank to read the message twice.

Mrinal looked at his face and asked, 'What happened?'

Shashank held out the phone. Mrinal read the entire message, then said, 'Do not decide after looking at the fee. Ask for the scope of the work in writing.'

Shashank liked the sentence, but another voice had already awakened inside him. The afternoon at the Red Fort, the cheap room, the unpaid balance, the old debt at home - all of that lay on one side; on the other were an airline ticket, Macao, three days' pay, and the prestige concealed inside the words a translator who travels abroad. It was not merely greed for money. It was greed for visible proof of his own importance.

He replied: Send the written description of the work. Within two hours a single page arrived. Language assistance; product presentation; questions and answers; limited test access; no receipt, remittance, or operation of any client's money or accounts. Travel and accommodation were the organiser's responsibility. Shashank read the page three times. The words were clear. He remembered the earlier sheet with its ambiguous arrows. Here, at least, the boundary had been written down.

He already had a passport. In his final year as an undergraduate, a teacher in the department had told him that someone who studied languages might one day have the chance to travel abroad; he had obtained it in that hope. Then the document had been only a possibility. Now, for the first time, it was about to be used.

Mrinal read the written description again. 'What is on this page is directly given,' he said. 'Do not turn what is not here into imagination. But wherever you go, remember your boundary.'

Shashank laughed. 'You are becoming my guru.'

'No. Your gurus are in your village and your books. I only point out the potholes in Delhi.'

Three days later, looking through the aircraft window as Delhi blurred below, Shashank felt an unfamiliar calm. It was his first journey abroad. The plane kept climbing, and it seemed to him that the village, the station, the room in Paharganj, the Red Fort - all of them had become small points on the same map. When a human being rises higher, distance does not diminish; only his gaze begins to imagine itself vast.

In Macao the organisers lodged him in a guest house. The bed, the white sheets, the gleam of the bathroom, fruit on the table, the flood of light beyond the window - everything was utterly unlike his life in Delhi. He set his bag on a chair and stood for a long time looking at his reflection in the glass. The clothes were the same, the face the same; yet the moment the place changed, a man began to feel that his value had changed as well.

The evening meeting was small: a Chinese coordinator, two technical employees, an Indian intermediary, and Shashank. After the introductions, his task was stated clearly - explain the Chinese terms used in the presentation, carry the Indian side's questions across, and suggest linguistic equivalents wherever the wording in the test system was unclear.

At one end of the table a computer was opened. The coordinator gave him a temporary access credential and said it would remain active only for the duration of the demonstration. On the first page of his notebook Shashank wrote: 'Limited, authorised access.' Writing down the boundary of a word had become a new habit with him.

The screen contained many fields - customer, merchant, payment, settlement, region, language, wallet, support. Some terms were familiar, others technical. Shashank asked their meanings one by one. The coordinator kept explaining, and for the Indian side Shashank formed plain Hindi-English equivalents rather than Maithili ones. Yet in his mind he broke everything down again in his own language: who would give the money, who would receive it, what institution stood between them, and in what form the record would remain.

On one page several merchant identifiers appeared together. Another showed markers for different regions. A third showed categories of settlement. Shashank asked, 'Is this real data, or demonstration material?'

The technical employee answered, 'Mixed material for demonstration.'

That answer, too, was not entirely clear. 'Mixed' could mean that some of it was real and some of it sample material; or it could mean only a variety of samples. In his mind Shashank drew a boundary. Perception: several

identifiers were visible on the screen. Inference: the system might be arranged for several commercial entities at once. Established fact: at present, only a demonstration was taking place.

The coordinator, noticing his caution, smiled. 'You ask a great many questions.'

Shashank said, 'One false certainty in translation can do more harm than ten wrong words.'

In the second part of the meeting he was asked to check terminology through the test access. He looked at the prescribed pages. Then, at the side of the screen, a report icon flashed. He did not need that page for the translation. But the access credential did not stop him.

For a few moments he remained still. Juliana's voice returned to him: language does not come by being seized; it comes when you make room for it. Mrinal's voice too: remember your boundary. Then a third voice rose: What harm can there be in merely looking? Knowledge itself is no crime.

Shashank opened the report page.

There, line after line, were times, amounts, merchant identifiers, region codes, and settlement status. The numbers were far larger than he had expected. He changed no row, copied down no detail, made no duplicate. But he saw what he had not needed to see. In that small act, for the first time, his curiosity crossed the written boundary of his work.

He closed the page and returned to the original presentation. No one said anything. It was possible that the organisers had no objection to his viewing an additional page; it was equally possible that the access had been broader than intended because of a technical oversight. Which was true, he did not know. What was directly given was only this: the page opened, he looked, and then he closed it.

When the meeting ended, the Indian intermediary informed him that the advance portion of his fee had been released. The sum was larger than many weeks of Shashank's earnings in Delhi. His first thought was to send money home. His second was to clear the balance on his room. His third made him ashamed of himself: to buy a good pen - the sort of pen which, when placed on a table, made people understand that this man was not an ordinary translator hired by the day.

Greed was not as simple as saying: I want money. Hunger, humiliation, responsibility toward his family, and the desire for social regard were wound around one another inside it. If he sent the entire advance home, would that make him self-sacrificing? If he kept something for himself, selfish? Navya-Nyaya would laugh at such moral naming. Separate the limits of each cause; only then decide.

Dinner that night was lavish. Many dishes, glittering glass, soft music, courteous attendants. Shashank did not know the names of half the food, but at the table his Chinese pronunciation drew everyone's attention. The coordinator praised him twice. The Indian intermediary said, 'If you know a language like this, why keep running after small jobs in Delhi? Stay with important people.'

The sentence entered Shashank more deeply than any threat could have done. Stay with important people. In the village, people had seen his poverty; in Delhi, now and then, someone had seen his talent; here, for the first time, wealthy people were judging that talent worthy of their table. The line between being respected and being useful is exceedingly fine.

After dinner he called Mrinal. Mrinal asked, 'Is the work clean?'

Shashank said, 'It is a presentation. Technical terminology. There are some payment-related sections too, but I am only handling the language.'

'You have access?'

Shashank was silent for a moment. 'Yes. For the demonstration.'

'Within the boundary?'

At that question Shashank's eyes settled on the lights outside the window. He could easily have said: I also looked at one additional report page. Instead he said, 'Nothing unusual.'

The sentence was not wholly false. He had directly seen no crime. But neither was it the whole truth. He concealed one part of what he had seen because he did not want the next questions that would rise after Mrinal's. Here, for the first time, Shashank understood that a translator does not only shorten or enlarge other people's sentences; a human being translates his own life through selection as well.

At the next day's meeting, terms such as 'settlement route', 'secondary wallet', and 'alternative channel' appeared. Shashank gave their ordinary commercial meanings. He did not add a criminal meaning, because there was no evidence for one. Yet he remembered the first page with arrows on it. The same words do not prove the same crime. Analogy is not proof; it is an indication. For the moment his governing category was perception, and therefore he would hold only to what he had seen.

At the end of the meeting the coordinator said there might be remote translation work for him in the future as well. The fee would be far higher than what ordinary guiding in Delhi paid. Without much thought Shashank said, 'If I can make the time, I will.' His voice sounded disconcertingly easy as he answered.

Before returning to Delhi, he sent a large part of the advance home. His mother called. The roof could be repaired; his sister's fees would not have to stop. Hearing this, Shashank felt his heart grow light. In that moment

his journey to Macao seemed entirely justified. For the first time he understood how difficult it is to question the source of money when that money lessens suffering at home.

With what remained he bought a good pen. It was not very expensive, but many times better than the cheap one he had used before. Opening the box, he ran a finger along the nib. He laughed at himself. Foreign travel, computer access, a large payment - and in the end a human being's greed could take the shape of a pen.

Back in Delhi, Mrinal met him near the bus stand. 'Foreign gentleman,' he said with a smile.

Shashank did not show him the pen. He said only, 'The tea is on me.'

The two sat by the stall. Mrinal did not ask many questions about Macao. His silence was a relief to Shashank, and also a discomfort. Before a friend who does not question you, the weight of your own answers becomes more audible.

That night in his room Shashank opened his notebook. His handwriting was more orderly than before:

Perception - a written scope for language work; authorised temporary access; several merchant identifiers; terminology relating to payment and settlement; one report page outside the assigned task, which the access credential allowed him to open.

Inference - the system might be connected with payment arrangements for several commercial entities and several regions.

Allegation - an illegal flow of money or a structure connected with crime. At present, not established on any basis.

Potential false allegation - merely seeing a foreign server, several account identifiers, wallets, or a complex settlement structure and taking that, by itself, as proof of crime.

Established fact - Shashank had been given limited access; he had also viewed a page that was not necessary for his immediate translation work; while speaking with Mrinal, he had not mentioned this part.

His hand stopped as he wrote that last line. In the previous episode, established fact had concerned the outside office. Here, for the first time, established fact concerned Shashank's own conduct. The edge of evidence was slowly turning from the world outside toward the world within.

He capped the pen. The new pen's cap gleamed incongruously against the old notebook. He understood that he was not yet inside a crime. He understood too that, for the first time, he had failed to tell the whole truth for his own convenience. A fall is rarely made by one great leap; it is built by the repetition of small choices.

Outside, Delhi's night was the same, but the room now seemed smaller than before. The lights of Macao remained in his eyes. Once his hunger had been for a livelihood; now he saw that respect, travel, high fees, and special access could become hungers too.

Gangesha's doctrine of perception had taught him: keep what you have seen separate from what you infer. The human difficulty, however, is deciding which of the things one has seen one will write down, which one will speak, and which one will hide. No book teaches the jurisprudence of that selection in full.

Shashank put out the light. In the darkness, the metal of the new pen glinted for a moment and then disappeared. One new sentence remained inside him: greed is not the name of money; greed is the moment when a human being begins to rewrite the meaning of his own boundaries for his own convenience.

CHAPTER 5

MITHILA TO DELHI 5

Three days after returning from Macao, Shashank's life slipped back into Delhi's old rhythm—the classes at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, afternoons at the Red Fort, the room in Paharganj, tea with Mrinal. Yet a small change had settled inside him. The young man who had once merely imagined foreign travel now knew its taste. The fee that had once seemed impossible had become, in memory, an actual number.

The new pen lay on his table. It was no longer merely an object; it was a small proof of Macao's brightness. Whenever Shashank took it in his hand, he remembered a sentence he himself had written: greed is the moment when a man begins to rewrite the meaning of his limits for his own convenience.

That afternoon a message arrived from the Indian intermediary. Two hours of linguistic assistance were required at a lawyer's office in Delhi. A few Chinese emails, a service agreement, and some payment-related annexures had to be read. At the end of the message were the words: 'confidential legal consultation.' The fee, once again, was higher than ordinary translation work.

Shashank read the message and looked first at the amount, then at the word 'confidential.' The order irritated him. Meaning should have come first, not price. But the mind's eye does not always obey the rules of books.

He told Mrinal, 'There is some work at a lawyer's office.'

Mrinal asked, 'Is the boundary in writing?'

'Yes. Translation only.'

'Then do only the translation.'

Mrinal's answer was brief. Shashank did not like its brevity. He felt that his friend now drew an invisible line around every piece of work he undertook. Then he understood: it was not Mrinal who had drawn the line. The last experience had.

The office was on the third floor of an old building in Connaught Place. A small brass plaque outside read: 'Raghav Bhasin, Advocate.' Inside, glass-fronted shelves held thick books, files, and bound collections of judgments. The young man behind the reception desk asked Shashank's name and led him into a small conference room.

Raghav Bhasin was around forty-five, a man with a composed face and a quiet voice. After the introductions he said plainly, 'I do not understand Chinese. I do not want the shine of words; I want the boundary of meaning. If the source is ambiguous, say it is ambiguous. Do not add inference to the translation.'

The sentence lightened something in Shashank. He remembered his teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan—the translator is the servant of context, not the author of falsehood. Shashank uncapped the new pen.

The first document on the table was a service agreement. The Chinese text lay beside an English draft. Raghav said he wanted only to know whether the two matched. Shashank began reading line by line. Most of it was ordinary: technical assistance, timelines, fees, scope of service, liability. In a few places, the Chinese sentence was broader than the English draft.

In one clause the Chinese text said 'associated payment channels,' while the English draft said only 'payment channel.' Shashank stopped.

Raghav asked, 'Difference?'

Shashank said, 'The Chinese sentence clearly allows for more than one channel. That breadth has been compressed in the English.'

Raghav marked the passage with a red pencil. 'Write what is there. Neither less nor more.'

The second document was a chain of emails. Senders' names were abbreviated; in some places recipients appeared only as initials. Shashank's task was to render the meaning of the messages, not identify the people. He stated that limit himself. Raghav agreed.

One message said that settlement of the 'secondary wallet' should be held until the next cycle. Shashank's mind went at once to the screen in Macao where he had seen the words 'secondary wallet.' A faint shiver passed through him. The same words. The same field. Perhaps the same people? The horse of inference broke loose in his mind.

But in the margin of his notebook he wrote: 'Same words do not establish the same source.' Then he gave Raghav only the literal meaning.

In the middle of the meeting a Chinese representative joined by video. His speech was rapid, his accent marked by a southern cadence. Shashank's ears sharpened. The representative objected to one sentence. He insisted that instead of 'be held,' they should write 'be adjusted'; the latter sounded softer in the language of business.

Shashank read the source again. The verb there plainly meant 'to hold' or 'to stop.'

The representative said, 'The meaning is almost the same.'

Shashank replied, 'Almost the same and the same are not the same.'

For a few moments the room was silent. Raghav looked at Shashank, then said to the representative, 'If you want the source changed, change the source. The translator will not change it.'

The sentence went deep into Shashank. Raghav had protected him just then. But Shashank saw something else as well: how greatly the force of a document could shift with the alteration of a single word. In law, words were not merely letters; they were bricks out of which boundaries, liabilities, and later arguments were built.

The next file bore the words 'LEGALLY CONFIDENTIAL' in bold. Inside were several business messages, several questions put to lawyers, and several replies. Shashank asked, 'Is all of this the same kind of confidential material?'

Raghav leaned back in his chair. 'No. Writing confidential on a paper does not magically change its nature. A communication seeking legal advice from a lawyer is one thing; an ordinary commercial account is another. My job here is to classify, not to put a cloak over it.'

Shashank listened carefully. Here, for the first time, fear took a clear shape in his mind. Until now he had kept complex payments, other people's accounts, servers, wallets—all of it—at a distance by treating them as technical or commercial terms. In a lawyer's room he began to understand that people could build many coverings of names around the same fact—advice, confidentiality, service, intermediation, testing. A name did not take the place of truth.

Raghav pushed a page towards him. 'I want a word-for-word rendering of this passage.'

The Chinese message was brief. It said: close the old access list, send the new list separately, and once the testing period ends, deactivate the temporary credentials. From a technical standpoint, it could also have been an ordinary security procedure. Shashank translated it. Yet his mind ran again at the words 'send separately'—why separately? Separate from whom? Was something being hidden?

He stopped himself. Perception contained only an instruction. Purpose was inference. An accusation of crime lay much farther away. He told Raghav, 'The words are clear; the reason is not given in the text.'

Raghav nodded. 'Good. If there is no reason, do not write one.'

The afternoon wore on. At one point the representative sent Shashank a private message: 'If you work with us regularly in future, learn to smooth sentences like these into the language of business.' A laughing emoji stood at the end.

Shashank did not answer for a long while. There was no threat in the offer. There was familiarity in it. Regular work, better fees, the possibility of travel abroad. Fear is a strange thing: sometimes it is born not from a raised voice, but from a gentle offer. A man understands that if he accepts, his boundary will slowly begin to change in his own language.

At last he wrote: 'I can make the language natural without changing the meaning of the source.'

The reply came: 'I understand.'

Shashank could not tell what, exactly, the man on the other side had understood.

When the meeting ended, Raghav looked through Shashank's translation. In two places there were question marks; in four, notes on literal differences; in one, the words 'source ambiguous.' He said, 'A good translator is not one who makes every sentence beautiful. A good translator is one who can leave an ugly ambiguity ugly—and ambiguous.'

Shashank smiled. 'A beautiful sentence can often make half a truth look like a whole truth.'

Raghav looked at him. 'Remember that. In court, the source matters more than the beauty of the sentence.'

As soon as he left the office, Shashank felt a heaviness in his steps. He had found no evidence of a crime. No one had compelled him to write a falsehood. On the contrary, twice the lawyer had stopped the discussion in defence of the original meaning. Why, then, the fear?

The fear came from what Shashank was beginning to see: how narrow the space was between language, commerce, and law. The softening of a word, the absence of a line, the heading of a classification—later, each could acquire enormous meaning. His gift, which until now had been a means of earning a living, might one day become someone else's shield.

Mrinal met him that evening. Shashank did not tell him the name of the office; the work was confidential. He said only, 'It was translation work for a lawyer.'

Mrinal set his glass of tea on the table and asked, 'Difficult?'

'Not the language. The boundary.'

'The boundary again?'

Shashank did not laugh. 'One paper is advice, another is business; both can have the same word confidential written across them. A word can be hard in the source, and someone can ask the translator to soften it. Where does the translator stand then?'

Mrinal did not hurry to answer. After a long time he said, 'Where his eyes saw, his ears heard, and the source spoke. If he goes beyond that, he is no longer only a translator. He begins to become a participant.'

'And if he only changes a word?'

'Sometimes changing a word changes the nature of the act.'

Shashank kept looking at the tea left in the bottom of his glass. Raghav's sentence returned to him—not to put a cloak over it. Mrinal's sentence came and stood beside it—he begins to become a participant.

That night in his room he opened his notebook. The nib of the new pen trembled for a moment as it touched the paper. He wrote the heading: 'The Fifth Test of Perception.' Then he made a sequence:

Perception—translation of Chinese records in a lawyer's office; several differences between source and draft; one representative's request for a softer word; Raghav's instruction to preserve the original meaning; different kinds of documents all marked confidential.

Inference—some people may wish to make commercial risk appear smaller through language or classification. That intention is not yet established.

Allegation—that crime is being concealed in the name of confidentiality, or that the lawyer is participating in crime. At present there is no adequate basis for such an allegation.

Potential false allegation—to see a lawyer's office, a foreign client, payment-related terminology, or confidential papers and immediately assume criminal participation.

Established fact—Shashank was asked to soften one word; he did not change the original meaning; Raghav too stood by the source text; for the first time Shashank clearly felt fear that his linguistic gift might in future become a means not only of clarifying truth, but of clouding it.

His hand stopped as he wrote the last line. How could 'fear' be an established fact? An inner state was not external evidence. Shashank struck out the words and wrote again: 'After this episode Shashank questioned Mrinal about the boundary of his role, and in his notebook he wrote down the distinction between translation and participation.' That stood closer to perception. Even in matters of his own mind, he required the discipline of evidence.

Then, on a separate line, he wrote: 'Statement of conscience: I was afraid.'

Looking at the difference between those two lines, he understood again the severity of Gangesha Upadhyaya's method. An outer fact and an inner admission might both be true, but the method by which each was proved was not the same.

Outside the room someone was climbing the stairs. The sound of footsteps approached his door and then continued upward. For a moment Shashank went alert. Then he laughed at himself. Fear, too, tries to distort perception—the urge to hear pursuit in ordinary footsteps, conspiracy in ordinary silence, crime in an ordinary sheet of paper.

He capped the new pen. So far there was no allegation against him, no established evidence of any crime in his hands, and Raghav Bhasin too was only a lawyer who had insisted that the meaning of the source be preserved. It was necessary to keep that boundary clear.

But another fact was also true: Shashank had begun to glimpse the doorway to a world in which language was not merely communication but a force capable of altering the shape of responsibility. Until now he had seen the beauty of that force; now he had seen its fear.

Before turning out the light he wrote at the bottom of the notebook: 'Confidentiality is not darkness; but darkness can take the name of confidentiality. A translator's task is not to look at the name, but at the source.'

That night Shashank lay awake for a long time. The brightness of Macao, Raghav's red pencil, the representative's softened word, Mrinal's hard boundary—all returned to his mind by turns. Fear did not stop him. It did only this much: the attraction of the next opportunity was no longer innocent.

And perhaps a man's fall does not begin on the day he writes a falsehood. Sometimes it begins on the day he understands how a falsehood can be made—and still cannot give up the desire to return to the doorway where it can be made.

CHAPTER 6

MITHILA TO DELHI 6

After leaving Raghav Bhasin's office that day, Shashank had written in his notebook about the distinction between confidentiality and participation. For four days nothing unusual happened. Classes at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan continued, the Red Fort afternoons again filled with the voices of tourists, and tea with Mrinal resumed its familiar rhythm. Yet inside Shashank, the language of law no longer sounded like ordinary language. Advice, confidential, service, liability—behind every word he had begun to look for a boundary.

On the fifth day another message came from Raghav's office. This time the work was not for two hours but for an entire afternoon. A foreign client had received a tax-related notice; some emails from the Chinese management, purchase details, and service agreements had to be read so that the advocate's team could understand the facts. Shashank read the message three times. The earlier fear had not yet settled, but the fee was not small either.

While telling Mrinal, he said before his friend could speak, 'Translation only. I will not compose any reply, and I will add no fact.'

Mrinal smiled. 'Did I say anything?'

'No. The voice inside me did.'

'Then let that voice keep speaking.'

When he reached the office, Shashank found two new people in the conference room with Raghav. One was an accounting consultant; the other, the company's Indian manager. On the table lay a copy of a notice. At its head was the name of an office concerned with a Goods and Services Tax inquiry. Shashank began to read the paper, but Raghav stopped him.

'Your work is not to read this notice,' Raghav said. 'Read the client's Chinese messages. I will examine the notice.'

Shashank nodded. The boundary had been made clear at the outset.

The first email seemed ordinary—some purchase orders, some service entries, a few dates of payment. In the second, a Chinese manager asked why there was a discrepancy between the returns filed by the Indian branch and the internal accounts. The third message was brief: 'The local team is asking for the records again; the position is being clarified at the higher level.'

Shashank stopped at 'higher level.' The Chinese phrase could mean a superior level, but it could also mean head office. He looked at Raghav.

'There are two possible meanings here,' he said. 'The company's head office, or a higher level of administration. The context does not decide between them.'

Raghav said, 'Write both possibilities. Do not choose one meaning for them.'

The Indian manager interrupted. 'Just write head office. Their language uses up and down all the time.'

Shashank read the original line again. 'I am not certain.'

The manager's face hardened slightly. 'Understand how the world works. This is not a class in jurisprudence.'

Raghav set his red pencil down on the table. 'Where the translator is not certain, the file will not pretend to be certain.'

Relief came over Shashank, but with it another question: why so much insistence over the meaning of one ambiguous word? A question was not a fact. In his notebook he wrote only: 'higher level/head office—context ambiguous.'

Around midday a Chinese officer joined by video. His voice was different from that of the representative Shashank had met before. He spoke rapidly. Shashank translated sentence by sentence. Most of the discussion concerned availability of records, an old accounting computer, changes of staff, and purchase details.

Then the Chinese officer said a sentence that altered the atmosphere in the room: 'Do not worry about the local inquiry; the people concerned are speaking to the main branch.'

Shashank stopped translating and asked again, 'The people concerned—people from the company?'

The Chinese officer shrugged. 'The people who are handling this matter.'

'The main branch—the company's?'

There was a moment of silence. Then came the answer: 'The Indian side understands it better.'

The Indian manager immediately said, 'Write that the headquarters compliance team is handling the matter.'

Shashank's hands stopped over the keyboard. The original sentence was not that clear. He looked at Raghav.

Raghav said, 'Write the original words. Put the interpretation separately.'

Shashank wrote: 'The people concerned are speaking to the main branch.' In brackets he added: 'Meaning of main branch ambiguous.'

Up to that point, no crime had been established. No official had been named, no payment mentioned, no direct proof of benefit produced. Yet everyone in the room understood that ambiguity itself had become a form of tension.

Before the work ended, a new message arrived. The Indian manager looked at his phone and said casually, 'All right. The local notice has been stayed for now.'

Raghav asked, 'Written order?'

'It will come.'

'Then until the written order comes, treat the notice as live.'

The manager laughed. 'You paper people. It has been spoken about upstairs.'

Again Shashank's ear caught on the word upstairs. This time it was not Chinese, but Indian speech—half Hindi, half the easy idiom of offices. The meaning was ambiguous again. Upstairs could mean a senior office, company management, or an influential connection. His mind wanted to build a story; Navya-Nyaya stopped it.

Raghav said quietly, 'I want only the written position. An oral assurance is not a fact on the file.'

At that moment Shashank felt respect for Raghav. Then another corner of his mind warned him: one or two cautious sentences do not prove a person wholly innocent or guilty. Judging conduct requires a longer chain of evidence.

At the same hour, some distance from Delhi, in an ordinary office of a local commissionerate, an investigating officer named Aditya Mishra sat at his desk with three files open before him. He too came from another village of Mithila, though he did not know Shashank. There was no book of Gangesha Upadhyaya on his desk—only an old notebook, a rulebook, and stacks of receipts. Yet his thinking had a natural discipline: first, what the papers said; only afterwards, what people said.

Aditya's team, having noticed a discrepancy between a service provider's purchases, payments, and declared returns, had asked for additional records. The discrepancy was not proof of a crime. An accounting error, a timing difference, a difference in classification—many explanations were possible. So Aditya had written on the note sheet: 'Cause to be determined upon receipt of records.'

At midday a colleague brought him a new order. Action on the earlier notice was to be 'kept in abeyance until further instructions.' The order had been properly entered in the system. It bore a signature as well. On its face it was a valid administrative direction.

Aditya asked only one question. 'Reason?'

His colleague said, 'From above.'

Aditya raised his head. 'Reason in the order?'

'No.'

'Then I will not write a reason.'

He did not strike out the earlier note. Beneath it he added a new line: 'Action on the earlier inquiry notice kept in abeyance until further instructions; no reason for the abeyance stated in the order.'

His colleague laughed. 'Why so much exactness? If it is stayed, it is stayed.'

Aditya replied, 'If tomorrow someone asks why it was stopped, my file must not say that I knew the reason when I did not.'

This resistance was not heroism. He obeyed the order. He stopped the paper. He accused no senior officer. But where the reason was absent, he did not fill the absence with imagination. In administration, sometimes this small discipline is the first form of resistance.

By evening another piece of information reached Aditya's desk: some material connected with the matter was being examined by a central intelligence branch. There were no details. That fact could have been sufficient reason to pause the local inquiry; administrative necessity might also require avoiding parallel action. Or there might have been some other reason. Aditya did not record both possibilities, because a file was not the place for possibilities. He entered only the information received.

In his private notebook he wrote a separate line: 'Do not fill an absent reason with an accusation.'

At that same time, leaving the Connaught Place office, Shashank was repeating almost the same rule to himself, though neither man knew the other existed.

On the way out, the Indian manager walked with Shashank as far as the lift. Just before the door closed, he said in a low voice, 'You are too literal. If you want to do bigger work, you will have to learn practicality.'

Shashank asked, 'What does practicality mean?'

The manager smiled. 'What everyone understands need not always be written on paper.'

The lift descended. Shashank said nothing. The sentence was not a threat, nor was it an explicit instruction. Yet he caught in it the first scent of betrayal—betrayal of whom? The law? The client? His friend? His own perception? He could not name it.

Outside, he called Mrinal. 'Tea?'

Hearing his voice, Mrinal asked at once, 'Did something happen?'

'Nothing has been proved.'

'Why did that answer come before the question?'

Shashank was silent. Then, without revealing the office's name, the client's identity, or confidential documents, he told him only the shape of the incident—the ambiguous 'above,' the local notice being stayed, the absence of a written reason, and the pressure to alter the translation.

Mrinal listened for a long time. Then he said, 'Avoid two errors. First, assuming everyone has been bought. Second, assuming that because a written order exists, all questions end.'

'Then what?'

'Keep what you saw. Do not invent a story about what you did not see.'

Shashank laughed. 'You have stolen my Navya-Nyaya.'

'No. You came to Delhi and taught me how it is used.'

That night Shashank opened his notebook. This time the nib of the new pen moved without trembling:

Perception—Chinese messages from a client connected with a tax inquiry; ambiguous statements such as 'the people concerned are speaking to the main branch'; the Indian manager's statement that 'the local notice has been stayed'; Raghav's insistence on waiting for a written order; the decision to preserve ambiguity in translation.

Inference—people from the company may be in contact at an administrative level; or 'main branch' may refer only to an internal unit of the company. Neither is yet established.

Allegation—that the central intelligence system has compromised itself and is stopping the local inquiry. The available material does not establish this allegation.

Possibility of false allegation—to see a stayed notice, a foreign client, and phrases like 'spoken about upstairs' and immediately assume that government officers are corrupt.

Established fact—the client's side pressed for an ambiguous sentence to be given a definite, harmless meaning; Shashank and Raghav preserved the original ambiguity; it was said orally that the notice had been stayed, but no written stay order was before Shashank.

This time he made a new heading beneath the last line: 'Betrayal.' Then he held his pen still for a long while. By whom? Where was the proof? In the end he struck out the heading. Emotional truth and established fact separated again.

Elsewhere, before closing his office, Aditya Mishra placed the copy of the stay order in sequence in the file. He too declared no one guilty. He recorded separately the original notice, the new order, the date, and the absence of a stated reason. He did not know that far away in Connaught Place, a translator had also refused that day to make the meaning of the word above more certain than it was.

Two young men from Mithila, two separate desks, two separate worlds. One was earning his living by selling language; the other was wrestling with questions of the state by reading papers. As yet there was no visible thread between them. Yet both had hold of unknown ends of the same method: what is not established, do not call established.

The only difference was that greed had already made a home inside Shashank, while inside Aditya there was, for the moment, only patience. Time would show whether method saves a man, or whether a man alters the meaning of method for his own convenience.

Before turning off the light, Shashank closed the notebook. Mrinal's words came back to him: it was an error to assume everyone had been bought, and also an error to assume that a written paper ended all questions. He still claimed to be walking the narrow path between those two errors.

But the new pen gleamed on his table, the payment from Macao sat in his bank account, and the foreign client's next message waited on his phone. The path of truth is difficult not only because of logic; sometimes at its other end stand more money, more prestige, and greater intimacy.

CHAPTER 7

MITHILA TO DELHI 7

That night Shashank remained awake for a long time. The ambiguity of the word “above,” the news that the local inquiry had been stayed, and Mrinal’s warning—keep what you saw; do not make a story out of what you did not see—circled through his mind again and again. But the next morning Delhi placed before him a story he himself had not made.

As he was getting ready to leave for Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, he opened his phone. Five messages had arrived with the same link. The first was from a classmate—“Why is your name in this?” The second, from a guide he knew at the Red Fort—“Brother, have you seen the news?” The third was from Mrinal—“Call me first. Do not write any reply yet.”

Shashank opened the link.

On a small digital news page, a headline stood in heavy type: “Mithila Translator for Chinese Company Involved in Halting Local Tax Inquiry?” Beneath it was Shashank Jha’s name. The article said that the name of a translator had appeared in “confidential material” linked to a foreign company, and that the translator was suspected of having acted as an intermediary in “contacts at higher levels.” The article named no official, reproduced no document, and gave no details of any payment. Yet the words had been arranged so that the question mark stood only at the end of the headline; the smell of guilt began with the first line.

Shashank’s finger went still on the screen.

He read the article again. “Role,” “intermediary,” “confidential material,” “higher levels”—all the words were familiar to him. But familiar words are not synonyms for truth. He understood at once that whoever had written the article knew fragments of something real: he had translated for a foreign client; he had heard ambiguous phrases such as “above”; there had been talk of the local letter being stayed. But the line drawn between those three fragments did not exist in his direct experience.

Humiliation, however, does not wait for logic.

He did not go to Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. The very thought that the class bell would ring, the teacher would go on teaching tones, the three books would lie on the desk—something inside him seemed to break. Until yesterday language had been his pride; today that same language stood beside his name as “translator for a Chinese company,” like the shadow of an accusation.

Mrinal reached his room within ten minutes. The moment Shashank opened the door, he said, “I am going to answer this.”

“Drink some water first.”

“Water will not clear my name.”

“Nor will anger.”

Shashank sat down at the table. His laptop was open. He had already written half a statement: “I have no connection of any kind with any foreign company’s tax inquiry or with any government official...”

Mrinal read it and stopped. “This sentence is false.”

Shashank’s face reddened. “I did not stop any inquiry.”

“That is a different matter. But you do have a professional relationship with a foreign company. You have also translated tax-related papers. Why write a sentence in your defence that can later become evidence against you?”

“Then should I remain silent?”

“There is a road between silence and falsehood.”

Shashank rose from the chair and went to the window. On the street the milkman, the rickshaw pullers, the schoolchildren—all moved at their usual pace. It astonished him that even on a day of public disgrace, the world remained ordinary.

“They are calling me a broker.”

“The article asks a question, but the suggestion is one of guilt,” Mrinal said. “I hate it too. But first write down what you actually did.”

Shashank opened his notebook.

Translation for a foreign client—yes.

Read tax-related messages in Raghav Bhasin’s office—yes.

Refused to give a single meaning to ambiguous words such as “above” or “main office”—yes.

Contacted any government officer on the client’s behalf—no.

Asked for an inquiry to be stopped—no.

Direct knowledge of any payment or benefit being given to anyone—no.

He kept looking at the list. It did not prove him innocent; it merely marked the boundary of his experience. Within that boundary were facts. Beyond it lay uncertainty.

In the afternoon Raghav called.

“Have you seen the article?”

“Yes.”

“Has any journalist spoken to you?”

“No.”

“Then do not enter a public argument yet. Preserve the link, the time, the headline, the entire page. If a response becomes necessary, write facts only.”

In a bitter voice Shashank asked, “Is my name in the confidential material?”

Raghav was silent for a few moments. “I have not been shown that material.”

“But the article says so.”

“The article says that its source says so. Those are three different things.”

The student inside Shashank caught the structure of the sentence at once—speaker, statement, source. The reliability of verbal testimony. But the humiliated mind said: all logic is easy when your name is not in the headline.

“If this goes to court?” Shashank asked.

“Then the headline will not be evidence. If the material is lawfully produced, its source, integrity, context, and meaning will all be examined. At present, all I know is that you worked in my office as a translator.”

“And if that material says something beside my name?”

“Then what is written will be read. What is not written will not be added by inference.”

After the call ended, Shashank’s anger subsided a little, but not his humiliation. He understood that Raghav’s answer was cautious. He also understood that caution was not proof of innocence. The rule he applied to others had to be applied to his own side as well.

That afternoon, at the local commissionerate, a thick khaki envelope arrived on Aditya Mishra’s desk. Across it, in red letters, was written “RESTRICTED ACCESS.” There was no wax seal, but a serial number and time of receipt had been recorded. The sender was an authorised section of the central intelligence wing. The letter instructed that the enclosed material be seen only by the investigating officer concerned and an approved senior officer.

Aditya first entered the time in the receipt register—11:40 a.m. Then he opened the envelope.

Inside were printed copies of several emails, service invoices, a meeting list, and a two-page internal summary. One service invoice carried Shashank Jha’s name under “language translation services.” The meeting list recorded him as “translator.” One email referred to the local inquiry; another contained a phrase like “clarify the position at the main level.” But there was no page showing that Shashank had paid a government officer, exerted influence, or stopped the inquiry.

Aditya read the material twice. Then, on a separate sheet, he made three headings: “Direct,” “Connection,” “Undetermined.”

Direct—Shashank present as translator; service invoice available; possible translator access to inquiry-related messages.

Connection—he was a linguistic link in the client’s communications.

Undetermined—administrative influence, payment, role in stopping the inquiry, secret arrangement with anyone.

Just then a colleague came in, holding up the same digital article on his phone.

“Sir, the news has already named him. Now his name is in the sealed material too. The matter is clear.”

Aditya looked up. “What is clear?”

“He was in the middle of it.”

“A translator is in the middle. The question is what he did.”

“The news says he had access all the way to the top.”

“The news is not my file.”

The colleague looked dissatisfied. “But the source must be this material.”

Aditya looked at the clock. The article had been published at 8:17 a.m.; the material had reached his office at 11:40. The time gap proved only this much: the copy now in his hands could not have been the writer's direct source. Whether another copy of the material had existed somewhere earlier, he did not know.

"I cannot write that the material went out from here," Aditya said. "I also cannot write that it did not. My direct knowledge is only that this copy reached me at 11:40."

The colleague laughed. "You put boundaries around everything."

"If I do not, accusation will put on the clothes of evidence."

He closed the khaki envelope again, signed the receipt note, and placed the material in a secure cabinet. He knew the word "sealed" worked like magic on the public imagination. A paper in an ordinary file invited questions; call it sealed, and people began to regard it as a hidden final truth. But a seal did not by itself establish the material's context, accuracy, or conclusion.

By evening the digital article had been copied by many small sites. On some, the question mark had vanished from the headline; elsewhere, "role?" had become simply "role." On one page, Shashank's name had even been preceded by the words "principal middleman"—a description unsupported even by the original article.

Shashank watched these transformations, and humiliation inside him hardened into anger. He found a journalist's number and thought of calling. Mrinal stopped him again.

"Will you fight every page?"

"Then what am I supposed to do?"

"Protect your own direct knowledge."

"People do not read direct knowledge. They read headlines."

"Then do not become a headline yourself."

The sentence hurt Shashank. He felt Mrinal was preaching while it was Shashank's own name that was burning. He said sharply, "Your name is not there."

Mrinal fell silent. After a few moments he said only, "You are right. The humiliation is yours. But if you write a false answer, the falsehood will be yours too."

For the first time Shashank looked away from his friend's eyes.

In that instant the seed of deceit stirred visibly within him. He wanted to keep the Macao trip, the higher fee, his closeness to the foreign representative—all of it out of his statement of defence. None of those facts proved the accusation; but hiding them all and writing "I have no connection" would not remain true either.

He returned to the chair and rewrote the statement:

"In my professional capacity as a translator, I have provided language services to foreign clients. As regards the suggestions in the published report that I influenced the stopping of an inquiry, acted as an intermediary with government officials, or was connected with unlawful payments, I know of no fact in my direct experience that supports them. I have not been given access to the material referred to in the report; I will therefore not speculate about its contents."

Mrinal read it. "This is your boundary."

"And people will call it fear."

"Perhaps. The boundary of truth sometimes looks like cowardice."

That night, at the local commissionerate, Aditya wrote his daily note. He placed a copy of the news report in the file, but wrote plainly across it: "Media publication; independent verification pending." He kept the inventory of the sealed material separate. Then he wrote: "Presence of translator's name established; role in administrative influence unestablished."

The senior officer read the note and asked, "Was it necessary to write it so explicitly?"

Aditya answered, "If a court asks tomorrow what meaning was drawn from the presence of a name, the file should show that a name and a role are not the same thing."

The senior officer looked at him for a few moments. "The pressure from the news will increase."

"News may change the speed of an inquiry. It cannot change the meaning of evidence."

It was easy to say. It would be harder to live by. Aditya knew that too.

That night Shashank opened a fresh page beneath his last entry. His hand was not yet steady. Even so, he wrote:

Direct—the appearance of my name on a digital news page; the fact that I provided language services to a foreign client; the article's reference to some real circumstances; but no direct act by me in stopping an inquiry has been shown.

Inference—the writer may have received some internal information; that the sealed material was the source of that information is not established.

Allegation—I used access to "higher levels" to get the local inquiry stopped.

Possibility of false allegation—to join the translator's name, the foreign client, and the stayed inquiry into a single chain and take influence-peddling as proved.

Established fact—I worked as a translator; the article was published; the writer presented no public evidence; my name caused social humiliation; the first draft of my defence was itself so broad that it stood on the edge of falsehood.

As soon as he wrote the last line, his hand stopped. The public false allegation had wounded him, but his private desire to write a false sentence made him smaller in his own eyes.

For the first time he understood: humiliation does not merely make a man a victim; it can also give him an excuse to make his own truth smaller.

Somewhere far away, in Aditya Mishra's secure cabinet, the khaki envelope lay closed. In a Delhi room, Shashank's brief statement remained open on his laptop. The same name was present in both places, but its meaning had entered two different struggles.

Direct knowledge said—the name is there.

Inference asked—what was the role?

The news said—the story is ready.

The court, if the day came, would ask—where is the evidence?

And conscience asked Shashank a different question—how much truth will you preserve in your own defence?

He turned off the light. Outside was night; inside, humiliation. But one line in the notebook remained clear: do not take a closed paper for the final house of truth; do not take a printed name for a synonym of guilt; and do not let an injury become a licence to lie.

CHAPTER 8

THE CHINESE TOURISTS AT THE RED FORT

Much later, when Shashank Jha stood in the witness box, an old photograph of the Red Fort was placed before him. Red walls, stones blazing in the sun, a crowd behind, and three Chinese tourists in the foreground. In one corner of the photograph stood Shashank himself – thin, a satchel over his shoulder, a cheap notebook in his hand, and in his eyes that confidence born less of experience than of aspiration.

The prosecution counsel lifted the photograph. 'Is this you?'

'Yes.'

'At this time, were you working as a professional translator?'

Shashank paused for a moment. 'I was learning the language and guiding tourists. Sometimes I translated as well.'

'Which means people relied on your translations?'

Counsel for the defence rose. 'The question is too broad.'

The judge said, 'Keep it narrow. Establish the relevance of this old incident only to the witness's method of translation.'

At the word 'method', Gangesha Upadhyaya's sutra stirred awake in Shashank's mind. Perception. What exactly had been said? What exactly had been heard? What exactly had been written? And where, between those three, had the translator inserted his own mind?

The counsel opened another paper. 'A statement by a Chinese tourist. You translated it. The original sentence meant: "I did not see this man take the bag; he was only standing nearby." But in the initial Hindi note, the words "I did not see" are missing. Why?'

The air of the courtroom suddenly became that afternoon at the Red Fort.

The Delhi sun had been fierce that day. Shashank had left his class at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan and gone straight to the Red Fort. He had barely enough money left in his pocket for the bus fare, the rent on his room loomed before him, yet the hunger to practise Chinese tones drew him there again and again. In a book, language remains still; in a crowd of tourists, it runs, falters, panics, and suddenly changes shape.

That afternoon he found a small group of three from Guangzhou – a middle-aged couple and their young niece, Lin Yue. Shashank's Cantonese pronunciation was still raw, but Lin Yue did not laugh when she heard him try. Instead, she repeated the words slowly, helping him catch the tone correctly.

Shashank showed them the ramparts, the remnants of the Diwan, the museum, and the pathways outside. While explaining history, he stumbled repeatedly over his choice of words. 'Empire', 'rebellion', 'independence', 'court' – every word carried not only meaning but memory. At one point Lin Yue said, 'A translator first decides which history I am going to hear.'

Shashank laughed, but the sentence remained inside him.

Before evening, the group reached an open path outside. Lin Yue set her small camera bag on a low stone seat and went a little distance away to take photographs with her phone. Five or seven minutes later she returned and found the bag gone. Her face changed at once. She spoke rapidly, then pointed to a man some distance away who was selling souvenirs.

At first Shashank only listened.

Lin Yue said, 'When I put down the bag, this man was nearby. When I came back, the bag was gone. I did not see him take it.'

There were three sentences. First – the bag had been put down. Second – the man had been nearby. Third – the act of taking it had not been directly seen.

Three separate compartments formed at once in Shashank's mind. Perception. Proximity. Inference.

A security guard arrived. He knew no Chinese. He asked Shashank, 'What is madam saying? Does she suspect this man?'

Shashank translated, 'Her bag was kept here. When she came back, it was gone. This man was nearby at the time.'

'Did she see him take it?'

Shashank looked at Lin Yue. He repeated the question in Chinese. Lin Yue shook her head. 'No. I did not see him.'

At this point, Shashank had only one thing to say: 'No.'

But the security guard's voice was impatient. The crowd was growing. The souvenir seller kept insisting that he had taken nothing. Lin Yue's uncle was speaking angrily. Shashank felt the pressure to prove his linguistic skill - if he kept adding qualifications, people might think he did not understand Chinese well enough.

He said, 'She did not see him take it, but she suspects this man.'

The sentence was not wholly false. But neither was it a complete translation.

Lin Yue did not understand the Hindi word for 'suspicion'. The security guard took the man aside. His name was asked. Someone began writing the incident on a small sheet of paper and said to Shashank, 'Tell me - bag kept here, this man was here, then the bag disappeared. That's all!'

A voice inside Shashank said, 'That is sequence, not cause.'

Another voice said, 'This is not the time to teach philosophy.'

He remained silent.

The paper recorded that the tourist's bag had disappeared from the place where the man in question had been present, and that the tourist had expressed suspicion of him. The sentence 'I did not see him take it' did not appear again.

Lin Yue asked Shashank, 'What have they written?'

This time his test came from the opposite direction. If he told her everything, she would understand that her caution had been diminished. If he simplified it, the matter would end quickly.

Shashank said, 'It says the bag was there, then it was not found, and the man was nearby.'

Lin Yue asked, 'Does it also say that I did not see him take it?'

For a moment Shashank was silent.

'The main point has been recorded,' he said.

Those four words were the first small linguistic evasion of his life.

About twenty minutes later, the group's driver came running. The camera bag had been found under the rear seat of the bus. Lin Yue stood stunned. Her uncle went at once to the security guard. The souvenir seller's face hovered between anger and relief.

What Shashank felt first was not relief, but shame.

Lin Yue said quietly, 'I told you I had not seen him take it.'

Shashank had no answer.

The security guard added one line to the old sheet: bag found in vehicle; no theft established. The man was allowed to go. In practical terms, the incident was over. The crowd drifted elsewhere. The sunlight remained on the walls of the Red Fort as if nothing had happened.

But for Shashank, the incident did not end.

That night, in his room in Paharganj, he opened his notebook. He wrote three lines:

Perception - Lin Yue had placed the bag on the seat; when she returned it was gone; a man had been nearby; Lin Yue had not seen him take the bag; later the bag was found on the bus.

Inference - because the man had been nearby, suspicion fell on him.

Established fact - theft was not established; the bag was found on the bus.

Beneath these, after a long time, he added a fourth line: 'In translation, I failed to preserve "I did not see him" with the clarity it required.'

He could have written 'error'. But he knew it had not been mere forgetfulness. Between impatience, the desire to prove his skill, and the convenience of ending the dispute quickly, he had allowed one sentence to fall away.

The next day, when he returned to the Red Fort, he looked for the souvenir seller. The man was nowhere to be found. Shashank wanted to apologise, but he did not even know his name. That day he understood the first difficulty of repentance: sometimes the wrong is small, but the person who suffered from it can never be found again.

Time passed. The Red Fort incident was pressed flat between the pages of his notebook. Shashank learned to speak Chinese better. His pronunciation improved. His fees rose. Clients changed. There was the journey to Macao. Papers, accounts, payments, confidentiality, government inquiries - language slowly began to carry much heavier things.

But in court, that old page opened again.

The prosecution counsel asked, 'You admit that the tourist clearly said she had not seen the man take the bag?'

'Yes.'

'And that part did not enter the initial note?'

'Yes.'

'Then you changed the meaning?'

The defence rose again. 'Shashank did not write the note. He only provided oral assistance.'

The judge said, 'Reframe the question.'

The counsel set the paper down. 'In your translation, you did not convey the negative - "I did not see him" - with the same clarity with which it appeared in the original statement. Correct?'

The old discipline of Navya-Nyaya stirred within Shashank. The delimiter of the question was clear. This time there was little room to escape.

'Correct.'

A faint rustle moved through the courtroom.

The counsel asked, 'Why?'

Looking not ahead but at the wooden edge beneath the judge's desk, Shashank said, 'Because at the time I wanted to appear more useful than a translator. The situation demanded a quick conclusion. I failed to preserve the limit of the sentence.'

'For convenience, then?'

'Yes. For convenience, impatience, and the vanity of displaying my ability.'

'Was it deliberate?'

Shashank drew a long breath. 'I did not invent words. But the words that fixed the boundary of the accusation, I did not give them sufficient clarity. I cannot hide here between "deliberate" and "unintentional".'

Counsel for the defence said nothing. For a moment the prosecution counsel, too, was silent. For the first time in court, Shashank understood that the true force of cross-examination lies not in the sharpness of a question, but in making its boundary exact.

Within himself he repeated Gangesha's method: do not dress inference in the clothes of perception. Do not turn an absent word into a present meaning. What was not seen must not be translated as though it had been seen.

Writing a note, the judge said, 'This old incident does not by itself prove the present allegations. But the answer will remain on record for the purpose of examining the witness's method of translation.'

To Shashank, the sentence was no less than punishment, and no less than relief. The court did not make one old error into his entire character; nor did it erase the error.

At that moment he remembered the man at the Red Fort whose name he had never learned. He remembered Lin Yue's question - 'Does it also say that I did not see him take it?' - and his own answer: 'The main point has been recorded.'

Now Shashank understood: in translation, the 'main point' is not for the translator to decide. The sentence belongs to its speaker; so does its boundary.

Standing in the courtroom, Shashank apologised inwardly for that small incident for the first time. No dramatic tears, no declaration. Only an admission: on the day he failed to preserve the word 'not', a subtle habit was born in him - the habit of bending language toward convenience.

Repentance could not change his past. But it could do one thing: this time he could state the boundary of perception in full.

The prosecution counsel rose for the next question.

Shashank lifted his head.

The red walls of the Red Fort lay far behind him now; yet their first lesson was still alive in the courtroom - to translate what was not seen as though it had been seen is not merely an error of language. It is an assault on justice.

CHAPTER 9

MITHILA TO DELHI 9

That day in court still belonged to the future. Shashank did not yet know how far a small linguistic error at the Red Fort would follow him. For the present, there was only one sheet of paper before him—the summons.

The summons reached his rented room in the afternoon. It bore an official seal, a date, the name of an office, and a clear direction that he appear on the appointed day and give his statement. Shashank read the paper twice. The first time for the words; the second for their meaning.

Mrinal looked at his face and asked, “What happened?”

Shashank handed him the paper. “They have summoned me.”

Mrinal read it slowly. “This is not an arrest warrant.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you so worried?”

Shashank did not answer. The office itself was not the only source of fear. The real reason was that he did not know what story his phone, emails, translation files, payment receipts, and client messages might tell when placed together. Seen separately, each thing was ordinary; placed side by side, meanings could change.

All night he arranged his papers in order. He destroyed nothing and tried to delete no message. Once his thumb paused over an old conversation on his phone, but he remembered Mrinal’s earlier warning—if something is directly there, making it disappear does not erase the truth; it only worsens your own position.

Shashank set the phone down on the table. Yet ambition was waking inside him in another direction. The investigators, he thought, probably did not know Chinese. The linguistic layers of the documents would have to open through him. If he became indispensable, influence might take the place of fear.

There was danger in that thought, but at that moment he did not see danger. He saw opportunity.

On the appointed day he reached the office before time. The waiting room was ordinary—iron chairs, an old fan, employees passing in and out with files. Nothing theatrically frightening. That ordinariness unsettled Shashank more. People often imagine calamity in extraordinary forms; real calamity can also sit in an everyday room, turning pages.

His name was called.

Inside, Aditya Mishra sat at a desk. Before him lay a copy of the summons, several printed emails, extracts from a bank summary, and two pages of translation. Shashank had never seen him before. Aditya, too, had known Shashank only through the record.

“Shashank Jha?”

“Yes.”

“You work as a translator of Chinese?”

“Yes. Mainly Mandarin. I understand some Cantonese as well.”

Aditya looked at him for a moment. “I will keep my questions short. Keep your answers within the limits of the question. If you do not remember something, say ‘I do not remember.’ Do not present inference as fact.”

A faint tremor passed through Shashank. The sentence sounded like a lesson from Gangesha’s school—the boundary of direct knowledge.

Aditya placed the first paper before him. “Is this translation yours?”

Shashank looked at the signature. “Yes.”

“In the original Chinese sentence, the expression rendered as ‘temporary settlement route’ has been translated by you as ‘temporary payment arrangement.’ Could ‘route’ here also mean a technical payment channel?”

Shashank read the paper. “It could.”

“Is that certain?”

“No.”

“Then the meaning you wrote earlier is a possible meaning, not an established one?”

“Yes.”

Aditya made a note. Shashank was startled inwardly. He had expected the officer not to understand the words and to depend on his explanation. But this officer was asking for meaning, not authority.

The second paper was a payment summary. Some amounts were small, some relatively large. Beside the names were brief remarks. Shashank's name appeared in one place too—language-assistance fee.

Aditya asked, "Did you receive this amount?"

"Yes."

"For what work?"

"Translation at meetings, reading two draft agreements, and client support by phone."

"Did you verify the ownership of the source from which this money came?"

Shashank paused for a moment. Ambition said: you understand a great deal; answer expansively. Caution said: say only what you saw.

He said, "No. I saw the name on the account from which the payment came. I did not verify who the beneficial owner was."

"All right."

One word. Neither praise nor accusation.

The statement moved forward slowly. There was a strange discipline in the questions. "Did you see it?" "Did you hear it?" "From whom?" "Do you remember the date?" "Did you create this document yourself, or was it sent to you?" Instead of giving Shashank opportunities to display his intelligence, each question measured its limits.

Near midday an officer entered the room and whispered something into Aditya's ear. Aditya looked at Shashank and said calmly, "Your phone and laptop will be lawfully seized for digital examination. An inventory will be prepared, the details of the devices will be recorded, and you will receive a copy."

Shashank's throat went dry. "Now?"

"Yes."

"There is personal material on them too."

"The existence of personal material does not alter the purpose of the seizure. The prescribed process will apply to what is relevant. What is not relevant will not be treated as evidence of a crime."

Shashank wanted to ask—how many days? Who would read it? Every message? But he did not want his voice to reveal fear. Ambition was still alive inside him; he wanted to present himself not as a victim, but as an indispensable specialist.

He took out the phone. The officer recorded the make of the device, its serial number, and its external condition. The laptop was described as well. Shashank read the inventory. In one place, the model number was wrong.

"This digit is not eight; it is three," Shashank said.

The officer looked again and corrected it.

Aditya did not even smile, but said, "Point out things like this immediately. A small error in a seizure memo can later become a large dispute."

Shashank suddenly remembered the incident at the Red Fort—the ambiguity of the word "no," the narrow boundary of direct knowledge. He understood that this officer too did not regard language as decoration.

The digital devices were sealed in separate bags. Shashank watched every seal, number, and signature. One part of his mind was afraid; another watched the procedure with almost professional curiosity. He even found it oddly alluring that his life had now reached a level at which the serial numbers of his devices were being entered in government records.

That attraction was a sickness within him—ambition could turn humiliation and fear themselves into evidence of prestige.

The statement resumed.

Aditya placed a printed message before him. In Chinese it said: "Do not use the old route for now; settle through the new person."

"Translation?"

Shashank read it. "Literally, that is all it says—do not use the old route for now; settle through the new person."

"Does 'route' mean a payment route?"

"It could."

"Is that certain?"

"No. It could also mean a channel of commercial contact."

"And 'settle'?"

"Without context, it could mean payment, arrangement, or resolution."

Aditya asked, "Is the context available?"

"Not from this one line."

"Then write this: on the basis of one line, an unlawful payment is not established."

Shashank looked at him. "Are you writing in my favour?"

For the first time Aditya looked directly into his eyes. "I am not writing in anyone's favour. Only what is established. If context emerges tomorrow and changes the meaning, the record will change too. Not today."

"And if there is some other expectation from upstairs?" The question escaped Shashank's mouth.

The room was silent for a moment.

Aditya said, "An expectation is not direct evidence. If there is a written order, there is a document. If there is an oral indication, its source and circumstances will be recorded. The inference will remain separate."

Shashank remembered the ambiguous indication from Chapter 6—"It has been spoken about upstairs." At the time, the sentence had been fear; now before him stood a method that broke fear into pieces and asked: who is upstairs? Who said it? When? Written or oral? What was the result?

At that moment Shashank felt a strange attraction towards Aditya. Not friendship—challenge. He thought: this man will not be easily caught in a net of words. And precisely there his ambition woke again. If the man sitting opposite him was difficult, defeating him would be worth even more.

The moment the thought came, Shashank felt uneasy with himself. So far no crime had been established against him. His role appeared limited to translation, ordinary fees for work, some client contact, and ambiguous messages. Yet inwardly he had begun to treat the investigation less as a process for finding truth and more as a contest of intelligence.

Aditya asked the next question. "There is a folder on your laptop called 'CN-client-map'?"

Shashank became alert. "Yes."

"What is in it?"

"Client language lists, contact names, pronunciation notes, contractual terminology. Copies of some invoices as well."

"Any account login or password?"

"Not as far as I remember."

"As far as I remember—that is the right formulation. If the digital examination reveals something else, I will ask you again."

Shashank nodded.

Aditya wrote on the paper: "Statement based on present recollection; digital examination pending."

That single line unsettled Shashank. He recognised his old habit—he wanted to make every sentence complete; he could not bear blank spaces. Aditya, by contrast, was leaving the blank space blank. "Examination pending"—neither guilt nor innocence; only incomplete direct knowledge.

By evening the statement was complete. Each page was given to Shashank to read. In two places he asked for corrections. One sentence said, "You understood the meaning of payment route." Shashank said, "I understood a possible meaning. Not a definite meaning." The sentence was corrected. In another place it said, "the financial arrangements of Chinese clients." He said, "Not all clients. The reference was only to those three documents." That too was corrected.

Aditya had him sign beside each correction.

Shashank asked, "Do you not think I am being excessively cautious?"

"Caution is not the problem. If caution protects the boundary of fact, it is necessary. If caution conceals fact, it is a problem."

"How do you distinguish between the two?"

"I begin with direct knowledge. Then corroboration. Then contradiction. Judgment at the end. If you begin with judgment, everything starts taking the shape of that judgment."

Shashank remained silent. This was Gangesha's principle, but hearing it from another man made him feel as though a private possession had been taken away from him.

When he left the office, his hands were empty. The phone and laptop remained sealed inside. The things that had been instruments of his ambition—language, contacts, messages, client lists—had now themselves become subjects of examination.

Mrinal was waiting outside. "What happened?"

Shashank said, "They recorded my statement. They kept the devices."

"Any accusation?"

"A great many questions."

"What has been established?"

Shashank paused before answering. The day's method had changed something inside him.

“Very little so far,” he said. “Some payments were received—my fees. There are some messages—their meaning is ambiguous. The rest will be examined.”

Mrinal looked at him carefully. “Earlier you used to build an entire theory from a single line.”

Shashank gave a faint laugh. “Today it was someone else’s job to stop me.”

They walked out together. The Delhi evening was hot. Traffic moved along the road. Shashank’s pocket felt light because his phone was gone; his mind felt heavy.

He kept thinking—had the summons come to make him smaller, or larger? If his linguistic talent became the centre of an investigation, was that humiliation or recognition? The question itself was evidence of his ambition.

Direct knowledge, however, amounted only to this: his statement had been recorded; the devices had been lawfully seized; his name appeared in some documents; the meaning of some messages was ambiguous; no wider crime had yet been established by his statement alone.

Everything else—how important he was, how guilty, how innocent, how useful, how clever—remained inference.

Shashank knew the distinction.

But knowing and accepting are not the same thing.

CHAPTER 10

MITHILA TO DELHI 10

After his phone and laptop were seized, Shashank's routine changed. For several days he managed with a borrowed basic phone, spoke only sparingly with clients, and kept wondering which layers of his life would descend onto government paper after the digital examination. Yet amid that anxiety, another feeling was quietly growing larger—his pride in language.

When a second summons came from Aditya Mishra's office, Shashank's first question was not what had been found against him. He asked, "Do they need a translator?"

Mrinal looked at him and gave a faint smile. "You found work for yourself the moment you read the summons?"

Shashank replied, "If the papers are in Chinese, who will understand them without the meaning?"

Mrinal said, "Understanding meaning and becoming its master are two different things."

Shashank did not like the sentence, but he did not argue. A strange confidence had begun to take root in him: at the investigation table, where officers examined documents, accounts, dates and signatures, there was one territory in which, sooner or later, they would need his eyes. Language was his territory.

At the office Aditya placed three files before him. The first contained a service agreement with a small Delhi supplier. The second held an agreement between that supplier and an intermediary entity. The third contained records relating to technical services with a vendor registered abroad. All three had English copies, but some annexures existed only in Chinese.

Aditya said, "I need translation, not conclusions."

Shashank said, "I'll keep the two separate."

"In writing?"

"Yes."

Aditya pushed a blank sheet towards him. "For every important term, make three lines—the literal meaning, the possible meaning in context, and what cannot be stated with certainty."

An involuntary pleasure rose in Shashank. This was precisely the kind of distinction he had practised in Navya-Nyaya. A word was never merely a word; relation, qualifier, limit and purpose each occupied its own place. He picked up the pen.

In the first contract, a Chinese term recurred several times and had been rendered as 'partner' in the English copy. Shashank stopped after reading the line. "This does not necessarily mean 'partner'," he said. "Here the sense is closer to 'appointed service party' or 'the party appointed to perform the work.'"

Aditya asked, "Then is the English copy wrong?"

"I would not call it wrong. It is loose. Read as 'partner,' it can suggest ownership or joint control. The original Chinese term shows only a relationship of appointment."

"Does this word establish beneficial ownership?"

Shashank answered at once, "No."

Aditya wrote: 'The original term does not establish partnership.'

A bright line of pride flashed through Shashank. A single word, made convenient in the English version, could alter the direction of an inquiry. Here language was not ornament; it was the boundary of evidence.

The second file contained a payment schedule. The Delhi entity was to pay the first vendor, the first vendor the second service party, and an annexure relating to the second service party referred to a 'designated beneficiary.' Shashank caught on the phrase.

"It says 'beneficiary' here," he said.

Aditya asked, "Beneficial owner?"

"Not necessarily. A beneficiary and the actual beneficial owner are not the same thing. Money may be paid into someone's account, but ownership, control and ultimate benefit are separate questions."

"Then what should we write?"

Shashank wrote on the sheet: 'The record names the recipient of payment; actual beneficial ownership is not thereby established.'

Aditya nodded. "Preserve that distinction."

Shashank remembered his first days in Delhi: the three books at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the drills in tone, the tourists at the Red Fort, the minute distinctions between words. Then language had been a ladder to employment. Now it was opening the body of records. He felt that years of labour had at last found their true place.

But greed walks just behind pride. Shashank thought: if this inquiry advances, no one will be able to read the original records properly without him. Officers may change, lawyers may change, vendors may disappear; but language? Language lived inside him. He began to think of himself as indispensable.

In the third file that feeling swelled further. An annexure named four entities. Their names were different, their seals different, their registration numbers different. Yet in two places the Chinese original used pronouns and word order that suggested the instructions might be coming from the same source.

Excited, Shashank said, "Look, all four are actually under the same control."

Aditya stopped his pen at once. "Actually?"

Shashank fell silent.

"What did you directly observe?" Aditya asked.

Shashank read the lines again. "Two letters use the same kind of designation for the person giving instructions. The linguistic structure is similar."

"That all?"

"The Roman spelling of one signature is similar too."

"Has that been verified?"

"No."

"Then 'all four are under the same control'—what is that?"

Reluctantly, Shashank said, "An inference."

Aditya made two separate headings on the page—'Direct' and 'Inference.' Under Direct he wrote: 'Similar linguistic sequencing in two records; similarity in the Roman spelling of a signature.' Under Inference he wrote: 'Possibly a common source of instruction; relationship of control not yet established.'

The division stung Shashank. His mind had seen the pattern in a single leap; Aditya was demanding steps in the middle of the leap.

"Sometimes language itself tells you the author is the same," Shashank said.

"It may," Aditya replied. "But in court, an entire case can live between 'may be' and 'is.'"

The sentence stung Shashank like his old mistake at the Red Fort. That day there had been a distance between 'I did not see' and 'I was not paying attention.' Today there was a distance between 'it may be the same source' and 'it is the same source.' Language was his pride, but language itself was holding him back.

In the afternoon an officer brought a bundle of printed invoices. Their numbers, dates, descriptions of services and payment instructions varied. Aditya said to Shashank, "Here I need less translation and more comparison. Is the service described in the invoice the same as the service written in the contract?"

Shashank began reading line by line. In one place it was 'technical assistance,' in another 'installation services,' elsewhere 'linguistic coordination.' One invoice carried the English heading 'consultancy,' while the Chinese description read 'site coordination and equipment inspection.'

"Loose translation again," Shashank said.

"In whose favour?"

"That is not a translator's question," Shashank said with a smile. "I can only say that the English heading is broader than the original description."

For the first time Aditya gave a slight smile. "Now you are giving the right answer."

The small praise went deeper into Shashank than he had expected. He felt that if a man as rigorous as Aditya acknowledged his command of linguistic limits, this was no ordinary compliment. He straightened his back.

Then another paper arrived—a printed email. The subject line referred to a change of vendor. The message said that future payments should be made through a 'newly designated entity.' The attached agreement carried a different name, though the service description was almost the same.

Aditya asked, "The vendor route changed?"

Shashank said, "The record shows only that the entity through which payment was to be made changed. It does not state the reason."

"Could this be a means of concealing the actual beneficial owner?"

Shashank paused for a moment. The ambitious part of him wanted to say yes, the structure was obvious. But he looked at the paper again.

“It could be. But this record alone does not establish it. There could also be a lawful reason—expiry of a contract, a change of service party, a banking arrangement, something else. The reason would require separate evidence.”

Aditya wrote: ‘Change of vendor established; purpose unestablished.’

Shashank’s pride was taking another form now. Earlier he had been proud that he could extract more meaning than others. For a moment today, he was proud that he could also stop meaning from being overdrawn. Refusing to write what was not written—this too was a linguistic skill.

When Mrinal came to collect him that evening, Shashank was unusually animated. The moment they stepped outside, he said, “Do you understand? A single English word had altered the entire impression of ownership.”

Mrinal asked, “Did you correct it?”

“Yes. The original text said something else.”

“Then good.”

Shashank stopped. “Only good? You do not understand—all the officers were reading that English copy. I was the one who caught the original meaning.”

Mrinal looked at him carefully. “I understand. But I also understand that you are putting too much emphasis on ‘I’ again.”

Shashank grew irritated. “I did the work. I learned the language. I trained my ear for the tones. If that has value, why should I not be proud?”

“Be proud,” Mrinal said quietly. “But do not turn truth into your achievement. You show them the words; ownership will be established through banks, papers, control and benefit.”

Shashank did not answer. He felt Mrinal was diminishing the importance of his talent. Yet some part of him knew his friend was not entirely wrong.

That night, on the borrowed phone, he looked through his old notes. On the first page from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, he had written: ‘Change the tone, and the meaning changes.’ Beneath that line he wrote a new one today: ‘Change the meaning, and the relationship changes; but words alone are not enough to establish the relationship.’

For a while he kept looking at the sentence. Then he felt the urge to write a third line: ‘And I hold the key to the correct meaning.’

The pen hovered over the paper.

He did not write the line.

But the thought did not disappear.

Direct knowledge amounted to this: differences of translation had been found in three chains of contracts; a payment beneficiary was named; there was a record of a vendor change; there were similarities in some linguistic structures. Actual beneficial ownership, common control, or unlawful purpose had not yet been established without independent evidence.

Shashank was capable of guarding that boundary.

And he also possessed the intelligence to cross it.

The real test of his pride in language had only just begun.

CHAPTER II

MITHILA TO DELHI II

After the papers from Chapter 10 had been closed, Aditya Mishra did not dismiss Shashank at once. The three contracts on the table, the names of payment recipients, and the notice of a change of vendor appeared to connect with one another; but the appearance of connection and the proof of a crime were not the same thing. Aditya gathered the papers again and said, “Your linguistic work does not end here. Some payment records have arrived.”

Shashank’s eyes brightened. “In Chinese?”

“Some in Chinese, some in English, some only in numbers and codes.”

Mrinal, who had been sitting outside in the waiting room, laughed when he heard about it later. “Do you want language, or mystery?”

Shashank replied, “Where are the two separate?”

Mrinal’s laughter stopped almost at once. “They ought to remain separate.”

The next day Shashank returned to the office. This time there were no contracts on the table, but copies of bank statements, payment-gateway settlement summaries, and lists of several accounts. Aditya began by drawing the boundary clearly: “The verification of these records is proceeding separately. You will read the names, the language, the references, and the relationships. Deciding who should be called a criminal is not your task.”

Shashank said, “I remember the boundary.”

Aditya looked at him. “Remembering it and obeying it are two different things.”

The sentence stung Shashank, but he did not argue. He opened the first statement. In the payment-gateway summary, many small amounts collected from numerous customers had moved into one account as though consolidated into a settlement amount. On the next page, a similarly structured sum had moved towards another account on the same day. The papers showed only that the route of the money had changed; why it had changed, who had changed it, or who ultimately benefited remained unknown.

Shashank asked, “This account is not in the company’s name?”

Aditya said, “Look at the name. Not the conclusion.”

The name belonged to a small business establishment whose declared line of work was the retail sale of electronic goods. Yet in the settlement summary, the service descriptions varied: digital entertainment in some places, consultancy in others, marketing assistance elsewhere.

Shashank said quietly, “The descriptions are not consistent.”

“Established fact?”

“Only that the descriptions differ.”

“Inference?”

“The same flow of money may have been given different labels.”

“Allegation?”

Shashank did not take his eyes from the paper. “That the real transaction is being deliberately concealed.”

Aditya wrote: “Allegation; not yet proved.”

Shashank felt an inward pleasure. In this discipline he could see his own Navya-Nyaya—substratum, qualifier, relation, limit. But within that pleasure there was another attraction as well: the numbers seemed like secret sentences whose grammar only he could read.

The next statement showed three personal accounts. Money arrived in small portions and, after a few hours or a day or two, moved onward again. The name of one account holder was unfamiliar to Shashank; the spelling of another resembled a Roman-letter form that had appeared in a Chinese message.

Shashank said at once, “This could be the same person.”

Aditya asked, “Direct evidence?”

Shashank fell silent. “Similarity of name.”

“That is all.”

“Yes.”

Aditya wrote in the margin: “Similarity of name; identity to be independently verified.”

A faint irritation rose in Shashank. He felt that linguistic resemblance often opened half the secret of a document, and every time Aditya reduced it to half again. Yet he knew that treating that “half” as whole would itself be an error of reasoning.

At noon Mrinal brought him food. The two sat on the steps outside the office. Opening the tiffin, Mrinal asked, “What did you find today?”

“Accounts.”

“Whose?”

“For now, all I can say is that some payments did not go directly into the company’s account.”

Mrinal studied him. “And your face says you want to say more than that.”

Shashank laughed. “Sometimes you cross-examine me more than Aditya does.”

“Because he is an officer. I am your friend.”

“A friend’s job is cross-examination?”

“Sometimes.”

They were silent for a while. Then Mrinal said, “When you first came to Delhi, you went looking for work. Now the papers come looking for you. Do you understand the difference?”

Shashank lifted a morsel from the tiffin. “The difference is that now my language is useful.”

“And the danger?”

“There is danger in every kind of work.”

Mrinal moved not his head but his shoulders. “That is not the danger I mean. I am afraid you have begun to enjoy the fact that everyone needs you.”

Shashank opened his mouth to answer, then closed it. The sentence was not wrong. The young man who, on his first day at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, had watched his teacher’s mouth in order to correct his tones was now watching the gleam of his own usefulness in the eyes of officials. That gleam fed both hunger and pride.

After lunch another stack of records was opened. A technical settlement summary from the payment gateway showed that, after settlement, part of the money had gone to an intermediary entity. That entity did not appear anywhere in the chain of contracts. In some messages it was called a “service partner”; in others it appeared only under a two-letter code.

Shashank read two Chinese messages. The first said, “the old road is congested”; the second said, “settlement will be faster through the new route.”

Aditya asked, “Do the words ‘road’ and ‘route’ refer to the transfer of money?”

Shashank thought. “In context, possibly. But the words by themselves do not say bank or hawala.”

“Then the translation?”

“There is difficulty with the old channel; settlement will be faster through the new channel.”

“You are adding ‘channel?’”

Shashank paused. “Yes. The original is metaphorical. The literal translation would be ‘road.’”

Aditya said, “Write both—the literal rendering and the contextual one. Later no one should be able to say that the translator turned a metaphor into a fact.”

The caution brought Shashank back once more to his old error at the Red Fort. Once, tempted to give an easy meaning to a tourist’s ambiguous sentence, he had shifted the direction of its meaning. Now, before every metaphor, he seemed to see a courtroom question: “Was this word in the original, or did you add it?”

Towards evening a small table arrived in which, after certain cash withdrawals, the balances in the accounts had fallen almost to zero. An assistant officer said casually, “Mule accounts.”

Aditya stopped him at once. “At this stage, even ‘mule account’ is a conclusion. Write: personal account; rapid inflow and outflow; cash withdrawal. The role of the account holder will be examined.”

Shashank looked at Aditya. For the first time he understood that in an investigation truth was not merely the work of adding things; very often it was also the work of subtracting words.

Some documents contained references to “cash settlement.” In some oral information the word hawala had appeared, but on the table that day there was no direct record establishing that these particular sums were hawala transactions. Aditya made two columns: “In the record” and “In the information.” For Shashank, this was no ordinary division. It was a door between story and evidence.

He asked, “What if the two columns connect later?”

“Then there must be evidence of the connection.”

“And if they do not?”

“Then they do not connect.”

“Even if the source of the information is reliable?”

“Reliability does not take the place of evidence.”

Shashank smiled. "Have you studied Navya-Nyaya?"

For the first time Aditya laughed openly. "No. But I have read a great many bad files."

For a moment the laughter narrowed the distance between them. Shashank felt something strange. Mrinal was his friend—the witness of his hard days in Delhi, the critic of his pride, the first hand extended in danger. Aditya was not a friend; yet at the level of method he understood the language of Shashank's mind. One was private trust, the other intellectual resistance. They were two different kinds of support.

That night, on the way home, Mrinal rode the bike slowly. At a red light he asked, "Did you quarrel with the officer again today?"

"No. He asks the right questions."

"That is progress."

"He stops me, but not out of stupidity."

Mrinal said, "Then learn from him."

Shashank answered at once, "I am teaching him a great deal too."

Mrinal gave a faint laugh. "That is precisely the sentence that frightens me."

The light turned green. The bike moved on. Sitting behind him, Shashank watched the lights of Delhi. He remembered leaving his village with a little money in his pocket, the dream of three books, and a hunger for language. Now before him lay papers from accounts through which lakhs moved as if they were merely numbers. The scale of the money was changing the name of the hunger inside him.

That night an unknown message arrived on his phone—in English, only this: "You understand the flow better than they do."

Shashank stared at the screen for a long time. The number was unfamiliar. There was no threat in the message, no offer, no name. Only a sentence that sounded like praise.

Mrinal asked, "Whose message?"

For a moment Shashank thought of saying, "Nothing." Then his incomplete defence in Chapter 7, the courtroom question in Chapter 8, and Aditya's words—"remembering and accepting are two different things"—rose together inside him.

He handed the phone to Mrinal. "Unknown number."

Mrinal read it. "Do not reply."

"Why?"

"Because someone who praises your talent at a time like this may not be reading your talent at all. He may be reading your weakness."

Shashank's face hardened. "Not every compliment is a trap."

"True. But not every trap looks like a threat."

Shashank took the phone back. He did not delete the message. He did not reply either.

The next day he showed the message to Aditya himself. Aditya noted the number, preserved a screenshot, and said only this: "Direct fact: this sentence arrived from an unknown number. Who the sender is, and what the purpose was, are presently unknown."

Shashank asked, "Do you not think it comes from that network?"

"I may think so—that is inference. I can record it. I cannot call it established."

Shashank nodded. The answer did not irritate him. On the contrary, it gave him a kind of relief. At least someone was not turning his fear into a story and selling it back to him.

At the end of the day Aditya prepared a brief list: movement of funds from the payment gateway into multiple accounts—directly observed; rapid inflow and outflow in some personal accounts—directly observed; cash withdrawals—directly observed; similarities in some names and messages—directly observed; some information suggesting a hawala connection—available, but the direct link to these particular transactions not yet established; one or two references relating to cryptocurrency—found, but their direct connection to the accounts not yet verified; actual beneficial ownership—not yet determined.

Shashank read the list. "After so many papers, the conclusion is this small?"

Aditya said, "In a good investigation the conclusion is often smaller than the file."

"And in a bad investigation?"

"The conclusion is made first. The papers are searched for afterwards."

Shashank fell silent. The sentence travelled a long way inside him. He knew his gift could do both things—limit a conclusion by the papers, or bend the meaning of the papers to fit a conclusion.

When Mrinal met him that evening, Shashank said of his own accord, "Today I showed the officer a message."

Mrinal smiled. "Thank you for telling me that."

Shashank laughed. "Why thank me?"

"Because friendship is not only standing beside someone in danger. It is also this: when you could have hidden something, you did not."

Something softened inside Shashank. When he had first come to Delhi, he had thought of friendship as support. Now he was beginning to understand that a true friend often reduces a man's conveniences. Mrinal protected him, but he did not protect his excuses.

That night Shashank opened his notebook. First he wrote: "Direct: the movement of money." Then a second line: "Inference: the purpose behind the movement." A third: "Friendship: the person who does not allow the two to become one."

He looked at the lines for a few moments. Then beneath them he wrote: "It is easy to say 'mule account'; hard to prove the account holder's role. It is easy to say hawala; hard to connect it to a specific chain of funds. It is easy to say cryptocurrency; hard to demonstrate its relationship to the records."

Shashank found this difficulty attractive. Hard questions summoned his talent. But he did not yet understand that behind this attraction another attraction was slowly taking shape—the attraction of understanding, once he had grasped the flow of money, how that flow might be redirected.

Direct knowledge still amounted only to this: some money had passed through several channels into personal accounts; some sums moved onward quickly or were withdrawn in cash; some messages indicated a "new road" for payments; the links to hawala and cryptocurrency remained limited to partial information and separate references; no particular account holder's criminal role followed automatically from these facts.

And the direct fact of friendship was only this: Mrinal stood with Shashank, but not with every excuse Shashank made.

In that distinction, for now, lay a road by which Shashank might still save himself.

And a road by which he might fall.

CHAPTER 12

MITHILA TO DELHI 12

For three days after the unknown message in Chapter 11, nothing happened. Shashank kept telling himself that to assign meaning to a single line of praise would itself be to enlarge an inference. But on the fourth day, through a teacher he knew from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, a formal email arrived. There was to be a two-day language session in Macao—a new presentation by the technical group he had met before, a review of certain payment-related terminology, and work examining language connected with Indian users within a limited level of computer access. The fee was almost twice what he had received for the first trip.

Shashank read the email once in full, a second time looking only at the amount, and a third time at the limits of the assignment. He did not laugh at himself. On his first trip to Macao he had been ashamed of the habit of looking at the money first; now the edge of that shame had gone blunt. When a man repeats the same failing often enough, it begins as discomfort, becomes habit, and ends as an argument in its own defence.

He showed the message to Mrinal. Mrinal read it for a long time, then asked, “The same group as last time?”

“Some of the same people. Some new.”

“The work?”

“Language. Presentation. Read access.”

“Written limits?”

“Yes.”

Mrinal looked at the page again. “It says ‘read-only review’ here. That is a good thing. But you are also reading papers from an investigation now. The two worlds have come very close to each other.”

Shashank’s voice hardened slightly. “I am not an officer. I am a translator.”

“Good. Then go as a translator.”

“You keep talking about boundaries.”

“Because every time you see a boundary, you begin measuring how intelligent it is.”

Shashank did not like the sentence. But that was one of Mrinal’s peculiar gifts: the sentences one disliked from him often acquired meaning after a few days had passed.

The very next day Shashank also informed Aditya Mishra about the trip. He could have concealed it; it was private work. But after showing the officer the message in Chapter 11, silence now felt heavy inside him. Aditya read the email and said, “I cannot stop you from taking private employment. But do not use there the records you have seen here; and do not return here and translate what you see there into established fact.”

Shashank smiled. “A boundary on both sides.”

“Yes. A boundary is not merely an ethical matter. It also protects evidence.”

“What if I see a name there that matches one in the papers here?”

Aditya replied, “Then the similarity of names will be directly observed. The role will still require separate evidence.”

There was nothing exciting in that answer. Perhaps for that very reason Shashank’s mind grew more restless in its search for excitement.

The second journey to Macao felt different from the first. Before, the city had looked small from the aeroplane window and he himself had felt large. This time the flight seemed no more than ordinary transport. The white bed in the guesthouse, the glass buildings, the lights, the courteous welcome—none of it astonished him. Familiarity reduces a man’s capacity for wonder; and when wonder recedes, greed can be seen more clearly.

At the beginning of the session, a senior Chinese coordinator praised Shashank’s pronunciation. “Last time you showed us some very precise distinctions between words,” he said. “This time we also need linguistic help in understanding the behaviour of Indian users.”

Shashank asked, “Behaviour—in what sense?”

“Which words people trust, which words create confusion, which information needs to be clear.”

The answer could have been commercial; it could have been innocent. Shashank wrote: “linguistic clarity.” He did not add a purpose to his notes.

He was given a temporary account. At the top of the screen it stated clearly: permission to read; modification prohibited. Compared with the first Macao trip, the arrangement was more orderly. There were separate sections

for merchant lists, customer support, settlement summaries, language forms, and regional information. Shashank was told to look only at the language-related pages.

The first hour was routine. They discussed Indian-language equivalents for ‘withdrawal,’ the difference between ‘pending’ and ‘under review,’ an appropriate word for ‘wallet,’ and error messages that would not frighten the customer. Shashank’s talent shone. He did not merely match Chinese and English words; he understood which sentences would sound like commands to an Indian ear, which like reassurance, and which like excuses.

In this praise his old pride in language awakened again. But now money had attached itself to the pride. An opinion he would have offered freely in a classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan was here being rewarded with a substantial fee. It was pleasant to see knowledge valued; the danger was that, once a man saw its price, he might begin setting even the boundaries of knowledge according to the market.

At noon a technical employee showed him some settlement information because the wording used in a customer message was linked to that status. Several merchant identifiers appeared on the screen. Shashank’s eyes stopped at an abbreviated name. Its Roman-letter form resembled the name of a payment recipient he had seen in Chapter II.

Two sentences rose inside him at once. The first: “It is the same.” The second: “Similarity of name is not identity.” Aditya’s voice was present within him even in Aditya’s absence.

Shashank asked the technical employee only this: “Is this merchant identifier the full legal name?”

The answer came: “No. It is an internal display name. Often abbreviated.”

The answer reduced the value of the resemblance. Shashank could have stopped there. But at the top of the screen was a search box through which names or terms could be searched for the purposes of language review. His assigned scope was to examine language; yet the name he was about to type came not from the needs of language review, but from the memory of the investigation.

His hand stopped.

Mrinal’s words—“Go as a translator.” Aditya’s words—“Do not mix the two worlds.” The extra report page from the first Macao trip. All of them returned together.

Then Shashank typed the name.

Two brief entries appeared. One was a merchant identifier, the other an old service reference. No bank account. No beneficial owner. No word suggesting a crime. Only this much: a sign resembling the name existed in the records of this system as well. Shashank took no photograph, made no copy, and changed nothing. But he knew that the purpose of the search lay outside the limits of the work he had been given in writing.

He closed the screen and returned to the original language page. No one stopped him. No one asked him anything. In the outer world, the incident was trivial. Inside him, it was a clearer step than on the first journey: before, the boundary had been crossed in a haze between knowing and not knowing; this time he saw the boundary and crossed it anyway.

At dinner that evening, the senior coordinator said to him, “You understand the language of flows in India. If you advise us regularly in future, there could be a monthly arrangement.”

The word “flows” put Shashank on alert. “Linguistic flows?”

The coordinator laughed. “Customers, merchants, support—everything. You are not a technical man. You are a language man.”

Again the answer was ambiguous. Shashank could have asked more questions. But in that moment the suggestion of a monthly payment proved stronger than his hunger to ask them. He said only, “Send the terms in writing.”

The answer was cautious, and it was willing. Greed often does not say “yes.” It says, “Send the details.”

That night Mrinal called. “How is the work?”

“Language work.”

“Only that?”

Shashank looked towards the window. Lights lay below. “Only that.”

As soon as he said it, he knew the sentence was not wholly false, but neither was it wholly true. He had concealed the search-box incident. On the first journey he had concealed the matter of an additional page; on the second he concealed a search he had carried out deliberately. Repetition changes the shape of a failing.

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. Then he said, “You are speaking slowly. Is there something?”

Shashank’s heart struck hard. “I’m tired.”

“All right. We’ll talk when you return.”

The call ended. Shashank felt no relief. His friend had stopped asking questions, but the silence itself had become a question.

The next day, when the language session ended, the fee was confirmed. On seeing the amount, Shashank did not first think of home. He thought: I could live somewhere better in Delhi; a new phone; better clothes; perhaps a laptop. None of these thoughts was wrong. The problem was that money was no longer merely a means of reducing hardship; it was becoming a means of changing identity.

He rebuked himself. "Keep need and greed separate." In the language of Navya-Nyaya he tried to distinguish the objects of his own mind. But mental analysis does not make a man pure; sometimes it merely makes his excuses more refined.

On the flight back to Delhi, Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote: "Direct: written language-review assignment; limited read access; resemblance of one abbreviated name; two records returned by the search; no ownership or crime directly established."

On the second line: "Inference: there may be a connection between the Macao system and certain payment records in Delhi."

Third: "Allegation: this system is part of an unlawful flow of money."

Fourth: "Not established."

He was about to close the notebook when he wrote a fifth line: "Established fact: I searched the name not because my language work required it, but because I remembered the Delhi investigation."

The line made him uncomfortable. It was easy to apply logic to things outside oneself; when turned inward, its edge felt sharper.

When he reached Delhi, Mrinal did not come to collect him. There was only a message: "You must be tired. We'll meet tomorrow." The ordinary sentence felt unusual to Shashank. On the day friendship ceases to celebrate every journey a man makes, he begins to see his inward journey more clearly.

The next morning, before going to Aditya's office, he spent a long time wondering whether to mention the resemblance of the name. There was no documentary proof, only his memory. No one had asked him about it either. Silence would be easy. But he could no longer clearly see the boundary between silence as confidentiality, silence as selected truth, and silence as the beginning of deceit.

He gave Aditya the general account of the trip—language review, read access, settlement-related terminology. He did not mention the search for the name.

Aditya asked, "Did you see anything there that changes the meaning of the records here?"

Shashank's throat went dry. "Not directly."

Technically, the answer could be defended. No meaning had been conclusively changed. But he knew that the purpose of the question was not merely courtroom defensibility; it was completeness.

Aditya nodded. "All right. Then for now, the papers here will remain on the evidence available here."

Shashank walked out. He did not feel victorious; he felt burdened. The first advantage of deceit is that a man is not caught immediately. Its first punishment is that he remembers the whole sentence inside himself.

That evening, over tea with Mrinal, Shashank was unusually quiet. Mrinal did not ask many questions. After a long time he said only, "Your language has changed."

"What do you mean?"

"Earlier you searched for words to make difficult things clear. Now, sometimes, it feels as though you make clear things difficult when you speak."

Shashank's hand went still on the glass. "Have you already decided that I am guilty?"

"No. I am saying only that your sentences are changing."

There was neither accusation nor forgiveness in the answer. Only direct observation. For that very reason it hurt Shashank more.

That night he did not remember the phonetics book from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. He remembered the Tao temple in Pitampura—Juliana, about whom his teacher had once said that tone is not merely a matter of the throat; impatience in the mind can spoil pronunciation too. Shashank had not gone there for a long time.

He decided that on his next free day he would go to Pitampura.

Direct knowledge, for now, amounted to this: Shashank had travelled to Macao a second time; under a written language-review assignment he had received limited read access; a sign resembling a name he had seen in the Delhi records appeared in the system; outside the needs of his assigned work, Shashank searched that name; the result established neither a crime nor actual beneficial ownership; he told neither Mrinal nor Aditya about the search; and a possible offer of regular advisory work was placed before him.

The inference was only this: there might be a connection between the two sets of records.

And the fact of greed was only this: Shashank now recognised that his hunger was not merely for money. He was drawn to privileged access, to the pleasure of being indispensable, and to possessing knowledge that others did not have.

The first journey to Macao had shown him the boundary. The second showed him how quietly a man could decide to cross it.

CHAPTER 13

THE TAO TEMPLE AT PITAMPURA

Shashank had decided, on the very night of Chapter 12, to go to Pitampura, but for three days he did not go. It was not for lack of time. Time he had; courage he did not. To sit before Juliana meant hearing not only his own pronunciation, but the tremor within himself. And just then there were several sentences in his own throat that he did not wish to hear.

At dawn on the fourth day he came out of the Metro and walked towards the temple. The October air was faintly cool. The shops along the road were not yet fully open. From the outer courtyard of the temple came the sound of a broom. Inside there was the light fragrance of incense, but the first thing he became aware of was not peace—it was the rapid beating of his own heart.

Juliana was in the same room where she had once made him practise Mandarin and Cantonese tones. On the small table stood two cups of tea, a notebook, and the old pages of phonetic exercises. The moment she saw Shashank she smiled, but asked no question.

“It has been a long time,” Shashank said.

“Fewer days than distance,” Juliana replied. “Sit.”

Shashank sat down. As before, he instinctively reached to open his notebook, then stopped his hand. Juliana noticed the small movement.

“Not writing today,” she said. “Listening today.”

Juliana spoke four short sentences, the same word in different tones. The first time Shashank repeated them easily. The second time his tones were correct, but he went too fast. The third time the final syllable rose where it should have remained level.

Juliana lifted a hand. “Slowly.”

Shashank spoke again.

“The tone is right. But before the word is finished, you are already worrying about the next sentence.”

Shashank tried to laugh. “Is that a fault of pronunciation?”

“Sometimes. Sometimes of the mind.”

Silence settled over the room after that answer. In Shashank’s memory the search box in Macao flashed—the name he had searched for beyond the requirements of his linguistic work; Aditya’s questions; Mrinal’s sentence: your language has changed.

Juliana pushed the cup of tea towards him. “You used to come here to learn language. Have you come now to escape from language?”

Shashank took the cup. “Can anyone escape from language?”

“A person who knows many words can preserve the illusion of escape for longer.”

The sentence was not harsh, yet it struck deep. Shashank asked, “What if one has no right to say something?”

“Then do not say it.”

“What if one does have the right to say it, but saying it raises questions about oneself?”

Juliana kept looking at him. “Then the question is not about language. It is about fear.”

Shashank lowered his eyes. Outside the temple someone rang a bell. Once. Then silence again.

Juliana said, “Confidentiality and keeping something hidden are not the same thing. I do not teach law; I only listen to language. But a voice often reveals which words a person chooses, and which words he leaves out.”

Shashank did not argue at once. He thought of how often he had given his silence names such as “boundary,” “confidentiality,” “uncertainty,” “incomplete direct knowledge.” Not all those names were false. The trouble was that in several places he had hidden his desire behind a correct word.

At that moment his phone vibrated. Raghav Bhasin’s name appeared on the screen.

Shashank stepped out into the courtyard and answered.

“Where are you?” Raghav asked.

“Pitampura.”

“Can you come to the office in two hours? There is a meeting with a Chinese client. Translation only. There are some documents as well.”

Something tightened inside Shashank’s stomach. “A legal meeting?”

“Yes. That is why I called. Treat what you hear as confidential. But where you do not understand something, do not infer. Keep the words as they are.”

After the call ended, Shashank stood in the courtyard for a few moments. Keep the words as they are—once, that instruction would have carried his old calm. Now every boundary reminded him of a boundary he had already crossed.

He went back inside and told Juliana, “Work has come.”

Juliana said only, “Listen slowly. Then speak.”

By the time he reached Raghav’s office, the meeting had already begun. In a medium-sized conference room sat Raghav, his assistant, two Chinese representatives, and an Indian accounting adviser. Three folders lay on the table—one marked “Legal Advice,” another “Business Records,” the third without any title.

Raghav took Shashank aside and said, “Your work is translation only. Translate the legal questions the client asks. Translate the commercial facts exactly as they are too. Do not soften anything or make it harsher.”

Shashank nodded. He remembered the old day at the Red Fort when the small difference between “did not see” and “did not pay attention” had later become a question in court.

The first half-hour of the meeting was ordinary: a reply to a notice, the language of a contract, the reason a payment had been held, the meaning of several emails. Of the two Chinese representatives, the older man spoke with great deliberation. The younger was impatient and repeatedly added something before Raghav had finished his answer.

At one point the older representative said, “We want what is in the lawyer’s file not to be seen by outsiders as ordinary business records.”

Shashank translated. Raghav replied, “Communications that are genuinely for legal advice have a different character. But changing the name of a file will not change the nature of older business papers. We cannot alter facts by manufacturing a label.”

Shashank paused for a moment in the middle of translating. We cannot alter facts by manufacturing a label—the sentence rose and stood before the many headings he himself had written in his notebook.

The younger representative immediately said something in a sharp tone. Shashank listened, then translated slowly: “He is asking whether, if an old message is later sent to a lawyer for legal advice, the entire message then becomes a legal communication.”

Raghav leaned back in his chair. “I will not answer a general question in a way that could be used to conceal a fact. Keep clear the history of what a document was made for, when, and for what purpose. If you want my advice, tell me the whole sequence.”

The room was silent for a moment. The Indian accounting adviser capped his pen. The younger representative’s face hardened, but the older man nodded.

Then the third folder was opened. It contained mixed papers—travel bills, service summaries, several chat printouts, and a list on which several merchant identifiers were written in Roman letters. Shashank’s eyes went automatically to the list.

One abbreviated identifier brought the Macao screen back to him. Not a full name. Only three letters and a digit. The resemblance was unclear. Direct knowledge went no further than this: the form looked similar; identity was not established.

His throat went dry again.

Raghav slid a page towards him. “Read this chat.”

Shashank read. In the message, one person was asking another whether the name displayed to the customer could be changed before “review.” The reply said: “Ask the technical team; record the reason.” That was all. Nothing about why the change was wanted, what review was meant, or which customer.

The younger representative said, “It was an ordinary presentation change.”

The older representative stopped him. “Say what is written.”

Shashank became alert at that small sentence. Say what is written. Juliana’s “Listen slowly. Then speak” came and settled on the same line beside it.

Raghav asked, “Shashank, is the word ‘review’ more specific in the Chinese original?”

Shashank read the page again. “No. By itself, the word does not establish whether this means a tax review, an internal review, a customer review, or something else. There is no context.”

“And ‘changing the name’?”

“Changing the displayed name. This sentence does not establish a change of account, ownership, or beneficiary.”

Raghav looked at his assistant. “Good. Put only that in the note.”

A strange relief rose inside Shashank. Here his linguistic skill was protecting a boundary, not deception. Yet with the relief came fear: if the method was this clean, why had he himself hidden the Macao search from Aditya?

The meeting went on. At one point Raghav asked several questions separately—who created a paper, who received it, when, and for what purpose. He did not use the word “crime.” Shashank saw that the discipline of direct knowledge was without glamour: date, sender, recipient, purpose, copy. Yet this very dullness placed limits around the fire of accusation.

Before the meeting ended, the younger representative asked Shashank separately in Chinese, “Do you speak to anyone outside about this?”

Before answering, Shashank looked towards Raghav. Raghav had not understood the exchange, but he caught the look. “What did he ask?”

Shashank translated the question in full.

Raghav told the representative, “Do not put the translator in a position where he has to give personal assurances. The office will give whatever instructions apply to the confidentiality of this meeting.”

The answer increased Shashank’s fear. The question might have been entirely ordinary, yet another question rose inside him: if someone demanded a private promise of silence from him, what silence would he be promising? The client’s confidential communication? A fact he himself had seen? A search he himself had carried out? The three were not the same.

After the representatives left, Raghav closed the file. Shashank was about to rise, but sat down again.

“I have a question,” he said.

“Ask.”

“If a translator is present in a confidential legal meeting, does that confidentiality also apply to the translator’s own conduct?”

Raghav lifted one eyebrow slightly. “His own conduct—meaning?”

Shashank chose his words. “Suppose, outside the meeting, he did something that might later connect with the same subject. Would the confidentiality of the meeting cover what he himself did?”

Raghav did not hurry to answer. “I will not give a legal ruling on your hypothetical question. But understand one simple thing: confidential material another person gives you for legal advice, and something you yourself do, are not the same event. Giving them one name does not make them one thing.”

Shashank’s fingers went still on the edge of the table.

Raghav looked at him. “Is there something real behind this?”

At the question, fear spread through Shashank’s whole body. The Macao search. Aditya’s question. Mrinal’s silence. Shashank could easily have said, “No.” It was a simple word.

He remembered Juliana’s voice: listen slowly, then speak.

Shashank said, “There is something. But it is not part of your client’s meeting. It concerns the limits of my own work.”

Raghav straightened in his chair. “Then do not mix it with the confidentiality of this meeting. Tell me the facts in sequence, to the extent you think necessary. If I have no role in it, I will say so plainly.”

Shashank did not make a complete confession all at once. He was still afraid. But for the first time he opened a crack in the wall of words he himself had built. He said that, during language review in Macao, a name had seemed similar to one in the Delhi records, and that he had typed the name into the search box even though doing so was outside the requirements of his assigned work. He had not told Aditya.

Raghav did not interrupt him. At the end he asked only, “Did you alter anything?”

“No.”

“Did you take a copy?”

“No.”

“Did what you saw establish a crime?”

“No.”

“Then for now the fact is only this: you conducted a search outside the scope of your authorised linguistic work, saw some ambiguous entries, and did not tell the investigating officer.”

Shashank said quietly, “Yes.”

Raghav took a deep breath. “That is not part of my client’s confidential communication. And I will not advise you to hide it behind some label. Understand clearly whatever institutional duty you have.”

The sentence gave Shashank no relief. On the contrary, the fear became more real. But now the fear had a name. Before, it had been an unnamed shadow; now he knew that his problem was not “confidentiality,” but his own selective silence.

Leaving the office, he did not go straight home. Evening had already fallen, yet he turned towards Pitampura again. It was almost closing time at the temple. Juliana was watering the plants on the outer veranda.

The moment she saw him, she asked, "Work finished?"

"The meeting finished. The matter did not."

Juliana laughed. "When do matters ever finish?"

Shashank sat at the edge of the veranda. After a while he said, "Today I told one thing in full. For many days I had been telling only half of it."

"To whom?"

"To a lawyer. Perhaps later I will have to tell the officer too."

Juliana offered no praise. She merely set the watering vessel down and said, "You understand the value of a complete sentence when half a sentence begins to bring you advantage."

Shashank's eyes went towards the open door of the temple. There was little light inside. He remembered his first day there, when he had come only to learn tones. Then his problem had been that the rises and falls did not land correctly. Now the problem was that even when the words were right, the purpose could be crooked.

He asked Juliana, "Will fear go away?"

"Why should it?"

"After telling the truth."

"Truth is not medicine that makes fear disappear the moment you swallow it. Truth only ensures that the cause of fear is not given a false name."

Shashank remained silent. This time his silence was not a defence. It was only exhaustion.

That night, when he reached home, he opened his notebook. At the top of the page he wrote: "Direct knowledge."

First line: "Conversation with Juliana at the Tao temple: the question of keeping confidentiality separate from concealment."

Second: "Legal meeting at Raghav's office; translator's role limited; business records and legal communications not merged under a single label."

Third: "A chat asked about changing a displayed name; purpose ambiguous; no crime, ownership, or flow of money established."

Fourth: "I told Raghav about the search I carried out in Macao beyond the limits of my assigned work."

Fifth: "I have still not told Aditya."

He stared at the fifth line for a long time. As before, alternative formulations suggested themselves: "I did not get the opportunity"; "relevance not yet established"; "confidentiality unclear." Every sentence could be true in some part. But he changed nothing.

Direct knowledge, for now, amounted only to this: Shashank went to the Tao temple at Pitampura; he spoke with Juliana about language, silence, and fear; at Raghav Bhasin's office he interpreted a confidential legal meeting; Raghav refused to merge the nature of business records with that of legal communications; an ambiguous chat raised a question about changing a displayed name, but did not establish purpose or crime; Shashank told Raghav about his out-of-scope search in Macao; he had still not told Aditya.

The inference went only this far: some of the signs Shashank had seen might become relevant to a future investigation; they did not yet establish a connection.

And the fact of fear was only this: for the first time Shashank understood that he was less afraid of disclosing someone else's confidential information than of being made to account for his own selective silence. The temple at Pitampura gave him no letter of absolution. It merely made him hear the tone again. The words were the same; the difference was that this time, for the first time, Shashank was hearing his own sentence in full.

CHAPTER 14

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE I

After returning from the Tao temple at Pitampura, five lines remained in Shashank's notebook, but one word stayed lodged in his mind—"word." In the tradition of Gangesha Upadhyaya, a word was not merely sound; a statement received from a trustworthy source could itself become evidence. But if the source's reliability clouded over, then however brilliant the sentence, its evidentiary value changed.

The fifth line of Chapter 13—"I have still not told Aditya"—had pricked inside him like a thorn ever since that night. He knew silence and falsehood were not the same thing. But he also knew that a truth not spoken at the proper time could later change its colour.

The next day Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan held a special practice session with his old teacher. After a long absence, Shashank returned to that classroom. The phonetic chart still hung on the wall, but in those characters he could no longer see the innocent curiosity of his first day. He saw his former self—the young man who learned words, measured the limits of meaning, and believed that correct pronunciation would carry a person to correct meaning.

The teacher wrote a Chinese sentence on the blackboard and said, "Three people may hear the same sentence in three different ways. The first question is not whose meaning is best. The first question is: who said it, in what context, and which part did the listener actually hear?"

Shashank's pen stopped on the page. He remembered Aditya's question—"Did you hear this yourself, or did you hear it from someone else?" At the time, the question had seemed unnecessarily severe. Today, in his teacher's voice, he heard the same question repeated.

At the end of the exercise, the teacher gave a small example. A merchant says, "Hold the goods." If the translator writes, "Hold the payment," only one word has changed, but the event itself has changed. The teacher said, "A translator has the right to open meaning, not to create a new event."

Lowering his eyes, Shashank wrote, "The evidentiary value of a statement depends on source, context, and intention." Beneath the line his hand wrote of its own accord, "And the meaning of silence?" He did not write an answer.

The moment he stepped out of the classroom, his phone vibrated. The number was unfamiliar. He answered. A man's voice said, "Mr Jha, it concerns the old tax matter. We only need the language clarified."

Shashank asked, "Who is speaking?"

The reply came, "What use is a name? You know our mutual acquaintance. It has been said from above that the wording in one record is too harsh. Keep the meaning the same, just soften the language."

A faint shiver passed through Shashank's body. "From above"—he had heard those two words many times before. Above whom? What order? Written or oral? By whose authority? The moment those questions were asked, the shine came off the sentence.

He said, "I cannot say anything without seeing the record. And if it is an official document, send it through an authorised channel."

The voice on the phone was silent for a moment. Then it said, "You have begun talking a great deal about rules. You were not this difficult before."

The sentence struck Shashank because it was not entirely false. Earlier he had seen opportunity first and the boundary later. Now the boundary was appearing first—but that did not erase what he had done before.

The call ended. The number remained on the phone screen. Shashank saved a screenshot and wrote the time in his notebook. The thought of calling Aditya came at once, but he stopped again. The fifth line of Chapter 13 seemed to be holding his hand from within.

He walked towards the Red Fort. After many days he saw groups of Chinese tourists there again. The red sandstone, the crowd at the entrance, fragments of different languages—everything was as before, but for Shashank the place was no longer a training ground. It had become a court of memory.

An elderly Chinese couple stood uncertainly over a map. Shashank helped them naturally. Hearing his pronunciation, the woman asked how many years he had lived in China. Shashank laughed. "Very few. Most of my practice happened here."

The man said, "From your speech, it sounds as though you have lived among many people."

Shashank paused before replying. "Yes, among many people. But living among people and understanding them are not the same thing."

In the middle of that brief conversation, a message arrived on his phone. The sender was Raghav Bhasin. It said only: "Do not rely on anyone's informal word. If there is an official paper, ask for a written copy."

Shashank was startled. He had not told Raghav about the unknown call. Was the message a coincidence, or had word reached Raghav through someone else? The direct fact was only that the message had arrived. Everything else was inference.

He did not reply. Standing in the shadow of the Red Fort's rampart, he felt for the first time that words did not merely carry meaning; they also revealed the direction of relationships. Who knew, who did not; who warned first; who hid a name and said "from above"—all of these could themselves become events.

At the same time, elsewhere, in the local commissionerate, Aditya Mishra had two copies of a file before him. The first carried a note directing that the inspection continue. The second, dated three days later, said: "Guidance awaited from higher level; further action stayed." The two notes bore different signatures in sequence, but there was no written order attached as the basis for the second.

A junior officer said, "Sir, an oral instruction had come."

Aditya asked, "From whom?"

"From the senior office."

"Name?"

The officer was silent.

Aditya asked again, "Did you hear it yourself?"

"No, sir. It was said in the section."

"By whom?"

This time an answer came, but without conviction. The name of an assistant was given. He was on leave that day.

Aditya made three headings on the paper—"Direct," "Heard," "Inference." Direct: there is a stay note in the file. Heard: the junior officer was told that an oral instruction had come from the senior office. Inference: perhaps someone's influence was used in an attempt to stop the inquiry. Beside the third line he wrote in bold letters: "NOT YET ESTABLISHED."

His colleague Arun said, "Everything is obvious. Why is it necessary to write all this?"

Aditya replied, "Where something appears most obvious is precisely where it is necessary to write. Otherwise tomorrow I will remember my own understanding as though it were evidence."

Arun did not laugh. He kept looking at the paper. Then he said quietly, "A great many people are interested in this file."

"Interest is not a crime."

"No. But be careful."

Aditya listened to his tone. Was it a warning, or friendship? Fear, or information? The words were one thing, the source familiar; the source's state of mind was not direct evidence.

After noon, Aditya received a call from the senior office. The voice was courteous. "Mr Mishra, the matter is sensitive. Proceed according to process. Do not expand it unnecessarily."

Aditya asked, "Please send the instruction in writing."

There was a brief silence at the other end. Then came the reply: "Not everything is put in writing."

Aditya said, "In an investigation, if something is not in writing, its limits should still be recorded in writing."

The call ended. Aditya wrote no conclusion. He merely recorded the time of the call, the number, and the principal sentence spoken. Anger rose inside him, but he did not give anger the place of evidence.

That evening Shashank reached the Tao temple at Pitampura. Juliana was gathering papers from a small table near the main hall. The moment she saw him, she asked, "Today it is not tone, but words that are heavy?"

Shashank looked at her in surprise. "How did you know?"

"By the way you walk. When a person begins defending his sentence before he has spoken it, his feet change pace."

Shashank sat down. He told her about the unknown call and Raghav's message, but when he came to the fact that he had still not told Aditya about the out-of-scope Macao search, his voice broke.

Juliana listened without interrupting. At the end she said, "When you were learning language, you did one thing very well—when you did not understand, you asked again. Why do you not ask now?"

"Whom?"

"Yourself. Whom are you protecting?"

No answer came from Shashank's mouth.

Juliana said, “Betrayal is not something only another person commits. Sometimes a person betrays what he has learned. You learned the limits of words. If, knowing those limits, you now use words as a shield, the fault is not language’s.”

The sentence sank very deep inside Shashank. His teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan had said: a translator must not create a new event. At the Red Fort he had learned not to add what he had not heard. At the Tao temple Juliana had taught him not to assign silence whatever meaning suited him. Years of discipline had pushed him in one direction; the betrayal was that, whenever it suited him, he kept changing the name of that direction.

He stepped outside the temple and called Aditya. This time he did not wait for the call to end.

“Mr Mishra, I need to add something.”

Aditya’s voice remained flat. “Go ahead.”

“Once in Macao, I opened a server interface outside the scope of my authorised access. I saw some directory names. I have already told Raghav Bhasin this. I did not tell you.”

There was silence for a few moments.

Aditya asked, “Why did you not tell me?”

Shashank answered, “At first I told myself it was irrelevant. Then I kept putting it aside under the name of confidentiality. Now I understand that neither word was the complete reason.”

“Tell me exactly what you saw, and only that much. We will examine the meaning later.”

Shashank gave the details—the journey, the device, how long he had access, what he saw, what he did not see. He said clearly that the screen did not establish any flow of money, ownership, crime, or involvement by a government officer.

Aditya interrupted only to ask dates and sequence. At the end he said, “Give me a written statement tomorrow. And one thing: what you have told me today does not erase the fact that you did not tell me earlier. Both things will remain in the record.”

The sentence seemed harsh to Shashank, but just as well. Repentance does not erase the previous line; it only gives one the chance to write the next line truthfully.

After the call, Shashank opened his notebook. At the top he wrote: “Word.”

First line: “Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: the meaning of a statement depends on source, context, and the part actually heard.”

Second: “Unknown call: ‘it has been said from above’; source unclear; authority not established.”

Third: “Raghav’s message: warning not to rely on informal words; how he learned of the call is unknown.”

Fourth: “In the local inquiry there is a written stay note; no independent written basis for the alleged oral instruction from a senior authority is presently available.”

Fifth: “Told Aditya about the out-of-scope server view in Macao.”

Sixth: “I had withheld this information earlier.”

He did not strike out the sixth line.

The evidentiary value of words was no longer, for him, a matter of grammar. The questions were now these: whose words? Received from whom? In what context? How much was direct? How much memory? How much convenience? And how much fear?

The established fact of betrayal was not, at this stage, a crime by any senior officer. The established facts were only these: there was a written note staying the inquiry, but no written instruction presently available as its basis; an anonymous caller had asked Shashank to soften language; and Shashank had failed to tell Aditya about an important experience at the proper time.

The inference went only this far: these events might be connected. To turn that inference into established fact would itself be the beginning of the very wrong from which Aditya was trying to protect his method.

Night deepened. Shashank closed the notebook. For the first time he felt that the discipline of language was not a journey towards perfect pronunciation, but a journey towards learning how much weight each word could bear—and when a person betrayed his own words.

CHAPTER 15

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 2

At dawn, Shashank's phone kept vibrating. The first message was from Mrinal: "Call me before you open any news page." The second was from a classmate: "What is this that has been published?" The third, fourth, and fifth messages all carried the same link.

Shashank looked at the phone screen many times, but did not open the link. The first line of the written statement he had decided, on the night of Chapter 14, to give Aditya was still open in his notebook. He had thought that the truth had been told late, but that at least now the record would contain it whole. The morning messages made him understand that before a record reached the court, it could begin a second life of its own in the street.

Mrinal called again.

"Did you open the link?"

"No."

"Then listen to me first. The headline says that you admitted to unauthorised access to a foreign server and that you knew of a secret arrangement to stop the tax inquiry."

Shashank's mouth went dry. "I never said the second thing."

"I know. But the article says, 'according to sources.'"

Shashank opened the link. The headline stood in heavy type. Inside, his name, Macao, the server, Raghav Bhasin, the tax inquiry, and the words "senior level" had been joined together as though they were all proven parts of the same sentence. Nowhere did the article state clearly what Shashank had seen himself, what he had merely heard, and what the writer had connected by inference.

One line said: "The sealed material is said to describe the translator's role as decisive."

Shashank read the line three times. "Is said"—said by whom? Which material? Whose word was "decisive"? The article answered none of these questions.

He told Mrinal, "This is a false allegation."

Mrinal did not answer quickly. After a few moments he said, "Some of it is certainly false. But it is now on record that you opened the server interface. If, in defending yourself, you call the whole article false, you will weaken even the part of your defence that is true."

The sentence stung Shashank. He wanted his friend to say: all of it is false, all of it is conspiracy. But Mrinal stopped him at exactly the point where Aditya always stopped him—accept what is established; contest what is not.

Shashank said, "Then what should I say?"

"First separate the words."

The answer took him back at once to his first class at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan—a change of tone could change meaning. Now it was not tone but category that was changing: direct knowledge, testimony, inference, allegation, established fact.

He opened his notebook.

"Established fact: once, I opened a server interface beyond the limits of my authorised work."

Second line: "Established fact: I first told Raghav Bhasin this, and later agreed to give it to Aditya Mishra in writing."

Third: "False allegation: I admitted to direct knowledge of a secret arrangement to stop the tax inquiry."

Fourth: "Unverified statement: my role in the sealed material is said to be 'decisive.'"

Fifth: "Inference: part of a sealed record, or an interpretation of it, reached the news media."

Beside the fifth line he wrote: "Not yet established."

Meanwhile, the atmosphere in Aditya Mishra's office was harsher. A senior officer placed a printed copy of the news report on his desk and asked, "How did this material get outside?"

Aditya replied, "I do not know yet."

"The file was in your unit."

"Some parts of the file are available in my unit. Access to the complete sealed material is much more restricted."

The senior officer's voice hardened. "What is written in the news—is it in the file?"

Aditya looked at the headline. "Not in this form."

"Meaning?"

"Shashank has admitted to viewing a server outside the limits of his assignment. But his statement contains no direct knowledge of a secret arrangement to stop the tax inquiry. Nor have I seen the sentence 'role decisive' in the record available to me."

Silence spread through the room.

The senior officer said, "Then the media wrote falsely?"

Aditya replied, "I do not know the writer's source. I can only say that the words in my record and the words in the news report are not the same."

"You speak very cautiously."

"The matter requires caution."

When the meeting ended, Aditya returned to his desk. He called for the access list for the sealed material. The list was short. But a short list did not prove a crime. A person's name appearing on it established only that the person was authorised to have access; the fact of having passed material outside required separate evidence.

He made three columns—"Access," "Copies," "Dissemination." The first contained names. The second, the number of recorded copies. The third was blank.

Arun said quietly, "Everyone's eyes are on you."

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"Because the news report points towards the local unit. People above will say the leak came from here."

Aditya stopped his pen. "If they say it, that will be an allegation. Evidence will still be required."

Arun kept looking at him. "I do not know whether this method of yours will protect you or leave you alone."

Aditya gave a faint smile. "The method is not meant to protect me."

At that moment Shashank arrived at the office to give his written statement. Two journalists were standing at the entrance. One called out his name: "Mr Jha, were you a technical associate of a foreign gambling network?"

Shashank stopped. The words "gambling network" sent anger through him. Up to this stage, what stood before him were some suspicious payment routes, foreign vendors, a server interface, and signs of name changes; there was no established fact that he had been a "technical associate."

The second journalist asked, "Did you name a senior tax officer in your sealed statement?"

Shashank wanted to say loudly, "No." But he knew that his written statement had yet to be formally recorded, and that he himself did not know every part of the sealed material.

He said only, "What I directly saw or did, I will give in writing to the authorised officer. Do not attach to my name what I have not said."

The journalist asked again, "Then is the news report false?"

This time Shashank remembered Mrinal's sentence. "The report contains some facts, and also some statements I did not make. It would not be right to give both the same name."

He went inside.

Aditya motioned for him to sit. On the table were the recording notice, the papers, and the time record. "Read your statement. Change any word that is not yours. Whatever you choose to say is your responsibility."

Shashank began to read. The first three pages set out the sequence of events. On the fourth page was the sentence: "The translator came to suspect that the access in question lay outside the scope of ordinary translation work."

Shashank stopped. "'Came to suspect' is correct. But even now I cannot say that the access itself was criminal."

Aditya said, "Then add that."

Shashank wrote: "Being outside the assigned scope and being criminal are not the same thing; the latter conclusion requires independent evidence."

On the fifth page was the information he had earlier given Raghav. Shashank read it and fell silent.

Aditya asked, "Anything to change?"

"No. This is correct."

"Then sign it."

Shashank signed. As he lifted the pen, it seemed to him that amid the public humiliation this small signature was something hard and solid—here he could not run away from his own words.

When the statement was complete, Aditya showed him the printed copy of the news report. "Would you like to comment on this?"

Shashank read the article again. In that moment his talent, pride, and humiliation woke together. He wanted to tear apart every sentence the writer had made, by grammar, source, and logic. He could do it. Perhaps—the word rose in his mind and he stopped himself; “perhaps” was more truthful—he could do it. But the question was whether doing so was necessary.

He said, “I will give one page. I will only clarify the distinctions.”

Aditya said, “There is no need to make a speech in your defence here. Write facts.”

Shashank wrote one page:

“One: I once opened a server interface outside the limits of my authorised translation work; this is now recorded in my written statement.

Two: I have neither seen, heard, nor admitted to any secret arrangement with a senior tax officer to stop the inquiry.

Three: the sealed material in its entirety has not been made available to me; I therefore make no claim about everything it contains.

Four: any additional statement published in my name should be independently verified.”

He did not write: “All the allegations are false.”

As he came out, he found Mrinal waiting. There were two cups of tea in his hands. Giving one to Shashank, he said, “This time you did the right thing.”

Shashank asked, “What?”

“You did not call the whole world false merely in order to defend yourself.”

They walked in silence for some distance. On a digital news display beside the road, Shashank’s name flashed again. The photograph was an old one—from the Red Fort, where he stood smiling among a group of Chinese tourists. It had been taken at a time when he had believed language would give him an honoured place among the worlds he moved between.

Now the same photograph had become an emblem of public disgrace.

Shashank took a sip of tea. “Does language raise a person, or bring him down?”

Mrinal said, “Not language. The use of words.”

Shashank looked at him. “Juliana says something like that too.”

“Then two people are telling you the same thing. Perhaps—” Mrinal corrected himself—“perhaps it is time to listen.”

They both laughed, but the laughter was brief.

That evening Shashank reached the Tao temple at Pitampura. Juliana had seen the news. She offered no consolation. She asked only, “Which word hurt you most?”

Shashank said, “‘Decisive.’”

“Why?”

“Because it makes me the centre of the event. As though everything happened because of me.”

Juliana asked, “Were you the centre?”

“No.”

“Were you entirely outside it?”

Shashank took time before answering. “Not that either.”

Juliana said, “Then the humiliation hurts more because the false statement carries a few particles of truth with it. A complete falsehood is an easy enemy. A half-truth is harder.”

Shashank remained silent.

“The discipline of words is here,” Juliana said. “Even when you are humiliated, do not break the boundary of words. If another person gives you a false name, do not give him a false name in your own defence.”

That night, when he returned home, Shashank opened his notebook. At the top he wrote: “Word: humiliation.”

First line: “The news report contains the fact of the out-of-scope server view.”

Second: “The report attributes to me direct knowledge of a secret arrangement to stop the tax inquiry; that is not my statement.”

Third: “I do not know the complete contents of the sealed material.”

Fourth: “The source of the leak is not yet established.”

Fifth: “Public humiliation is not evidence.”

Sixth: “Reaction to humiliation is not evidence either.”

After a long while he wrote a seventh line: “Because of my earlier silence, I do not feel wholly innocent in my own conscience; but I will not allow guilt to become evidence for someone else’s false allegation.”

After writing the line, he put the pen down.

Elsewhere, Aditya was comparing the access list, the copy register, and the publication timeline. He found one interesting fact: before the news report was published, an official digital copy of part of the sealed file had been created, but the available log did not make clear who had downloaded it. It was a lead, not proof of guilt.

He wrote in the file: "Creation of digital copy established. Person responsible for external dissemination unknown. Additional records required for identification."

With that single sentence he was protecting three people—the possibly innocent employee, himself, and the investigation.

Late at night, Aditya read Shashank's written clarification again. His eye stopped on one line: "The sealed material in its entirety has not been made available to me."

He murmured, "At least the man is learning to write 'I do not know.' "

It was not praise. But neither was it condemnation.

For Shashank, the discipline of language had by now travelled far beyond pronunciation or dictionary meanings. Words now made reputations, broke reputations, constructed accusations, placed limits on defence, and kept alive the question of how much truth remained protected inside sealed papers.

He was beginning to understand that humiliation gives a person two roads: on the first, distort another person's words in retaliation; on the second, make one's own words more exact.

The first road was easier.

That night Shashank chose the second—for now.

CHAPTER 16

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 3

Beneath the high ceiling of the courtroom, Shashank heard his own voice with an unnatural clarity. Years ago, in a classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, his teacher had said that if even one part of a sound went astray, meaning could change. Then it had been only a lesson in language. Now every word he spoke was becoming part of the record.

The senior counsel conducting the cross-examination for Raghav Bhasin's side lifted a copy of a document. "You have stated that in Macao you opened a server interface beyond the limits of the translation work you were authorised to perform?"

Shashank answered, "Yes. I have admitted that in writing."

"And you understand Chinese?"

"I understand Mandarin. I have also trained in Cantonese. But my proficiency is not the same in both languages."

The counsel paused. "Then are we to take it that, among everyone in this courtroom, you understood most accurately what the foreign side was saying?"

For a moment Shashank's old pride stirred. He remembered the day at the Red Fort when a group of tourists, hearing his pronunciation, had not laughed but gathered around him to ask questions. At the temple in Pitampura Juliana had told him: knowing a language and knowing the speaker's mind are not the same thing.

He answered, "No. Knowing the language is one means of understanding what a statement says. The speaker's intention, the truth of the document, and the reality of the event are separate questions."

Silence spread through the courtroom for several moments.

The counsel asked again, "You say knowing the language is not enough. Yet at many places the investigation record relies upon your translations. Why, then, should the court trust your words?"

Shashank had answered that question many times in his own mind before—because he was gifted, because he could read the original language, because others depended on him. Now, in that answer, he could see the seed of his own fall.

He said, "The court should not trust me; it should trust the process. The original text should be available, the translation should be available, another expert should be able to check it, and the context should be available. If my words are the sole basis, the limits of that basis should be written into the record."

Seated in the rear row of the courtroom, Aditya Mishra wrote something in his notebook. There was neither praise nor triumph on his face.

The senior counsel smiled. "A very fine answer. When did you learn it?"

Shashank understood the edge of the question. "It took time."

"Meaning you did not know it before?"

"I knew the principle. I did not always follow it in practice."

"Where did you fail to follow it?"

The air in the courtroom seemed to grow heavy.

Shashank's mind travelled back to the Red Fort. A Chinese tourist had said something; tempted to make the meaning easier, Shashank had added an extra shade of feeling. At the time he had thought he was merely making the point clearer for the listener. His teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan had said that if a translator took the author's place, the sentence ceased to belong to the author. Juliana had once asked him, "How can you add to a translation what you did not hear?"

He also remembered a cultural gathering of Delhi's Chinese community, where he had compressed an elderly speaker's long statement into the phrase "everything is fine." It had made things easier for everyone, but the speaker's hesitation, disagreement, and conditions had disappeared from the translation. That incident proved no crime by anyone; but it certainly proved one of Shashank's habits—the habit of flattening complexity for his own convenience.

He said in court, "In my early years, I sometimes said more than the original statement under the pretext of making the meaning clear. Later I understood that this was not convenience; it was intervention."

The counsel became alert. "Then you admit your translations have been unreliable?"

"No. I admit that on some earlier occasions I did not maintain the boundary properly. The reliability of each translation must be tested against its own material, its date, and the original record."

"That is a very convenient distinction."

Before answering, Shashank did not look towards Aditya. He now remembered Aditya's method: do not answer an accusation with another accusation; separate the categories.

"Convenient or inconvenient," Shashank said, "one error does not make every translation false, and several correct translations do not make one error correct."

The judge stopped writing. "Let that answer be recorded clearly."

The senior counsel opened the next document. "You translated this Chinese message as: 'The arrangement above is all right.' The investigating side treats this as an indication of access to and influence over senior officials. Do you agree?"

Shashank looked at the original message. The Chinese characters were familiar. He had heard such a sentence used in business conversation to mean many things—the arrangement was ready, approval had been obtained, the senior level was in agreement, or simply that the working arrangement was in order.

He said, "What is directly established by this sentence is only that the speaker says some arrangement 'above' or at a higher level is all right. 'A senior tax official was influenced' is not established by this sentence alone."

"But it is possible?"

"Possibility belongs to inference. It is not an established fact."

"Are you teaching us philosophy again?"

A faint sting rose inside Shashank, but he did not change his tone. "No. I am stating the limits of the words."

The counsel said, "And does your Navya-Nyaya determine those limits?"

"Navya-Nyaya gives me the discipline to ask the questions. Evidence gives the answers."

This time Aditya's pen moved again.

The next stage of the cross-examination was more difficult for Shashank. An old message of his was shown in which he had written to an associate: "Write this sentence in such a way that the Indian side does not raise unnecessary questions." The moment he read the words he heard his former voice—confident, capable, willing to play with boundaries in pursuit of a result.

The counsel asked, "Is this your message?"

"Yes."

"So that the Indian side does not raise unnecessary questions'—why?"

Shashank was silent. In the courtroom, silence weighed more heavily than words.

"Answer," the judge said.

"At that time I thought that if the commercial meaning remained the same, the language should be framed in a way that would not generate dispute."

"Meaning you wanted to suppress questions?"

"I would not say I wanted to suppress questions. But I will say that I chose language in order to reduce the likelihood of questions being raised."

"What is the difference between those two things?"

Shashank's throat went dry. He remembered Juliana's voice—the discipline of words begins where a person stops choosing the synonym most convenient for himself.

He said, "The difference lies in intention. But the result can be the same. That is why such language was not proper."

Mrinal, seated in the public gallery, lowered his head slowly.

The senior counsel immediately asked, "Then you admit that you deliberately shaped the language of records so that fewer questions would be raised?"

Shashank answered, "In the context of this message—yes. But that does not by itself establish that the record was created to conceal a crime. For that conclusion, the record, the transactions, the purpose, and other evidence must be examined separately."

"You are immediately limiting your own admission."

"I am not adding a limit. The limit was there from the beginning."

The judge said, "The cross-examination will not extract more meaning from an admission than it contains. Let the witness complete his answer."

For the first time Shashank took a deep breath.

During the afternoon recess he came out into the court corridor. Mrinal was waiting for him with a bottle of water. Shashank took it, but for several moments could not drink.

Mrinal said, "That was difficult."

"Yes."

"That message..."

"I remember."

"Why did you not tell me then?"

Shashank stared at the wall. "Because at the time I thought it was clever."

"And now?"

"Now I understand that the distance between cleverness and deceit is small in words, but large in purpose."

Mrinal said nothing.

Shashank asked, "Do you want to save me, or do you think I am guilty?"

Mrinal's eyes hardened. "I am your friend. That is why I will neither make you a saint nor declare you a criminal. Whatever you did, give it the right name."

The sentence sounded to Shashank like Aditya's method.

After the recess, Aditya was called to give evidence. Shashank sat in the observers' section. Now the questions were about Aditya's method.

Counsel for Raghav's side asked, "Did you rely on Shashank Jha's translations?"

Aditya said, "For understanding the preliminary meaning of some material, yes. Not for the final conclusion."

"Why not?"

"Because a translation is one source; verification is a separate stage."

"Did you obtain another translation?"

"Where a statement could become decisive, an independent comparison was obtained, or the original text was preserved in the record."

"And if the independent translation differed?"

"The difference would be recorded. Which word is polysemous, which grammatical relationship is uncertain, and which conclusion is only an inference—those things must remain separate."

The counsel asked, "Did Shashank teach you all this?"

For the first time Aditya looked towards Shashank. "No. The method was already known to me through my training and study. But Shashank's errors made the need for using it much clearer."

A faint rustle moved through the courtroom.

Inside Shashank, the words caused both pain and relief. Aditya had called him neither a teacher nor a demon. He had called them errors—errors that made the need for investigative discipline clearer.

In the final stage of cross-examination, two Navya-Nyaya methods seemed to stand face to face. Counsel for Raghav's side invoked Shashank's older reasoning—the plurality of meanings, uncertainty of a speaker's intention, the translator's limits, the many possible readings of a record. All of this was being used to create doubt. Aditya answered through the same method: where the doubt is real, accept it; where an independent record exists, the haze of language cannot erase the fact.

In one message, the word "arrangement" was ambiguous. Aditya accepted: ambiguous.

In a bank record, the date and amount of payment were clear. He said: linguistic interpretation cannot change that.

Two accounts of the purpose of one meeting differed. He said: disputed.

A digital access log carried Shashank's user identifier. He said: access established; what was done after access is a separate question.

Shashank listened. Suddenly he understood that a method is not moral by itself. The same fine distinctions he had sometimes used to blur an answer were being used by Aditya to protect the limits of evidence.

Navya-Nyaya was not a sword.

The hand decided where the edge would fall.

By evening the proceedings were adjourned. People began to leave. Shashank was gathering his papers when Aditya came over.

"May I ask you something?" Shashank said.

"Ask."

"You said my errors made the need for the method clear. Do you consider me unreliable?"

Aditya took time before answering. "I do not work by writing off an entire person as 'reliable' or 'unreliable.' I test statements."

"That answer is very severe."

"It may be severe. But it is safe."

Shashank gave a faint laugh. "Juliana would say—the limit of words."

"Who is she?"

"My language teacher."

Aditya said, "Then thank her. At least now you can say, 'I do not know.'"

Shashank had heard versions of that sentence before. This time it did not sound like sarcasm.

That night he went to Pitampura. The temple courtyard was quiet. Juliana sat beside a lamp. For a long time Shashank said nothing.

At last Juliana asked, "Did your voice tremble in court?"

"Twice."

"Your words?"

"A few times."

"Did you lie?"

Shashank thought. "Where I had been wrong, the impulse to defend myself came. But I admitted some things."

"Everything?"

Shashank answered, "Within what was asked, I tried to say everything I knew. But I am still afraid that I make my own story beautiful."

Juliana said softly, "Atonement is not a beautiful story. Atonement is the word in which you neither diminish nor enlarge the size of your fault."

Shashank listened to the sentence for a long time.

He said, "Sometimes I added meaning in translation. Sometimes I chose language because I wanted fewer questions to arise. Sometimes I did not say in time what I had seen. But I cannot say that because of all this, every crime was mine."

"Nor do you need to," Juliana replied. "Give your own part its right name. Leave another person's part to that person."

For the first time, the fatigue of the entire day settled visibly into Shashank's eyes.

Back home, he opened his notebook. At the top he wrote: "Word: Atonement."

First line: "Admit only as much as direct memory and the record support."

Second: "Do not turn a translator's error into the entire story of a crime."

Third: "Do not diminish an error by calling it merely 'linguistic convenience.'"

Fourth: "If a word is ambiguous, record it as ambiguous."

Fifth: "Do not hide what is established inside the smoke of doubt."

Sixth: "Do not declare what is unproved to be proved merely because it is morally repugnant."

His hand stopped before the seventh line.

After a long while he wrote: "At times I have used language as a shield. If language is now to bear the weight of truth, I must first bear the weight of my own words."

He put down the pen.

Night was deep outside. Amid the city's countless noises, he remembered the old exercise from his teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan—listen to one word, identify its tone, then state its meaning. Then it had been an exercise in learning a foreign language.

Now life was teaching him the same lesson again.

Listen first.

Then say what it means.

And where the meaning does not fully open, have the courage to say, "I do not know."

For the first time Shashank felt that the discipline of language was not making his talent greater.

It was making his pride smaller.

CHAPTER 17

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 4

On the second morning of the court proceedings, Shashank sat for a long time looking at the seventh line in his notebook—"Sometimes I have used language as a shield." The weight of that sentence had not lessened through the night. In the light of morning, it appeared even clearer. The first difficulty of atonement is not confession, but the ordinary life that follows confession—where a person must work again, decide again, and meet the same old temptations in new forms.

His phone vibrated. A message from an official number: supplementary summons. His presence was required to clarify the meaning of several Chinese statements and audio messages found in seized digital material. The time, place, and case number were clearly stated.

Shashank read the message twice. His first feeling was not fear.

His first feeling was—importance.

An old voice rose within him: "See? In the end, everyone needs you."

The voice was so familiar that recognising it startled him. Money, foreign travel, large contracts—he had seen those forms of ambition before. But the desire to become indispensable was subtler. Here a man could call his greed service.

He saved a screenshot of the summons and sent it to Mrinal.

Mrinal replied: "Go. Say only what you know. Leave the thought 'without me the meaning will not open' at home."

Shashank smiled. His friend had read the line in his mind that he had never written.

Before going to the investigating office, he stopped at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. That day there was a short practice session. The teacher was speaking about phonetic transcription and errors of hearing. A Chinese sentence was written on the board without tone marks. Three students gave three meanings. All three were grammatically possible, yet incomplete without context.

The teacher said, "A written word is sometimes only half the body of sound. If tone, speaker, context, or pause is lost, a transcript can become a very confident falsehood."

Shashank's hand tightened around his pen. The supplementary summons had used the words "audio messages."

At the end of the exercise, the teacher played a recording. The machine transcript had captured one word; the human ear heard another. The teacher did not immediately accept either meaning as final. First he played the whole sentence, then the preceding statement, then the reply that followed. Only then did the range of meaning narrow.

Shashank wrote: "Heard word = sound + context + speaker + doubt."

Beneath it he wrote: "A translator's confidence is not evidence."

At the investigating office, Aditya Mishra was already seated. On the table lay three envelopes, a seizure inventory, and two printed transcripts. No device was open. Aditya greeted him and said, "Today I will play or show you three items. A separate statement will be recorded for each. If the meaning is uncertain, say 'uncertain.'"

Shashank asked, "The original devices?"

"Seized and sealed. The material has been extracted from working copies; the seizure inventory and source of the copies are on record. Your task is only linguistic clarification."

"May I ask for context?"

"Where it is available on record, yes. But if context has not been given to you, do not fill it in by inference."

The boundary did not feel harsh to Shashank. On the contrary, it felt like relief.

The first item was a short audio message. A man's voice spoke a Chinese sentence whose literal form could move in two directions: to "close" an account could mean terminating dealings, or it could mean "settling" accounts. The machine transcript had rendered it in only one sense.

Aditya asked, "What do you hear?"

Shashank listened again. "One word is clear, but in this context it has two common possible meanings. From this fragment alone I cannot say with certainty, 'Close the bank account.'"

"Settle the account?"

"That too is possible. But not certain."

Aditya told the clerk, "Write both possibilities; no conclusion."

Shashank's old ambition stirred again. He remembered that in such moments, if he gave a grand interpretation, everyone would look towards him. He could explain which meaning was more common in commercial Chinese, which idiom was used in which community. He possessed that knowledge.

But he remembered the blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan.

He remained silent.

Aditya looked at him. "Anything to add?"

"I can comment on general usage, but the context is insufficient for a specific conclusion about this audio message."

"Then record the general comment separately. Do not mix it into the specific conclusion."

Shashank felt a strange pleasure. His knowledge had not diminished; its limits had become clear.

The second item was a chain of messages. Between Chinese characters appeared English abbreviations, amounts, dates, and a nickname. One line contained a word that could mean "route," "channel," or "medium." In an earlier translation it had been rendered as "payment gateway."

Aditya asked, "How certain is that translation?"

Shashank read the lines above and below it. "This chain discusses money and transfers, so 'payment channel' is possible. But this word alone is not enough to establish a specific technical payment gateway."

"If another record contains the name of a payment gateway?"

"Then the connection may become stronger. But the meaning of this word would be corroborated by that other record; this word by itself does not create the name."

Aditya gave a slight nod.

The third item made Shashank uneasy. A contact name in Chinese characters meant "master" or "teacher." The media had earlier written in an article that it was perhaps a code name. In the seized phone's contact list, the name appeared repeatedly.

Aditya asked, "Do you recognise anyone by this name?"

The temple at Pitampura flashed in Shashank's mind. Juliana. His teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. An elderly tourist at the Red Fort who had jokingly called him "little master." The word "master" could be used in many real relationships.

He said, "No. I cannot identify a person from the name alone."

"A code name?"

"It could be. It could also be an actual teacher. Or a title. This list does not establish that it is a code name."

"Your experience of Chinese society?"

For a moment Shashank sat straighter with pride. "I have heard this form of address in many contexts."

"Therefore?"

"Therefore the word has many uses. That is all."

Aditya wrote: "Multiple uses; identity of person not established."

Those four words seemed very important to Shashank. Language was acquitting no one and condemning no one. It was merely drawing a boundary.

While the statement was being recorded, the clerk read out a sentence: "The witness is fully confident that the said word means payment channel."

Shashank stopped him at once. "Not fully confident. Write: 'possible on the basis of context.'"

The clerk looked at him. So did Aditya.

"You said 'possible' earlier," Aditya said.

"Yes. The written sentence has removed the boundary."

The clerk corrected it.

A faint tremor passed through Shashank. How many times had he himself removed such boundaries? Turned "possible" into "meaning," "heard" into "known," "convenience" into "necessity." Crimes of language are often born in spaces so small that they are difficult to see on paper.

During the break Aditya offered to order tea. Shashank asked for water. Outside the window the sunlight was harsh.

Aditya asked, "You are very careful today."

"Is that praise or an observation?"

"It will not go into the record," Aditya said.

Shashank laughed. Then, becoming serious, he said, "I am afraid caution itself can become a performance. After hearing everything in court, a person can suddenly begin speaking with great purity."

Aditya replied, "That is why the process must be larger than the individual. Whether you are careful or not, there should be an opportunity to read and correct the statement before signing it; the original material should remain preserved; another expert should be able to examine it."

Shashank asked, "You do not trust me?"

"I want to replace trust with process."

The answer hurt Shashank, but he knew the wound belonged to his pride.

After the break, a fourth extract was placed before him. It had not been mentioned in the summons. Aditya said, "This material was found in a backup copy of your old phone. If you wish, you may ask for a lawyer to be present."

Shashank read the line. It was his own message, a year old. In Chinese he had written to an acquaintance: "Send the record to me first; I will fix the wording; the Indian side will not ask too many questions."

A different version of this idea had already been shown in court. But the original Chinese sentence was harsher.

Here Shashank's ambition rose in self-defence. His mind said: a translator works with language; that is not a crime. "Fix the wording" is ordinary professional work. "Will not ask too many questions" merely means ease.

He could have had that very explanation recorded.

But he read the line again.

"This is my message," he said.

Aditya asked, "Meaning?"

"It says to send the record to me first. I am proposing to change the language so that the Indian side will ask fewer questions."

"Why are you translating 'fix the wording' as 'change the language'?"

Shashank's throat tightened. "Because in this context I was not talking only about correcting grammar. The purpose was to reduce questions."

The room fell silent.

Aditya asked, "Is that an admission of a crime?"

Shashank answered, "No. It is an admission of my purpose—to reduce questions. What the record contained, whether any fact was concealed, and who benefited are separate matters of evidence."

Aditya told the clerk to record only that much.

Sweat stood on Shashank's forehead. Yet inside him there was also a strange lightness. Earlier he had used his talent to make sentences safer for himself. Today he was himself making clear the limits of a sentence that could go against him.

Before the statement ended, Aditya gave him every page to read. Shashank examined each line. On the third page it said: "The witness believes that the word 'master' is not a code name."

He stopped again.

"Change this too. I did not say 'it is not a code name.' I said—the code-name interpretation is not established."

Aditya looked at the clerk. "Correct it."

The difference was only between "not" and "not established." But for Shashank they were two different worlds.

After signing, the moment he stepped outside, a message arrived from an old acquaintance in Delhi's Chinese community: "I hear you are helping the investigation with language again. If my name appears anywhere, tell me first."

Shashank stared at the message for a long time. There were many possible replies: a warning in the name of friendship, an ambiguous reassurance, silence, or a clear boundary.

He wrote: "I will not discuss confidential investigative material outside. I cannot say anything about whether your name appears."

After sending it, his own reply felt harsh. But the harshness did not accuse the other person of anything. It existed only to preserve his role.

In the evening he went to the Red Fort. The crowd was thinning. A Chinese family asked for directions. Shashank explained the way, and then a small boy laughed at his pronunciation and asked whether he was a teacher.

Shashank replied, "No. I am a student."

The boy laughed again. So did Shashank.

A few years earlier he might have said, “You could think of me that way.” Today the word “student” felt more accurate.

At night, in the Tao temple at Pitampura, Juliana saw him and asked, “Which word was difficult today?”

Shashank said, “Indispensable.”

Juliana raised an eyebrow. “Was that a Chinese word?”

“No. One inside me.”

He told her about the summons, the audio messages, the ambiguous words, the corrections to the statement, and his old message. Juliana listened quietly.

“What did you enjoy?” she asked.

Shashank was startled. “Enjoy?”

“Yes. You have told me all the things that frightened you. But what about ambition?”

Shashank was silent for a long time. At last he said, “I like it when everyone says—without Shashank, this language will not open.”

“And then?”

“Then I feel that meaning belongs to me.”

Juliana looked at the flame of the lamp. “The first pride of learning a language is: I understand. The second pride is: others do not understand. The third, and most dangerous, is: meaning will become truth only after passing through me.”

Shashank lowered his eyes.

Juliana said, “A translator is a bridge. If the bridge begins to think the river flows because of it, destruction has begun.”

That night, when he reached home, Shashank opened his notebook. Beneath “Word: Atonement” he wrote a new heading: “Word: Ambition.”

First line: “The desire to become indispensable is also greed.”

Second: “To see ambiguity is a gift; to claim ownership over ambiguity is the beginning of deception.”

Third: “A summons is an invitation to answer questions, not a certificate of importance.”

Fourth: “In a statement, do not turn ‘possible’ into ‘established.’”

Fifth: “Justice may reside in the distance between ‘not’ and ‘not established.’”

Sixth: “Digital material can preserve the body of words; the soul of meaning still requires context.”

Seventh: “A translator may be useful, but must not become a monopoly.”

He stopped his pen. He remembered the chain of contracts—representative, payment recipient, beneficial owner. There too language would be more than words; it would open relationships among names, titles, signatures, and ownership. His pride would be tested again.

Shashank closed the notebook.

Outside, the first suggestion of dawn was still far away. Delhi’s night flowed through its countless sounds. Shashank remembered his teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: listen first, then look at the context, then state the meaning.

This time he added one line for himself—

“And even after you have stated the meaning, resist the temptation to become its owner.”

CHAPTER 18

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 5

That final line kept echoing in Shashank's mind through the night—once you have stated the meaning, resist the temptation to become its owner. At dawn, when he opened the notebook, he wrote a new question beneath it: “Whose is the name, whose is the authority, whose is the benefit?”

The question carried him back to the classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, where language had first entered him as sound, then sentence, then conduct. The teacher wrote four terms on the blackboard—“representative,” “authorised signatory,” “payment recipient,” “actual beneficial owner.” Then he turned to the class and said, “These four expressions may be neighbours. They are not synonyms.”

Shashank felt his old excitement rise. This was exactly the kind of distinction he had always taken pride in catching. The teacher gave an example: an organisation appoints someone as its representative; the representative signs the paper; payment goes to another account; the ultimate benefit may reach a third person. “Do not write ‘ownership’ the moment you see one name,” the teacher said. “Look at the relationship expressed by the words.”

When the class ended, Shashank stood before the blackboard for a long time. He remembered the file in which the word “partner” had begun to carry more meaning than the original Chinese term allowed. That day he had stopped Aditya. Today it was his turn to stop himself.

The moment he stepped out of the classroom, a message from Aditya arrived: “Supplementary examination of the old chain of contracts. Come if you have time.”

Shashank replied: “This evening.”

When he reached the office, Aditya did not place three new copies before him. Instead he brought out expanded copies of the old file. Some pages were in English, some in Chinese, some only seals and lists of signatures. Aditya said, “This time I need less translation of names and more understanding of the language of relationships.”

“The language of relationships?”

“Which word shows appointment, which control, which payment, and which merely contact. We will form the conclusion by putting the papers together. You tell us the limits of the words.”

A bright current of pleasure ran through Shashank. This was precisely his field. He drew the first page towards himself.

The first contract was between a Delhi service entity and a vendor registered abroad. In the English copy, one person was described as the “owner representative.” The Chinese original was not so broad. Shashank read the line again and said, “This does not say ‘representative of the owner.’ A closer meaning is ‘authorised contact representative.’ There is no statement of ownership in the original.”

Aditya asked, “So the English translation adds meaning?”

“Yes. The word ‘owner’ is not in the original line.”

Aditya wrote: “English copy increases the suggestion of ownership; original term indicates only authorised contact.”

Shashank immediately added, “That also does not establish that the person is not the owner. It establishes only that this line does not prove ownership.”

Aditya looked at him and smiled. “‘Not’ and ‘not established’—the same two worlds again.”

A faint smile appeared on Shashank's face. “At least I remember that lesson.”

The second page contained payment instructions. One entity issued the invoice, another accepted the funds, and in an attached Chinese letter a third name was accompanied by a term that could mean “recipient of the benefit.” The English summary had rendered it directly as “beneficial owner.”

Shashank placed his thumb on the line. “This is a serious distinction.”

“How serious?” Aditya asked.

“A ‘recipient of benefit’ and an ‘actual beneficial owner’ are not the same thing. Someone's name may appear as the recipient of a payment benefit; ownership, control, and ultimate economic benefit are separate questions.”

“Then is the summary wrong?”

For a moment Shashank tasted his old impatience. The words came to his tongue—“Yes, wrong.” But he stopped.

“The summary goes beyond the limits of the original term,” he said. “Before calling it wrong, we need to know what basis the writer had. Perhaps there was other material. This one line alone does not yield that conclusion.”

Aditya wrote it down. Then he asked, “If this question comes up in court, will you say only this much?”

“Only this much. No more than the original term says.”

Pride rose inside Shashank at that answer—but this time it was a different kind of pride. Earlier he had been proud that he could see more meaning than anyone else. Today he was proud that he could see where meaning stopped.

The third file contained a vendor-trail list. Five entities, three countries, different registration numbers; yet in two places the same email domain, a similar style of signature, and the same family name recurring in Chinese correspondence. The moment he saw the list, Shashank almost said: “Same group.”

Before the words came out, he remembered the line: claiming ownership over ambiguity is the beginning of deception.

He remained silent.

Aditya asked, “What do you see?”

“Some similarities. Two entities use the same email domain. Two signatures have a similar style. One family name recurs in three places. But this is not enough to write ‘same group.’”

“Why not?”

“They may use the same service provider. The family name may be common. Similar signatures may result from imitation or from a shared administrative format. Direct observation: similarity exists. Inference: common control is possible. Established fact: not yet.”

Aditya drew three boxes in the margin of the page—“Direct,” “Inference,” “Established.” To Shashank the sight looked like the blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan.

At that moment a junior officer came in and said, “Sir, it looks as though we have found the beneficial owner. The same name appears in the papers of all three companies.”

Shashank’s pride pricked him again. He looked at the name. It was indeed the same name, but the role was different in each place—authorised representative in one, payment recipient in another, contact officer in the third.

He said, “The name is the same. The role is not.”

The junior officer replied, “But the same person is everywhere.”

“That is an important fact,” Shashank said, “but ‘present everywhere’ does not automatically become ‘actual beneficial owner.’”

Aditya said nothing. He let Shashank continue.

Shashank said, “If documents of control, the flow of benefit, the authority to issue directions, or records of ownership all point in the same direction, then the conclusion will gain strength. But repetition of a name is not itself the conclusion.”

The junior officer looked at the paper again. “So should we write this?”

The old temptation rose in Shashank—he wanted everyone to write his sentence. But he looked towards Aditya.

Aditya said calmly, “The translator will state the limits of the words. The investigative conclusion will be formed in the investigation record.”

Shashank felt a slight sting. He knew it was a necessary one.

When the session ended, Aditya handed him a separate page. “I want your written comment on this. Language only.”

Shashank read it. A sentence in the Chinese letter meant, almost literally, “the arrangement for the ultimate benefit will remain as previously agreed.” The English copy said: “ultimate beneficial ownership remains unchanged.”

Shashank’s eyes sharpened. This was no small difference.

“‘Arrangement for the ultimate benefit’ and ‘ultimate beneficial ownership’ are different,” he said. “The first points towards an economic arrangement; the second uses the language of legal ownership directly.”

Aditya asked, “Is the first sentence unrelated to the question of ownership?”

“No. It may be related. But the words themselves do not declare legal ownership. Context and other records are needed.”

“The importance of this line?”

Shashank paused before answering. “An important indication. Not established ownership.”

Aditya wrote: “Important indication; independent confirmation required.”

Shashank felt an unexpected pleasure. His language was not obstructing the investigation; it was making it more exact. Pride in language did not feel poisonous in this form.

As he left the office, he found Mrinal waiting outside. Looking at Shashank's face, Mrinal said, "You look very pleased today."

"Language was useful."

"Language is always useful. The question is whether you work for language or make language work for your pride."

Shashank burst out laughing. "Have you been spending more time with Juliana?"

"No. I have spent enough time with you."

The two walked towards the Red Fort. In the evening crowd, several Chinese tourists were arguing with their guide. One young man was confused because the order of his name on the ticket differed from the order on his passport. Shashank explained naturally that Chinese name order could be reversed in Indian records; a change in order alone did not make the person someone else.

The young man thanked him. Mrinal said lightly, "You have saved another name."

Shashank replied, "Not saved the name. Saved the limits of the name."

As soon as he said it, he heard pride in his own voice. He fell silent.

In the shadow of the Red Fort's rampart, they met an old Chinese acquaintance. Taking Shashank aside, the man asked quietly, "I hear the names of some companies are under investigation. Is such-and-such person really the owner?"

Shashank's first reaction was: he knew what the records contained. The second: this knowledge could increase his importance. The third: confidentiality.

He said, "I will not discuss investigative material outside."

The acquaintance smiled. "I only asked. You understand the language; you understand people too."

Shashank replied, "That is precisely why I will not answer. Understanding people and declaring someone an owner are not the same thing."

The acquaintance's smile faded. He took his leave.

Mrinal remained silent for some distance. Then he said, "Earlier you would have turned such a question around and answered it somehow."

"I still felt like doing that."

"Then what changed?"

Shashank said, "Earlier I thought that if I understood something, I also had the right to use it. Now I am beginning to understand—knowledge and authority are different things."

That night, at the Tao temple in Pitampura, Juliana sat before a lamp. Shashank told her the whole story of the day—representative, payment recipient, actual beneficial owner, the recurrence of the same name, and the pride rising inside him.

Juliana asked, "Is pride in language wrong?"

Shashank wanted to answer at once, but the lesson stopped him. "No. Perhaps it is necessary too. If one feels no pride in language, why would one labour over its subtleties?"

"Then where is the danger?"

"When pride becomes authority."

Juliana looked at the lamp. "The same thing happens in the discipline of tone. One day a student pronounces a tone correctly, and then begins to think that whatever he says thereafter must be correct. The real discipline begins on that day."

Shashank laughed. "Meaning I have only just begun?"

"Perhaps."

Leaving the temple, he returned home and opened his notebook. After "Word: Ambition" he wrote: "Word: Pride in Language."

First line: "Representative, signatory, payment recipient, and actual beneficial owner may be the same person; they do not mean the same thing."

Second: "Recurrence of a name may indicate a relationship; it does not prove ownership."

Third: "If a translation grows larger than the limits of the original term, it can change the direction of an investigation."

Fourth: "Pride in language is useful when it reveals a boundary; destructive when it claims authority over the conclusion."

Fifth: "Words can open the door to evidence; what lies inside must be shown by other evidence."

Sixth: "Confidential knowledge is not a means of earning prestige."

Seventh: “What I understand is not my property.”

For a while he kept the pen in his hand. The blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the tourist’s reversed name at the Red Fort, the lamp at Pitampura, Aditya’s three boxes, Mrinal’s hard questions—all seemed tied together by a single thread.

“Word” no longer meant merely a spoken sentence. A word was a role, a relation, a boundary, and sometimes a mirror of pride.

Shashank closed the notebook. Outside, the sound of traffic on the road was diminishing. The voices within him, too, had quietened somewhat, but they were not gone. He knew that in the next stage, records concerning payment gateways, mule accounts, hawala, and cryptocurrency would make these linguistic boundaries difficult again. There, friendship too would become a question.

He switched off the light. The night was dark, but this time he understood: knowing the name of darkness is not light. For light, one must see, examine, and accept the boundary.

CHAPTER 19

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 6

That final line—“Knowing the name of darkness is not light”—remained with Shashank the next day as well. In the classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the teacher was discussing not only the meaning of words but their purpose. The same word could mean one thing in a business letter, another in a friend’s message, and a third in an investigative record. Shashank wrote in his notebook: “A word separated from its context is not evidence; it is only a shell.”

After class, there was a message from Aditya on his phone: “Some payment records have been added to yesterday’s chain of contracts. Come if you have time.”

Shashank replied: “After noon.”

He sent the message, but the first person who came to mind was not Aditya. It was Mrinal. That evening Mrinal had told him, “Knowledge and authority are different things. But friendship and silence are different things too.” Shashank had not answered. Today he understood that Mrinal had left the question unfinished, and unfinished questions often survive longer than complete answers.

In the small meeting room of the commissionerate, Aditya had placed not one thick file but four thin ones. The first contained monthly payment-gateway statements, the second a list of bank accounts, the third translations of seized messages, and the fourth several records relating to external digital assets.

Aditya said, “Do not read all four as one story. Look at the words first.”

Shashank smiled. “This time I will not write the conclusion first.”

“I am not asking you to suppress the conclusion. I want the birthplace of the conclusion to remain visible.”

Shashank opened the first file. Some entries contained customer references, some vendor codes, some only numbers. The payment-gateway records showed that money had moved from one place to another, but they did not themselves say why it had moved.

Shashank said, “The movement is directly visible here; the purpose is not.”

Aditya nodded. “Write that.”

Shashank wrote: “The flow of payments is visible; a conclusion about the reason requires separate evidence.”

The second file contained the names on several accounts. Some names belonged to people who did not appear on the company’s earlier employee list. One account holder had a different occupation recorded, yet commercial sums had repeatedly passed through that account.

Shashank said instinctively, “A mule account.”

Aditya did not answer at once. After a few moments he asked, “Is that term in the record?”

Shashank stopped. “No.”

“Then what did you see?”

“An account belonging to a person whose name is not among the principal parties to the contract, but through whose account some of the payments passed.”

“Write only that much.”

Shashank stopped his pen and looked at Aditya. “You avoid the term ‘mule account’?”

“Not the term. Premature naming. If later evidence shows that the account holder was merely a service provider, the name I give it now will distort my investigation. If the evidence shows that the account was knowingly used to move another person’s money, then we will give it the appropriate name.”

In the margin of his notebook Shashank wrote: “Naming can itself be a conclusion.”

The third file contained Chinese and English messages. In several places appeared words such as “settle,” “clear,” “outside,” and “token.” One Chinese sentence had a literal sense roughly like “balance it outside.” At first sight, it reminded Shashank of a hawala-like arrangement, but this time he remained silent.

Aditya asked, “What are you thinking?”

“An inference. But not one worth writing yet.”

“Why?”

“Because the sentence is polysemous. It may mean a commercial adjustment. It may mean an informal settlement of funds. The word alone does not decide.”

There was a faint satisfaction on Aditya’s face. “This is not the Shashank of Chapter 14.”

“The Shashank of Chapter 14 is still inside me.”

"Then ask him a question before you let him write."

The fourth file contained references to digital assets. There were dates, estimated values, several external addresses, and one or two words rendered in translation as "convert" and "hold." Shashank kept looking at the record. He remembered the hotel in Macao where he had been shown a restricted authorised dashboard. At the time these words had gleamed with fascination. Now they stood before him as dry lines.

"An inference of cryptocurrency layering could be drawn here," Shashank said, "but this record alone does not establish it."

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"Because conversion and holding are not crimes in themselves. To connect them with a crime, we need the source, purpose, recipient of the benefit, control, and other evidence."

Aditya wrote: "Translator's comment: linguistic possibility, not proof of criminality."

Shashank laughed. "You make what I say stricter than I do."

"In an investigation, strictness is not against a person. It is needed for the boundary of a sentence."

When the meeting ended, Shashank came outside and found Mrinal standing near the gate. He had come without saying anything.

"You are here?" Shashank asked.

"Not everything in Delhi can be said by sending a message."

They walked to a nearby tea stall. Shashank ordered tea. Mrinal remained silent for a while, then said, "Someone telephoned me. He asked how long I have known you, how many connections you have with people from China, whether you have received foreign payments."

Shashank's hand went still around the cup. "What did you say?"

"That I would say only what I directly know. For the rest, look at the records."

Shashank stared at him. "You have begun speaking like Aditya."

"No. Living with you has taught me that words have boundaries. The difference is that sometimes you use that lesson to defend yourself."

The sentence was harsh. Shashank opened his mouth to argue, then closed it.

Mrinal said, "I am your friend, so I am asking. If things about accounts, payment gateways, hawala, or cryptocurrency had come before you earlier, why did you not tell me?"

"Must everything be told to a friend?"

"No. But friendship is not only the sharing of pleasant news. I told you before—silence and confidentiality are not the same thing."

Shashank set the cup on the table. "Some things were confidential. Some things I did not properly understand myself. And some..."

"And some?"

"Some things, if I had told them, might have reduced my importance."

Mrinal's expression changed. It was not anger. It was disappointment. "I am not calling you guilty because of that answer. But I will remember the answer."

A faint pain rose inside Shashank. "Do you think I am a criminal?"

"I have not used that word."

"But the meaning—"

Mrinal cut him off. "That is exactly your problem. I said one thing and you completed its meaning. Today I am saying only this: you did not disclose certain things because not disclosing them protected your prestige. That is a moral fact. It is not a legal conclusion."

Shashank fell silent. His friend was cutting through him with the very method he himself had practised.

On the way towards the Red Fort, the two walked together, but there was little ordinary conversation between them. At one place, a small group of Chinese tourists asked for directions. Shashank answered easily in Chinese. His tones were precise, the sentence effortless. The tourists thanked him warmly.

Mrinal said, "Your real gift is here—carrying what one person says to another in the right meaning."

"And you think I have misused that gift?"

"I think talent is not moral by itself. Its use becomes moral or immoral."

Shashank remembered Juliana's old sentence: once the student gets the tone right, he begins to think that whatever he says thereafter must be right. The real discipline begins on that day.

In the evening the two reached the Tao temple at Pitampura. Juliana was seeing Mrinal for the first time. Shashank introduced him: "This is Mrinal Karn. He rescued me first in Delhi, then became my friend, and now asks questions."

Mrinal laughed. "The last part is the most accurate."

Juliana gave them both tea. After a while Shashank described the day's investigation in general terms, without names or confidential details: payment gateways, names on accounts, polysemous words, digital assets, and the limits of evidence.

Juliana asked, "And where did friendship enter?"

Shashank looked towards Mrinal. "At the point where the question became what I knew, and what I did not say."

Juliana asked Mrinal, "What do you want—all the truth?"

Mrinal said, "No. I want Shashank to distinguish between confidentiality and his own convenience."

Juliana turned to Shashank. "That is a difficult lesson. When learning language, we cannot hide sound at first; the error can be heard. In life, a person can choose words and hide his error."

Shashank said quietly, "And sometimes even the correct word becomes a shield."

"Yes. 'Confidentiality,' 'inference,' 'direct knowledge,' 'authority'—all are correct words. The question is whether you use them to make the truth clearer or to keep your own convenience safe."

As they left the temple, Mrinal said, "I am not your enemy."

"I know."

"One day you may think I am."

Shashank stopped. "Why?"

"Because if friendship is only agreement, it is not friendship. If I think you are crossing a boundary with your talent, I will say so."

Shashank almost answered, "I know the boundary." But the sentence reached his lips and stopped. The lesson returned to him: knowledge and authority are different. Today another line was being added—knowing the boundary and honouring the boundary are different.

When he reached home, he opened his notebook and wrote: "Word: Friendship."

First line: "The flow of payments may be directly observed; its purpose may be an inference."

Second: "Do not declare an account holder who is absent from the contract to be a mule account merely from the name."

Third: "Hawala, cryptocurrency layering, or any other criminal label requires separate, corroborated evidence."

Fourth: "In translation, record the possible meanings of a polysemous word; do not choose the convenient meaning and build the conclusion from it."

Fifth: "Confidentiality and selective silence are not the same thing."

Sixth: "A friend who shows you a boundary is not an enemy."

Seventh: "Words can clarify truth; even the correct word can become a shield for self-deception."

Eighth: "Knowing the boundary is not enough; one must honour it."

Shashank sat before the eighth line for a long time. He remembered the disappointment in Mrinal's eyes, Aditya's three boxes, Juliana's lamp. Three kinds of people were present in his life—one who saw his talent, one who tested his statements, and one who recognised his self-deception. Sometimes all three roles merged in the same person.

Night deepened. Outside, Delhi's traffic slowly diminished. Before closing the notebook, Shashank wrote one final line: "Friendship too is testimony of a kind, but not evidence in a court; it is a question for the conscience."

He switched off the light. In the darkness he understood that the road ahead was not only a road of records. Language was taking him closer to money, prestige, and access; Juliana's lessons were warning him; Mrinal's friendship was holding him back. But greed had not ended. It was only searching for its next name.

CHAPTER 20

JULIANA'S LESSON

That final line from Chapter 19—"Friendship too is testimony of a kind, but not evidence in a court; it is a question for the conscience"—remained in Shashank's notebook. The next morning, as he read it, Mrinal's eyes came back to him. The question had been harsh, but the friendship had not yet broken. What had broken was Shashank's old convenience: the belief that choosing the right words could also prove the rightness of his mind.

That day at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the teacher was discussing the reliability of "word." Two sentences of the same meaning were written on the blackboard—one direct, the other honorific. The teacher asked, "If the meaning is the same, why is the effect different?"

Shashank answered, "Because words do not merely give information; they also shape the form of a relationship."

The teacher smiled. "And what if the desire for a relationship changes the meaning?"

It was an ordinary classroom question. Inside Shashank, the answer became private.

As soon as class ended, an official message arrived from Macao. The senior coordinator from his previous visit had sent him an offer for regular language consultancy: monthly remuneration, a fixed term, travel allowance, and meetings in Macao as required. One clause stated that, for language review, Shashank might receive "read-only access" to selected server pages; the project head would determine the limits of that access.

Shashank looked first at the amount. Then at access. Then at the title—"Regional Language Consultant." Together the three words created a brightness inside him in which money, prestige, and special access began to dissolve into one another.

He did not answer immediately. Even the impulse to write "immediately" seemed careless to him. He closed the message and went towards the Red Fort, where in the afternoon he had interpreting work for a small group of two Chinese tourists.

The red walls of the fort, the open sky, and the crowd gave him an ordinary pleasure he had not felt for a long time. An elderly Chinese tourist asked why royal power here had been displayed through buildings of such scale. Shashank replied, "Power is not merely possessed; it is also displayed." The moment he spoke, his new title came back to him.

The other tourist heard his pronunciation and asked, "Have you spent many years in China?"

"Not many. A few visits."

"Even so, your tones sound very natural."

The praise brought back an old pleasure. Language was an ability he had earned; there was nothing wrong in taking pride in that. But now behind praise stood the shadows of title, access, and money. He understood that greed did not always arrive with an ugly face. Sometimes it came dressed as honour.

That evening he showed the offer to Mrinal. Mrinal read the whole document without comment. At the end he asked only, "What do you want?"

"The work is good. The remuneration is good. Language is my field."

"That answers all three things. My question was about you."

Shashank grew irritated. "How can what I want be separate from the work?"

Mrinal pointed to the line containing "read-only access." "Your eyes stayed here longer."

Shashank said nothing.

"Wanting money is not a crime," Mrinal said. "Wanting respect is not a crime either. But if access becomes, for you, more than a tool for the work—if it becomes proof of your importance—then be careful."

"You see a boundary in everything."

"Because in every boundary you see a door—to be opened."

The sentence was sharp. Shashank lifted his glass of tea and set it down again. He found no answer that satisfied even himself.

That night he opened the proposal and drew three boxes: Direct, Inference, Desire. Direct: an offer of regular language consultancy; monthly remuneration; meetings in Macao as required; limited read-only access to selected server pages. Inference: the project might be connected with the same technical group as before; some business names might appear again. Desire: higher remuneration, a special title, greater access, and knowledge that others could not see.

Writing the third box made him uncomfortable. It was difficult to write desire as though it were evidence, because a person is both witness to his own greed and advocate for it.

At dawn he went to the Tao temple at Pitampura. Juliana was cleaning the small lamps in the courtyard. When Shashank arrived, she smiled. "After so many days, the student has come on his own. This time has the pronunciation gone wrong, or the mind?"

Shashank tried to laugh. "Examine both."

Juliana seated him inside. Tea arrived. Shashank placed the proposal before her. Juliana could read English, but Shashank himself explained every clause in Maithili. When he came to the server-access provision, Juliana stopped him.

"Read it again."

Shashank read.

"This time do not read the title of the position. Read only the limits of the authority."

Shashank read again: "Selected pages for language review; permission to read; no modification; limits to be determined by the project head."

Juliana asked, "Where does it say 'special'?"

"Nowhere."

"Owner of confidential knowledge?"

"No."

"Independent authority to investigate?"

"No."

"Then where did your mind add those three expressions?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "Because I feel that if I am given access, I will no longer be an ordinary translator."

Straightening the wick of a lamp, Juliana said, "When a student pronounces a difficult tone correctly for the first time, he begins to think the language now belongs to him. But language is no one's property. It is a relationship. Access too is not property; it is responsibility."

Shashank asked, "How do I recognise the limits of that responsibility?"

"Only as far as the work for which the access was given. If your mind says, 'Look here just once; no one will know,' then understand that the boundary is standing before you."

The search box in Macao appeared before his eyes. On the previous journey he had heard precisely that sentence without words: search once. No one will stop you.

He said quietly, "I have crossed that boundary once already."

Juliana kept looking at him. "How far?"

Shashank told her what had happened on the previous trip: a sign resembling a name he had seen in the Delhi records; a search he carried out beyond the needs of his assignment; two brief results; no copy, no alteration, but a purpose outside the limits of his work. He also told her that he had concealed it from both Aditya and Mrinal.

Juliana did not interrupt. When he finished, she asked, "What did you establish?"

"Nothing. Only an indication resembling a name."

"Then there is no established fact of a crime. But what is the established fact about your own conduct?"

"Knowing the boundary, I carried out a search beyond it."

"That line is important. An allegation of crime is one thing; an admission about your own conduct is another. To merge the two would also be false."

Shashank remembered Aditya's three boxes. Juliana did not speak in the language of a courtroom, but the method was the same: separate the thing, separate the name, separate the relationship.

Juliana said, "You studied Navya-Nyaya. 'Word' is not merely what was said. By whom, in what context, with what authority, for what purpose—these things make its boundary. The problem with your greed is not money. The problem is that you enlarge the meaning of the word 'access' until it becomes 'authority,' turn 'knowledge' into 'ownership,' and turn 'confidentiality' into 'permission to remain silent.'"

Shashank lowered his head. "Then should I reject the offer?"

"Why should I say that? If the work is lawful, the boundary is clear, and you can honour the boundary, then do the work. If a teacher makes the decision for the student, the student will become merely obedient, not responsible."

"And if I fail again?"

"Then call the failure a failure. Do not hide it by calling it talent, business, confidentiality, or opportunity."

As he left the temple, the brightness of the offer had not disappeared. On the contrary, it had become unmistakably clear that he still wanted the work. The clarity was not pleasant, but it was true. Juliana had not erased his greed; she had corrected its name.

He went straight to Aditya's office. Aditya was reading a file. Without any preface, Shashank placed a copy of the proposal before him.

"Regular consultancy in Macao?" Aditya asked after reading it.

"Yes."

"Will you accept?"

"Probably. But first I need to add something to the record."

Shashank told him the whole story of the out-of-scope search on the previous trip. Aditya interrupted only to ask the date, the type of access, the sign searched, and the nature of the results. When the account was finished, he wrote: "Voluntary supplementary statement: name search conducted by translator beyond the requirements of assigned work; two brief entries returned; no direct evidence of ownership, payment, or crime; no copy produced."

Shashank asked, "Do you consider me guilty?"

Aditya stopped his pen. "Right now I am recording an event. Guilt may become a question for decision, and sometimes it may not arise at all. If an investigator calls every improper act a crime, he himself breaks the boundary of evidence."

"But your trust?"

"Trust is not a courtroom exhibit. But it matters in work. You did not tell me in time—that is a fact. You have now told me yourself—that is also a fact."

The answer was harsher than Shashank had expected, and more just.

He called Mrinal. "Can we meet?"

The two sat at their old tea stall. Shashank told Mrinal that he had informed Aditya about the search beyond the boundary. For a long time Mrinal said nothing.

At last he asked, "Why did you tell him?"

"Because not telling him would benefit me."

For the first time a faint relief appeared on Mrinal's face. "This time you gave the right answer."

"I want to accept the offer."

"Then do."

Shashank was surprised. "You will not stop me?"

"I am your friend, not your guardian. But write one condition for yourself: only as far as the work for which access is given."

"Juliana said almost exactly the same thing."

Mrinal laughed. "Then at least on this point you need not treat me as your teacher."

That night Shashank wrote his reply to the proposal. He accepted in principle, but asked for two matters to be added in writing: no investigative authority beyond language review; server access limited to pre-defined selected pages. These conditions did not make him noble. Perhaps he was merely drawing a visible line around his own greed.

After sending the reply, he opened his notebook and wrote: "Word: Juliana's Lesson."

First line: "Access is not authority; it is a limited instrument of responsibility."

Second: "Similarity of names may indicate a relationship; it does not establish ownership or crime."

Third: "Admit the fact of an out-of-scope search; do not enlarge its result into proof of a crime."

Fourth: "Wanting money, respect, or special work is not itself a crime; but giving desire the meaning of authority may become self-deception."

Fifth: "Confidentiality is not freedom to hide the truth."

Sixth: "A teacher of words gives meaning; character decides how far that meaning will be extended."

Seventh: "Greed need not first be erased; first recognise its proper name."

Eighth: "Only as far as the work for which access is given."

Shashank read the eighth line twice. Outside, Delhi's night was dense. The possibility of returning to Macao had opened again; the attraction of server access had not vanished either. But this time, at least, he could hear the whole sentence inside himself.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: an offer for regular language consultancy had arrived; it included monthly remuneration, meetings in Macao as required, and limited permission to read selected server pages; before Juliana, Shashank admitted the previous out-of-scope search; later he gave Aditya a voluntary

supplementary statement; the search results did not establish ownership, payment, or crime; Shashank expressed his intention to accept the proposal and asked for the limits of access to be stated clearly in writing.

The inference went only this far: regular work might in future bring him back to Macao and closer to the same technical group.

And the fact of greed was only this: more than money, Shashank was beginning to recognise his attraction to the feeling that special access set him apart from ordinary people. Juliana's lesson had not removed the greed; it had removed its false name.

CHAPTER 21

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 8

At dawn Shashank's phone rang. A message had come from Raghav Bhasin's office: Chinese-language interpretation was required at a confidential meeting that afternoon. The final line of the message was brief: "This is a conversation within legal consultation; it must not be shared outside."

Shashank looked at that line for a long time. The previous night he had written Juliana's eighth sentence — "Only as far as the work for which access is given." Today he understood that a boundary did not exist only on a server page; it existed around words as well.

That morning at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the teacher was making the class practise two kinds of statements. One student said, "I heard it." Another said, "I saw it." The teacher wrote both sentences on the blackboard and asked, "Are they equal?"

Shashank answered, "No. The first depends upon another person's statement; the second claims direct perception."

The teacher asked again, "If a translator turns 'I heard it' into 'I know it,' what changes?"

"The weight of the evidence," Shashank said.

After answering, he felt his own voice grow heavy. What had once been an ordinary exercise in linguistics was now circling inside his life.

At noon he reached Raghav's office. Present at the meeting were Raghav, a Chinese business representative, the representative's assistant, and Shashank. At the outset Raghav made the position clear: "This conversation is for legal advice. Shashank is here only for language assistance. Where a question should not be answered, I will say so."

Shashank nodded. He felt relief and fear at once. The boundary had been stated. But he knew that a stated boundary and an honoured boundary were not always the same thing.

The Chinese representative first read an old clause from a contract. It said that questions might be raised in India about the classification of certain fees charged by a vendor. Raghav asked, "Were these fees for services, for transfer of funds, or for something else?"

Before answering, the representative looked towards Shashank. In Chinese he used a word whose direct meaning was "adjustment," though in a commercial context its range could be wider. Shashank translated: "He is using the word 'adjustment'; that word by itself does not presently establish the actual purpose of the fee."

Raghav immediately asked, "Meaning you cannot say that this was merely an accounting adjustment?"

"Yes. The original word does not establish that much."

Raghav made a note. The representative appeared slightly uncomfortable. He then said in Chinese that the "old arrangements" had all been "closed." Shashank paused.

"What does 'closed' mean?" Raghav asked.

Shashank said, "The verb in the original sentence can mean that the arrangement is no longer in use, or that its effect has ended. Both are possible. Without records, it would not be proper to choose one meaning."

Raghav looked at him for a moment. "Good. Only as much as there is."

Those four words settled inside Shashank—only as much as there is. That, in essence, was what Juliana had been teaching him too.

The meeting moved on. At one point the representative said very quietly to his assistant in Chinese, "The old payment names should not appear in the legal letter." Shashank heard him. The sentence had not been addressed to him for translation, but he was present inside the meeting as the interpreter.

His heart began to pound.

At that moment Raghav was reading another document. Two voices rose inside Shashank. One said: this was a private whisper; it is not the interpreter's concern. The other said: if this sentence could change the legal advice, why remain silent?

He remembered his boundary: only as far as the work for which access is given. The question was whether this sentence lay inside that work or outside it.

Shashank said, "Raghavji, I heard an additional statement. The representative told his assistant that the old payment names should not appear in the legal letter. I do not know the purpose of the statement; I am reporting only the words."

The meeting suddenly fell silent.

The representative said something sharply. Shashank translated: "He says this was not legal advice, but a private remark."

In a very calm voice Raghav said, "Private or not, let me make one thing clear first: I will not give instructions to conceal facts in any record. Which information is legally required will be determined after examining the record and the context."

Shashank's fear did not lessen. It increased. He understood that confidentiality and silence were not the same word. Lawyer-client confidentiality and privilege might protect certain communications; but separate questions remained: what activity the interpreter himself took part in, what he heard, what he translated, and whether anyone asked him to conceal anything. The decisive boundary there belonged to a court or lawful legal process, not to whatever interpretation suited Shashank.

When the meeting ended, Raghav asked him to stay.

"You did the right thing by reporting that sentence," he said.

Shashank asked, "Did that not break confidentiality?"

Closing the papers, Raghav replied, "Confidentiality concerns the outside world. Failing to tell me a necessary fact inside the meeting is a different matter. But do not turn this into a universal rule; every situation may be different. Your job is to keep the words accurate."

"And if someone tells an interpreter not to translate certain words?"

Raghav looked directly at him. "First determine whether it is a matter of linguistic convenience or a request to suppress a fact. Those are not the same thing. If the boundary is doubtful, ask for written instructions or stop the work. Do not create a legal boundary out of your own interpretation."

Shashank stepped outside. The Delhi sun was harsh. The sentence he had heard inside the confidential office still seemed to be sounding in his ears: "The old payment names should not appear in the legal letter."

He did not go directly to the Red Fort, yet his feet turned of their own accord towards the old route of practice. Near the fort stood a small group of Chinese tourists with another guide. Shashank listened from a distance. One tourist said something to a companion; the guide heard only half of it, smiled, and supplied a different meaning. Everyone laughed.

A few years earlier Shashank too would have added something to a sentence for the sake of such laughter. Today it no longer seemed harmless. An inaccurate joke might have negligible consequences; in a legal document, the addition of a single word could change a person's role.

At night he went to the Tao temple in Pitampura. Juliana was straightening the wick of a lamp. Shashank bowed to her.

"Words again?" Juliana asked.

"Fear again."

Juliana motioned for him to sit.

Shashank told her what had happened—the confidential meeting, the private whisper, his translation of it, Raghav's response. He gave no names or business details; he described only the ethical structure.

Juliana asked, "Whose words did you own?"

"No one's. I was only the interpreter."

"Then what was your responsibility?"

"Not to distort the limits of what I heard."

"And what you did not know?"

"Not to fill it in with inference."

Juliana smiled. "Where is the fear now?"

Shashank replied, "That one day someone will say I disclosed confidential material. Someone else will say I concealed a fact. Between those two accusations, where does an interpreter stand?"

Juliana said, "Not between the words. Inside your work. Keep clear in your memory what you heard, what you said, at whose request you said it, and at whose request you did not. In fear, a person enlarges or diminishes his own role."

Shashank thought of Aditya. He did not telephone him that night. But the next morning he went to the office himself.

Aditya was examining a digital seizure inventory. Shashank said, "Yesterday I interpreted at a legal consultation. There is one thing I want placed on record, but not the confidential details."

Aditya put down his pen. "Say only what can lawfully be said. I am not asking you for the contents of confidential legal advice."

Shashank described only the structure of what had happened—the meeting, his linguistic role, hearing a private remark, translating it to the lawyer inside the meeting, words that sounded like a request to keep a fact out, and Raghav's response that he would not instruct anyone to conceal a fact in a record.

Aditya asked, "Did anyone ask you to alter, erase, destroy a record, or make a false translation?"

"No."

"Did anyone teach you a technique for concealing the original source of a payment?"

"No."

"Did anyone tell you to give a false answer to an investigative question?"

"No."

"Then the directly established facts, for now, are only these: you heard an ambiguous statement, you translated it inside the meeting, and the lawyer refused to give an instruction to conceal facts."

Shashank said, "But 'the old payment names'?"

"Those words may be important. But without knowing which payment, which names, which time, which document, I will not establish a crime. Nor will I decide the legal limits of privilege at this desk by inference."

Shashank remained silent for a long time.

Aditya asked, "Are you afraid?"

"Yes."

"Of what?"

"Both sides. If I speak, I may be accused of breaking confidentiality. If I do not speak, I may be accused of participation."

Aditya replied, "Fear can be useful if it makes you keep a clear record. But if fear teaches you to rewrite your own role, then it becomes dangerous."

He pushed a blank sheet towards Shashank. "For your private record, write the date, place, role, what you translated, and what you did not. No confidential details; only the boundaries of your own conduct. Later, memory changes according to convenience."

Shashank wrote. First line: "I am not the lawyer; the legal conclusion is not mine."

Second: "Confidentiality does not confer a right to alter the meaning of a fact."

Third: "The purpose of the private remark that was heard is unknown; only the words are directly known."

Fourth: "No one instructed me to translate falsely, destroy a record, or give a false answer to the investigation."

Fifth: "An ambiguous word does not establish a crime."

Sixth: "Do not make my role smaller or larger because of fear."

Seventh: "Words may be evidence, but the context of the words is also part of the evidence."

Leaving the office, he met Mrinal. Looking at Shashank's face, Mrinal asked, "Something again?"

Shashank said, "It seems to me that the more language I learn, the harder silence becomes."

Mrinal held out a clay cup of tea. "Silence is not hard. The right silence is hard."

"The difference?"

"Not telling another person's private grief is one kind. Publicly declaring someone guilty of a crime is another. And concealing a fact to protect yourself is a third. Not all silences are the same."

Shashank did not laugh. "You too have begun speaking like Juliana."

"No. I have merely spent too many days with you."

They remained silent for a while. The silence of friendship did not remove Shashank's fear entirely, but it changed its form. Fear was no longer darkness; it was like a boundary line that could be seen.

That night he wrote a heading in his notebook: "Word: Confidentiality and Participation."

Beneath it he wrote: "Confidentiality may prohibit outside disclosure; it does not give the interpreter authority to alter the original statement."

"The legal limits of lawyer-client privilege may be a judicial question; the interpreter must not enlarge them for his own convenience."

"Hearing a private remark and participating in a crime are not the same thing."

"An ambiguous sentence that seems to ask for concealment may create suspicion; without particulars it does not establish a crime."

"In fear, make a record; do not make a story."

He put down the pen. Juliana's question returned to him: "Whose words did you own?" The answer was now clear: no one's.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: Shashank provided language assistance at a confidential legal consultation; the Chinese representative made a remark to his assistant to the effect that old payment names should not appear in the legal letter; without adding an inference about the purpose of that remark, Shashank translated it to Raghav within the meeting; Raghav refused to give any instruction to conceal facts in a record; later Shashank discussed the boundaries of his role with Juliana, Aditya, and Mrinal.

The inference went only this far: the words “old payment names” might point towards some relevant link in a future investigation. Which payment, which names, which person, and whether any of it was lawful or unlawful had not yet been established.

The false allegation here would be to declare Raghav, the representative, or Shashank a participant in a crime merely because they were present at a confidential meeting. The available direct evidence did not support such a conclusion.

The fact of fear was only this: for the first time Shashank understood clearly that the danger for an interpreter lay not only in an incorrect word; the time, place, context, and limits of even the correct word were also a test of character.

CHAPTER 22

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 9

At noon two papers lay one upon the other on Aditya Mishra's desk. The upper page said, "The priority of the matter shall be reduced." The lower page contained the original note from the same day: "Further verification of the payment chain and related vendor details is required." Both pages had come from the same file, but the words on them did not point in the same direction.

Aditya read the first page again. It carried a signature, a date, an office seal. But it did not answer the question: why reduce the priority? On the second page, the question was clear; the answer was still pending. This small difference on paper disturbed him, because in an investigation an order does not merely give direction; it also determines which questions remain alive and which suffocate inside a file.

He asked his colleague, "Which note is the basis for this change?"

The colleague shrugged. "It was said from above."

"By whom?"

"No name was given."

"Written instruction?"

"I have not seen one."

Aditya remained silent for a while. In Navya-Nyaya, shabda - word or testimony - is not mere sound. Speaker, context, reliability, purpose, and the circumstances in which the statement is received all combine to determine its evidentiary value. In administration, the sentence "it was said from above" often moves like an order; under the discipline of investigation, however, it is not evidence by itself.

In his notebook he wrote: "Oral information: source unclear. Written order: available. Reason for the order: unavailable."

Then he called Shashank.

"I need you to look again at the original text of a Chinese email," Aditya said.

Shashank was silent for a moment. Over the past few days he had begun to feel that every translation he made was no longer merely language work; it was also a future cross-examination. "When should I come?"

"After noon."

"All right."

After ending the call, Shashank stood by the window. The sunlight over Delhi looked not yellow but white. Once, at the temple in Pitampura, Juliana had told him, "The meaning of a word lies not only in its pronunciation; before whom it was spoken, at what time, and under what fear are also part of its meaning." At the time Shashank had understood it as a lesson in language. Now he understood that it was also a lesson in evidence.

When he reached the office, Aditya showed him two texts on a computer screen. The first was the original Chinese email. The second was an English summary attached to the file.

"Read the original," Aditya said.

Shashank read it line by line. His eyes stopped at one sentence.

"It says here: 'Suspend use of the payment name until legal confirmation is received.'"

Aditya looked at the English summary. It said: "Stop using the payment name."

"Difference?"

"Yes," Shashank replied. "In the original, the suspension is temporary and conditional - until legal confirmation is received. The condition has disappeared from the summary. As a result, the sentence reads like a permanent prohibition."

"So does the original email by itself establish an instruction to conceal something?"

"No," Shashank said clearly. "The original says only that use of the name should be suspended until legal confirmation. It does not say why."

Aditya looked at him. Shashank's answers had changed over the previous weeks. Earlier he had been eager to fill empty spaces in meaning; now he pointed out the empty spaces.

"Who prepared this summary?" Shashank asked.

"There is no name in the file. It only says 'translation summary.'"

"Then the author is unknown."

"Yes."

Shashank said quietly, "It is dangerous to read a summary by an unknown author as though it were the original words."

Aditya did not smile, but his gaze softened. "That is why I called you."

At that moment an attendant entered and placed a small slip on Aditya's desk. It said: "Oral information from senior chamber: keep further action on the file in abeyance."

Aditya read the slip. "Whose signature?"

"No one's," the attendant said. "I was told to deliver it."

"Who told you?"

The attendant hesitated for a moment. "From the sahib's room."

"Which sahib?"

He remained silent.

Aditya placed the slip back on the desk. "All right. You may go."

Shashank tried to read his face. "Will you treat this as an order?"

"If a proper order comes, I will comply with it," Aditya said. "This slip is information, not proof of an order."

"But what if it really was said from above?"

"Then it can come in writing."

Shashank remembered Raghav Bhasin's office - confidentiality, selective silence, the old payment names. It seemed to him that in different institutions words changed their shells in the same way. 'Confidential,' 'stayed,' 'legal confirmation,' 'instruction from above' - each expression could be innocent in itself; remove the context, and its use could change.

By evening no written stay order had arrived. Instead, the records branch produced an older email chain in which an officer had supported continuing the investigation. Aditya placed a copy of that email in the file, but did not declare the officer 'alert' or 'honest' on that basis. He wrote only: "Email dated [date] supports continuation of further verification."

Shashank asked, "Does everyone in your office write with this much care?"

Aditya did not laugh. "No. And that is why many problems are born."

"Then whom do you trust?"

"Not a person. A record that can be checked."

The sentence lodged somewhere inside Shashank. Many of the relationships in his life had been built upon trust in persons - the teacher in his village, the teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Juliana, Mrinal, Raghav, foreign clients. Learning language without trust was difficult. But in an institutional investigation, trust alone was not enough.

He wondered: had he really needed to travel this far to understand that distinction?

That night, when he met Mrinal, Shashank did not tell him the whole episode, only his unease.

"Suppose," Shashank said, "someone first says, 'Take the question further,' and later says, 'I never said any such thing.' What is that?"

Mrinal set his cup of tea on the table. "First see what evidence exists for the first statement."

"If there is only memory?"

"Then it is memory."

"If someone heard it?"

"Then there is a witness, but a witness is not beyond question either."

"And if there is a written note?"

"Then it is a firmer basis, but its meaning must still be read in context."

Shashank smiled. "You have begun speaking like Aditya."

"No," Mrinal said. "I am only saying that this is your problem - the moment you feel betrayed, you begin looking for the guilty person."

Shashank fell silent.

Mrinal continued, "The feeling of betrayal may be true. But a conclusion of guilt is a different thing."

The sentence made Shashank uncomfortable, because he was learning the same thing in Aditya's office: feeling and conclusion were not one.

The next day a small meeting was held in Aditya's department. A senior officer attended. His voice was steady, his manner courteous. He said, "The priority of some files changes for administrative reasons. Do not attach unnecessary meaning to that."

Aditya asked, "Can the reason for reducing the priority of this particular file be made available in writing?"

Silence spread through the room for a moment.

The senior officer said, "If necessary, it will come through the proper channel."

"Was action expected to stop on the basis of an oral slip?"

"I gave no such personal instruction."

Aditya placed the slip before him. "It says 'senior chamber.' The source is not clear. So I did not treat it as an order."

The officer looked at the slip. There was neither anger nor fear on his face. "You did right. Verify the source."

The meeting ended.

As they stepped outside, Shashank asked, "Then does this prove the officer is innocent?"

Aditya answered immediately, "No."

"And guilty?"

"Not that either."

"Then what does it prove?"

"Only that he denied giving such a personal oral instruction, and that no written order is presently available. Now we find the source."

Shashank nodded. It seemed to him that Navya-Nyaya was no longer an old subject he had studied, but a daily humiliation - because every time his mind wanted to make a story at once, the method stopped him exactly there.

That afternoon the records-branch employee was questioned. He said the words on the slip were not his; they had been dictated to him over the telephone. He did not properly remember which extension number the call had come from. Nothing had been entered in the record.

Aditya wrote: "Source of the slip presently unverified."

That was all.

No "conspiracy."

No "collusion established."

No "innocence established."

Shashank kept looking at the paper. Such sentences had once seemed weak to him. Now he was beginning to understand that sometimes the hardest form of truth lived in a sentence that resisted the temptation to say more than it could support.

In the evening he went to Pitampura. Juliana was sitting on the temple veranda. The sound of the bell had already faded. Without any preface Shashank asked, "If someone gives words and later says those words were not his, what does language do?"

Juliana looked at him for a while. "Language does nothing. People do."

"But evidence?"

"Look for footprints behind the words. Written? Heard? Repeated? Changed? By whom?"

Shashank laughed. "Everyone is saying the same thing."

"Then perhaps you have begun to listen."

The answer stung him and calmed him at the same time.

Juliana continued, "Betrayal does not happen only when someone lies. Sometimes shifting responsibility for the truth onto someone else is also betrayal."

In Shashank's mind, the attendant's slip, the anonymous translation summary, 'it was said from above,' and his own old selective silence rose together. For the first time he felt that there was an invisible thread between institutional betrayal and personal deception - in both, a person abandons ownership of the words while leaving their effect behind.

That night, when he returned, he opened his notebook.

He wrote the heading: "Word: Footprints of Responsibility."

Beneath it he wrote:

"The existence of an oral instruction and its validity are not the same thing."

"A summary by an unknown author is not the original text."

"A written order reducing priority is a fact; the absence of its reason is a separate fact."

"A senior officer's denial is a statement; it does not by itself establish guilt or innocence."

"The feeling of betrayal may be a truth of character; a criminal conclusion requires independent evidence."

"Hiding responsibility for words does not make the words ineffective."

He put down the pen. Outside, the night was thickening. Inside, it seemed to him that the discipline of language had travelled far from pronunciation. At Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan he had corrected tones; at the Red

Fort he had learned about immediate judgments of meaning; at the Tao temple, the discipline of silence. Now offices and courts were teaching him the fourth lesson of words - ownership of what has been said.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: a written order directed that the file's priority be reduced, but its reason was not recorded in that order; an unsigned slip, describing itself as oral information from the 'senior chamber,' conveyed a message to suspend further action; the relevant senior officer denied giving any personal oral instruction; the actual source of the slip remained unverified; in the original Chinese email, the instruction was to suspend use of the payment name 'until legal confirmation is received,' a condition omitted from the English summary.

The inference went only this far: someone may have influenced the direction of the file by reducing the context of certain words. There were some inconsistencies supporting that inference, but whose role was what had not yet been established.

The false allegation here would be to declare any officer, employee, translator, or institution a participant in a crime merely on the basis of the priority-reduction order, the unsigned slip, or the error in the translation summary.

The feeling of betrayal went only this far: Aditya felt that instead of responsibility being stated clearly, it was being moved around inside words such as 'above,' 'channel,' and 'summary'; Shashank saw in that scene a reflection of his own former selective silence. But feeling, accusation, and established fact remained separate.

CHAPTER 23

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 10

At dawn Shashank's phone vibrated several times in quick succession. The first message was from Mrinal: "Call me before you write anything." The second was from an old classmate at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: "Is this news true?" The third came from a Chinese acquaintance: "Your name is being linked with me; please clarify."

Shashank opened the screen. The headline of a digital news outlet lodged between his eyes like a thorn: "Translator a Key Link in Chinese Network in Sealed Records?" Beneath the headline was an old photograph of him against the Red Fort, standing with a small group of Chinese tourists many years earlier.

Three phrases recurred throughout the article: Macao trip, limited server access, and "old payment names." Between those three phrases, the writer had inserted his own conclusion—that Shashank understood the "operation of the money chain" and used language to alter the direction of the investigation. The article did not name its source; it said only, "a source familiar with sealed material."

Shashank's first reaction was not anger but shame. He was not afraid that the police would arrive at once; he imagined instead that his teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, old acquaintances from the Red Fort, Juliana in Pitampura, and members of Delhi's Chinese community would all see the same image—his face, his name, and above him a sentence he had never spoken.

He read the article again. Some of the facts were true. He had gone to Macao. He had been given limited display access. He had translated the words "old payment names" during a confidential meeting. But those facts did not establish that he had "operated the money chain." He knew that. The language of the report had erased the distance.

The phone rang. It was Mrinal.

"Have you written anything?"

"I am writing that all the allegations are false."

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. "All?"

Shashank's thumb stopped on the screen.

"Meaning?"

"Did you go to Macao?"

"Yes."

"Did you see a limited server display?"

"Yes."

"Did you translate the words 'old payment names'?"

"Yes."

"Then if you write 'all false,' are you correcting the report's errors, or erasing your own history?"

Shashank gave no answer. Mrinal's voice was not harsh; that was why it cut more deeply.

"Call the false allegation false," Mrinal said. "Call the fact a fact. If, in answer to humiliation, you paint everything the same colour, what difference remains between you and that article?"

Shashank ended the call. He remembered his teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan saying that a change in tone could change the meaning of a word. Now he understood that in news, tone was not merely sound; headline, sequence, omission, and addition were tones too.

He deleted the first draft of his statement. He wrote a second: "The Macao trip and limited display access mentioned in the report are facts; however, those facts do not establish that I operated a money chain or influenced the investigation. The expression 'old payment names' occurred in a confidential interpreting context; its meaning, role, and legal consequence cannot be determined without the full context of the record."

At the end he added: "I will not make public comment on the actual contents of sealed material."

As he wrote the sentence, a strange emptiness opened inside him. Earlier he had used words to construct his image. Today, for the first time, he was being forced to use words to surrender part of that image.

At that same time in Aditya Mishra's office, the same news article lay printed on the desk. Two officers were looking at the headline. One said, "This is clearly a leak."

Aditya looked up. "Clearly—on what basis?"

"The article mentions sealed material."

"Mention is not proof that the writer saw sealed material."

“But the phrase ‘old payment names?’”

“That phrase was used in a confidential meeting. More than one person was present. A translation summary was later prepared. We will trace the journey of the phrase, but its source is not yet established.”

He called for the access register of the sealed envelope. The register recorded who had viewed the material, at what time, and under what authority. The outer seal was intact. But Aditya knew that “seal intact” did not mean “no one carried the contents in memory.” Several people had seen the original records before the material was sealed.

He made a separate list of each claim in the article.

First—Shashank travelled to Macao. Supported by records.

Second—he saw a limited server display. Supported by his own statement and travel-related documents.

Third—he operated the money chain. No present support.

Fourth—he altered the direction of the investigation. No present support; there were only certain translation choices and episodes of selective silence.

Fifth—the source of the article was sealed material. Presently unverified.

At the top of the list Aditya wrote one word: “Words.” Beneath it: “said, quoted, added, inferred.”

His colleague laughed. “Are you checking the grammar of the news?”

Aditya said, “Sometimes the wrong is not hidden in a word but in the relationship created between words. But seeing a relationship does not establish a crime.”

By noon excerpts from the report had spread through several groups. One of Shashank’s old acquaintances at the Red Fort called him. “Do not come here for a few days. The tourist agencies are asking questions.”

Shashank’s mouth went dry. The Red Fort had been his first open stage, where he had begun to believe language might become his livelihood. Now an old photograph against that same background had become the cover of his public humiliation.

A brief message arrived from an elderly teacher at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: “Read the original sentence, not the news.” Nothing more.

Shashank stared at the screen for a long time. It was the same lesson his teacher had once given him about tones; today the form of the lesson had changed.

In the evening he reached Pitampura. Juliana was separating dried petals on the veranda. As soon as Shashank sat down, he held out the phone to her.

Juliana did not read the entire article. She read the headline, then the first paragraph, and set the phone down.

“What do you want?” she asked.

“I want people to understand that none of this is established.”

“People?”

“Everyone.”

“Everyone will not understand the same thing on the same day.”

Shashank grew impatient. “Then what should I do?”

Juliana looked at him. “In humiliation, a person makes two errors. One—to hide everything. Two—to tell everything. In both cases words become servants of fear.”

“But if I remain silent?”

“You are not silent. Write the limits of what you know. Write the limits of what you do not know as well.”

Shashank did not laugh. “Will writing limits clear my name?”

“Clearing your name is not the work of language. The work of language is to place only as much weight on a sentence as the sentence can bear.”

A bell sounded once inside the temple. The old days at the Red Fort rose in Shashank’s mind—a Chinese tourist had asked a question, and while explaining the meaning Shashank had added an inference of his own. At the time, he had thought it a skill. Now he was beginning to understand how far a small addition of inference could travel.

As he left Pitampura, a message from Aditya arrived: “The claims made by the news report are being verified separately. Please do not write inferred contents of sealed material in any public statement.”

Shashank replied: “I have written only facts directly known to me.”

A few moments later Aditya answered: “That much is appropriate.”

That night Shashank’s name rose again across social media. Some called him a traitor, some an innocent scholar, some a “Chinese agent,” some a “government scapegoat.” At first he kept reading everything. Then he turned the phone face down.

Mrinal came late at night carrying two cups of tea. He placed one before Shashank and said, "People will write your story according to their convenience. The question is—by what rule will you write your own?"

"By truth," Shashank said.

Mrinal looked directly at him. "All of it?"

Shashank took time before answering. "As much as I know. What I do not know, I will not fill in."

For the first time Mrinal smiled faintly. "You should have given that answer earlier."

"Earlier I thought intelligence meant filling empty spaces."

"And now?"

"Sometimes it is harder to leave an empty space empty."

That same night Aditya placed the access register, the news article, Shashank's public statement, and the attendance list from the confidential meeting side by side. He found one unusual similarity: a phrase used in the article resembled a phrase from the translation summary, but did not appear in exactly that form in the sealed note. The simple story of a "sealed leak" therefore weakened. The source might have been the sealed record, an earlier summary, someone present at the meeting, or a mixture of more than one source. All remained possible.

He wrote: "Similarity of wording does not establish identity of source; the source chain must be examined separately."

On the next line: "A false conclusion by the media cannot justify a false conclusion by the investigation."

Then: "Public humiliation of a person is not a reason to lower the evidentiary standard."

After writing that final sentence, Aditya paused for a while. He knew that Shashank was no symbol of innocence; his own statements contained selective silence, an out-of-scope search, and signs of self-importance. But none of those things justified declaring him guilty of a crime for which independent evidence did not yet exist.

Elsewhere, Shashank opened his notebook. He reread the heading from Chapter 22: "Word: Footprints of Responsibility." On the next page he wrote: "Word: Limits in Humiliation."

Beneath it he wrote four lines:

"A fact that is difficult to admit because of shame does not thereby become false."

"An accusation that humiliates does not become true merely because it humiliates."

"Naming sealed material and knowing its actual contents are different things."

"In public defence, denying what is unknown may itself become an inference."

His pen stopped. The humiliation inside him was still there—sharp, hot, unbearable. Yet within that humiliation a small discipline had begun to grow. He had not yet abandoned the desire to see his name cleared; but for the first time he had become wary of the desire to dirty the facts in order to clean his name.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: a digital news outlet published severe conclusions about Shashank's role on the basis of his Macao trip, limited server display, and the phrase "old payment names"; the Macao trip and limited display access were supported by earlier records; "old payment names" had arisen in a confidential interpreting context; the access register for the sealed envelope was available and the outer seal was intact; some language in the article resembled language from an earlier translation summary, but the source had not yet been established.

The inference went only this far: the writer or the writer's source might have known some confidential or formerly confidential material. That inference warranted investigation, but a direct leak from sealed records, its source, and any person's criminal role had not yet been established.

The false allegation here would be to declare Shashank, on the available facts, the operator of the money chain, an influencer of the investigation, or a proved participant in a wider crime; likewise, the mere publication of the article would not justify treating any officer or meeting participant as the person who leaked sealed material.

The feeling of humiliation went only this far: because of a single news headline, Shashank saw his old professional world—the memories of Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, his identity at the Red Fort, the discipline of the Tao temple, and Delhi's Chinese community—begin to draw away from him. But public humiliation, personal guilt, actual crime, and judicial proof remained separate things.

The night had grown very late. Shashank switched off his phone. Tomorrow the papers would be read again, the source of words would be questioned, and perhaps in court every joint in a sentence would be challenged. He was beginning to understand now: evidence could lie not only in what words said, but also in the journey by which the words arrived.

CHAPTER 24

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE II

The next morning, before leaving for court, Shashank opened his notebook. The four lines he had written the previous night were still fresh - fact, allegation, sealed material, and the limits of what was unknown. On the next part of the page he wrote only one word: "Word."

Today the word was not a classroom exercise. Today every word would have to carry the weight of an oath.

Mrinal arrived before the appointed time. In his hand was a paper cup of tea. He placed it before Shashank and said, "In court they will not ask what you think about yourself. They will ask which sentence you spoke and when, which sentence you translated, and in which sentence you added your own meaning."

Shashank lifted the cup but did not drink. "I know."

Mrinal looked at him. "Knowing and obeying are two different things."

The sentence lodged inside Shashank. Juliana too had said the same thing many times in another form - recognising a tone was one thing; accepting the discipline of tone was another.

The court corridor was cold. Outside, journalists had gathered, but inside the rustle of papers seemed louder. The matter was not yet at the stage of final adjudication; the hearing concerned the permissible use of sealed material, translation summaries, and certain electronic records. Even so, for Shashank this was the first occasion on which his own language would stand naked before the questions of a court.

Raghav Bhasin came over while gathering his papers. "Answer only what is asked."

An immediate objection rose in Shashank's mind, but he stopped the words. "Yes."

A short distance away, Aditya Mishra was examining the government's records. His face was neither hard nor reassuring. Shashank found that neutrality unsettling. Anger could be answered; method could be answered only with method.

The hearing began. The first questions concerned the source chain of the translation summary. The original Chinese audio fragment, its written transcription, the provisional translation prepared by Shashank, and the official summary prepared later - all four were identified separately.

The judge asked, "Are all four forms of the same material?"

Government counsel said, "The underlying event is the same, but the levels of expression are different."

Raghav Bhasin rose at once. "It is not enough to say 'different levels.' The record must show at which level human interpretation entered."

The judge looked towards Shashank. "Is the interpreter present?"

Shashank stood. "Ji--" The word had barely left his mouth when he stopped. "Yes, I am present."

Some people did not notice the correction, but Aditya looked up. Shashank remembered his first class at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan - the teacher had said that as the tongue adopts a language, the mind slowly learns its discipline as well.

The cross-examination began.

"Where did you formally learn Chinese?"

"I began my studies at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. Later I practised with tourists at the Red Fort, and at the Tao temple in Pitampura I learned pronunciation and cultural cues from Juliana."

"Were you a certified court interpreter?"

"Not at that time."

"Then why were your translations used in the investigation record?"

"I was asked to help understand certain Chinese statements. Some portions were later verified through official procedure."

"All portions?"

"No."

A brief silence spread through the courtroom. Shashank knew that a bare "no" did not seem to help him. But at that moment he heard Juliana's voice in his mind: let a sentence carry only as much weight as it can bear.

Counsel lifted the next paper. "You translated this sentence as: 'Do not use the old payment name again.' Correct?"

"Yes."

"What is the literal meaning of the original Chinese sentence?"

Shashank was silent for a moment. "A closer literal meaning would be: 'The previous payment name is not to be used again.' The subject is not explicit."

"Meaning the word 'you' or the imperative 'do' was added?"

"Yes. I added an imperative force because that was how I understood it."

"An instruction to whom?"

"At the time I thought it was directed to the person in front of the speaker."

"You thought?"

"Yes. The subject was not explicit in the original sentence."

Raghav Bhasin's pen stopped. There was movement among the journalists. Shashank's shoulders tightened. He knew that after this admission, articles might again turn it into a headline. But this time he did not take the sentence back.

The cross-examiner asked, "Did you record this ambiguity in your first written translation?"

"No."

"Why?"

The old answers were ready inside Shashank - there was little time, the context seemed clear, everyone wanted speed. But all of them were half-truths. He said, "Because at that time I trusted my understanding of the context more than I should have."

"Was that an error?"

For a moment Shashank's eyes moved towards Aditya. Aditya was not looking at him; he was writing a note.

"Yes," Shashank said. "Failing to record the ambiguity was an error."

As he said it, something loosened in his chest. Atonement is not always tears; sometimes it is only the correct noun.

The cross-examination moved to the next portion. The issue of limited server display in Macao was raised. Counsel asked, "Was your access officially limited to the display you were shown?"

"Officially, yes."

"Did you later try to open an additional menu?"

"Yes."

"Did you have permission?"

"No."

"Did you find anything?"

"I saw some technical names and lists, but not enough to establish their full meaning, ownership, or connection with any crime."

"Did you then tell anyone that you had reached inside the network?"

Shashank's mouth went dry. He remembered the sentence. In a moment of self-importance before Mrinal he had said, "I have understood the inner structure."

"I said something like that out of pride," he answered. "It was factually broader than the evidence justified."

"False?"

Shashank paused. "Not entirely false, but broader than the evidence. I had seen some structure; saying I had 'reached inside' was an exaggeration."

The judge intervened. "You are making three categories of your own statements - falsehood, exaggeration, and established fact?"

"Yes."

"Why is that distinction necessary?"

Shashank took a breath before answering. "Because not every defective statement is defective in the same way. Some statements contradict the facts. Some go beyond the facts. In some, the facts remain correct but we expand their meaning further than we should."

The judge's face showed nothing. "Very well. Record that answer in full."

For the first time Aditya looked towards Shashank. There was no praise in his eyes, but no opposition either - only an acknowledgment that proper classification made an investigation easier.

Government counsel raised another point. "The news report stated that sealed material identifies Shashank Jha as a principal operator. Does the available sealed material support that claim?"

Raghav Bhasin objected to any public disclosure of the contents of sealed material. The judge examined the papers and permitted a limited answer.

Aditya was called to the witness stand.

"Have you seen the material?"

"Within my authorised limits."

"Does Shashank Jha's name appear in it?"

"His name and his role as an interpreter appear in some records."

"As a principal operator?"

"No established conclusion in those words."

"Then the news report was false?"

Aditya paused. "That particular conclusion in the report is not supported by the material presently available. But not every underlying fact described in the report is false. The journey, limited access, certain translations, and certain episodes of selective silence exist separately in the record."

Shashank felt another blow inside, but this one was familiar. Aditya was not rescuing him. Nor was he making him guilty. He was only drawing the boundary.

The cross-examiner asked, "Do you trust Shashank's translations?"

Aditya said, "I do not rely on the translator; I rely on a verifiable method of translation."

"The distinction?"

"A person may be gifted, but talent is not evidence. If the original sound, transcription, context, alternative meanings, and words added by the translator are kept separate, the translation becomes testable."

A shiver ran through Shashank. This was the language of Gangesha's method - qualificand, qualifier, relation, boundary. But the method Shashank had once used to take pride in his intelligence, Aditya was using to set limits upon that intelligence.

The judge asked, "So the dispute is not with Navya-Nyaya, but with its use?"

Aditya inclined his head slightly. "The method itself takes no one's side. The question is which relationship we treat as established and which as inference."

The village in Mithila rose in Shashank's mind - old books, the name of Gangesha Upadhyaya, the pride with which he had come to Delhi. Then he had thought subtle reasoning would place him ahead of others. Now in court that same subtlety was turning him towards responsibility for his own sentences.

Raghav Bhasin sought permission to ask further questions. "Shashank, if the subject was not explicit in the original sentence, why did you add the imperative 'do not use'?"

"Because of the context."

"Is context-based translation common?"

"Yes."

"Then you made no error?"

The question opened an easy door of defence for Shashank. He could have said: no, it was normal practice. But he remembered how often the word "normal" hides responsibility.

"Context-based translation is common," he said, "but when a sentence may become a basis for investigation, it is not proper to turn an ambiguous subject into an explicit one in writing without marking the addition."

Raghav Bhasin was silent for a moment. "So you are criticising your own earlier translation?"

"Yes."

"Under pressure?"

"No. After reading the later records."

The answer was ordinary in the courtroom, but heavy for Shashank. He was giving up the defence of his former self. He was beginning to understand atonement - not erasing one's history, but writing the proper name of it.

During the recess Mrinal found him outside. "Was it difficult?"

"Yes."

"What was the hardest part?"

"Saying that I had committed an error--" Shashank stopped, then corrected himself. "Saying that I had made an error."

Mrinal smiled. "Language polishing even in court?"

For the first time Shashank laughed. "Sometimes changing a word makes the meaning clearer."

Mrinal said, "And sometimes the mind."

After the recess the court reserved its order on the limited use of the sealed material. No final finding of criminal guilt was made. It was made clear only that the interpreter's provisional line could not be treated as identical to the original statement, and that any addition or interpretation had to be identified.

As Shashank came out, reporters threw questions at him: "Have you admitted making a defective translation?" "Were you protecting the network?" "Did officers change your statement?"

Shashank did not stop. Earlier, in such moments, he would have wanted to repair his story immediately. Now he understood that an answer in a corridor was not the record of a court.

When he reached Pitampura, Juliana was sitting on the veranda. Shashank told her about the court.

"What did you learn?"

"That the meaning of a word is not only the dictionary."

"You already knew that."

Shashank was silent for a while. "That presenting a meaning I added as though it were the original meaning is arrogance."

Juliana looked at him. "And atonement?"

"Writing my own name beside that addition."

Juliana smiled faintly. "Then the lesson has begun."

That night Shashank opened his notebook. At the top of the page he wrote: "Word: Original, Translation, Interpretation." Beneath it he drew three lines.

On the first he wrote: "Original statement: where there is no subject, do not invent one."

On the second: "Translation: context is an aid, not proof."

On the third: "Interpretation: if I add something, I must name the addition as mine."

Then he remembered the three books from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. The first had been about sound, the second about sentences, the third about conduct. Now he understood that a fourth book had never been written on paper - the book of responsibility.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: in court, the original Chinese statement, the written transcription, Shashank's provisional translation, and the official summary were treated as separate materials; Shashank admitted that his addition clarifying the subject of an ambiguous sentence had not been recorded as an addition; after limited server access he had made an exaggerated statement about the extent of his access; sealed material linked his name to the role of interpreter, but no established conclusion identifying him as a "principal operator" was shown in the available material.

The inference went only this far: some of Shashank's linguistic additions may have influenced the meaning later attached to the investigation or public opinion. That influence could not be established without separately examining each record, each statement, and its source chain.

The false allegation here would be to declare him automatically the operator of a wider crime because of an interpreter's error or exaggeration; or, conversely, to use the exaggeration of the news report to pretend that all his earlier selective silences and out-of-scope conduct never existed.

The limit of established fact was this: in some places Shashank had made context-based additions in translation and had failed clearly to mark one important ambiguity. The criminal purpose of those errors, the extent of their effect, or any connection with a wider conspiracy was not established in this hearing.

The feeling of atonement went only this far: in court Shashank could have opened an easy door to defend his old sentences, but at several points he himself said, "That addition was mine," "That exaggeration was mine," "I should have recorded that ambiguity." He still cared about his name, reputation, and future; but for the first time, instead of distorting the categories of words to save his reputation, he surrendered a part of his reputation to preserve the limits of the words.

The night had grown very deep. Outside, the sounds of Delhi traffic were sparse. Shashank closed the page. He knew that the next stage would bring more summonses, statements, and papers from digital seizures. His ambition was not dead; the voice inside him saying, "I am necessary," was still alive. But now another voice had been born to stand before it: "The limits of what I say are also my responsibility."

CHAPTER 25

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 12

The exhaustion of the previous day in court had not fully left Shashank when, early in the morning, a message arrived on his phone from the commissionerate—a supplementary summons had been issued. The reason for his appearance was stated briefly: linguistic verification of certain Chinese statements found in seized digital material, clarification of his earlier statement, and confirmation of the source chain.

Shashank read the message twice. For many months, a summons had seemed to him a sign of fear, humiliation, and insecurity. Today, for the first time, another feeling rose inside him—ambition. If the investigators once again depended on his linguistic knowledge, he thought, perhaps his talent could still preserve his place.

Mrinal read his face. “A summons?”

“Yes.”

“And you are pleased?”

Shashank did not answer at once. “Not pleased. But... I am needed.”

Mrinal set his cup of tea on the table. “Are you needed, or do you want to remain necessary?”

The question was simple. The answer was not.

When Shashank reached the commissionerate, Aditya Mishra was already seated with a file open. Before him lay three separate envelopes—one containing a copy of the seizure memo, another the verification list for the digital copies, and the third the extracts selected for translation. As Shashank sat down, Aditya said without preamble, “Today you will not perform the roles of translator and statement-giver at the same time.”

“Meaning?”

“Where you speak about facts concerning your own work or travel, that will form part of your statement. Where you explain a Chinese line from the seized material, that will be linguistic assistance. The two will go into separate records.”

Shashank smiled faintly. “Meaning you will keep me separate even from myself?”

“In the record, yes.”

Aditya opened the first envelope. The seizure memo listed phones, a laptop, external storage media, and several paper records. Each item had its own number, time of seizure, seal description, and separate notation that a digital copy had been created.

“You will not see all of this,” Aditya said. “You will see only the copies carrying verification numbers.”

An old sting rose inside Shashank. He remembered the limited server access in Macao, where curiosity had carried him beyond the boundary. Today Aditya was showing him the boundary before the work began.

Several printed pages came out of the second envelope. They were excerpts from chats. Beside each line were the time, the source-device number, and the page number of the copy. The names were not written in full, only in abbreviated marks.

Aditya said, “First rule?”

Shashank answered, “Original line first. Translation after it. Interpretation separately.”

“Second?”

“Where there is no explicit subject, do not add one.”

“Third?”

Shashank was silent for a few moments. “Where more than one meaning is possible, record all the plausible meanings.”

Aditya nodded. “Good.”

The first Chinese line was simple: “Do not use the old list.” Shashank wrote it down. In the second line there was a word which, depending on context, could mean “list,” “account details,” or “roster of names.” For a moment Shashank’s pen moved towards writing “account.” Earlier material had referred to payment recipients; “account” would make the story clearer.

But he stopped.

“Three possibilities,” he said. “List, roster of names, or, in a particular context, account details. It would not be proper to choose one meaning from the line alone.”

Aditya looked at what he had written. “Did this change after the court hearing?”

“No,” Shashank said, “but the court gave me the courage to accept that ‘I do not know’ is also an answer.”

The third extract was a transcript of an audio message. A voice said, “Leave the old name; take the new arrangement.” Shashank read the line and fell silent.

“What is it?” Aditya asked.

“The word ‘arrangement’ is broad. It could mean a payment arrangement, a contact arrangement, a group of names, or an internal working arrangement. The audio by itself does not establish a criminal meaning.”

“Then write only that much.”

Again the old voice of ambition rose inside Shashank—if he gave a bolder meaning, the investigators would see his intelligence; if he wrote only the boundary, he would remain an ordinary translator. His old nature whispered to him: fill the empty space in meaning; people will depend on you for clarity.

He stopped his pen and remembered a page in his notebook—“Original, Translation, Interpretation.”

He wrote: “The original term has a broad range of meaning; a payment-related context is possible, but the line itself does not establish that conclusion.”

Aditya said nothing. He merely pushed the next page towards him.

The work continued until noon. Some lines were contractual language, some travel information, some social conversation. In one place appeared an expression like “the people above.” Earlier Shashank might have translated such an expression as “senior management” or “the owner.” Now he wrote: “Literal sense: person/people above or at a higher level; actual position unknown.”

Aditya asked, “In your experience, which position is this expression usually used for?”

Shashank answered, “It depends on context. Sometimes an officer, sometimes a manager, sometimes merely a senior colleague. Experience gives possibilities, not identification.”

There was a faint satisfaction on Aditya’s face. “That is why discipline in words is necessary.”

In the middle of the work, Shashank’s mind travelled for a moment to his first class at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. The teacher had made them pronounce the same sound again and again, saying that a small change in tone could change meaning. Talking with Chinese tourists at the Red Fort, Shashank too had seen the same word acquire different shades through region, age, and context. His later acquaintance with Delhi’s Chinese community had made that even clearer. Now, before these seized digital lines, he understood the value of those old exercises—familiarity with language opens meaning, but familiarity cannot take the place of evidence.

After noon, the statement-taking began. An officer questioned Shashank about his previous foreign trip, his limited server access, the meeting at Raghav Bhasin’s office, and his earlier translations. This time Aditya was not the questioner; he sat to one side examining the record.

“Had you ever seen any of the seized devices before?”

Shashank examined every number carefully. “I cannot identify any device from these numbers. Some device types look familiar, but similarity of type is not proof of identity.”

“Do you know the meaning of the ‘old list’ mentioned in this chat?”

“No. I know possible meanings, not the definite intention.”

“Did your former clients use language like this?”

For a moment Shashank felt the temptation to display his importance. He could have said: yes, I know this linguistic world from the inside. The sentence would make him an expert.

He said, “I have heard some similar expressions, but the same words do not establish the same intention.”

The officer writing the statement looked up at him. “Why do you add a limitation to every answer?”

Shashank smiled faintly. “Because if I do not add the boundary, the answer will become larger than I am.”

For the first time Aditya looked towards him.

Before the statement ended, the officer asked, “Would you be willing to assist the department with regular linguistic examination of this material?”

The moment he heard the question, the old voice of ambition inside Shashank grew louder. This was the door to the recognition for which he had waited so long—official work, a continuing role, acknowledgment of his knowledge.

But Aditya did not intervene. He waited for Shashank’s answer.

Shashank said, “If the rules permit, I would like to provide linguistic assistance. But wherever I myself am a statement-giver or a related person in the material, my interpretation should not be treated as final without independent verification.”

The officer wrote it down. “You added this condition yourself?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because I want to be necessary. And that desire can itself become a source of bias.”

Silence spread through the room for a moment.

Aditya closed the file. "Leave that sentence in the statement."

When Shashank came outside, Mrinal was waiting. The moment he saw him, he asked, "Were you necessary today?"

Shashank said, "Perhaps—" He stopped himself. "I will provide linguistic assistance. But with clear limits."

Mrinal smiled. "You set the limits for the department?"

"For myself."

The two walked slowly along the roadside. Mrinal said, "Ambition is not improper."

"I know."

"No. Earlier you did not know that. Earlier you believed that for ambition to be proved good, its result had to be successful. Now understand this—ambition needs a boundary."

Shashank said nothing.

That evening, at the Tao temple in Pitampura, Juliana was sitting on the veranda. Shashank told her about the summons, the digital copies, and the question of assisting the department.

Juliana asked, "What do you want?"

"I want my linguistic skill to have value."

"And?"

"I want people to consider me necessary."

"And?"

Shashank was silent.

Juliana said, "When a student begins measuring his own worth by how much the teacher needs him, he stops creating learning and begins creating dependence."

The sentence pierced Shashank. "Then should I abandon ambition?"

"No. Give ambition a direction. Become the kind of translator whose translation can be checked even without you. If your work is held to be true only because people trust you, that is not knowledge; it is dominion."

That night Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote the heading: "Word and Ambition."

Beneath it he wrote four lines:

"My talent may be useful; it is not evidence."

"My experience gives possibilities; it does not identify."

"My translation is useful only if it can be checked."

"I may wish to be necessary; but truth must not have to depend upon me."

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: a supplementary summons was issued; Shashank examined selected Chinese extracts from verification-numbered digital copies; he recorded multiple possible meanings for certain words; he answered questions concerning his earlier statement; and when the possibility of departmental linguistic assistance was raised, he himself asked that the limits created by his potential conflict of interest be recorded.

The inference went only this far: some lines in the chats might relate to payment, a list of names, or an internal arrangement. Without the original line, context, source chain, and other independent evidence, no criminal intention could be fixed.

The false allegation here would be to declare Shashank or any other person the operator, beneficiary, or accomplice of a definite crime merely because ambiguous words appeared in the seized material. Conversely, linguistic ambiguity did not justify treating clear documentary facts as though they were nothing.

The limit of established fact was this: selected digital material was presented in the form of copies linked to seizure-memo numbers; Shashank translated certain extracts; instead of assigning fixed meanings to some words, he recorded alternative meanings; his own statement was taken in a separate record. The complete ownership, purpose, beneficial relationship, or proof of criminality of the digital material was not established in this context.

The fact of ambition went only this far: Shashank still wanted recognition, work, and a place in which he was needed. But for the first time he himself was writing the limits of that ambition into the record. The old voice inside him—"Without me the meaning will not open"—had not fallen completely silent; but another sentence now stood before it: "Let the truth be made in such a way that it can be tested even without me."

Night deepened. Outside, the sounds of Delhi were thinning. Shashank closed the notebook. He knew that the next stage would again raise questions of contracts, vendor trails, and actual beneficial ownership. His pride in language would be tested again. But the summons that day had taught him one thing—the power of words is greatest when their limits are written too.

CHAPTER 26

THE DISCIPLINE OF LANGUAGE 13

The next morning, the old blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan looked unusually bright to Shashank. The class was already over, but his former teacher was still listening to questions from a few students. Shashank had stopped only to pay his respects. Seeing him, the teacher smiled. “Do you teach lessons now, or are you still learning them?”

Shashank replied, “Both. The more I translate, the more difficult words seem than they did before.”

The teacher wrote two short sentences on the blackboard. The first meant: “He is the company’s representative.” The second: “He exercises actual control over the company.” Then he asked, “Are they the same thing?”

“No,” Shashank answered at once. “Being a representative is one form of authority; actual control is a different relationship. A representative need not be the owner.”

The teacher nodded. “Then you have learned language. When you can preserve the distance between two neighbouring words, language serves you. When you erase that distance for your own convenience, you do not take service from language; you make language a slave.”

The sentence remained with Shashank all day. When he reached the commissionerate, Aditya Mishra placed four files before him. All four concerned the same commercial chain, but the names were different: a local service contract, a foreign-vendor amendment, a payment instruction, and an ownership declaration. The copies were numbered; the Chinese extracts selected for Shashank were on separate pages.

Aditya said, “Today the question is not crime. The question is relationship. We need to understand only how these names are connected with one another.”

Shashank read the first contract. In the original Chinese text, the person named had been described in the English summary as the “owner.” Shashank returned to the original term, read the whole paragraph around it, then said, “‘Owner’ is not certain here. A closer sense is ‘authorised representative’ or ‘person responsible for dealings.’”

Aditya asked, “Can we treat him as the actual beneficial owner?”

“Not from this line alone.”

“Why?”

“Because authority, representation, control, and benefit can be four different relationships. One person may sign the contract, another receive the payment, a third exercise day-to-day control, and the benefit may flow to a fourth structure. To make them all one person on the strength of a word would go beyond the evidence.”

Aditya made a note. “So for once the translator is not closing the question of beneficial ownership; he is only closing an improper door.”

Shashank smiled faintly. “I like that sentence.”

“Liking it is not evidence,” Aditya said without expression.

Shashank laughed. He understood that Aditya was taking the temperature of his pride.

The second file was a vendor amendment. It mentioned one company providing services instead of another, but in the original Chinese sentence the sense of “instead” did not amount to complete substitution; it was closer to “another party appointed to perform the work.” The English summary was again more categorical: “The new vendor replaces the old vendor.”

Shashank read the line three times. “It is not clear here that the old party ceased to exist in the arrangement. A new party has been added to perform the work. Without seeing the remaining clauses of the contract, it would not be proper to state ‘replacement’ as certain.”

Aditya opened the third file. “Payment instruction?”

A different company’s name appeared on the page. Beneath it, a short Chinese note said: “designated recipient.” Shashank wrote the translation: “designated payment recipient.” Then he added on his own, “This is not synonymous with beneficial owner.”

“Can a payment recipient be a beneficial owner?”

“It can.”

“Is it here?”

“The record does not yet say.”

Aditya turned the page. "Keep the distance between those two sentences."

Pride in language rose inside Shashank. This was the kind of work for which he had come to Delhi. The subtlety of Chinese words, the Maithili habit of separating relations in reasoning, and the limits of legal records - all three met in one place. For a moment he felt that everyone sitting in the room would be in darkness without him.

The sentence rose almost to his lips: "This distinction is difficult to catch without knowing Chinese."

But he stopped. He remembered the line he had written during the previous summons: "Truth must not have to depend upon me."

He said, "The distinction is visible from the original language. But my translation should also be independently checked by another translator."

Aditya looked up. "You are saying that yourself?"

"Yes."

"Is your pride in language diminishing?"

Shashank answered, "No. Perhaps it is reaching the right place."

The fourth file was an ownership declaration. It listed the company's formal shareholdings. One name matched the representative in the first contract, but the shareholding was small. Another name appeared to be indirectly connected with the company receiving payment, but the documentary chain was incomplete.

Aditya asked, "What would you say now?"

Shashank looked through the papers one after another. "Directly established: one person is a representative; a separate entity receives payment; the ownership declaration lists shareholdings in a different order; some names or addresses appear connected with one another. Who the actual beneficial owner is has not yet been established."

"Inference?"

"The structure may be multilayered. The representative or payment recipient may be acting for someone who exercises actual control. But to turn 'may be' into 'is,' independent material is needed."

"False allegation?"

"Declaring someone the actual beneficial owner or the beneficiary of a crime merely because that person's name appears in a contract, payment record, or representative role."

Aditya remained silent for a few moments. Then he said, "Good. Write those three categories separately."

While writing, beneath his signature Shashank added one further line: "Linguistic meaning clarifies the type of relationship; the final conclusion on ownership depends upon independent records."

Aditya read the line. "Was this necessary?"

"For me."

After noon he met Mrinal. The two walked towards the Red Fort. During the previous several weeks Shashank had spent less time among the tourists there. Today the crowd, the red stone, and the sounds of different languages carried him back to the old days of practice.

A Chinese tourist, introducing the person travelling with him, used a term whose formal sense could be "person responsible." From the conversation it became clear that the person was not the owner of a company at all; he was merely handling arrangements for the tour group. Shashank stopped for a moment.

Mrinal asked, "What happened?"

"A form of the same word appeared in the contract this morning. The English summary had turned it into 'owner.'"

"So you have been proved right?"

Instead of answering immediately, Shashank looked towards the tourist. "No. This only shows that the word has a broad field of meaning. This tourist's use does not establish the meaning of that contract."

Mrinal laughed. "Now you are limiting even your victories."

"Without limits, victory quickly turns false."

As he walked out from the shade of the Red Fort, Shashank remembered his earliest days. Back then he had delighted in pronouncing a Chinese word correctly and earning the praise of tourists. His pride in language had lived in the purity of tone. Later, that pride had become a desire to control meaning. Today, for the first time, he understood that a more mature form of pride might lie in protecting the limits of meaning.

On his way back from the Red Fort, Shashank also stopped at a small cultural gathering of Delhi's Chinese community. At the book-exchange table, two people were listed under the same Romanised surname. The volunteer preparing the list said they were probably from the same family.

Shashank looked at the original Chinese forms of the names. The characters were different, and even the shades of pronunciation differed. "The same Roman spelling does not establish that they are the same person or from the same family," he said. "Identification needs other records."

The volunteer asked casually, "But the name is the same, isn't it?"

"It only looks the same in Roman letters," Shashank replied. "Without the original name, birth details, address, or authorised identification, we cannot connect the two."

There was no investigation here, no court, no allegation - only a list at a cultural gathering. Even so, the ownership declaration at the commissionerate rose again in Shashank's mind. This ordinary list showed him how dangerous it could be to assume that the same Romanised name in commercial records meant the same person.

In his notebook he wrote a brief line: "Similarity of name is not identity." Beneath it: "Language may show a relationship; personal identification requires independent evidence."

That evening, at the Tao temple in Pitampura, Juliana sat before a lamp. Shashank explained the four categories from the contracts: representative, payment recipient, person exercising control, beneficial owner.

Juliana asked, "Your language separated them all?"

"Yes."

"Then you are pleased?"

"Very."

"Be careful of that pleasure."

Shashank was startled. "Why?"

"Because seeing a correct distinction can become a source of pride. But if you begin to believe that only you can see the distinction, the same pride will close the door again."

Shashank remained silent.

Juliana continued, "Language is not your property. For a little while, you are its servant. Words leave your mouth and enter other people's lives, reputations, and justice. So the highest form of pride in language is not 'I know.' It is: 'I also know the limits of what I know.'"

When he returned home that night, Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote the heading: "Word and Ownership." Beneath it: "Representation is not ownership. Payment is not benefit. Control is not shareholding. The same name is not the same person. Linguistic proximity is not legal identity."

A little later, a phone call came. A Chinese company's office in Noida needed a local coordinator for a small repair job - someone who understood the language, could speak with contractors, and could make the work list clear. The caller had obtained Shashank's name from an acquaintance in Delhi's Chinese community.

After the call ended, Shashank looked at the page for a few moments. This was a small job outside translation, but it could open a new path where livelihood, language, and commercial relationships met.

He wrote to Mrinal: "A small contract offer has come from Noida."

Mrinal replied at once: "Read the contract first. Your pride in words has passed one test; the test of money is still to come."

Shashank smiled. On the last line of the page he wrote: "Language separates relationships; life brings those relationships back together again."

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: at the commissionerate, selected extracts from a contract, a vendor amendment, a payment instruction, and an ownership declaration were presented for Shashank's linguistic examination; some English summaries gave broader or different meanings than the possible range of the original Chinese terms; the relationships of representative, payment recipient, formal shareholding, and possible control were recorded separately; Shashank himself wrote that his translation required independent verification.

The inference went only this far: different entities or persons might form part of a wider commercial structure, and some relationships might point towards actual beneficial ownership. But an incomplete contract trail, similar names, receipt of payment, or representative status alone did not establish that conclusion.

The false allegation here would be to see someone described as a representative, signatory, or payment recipient and immediately declare that person the actual beneficial owner, hidden controller, or beneficiary of a crime. Conversely, it would also be improper to dismiss clear documentary relationships merely because the structure was complex.

The limit of established fact was this: the selected records used different language for different roles; some English summaries did not reflect the full range of possible meaning in the original Chinese terms; Shashank provided written comments on those distinctions. Actual beneficial ownership, the final chain of control, and any connection with crime were not established in this chapter.

The fact of pride in language went only this far: because of his skill, Shashank saw distinctions that were useful to the investigation. The old voice rose inside him again: "Without me this will not open." But this time

he himself asked for independent verification. The pride had not disappeared; its direction was beginning to change.

Night was falling. Outside, the sounds of Delhi grew sparse. The commissionerate papers lay closed before Shashank, but the message about the small Noida contract remained open. This part of his discipline in language seemed to be completing a circle. Ahead, the test of words would no longer be confined to paper; it would unfold amid work, money, pressure from thugs, fear, and friendship.

CHAPTER 27

CONTRACT AND SHADOW I

The first morning in Noida felt different to Shashank from Delhi. The moment he came out of the metro, broad roads, glass buildings, half-built structures, dust, and the noise of machinery appeared before him all at once. The Chinese company whose office had called him already had a list of minor repairs ready—dampness on a wall, two loose electrical points, a broken plank in the storage area, and replacement of a wooden partition in the reception room. The work was small, but for Shashank this was the first occasion on which his language was descending directly among workers, materials, costs, and payments.

Mrinal had come with him. The previous night he had said plainly, “Do not say yes before reading the contract.” So early that morning Shashank had placed two copies of the contract, his notebook, and a small dictionary in his bag. At the entrance the security guard asked their names; inside, an Indian administrative assistant and a Chinese project coordinator were waiting for him.

The Chinese coordinator explained the work in short sentences. The Indian assistant read out the English summary. Within the first five minutes Shashank found two differences. At one place the Chinese original said “inspection after completion of repairs”; the English summary said “satisfactory completion.” At another, the original said “actual invoice for materials”; the English version said “approved cost.”

Shashank said, “The meanings are close, but they are not the same. Inspection is a process; satisfaction is a decision. An actual invoice and an approved cost are also different things.”

The Indian assistant laughed. “It is a small job. Why so much precision?”

Shashank replied, “The word that is casually left loose in a small job becomes a dispute in a large one.”

Mrinal said nothing. His eyes were on Shashank. Shashank understood that his friend was not watching his skill; he was watching the pride rising inside him.

They walked through the premises to inspect the work list. A local contractor had also arrived. He estimated the materials, labour, and time required. Shashank kept explaining the Chinese coordinator’s questions to him in simple conversational language, adding commonly used technical terms where needed. More than once he felt that language was not merely changing sentences; it was becoming a measuring line between two different cultures of work.

While examining the wooden plank in the storage area, the Gangeshian idea of upamā—analogy—rose in his mind. Knowledge of an unfamiliar thing often opens through resemblance to something familiar—but resemblance is not identity. The rotten wood of a veranda back in his village and the swollen plank in the Noida storage room looked similar, yet their causes could be different: rainwater in one place, air-conditioning moisture in another, a leaking pipe in a third. Analogy shows a path; it does not deliver a verdict.

Shashank applied that thought to the work. The local contractor said the problem was “like that old storage room” where he had worked the previous month. Shashank asked, “What was the cause there?”

“A pipe.”

“Has the pipe here been checked?”

“Not yet.”

“Then do not treat the cause as certain merely from analogy.”

The contractor looked at him, then smiled. “Are you an interpreter or an engineer?”

“An interpreter,” Shashank said, “but it is my job to see the limits of what words claim.”

By noon the work list had been settled. On the final page of the contract, payment was divided into three stages—an advance, a second instalment after the mid-stage inspection, and the balance after completion. Here something new appeared. The company’s accounts assistant showed a printed email containing an account number different from the local contractor’s name. A note said: “For material payment.”

At once the earlier records at the commissionerate came alive inside Shashank. There too, the payment recipient and the contracting party had been different. In some digital messages, one entity had been named as the payment gateway and another as the final recipient. In several places, inferences about mule accounts, hawala, or cryptocurrency had arisen. The scene here looked similar.

But he stopped himself.

Resemblance is not evidence.

He asked the contractor, “This is not your account?”

The contractor said, “No. It belongs to the material supplier. The advance will go there.”

"Is the supplier's name in the contract?"

"No. It will be on the invoice."

Shashank turned to the accounts assistant. "If payment is going to a third party, the written instruction should state that party's role clearly. Otherwise, later the contracting party, payment recipient, and actual beneficiary will dissolve into one another."

The Chinese coordinator asked why so much formality was needed. Shashank said quietly, "Because the same structure can arise from different causes. Sometimes there is a legitimate supplier, sometimes an accounting convenience, sometimes an improper arrangement. The cause cannot be decided from the form alone."

For the first time Mrinal spoke. "And if the reason is recorded in writing, everyone will be protected later as well."

At that one sentence Shashank looked towards him. Mrinal's voice was not harsh. Shashank was beginning to understand that friendship sometimes protects not by offering support, but by becoming a boundary.

Before the work began, Shashank had a separate payment instruction written out: who was the contracting party, who was the material supplier, against which invoice the payment would be made, and by what record payment would be confirmed. He asked for no additional details. He wanted only the relationships to be clear.

In the afternoon, while the workers were unloading materials, Shashank's phone rang. An unfamiliar number.

"You have taken a new job in Noida?" a male voice asked from the other end.

"Who is speaking?"

"What difference does a name make? If you work in this area, understand the arrangements of the area."

Shashank's hand turned cold. "What arrangements?"

A laugh came from the other end. "People who understand need to be told only once."

The call ended.

For a few moments Shashank stood still. His mind immediately began producing inferences—a local thug? A rival contractor? A prank? Someone inside the company? Pressure connected with the earlier investigation? There was not enough basis for any one of them.

Mrinal saw his expression and asked, "What happened?"

Shashank showed him the phone.

Mrinal said, "Write down the time. Save the number. Record only the words that were actually spoken. Use the word 'threat' only if the form of the statement justifies that conclusion."

Shashank was startled. "Why are you speaking like Aditya?"

A faint smile appeared on Mrinal's face. "Because after living with you this long, I too am learning that fear makes inference run very fast."

Shashank opened his notebook and wrote: "Unknown male voice. Question: Have you taken a new job in Noida? Statement: Understand the arrangements of the area. Statement: People who understand need to be told only once. No amount of money, name, location, or explicit demand stated."

After writing it, his fear did not diminish, but its shape changed. The anonymous shadow that a moment earlier had spread in every direction was now bounded within four lines. Words did not erase his fear; words gave it a boundary.

The question arose whether the work should be stopped. The local contractor said calls like this sometimes came from rivalry. The Indian assistant said the company's security department should be informed. Shashank was not in a position to decide. He said only, "I will put in writing what is directly known. Whatever is inference, I will call inference."

By evening the first day's work was complete. The actual cause of the dampness turned out not to be a pipe but a minor blockage in the air-conditioning outlet. The local contractor himself laughed and said, "You were right—it looked like that storage-room problem, but the cause was not the same."

Shashank replied, "That is why analogy is useful and dangerous at the same time."

Mrinal asked, "How dangerous?"

"As dangerous as the moment when we see similarity and treat it as identity."

"And friendship?" Mrinal asked suddenly.

Shashank looked at him.

Mrinal said, "You received that phone call. If I judged only by analogy with the old Shashank, I would say you were hiding something again. But the direct fact today is only this: you showed me the call, wrote down the words, and did not abandon the work and run away."

Shashank did not answer for a few moments. Mrinal's suspicions during the previous months had hurt him; but today he saw a new form of trust inside that suspicion. Friendship was not blind support. Sometimes

friendship meant allowing the other person's present choice to be judged by present evidence rather than by analogy with his old character.

As they were leaving the office, the Chinese coordinator raised the payment issue again. The supplier's invoice had arrived; the account name matched the invoice. In the written note Shashank added only this: "The payment recipient is the material supplier; that fact alone does not establish the contracting party or actual beneficial ownership."

As he wrote the line, the old commissionerate files flashed again in his mind. Payment gateways, mule accounts, hawala, cryptocurrency layering—all those words stood in this new commercial world like distant shadows. But Shashank was beginning to understand that the language of investigation and the language of commerce placed different weights upon the same word. Seeing an "account" did not make it a "mule account"; seeing a "third-party payment" did not make it "hawala"; seeing "digital currency" did not make it "layering."

On the way back that night, Mrinal said, "First day survived."

Shashank laughed. "The job was small."

"The job was small. The shadow was large."

"The phone call?"

"That too. But the shadow inside you as well."

Shashank fell silent.

Mrinal continued, "Now you are seeing two kinds of resemblance. One in the papers. The other between your old life and your new one. Be careful. Not every similarity is identity."

Watching his reflection in the metro glass, Shashank remembered Juliana's words—language is not your property. Now he understood that analogy was not property either; it was a bridge. While crossing a bridge, one had no right to forget that the two banks were different.

When he reached home, he wrote a heading in his notebook: "The First Day of Analogy." Beneath it, four lines:

"A similar payment path is not the same crime.

A threat-like voice is not the same source.

A similar experience is not the same decision.

A similar friendship is not the same silence."

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: Shashank took a language and local-coordination role in a small repair job for a Chinese company in Noida; there were subtle differences of meaning between certain Chinese clauses of the contract and their English summaries; for material payment, an account belonging to a third-party supplier was provided, and later the invoice and account name matched; an unfamiliar caller made an ambiguous statement about "the arrangements of the area"; Shashank made a verbatim record of the words spoken.

The analogy went only this far: Shashank saw certain structural similarities between the new payment instruction and earlier investigation records, and he also saw a resemblance between the apparent cause of the repair problem and an earlier job. In both cases he treated resemblance as the beginning of inquiry, not as a conclusion. The Navya-Nyaya principle governing this episode was: similarity may provide recognition; it does not establish identity.

The inference went only this far: the third-party account might belong to a legitimate supplier or might form part of an improper payment arrangement; the unfamiliar call might have arisen from local pressure, rivalry, a prank, or some other cause. The available material did not establish any one of those possibilities.

The false allegation here would be to see the supplier's third-party account and immediately declare it a mule account, hawala route, or part of cryptocurrency layering; or, on the basis of the ambiguous call, to identify any person, community, or company as the source of pressure by thugs. No such conclusion was established in this episode.

The limit of established fact was this: the name of the payment recipient matched the invoice; its role was recorded in writing as the material supplier; the call contained no explicit demand for money, no name, and no admission of crime; inspection showed that the dampness in the repair area was caused by a blockage in the air-conditioning outlet. Any conclusion beyond those facts depended upon further evidence.

The feeling of friendship went only this far: Mrinal stayed with Shashank, did not intensify his fear, and helped him make a record; but he did not give him blind trust either. Instead of deciding the present Shashank by analogy with the old Shashank's character, he looked at the direct facts of the present. For Shashank this was a new definition of friendship—one that would stand beside him while still protecting the limits of truth.

The night was growing dense. The first small Noida contract was not complete; only its first day had passed. But Shashank understood that language had now stepped outside the safe blackboard of the classroom and entered among money, labour, fear, and shadow. The real test of the contract would begin the next day.

CHAPTER 28

THE FIRST CONTRACT IN NOIDA

When Shashank reached Noida on the second day, the anonymous call from the previous day was still in his mind, but he did not want to let it spread over the work like a shadow. Four lines had been recorded in his notebook; the number had been given to the company's security department; beyond that, he possessed no direct fact. The work had its own pace—the swollen plank in the storage area had to be replaced, the air-conditioning outlet cleaned, the wiring cover repaired at two places, and the material bills reconciled.

Mrinal was with him that day as well. He said, "Yesterday there was fear; today there are accounts."

Shashank smiled. "When fear becomes an account, you can see its size."

Mrinal replied, "And when an account becomes fear?"

Shashank said nothing. He understood that his friend was asking not only about the anonymous call but about his new professional world. Over the past few months, Shashank's linguistic skill had taken him among people and documents where the difference of a single word could alter the meaning of payment, responsibility, or authority. That power gave him pleasure, and it frightened him too.

The workers began their tasks. The Chinese coordinator gave Shashank a short list—what part had been replaced, what material had arrived, and against which bill payment would be made. There were differences at two places between the Chinese original and the English summary. In one place the English said "complete replacement," while the Chinese meant "replacement of the necessary portion." In another, approval of inspection was worded as though the company had already accepted all the work, whereas in the original the approval depended on the final inspection.

Shashank corrected the two lines and explained them to the coordinator. Laughing, the coordinator said, "You see a great many words even in a small contract."

"In a small contract, a mistake may cost less," Shashank said, "but the nature of a mistake is not small."

There was pride inside that answer. Shashank felt it. Earlier he had been learning language; now language was becoming his identity. The blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the tourists at the Red Fort, Juliana's exercises in pronunciation—all rose inside him like a long staircase. For a moment he felt that he really was different from people who merely exchanged words. He could see the fine joints of meaning.

Mrinal read his face. "You look very pleased."

"If I am useful in the work, should I not be pleased?"

"Be pleased. But keep a distance between useful and indispensable."

Shashank's laughter stopped halfway.

After noon the final inspection of the contract work took place. The air-conditioning outlet had been cleared, the dampness was receding, and the wooden plank had been replaced. The material supplier's invoice, account name, and delivery slip were matched. The third-party account that had reminded Shashank on the first day of earlier investigation papers now had a clearer role—it was the commercial account of the material supplier. That fact did not answer the question of the actual beneficial owner of the contracting arrangement, but at least a lawful explanation for this part of the payment was now available.

In his notebook Shashank wrote: "On the first day, analogy gave the question; on the second day, the record gave one part of the answer."

At that moment the Chinese coordinator called him aside. Only the two of them were in a small glass-walled meeting space. The coordinator opened a letter on his phone and showed it to Shashank. The proposal, in English, was for language assistance at a regional vendor meeting: a two-day trip, location Macao. Travel, accommodation, and consultancy fee would be paid separately. The fee was far higher than for the small Noida contract.

For a moment Shashank's eyes remained fixed on the amount.

The coordinator said, "Our senior people are impressed by your language skills. They need someone who understands Mandarin, can catch some Cantonese sounds, and can also deal with Indian vendors."

At the word Macao, an old memory rose inside Shashank—limited access, authorised records, the edge of a forbidden section, and curiosity taking one step beyond his boundary. The memory made him ashamed, and it attracted him too. Human beings were strange: sometimes the threshold of the very error that frightened them gleamed again like proof of their own importance.

"What would the work involve?" Shashank asked.

"Interpreting at meetings, some records, and first looking through computer-based material. The trip is not final yet; legal and internal approvals are pending."

"What do you mean by computer-based material?"

"Temporary access to the company's document repository. Read-only. Technical lists, vendor names, meeting schedules. Sections unrelated to your work will not open."

The words "temporary access" remained in Shashank's ears for a long time. The temptation to call it "special access" rose immediately within him. The difference was only one adjective, yet that adjective could transform his self-image. Temporary access meant a requirement of work; special access meant prestige. Shashank understood that such a small alteration in words could later allow a person to tell a false story about his own role.

He asked, "Will I receive a written scope of work?"

"Yes. And a confidentiality agreement as well."

"The period of access and the material I am permitted to see should be stated clearly."

The coordinator looked at him. "Have you done this kind of work before?"

Two answers rose inside Shashank. One could make his experience shine—"Yes, I have seen such systems abroad." The other was limited and true—"I have worked as an interpreter with limited access to records." He chose the second.

"I have worked as an interpreter with limited access to records. But only as far as the written permission allowed."

As he said it, he remembered his earlier breach of boundary. The word "only" was not his complete autobiography; but in the context of this proposal, it was the correct rule. He was not concealing the old fact to protect himself—that fact was already in Aditya's record. The question here concerned the limits of the new work.

When the meeting ended, Shashank came outside. Mrinal asked, "What is new?"

Shashank showed him the letter. Mrinal read the amount, then the word Macao.

"Which word did your eyes read first?" Mrinal asked.

"The place."

"False."

Shashank laughed, but Mrinal's eyes remained steady.

"The amount," Shashank admitted.

"That is why I am your friend," Mrinal said, "so that you can rewrite your first answer."

Shashank looked at the letter again. "The amount is large."

"A large amount is not proof of a crime."

"I am not saying it is."

"But a large amount may be evidence of greed—at least inside yourself."

This time Shashank did not answer. Analogy rose again in his mind. His earlier Macao experience had included foreign travel, limited server access, special treatment, and the attraction of higher remuneration. This new proposal also included foreign travel, limited document access, and a higher fee. The structure resembled the earlier one. But the rule of analogy was clear: a similar structure does not establish a similar purpose.

He opened his notebook and made two columns. The first—"Similarities": foreign travel; temporary server access; selection because of language skill; a fee higher than ordinary work. The second—"Differences/Unknowns": the organiser's actual role; nature of the material; purpose of the meeting; actual limits of access; source of payment; legal review. As soon as he made the list, some of the excitement inside him became restrained.

"Does it say 'crime' anywhere?" Mrinal asked.

"No."

"Does it say 'safe' anywhere?"

"No."

"Then?"

"It says 'proposal.' The rest must be examined."

Mrinal nodded. "And greed?"

After a few moments Shashank said, "That is not in the document. It is inside me."

That evening a temporary credential arrived from the company's information-technology department. Access was for only seven days. Three sections appeared on the computer screen—meeting schedule, vendor list, and bilingual records. The name of a fourth section was visible, but he had no permission to open it. Shashank's finger remained still for a few moments. The old Shashank might have tried, out of curiosity, to open the restricted section, then counted even a failed attempt as part of his discovery. This time he neither captured an

image of the screen nor tried to open the restricted section. He wrote down only the names of the three authorised sections.

Even so, pride rose within him—he had access to a system that Mrinal, his classmates at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, and other guides at the Red Fort could not enter. This pride was another form of greed. Money can be counted; the intoxication of special access cannot be measured in numbers.

Juliana's sentence returned to him—language is not your property. Shashank added inwardly: access is not property either. Permission is the boundary of the work, not a crown of prestige.

After dinner that night he called Mrinal. "I got access."

"How much?"

"Seven days. Three sections."

"And the fourth?"

Shashank was startled. "Who told you there was a fourth?"

"Your silence." Mrinal laughed. "You paused for a moment after saying three sections."

Shashank laughed too. "The fourth is visible, but it does not open."

Mrinal said, "Know only that much."

"Only that much."

For a while both remained silent. Friendship was no longer surveillance; it was companionship that reminded him of the boundary.

On the following day the Noida contract was formally completed. The local contractor, the company assistant, and the Chinese coordinator signed the final inspection sheet. Written instructions stated that the remaining payment would go to the contracting party, while the cost of materials would go to the supplier according to the invoice. There was no second call from the anonymous number. The security department recorded only that the number details had been preserved according to available procedure; there was no established conclusion about the source.

Shashank now held two papers in his hands—the completed Noida contract and the proposal for a possible meeting in Macao. The first was evidence of his labour; the second was a mirror of his greed. Both contained signatures, payment, and roles, but their meanings were different.

He asked himself: would it be proper to reject this new proposal merely by analogy with his first foreign experience? No. Would it be proper to assume it was safe merely because of similarities? No again. Analogy is neither an order issued by fear nor permission granted by greed. Analogy says only: "I have seen something like this before; now examine the differences."

At the beginning of the following week, the draft confidentiality agreement arrived. A note below said: to be signed after review by India-based counsel. Shashank recognised the name—Raghav Bhasin.

He closed the computer screen. The story was not over; only the first Noida contract was complete. Its shadow now stretched towards foreign travel, limited server access, legal confidentiality, and a proposal carrying a higher fee.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: the prescribed work under the first Noida repair contract was completed; the material supplier's invoice matched the account name; there was no second call from the anonymous number; Shashank received a written proposal for language assistance at a possible Macao meeting; the company system gave him limited, read-only access for seven days; three authorised sections opened and the fourth did not; the confidentiality agreement was sent for review by India-based counsel.

The analogy went only this far: Shashank saw certain structural similarities between the new proposal and his earlier foreign experience—travel, limited server access, selection because of language skill, and comparatively higher remuneration. Those similarities did not establish the same purpose, the same people, or the same crime. Analogy gives a question, not a decision.

The inference went only this far: the proposal might be ordinary commercial language work; or it might later reveal relationships whose nature was presently unknown. The available documents did not establish either possibility.

The false allegation here would be to see the higher fee, the word Macao, or limited server access and immediately declare the proposal part of a criminal network; or to make claims about the contents of the fourth restricted section merely because that section existed. No such fact was established here.

The limit of established fact was this: the first Noida contract was completed; the supplier's role was recorded in writing in the payment papers; the proposal for the Macao meeting arrived; server access was limited and time-bound; Shashank did not attempt to open the unauthorised section; legal review of the confidentiality agreement remained pending.

The fact of greed went only this far: the higher fee attracted Shashank, but even more than the money he was attracted by the idea of special access, foreign travel, and becoming indispensable. That greed was not

evidence of crime; it was an inner truth of character. Mrinal taught him to name that truth; analogy showed him the resemblance to his old experience; Shashank's next test would be whether, seeing the similarity, he would preserve the boundary or again fall into the temptation of becoming the owner of meaning.

CHAPTER 29

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 3

The draft confidentiality agreement reached Shashank's inbox the next afternoon. At the top was the company's name, below it a reference to the proposed meeting in Macao, and at the end a note from the office of Raghav Bhasin, the India-based lawyer: "The role of the language assistant shall be limited to translation and authorised interpretation of records."

The first time Shashank read it, he felt relieved. The sentence was clear. The boundary was written down. Seven days of temporary access, three authorised sections, interpretation at the meeting, the meaning of records. Everything that had once stirred attraction inside him was now enclosed by a fence of words.

But on the second reading, one line stopped his eyes.

"Where necessary, coordination assistance may be provided between the parties."

"Coordination assistance"—two words. Their meaning was not small.

Shashank leaned back in his chair. In the first Noida contract, being a coordinator had been practical—time, workers, materials, translation. But in the Macao proposal, how far did "coordination assistance between the parties" extend? Only meeting schedules? Carrying papers? Questions about payment? The language of a legal response? Or everything that people later minimise by saying, "He was only in the middle"?

He opened his notebook. At the top he wrote: "Analogy."

The confidential legal meeting from earlier returned to him. There too, one sentence had mattered—the reference to old payment names. The fear then had been that confidentiality and selective silence might take each other's form. Today the situation was different, but the structure of the question was similar: when a language assistant hears something outside the role for which he was engaged, is he merely conveying words, or has he become part of the act itself?

Shashank stopped himself. Similarity is not a decision.

He wrote to Raghav Bhasin's office: "Please clarify the functional limits of 'coordination assistance.' Is it confined to time, place, transmission of records, and language facilitation? Does the phrase include representation concerning financial, tax-related, or party decisions?"

No quick reply came.

Mrinal came to see him in the evening. Shashank put the letter before him. Mrinal read it once and remained silent.

"What exactly are you afraid of?"

"That an ambiguous phrase will later acquire a much larger meaning."

"Is that fear useful or improper?"

Shashank thought for a moment. "If fear makes me ask questions, it is useful. If it stops me from asking questions, it is improper."

Mrinal smiled. "You have begun reciting your own lessons now."

Shashank did not laugh. "I will not sign until Raghav replies."

"The money is not making you hurry this time?"

"It is. That is why I am stopping."

At nine that night a message came from Raghav, asking him to come to the office the next morning.

Raghav's room was as orderly as before: a glass-topped table, two thick files, one closed cabinet. The moment Shashank entered, Raghav came directly to the point.

"Your question is valid," he said. "This line in the draft is too broad. I will have it narrowed."

Some tension left Shashank's shoulders. But Raghav opened the next file.

"There is another issue. The company wants you, during the meeting, to provide linguistic comments on statements made by certain Indian vendors and foreign representatives. Not merely translation—also which term most closely corresponds to which meaning in Indian contractual practice."

"That can be done, if it is written clearly that I am not giving legal conclusions."

"Good. But suppose a party asks you, 'Is this payment arrangement lawful?' Then what?"

"I will say that is outside my role. I can explain the words; I cannot determine legality."

Raghav nodded. "That is exactly the boundary we need."

There was a brief silence. Then Raghav said, “Understand one thing about confidentiality. Protecting genuine communications made for the purpose of legal advice, and using a lawyer’s name to carry out some potentially improper act, are not the same thing.”

An old fear stirred inside Shashank. “What if something is said in front of me whose meaning is not clear?”

“Then do not immediately give it the name of a crime. First ask: what exactly was said, what was the context, and what was your role? And if it appears to cross the limits of your work, ask for the limits in writing or stop the work.”

“And if I have already heard it?”

“There is no universal answer to that. Circumstances, legal duties, and court orders all matter. Do not treat confidentiality as an all-consuming shield, and do not treat it as a toy.”

The answer did not completely reassure Shashank. But it reassured him that the honest name for uncertainty could simply be uncertainty. Fear often drives a person to one of two extremes—to tell everything or to hide everything. Raghav was showing him a third path: identify the role, write the boundary, separate the questions.

Raghav dictated the revised line: “Coordination assistance shall be limited to meeting schedules, transmission of records, authorised language assistance, and pre-defined administrative arrangements; financial decisions, payment instructions, representation of ownership, and the giving of legal opinions shall not form part of this role.”

Shashank read the sentence again.

“Why ‘representation of ownership’?”

Raghav said, “Because you have previously worked on the distinction between beneficial ownership and representation. The company wants to ensure that language assistance is not treated as a commercial power of attorney.”

For a moment pride rose inside Shashank—his earlier caution was now becoming a sentence in a contract. At once he remembered Juliana’s warning: being useful and becoming the owner of truth were different things.

He said only, “This amendment is appropriate.”

As he stepped out of the office, his phone rang. Unknown number.

“Are you going to Macao?” an unfamiliar male voice asked.

Shashank stopped. “Who are you?”

“No need for a name. You completed the Noida work well. If cooperation continues, everything will remain simple.”

Shashank’s palm grew damp. He remembered the first anonymous call—the local work, the old ways, no unnecessary questions. The words were different; the structure felt similar.

Analogy activated at once.

But so did its first rule: a similar tone, similar suggestion, and another unknown number do not establish the same person.

Shashank said, “Send your identity and the subject in writing.”

The call ended.

This time he preserved the call details and informed not Mrinal first, but Aditya. Aditya asked only three questions: the time? the exact words? any demand?

Shashank repeated only as much as he remembered. Aditya made no comment on what “everything will remain simple” might mean.

“Does it resemble the earlier call?” Shashank himself asked.

Aditya replied, “Yes. But similarity does not establish the source. The number is different. Is your identification of the voice an inference or a certainty?”

“Not certain. The cadence sounded somewhat similar.”

“Then write: ‘The cadence sounded similar.’ Not: ‘the same person.’”

In that small correction Shashank again saw the severe mercy of Navya-Nyaya. Fear said: the same people have returned. Method said: your experience matters, but write its limit as well.

Aditya asked, “Did the caller admit any crime?”

“No.”

“An explicit threat?”

Shashank paused. “Not directly. He said, ‘Everything will remain simple.’”

“Then the fear may be real; but the legal meaning of the statement cannot be fixed without examination. Keep the fact of the call separate from its effect on you.”

Shashank wrote in his notebook: “Fear is not evidence either; but a statement that causes fear may itself be a matter for examination.”

That afternoon Raghav's revised confidentiality agreement arrived. The company assistant had added a short note: "Where necessary for language facilitation, Mr Jha may convey messages between the parties."

Shashank stopped again. "May convey messages" sounded ordinary. But whose messages? What kind? Oral? Written? Related to payment or authority?

He called Raghav.

Raghav said, "There is nothing wrong with being a messenger if the message is authorised, recorded, and within your role. The problem begins when 'convey it' slowly turns into 'change it,' 'say it secretly,' or 'say it in your own name.'"

Shashank's attention caught on "say it secretly." Moments from his old life in which he had altered words rose again. He had not invented whole sentences, but he had softened language so that fewer questions would be asked. The same boundary stood before him again.

He said, "I will convey only written messages, or authorised messages stated in everyone's presence. No private oral instructions."

"Add that boundary to the agreement," Raghav said.

Shashank asked, "Is this conversation with you about the matter confidential?"

Raghav was silent for a few moments. "You are asking in order to understand the limits of legal advice; but the precise form of any formal client relationship between you and me will be determined by a written engagement. Before assuming confidentiality, make the nature of the relationship clear. Seeing the word 'lawyer' and assuming that every communication has identical protection would itself be an error of analogy."

The answer jolted Shashank. Because Raghav was a lawyer, he had been using the analogy of the earlier meeting to place the same covering over this conversation. But the same person did not establish the same relationship.

This time analogy showed him not merely an external danger, but an error in his own thinking.

That evening he went to the Tao temple in Pitampura. Juliana was sitting on the small veranda outside the prayer room. Shashank did not tell her the full legal details; he asked only, "If fear makes a person enlarge the meaning of words, what is the cure?"

Juliana said, "First, do not insult fear. Fear is information from the body. Then ask: is the information about something outside you, or about your own memory?"

"It can be both."

"Then give each one a different name."

In his mind Shashank repeated the anonymous caller's words: "Everything will remain simple." Fear had risen from that sentence. One part of the fear came from the present voice; another came from memories of the earlier Noida call, his old breach of boundary in Macao, and his greed for the coming trip.

Juliana said, "One difficult lesson in language is this: the same word can reopen an old wound. The pain of the wound is real; but it is not the only meaning of the word."

That night, before signing the revised confidentiality agreement, Shashank wrote down four limits of his own: first, translation and interpretation of records; second, administrative coordination only within the written scope of work; third, no representation in financial or legal decisions; fourth, if he received ambiguous or private oral instructions, no action without written confirmation.

He showed the list to Mrinal.

Mrinal read it and asked, "Where is friendship in these four?"

Shashank smiled. "If I forget the boundary, remind me."

"And if you are afraid?"

"First I will name it—fear. Then I will write the facts."

Mrinal placed a hand on his shoulder. "That is enough friendship."

At last Shashank signed. The fear inside him had not ended. The source of the anonymous call was unknown. The Macao trip still awaited final approval. Raghav's legal role was limited. About the company's purpose, only what the papers showed was known. But earlier fear had either made him silent or made him build imaginary walls of safety inside words. Now he could write boundaries even while afraid.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: in the initial draft of the confidentiality agreement, the phrase "coordination assistance" was broad; after Raghav's review, its functional limits were narrowed and written down; Shashank received an anonymous call in which the phrase "everything will remain simple" was used; there was no explicit confession of crime or direct threat; Shashank gave the call details to Aditya; in the revised agreement, financial decisions, representation of ownership, and legal opinions were expressly placed outside his role.

The analogy went only this far: there were some structural similarities among the earlier legal-confidentiality situation, the earlier anonymous call, and the events of today. Similarity raises questions; it does

not establish the same client relationship, the same caller, the same purpose, or the same crime. Raghav was indeed the lawyer Shashank had met before, but the legal character of this conversation could not automatically be assumed to be identical to that of the earlier one.

The inference went only this far: the anonymous call might have been an attempt at pressure; or someone might simply have used ambiguous language to display influence. The available facts did not establish either possibility. The initial ambiguity of “coordination assistance” could have increased future risk, but an ambiguous clause was not by itself evidence of participation in crime.

The false allegation here would be to see a lawyer’s review and conclude that the entire arrangement was concealing crime; or to see the word confidentiality and treat silence contrary to duty as established; or to infer from the similar style of two anonymous calls that the same person or group made both. No such fact was established in this episode.

The limit of established fact was this: Shashank asked for written limits on his role; Raghav amended the ambiguous clause; a limit was added that private oral instructions would not be acted upon without written confirmation; details of the anonymous call were provided for examination; the Macao trip remained at the proposal and approval stage.

The fact of fear went only this far: earlier Shashank had been afraid of people outside himself; in this episode he also understood that fear can compel a person to turn confidentiality, friendship, law, and analogy alike into stories of self-protection. The fear did not disappear; but he named it, wrote it separately from the facts, and found the courage to limit his own role.

The next day a copy of an internal government note reached Aditya’s desk. It referred to an oral indication that the file’s priority should be reduced, but again there was no written order. A new shadow began there.

CHAPTER 30

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 4

The next morning, the internal note lying on Aditya's desk bore the file number in bold at the top and two lines of instruction beneath it: "No direct revenue link has been established in the material presently available. The priority of the matter may be reconsidered."

Aditya read the paper once, then opened the original note from the lower office attached to it. The original note said: "Verification of the relationship between vendor payments and actual beneficial ownership remains incomplete; additional records are required."

The two sentences looked close to one another. Neither used the language of a definite conclusion. But they did not mean the same thing.

"Verification incomplete" meant: the work remained unfinished. "No relationship established" could easily be read as: no relationship had been found.

Aditya did not ring the bell or make a call. First he separated copies of both papers, recorded the time of receipt, and entered a note in the file movement register: "Semantic difference between upper summary and original office note; source and editing sequence to be verified."

Shashank was called in after noon.

When he arrived, Aditya did not hand him the papers immediately. He first asked, "If an original sentence says, 'Identity has not yet been established,' and the summary says, 'No identity,' would you treat them as the same statement?"

Shashank stopped his old habit of answering before thinking. "No. The first sentence describes the state of the evidence. The second can be read as a statement about whether the thing exists at all."

"And if the person preparing the summary says he merely shortened it?"

"Then we first examine whether the shortening changed the meaning. Purpose comes later."

Only then did Aditya slide the paper towards him.

Shashank fell silent as he read. He remembered one of his own old lessons: justice can live between 'not' and 'not established.' Now that distinction stood before him on two pages of a government file.

"Who wrote the original note?"

"The investigating team at the lower commissionerate. A joint note by three officers."

"And the upper summary?"

"At present the digital file contains only the author identifier. The editing history has been requested."

Shashank asked, "Do you think the meaning was changed deliberately?"

Aditya answered at once: "What I think is not evidence yet."

Shashank remained silent.

Aditya continued, "This file concerns the same Noida vendor chain in which you provided translation assistance. So your role is limited to comparing the words. Do not comment on which officer wrote what with what intention."

"Understood."

"And one more thing. One of your earlier translation notes is quoted in this file as well."

Shashank's body tightened slightly.

Aditya opened a third page. Shashank's original note said: "The expression used in the original Chinese text indicates actual control, but to establish beneficial ownership in the Indian legal sense, separate records of ownership, control, and benefit are required."

In the upper summary, that sentence had been compressed to: "Translator found indications of beneficial ownership."

Shashank's mouth went dry.

"That is not what I wrote."

"Correct," Aditya said. "You did write the word 'indication,' but you also wrote the limitation. The summary has dropped the limitation."

"Then this distorts my statement."

"You may call it a distortion of meaning. But do not yet say that someone did it deliberately."

Anger rose inside Shashank. How many times had he himself softened words to reduce questions? How many times had he been warned that a translator's small addition or omission could change an entire relationship? Today the limiting clause had been cut away from his own careful sentence.

It did not feel to him like a mere professional error. It felt like betrayal.

"Whoever quoted my name should have read the whole sentence."

Aditya looked at him. "Name the feeling correctly. Are you angry?"

"Yes."

"Humiliated?"

"A little."

"Betrayed?"

Shashank paused before answering. "I feel that my caution has been used against me."

"That is your experience. The investigative questions now are different: who had access to the complete sentence, who prepared the summary, when the limiting clause disappeared during editing, and who approved it?"

Shashank said quietly, "Meaning the feeling of betrayal can be real, while the identity of the betrayer remains a separate question."

"Exactly."

After noon, two officers from the lower commissionerate came into Aditya's room: a senior inspector and a records officer. Both looked tired. The inspector opened the file and said, "Our original note was clear. Yesterday evening an oral indication came that this matter would be taken up by the higher unit, so its priority here should be reduced."

Aditya asked, "Written transfer?"

"No."

"File number?"

"No."

"Whose call?"

The inspector gave a designation, not a person's name. "From senior level in the office."

"Do you remember the exact words?"

The inspector thought. "We were told: 'Do not take this forward for now; it is being consolidated above.'"

Aditya looked towards the records officer. "Did you hear that?"

"I was in the room. Not the entire conversation. I heard the final line."

Aditya wrote: direct hearing by one officer; partial hearing by the second. No written order.

The inspector grew impatient. "Sir, we all understand what is happening."

Aditya stopped his pen. "What is happening?"

"The file is being suppressed."

Silence spread through the room.

Aditya said, "That is a possibility. But what I have at present is this: an oral instruction concerning priority, no written transfer, and a summary different from the original note. 'The file is being suppressed' is a conclusion. We need further evidence to establish it."

The inspector's face remained hard. "Then what should we do?"

"Do not stop work within your lawful authority. Continue to issue proper requests for the records you require. If a written instruction arrives directing you to stop, the question of compliance will be separate. Do not alter the original note because of an ambiguous oral message."

"That will be treated as resistance."

"Not resistance. Record discipline."

Shashank was only a witness to the exchange. Aditya's method reminded him of an old lesson from Mithila—upamā, analogy. Two situations looked similar: the earlier ambiguity around an 'instruction from above,' and now another oral instruction about priority. But resemblance was not evidence. What had happened before did not establish the source of what was happening today. Still, the earlier experience gave one valid question: where was the written basis?

When the meeting ended, Aditya asked Shashank to stay.

"I need the complete original of your earlier translation. Not merely the quotation."

"I have it. It is preserved in my archive."

"Original date, sender, recipient, and every version if there were revisions."

For a moment an old fear rose inside Shashank. His archive contained papers that showed both his professional boundaries and his earlier mistakes. But the courtroom had taught him one thing: an incomplete truth does not protect you.

"I will provide the complete set."

When he reached home that evening, Mrinal was already waiting. Shashank told him the outline of what had happened.

Mrinal asked, "What hurt you most?"

"My sentence was quoted only halfway."

"Why did that hurt?"

"Because I had written the boundary."

"And you think someone deliberately removed it?"

Shashank was silent.

Mrinal asked again, "Have you ever done anything like that before?"

The question was direct. Something inside Shashank contracted.

"I have softened language to reduce questions. I would not say that I deliberately cut a complete sentence to create another meaning. But sometimes the result moved in that direction."

"Then today's pain is not only about what someone else did. It is also showing you your old face."

Shashank looked at Mrinal. "Must friendship be this harsh?"

"If you want gentle lies, you can find plenty of other people."

For the first time Shashank laughed faintly, though the laughter did not last.

That night he opened his old archive: contracts, emails, translation notes, meeting summaries. Looking at the names of the files one after another, he understood that institutional memory too can be selective like human memory—the sentence that rises to the top becomes history; the boundary that gets cut away becomes the seed of suspicion.

He found a third version of one record. After his original translation, a company assistant had written: "Short version for the Indian side." In the short version, the same limiting clause was again absent.

Shashank's heart began to beat hard. But he stopped himself.

The record established only this much: an abbreviated version had earlier been created at the level of a company assistant. Whether that document became the source of the government summary, or whether an independent summary later made the same omission, was not yet clear.

He sent the record to Aditya and wrote: "Found this earlier abbreviated version. It has linguistic similarity with the government summary; identity of source is not established."

A few minutes later the reply came: "Received. Preserve the original."

Shashank put down the phone. Upamā stood before him again. The same kind of omission in two sentences; two different times; two different institutions. The mind immediately built a story: the words travelled from here to there. But method said: resemblance points towards a route; it does not establish the journey.

The next day he happened to meet his old teacher from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. The teacher looked at his face and asked, "Have you been carrying the weight of words for too many days?"

Shashank smiled. "Sometimes the words carry me."

The teacher asked, "What is the hardest thing in translation?"

Like his old student self, Shashank answered, "The meaning of words."

"No," the teacher said. "The boundary of words. People enlarge meanings easily; preserving the boundary is difficult."

Shashank remembered his half-quoted sentence.

He asked, "What if someone cuts away the boundary?"

"Then put the whole sentence before them again. Do not add a new meaning out of anger."

That brief answer gave direction to his day.

After noon a message came from Aditya's office: the lower commissionerate had continued its original list of investigative requests unchanged. There was no confrontational letter, no accusation. Only one written line: "All previous requests shall remain effective until a contrary written direction is received from the competent authority."

Shashank read the sentence and remained silent for a long time. Institutional resistance is not always a declaration; sometimes it is only a clear sentence placed in a file.

But that evening something new happened.

A news reporter telephoned Shashank and asked, "Would you like to respond? I have a reference to sealed government material in which your name appears as the 'principal linguistic coordinator' of a payment route."

A chill ran through Shashank's body.

"Do you have the original material?"

"I cannot disclose my source."

"Is 'principal linguistic coordinator' the exact wording?"

"That is what the record says."

"Please read the full sentence."

There was silence for several moments at the other end.

"Not now."

"Then I will not respond to an incomplete quotation."

The call ended.

Shashank did not inform Aditya immediately. First he sat for a few moments with the phone in his palm. Again he felt betrayed—how had his name travelled to the media from papers whose access ought to have been limited?

Then he opened his notebook.

"Feeling: betrayal.

Direct fact: the reporter referred to sealed material; did not read the full sentence; did not disclose the source.

Inference: the material, or a summary of it, may have gone outside.

Established fact: not yet."

Only then did he call Aditya.

After hearing everything, Aditya said only, "Write the exact words and send them. And do not argue with the media."

Shashank asked, "Does this establish an internal collusion?"

"No. It establishes a new question for investigation."

After the call, Shashank stood by the window. The first Noida contract had taught him about money, fear, friendship, and the desire for special access. Now the shadow of that contract was stretching into government files, truncated quotations, and questions from the press.

Analogy showed him resemblance; justice restrained him—do not turn resemblance into source, source into intention, or intention into crime.

The pain of betrayal was real. But pain cannot itself write the name of the accused.

Direct knowledge amounted only to this: the original note from the lower commissionerate said verification remained incomplete; the upper summary said "no relationship established"; Shashank's original translation referred to an indication of beneficial ownership together with an explicit limitation, while the abbreviated quotation omitted the limitation; there was an oral indication that priority should be reduced, but no written transfer or stop order was available; the lower office continued its earlier written requests for records; a reporter sought Shashank's response while referring to sealed material.

The analogy went only this far: the earlier oral 'instruction from above' and today's priority indication had a similar structure; the company's older abbreviated translation and the government summary showed a similar removal of the limiting clause. But those similarities did not establish the same source, the same person, or planned collusion. Similarity gives direction to an inquiry, not a conclusion.

The inference went only this far: the file's priority may have been deliberately reduced; or an administrative process of consolidation by a higher unit may have been communicated unclearly. The government summary may have been influenced by the company's older short version; or both may independently have lost the same limitation while being condensed. The reporter's information may have come from an internal leak; the source remained unknown.

The false allegation here would be to hear of the oral instruction and immediately declare senior officers corrupt; to see the limiting clause disappear from the summary and treat collusion between the government unit and the company as established; or to infer from the reporter's call that the original sealed record had been stolen. The available facts established none of those conclusions.

The limit of established fact was this: the language of the original and the summary differed; no written stop order was found; the lower office continued its documentary process; Shashank's complete sentence was presented incompletely in the abbreviated form; and a person from the media referred to sealed material without showing the source or the full sentence.

The feeling of betrayal went only this far: Shashank was hurt to see his caution cut away; the officers felt institutional trust falter because of oral ambiguity; and Mrinal reminded Shashank that his own former linguistic conveniences were also a mirror of this pain. Betrayal was present as an experience; the person responsible had not yet been established.

At the end of the night, as Shashank closed the notebook, he wrote only one line: “Put the whole sentence before them again.”

The next morning, his name really did appear on the news page.

CHAPTER 31

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 5

The next morning, Shashank's name was not merely printed on the news page; a whole story had been built around it. The headline carried a question mark, yet the words were arranged so that an answer rose in the reader's mind before the question had even been considered: "A Linguistic Link in a Foreign Payment Network?" Beneath it, his old Noida contract, the Macao proposal, limited server access, and the government investigation were joined together in a single paragraph.

The first time, Shashank could not read the entire article. His eyes kept returning to one line: "In sealed government material, Jha is described as the 'principal linguistic coordinator.'"

He remembered the reporter's call from the previous day. When Shashank had asked him to read the whole sentence, the reporter had fallen silent. Today the incomplete words were public.

His phone began ringing. The first call was from an old classmate. The second from an acquaintance in Noida. The third from an unknown number. Shashank answered none of them. For a few moments he felt that silence itself was protection. Then he remembered that earlier day of humiliation, when his first impulse too had been to call every allegation "false" at once. Later he had understood that a news report could contain true facts, defective presentation, and unproved conclusions in the same place.

He opened the article again. On a sheet of paper he wrote three headings: "What is written," "What I know," "What is not established."

In the first list he wrote: his name, the Noida contract, the Macao proposal, language assistance, reference to sealed material. In the second: the Noida work was real; the Macao trip was still only a proposal moving through an approval process; server access was limited and time-bound; financial decisions lay outside his written role. In the third: the source of the report; the full context of "principal linguistic coordinator"; any authority he had over the operation of a payment network; whether the original sealed material had in fact reached the reporter.

A message from Mrinal arrived: "I read the article. Do not write anything yet. I am coming."

Anger rose inside Shashank. The sentence felt like an order. At once he began typing a response: "The report is entirely false."

His finger reached the send icon and stopped.

"Entirely?" he asked himself.

His name was true. The Noida contract was true. The Macao proposal was true. Limited access was true. The question was whether the conclusion created by joining those truths together had been established.

He deleted the sentence.

When Mrinal arrived, Shashank put the phone before him. "Look. What should I write?"

Mrinal first read the report, then the half-written response. "You feel humiliated?"

"Is that even a question?"

"It is. Because in humiliation a person often makes the size of his rebuttal equal to the size of the accusation."

Shashank remained silent.

Mrinal read the three lists on the paper. "The answer is here. Do not deny what is true. Do not allow what is unproved to be called proved."

"People read headlines, not explanations."

"Then your job is not to imitate their impatience."

The sentence hurt, but Shashank understood that friendship had again appeared before him in its hard form: consolation that refused to break the boundary of truth.

At noon he was called to Aditya's office. A printed copy of the report lay on the desk. Aditya had underlined five sentences in red, but beside none had he written "false" or "true." There were only numbers: one, two, three, four, five.

"First," Aditya said, "your name. True."

"Second - language assistance in Noida. True."

"Third - the Macao proposal. The record exists, but the trip has not yet occurred."

"Fourth - 'principal linguistic coordinator.' The source of those words must be verified."

"Fifth - operation of a payment network. The report shows no support for that conclusion."

Shashank asked, "Do those words appear in the sealed statement?"

Before answering, Aditya opened the file. "A similar phrase appears in the translation summary of one sealed statement. But that does not establish the source of the news report."

"Why not?"

Aditya slid another paper towards him. It was a copy of an old company email dated before the investigation began. In that email too, Shashank had been introduced with words close in meaning to "principal linguistic coordinator."

For a moment Shashank's anger lost its direction. "Then the reporter falsely claimed it came from sealed material?"

"That conclusion is not established either." Aditya's voice remained steady. "He may have some part of the sealed material; he may have the old email; he may have heard a summary from another person. Similar wording does not establish identity of source."

Shashank leaned back in the chair. Upamana - analogy - stood before him again: one phrase, two records, two moments in time. Similarity gave direction; it did not give identity.

Aditya said, "I am separately checking the access list for the sealed record: who saw the file and when, which copies were lawfully made, which judicial parties had access - each is a separate question. The fact that a report was published does not justify selecting one person as the source of the leak."

Shashank asked, "And my reputation?"

For the first time Aditya looked up from the file. "An investigation is not a machine for restoring reputation. It is a method for defining the limits of fact."

The answer was harsh. Resistance rose inside Shashank: for the person whose name had been printed, mere boundaries were not enough. But he knew Aditya's work was not to avenge his humiliation.

"Can I issue a public response?"

"For facts supported by your own experience and non-confidential records, take advice from your lawyer. I will say nothing about the alleged contents of sealed material."

He spoke briefly with Raghav Bhasin by phone. After hearing Shashank's draft, Raghav said, "Write three things. The limits of your Noida work. The Macao trip is still only a proposal. Financial decisions were not your role. Do not speculate about sealed material."

"And the allegation in the article?"

"Answer the specific sentence. If you dismiss the whole article with one word, even the true facts in it can be used against you."

The advice felt insultingly restrained to Shashank. His mind wanted one sharp sentence that would silence every voice. But Navya-Nyaya did not ask for a sharp sentence; it asked for a bounded one.

He wrote a public statement: "I performed a limited role in language assistance and administrative coordination in a repair job in Noida. The proposed Macao trip has not yet taken place. No payment decision, determination of beneficial ownership, or financial instruction formed part of my written role. I will not comment on the alleged contents of sealed material. Any conclusion not supported by the available record requires independent verification."

Mrinal read it and said, "There is no anger in this."

"There is."

"It does not show."

"Not every truth has to be shown."

"Yes," Mrinal said, "but not every truth should be hidden either."

They looked at each other for a few moments. Shashank understood: Mrinal was not commenting on his public language; he was commenting on his old tendency.

The next day, when Shashank went to Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, two students in the corridor fell silent as soon as they saw him. After class, his old teacher stopped him. "I read the news."

Shashank's face grew hot. "Everyone read it."

"What did you learn?"

For a moment he was irritated. "Can humiliation be a lesson too?"

The teacher said, "If words caused the humiliation, you must examine the boundary of the words again."

"The headline used a question mark and still delivered a conclusion."

"Then compare a question mark with a conclusion. They may look close, but they are not the same."

Shashank's mind became a little calmer. The teacher wrote two sentences on the blackboard: "He was near the scene." "He committed the act."

"What is needed to move from the first to the second?"

"Additional evidence."

"That is all."

There was the first ease of the day in that brief smile.

In the evening he met Juliana at the Tao temple in Pitampura. Shashank did not give her the full details of the report; he said only, "When people attach a meaning to your name that you do not accept as your own, the humiliation inside is very great."

Juliana asked, "Is your name your property?"

Shashank was startled. "At least my name is mine."

"The name is yours. But the meaning people make when they hear it is not entirely under your control. You can control your conduct, your sentences, your boundaries."

"Then should I simply accept the humiliation?"

"Do not accept it. Correct it. But do not let humiliation make you distort language in the same way you say your opponent has distorted it."

Shashank thought about the sentence for a long time. He remembered the earlier controversy. That time there had been humiliation through news; today there was humiliation through news again. The analogy came easily: "The same thing again." But it was not the same thing. The disputed material then had been different; today there was a claim about a sealed source, a similar phrase in an old email, and a new shadow cast by the Noida contract. Similar emotion did not make the circumstances identical.

At nine that night the local contractor in Noida called. "The next small job has been put on hold for now. The company is conducting an internal review."

Shashank's chest tightened again. "Is there any written allegation against me?"

"Not that I have. Only a review."

After the call, humiliation acquired an economic shape for the first time. The report was no longer only on paper; its shadow could fall on whether he received future work, whether people shook his hand or kept their distance.

Mrinal said, "A paused job does not mean guilt has been established."

Shashank replied bitterly, "That sentence is easy to say when it is not your work that has been stopped."

Mrinal fell silent. Instead of getting up and leaving a few moments later, he remained seated.

"You are right," he said. "The pain is yours. I will not make it smaller. But I will not call every conclusion the pain wants a fact."

Shashank's eyes filled, but he turned his face away. Friendship here was not consolation but presence - the kind of presence that acknowledged the truth of humiliation without declaring every story born from humiliation to be true.

Late at night a message came from Aditya: "Inquiry into the source of the phrase used in the report is continuing. An application concerning confidentiality of the sealed material and the published claim is listed before the court tomorrow."

Shashank read the message and sat still. Court. Questions again. Words again. Again the danger that half of one sentence might become the meaning of an entire person.

He opened his notebook.

"Direct facts: the report was published; my name and the phrase 'principal linguistic coordinator' appeared in it; the Noida work, Macao proposal, and limited access are separate real facts; a similar phrase appears in an old company email; a closely related phrase also appears in a sealed translation summary in the investigation; the next Noida job has been paused pending internal review."

"Analogy: the earlier media humiliation and today's media humiliation are emotionally similar; the wording in the old email and sealed summary is similar; but similar humiliation is not the same source, similar wording is not the same record, and a similar role is not financial authority."

"Inference: the reporter may have seen sealed material; or may have taken the phrase from the old email, an oral summary, or another record. The next job may have been paused because of the report; or because of an independent internal review by the company. The reason has not yet been established in writing."

"False allegation: declaring me the operator of a payment network; identifying a particular officer or party as the source of sealed material merely because the same phrase appears elsewhere; treating an internal review as proof of guilt - all would go beyond the available evidence."

"Limit of established fact: my limited Noida role is recorded; the Macao trip has not yet occurred; financial decisions lay outside my written role; a similar phrase exists in more than one source; the actual source of the news report has not been established; an application concerning confidentiality is listed before the court."

At the end he wrote: "Humiliation is not evidence. A rebuttal too must remain within the limits of evidence."

As he closed the notebook, he understood that the hardest lesson of analogy was not seeing resemblance but resisting its seduction. Humiliation tempts a person to give every old wound the face of the same enemy. Justice says: look at each face separately.

The next morning, the court corridor was waiting for him again.

CHAPTER 32

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 6

In the court corridor that day, Shashank felt for the first time that the sound of humiliation echoed less outside than within. The previous day's news page, the next Noida job that had been put on hold, the phrase "principal linguistic coordinator," and the discussion of sealed material were all joining themselves together in his mind. But he remembered the last line in his notebook: humiliation is not evidence.

Raghav Bhasin arrived at that moment. He carried a thin file. "Today the court will look at two things," he said. "How far the confidentiality of the sealed material is to be protected, and to what extent questions can be asked about the source of the published phrase. You will testify, but do not go beyond the limits of your role."

Shashank asked, "What if they question me at length about language?"

"Answer only what is asked. This is not a day to display scholarship."

The sentence caused a small sting inside Shashank. Language was his strength; being advised to restrain that strength in court was difficult for him. But now he understood that when talent crosses the boundary of an answer, it ceases to be evidence and can become dominion through interpretation.

The courtroom was full, but there was no theatrical noise in the atmosphere. At the outset the judge made it clear that the purpose of the hearing was not to determine the complete truth of the news report or the criminal guilt of any person. The questions were limited: the protection of sealed records, the possible source of the published claim, and the reliability of the material presented in that connection.

Shashank was called to the witness stand.

Opposing counsel showed him the first paper. "This is an old company email?"

"Yes."

"And the Chinese phrase introducing you in it—you translated that as 'principal linguistic coordinator'?"

Shashank examined the paper carefully. "My old note is on this copy. Yes, I wrote that meaning."

The second paper was an authorised extract from the sealed record. "And this translation summary also says 'principal linguistic coordinator'?"

"Yes."

Counsel turned towards the court. "The same person. The same translated phrase. The same kind of company context. Is it not a reasonable analogy that both records came from the same internal source?"

Raghav rose. "Analogy cannot take the place of a conclusion."

The judge said, "The witness may state the linguistic facts. The court will consider the conclusion."

Counsel turned back to Shashank. "Are the two original Chinese phrases identical?"

For a moment the old pride stirred inside Shashank. He wanted to deliver a complete linguistic lecture. Then he remembered Raghav's sentence: answer only what is asked.

"No," he said. "The original phrases are not identical."

A light rustle passed through the courtroom.

"Then why is the translation the same?"

"Because at that time I regarded the functional meanings of the two expressions as close."

"Close? Not identical?"

"Close."

"Explain the distinction to the court."

Shashank indicated the first paper. "The phrase in the old email meant something like the primary point of contact for language-related coordination. The original phrase in the second record mainly conveys responsibility for language contact. The roles resemble each other, but the original words are not the same."

Counsel asked immediately, "But as translator, you gave both the same phrase?"

"Yes."

"Then if a reader sees the same phrase in a news report and understands the role to be the same, is the reader at fault?"

The question drove into Shashank's chest. There was an easy defence available: the translation depended on context, the newspaper's conclusion was separate. But another answer rose from within, one he had been avoiding for a long time.

"Not only the reader," he said.

Raghav looked towards him.

Counsel paused. "Explain."

"In some of my older translations, for convenience, I compressed different original phrases with close meanings into the same Indian functional phrase. At the time it seemed practical to me. I now understand that in an investigative or judicial context, such compression can erase distinctions."

"Meaning your translations were defective?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments. "Not everywhere. But where the difference between the original expressions could matter for later questions, giving them uniform wording was improper."

Counsel smiled. "You are saying this now, when those translations are being used against you—now you have discovered the limits of your own translation?"

The old heat of humiliation rose again. Shashank's first impulse was to answer sharply. But atonement did not mean making the size of one's own fault smaller.

"No," he said. "I am also saying that the responsibility for that uniformity is mine. But that responsibility does not establish that the two original sources were one and the same."

The judge made a note.

Counsel lifted a third paper. It was the language-assistance list from the Noida repair contract. "You used the word 'coordination' here as well?"

"Yes."

"And in the Macao proposal?"

"Yes, but the roles were different."

"Again, the same word."

"The same word does not create the same authority."

"Is this your Navya-Nyaya?"

"It is the distinction in the records."

Counsel did not laugh. "What does upamā—analogy—mean?"

Shashank answered, "It helps us understand an unfamiliar thing through resemblance to something known. But resemblance does not establish identity."

"So even if the court sees the same word, the same person, the same company context, and the same foreign connection, it should not infer the same source?"

"Whether it should or should not is for the court to decide. I can only say that beyond these similarities, the source chain is needed."

"What additional material?"

"The creation history of the original record, transmission path, access record, timing, and verification of the author or sender—whatever is available."

For a moment satisfaction appeared in Raghav's eyes, but as soon as Shashank noticed it he restrained the pride rising within him. Giving the right answer in court was not a victory; it was only giving the right answer.

The cross-examination sharpened again. "You admit that in the past you tried to soften language so that fewer questions would be raised?"

"Yes. In some contexts."

"You admit that in some translations you made the subject explicit where the original sentence was ambiguous?"

"Yes. Later I came to regard that practice as improper."

"You had limited server access?"

"Yes."

"Your name appears in certain messages concerning payments?"

"It appears in the role of language assistance or contact. Authority to decide payments is a separate question."

"You provided language assistance concerning determination of beneficial ownership?"

"I explained the meaning of terms. I did not determine ownership."

Counsel's voice became slightly harder. "Is it not possible that every time you describe your own role in smaller words, even though you repeatedly appear in the records?"

An answer was already prepared inside Shashank: presence is not participation; participation is not crime. But he stopped. The question was about his character, not only language.

"It is possible that at times I tried to make my role appear smaller," he said. "Because of fear, reputation, and self-protection. But in court I will not minimise what is recorded. Nor will I add as my guilt what is not recorded."

The courtroom fell silent again.

As he spoke, Shashank felt a strange lightness inside. Atonement was not merely asking forgiveness; nor was it surrendering the right to defend oneself. Guilt only as far as guilt. Innocence only as far as innocence.

Counsel asked the final question. "The phrase 'principal linguistic coordinator' published in the news came from the sealed material—do you deny that?"

"I cannot deny it. Nor can I say it is established. A similar phrase exists in more than one record."

"Meaning you do not know?"

"Yes. Not yet."

That "not yet" was no longer a failure for Shashank. Once he had wanted an answer to every ambiguous question. Today naming uncertainty felt harder, but more truthful.

Aditya was then called for limited questioning. He made no dramatic claim. He only described the status of the access records—how many authorised persons could see the sealed material, which copies had been created under judicial orders, and which digital entries still awaited verification.

Opposing counsel asked, "Do two sources containing a similar phrase not strike you as suspicious?"

Aditya said, "Suspicion may be sufficient to begin an inquiry. It is not sufficient for a conclusion."

"Do you use analogy?"

"I do. An old pattern gives questions for new material. It does not give answers."

"If the same person appears in both events?"

"Then the person is the same. The events do not automatically become the same."

The judge wrote something at that answer. Shashank suddenly remembered the blackboard at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan: "He was near the scene" and "He committed the act." Justice lived in the distance between the first and the second.

Raghav's re-examination contained only two questions. "For the two different Chinese expressions that you rendered with the same Indian phrase, are the original copies available?"

"Yes."

"Can an independent expert compare the originals?"

"Yes."

Raghav sat down. He did not make a long speech to rescue Shashank. Shashank noticed this carefully. Earlier he had thought defence meant bending every ambiguity towards one's own side. Today it seemed to him that a good defence sometimes meant allowing the original material to speak more loudly than oneself.

After noon the court pronounced an interim direction. Protection of the sealed material would continue. No definite conclusion about the source of the published phrase would be drawn at this stage. The investigating side was directed to preserve the original digital sources, access records, and all translation versions. If necessary, the material could be placed before an independent language expert for comparison.

The judge also observed: "The same translated phrase does not establish identity of original source, particularly where the witness himself accepts that different original expressions were at times compressed into the same functional phrase. That admission, however, does not end the questions concerning the translator's responsibility."

Shashank lowered his head on hearing the sentence. Two feelings rose together inside him—relief and shame. The court had not declared him innocent; nor had it declared him guilty. It had only erected boundaries. Strangely, within those boundaries he could see the shape of his own atonement.

As he stepped outside, reporters again tried to surround him. "Has the court accepted that the news report was false?"

Shashank stopped. Earlier he would have chosen the answer most favourable to his side. Today he said, "No. The court made no such finding."

Another question came: "Then are the allegations against you correct?"

"The court did not say that either."

"Then what happened?"

"The inquiry into the source and the limits of the evidence will continue."

Having said only that much, he moved on.

Mrinal was waiting at the turn in the corridor. "Was today difficult?"

"Yes."

"The hardest question?"

Shashank thought for a moment. "Why I erased distinctions in my own translations."

"Did you find an answer?"

"Convenience. Pride. Sometimes the desire to give a client a simple answer. Sometimes the desire to reduce questions."

Mrinal said softly, "And atonement?"

Shashank replied, "To show the distinctions again. Especially the distinctions I myself erased."

That evening he did not go to the Tao temple in Pitampura. He sent Juliana a short message: "Today I told the court that giving different original expressions the same translation was my error."

Her reply came: "Admitting an error is not the defeat of words. It is returning their boundary to them."

That night Shashank opened his old translation archive. He identified five phrases where, for convenience, he had used the same Hindi or English functional term for different original expressions. This time he deleted nothing. Beside each one he wrote the original meaning, context, possible alternatives, and uncertainty.

In his notebook he wrote: "Analogy: the same translation may raise the possibility of the same original; it does not establish it. The same person may appear in different events; the events do not thereby become one. The same fear does not establish repetition of an old crime."

Then a second line: "Atonement: acknowledge my earlier simplifications, but do not convert admission into unnecessary self-accusation."

Late at night a message came from Aditya. Under the court's direction, some old devices and the original copies of the translation archive needed to be preserved. A formal summons would be issued the next morning; Shashank would be asked to appear for a statement.

The final line of the message said: "Please do not alter, delete, or rename any file."

Shashank looked at the glow of the phone for a long time. Once, such a summons would have awakened fear inside him. Now, alongside fear, another voice rose—ambition. Again everyone would need his words. Again meaning would seem incomplete without him.

He smiled at himself. The lesson was not over yet.

On the final line of the notebook he wrote: "If the investigation seems to make me the centre again, remember—being at the centre is not the same as owning the truth."

CHAPTER 33

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 7

The next morning the summons was only a sheet of paper, but its weight fell more heavily on Shashank's mind than on the page. The previous night Aditya had written clearly that no file was to be altered, deleted, or renamed. Shashank read the instruction again, closed the lid of his laptop, and placed his old external storage devices together on the table.

A few years earlier, at such a moment, his first question would have been: "What do I need to save?" Today his first question was: "Have I done anything that would alter the form of the record?" He felt a faint pride in that difference. Immediately another thought arose—the investigation once again needed his words. That fine line of pride could become ambition.

A message from Mrinal arrived: "Read the summons?"

"Yes."

"Will you surrender the devices?"

"Everything on the list."

"And your sense of importance too?"

Shashank smiled. He did not answer.

When he reached the investigation office, Aditya first read aloud every paragraph of the summons. "This seizure is not a punishment," he said. "It is preservation. The purpose is to preserve the original condition of the devices, the time of the records, and the integrity of the copies. Your statement will be a separate record. The devices will speak separately for themselves."

Shashank asked, "May I be present when the copies are made?"

"For whatever part of the process the rules permit. But one thing must be clear—you are an interpreter, not an examiner of devices."

The sentence was simple. It left a slight scratch inside Shashank.

An officer read out the inventory—an old laptop, two external storage devices, one phone, and a printed copy of the translation archive. The description, serial number, and external condition of every item were recorded. Shashank watched carefully. He understood that procedure was stricter than human memory. Memory could say: "This is the same device." The record asked: "At what time was it taken? What identifying mark did it have? Who received it? What seal was applied?"

The lesson of analogy rose again. Looking alike is not identity.

The statement began. Aditya asked the first question: "What was your role in the Noida repair contract?"

"At first, language assistance. Later, some coordination."

"What do you mean by coordination?"

Shashank paused for a moment. "Conveying questions from the workers' side to the company side, explaining terminology between the Chinese and Indian sides, and clarifying messages about schedules."

"Deciding payments?"

"No."

"Receiving payments?"

"No."

"Seeing the name of a third recipient of payment?"

"Yes, in the records."

"Verifying the ownership of that name?"

"No."

Aditya gave him the written statement to read. Shashank stopped his thumb at one line: "The third recipient was suspicious."

"I did not say that," he said, stopping himself and then speaking clearly. "I said the name was different from the principal contracting party. Calling it suspicious would be a conclusion."

The recording officer changed the line. Aditya said nothing; he merely nodded.

A small wave of pleasure rose inside Shashank. He thought: this is why they need me. The difference of one word can change the direction of an entire record.

At once he remembered his own note: translation should be useful, not monopolistic. He restrained his pleasure.

The second question concerned the earlier phone calls. "Did you ever receive a pressuring message from this number?"

"Yes."

"Do you know who the sender was?"

"No."

"Did you infer anything from the language or sentence structure?"

"I did."

"What inference?"

Shashank said, "The vocabulary was of a kind I had heard earlier in some commercial messages. But that was only a similarity."

"Could you identify a person on that basis?"

"No."

"A company?"

"No."

Aditya said, "Good. Analogy opens a question; it does not close an identity."

Pride rose again in Shashank's mind—Aditya was now speaking the language of his method. Then he checked himself. Navya-Nyaya was not his private property.

The statement continued until noon. An old message was shown to him. It said: "Let Shashank see the records first, then send them to the Indian side."

Aditya asked, "What did you understand this arrangement to mean?"

"Language revision."

"Only language?"

Shashank was silent. "Not every time. Sometimes I softened sentences with the intention that fewer questions would arise."

"Is that an admission of crime?"

"No. It is an admission of my linguistic intervention. Its legal meaning is a separate matter for investigation."

"Did that intervention change the facts in the record?"

"In some places, not the facts but the emphasis. But emphasis too can have an effect."

Aditya stopped his pen. "Example?"

"Writing 'no problem was found regarding ownership' instead of 'ownership verification is not available'—those are not the same thing."

"Have you made such a change?"

"Not in that particular sentence. But I have made this kind of simplification in the past."

A momentary silence spread through the room. Shashank understood that this admission did not make his position easier. But atonement meant neither reducing the size of his fault nor enlarging it.

During the preliminary inventory of the devices, an officer said, "This external storage device contains old translation tables."

The list also showed several folder names—"Final," "Approved," "New," "Old." A junior officer said casually, "Then the folder called 'Approved' must contain the finally approved copy."

Shashank's attention sharpened at once. "The name does not establish that," he said. "I myself have sometimes kept a working folder named 'Approved' even when formal approval came later."

The officer asked, "Then a folder name means nothing?"

"It means something—it shows that at some point someone gave it that name. But it does not show which competent person formally approved it, or whether anyone did."

This time Aditya looked towards him. "Correct. A file name is a statement; proof of authority is separate."

A sudden, intense pleasure rose inside Shashank. It seemed that the whole room depended on his subtle distinction. He could have treated the moment as a victory. But he saw the officer write down the name and move on; the process did not stop to praise his scholarship. Strangely, the sight humbled him.

A little later another officer read an old file name containing the word "principal." Shashank was eager to explain, without being asked, how many ways the equivalent Chinese expression could shift in meaning. He opened his mouth and closed it again. Answer when a question is asked. Sometimes ambition becomes an answer to a question no one has asked.

Aditya did not look at Shashank. "Do not open anything yet to extract meaning. First the copies, verification, and time records."

Impatience rose inside Shashank. He believed that merely from the folder names he could tell which client, which year, which contract. Again he felt his own importance.

"Shall I read the names out?" he asked.

"If needed for the inventory, the officer will read them. The review of meaning comes later."

The junior officer remarked without thinking, "The language part will be difficult without you."

The sentence entered Shashank like sweet music. "Difficult without you"—that was exactly what he wanted to hear. His mind immediately began joining old scenes: the first Chinese tourist at the Red Fort, Juliana's lessons in tone, the Macao meeting, company contracts, courtroom questions. Everywhere language had brought him into the middle. Did all of this not mean that he was special?

At that moment he remembered one of Juliana's old sentences: if the bridge begins to think the river flows because of it, destruction has begun.

Shashank said only to the officer, "Independent experts can also do it. I can explain the context of my old work."

Aditya made a small mark on the paper with his pen. He offered no praise, but Shashank understood that sometimes the value of a correct answer lies in silence.

Once, such restraint would have felt like distrust to Shashank. Now he understood that sometimes procedure restrains not the person, but the excess of the person's talent.

During a short meal break in the afternoon, Mrinal came to see him. There was no veranda outside, only a small waiting area in the office. Mrinal handed him a paper cup of tea.

"What happened?"

"Devices surrendered. Statement is continuing."

"Everyone asking about your words?"

Shashank laughed. "A lot."

"And inside, you are pleased."

"A little."

Mrinal studied his face. "What is a friend's job here—to console you, or to prick you with a thorn?"

"Both."

"Then listen. The investigation's use of you does not prove you innocent. The investigation's use of you does not prove you guilty either. And most importantly—you are useful; that does not make you indispensable."

Shashank kept his eyes lowered towards the cup.

"Did Juliana say that?"

"No. I am saying it. A friend has rights of his own."

Shashank smiled. "Analogy?"

"Yes. A teacher and a friend can both correct you. That does not turn the friend into the teacher."

Both of them laughed. In the middle of fear, the laughter made Shashank feel lighter.

In the second session of the statement, Aditya showed him a printed contract. "In your old note, you gave two possible meanings for this Chinese expression—'operational representative' and 'person connected with control.' In the later Hindi version there is only 'representative.' Why?"

Shashank examined the paper. It was his handwriting. "At the time I thought 'representative' was sufficient for the Indian side."

"Was it sufficient?"

"For linguistic convenience, perhaps. For an inquiry into ownership or control, no."

"Did you knowingly remove the second possibility?"

Shashank took a deep breath. "Yes. But my purpose was to keep the text short, not to conceal ownership. That is my statement about my purpose; the evidence for it should be examined separately."

Aditya said, "That distinction will remain in the record."

Hearing the sentence, a strange calm entered Shashank. Earlier he would have wanted the officer to accept his stated purpose. Now he could accept that his claim about purpose too was something to be examined.

Towards evening, a copy inventory was given to him for signature. He read every line. One place said: "All translation-related material seized."

Shashank said, "Not all. Material available on the listed devices. Some of my printed dictionaries and textbooks were not taken."

The officer corrected the sentence.

Aditya smiled faintly. "Words asking for boundaries again?"

"Boundary is the life of a word," Shashank said. As he spoke, he liked the beauty of his own sentence. Pride rose inside him again.

Aditya did not praise him. "A beautiful sentence is useful only when it matches the record."

The remark struck Shashank's pride in exactly the right place. He laughed. "Fair."

Before leaving the office, Aditya said, "In the next session we will examine an old set of bilingual contracts. There the vendor names, payment recipients, representatives, and terms relating to possible control are distinct. You explain the language. We will test any conclusion about ownership against the records."

Shashank asked, "Is it connected with the Noida chain?"

"I cannot say yet. Some names look similar; that is all."

Analogy was present again—similarity of names was a question, not proof.

That night, after returning home, Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote: "Summons: it can be a means of putting the process, not the person, at the centre."

Second line: "Seizure: not merely taking an object, but preserving its condition, time, and chain."

Third: "Statement: only what was said. Do not turn 'different' into 'suspicious.' Do not turn 'possible' into 'proved.'"

Then his pen remained still for a long time. At last he wrote: "Ambition: that everyone asks me is not an achievement; that no one can understand the truth without me is a disease."

He remembered Mrinal's sentence: useful, not indispensable.

Shashank wrote the final line: "Analogy shows similarity. A friend shows the boundary. Procedure ensures that neither takes the place of truth."

He closed the notebook. The next day the set of bilingual contracts would be waiting for him—with those fine distinctions among name, representative, payment recipient, and actual control, where his pride in language would once again be tested.

CHAPTER 34

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 8

The next day five files lay separately on the investigation-office table: three bilingual contracts, one payment schedule, and one record concerning company structure. Aditya first showed Shashank only the external particulars of the files.

"Do not rush to extract meaning today," he said. "First understand what each record says, and what it does not say."

Shashank smiled. "Another day for analogy?"

"Every day is a day for analogy," Aditya said. "The problem begins when similarity is made into identity."

The first contract concerned the repair work in Noida. The Indian party's name was clear. The other party was an overseas supplier. In the Chinese original there was a phrase that Shashank had translated the previous year as "local representative." But when he read it again today, he stopped.

"Representative' is not enough here," he said.

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"Because the phrase suggests not only representation but responsibility for carrying out the work. Yet it does not say 'owner,' nor does it say 'controller.'"

"Then what would be appropriate?"

Shashank thought for a few moments. "We could say 'operational representative.' But the note should state that the word does not extend as far as ownership."

The recording officer wrote the line down. A faint pride rose inside Shashank. This was the field in which years of discipline could preserve the meaning of a record through the difference of a single letter.

The second contract was opened. This time there was a closely related word in the Chinese original, but the context was different. Here the person had authority to receive information from the client side and pass on certain operational instructions. The Hindi translation again said only "representative."

Shashank wanted to say at once: the two are not the same. He stopped himself. Aditya was watching him.

"What do you see?"

"Close in wording, different in role. In the first there is more local assistance with the work. Here there is authority to transmit instructions. But here too actual control is not established."

Aditya said, "So two words may look similar while the type of relationship is different?"

"Yes. Analogy warns us here. It would be an error to see the first word and decide the meaning of the second from it."

There was unbidden pride in Shashank's voice. He felt every eye in the room fixed on his face. There had been a time when such attention intoxicated him. Now he could recognise the old wave as it rose within him.

The third file was the payment schedule. It contained three different names: the contracting party, the recipient of services, and the recipient of payment. An officer asked, "If payment went to a third person, could that person be the actual beneficial owner?"

Before answering, Shashank looked towards Aditya.

"Give the linguistic answer," Aditya said. "We will test the legal conclusion against the records."

Shashank said, "Being the payment recipient is not proof of beneficial ownership. The recipient may sometimes be an agent, contractor, sub-supplier, or part of some other lawful arrangement. At times such a difference raises questions. But a question and proof are separate things."

"Does the Chinese original contain any word like 'beneficial'?"

"Not in this schedule."

"Control'?"

"No."

"Ultimate owner'?"

"No."

Aditya said to the recording officer, "Write each of those three 'no's separately. Later no one should look at the payment name and add words that are not there."

The sentence satisfied Shashank. He remembered how he himself had sometimes added words for convenience—in the name of shortening meaning, reducing questions, or making a paper easier. Today he could see how a small convenience could later become a large confusion.

The company-structure record was opened. The paper did not contain shareholding percentages; it listed the names and responsibilities of various contact persons. One name resembled the name of the "operational representative" in the third contract. The characters were not identical, but the pronunciation was close.

The junior officer said, "This could be the same person."

Shashank answered easily, "It could be. But only that much."

"The names are almost the same."

"Almost the same name can belong to different people in China. Transliteration too can vary. We need some match of date of birth, identification number, official contact, signature, position—something."

Aditya said, "A fine test of analogy. Similarity of names opens a question; it does not establish a person."

Pride rose again inside Shashank. This time he did not run from it. He understood that pride itself was not the fault; the fault began when pride took the place of evidence.

At noon a message from Mrinal arrived: "How deep into the jungle of words are you?"

Shashank replied: "Not a jungle. A map."

At once he added: "And the map is not the terrain."

Mrinal replied: "You are improving."

Shashank laughed.

In the second session, they showed him an old email summary. The Hindi version of that summary was in Shashank's hand. He had rendered one line of the Chinese original as "principal benefit-side." When he looked at the original line again today, his face tightened slightly.

Aditya asked, "What happened?"

"This translation is too strong."

"Meaning?"

"The original expression is closer to 'principal interest-side.' Writing 'benefit-side' makes the sense of financial gain much more explicit, whereas the original word 'interest' is broader."

"You made this translation?"

"Yes."

Silence spread through the room. Shashank looked at his old signature on the paper. For a moment he wanted to say: the context was like that, everyone understood it that way, there was little time. There were many excuses.

He said, "This was my error. I inserted an inference from the context into the word itself."

"Was your purpose to establish some ownership relationship?"

"No. At that time I was not translating for a financial investigation. But what my purpose was is one question; the effect of what I added to the text is another."

Aditya asked, "What does this error establish?"

Shashank replied, "Only that the old translation of this line should not be treated as independently reliable. The original should be examined again. This proves neither crime nor innocence."

Aditya nodded.

The junior officer asked, "Then you do not trust your own translations?"

The old pride in language stung Shashank again. The question felt like an attack on his talent. He could have said that one error did not erase years of learning. That would have been true. But his answer was different.

"Trust should rest not on a person but on a process. My translation is a useful source. It should be tested against the original text, another translation, the context, and the record. If everything is accepted merely because I say so, that is no longer discipline in language; it becomes a monopoly over language."

As he said it, Juliana's image returned to him: a bridge is not the owner of the river.

A little later, in one company record, the power of "final decision confirmation" appeared against a different designation. The name attached to that designation was different from the representative in the first contract. Aditya asked, "Does that establish control?"

Shashank said, "The authority to confirm a decision is important. But what kind of decision? Purchase? Payment? Appointment? Contract? All decisions? Some decisions? Without seeing the boundary, using the word 'control' would be premature."

Aditya said, "Correct. We need the description of the authority, not merely the name of the post."

An officer made four headings on a separate sheet: representation, payment, decision-making authority, ownership. Shashank saw that all four could appear beneath the same name, but need not.

He said quietly, "So often in language we see all these as though they were one shadow."

Aditya asked, "And in reality?"

"The shadows may merge. The objects may remain separate."

"That is why analogy matters."

After a while, Shashank was shown an annexure to the first contract. One sentence said: "The local party shall procure the necessary approval." In the Hindi version it had become: "The local party shall grant approval." Shashank frowned.

"Those are two different things," he said. "Procuring approval and granting approval oneself are not the same."

Aditya asked, "Why does that difference matter in an ownership inquiry?"

"Because if someone merely moves the process forward, it would be wrong to treat that person as the decision-maker. And if the person is the decision-maker, the boundary of that authority must be examined separately."

The recording officer marked the old translated line. For a moment Shashank felt satisfaction that his training had again proved useful. But in the next moment he understood: the correction was not his private victory; it was the purification of the record.

He thought to himself that pride in language remains beautiful only while language itself is the purpose; when pride places the person above the evidence, deception begins.

By late afternoon, verification of three names remained pending. Aditya gave a clear instruction: no name was to be described in any report, statement, or allegation as the beneficial owner until there was an independent basis for ownership or effective control.

Shashank asked, "What if several indirect indications point in the same direction?"

"Then the inference may become stronger," Aditya said. "But the word changes only when the level of evidence changes. 'Possible,' 'under investigation,' 'connected,' 'controlling,' 'owner'—these are not rungs of a single automatic staircase."

Shashank liked the sentence very much. He could not resist writing it in his notebook.

Before the session ended, they showed him an old message. Someone had written: "Keep the names separate; the work belongs to the same people."

Aditya asked, "Linguistic meaning?"

Shashank studied the original sentence for a long time. "The statement makes a claim of relationship. But who 'the same people' refers to—which person, which group, which company—is not clear. Actual ownership cannot be determined from this sentence."

"Is it important?"

"Yes. Because it opens the question of why the names are separate and whose work it is. But the answer is not contained in this sentence."

"Good."

As Shashank left the investigation room, his mind felt strangely light. His learning had been useful that day, and at the same time one of his old errors had been exposed. Once he would have experienced such a day as defeat. Now he understood: seeing one's own error is not an insult to talent; it is the purification of talent.

His phone rang as he descended the stairs. Unknown number.

He stopped. He remembered the pressuring call from the previous week. For a moment fear rose again through his body.

He accepted the call.

A male voice spoke from the other side—calm, almost courteous. "A great many papers are being looked at, Shashankji."

Shashank said nothing.

"Do not go too deep into the names. A contract is a contract. Whoever received the payment received it. Leave old matters alone."

Shashank's thumb tightened around the phone.

"Who are you?"

A soft laugh came in reply. "Why does a name matter? You understand words, after all."

The call ended.

For a few moments Shashank stood motionless on the stairs. His mind immediately began joining this call to the earlier one—voice? wording? pressure? the same person? the same group?

He stopped himself. Analogy gives a question, not identity.

He turned immediately back towards Aditya's room.

"I received a call," he said. "The words resemble those in the earlier call. But at present I can say only this: there is a similarity."

Aditya wrote down the time of the call. "And that is where we begin."

After leaving, Shashank sent Mrinal only one line: "The shadow returned today."

Mrinal replied: "Look at the shadow. Do not give it a person's name until you find the light."

Shashank looked at the sentence for a long time. For the first time, his pride in language was not lifting him above the ground; it was keeping him grounded.

He opened his notebook and wrote: "A representative is not an owner. A payment recipient is not a beneficial owner. A similar name is not the same person. A similar sentence is not the same source."

Beneath it: "The discipline of analogy: see the similarity, preserve the difference."

And the final line: "Pride in language is pure only when it does not make a word heavier than the evidence."

CHAPTER 35

THE THUG'S PHONE CALL

As Shashank turned back towards Aditya's room, the evening light was fading in the long corridor of the government building. His hand was still clenched around the phone, as though the unknown voice had lodged not inside the device but in the nerves of his palm.

Aditya motioned for him to sit. "Say only as much as was said."

Shashank opened his notebook. "A male voice. He said: 'A lot of papers are being looked at, Shashankji.' Then: 'Do not go too deep into the names. A contract is a contract. Whoever received the payment received it. Leave old matters alone.' I asked his name. The reply was: 'Why does a name matter? You understand words, after all.' Then the call ended."

Aditya looked towards the recording officer. "Write it verbatim. Do not use 'threat' as the heading yet."

Disagreement rose inside Shashank. "But the intention was clear."

"The inference about intention may be clear," Aditya said, "the source is not. We also do not know whether the person in the earlier call and the person today are the same."

Shashank fell silent. His mind was making comparisons of its own—neither caller gave a name; both spoke in hints; both expected Shashank to understand without an explicit demand. Analogy was fast. Evidence was slow.

Aditya asked, "Any sound, location, background—anything you can state with certainty?"

"No. The voice was calm. I can say that the caller knew my name and either knew or inferred that the contract papers were being examined."

"Good. Write both possibilities: 'knew' and 'inferred.'"

For a moment Shashank felt irritated. Repeatedly writing possibilities seemed to weaken the truth. Then he remembered his own earlier error—that was precisely where he had turned possibility into proof.

Aditya said, "Do not go to Noida alone tonight. Give written notice to the company's security officer. Preserve the time of the call, the number, and the words. Do not construct the rest of the story."

"The caller is constructing the story," Shashank said.

"Perhaps. But I need a record, not a story."

As he stepped outside, he found Mrinal sitting on a chair in the waiting area. Shashank was startled. "You are here?"

"After reading your message—'the shadow returned today'—you expected me to go home?"

Shashank smiled faintly, but the tension did not leave his face. They walked out of the building. The roadside was busy, yet to Shashank every face seemed like a possible gaze.

Mrinal said, "What is certain right now?"

Shashank snapped, "You too, Aditya?"

"No. A friend. That is why I am asking. Are you afraid?"

At that simple question, the covering inside Shashank broke. "Yes."

Mrinal remained silent for some distance. Then he said, "That much truth is already a great deal."

Shashank looked at him at once. For a few moments neither spoke. Fear withdrew a little. Shashank thought how strange friendship was: when a shadow was closing around one's life, even a simple admission could return a person to his own place.

The next morning, the atmosphere at the Noida office had changed. The company's Indian administrative assistant said that the security department had taken the information about the call in writing. The local contractor had also come, but his voice was subdued that day. "No one contacted us," he said. "But people in the area keep asking names."

Shashank asked, "Which people?"

The contractor shrugged. "That is all I heard. No names."

Shashank resisted the urge to make a note. "People are asking names" was a statement. "Thugs are asking names" could become a story. The distance was small; the consequence large.

The company's accounts department provided several records concerning payment for the first repair job. The advance had gone to the material supplier; the mid-stage payment to the contracting party's account; a small service charge had been settled through a separate payment gateway. The arrangement immediately lit up old

investigation records in Shashank's memory—mule accounts, payment gateways, hawala, cryptocurrency layering. Words he had once seen following one another like shadows.

A junior accounts employee said, "All this is normal, sir."

Shashank paused before answering. "On what basis do you call it normal?"

"I have seen payments like this here before."

"Then you have seen similarity," Shashank said. "Not legality or illegality."

The accounts employee fell silent.

Mrinal, who had come with him especially that day, said softly, "Remember that for yourself too."

Shashank understood the reference. The old pride inside him said: I recognise this pattern. The discipline of analogy said: before you call it recognition, look at the difference.

At noon a message came from Aditya's office saying that a comparative list of certain older digital records concerning payments had been prepared. Shashank was called only for linguistic verification. He asked Mrinal to wait outside.

The list contained four kinds of expressions: "local cooperation," "service settlement," "third payment," and "digital asset." Some entries were accompanied by the name of a person, some by an institution, some only by an identifier. Aditya said clearly, "This list is not a complete money trail. It is only a list of the words used in the records."

Shashank examined one Chinese sentence. The expression translated there as "local arrangement" could, depending on context, mean "local management," "local coordination," or simply "local arrangement."

"This cannot be turned into 'local collection' on this basis," Shashank said.

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"The original expression does not require that meaning. If other evidence shows collection, that is different. The word alone does not."

A second entry contained the phrase "old route." A junior officer asked, "Could this be coded language for hawala?"

Shashank answered, "It could be—if context, conduct, the parties, and other evidence point that way. But 'old route' by itself is not hawala."

At a third place there was a reference to a digital asset. The officer asked again, "Layering?"

"Not from the presence of this word," Shashank said. "All that is established here is a reference to a digital asset. Its purpose requires separate evidence."

Aditya looked towards Shashank. "Today you are using analogy to stop comparison."

"Not to stop comparison," Shashank said, "to give comparison a boundary."

A brief silence followed. Shashank felt that his learning was no longer merely an instrument for displaying brilliance; sometimes it was a line drawn around a fire.

In the evening he returned to the Noida office. Mrinal sat with tea in the open space outside, almost like a veranda. "You took a long time."

"There were few words, but many possible meanings."

"And conclusions?"

"Few."

Mrinal laughed. "Progress."

Just then Shashank's phone rang again. Unknown number. Their eyes met.

Mrinal said, "Answer it. If you think it is proper, put it on speaker. I will listen, but first say clearly that I am here."

Shashank accepted the call. "Hello. My friend Mrinal is with me. He may hear whatever you say."

There was silence at the other end for a moment. Then came the same calm kind of male voice—the same voice or only a similar one, Shashank could not be certain.

"You have learned a great deal of caution, Shashankji."

Shashank's heart began to beat faster. "Tell me your name."

"Leave the name. Keep doing your small work in Noida. It is not your job to get into old payment accounts. It is better to remain on friendly terms."

Mrinal's face hardened, but he said nothing.

Shashank asked, "Are you instructing me to do something, or not to do something?"

A soft laugh came from the other side. "You understand words. Why do you need so much clarity?"

"Because people later fill ambiguity according to their own convenience."

Silence. Then the tone changed; beneath the politeness, the hardness was clearer. "Then understand only this: it is better to keep your distance from papers that are not yours."

The call ended.

Shashank's hand was trembling. Mrinal did not ask him to hand over the phone. He said only, "Sit down."

For a few moments both were silent.

Shashank said, "This time the threat is clear."

Mrinal replied, "The fear is clear. The statement is pressuring. 'Threat' may be a legal conclusion—let Aditya decide what word belongs in the record. I am a friend, not a court."

Shashank kept looking at him. "Are you protecting me or restraining me?"

"Both. Friendship that only protects can sometimes enlarge deception. Friendship that only restrains is no longer friendship. I want you to be safe, but I do not want fear to make you invent a story."

Shashank's eyes grew moist, though he turned his face away. "Sometimes it seems I entered all of this myself. The desire to learn languages, to sit among important people, foreign travel, servers, special access—all of it."

Mrinal said quietly, "Yes. You opened some doors yourself. But the acts of whoever is calling you belong to him. Name your own share correctly. Do not take the weight of another person's share on your head either."

It was an echo of Juliana's lesson: make guilt neither smaller nor larger.

Together they sent Aditya a complete written account of the incident. Mrinal wrote separately the words he had heard; Shashank wrote his own recollection separately. The sentences common to both accounts were marked; impressions about tone or intention remained in separate comments.

That night, after reaching home, Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote:

"Analogy: the style of two calls is similar; the source is not established."

"Direct facts: no name was given; a pressuring statement was made telling me to keep away from old payment papers; Mrinal heard the second call."

"Inference: the caller may have an interest connected with the inquiry into the contract or payments; not established yet."

"False allegation: naming any person, company, community, or officer as the source of the calls without independent evidence."

"Established facts: words, time, number, witness."

After that his pen remained still for a long time. At last he wrote: "Friendship: do not let fear become a story."

At that moment a new message arrived in his email. The subject line read: "Macao—Updated Invitation for Consultation Meeting." It referred to the successful coordination of the Noida contract and said that the technical group wanted his linguistic assistance; a limited demonstration of the system during the meeting was also proposed.

Shashank looked at the message for a long time. At the end of a day of fear, the glitter of foreign travel seemed unnaturally bright—as though one shadow had barely withdrawn before another light began calling him towards itself.

A message from Mrinal arrived: "Reached home?"

Shashank replied: "Yes. The Macao invitation has come again."

A few moments later came the answer: "Do not run towards glitter to escape fear of the phone. First see what the invitation is, what the limits of access are, and what your greed is saying."

Shashank wrote the last line in his notebook: "Analogy does not establish a source in fear; neither does it establish the innocence of an opportunity in greed."

The night was deep. The phone had fallen silent. But Shashank understood that the thug's call was not only pressure from outside; it was an inner test as well. Friendship did not save him from fear; it kept him standing on the boundary of truth within fear. And now the next test waited in the glitter beyond the sea.

CHAPTER 36

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 10

For three days the Macao invitation remained open in Shashank's email. He would draft a reply, then delete it. Writing "I accept" was easy; the difficult part was understanding how much of that acceptance came from professional need and how much from the seduction of glitter.

The Noida repair contract was moving towards completion. The workers' final list, confirmation of payments, and equipment handover papers were being placed in separate files. Because of the pressuring call from the previous week, an invisible tension hung inside the office, but no new threat had arrived. Aditya had said clearly: do not turn silence into a conclusion. The fact that the calls had stopped did not end the question of their source; and the fact that calls had occurred did not prove the Macao invitation tainted.

The sentence lodged inside Shashank: "Two events happened close together; that does not establish a causal relationship." Analogy showed him resemblance; Navya-Nyaya also taught him the boundary of resemblance.

One evening Mrinal sat on his veranda. A cup of tea stood between them. Shashank handed him a printed copy of the invitation.

Mrinal read: "Linguistic consultancy, review of bilingual agreements, limited system demonstration, travel and accommodation at the organiser's expense." He did not fold the paper. "What attracts you?"

"The work," Shashank wanted to say immediately, but he stopped. "The work... and the fact that they are calling me again."

"Pay attention to that second part."

"I understand."

"Understanding and admitting are different things."

Shashank smiled, but the smile did not last. "Do you think I should not go?"

"I will not make your decision. But if you are going, write your limits beforehand—what you will see and what you will not; what you will translate and what you will not; which material you may retain a copy of and which you may not. If greed shifts the boundary later, you will remember that the boundary existed before the temptation arrived."

The advice felt uncomfortably right.

The next day he went to Raghav Bhasin's office. Raghav read the invitation, the confidentiality agreement, and the conditions of access.

"Not the earlier mistake this time," Raghav said. "Watching a technical demonstration and independently searching inside a system are not the same thing. Your role is language assistance. If some screen opens by itself, your authority does not expand merely because you can see it."

Shashank's face flushed slightly. "I understand the law."

Raghav kept looking at him. "The problem was never that you did not understand the law. The problem was that sometimes you treated your talent as permission."

The sentence struck directly. Shashank did not reply.

He asked for written conditions—the limits of the demonstration, the material to be translated, the prohibition on copying, and the limits of technical questioning. The organisers sent a revised letter. Raghav read it again. After that, Shashank informed Aditya about the proposed journey, although he had no formal obligation to do so.

Aditya's reply was brief: "Information received. Travel by itself is not evidence of a crime. For anything you see, make a private note of the time and context; do not copy confidential material. If something is an inference, write it as an inference."

On reaching Macao, Shashank remembered his earlier trip. Once, foreign lights had seemed to him proof of success. This time he saw within those lights his old hunger. Looking out at the city from the high hotel window, he remembered Juliana's sentence: a bridge does not own the river.

The meeting was on the second day. In the model contract the organising company was named "SeaBridge Digital Services." Representatives of different service partners from China, Singapore, and India sat across the table. Shashank's task was to clarify terms in the bilingual contract and interpret questions and answers during the technical team's presentation.

The first two hours were ordinary. Terms such as "service provider," "technical partner," "payment settlement," and "internal testing" recurred. Shashank noticed that one Chinese term had been rendered

differently in two English versions. In one place its meaning was closer to "account reconciliation"; in another it had been translated as "settlement."

He raised his hand. "The same Chinese term appears in both places, but the contexts are not the same. In the first, internal account reconciliation is the more likely meaning; in the second, external payment settlement may be intended. Using the same English word in both places would create confusion."

For a few moments the room was silent. The technical head nodded. "Correct. That is why we invited you."

The praise awakened the old heat inside Shashank. Language was his field; everyone was looking at him. For a moment he became again the man who thought: if I am not here, meaning will remain incomplete.

After lunch, the limited system demonstration began. A test environment was opened, containing fictional customers, sample transactions, and screens for internal reconciliation. Shashank's role was to explain terminology. A Chinese heading over one column caught his eye. Literally the word could mean "route," while in a financial context it might also mean "medium" or "channel."

The presenter said, "We can call this a payment route."

Shashank did not answer at once. "We can, but without context the word 'route' does not establish an actual payment path. On a test screen it may simply be a classification."

The technical head smiled. "You have become very cautious."

Shashank smiled too, though something moved inside him. "Caution is knowledge learned late."

During the demonstration, an additional list appeared for a moment on the left side of the system. The presenter immediately switched to another screen. Shashank had caught the pattern of some names on the list—letters, numbers, regional markers. Their structure reminded him of abbreviated names in some old Noida papers.

Temptation came at that instant—not as a question, but as desire. If only he could see that list again. If only he could match those names. What if this momentary resemblance gave him the secret that would place him ahead of Aditya, Mrinal, Raghav—everyone?

He wanted to say to the presenter: "Open the previous screen again."

The sentence reached his tongue and stopped. He remembered Raghav's warning: a screen opening does not increase your authority. He remembered Mrinal's: write the boundary first.

He wrote only in his notebook: "An extra list appeared briefly; context unknown; naming pattern looked familiar; no conclusion without comparison."

After the presentation, the technical head stopped him separately. "If you wish, you can sit in tomorrow's extended technical session. It is difficult to give you more access, but some sections can be shown for observation only."

"Is that within the contracted work?"

"Not directly. But it would be useful."

Temptation flashed again inside those four words: "You can see more." Shashank asked, "Written permission?"

The technical head looked slightly surprised. "You want one?"

"Yes. With limits."

By evening a short written approval arrived: observation only of specified test segments, no copies, no independent search. Shashank sent it to Raghav. Raghav replied: "The limit is clear. Seeing the limit is not enough; you have to obey it."

That night Mrinal called.

"How much glitter?"

"A great deal."

"And greed?"

Shashank laughed. "A great deal of that too."

"That is a good answer. Earlier you would have said, 'I am only doing my work.'"

Shashank looked out of the window. "I saw a list today. Some of the naming patterns looked familiar."

"So?"

"Nothing. There was no context."

"Nothing? Or a question?"

Shashank was silent. "A question."

"Good. Analogy gives a question."

In the extended session the next day, Shashank saw only the approved test segments. The names there turned out to be fictional training labels. Part of the similarity that had seemed unusual the day before was simply a common naming convention. But another issue emerged: in one contract, the Chinese term translated into

English as "service assistant" was closer in meaning to "coordination assistant." That small difference could make the role appear larger than it was.

Shashank suggested a correction. The technical head agreed. Then a foreign representative laughed and said, "You create a lot of problems because of words."

Shashank replied, "Words do not create the problem. Definite conclusions built on ambiguous words can create problems."

After answering, he surprised himself. Once he would have said such a sentence to display his brilliance; now he was saying it to protect a boundary.

At the end of the meeting, he was offered a consultancy for the next six months—higher remuneration, regular foreign travel, priority access to technical sessions. As he read the proposal, the old pride rose in his chest. This was the doorway to the life he had imagined when he first came to Delhi.

But he did not sign immediately. "I will answer after returning to India and obtaining legal review."

The representative asked, "You do not trust us?"

Shashank said, "Trust and conditions are different questions."

On the flight back to India, he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Direct knowledge: the Macao meeting took place; I saw a limited test demonstration; additional observation was within a written boundary; one correction concerning the translation of a role appeared necessary."

"Analogy: the naming pattern resembled some Noida papers; the test system also contained ordinary naming conventions. Similarity does not establish source or ownership."

"Inference: some service roles may appear larger or smaller in English translation; the original text, contract, and records must be examined together."

"False allegation: calling a limited server demonstration proof of a criminal system; treating foreign travel as proof of participation; declaring similar naming patterns to be the same network."

"Established facts: the journey, the meeting, the written limits, the test segments shown, the proposed contract."

At the end he wrote: "Greed: mistaking the right to see more for the right to know more truth."

After reaching Delhi he did not go straight home. He met Mrinal at a small restaurant. Looking at his face, Mrinal asked, "Did you find anything big?"

Shashank replied, "The big thing I found was that the list which looked like a secret to me was partly ordinary."

Mrinal laughed. "Is that disappointment or relief?"

"Both. A part of me wanted to discover something extraordinary."

"Did you want truth, or victory?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "The difference between the two is clearer to me now."

That evening at Aditya's office, Shashank submitted only the limited factual details of the journey. Aditya asked, "Did you go beyond the approved boundary?"

"No."

"Did you see anything that might be useful from the perspective of the investigation?"

"One or two differences in the meaning of role-related terms. But they do not establish ownership or crime. If formally required, the original contracts can be requested."

Aditya wrote: "Linguistic indication—independent verification required." Then he looked up. "You did not use to say this sentence."

Shashank smiled. "Earlier I used to say: 'I understand the meaning.'"

"And now?"

"Now I say: 'I see one possible meaning.'"

Evening was falling outside. Shashank remembered the lights of Macao, but this time not as glitter—rather as a mirror. The greed outside had its root within: special access, specialised knowledge, the pride of understanding before everyone else. Analogy repeatedly showed him a familiar shape; truth demanded separate permission before he could enter that shape.

As he was returning home, a message from Raghav Bhasin arrived on his phone: "In the new six-month consultancy proposal, two clauses concerning confidentiality and assistance are worryingly ambiguous. Let us sit tomorrow and examine them. The boundary between legal advice and actual participation must be made clear first."

Shashank read the message and switched off the phone. The test of Macao's temptation was not over; only its form had changed. Now the question was not a server screen, but clauses on paper—and fear, confidentiality, and participation were again waiting before him.

CHAPTER 37

CONTRACT AND SHADOW II

The next afternoon Shashank reached Raghav Bhasin's office. Outside, the October sunlight was pale, but his palms were damp. A copy of the six-month consultancy proposal he had brought back from Macao lay in his bag. The paper had not left his mind even through the night.

Raghav placed two copies of the proposal before him—one in English, the other in Chinese. "You read first. I will look at the legal language afterwards."

Shashank read the first clause. Commercial confidentiality, technical material, translated records, restrictions on external publication—none of these seemed especially problematic. When he reached the second marked clause, he stopped.

In the Chinese original there was a phrase whose closest meaning was "cooperation in external coordination work." The English version said "regulatory and service-facilitation assistance." Shashank frowned.

Raghav asked, "The difference?"

"The English wording appears broader. The Chinese phrase says 'cooperation,' but does not by itself amount to representation. An English reader could understand that the consultant will actively handle matters involving third parties, service partners, or regulatory questions."

"Your work?"

"Translation, clarifying terms, language assistance in meetings."

"Payment reconciliation?"

"No."

"Dealing with third-party accounts or service partners?"

"No."

"Representing the company before government officials?"

"No."

Raghav put down his pen. "Then all of those must be expressly outside the written role."

An old wave of fear rose inside Shashank. "If I insist on so many limits, they will think I do not trust them."

"Trust does not mean accepting an ambiguous contract."

"But the opportunity is large."

"The larger the opportunity, the clearer the boundary should be."

Shashank remained silent. The tall buildings of Macao, the glittering city, the technical meeting, the praise, six months of future travel—all woke again inside him. Beside them, the red pen on Raghav's table looked small. Yet he knew that a small red line could sometimes stop a large darkness.

Raghav reached the third marked clause. "Here it says that the consultant will provide confidential assistance under the direction of the company's lawyers. How do you understand that sentence?"

Before answering, Shashank read the original again. "In Chinese, the meaning is closer to 'necessary linguistic cooperation under legal review.'"

"Meaning?"

"Translation."

"And in English?"

"The phrase 'confidential assistance' can be very broad."

Raghav leaned back in his chair. "This is where fear begins. People imagine that if lawyers are involved, every conversation is confidential, every act is safe, every record falls within privilege. But confidentiality of legal advice and actual conduct are not the same thing."

Shashank looked at Raghav. "You mean the work does not become protected merely because a lawyer is present?"

"I mean only this: do not turn the confidentiality of legal advice into evidence of conduct or proof of innocence. Which communication is protected, which record exists independently, which act is actual work separate from advice—those depend on context, role, and law. That is why the boundary must be written first."

An old meeting returned to Shashank's mind—Raghav had said then too that confidentiality was not shelter for falsehood. The shape of the present situation resembled the earlier one: lawyer, confidentiality,

ambiguous instruction, his own fear. Analogy immediately showed him the similarity; this time he stopped his own mind.

"This contract looks like that earlier meeting," he said, "but the similarity does not establish the same purpose."

Raghav smiled faintly. "Keep that sentence."

At that moment Shashank's phone vibrated. Unknown number.

He looked towards Raghav.

"Answer it. Do not assume anyone's identity."

Shashank put the phone to his ear.

A male voice spoke from the other side—calm, subdued. "You received the proposal?"

"Yes."

"Why the delay in signing?"

"It is under legal review."

"Legal review is confidential. What is with a lawyer does not go outside. Why worry?"

A tingling ran down Shashank's back. The words were ordinary, but their sequence felt familiar. In the earlier anonymous Noida calls too there had been phrases like "the papers are fine," "no need for more questions," "do not waste time." Here the language was different, but the tone felt similar.

He asked, "Who are you?"

The reply came: "The name does not matter. Accept the proposal. Opportunities do not come again and again."

The call ended.

Shashank remained holding the phone for a few moments.

Raghav asked, "What has been established?"

Shashank's first reaction was: the same people... but the words did not leave his mouth. He steadied his breathing and said, "This much is established: someone from an unknown number who knew about the proposal contacted me. The voice or sentence pattern felt familiar. The same person is not established."

Raghav nodded. "Analogy."

"Yes."

"And fear?"

Shashank lowered his eyes. "One fear says: sign it and end the matter. Another says: do not sign, or everything will come down on you."

"Both fears are asking for the authority to make the decision."

"Then what?"

"Facts. Boundaries. Written terms."

Raghav wrote four amendments into the contract: the translator's role limited to linguistic assistance; no authority over financial transactions or payment reconciliation; no representation before government bodies or third parties without separate written authorisation; access to systems or records only within an expressly written scope.

Shashank kept reading them. "If all of this is written, the company may refuse."

"It may."

"Then the opportunity is gone."

"Possibly."

The casualness of the answer made Shashank feel a trace of anger. "For you this is only a contract. For me it is a professional life."

Raghav's face did not harden. "And that is precisely why you have to be more careful than I do. The more a person fears losing something, the more attractive an ambiguous term can become."

Shashank rose and went to the window. People were walking on the street below. He remembered Mrinal's sentence: fear creates stories. At that moment he wanted to create his own story—the story of a gifted translator from whom opportunities were always being taken away. But the problem on the page was much simpler: the role was not clear.

He sat down again. "Send the amendments."

Raghav said, "One more thing. Note the time of the unknown call. Write the words separately, as exactly as you remember them; do not add meaning from your own mind."

Shashank opened his notebook.

"Unknown number. Knew about the proposal. 'Legal review is confidential.' 'Opportunities do not come again and again.' Source unknown. Purpose unknown."

He stopped, then wrote: "Stylistic similarity with earlier calls; same person or group not established."

Raghav's eyes rested on the line. "That is the discipline of analogy."

After leaving the office, Shashank went directly to Mrinal. Mrinal understood from his face that something heavy had happened.

"Bad paper?"

"Ambiguous paper."

"And you?"

"Afraid."

Mrinal said nothing at first. He ordered two cups of tea. By the time the tea arrived, Shashank had told him everything—the contract, Raghav's amendments, the unknown call, the fear of losing the opportunity.

Lifting the tea, Mrinal said, "Sometimes the problem larger than fear is having to hide fear."

"I am not hiding it."

"Half hiding. You keep asking: 'What if this opportunity disappears?' You are not asking: 'What if it comes without boundaries?'"

Shashank remained silent.

"Friendship is useful," Mrinal continued, "when a friend respects your fear but does not accept fear's reasoning."

"Do you want me to refuse?"

"I want you not to say yes without clear terms. The decision is yours."

The sentence gave Shashank relief and irritation at once. Everyone was leaving the decision to him—Raghav, Mrinal, Aditya. Perhaps this was adult fear: no one would issue an order, but the consequence would still be one's own.

In the evening a message came from Juliana: "Was the Macao trip good?"

Shashank wrote: "The trip was good. The proposal is difficult."

A little later Juliana called. Shashank briefly explained the ambiguity in the contract.

Juliana said, "When a student begins learning a language, he first fears words. Later he becomes proud of words. At the third stage, he understands that some words require him to write their boundaries himself."

"And confidentiality?"

"Confidentiality may be a rule of silence. It is not the shape of truth."

Shashank smiled. "All of you are saying the same thing in different languages."

"Then perhaps the thing is important."

At nine that night the company's revised proposal arrived. Three of the four amendments had been accepted. But the clause concerning representation in governmental or regulatory matters remained ambiguous: "The consultant shall provide necessary coordination assistance."

Shashank sent it to Raghav.

Raghav replied: "My advice is not to sign until there is agreement on this phrase."

Shashank stared at the paper for a long time. Fear returned. The opportunity might disappear. The glitter of Macao, travel, remuneration, special access—all stood on the other side of one sentence on the page.

He picked up the phone and wrote to the company representative: "Please clarify 'coordination assistance' as linguistic/administrative assistance only. Representation, payment, third-party financial dealings, or influence over regulatory decisions will not fall within this scope."

No reply came immediately.

That night he wrote five lines in his notebook:

"Direct facts: six-month proposal; ambiguous assistance clause; unknown call; three amendments accepted; one clause still ambiguous."

"Analogy: stylistic similarity with earlier pressuring calls; same source not established."

"Inference: the ambiguous clause may create a future risk of role expansion; purpose cannot be fixed without verification."

"False allegation: calling legal review criminal protection; linking the unknown call to the company or any identified person; treating ambiguity as proof of crime."

"Established facts: written proposal, Raghav's review, amendments, time and words of the call received."

Beneath that he wrote: "Fear: mistaking confidentiality for safety; mistaking opportunity for an order."

The next morning the company's reply arrived. The clause had been revised again. Linguistic/administrative assistance was expressly stated; representation without separate written approval was prohibited. Shashank sent the paper to Raghav. Raghav wrote: "The language is now much clearer. The final decision is yours."

Shashank waited one hour before signing. In that hour he remembered the temptation of Macao, the Noida calls, the humiliation in court, Mrinal's friendship, Juliana's words. Then he signed the limited form exactly as it stood on the page.

At noon another message arrived. The lower commissionerate had requested clarification of certain vendor records. At almost the same time a company coordinator wrote: "Hold the reply for now; discussions are taking place above."

Shashank stopped as he read the message.

Only a few hours earlier the limits of confidentiality and participation had become clear on paper. Now a new shadow stood before him: whose 'above'? What authority? Where was the written order? And why should the lower office's questions be held?

His finger stopped over Aditya's name on the phone. First the record had to be preserved. He wrote down the time of the message, wrote down the source, and added only one line to his notebook:

"Analogy again shows a familiar shape; no decision yet."

Fear was still present. But this time fear was accompanied by a new habit—the habit of writing the boundary.

CHAPTER 38

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 12

Dawn had not yet fully spread when a brief message from Aditya arrived on Shashank's phone: "Preserve yesterday's original message exactly as it is. Meet me before replying."

Shashank read again the line from the previous night: "Hold the reply for now; discussions are taking place above." The sentence was short, but inside it lay a blank space into which the mind could easily pour its own fear. Whose 'above'? What discussion? What authority? And for whose benefit was the reply to be held?

He opened his notebook. The final line from Chapter 37 was still fresh: "Analogy again shows a familiar shape; no decision yet."

Beneath it he wrote: "The feeling of betrayal is not evidence."

When he reached the lower commissionerate, Aditya showed him not the message first, but the file. It contained five questions concerning vendor records. Three had been answered; two remained pending. The lower office's note said: "Verification of ownership and payment relationships remains incomplete; original records should be called for."

Above it another note had been added: "No direct relationship is established by the material presently available."

Shashank read the two sentences and fell silent.

Aditya asked, "Do they say the same thing?"

"No."

"The difference?"

"The first sentence says the inquiry is unfinished. The second says the available material does not establish the relationship. The second sentence is not false by itself; but if the first is removed, a reader may understand that further verification is unnecessary."

Aditya nodded. "That is all I need you to write."

Irritation rose inside Shashank. "Someone may have done this deliberately."

"That is a question," Aditya said, "not an answer."

"Yesterday the company coordinator told me to hold the reply because things were being discussed above. Today this note is in the file. The two happened almost at the same time."

"Analogy." Aditya's voice was flat.

Shashank looked at him.

"Two shapes resemble each other," Aditya said, "but it is not yet established that one caused the other. We need a link between the company's message and the government note. Without that link, proximity in time raises a question only."

Shashank felt his own teaching stand against his own desire. He had known this feeling before: knowledge feels harsher when it resists what we want to believe.

On the next page of the file was a handwritten note: "As discussed above, aggressive follow-up action is deferred for now." The signature was unclear; only initials were visible.

Shashank said, "Again, 'above.'"

"Yes."

"The same word."

"Does the same word establish the same person?"

"No."

"The same instruction?"

"No."

"Then?"

Shashank took a deep breath. "Then its source, date, author, and authority must each be verified separately."

Aditya smiled faintly for the first time. "Your language is working now."

The praise pleased Shashank, but almost immediately another feeling rose—the pride of proving useful again after months of humiliation. He recognised the surge. Talent was again asking for permission to cross the boundary of evidence and become the owner of the conclusion.

By noon three records had been gathered. The first was the lower commissioner's original questionnaire. The second was an internal summary in which the line "verification remains incomplete" was absent. The third was a short forwarding note from the upper office: "Consolidated review of the matter is required." There was no instruction in that note to close the inquiry.

Shashank kept looking at the language of the summary. It reminded him of an old translation in which he had once replaced "further confirmation required" with "relationship unclear." At the time his purpose had merely been to shorten the sentence. Later he had understood that a shorter sentence could shift the boundary of meaning.

"This language feels familiar," he said.

Aditya did not stop him immediately. "Why?"

"Because I myself have sometimes moved from 'verification remains' to 'relationship not established.'"

"Then did you write this summary?"

"No. At least not in this form. I am not the author of this file."

"Then the similarity?"

"It may simply be a common habit of office summarisation. Or someone may deliberately have narrowed the boundary. Neither is established yet."

Aditya said, "Keep that answer."

Something inside Shashank stung. He had imagined that hearing about his old error might make Aditya look at him with suspicion. Instead Aditya recorded only the status of the sentence—neither praise nor accusation. Sometimes that neutrality felt like punishment because it left so little room for the theatre of self-defence.

It suddenly occurred to Shashank that institutional betrayal does not always arrive as a dramatic transaction. Sometimes one word disappears, one adjective changes, one question moves from "pending" to "irrelevant," and the consequence travels very far.

But even this thought carried danger. To see a change in language and immediately name a corrupt intention would be the same haste against which he had been training himself.

He placed two pages of the file side by side. One said: "Original ownership records required." The other said: "Available material insufficient." The first demanded work; the second could postpone a decision. The difference in effect was clear. The author's intention was not.

Shashank noted: "The linguistic consequence is visible; the state of mind is not."

At that moment the record keeper brought the incoming-register. It showed that three days earlier the lower office had requested the original papers. The upper summary came later. But the register contained no written order cancelling the inquiry.

Aditya said, "The sequence matters."

Shashank asked, "Does the sequence establish pressure?"

"No. It establishes this much: the questions arose first, the summary came later, and no written cancellation has been found. Cause is a separate question."

The answer felt severe to Shashank, but clean. The discipline of analogy stood before him like a mirror: show the shape; do not declare the person.

After noon an officer from the lower office arrived. He looked tired. "I was told orally to reduce the priority of the questions. When I asked for a written order, I was told that a consolidated review was under way. That is why I wrote in the file that the original verification remained pending."

Aditya asked, "Who told you?"

The officer gave a name, then added, "I cannot say whether that person spoke on his own decision or on someone else's instruction."

"Any written message?"

"There was a short message: 'Wait for now.' But no clear order to stop the inquiry."

Shashank looked at the officer. He remembered the same kind of weariness from an earlier stage of the investigation—words small, responsibility heavy.

After the officer left, Shashank said, "Then there was an internal compromise?"

Aditya looked straight into his eyes. "You are reaching the conclusion again."

Shashank fell silent.

"What we have at present," Aditya said, "is this: the lower office had questions; verification was pending; there is an account of an oral change of priority; the written direction is ambiguous; a summary has narrowed the qualification. Together they raise a question of procedural interference. By whom, for what purpose, and at what level remain open questions."

Shashank wrote in his notebook: "The feeling of betrayal may increase the intensity of a question; it does not increase the quantity of evidence."

In the evening he met Mrinal. One look at Shashank's face was enough. "Something again?"

Shashank told him only the necessary part. "The lower office wanted verification. In the upper summary, the language became softer."

Mrinal asked, "Someone sold out?"

"I cannot say that yet."

"Good. Earlier you would have built the entire story from this much."

The sentence stung Shashank. "Do you see my improvement at all, or only my old faults?"

Mrinal looked at him. "Friendship is not counting old faults. But I will not let you turn improvement into another form of pride either. You just gave the right answer—'I cannot say yet.' That small answer matters a great deal."

They remained silent for a while.

Then Mrinal asked, "What hurts you most?"

At first Shashank was going to say: "the system." Then he stopped. "That I am trying to make the boundaries clear, and someone can still blur them again inside a file."

"Whom did you trust?"

"The process."

"People run the process."

"Then what can one trust?"

Mrinal said, "A record capable of surviving questions later. Trust in a person can break. A written boundary can still be read again."

That night Juliana called. This time Shashank used the word "betrayal."

Juliana asked, "Established?"

"No."

"Then the word is heavy."

"The feeling is heavy."

"Call the feeling an experience; do not call it a fact."

Shashank did not laugh. "Analogy keeps showing the same shape—discussion above, wait, reduce priority, narrow the boundary."

"If you hear the same melody in two houses, must the singer be the same?"

"Not necessarily."

"But the melody should be written down."

"Yes."

"That is all," Juliana paused, then said. "Write the melody. Do not write the singer's name without evidence."

A faint smile appeared on Shashank's face for the first time. "You are correcting my Maithili now too?"

"You corrected my Chinese. I am repaying the debt."

At ten that night Aditya sent a new update. A copy of the lower commissioner's original file had been secured. The timeline was being matched. One officer's statement would be formally recorded. The person who wrote the upper note would be asked for an explanation.

Beneath that was another line: "Meanwhile, do not connect any person's name with an outsider or with the media."

Shashank replied: "Understood."

A few minutes later a message arrived from an unknown number: "Do you confirm that the lower office's objection was suppressed in the sealed GST file?"

Shashank's hand became still. This was not an ordinary question. The phrase "sealed GST file" had appeared in the message of an outsider.

He did not reply. He preserved the message, recorded the time, and instead of forwarding its contents away from the original device, informed Aditya only that such contact had occurred and that the material remained preserved on the original device.

Aditya replied: "Do not answer. We will verify the source."

Shashank opened his notebook. On the final page he wrote:

"Analogy: similar language, similar timing, similar pressure—grounds for inquiry."

"Inference: interference in the process is possible—not established."

"False allegation: calling an ambiguous note final proof of a corrupt arrangement; automatically linking the company's message to a government instruction; treating the lower office's resistance as proof of the entire institution's integrity."

"Established facts: questionnaire; verification pending; changed language in the summary; recorded account of oral priority change; ambiguous upper note; unknown message asking a media-like question."

Beneath that he wrote: "Betrayal: when feeling runs ahead of evidence, a second betrayal of truth begins."

He put down his pen. Outside, the night was deep. Inside, the door to a new crisis had opened: whether some words from the investigation file had reached outside, or whether someone had merely cast a net of inference, remained unknown.

But Shashank had learned one thing by now: when you see a shadow, do not immediately write a person's name. First find the source of the light.

CHAPTER 39

CONTRACT AND SHADOW 13

By dawn Shashank had read the words of the unfamiliar message three times: “Was the lower office’s objection suppressed in the sealed GST file?”

The question had the form of an ordinary journalist’s inquiry, but two things inside it kept disturbing Shashank—“sealed” and “the objection was suppressed.” The first described the status of a record; the second had already manufactured a conclusion. It was not quite a question, more like half a verdict.

He had not replied. Aditya’s instruction had also been clear. Yet even after silence, the mind does not remain silent. Shashank kept wondering: did someone know something from inside? Had someone inferred it from public clues? Or had someone deliberately chosen such words in the hope that fear would make the person questioned reveal more on his own?

He had no evidence that allowed him to choose any one of those three possibilities.

At eight-thirty a message from Aditya arrived: “Can you come to the office? Bring the original device. We need to record a statement about the unfamiliar contact.”

Shashank wrote only: “Yes.”

When he reached the office, he saw that the file from the lower commissionerate was not on Aditya’s desk. Instead there lay a thin brown envelope. In red letters on it were the words: “RESTRICTED INSPECTION—NO COPY.”

Shashank’s eyes stopped on the envelope.

Aditya said, “This is the index of material that may be seen only in a limited manner under the court’s order. Not the papers inside. First, the unfamiliar message.”

Shashank placed his phone on the desk. “The original device is here. The message has not been deleted.”

“Did you reply?”

“No.”

“Discuss it with anyone?”

“Not even with Mrinal or Juliana. I informed only you.”

Aditya recorded the time, number, wording, and condition of the device. Then he asked, “Your own inference?”

Shashank paused for a few moments. “Someone may have heard words from inside. Someone may have joined public clues and inferred them. Or someone may have thrown out those words to provoke a reaction from me. All three are possible.”

“Which is more likely?”

“It would be premature to say.”

For the first time Aditya gave a slight nod. “That answer is useful.”

Then he opened the envelope. Inside was only one sheet—the index of the sealed record. Each item had a name, date, source, and limit of access.

As he read, Shashank stopped at one entry. The index said: “Verification note of the lower commissionerate—original.” Elsewhere: “Consolidated review summary—internal.” A third entry: “Earlier correspondence concerning translation assistance.”

He asked, “The media report uses the phrase ‘confidential translation note.’ There is no item under that name in this list.”

“Correct,” Aditya said. “But that alone does not prove the report false. The item may have been described under another name, or the source may be different. We have to separate every component of the original claim.”

He opened a news article on the computer screen. The headline was sharp: “Translator’s Confidential Role: Signs of Suppression in Sealed Records?”

The old humiliation rose again in Shashank’s chest. His name was not explicit, but the description was close enough that no name was needed to identify him. The article said that “a language intermediary” had helped soften the meaning of objections from the lower office, and that “sealed material” supported that suspicion.

Shashank’s first impulse was to say: “All of this is false.” But the sentence reached his tongue and stopped.

Aditya was watching him. “Say it.”

"The article has not established its main conclusion," Shashank said slowly. "But it would also be wrong to say that everything is false. In the past, I have softened language with the purpose of reducing questions. That is a fact. But that I suppressed objections in this particular sealed material is not established."

"Write the distinction," Aditya said.

Shashank opened his notebook.

"Admitted fact: in some earlier translations I simplified or softened language with the intention of reducing questions."

"Unproved claim: that in this specific GST file I deliberately intervened to suppress the objection of the lower office."

"Ambiguity: which record the report means by 'confidential translation note' is presently unknown."

When he finished writing, Aditya asked, "Do you feel less humiliated?"

Shashank gave a bitter laugh. "No."

"Then the method did not work?"

"Method is not medicine for humiliation."

"Correct. It only prevents humiliation from making you enlarge the facts."

The sentence sank deep into Shashank. He remembered that day when a news article had almost presented him publicly as a criminal. At the time, in anger, he had wanted to prove every part of himself innocent. Now he understood that self-defence too can become falsehood if it erases admitted facts.

By noon a second version of the news story appeared. This time it cited an unnamed "senior source." The article said: "The sealed material appears to connect the payment route, vendor relationship, and the role of the language intermediary in a single chain."

Shashank read the sentence and remained silent.

Aditya asked, "What do you see?"

"A misuse of analogy."

"Explain."

"The fact that three things appear in the same body of records does not establish that they form one transaction. The payment route is one question; the vendor relationship another; the translator's role another. Being placed in the same file does not establish the nature of the relationship among them."

"And if all three are from around the same date?"

"Then similarity of time gives a reason to inquire, not a conclusion."

"If the same name appears repeatedly?"

"The identity of the name must first be verified. A similar name is not the same person."

"If the same Chinese expression appears in different papers?"

"Then the original context must be examined. The same phrase does not establish the same legal role."

Aditya did not smile, but some of the tension in his eyes eased. "In this chapter you are becoming a useful expert against yourself."

Shashank's face tightened. "Is there something amusing in that?"

"No. It is one of the harder forms of truth."

Just before noon, his old teacher from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan called. There was neither excessive sympathy nor curiosity in the voice.

"I read the news," the teacher said. "Are you all right?"

"I am trying to be."

"Remember one thing. The classroom is not a certificate of your character, and an accusation against you is not an insult to the classroom. If anyone asks what you learned here, name the lesson—not a story proving your innocence."

The sentence felt severe to Shashank, but he understood. "I will not use the institution's name in my defence."

"And do not turn your old studies into a shield either. There is no rule that a person who has learned languages cannot make mistakes."

After the call ended, Shashank remained for a while among memories of the old classroom. Once the teacher had written on the blackboard: "Context gives a word its meaning; the speaker's prestige does not." Then it had been an exercise. Today the weight of the sentence lay across his professional life.

He added to his notebook: "Education is not a substitute for evidence. Prestige is not a source of meaning."

In the afternoon a message came from Mrinal: "I saw the news. Call if you want to talk."

At first Shashank thought of avoiding it. Then he called.

Mrinal asked without preamble, "How much of it is true?"

"That I softened language in the past—true. That I suppressed objections in this particular sealed file—not established. That payment, vendors, and my role are one criminal chain—at present an inference."

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. "Was it hard to say that?"

"Very."

"Why?"

"Because if I admit the first thing, people will assume the second as well."

"And if you deny the first thing?"

Shashank did not answer.

Mrinal said, "Then in order to defend yourself you will do exactly what the article is doing to you—you will turn two different things into one."

Shashank closed his eyes.

"Friendship," Mrinal said again, "is not an institution that declares you innocent. We say what is true. We protect the boundary of what has not been established."

In the evening Juliana called. This time Shashank himself brought up the news.

"People say the sealed material is against me."

Juliana asked, "Have you seen it?"

"Not all of it."

"Then where did the word 'against' come from?"

"From the news."

"Is the news the meaning of the material?"

"No."

"Is your guilt the meaning of the material?"

Shashank was silent.

"Is your humiliation the meaning of the material?"

"No."

Juliana said, "Analogy becomes dangerous when the mind pastes the shape of an old wound onto a new object. You made old mistakes. That does not make every new allegation true. And because you made old mistakes, that does not make every new allegation false either."

Shashank wrote: "Guilt is not evidence; self-defence is not evidence either."

That night Aditya called him back. This time a printed copy of the news article lay on his desk, and beside it a timeline.

"Preliminary verification," he said. "So far, we have found no evidence that a complete copy of the sealed index went outside before the first article was published. But two phrases in the report correspond to terms used in limited office discussions."

Shashank asked, "Then someone from inside—"

Aditya raised a hand and stopped him. "No. Do not jump from 'corresponds' to 'someone from inside gave it.'"

Shashank left the question unfinished.

"Second," Aditya said, "the identity of the holder of the unfamiliar number remains unverified. Third, the basis for the phrase 'payment route' in the news may also be a portion of a public company record. So it is not established that internal material went outside."

"But the word 'sealed'?"

"Important. But one word can have several possible sources—court proceedings, legal parties, the office, inference. No naming without a source chain."

Again Shashank remembered the original lesson of analogy: resemblance to a known thing may introduce the unknown; it does not turn the unknown into something known.

He said, "I think humiliation increases my hunger for evidence. I want it proved quickly that someone else was wrong."

Aditya said, "And because of that hunger, the mind turns the first resemblance into final proof."

Shashank nodded. "Yes."

Aditya slid a new page towards him. "Tomorrow there is a limited hearing in court. Because the news report refers to sealed material, both sides will offer clarification. There may be questions about the distinction between your earlier translations and the new claim."

Shashank read the page. His name was not on the witness list, but he was mentioned as a “source of linguistic assistance.”

“Could I be called?”

“Possibly.”

“And if I am asked whether the news report’s claim is true?”

“Say what you know. Say ‘I do not know’ for what you do not know. Call inference inference. Do not minimise your old mistakes, and do not turn them into proof of the new accusation.”

That night, after returning home, Shashank wrote four lines in his notebook:

“Analogy: similar words, similar timing, similar subject—grounds for inquiry.”

“False allegation: treating the existence of sealed material as proof of guilt.”

“Established facts: earlier linguistic softening; a news claim about sealed material; an unfamiliar message; a limited index; source presently unverified.”

“Humiliation: the heat of the mind, not the temperature of the evidence.”

He put down his pen. Outside the door, the sounds of the city had diminished. The image of tomorrow’s courtroom was rising before his eyes. This time the question would not be only about the news; it would be whether two languages built from the same fact—defence and accusation—could survive the test of Navya-Nyaya.

Shashank turned off the light. It seemed to him that the shadow had now reached the walls of the court. The next light would be tested there.

CHAPTER 40

THE CANTONESE DOOR I

In the second half of that limited court hearing, Shashank was called to the witness stand. The news controversy from the previous episode still lingered in the atmosphere, but at the outset the judge made it clear that the questions that day would not concern the whole of the sealed material; they would be limited to language sources, earlier professional contacts, and the boundaries of the inferences drawn from those contacts.

Shashank took the oath and sat down. Two files were placed before him. One was a copy of an old service contract of a mobile-phone company, containing papers relating to linguistic and coordination assistance for the Indian unit of a company named Vivo. The second file contained notes from a meeting some months later, where Shashank had acted briefly as interpreter with a representative of a betting-based app vendor.

Counsel for the prosecution lifted the first paper.

"You made this translation?"

"Yes."

"In this service contract, did you speak directly with representatives of the Chinese side?"

"Yes, within the limits of the linguistic work."

"Cantonese as well?"

"Some individuals spoke Cantonese. The main contract was principally in Standard Chinese and English."

Counsel lifted the second file.

"And at the meeting with this betting-based app vendor, was Cantonese used there too?"

"One person spoke in Cantonese."

"So in both places the language was the same, the translator was the same, the business field was technological, and even the city of contact was almost the same?"

Shashank paused for a moment.

"Those are similarities."

"Then is an inference of connection not natural?"

"A question may arise naturally. A connection is not thereby established."

Counsel smiled. "Are you again trying to teach Navya-Nyaya?"

For a moment Shashank felt his old pride rise, but immediately steadied his voice.

"No. I am only stating the limits of my testimony."

The judge said, "Proceed with the answer."

The prosecution opened a page. The old Vivo-related service contract contained expressions such as "technical assistance," "local coordination," and "language facilitation." In the notes of the later meeting, a representative of the app vendor had described his company as a "technical service provider."

"'Technical service' in both places," counsel said. "Chinese-speaking representatives in both places. Shashank Jha in both places. Should this be treated as mere coincidence?"

Before answering, Shashank looked towards the judge.

"What I see is that the same general term can occur in many different businesses. 'Technical service' by itself does not indicate ownership, a payment relationship, or partnership."

"But you were already acquainted with the person from that app vendor?"

"I knew the name. A mutual acquaintance had asked me to provide language assistance."

"Who was the mutual acquaintance?"

Shashank gave the name. The court clerk wrote it down.

"Was that person involved in the Vivo contract?"

"Not to my recollection."

"To your recollection? So you are not certain?"

"I would not claim complete certainty without examining the old records."

Counsel paused and slid a paper across.

"Look at this. That person's name appears in an email chain relating to the contract."

Shashank read it. The name was the same, but the email address was different. He raised his head.

"The name is the same. That alone does not establish that it is the same person."

"What would be required, in your view?"

"An independent basis of identification—email, designation, company records, contact details, or direct confirmation."

Counsel said, "And if name, language, city, business acquaintance, and the same translator all appear together?"

An old lesson of Navya-Nyaya awakened inside Shashank: a reason is useful only when its relation to what is to be proved has been established. Smoke indicates fire when the pervasion between smoke and fire is known; to see something grey and immediately call it fire is not inference but error.

"Many similarities can gather in one place," he said, "but if the necessary connecting link is absent, increasing the number of similarities does not change the nature of the evidence."

Counsel for the prosecution immediately changed direction.

"In the meeting note concerning the app vendor, you wrote the phrase 'entertainment platform.' What was said in the original Cantonese?"

Shashank's throat went dry.

This was the question he had feared.

"The original statement was more specific," he said.

"How specific?"

"It referred to an online game played by placing bets."

For a moment the courtroom was still.

"Then why did you render 'betting-based game' as 'entertainment platform'?"

Shashank felt his nails press into his palm.

"I softened the language."

"At whose instruction?"

"I do not remember any direct instruction."

"Then on your own?"

"From a tendency to keep the tone of the meeting lighter."

"A tendency?" counsel said sharply. "You softened the nature of a risky business, and now you are telling the court not to infer a connection?"

The defence objected. The judge directed counsel to narrow the question again.

The old heat of humiliation rose inside Shashank, but this time atonement rose with it. He understood that minimising his earlier word choice would be another deception.

"I accept," he said, "that the translation was improperly softened. The original wording was more explicit. Because I wanted fewer questions to arise, I chose a more general expression. That was not merely a linguistic error; it was an error of professional judgment."

The court clerk kept writing.

The prosecution pressed on.

"So you knowingly concealed reality?"

"No. Record what I have admitted only to that extent. I compressed the nature of the original business into a general term. But it is not true that I knew of an ownership or payment relationship between the Vivo contract and this vendor."

"Did you benefit?"

"I received a fee for the meeting."

"And the fee for the Vivo contract?"

"A separate professional fee."

"You were paid in both cases. Is that not a reason indicating a relationship?"

For the first time Shashank looked directly into counsel's eyes.

"It establishes my professional role. It does not establish a relationship between the two clients."

The judge said quietly, "Good. Next question."

This time the defence began cross-examination.

"Mr Jha, did the Vivo-related contract explicitly mention any betting-based app, gaming vendor, or the person from that later meeting?"

"No."

"Did payment under that contract come from the app vendor's account?"

"There is nothing of that kind in the records available to me."

"Was any Vivo-related representative present at that later meeting?"

"No."

"Then the similarities shown by the prosecution—language, city, technical service, translator—may all be real; but a conclusion of connection still requires another link?"

"Yes."

"What kind of link?"

"Ownership records, a clear payment chain, written instructions, common control, or other independent evidence showing an actual relationship between the two events."

Defence counsel paused.

"And your translation 'entertainment platform'?"

Shashank's voice dropped.

"Improper."

"Does that improper translation establish a relationship between the Vivo company and the app vendor?"

"No."

"Does it raise a question about your professional reliability?"

"Yes."

At that answer Shashank felt something inside him break and reassemble. Perhaps atonement was not self-punishment; it was giving the correct fault its correct name. No less, no more.

The judge called Aditya Mishra. Aditya came and sat in the witness box.

"How did the investigation view the relationship between these two events?" the judge asked.

Aditya replied, "Because of the initial similarities, a comparison was made. But so far the investigation has found no independent evidence establishing ownership or a joint payment relationship between the party to the lawful Vivo-related service contract and the later betting-based app vendor. The same translator and a similar linguistic circle provide a reason for inquiry, not a conclusion."

The prosecution asked, "Then what is the significance of Shashank's softened translation?"

"It has a separate significance," Aditya said. "His linguistic reliability, purpose, and past conduct are matters for examination. But one person's defective translation cannot substitute as evidence of a relationship between two other institutions."

"Meaning you are defending Shashank?"

Aditya's face remained expressionless.

"No. I am separating categories."

Silence filled the courtroom again.

In that sentence Shashank heard the whole of his recent life: separate the categories. Fact separate, meaning separate, inference separate, desire separate. He had spent so long combining them to manufacture his own importance.

Before adjourning the hearing, the judge made an observation:

"The court is not drawing any broad conclusion at this stage. The admission of linguistic simplification is on record. The question of any relationship between the two commercial contexts will depend on independent evidence. Similarity alone cannot form the basis of inference."

As Shashank came outside, Mrinal met him and walked beside him for some distance.

"What happened?" Mrinal asked.

"For the first time in court, one line of my own translation sounded like evidence against me."

"Which one?"

"Entertainment platform."

Mrinal said nothing.

Shashank continued on his own. "I chose that phrase to reduce people's questions. At the time I thought language could keep the atmosphere under control. Now I understand that sometimes controlling questions through language means reducing the weight of truth."

Mrinal said softly, "But you are not now saying that every allegation is true."

"No."

"Good. Atonement does not mean enlarging your guilt either."

Shashank smiled faintly. "Juliana said much the same."

That evening at the Tao temple in Pitampura, Shashank told Juliana the entire hearing. Juliana kept looking at a thin line of incense smoke.

"What is the hardest part of inference?" she asked.

Shashank said, "Choosing the reason?"

"No. Not turning your own desire into the reason."

Shashank remained silent.

Juliana continued, "You wanted people to ask fewer questions. So you softened a harsh word. Now you want people to believe you are innocent. Be careful that this time you are not tempted to cut every link of similarity."

"Then what?"

"Say what is connected is connected. Say what is not connected is not connected. What is still under investigation—leave it under investigation."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

"Inference: there must be a valid relation from reason to what is to be proved."

"Similarity: it can open the door of a question; it cannot fill the room of a conclusion."

"Atonement: admit my linguistic softening."

"False self-accusation: to accept an unproved relationship merely because of that softening."

"Vivo service contract: separate record."

"Meeting with betting-based app vendor: separate record."

"Common points: translator, language, professional acquaintance."

"Unproved points: joint ownership, joint payment, shared control."

He was still writing when the phone rang. It was Aditya.

"Can you come to the office tomorrow?"

"What is it?"

"Following the court's observation, a formal summons has been issued regarding old messages, meeting notes, and two devices. Some digital material will be taken into secure custody. We will also need your statement."

Shashank's eyes rested on the final line of his notebook.

The court, the seizure, the sealed material—all the earlier experiences awoke together inside him. The old ambition whispered again: once more, everyone needs you.

Shashank lifted his pen and added one more line:

"A summons is not a certificate of importance; it is the formal shape of a question."

He replied to Aditya, "I will come."

After putting down the phone, Shashank looked towards the door. The first door of Part Four had opened. Cantonese had once given him entry into a new world; now that same language was leading him towards the strict discipline of inference.

And this time the next test would not be the cleverness of words, but the silence of seized records.

CHAPTER 4I

THE CANTONESE DOOR 2

The next day Shashank reached the office long before the appointed time. The final line from the previous night —“A summons is not a certificate of importance; it is the formal shape of a question”—was still echoing in his mind. Yet another voice lived inside him too: after the court’s observation, they needed him again; without his knowledge of language, it would be difficult to interpret the digital material. The thought pleased him as much as it warned him.

The moment Aditya saw him, he pushed a thin file forward.

“There are three separate tasks today,” he said. “First—your formal statement in response to the summons. Second—the evidentiary inventory of two seized devices. Third—the limits of meaning in certain Cantonese and Mandarin messages. Do not merge the three.”

Shashank opened the file. The first page recorded that, following the court’s observation, old message chains, meeting notes, and two digital devices had been taken into secure custody. The seizure inventory listed the date, time, type of device, number of the sealed bag, and names of those present.

“Will I open the devices?” Shashank asked.

“No,” Aditya replied. “The technical team has already prepared copies. You will examine only the language in the certified copies. As far as the original devices are concerned, your role is zero.”

A faint dissatisfaction rose inside Shashank. For a moment he felt he was being kept at a distance. Then he caught himself. This too was one form of ambition—the desire to have every door of the process opened for him.

The first message chain dated from the time of the Vivo service contract. A Chinese official had written: “The person providing local language assistance should remain in the meeting; he will simplify the difficult service-related terms.” Shashank had replied: “I will be present; if questions arise, I will clarify the meaning.”

Aditya asked, “What does this establish?”

Shashank answered, “That I was present at the language meeting concerning the service contract. No more.”

“Does it establish payment authority, ownership, or managerial power?”

“No.”

“Does it establish that when you later met the betting-based app vendor, you occupied the same role?”

After a brief pause Shashank said, “No. That role has to be established separately.”

Aditya wrote: “Similarity of presence does not establish similarity of role.”

The second item was a personal note from a meeting. In the margin Shashank had written in his own hand: “Client asks too many questions; keep the language soft.” His eyes stopped on the line. He had already admitted this tendency in court. Yet seeing his old sentence in writing was a different experience.

Aditya asked, “Whom were you referring to with the word ‘client’ here?”

“I cannot recall with certainty now.”

“The Vivo side?”

“Possible.”

“The app vendor?”

“Possible, but not proved.”

“A person common to both?”

Shashank shook his head. “Not from this note.”

Aditya stopped his pen and looked at him. “This time you are calling an inference an inference. For me, that is no less important than your knowledge of language.”

Pride rose again inside Shashank when he heard the sentence. Praise was his weakness. He immediately checked his own mind. To harden an inference merely because one has been praised is ambition too.

The third item was more difficult. In the phonetic transcription of a Cantonese message, there was a term that, depending on context, could mean “connected channel,” “associated medium,” or simply “contact through that route.” The technical team’s preliminary Hindi summary had rendered it: “shared payment channel.”

Shashank read the page several times.

“This summary is too definite,” he said.

“How so?”

“The original statement does not expressly mention payment. ‘Channel’ can also mean a medium of contact. The next sentence does refer to a sum of money, but the grammatical relation between the two sentences is not certain.”

Aditya asked, “Then what would you write?”

Shashank said, “Possible meanings: ‘associated medium’ or ‘contact through that medium.’ A specific payment meaning may be inferred from the context, but it is not established by the original word itself.”

“Good.”

A member of the technical team asked, “But if the next sentence mentions an amount, isn’t it natural to understand this as payment?”

Shashank turned towards him. “It may be a natural inference. It is not an established meaning. Write the reasons for the inference—proximity, sequence, context. Then ask whether those reasons make the conclusion necessary or merely possible.”

Aditya did not smile. He merely continued writing. Shashank was beginning to understand this habit of his: an investigator creates a record of limits more readily than a record of praise.

The second part of the technical copy contained automatic transcriptions of voice messages. In several places the machine had mistaken Cantonese pronunciation for Mandarin words. Shashank identified three errors at first glance. Once, a victorious excitement would have filled him—See, none of this works without me. Today, instead of lifting a red pen, he asked, “Have both the automatic text and the original audio been preserved?”

“Yes,” the technical member replied.

“Then preserve the original form alongside every correction. Wherever I am not certain, I will write two possibilities.”

Aditya asked, “If you wish, can we make the corrected text the principal text?”

Shashank thought for a moment. “No. The error in the original machine transcript is itself part of the history of the record. Do not erase it; add human review beside it.”

After giving that answer, he felt a subtle change within himself. Earlier he had treated correction as authority; now correction seemed more like annotation—not rule over the original, but responsibility beside it.

In one audio fragment his own voice could be heard. At some point he had laughed and said: “Let us simplify this term here, otherwise two pages of questions will follow.” Shashank listened and fell silent. The voice was his; the intention was not unfamiliar. But the recording did not by itself say which questions had been reduced, what decision had changed, or whether any unlawful act had thereby been facilitated.

He said on his own, “This sentence is useful material against me, but it cannot be called proof of its consequences.”

Aditya replied, “That is enough to say.”

At noon the formal statement began. Each question was read out one by one. Shashank’s answer was typed and then read back to him.

“Were you present as interpreter at meetings concerning the Vivo service contract?”

“Yes.”

“Did you later meet a betting-based app vendor?”

“Yes, in the context of a separate professional introduction.”

“To your knowledge, was there an economic relationship between the two meetings?”

“No. No verified record of such an economic relationship was before me.”

“Did you ever choose language so that a client would ask fewer questions?”

Shashank’s throat went dry. “Yes. On some occasions I changed harsh or complex terms into softer functional language. That was professionally improper where it reduced the force of the original meaning.”

“Does that mean you were knowingly concealing unlawful activity?”

Shashank paused for a long time. The question could pull him simultaneously towards self-defence and self-accusation.

“That is not established by this fact alone,” he finally said. “I admit the softening of my language. But knowledge of a specific unlawful act, or an intention to conceal it, requires separate evidence.”

The typist entered the words. Aditya read them back. Shashank changed one expression—from “separate evidence is needed” to “it requires separate evidence.” To him, “is needed” contained too much of his personal demand; “requires” sounded like the language of a rule governing the process.

During the statement, an old message was produced. An acquaintance had written: “These people will get stuck without your translation.” Shashank had replied: “Then bring me in first; afterwards everything will become easier.”

Aditya asked, "What did you mean by that sentence?"

The old pride suddenly came alive inside Shashank. At the time, he truly had felt that language was not merely his capital but his right.

"I was exaggerating my own usefulness," he said. "I was proud of my linguistic ability. Probably more than was warranted."

"Does 'bring me in first' mean authority over the decision-making process?"

"No. The available sentence shows only that I wanted to be involved in language assistance from the beginning."

"Was that ambition?"

Shashank laughed faintly, though the laughter carried fatigue. "Yes. 'Ambition' is the right word."

By the time the statement ended, evening had fallen. But Aditya said the name of one digital folder remained. Its title was in Romanised Cantonese and could roughly mean "key people" or "key contacts." Inside were various business cards, travel details, and meeting schedules.

A technical team member asked, "Does 'key people' mean the principal operators of a network?"

Shashank shook his head at once. "No. The title does not say that much. It could mean principal clients, key contacts, important acquaintances—any of those."

"But the app vendor is inside."

"People from the Vivo service contract are inside too. Two names being in one folder may indicate some relationship, but it does not tell us the nature of that relationship."

Aditya asked, "The structure of the inference?"

Shashank replied, "Reason: inclusion in the same folder. What may be proved: some shared classification. But the pervasion needed to say 'shared criminal network' is absent. It could just as well be a list of professional contacts."

Aditya wrote in the file: "Shared classification possible; nature of classification unproved."

The simplicity of that sentence struck Shashank. For years he had added words to make meaning more forceful. Here, four words were not diminishing the meaning; they were protecting it.

As he left the office, Mrinal was waiting outside. He had deliberately not gone in.

"How long?" he asked.

"All day."

"Did they make you an accused?"

Shashank looked at him. "No."

"Declare you innocent?"

"No."

Mrinal smiled. "Then the investigation is continuing. You have learned that sentence now."

They began walking slowly along the roadside. After some distance Shashank said, "Today they found an old message—I had written, 'Bring me in first.'"

Mrinal said, "Back then you wanted every door to open through your hand."

"Yes."

"And now?"

Shashank took time before answering. "Now I understand that opening a door and owning the house are different things."

Mrinal looked at him. "Tell Juliana that line. She will like it."

That night Shashank went to the Tao temple in Pitampura. Juliana sat quietly amid the scent of incense. Shashank told her the whole story of the day.

Juliana asked, "What hurt you most?"

"That they did not put the devices in my hands."

"Why?"

Shashank smiled. "Because I still feel—if I see more, I will understand more."

"And if you understand more?"

"I will become more important."

Juliana closed her eyes. "Then today you were not studying translation. You were studying ambition."

Shashank remained silent.

"In inference, the first mistake is not always a defective reason," Juliana said. "Sometimes the first mistake is believing that the conclusion is yours to make. Truth is not your office."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“A summons gives the right to answer questions; it is not proof of prestige.”

“Digital seizure preserves material; it does not write the meaning by itself.”

“Two names in one folder—an indication of shared classification; not proof of shared crime.”

“Linguistic softening—my admitted error.”

“Knowledge of a specific crime—a matter for separate evidence.”

“Ambition: when the desire to be useful becomes the insistence on being indispensable.”

“Inference: discipline of the reason, not of desire.”

He was about to put down his pen when a message from Aditya arrived.

“Tomorrow we will examine records of three vendors connected with the Vivo service contract, names of payment recipients, and company-ownership records. We need your language assistance, but conclusions about ownership will come from the records.”

Shashank read the message again. A year earlier, the final sentence would have wounded him—“We need your language assistance, but conclusions will come from the records.”

Today the sentence gave him relief.

He added the final line to his notebook:

“Language can open the door; records build the house of ownership.”

The next day, the Vivo gate was waiting for him.

CHAPTER 42

VIVO'S GATE

When Shashank reached the gate of the Noida office complex, he stopped for a moment. The final line from the previous night—"Language can open the door; records build the house of ownership"—was still fresh in his mind. Today he had to put that sentence to the test.

Aditya had arrived before him. Three thin files, certified copies of company records, two payment lists, and several bilingual contracts lay before him.

"Today I need language assistance," Aditya said, "but you will not give the conclusion on ownership. You tell us the limits of the words; the records will tell us their own limits."

Shashank smiled. "That no longer hurts to hear."

"A good sign," Aditya said, "but a sign is not proof."

Shashank laughed. "You too have learned inference."

"My job is precisely to make sure inference does not forget its boundary."

The first file concerned a local repair vendor connected with the Vivo service contract. One expression in the Chinese original of the bilingual agreement caught Shashank's eye. In the English translation it had been rendered as "authorised representative," but in context the original was closer to "contact representative" or "work coordinator."

Shashank said slowly, "'Authorised representative' carries too much weight here. The original does not necessarily grant decision-making authority. This person may merely be a point of contact."

Aditya wrote: "Translator's opinion: original term does not necessarily establish decision-making authority."

Shashank immediately added, "But this is my linguistic opinion. What authority the person actually had inside the company must be seen from the appointment letter, board records, or power-of-authority document."

Aditya nodded. "Correct."

The second file contained the name of a company receiving payment. Shashank was startled as soon as he read it. The first two characters of the Chinese name resembled the name of a business group he had seen in a third contract. The old excitement rose inside him—the excitement that wanted to turn resemblance into a story the moment it appeared.

He read the paper again.

"The names match?" Aditya asked.

"Partly."

"Then?"

Shashank took time before answering. "Analogy gives us a question. The beginning of the name is the same, but the full name is different. The registration number is different. The address is different. The list of directors is different. Two shared Chinese characters alone do not establish common ownership."

"Meaning?"

"The similarity gives a reason to investigate, not a conclusion."

At that moment Shashank felt a strange pride within himself. Once, such subtlety had made him believe he understood more than everyone else. The pride was still there today, but its voice had changed. Earlier it said: "See? Only you caught this secret." Now it said: "See? You can catch the boundary too."

The third file was more difficult. In the contract, a Chinese term used for the "recipient of benefit" had been translated into English as "beneficial owner." Shashank frowned as soon as he read the sentence.

"This translation is risky."

Aditya stopped his pen. "Why?"

"The literal sense of the original may be close to 'actual recipient of benefit,' but it is not automatically correct to turn that into the legal term 'beneficial owner.' In this contract the term may also refer to the person receiving the proceeds of a payment. Ownership, control, and economic benefit are not the same thing."

"Then is the English translation wrong?"

Shashank paused again. The earlier Shashank might have answered at once: "Yes, it is wrong."

"I would say that, for purposes of a legal conclusion, the translation is more definite than the original warrants. The original opens a possibility; it does not establish a legal status."

Aditya wrote the sentence exactly as he had said it.

The same file contained an annexure. In the Chinese original there was a term whose literal meaning was close to “the person exercising actual control,” but the English version had rendered it simply as “owner.” Shashank stopped his finger on the line.

“The same problem again,” he said. “Control and ownership are not identical. A person may influence decisions without necessarily being a shareholder or beneficial owner.”

Aditya asked, “But actual control can be an indicator of beneficial ownership?”

“It can be an indicator,” Shashank said, “but an indicator needs a valid relation to what is to be proved. What kind of control? Under what authority? For what period? With what economic benefit? None of that follows merely from translating a single term.”

Aditya placed the English annexure and the original side by side. “So this term can justify extending the inquiry?”

“Yes.”

“Can it become the conclusion?”

“Not by itself.”

After answering, Shashank felt a gentle pride inside. This was the very language for which he had practised for years—tone, context, terminology, legal meaning, commercial usage. For a moment he felt that among all the people sitting before Aditya, he saw this distinction most clearly.

At once he remembered Juliana’s sentence: “Truth is not your office.”

He added of his own accord, “My view should also be checked by an independent language expert. If another reader sees a different meaning from the context, that too should remain on the record.”

Aditya looked up. “You are saying this yourself?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because pride in language does not mean my translation is final. Pride is useful when I take responsibility for my words, not for my ego.”

Aditya smiled faintly. “I will not put that sentence into the statement. It will become too literary.”

“Fine,” Shashank said. “Let it remain in the mind.”

A little later, the company records were opened. The shareholders’ names, directors’ names, declared ownership, signing authority, and payment recipients were all in separate columns. One name appeared in two places but not in the third. One person had signed a contract but was not a shareholder. Another company was receiving payment, but its directors’ list was entirely different.

Shashank placed a finger on the paper. “My language-related work ends here.”

Aditya looked at him. “So soon?”

“What remains now concerns company records, the bank trail, and actual evidence of control. I can read the names and explain the terms, but declaring who the real owner is from all this is not my job.”

Aditya smiled faintly. “Could you have said that yesterday?”

Shashank smiled too. “Not yesterday. A few months ago, certainly not.”

During the lunch break, a message from Mrinal arrived: “Did VIVO’s gate open?”

Shashank replied: “The gate opened. The house now belongs to the records.”

The reply came immediately: “Less poetry. More facts.”

Shashank laughed. “Three vendors. Two linguistic similarities. One risky translation. Ownership still not established.”

Mrinal wrote: “This time it sounds right.”

Shashank put down the phone. Sometimes one sentence from a friend is sterner than an entire lecture.

After lunch Aditya opened a separate file. It contained travel details, a meeting invitation, and a description of services relating to Shashank’s earlier meeting with the betting-based app vendor—the meeting already discussed in court.

“This is separate from the Vivo service-contract file,” Aditya said at once. “I am keeping it separate. The only question is whether there is any documentary overlap of person, company, or payment recipient.”

Shashank read the names carefully. One business alias looked familiar. He remembered that something with a similar pronunciation had appeared in the Chinese text of the earlier contract.

The old quickness stirred inside him again. “This is the same—”

He stopped halfway through the sentence.

Aditya said nothing. He simply waited.

Shashank looked again at the original characters. “No. The pronunciation is close, but the characters are different. The English transliterations look almost the same. These may be two different names.”

“May be?”

“Yes. And even if they are the same person, that still requires separate proof.”

“What proof?”

“Identification records, registration records, directors’ lists, authorised signatures, contact records—whatever is lawfully available. Linguistic similarity alone is not enough.”

Aditya did not close the file. On the next page he showed a payment schedule. There were three different payment recipients, three different dates, and the same abbreviated notation in the remarks column.

Shashank’s eyes lit up. “This notation is identical in all three places.”

“Meaning?”

“Something like ‘service settlement.’ But it may also be an accounting category. The same remark does not establish the same payment route.”

Aditya said, “That is why tomorrow we will examine the financial records separately.”

“Tomorrow?”

“Yes. We have some payment-gateway records, names connected with third-party accounts, and a few references to cryptocurrency. At present they are only references. No conclusion.”

Shashank’s mind went suddenly to Mrinal. An old conversation came back—silence, friendship, payment trails, selected language.

“Is Mrinal’s name there?” he asked before he could stop himself.

Aditya did not answer immediately. “You are here at present as a language assistant. If any person’s name becomes formally relevant to your statement, you will be asked about it.”

Shashank felt embarrassed by his question. “All right.”

“This too is a boundary,” Aditya said. “Being close to an investigation does not give you the right to know everything.”

The pride he took in language was wounded again. He could read so many fine characters, distinguish so many shades of terminology, yet not every file was open to him. Once this would have felt unbearable. Today he understood: a boundary is not an insult to talent; it is a condition of process.

As he left the office in the evening, he turned once near the gate and looked back. The company’s name shone in large letters. Once, names like this had seemed to him like power—as though simply crossing the gate of a large company made a person important.

Today the gate seemed only a gate. Inside were contracts, vendors, employees, payments, records—and every relationship required its own evidence.

That night in Pitampura, after listening to him, Juliana asked, “Were you proud of your language today?”

“Yes.”

“Is pride bad?”

Shashank thought. “No. Not if it helps me see the boundaries of words more clearly.”

“And if pride tells you that your conclusion alone is final?”

“Then it is not pride. It is another form of greed.”

Juliana looked pleased. “In inference you look for the reason. Look for the reason inside yourself too.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

“Representative ≠ owner.”

“Payment recipient ≠ beneficial owner.”

“A linguistic term meaning recipient of benefit ≠ automatic proof of legal beneficial ownership.”

“Similar pronunciation ≠ same person.”

“Same remark ≠ same payment route.”

“Pride in language, if it marks boundaries, is discipline; if it seizes conclusions, it is deception.”

“The reason in an inference must be supported by records, not by desire.”

He stopped his pen. Aditya’s words about the next day returned to him—payment gateway, third-party account, references to cryptocurrency.

This time Shashank’s first thought was not: “If I am there, the mystery will open.” His first thought was: “Where does Mrinal stand?”

And that question was not about language. It was about friendship.

CHAPTER 43

THE CANTONESE DOOR 4

When Shashank reached Aditya's office the next day, the first question inside him was not about language. He could think only of Mrinal. The final question from the previous night—"Where does Mrinal stand?"—had not left his mind even after he slept.

Aditya motioned for him to sit. Three files lay on the table. One contained payment-gateway records, the second papers connected with a third-party account, and the third a collection of messages and financial references.

"I need language assistance with all of these," Aditya said, "but one thing first. The person whose name you are eager to know—I will not say it unless necessary."

Shashank's body stiffened slightly for a moment. "You understood?"

"Yesterday's question was very clear."

Shashank lowered his eyes. "Can friendship distort inference?"

"If the conclusion is fixed in advance, yes. Enmity can distort it; friendship can too."

Shashank nodded. When studying Navya-Nyaya he had debated reason, subject, probandum, and pervasion. Today it seemed to him that the hardest subject was not the paper but one's own mind.

Aditya placed the first paper before him. In the payment-gateway details, beneath the name of a service vendor, the account of a third company was listed as recipient. The name was not unfamiliar; it bore a phonetic resemblance to one line in the vendor list he had seen in the earlier context.

Shashank read the paper again. "The names resemble each other, but they are not the same."

"Meaning?"

"It could be an alias within the same business group. It could also be a separate company. Phonetic similarity raises a question; it does not establish identity."

Aditya wrote: "Name similarity: verification required."

"And this payment?" Shashank asked.

"The payment occurred. That much is established. The reason for the payment, the actual service, control of the account, and the ultimate identity of the person benefiting are separate questions."

Shashank smiled for a moment. "You remember my lesson better than I do."

"That is my job."

The second file contained several messages. In the English translation of one Chinese sentence, the word had been rendered as "medium." Shashank read the original line and said, "Here 'route' or 'medium' would be more appropriate. It could mean a payment gateway, a contact path, or an ordinary arrangement. It is not proper to choose a specific meaning without context."

"Why did the earlier translation say 'payment medium'?"

"The translator probably drew the meaning from the following line. But this sentence by itself is not that definite."

Aditya looked at him. "Have you done that in the past?"

The question was simple; the answer was not easy.

"I have," Shashank said. "When I thought the context was clear, I would reduce the range of possible meanings in the original and give one meaning. Sometimes for convenience. Sometimes to reduce questions."

"And now?"

"Now I would write: possible meaning. Definite meaning only when the context supports it."

Aditya wrote. No praise, no sarcasm. Shashank liked that. Atonement was not turned into a performance; only a record was made.

The third paper contained several references to cryptocurrency. There were some numbers, several dates, and two short comments. The moment Shashank saw the terms, he felt tension within. The days of media reports and incomplete allegations rose again in his memory.

"It would be easy to build a story merely from seeing this," he said.

"Then do not build a story," Aditya replied. "The references exist. The relation to actual transactions, ownership, source, and purpose still require separate verification."

Shashank rested his thumb on one comment. "This term can mean a 'layer,' but it does not automatically mean criminal financial 'layering.'"

"Correct. Record it that way."

Shashank wrote: "The linguistic term may mean 'layer/level'; it is not a conclusion of criminal layering."

As he wrote that sentence, he remembered the old form of his pride. Earlier, seeing such a term, he might have said: "I understand." Today he was writing: "Not yet."

Aditya played a short audio fragment. The Cantonese rhythm was rapid. Two people were speaking, but one pronoun was omitted in the middle of the sentence. The machine transcription had translated it directly as: "Send it from that account."

Shashank listened once, then a second time. The third time he closed his eyes and listened only to the sound.

"This translation is too definite," he said.

"The original?"

"Literally it is closer to 'send it that way.' But what 'that' refers to—an account, a record, a contact route, or some other object in the previous sentence—the audio fragment alone does not say."

"Then the machine is wrong?"

Shashank paused. "The machine chose one possibility. Calling it false would not be proper, but its certainty is unsupported."

Aditya wrote the sentence exactly.

"Does this audio establish a payment?"

"No."

"A third-party account?"

"No."

"Then what is its use?"

"If its time, speakers, surrounding messages, and actual financial records correspond, it can become a supporting reason. Not by itself."

Aditya said, "Inference often slips precisely here. A person builds the story first, then gives the words meanings that fit the story."

Shashank remembered his early days at the Red Fort, when he would understand half a tourist's sentence and infer the whole meaning. Then the cost of an error was at most a wrong direction, an unsuitable food order, or a brief laugh. Now an over-certain translation of a single word could attach an accusation to someone's name.

"The first pride in learning a language was—'I understand,'" he said softly. "The second pride was—'I understand more than everyone.' Now I think the third lesson is the courage to say how much I do not understand."

Aditya said, "You may add that to your statement if you want. Not as philosophy—as a practical limit."

Shashank laughed. "You stop me from writing poetry too."

"In the record, yes."

Both laughed for a moment. The tension eased slightly.

Then Aditya opened a fourth paper. It contained an extract from an old conversation seized from Shashank's own phone. Mrinal's name appeared at the top.

For a moment Shashank's breath caught.

Aditya made no attempt to read his face. He simply turned the paper towards him.

The conversation was old. Shashank had once mentioned an ambiguous payment proposal, and Mrinal had replied: "Do not attach your name to something that is not clear on paper. If anything seems unusual, ask for a written clarification."

Shashank read the whole extract. Something softened behind his eyes.

"Here Mrinal is stopping me," he said.

"Yes," Aditya said. "That is all this extract shows."

"Then his name—"

"In this extract his name is connected with advice, not with a crime. But one extract cannot decide the whole person."

Shashank felt immediate relief rise inside him. Along with the relief came another voice: See? Mrinal is innocent.

He stopped himself.

"I am crossing the boundary again," he said.

For the first time Aditya smiled faintly. "Say it."

"This conversation establishes that in this context he advised me to seek written clarity. It does not permit a conclusion about his entire life, all his conduct, or his other work."

"Here the inference is moving in the right direction."

Shashank took a deep breath. Friendship was eager to give him certainty; method was fixing the boundary of that certainty.

After noon he met Mrinal. They sat facing each other in a small restaurant in Delhi. The moment Mrinal saw his face, he asked, "Did you see the name?"

Shashank was startled. "Who told you?"

"Your face."

Shashank remained silent.

Mrinal lifted his cup of tea. "Do not tell me anything about the investigation. But tell me this much—you are not trying to save me, are you?"

"I am your friend."

"So?"

"So the mind wants to protect first."

Mrinal looked at him for a few moments. "Do you remember when you first went to Noida for work? You said: 'Without me these people will not understand one another.' Even then I told you that knowing a language is power, but when that power begins to rule over your friend as well, there is a problem."

Shashank smiled slowly. "You said many things long ago that I understood very late."

"I do not understand everything correctly either," Mrinal said. "Remember that. One danger in friendship is that we turn each other into heroes. Do not take responsibility for proving me innocent. I will not take responsibility for proving you innocent. Each person's acts, each person's facts."

"Then what does friendship do?"

"When facts are bitter, it does not run away. When an accusation grows larger than the evidence, it does not remain silent. When one's friend lies, it does not applaud."

For a few moments Shashank's eyes rested on the steam rising from the tea. Suddenly friendship seemed to him not a soft thing but a hard discipline.

Mrinal set down the cup. "Let friendship protect, but not by hiding the truth."

Shashank kept looking at him.

"And one more thing," Mrinal said. "If my name appears somewhere, say what you actually know. What you do not know, do not invent in order to protect me. A false inference in a friend's favour is also a betrayal."

The sentence sank very deep into Shashank. Betrayal is not only against a friend; distorting truth in a friend's favour can also be betrayal.

"You teach me very hard lessons," Shashank said.

"You studied Navya-Nyaya. I am only a friend."

Both laughed. It was a small laugh, but amid the strain of so many days, old friendship appeared again inside that brief sound.

That evening in Pitampura, Juliana listened to Shashank's account. She asked, "Is friendship the enemy of inference?"

"No."

"Then?"

"If friendship becomes a prior conclusion, it is an enemy. If friendship gives the strength to endure truth, it helps."

Juliana nodded. "The same happens in language. When a translator likes a word, he enlarges its meaning. When he dislikes it, he reduces it. Love and fear can both distort meaning."

Shashank asked, "Then is impartiality the absence of love?"

"No. Impartiality is the discipline of love."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

"Friendship $\neq$ evidence."

"A friend's advice $\neq$ proof of the friend's entire conduct."

"Payment $\neq$ proof of purpose."

"Third-party account $\neq$ automatically someone else's account."

"Reference to cryptocurrency $\neq$ proof of criminal layering."

"Linguistic 'route' $\neq$ necessarily a payment gateway."

"In inference, let the reason be the record—not affection or fear."

He wrote the final line:

“Friendship should not hide truth; it should give the courage to endure truth.”

As he stopped his pen, a message from Aditya arrived on his phone: “Tomorrow we will examine old records relating to foreign travel, notes from the Macao meeting, and details of limited server access.”

Shashank remained still for a while after reading the message. With the word Macao, the old shadow of temptation rose again—special access, foreign travel, importance, the desire to see the world inside.

Mrinal's sentence from that day sounded again in his mind: “A false inference in a friend's favour is also a betrayal.”

Shashank understood: tomorrow's test would not be friendship. Tomorrow the test would again be greed.

CHAPTER 44

THE CANTONESE DOOR 5

The night after reading Aditya's message, Shashank remained awake for a long time. Macao no longer came to his mind merely as the name of a city. With it returned the glittering hotel corridors, foreign representatives seated beyond glass, controlled computer screens, signs of limited access, and the old sentences that had once risen within him: "I understand this language," "I understand what this system means," "Without me these people will not understand one another."

Now he knew that those three sentences were not the same.

Understanding a language was one thing.
Understanding the limits of a system was another.
Believing oneself indispensable was a third.

At dawn he gathered together his old travel records, written notes from the Macao meeting, access-permission letter, and his handwritten comments from that time. Some papers bore his old signature. Some carried Chinese phrases. Some pages contained sentences which, read today, seemed to give off the scent of his earlier pride.

One note said: "Special access available."

For a long time he kept his eyes fixed on those two words.

Special access.

Today he understood that when he had written the word "special," he had not been recording the boundary of the evidence; he had been recording his own importance.

When he reached the investigation office, Aditya had arranged the records in three separate sets.

"First—travel," he said.
"Second—the meeting."
"Third—system access."

Shashank nodded.

Aditya slid his old note towards him. "You wrote this—'special access'?"

"Yes."

"Meaning?"

Shashank paused for a few moments before answering. "At the time I felt that, compared with an ordinary interpreter, I had been given more direct visibility."

"Visibility?"

"The chance to see a limited demonstration of the system."

"Then why 'special access'?"

Shashank looked at the paper. "Because I exaggerated the importance of my experience when I wrote it."

For a few moments there was silence in the room.

Aditya asked again, "Did that access give you the right to see all customer accounts?"

"No."

"All payment routes?"

"No."

"Administrative control?"

"No."

"Authority to alter primary data?"

"No."

"Then it was a limited demonstration?"

"Yes."

Aditya wrote a note: "According to the witness, 'special access' was his personal description; the available record shows permission for a limited demonstration."

Shashank read the sentence. A slight pain rose inside him. His old pride had now been reduced to one line of administrative correction.

But there was no humiliation in becoming smaller in this way. For a moment an unpolished word rose in his mind, but he stopped it. "Perhaps—this was purification," he said to himself.

Aditya opened the second paper. "Was the betting-based app vendor present at this Macao meeting?"

"There was a representative of a company by that name."

"Was it the same institution that appeared in the Vivo service contract?"

"No. According to the records I have seen, it was a separate institution."

"Any person common to both?"

"The name of one technical coordinator appeared in both places. But the same name does not establish the same person. And even if it were the same person, that would not establish common ownership of the two institutions."

Aditya did not smile, but there was approval in his eyes. "Inference?"

Shashank said, "The reason is insufficient."

"Pervasion?"

"Not established."

"Conclusion?"

"Withhold it."

Those three short answers reminded him of Gangesha's school: seeing smoke and inferring fire. But what if the smoke was dust? What if the place had changed? What if the rule connecting the two had not been established?

Navya-Nyaya did not merely teach one how to reach conclusions. It also taught one how to stop them.

In the afternoon an old audio fragment was played. At the Macao meeting a Chinese representative had said: "Next time we will show you the inside part as well."

The earlier Shashank had treated that sentence as a victory.

Today he listened to the recording again.

Aditya asked, "The 'inside part'?"

"The meaning is uncertain."

"Why?"

"In context it could mean a more detailed demonstration of the system. It could mean an administrative level. It could also mean commercial details. This sentence alone does not determine the level."

"What did you understand at the time?"

"I understood that I would receive greater access."

"And the record?"

"The record does not say that much."

Aditya asked, "The difference between your inference then and your inference today?"

Shashank answered, "Then desire had taken the place of the reason. Today I do not treat desire as evidence."

Something trembled inside him as he said it. This was not merely an answer in an investigation. It was testimony against his former self.

In the evening he met Mrinal. They sat at a small tea stall beside the road.

Mrinal asked, "Macao has been opened again?"

"The old records."

"What did you find?"

"In my own note, I had made myself larger than the record."

Mrinal turned the cup in his hands. "You understood that only today?"

"I had understood some of it before. Today I saw the evidence."

"What evidence?"

"What I had called 'special access' was actually a limited demonstration."

Mrinal did not laugh. "Greed does not always look like water spilling from your hands. Sometimes it looks like a word—you add one adjective and make yourself larger."

Shashank remained silent.

Mrinal continued, "Greed for money is easy to recognise. Greed for importance is harder."

"Why?"

“Because greed for importance can hide itself in the form of a virtue—‘I am useful,’ ‘I am an expert,’ ‘They trusted me.’ All of those may be true. But what if inside those truths slips the thought: ‘Therefore I may cross the boundary?’”

Shashank set down his cup. “Then truth itself becomes the covering for greed.”

Mrinal nodded.

That night, sitting with Juliana in Pitampura, Shashank repeated the same thought.

Juliana asked, “What attracted you most in Macao?”

“Not foreign travel.”

“Money?”

“Not that either.”

“Then?”

After a few moments Shashank said, “Permission to look inside.”

“Why?”

“Because I thought whoever sees the inside knows more.”

Juliana said softly, “And the one who knows more?”

“Becomes more important.”

“And the one who becomes more important?”

Shashank was silent.

Juliana did not finish the sentence for him. The silence waited for Shashank’s answer.

At last he said, “He may begin to think the rules are looser for him.”

Juliana said, “That is where greed is born.”

On the wooden table before her lay two sheets. On one, in Chinese characters, was written “access.” On the other: “authority.”

Juliana said, “The two words may stand beside the same door. But one is not the other.”

Shashank smiled. “Access is not authority.”

“And authority is not ownership.”

“Ownership is not crime.”

“And crime is not established by inference alone.”

For a few moments both were silent.

Juliana pushed towards him a copy of an old translation lying on the table. In it Shashank had translated one Chinese term as “internal control panel,” even though in the original context it could also have meant “the later part of the demonstration.”

“Why did you choose the stronger meaning then?” Juliana asked.

Shashank read the page. “Because during the meeting that was the meaning I expected.”

“Meaning the expectation arrived before the word?”

“Yes.”

“Was this error merely a deficiency in language skill?”

“No. I knew enough of the language. The problem was that I treated my desire as context.”

Juliana said, “Scholarship does not free a person from error. Sometimes scholarship merely teaches one to give more beautiful reasons for the error.”

Shashank did not fold the page or push it away. He kept it in front of him.

“If you translated it again today?” Juliana asked.

“I would write: ‘internal part of the demonstration’ or ‘later management panel’; if the context were insufficient, I would preserve both possibilities.”

“Would that reduce your importance?”

“Perhaps.”

“Then?”

“It would increase the honesty of the meaning.”

Juliana nodded.

Then Juliana asked, “What is the greed of inference?”

Shashank answered, “To treat the story that attracts me as the reason.”

“And the greed of the translator?”

“To think that because I opened the meaning, the key to the truth is mine as well.”

Juliana said, “Remember—language can open the door. It does not become the owner of what is inside.”

The next day, at Aditya's office, the Macao meeting papers were opened again. This time a small travel-allowance entry, a hotel reservation, and a technical demonstration permit were placed before him.

Aditya asked, "What do these three together establish?"

Shashank said, "That the journey took place, the meeting was arranged, and there was permission for a limited demonstration."

"What do they not establish?"

"That I had administrative control. That I saw payment routes. That I was part of some secret system. That the Vivo service contract and the app vendor were part of the same network. That my presence in Macao establishes a criminal purpose."

Aditya asked, "Then why investigate?"

"Because some language, names of persons, and chronology raise questions."

"Are those questions accusations?"

"No."

"And is an accusation an established fact?"

"No."

Aditya put down his pen. "The entire matter may stand on this distinction."

Shashank replied, "And an entire life as well."

At that moment a message from Raghav Bhasin arrived. It was brief: "The earlier confidential legal review connected with the Macao consultancy has surfaced again. The boundaries of certain records have to be determined. Be present, but first have your role clarified in writing."

Shashank read the message.

In earlier days he would have thought immediately: the matter cannot proceed without me.

Today his first thought was: "What is my role?"

Second: "What constitutes confidential legal advice?"

Third: "What is actual conduct?"

And fourth: "How far do I have the authority to speak?"

Those four questions were blocking the four directions of greed.

That night he wrote in his notebook:

"Foreign travel ≠ proof of purpose."

"Macao meeting ≠ proof of criminal connection."

"Limited access ≠ control."

"Access ≠ authority."

"Authority ≠ ownership."

"Same person's name ≠ same institution."

"An attractive story ≠ a proved inference."

"The reason in an inference must come from the record, not desire."

He paused for a while, then wrote:

"Greed is not only for money. The desire to know more, see more, and become more important is greed too."

And the final line:

"An open door does not make the house mine."

As he closed his pen, a second message from Raghav arrived: "Tomorrow questions will arise about the boundary between confidential advice and possible actual participation."

Shashank read the line.

After the greed of Macao, the chapter of fear now stood before him.

CHAPTER 45

THE CANTONESE DOOR 6

The morning after Raghav Bhasin's message, an old fear awoke again inside Shashank. It was not fear of a summons, nor of court, nor of the media. It was fear of the question that is hardest when a person asks it of himself: was what I did only language work, or did I also play a part in changing the direction of the work itself?

The meeting at Raghav's office was fixed for ten. Shashank arrived early. Sunlight fell on the glass of the reception area. Everything inside was orderly, calm, professional. Yet in his mind sharp questions rose like the corners of paper.

Raghav came in and said, "Before the meeting begins, let us define your role in writing."

Shashank opened his notebook.

Raghav read aloud: "Shashank Jha will provide linguistic assistance; he will not give legal advice; he will not decide the truth of facts; and he will issue no business instruction."

Shashank asked, "Was it necessary to state it this explicitly?"

"Today it is necessary," Raghav replied. "Because in the older records the roles are not always clear."

"Confidentiality?"

Raghav looked at him. "The moment people hear the word confidentiality, they often think everything has gone under the same blanket. But first I want to understand which communication is for legal advice, which is merely translation, and which is part of actual business conduct."

Shashank's hand became still at the corner of the notebook.

Raghav continued, "Changing the label does not change the nature. Writing 'legal review' over an ordinary operational message does not turn it into legal advice."

The sentence entered Shashank deeply. He remembered an earlier meeting where the boundary between confidentiality and selective silence had first wounded him.

There were three people in the meeting: an Indian representative of the company, an outside accounting adviser, and Raghav. Shashank sat in the fourth chair as interpreter.

The first paper was an old annexure to the Vivo-related service contract. The second was a note from a meeting with a separate betting-based application vendor. The third was new: selected extracts from several messages whose subject line read, "For legal review."

Shashank's eyes stopped on that subject line.

Raghav asked, "What happened?"

"Was this wording added later?"

The Indian representative said, "I do not remember."

Raghav said at once, "Then we will not infer. We will examine the original timestamp and version."

Shashank remained silent, but an old habit rose in his mind—on seeing that subject line, he wanted to treat the whole message chain as legal communication, because that classification reduced his own fear.

The Indian representative read one message: "Send the details of the previous vendor route through the lawyer."

Raghav said, "This sentence has three possibilities. First: an instruction to send records for genuine legal review. Second: the lawyer was chosen merely as a convenient channel. Third: someone thought that adding a lawyer's name would change the nature of the paper. At present, none of the three is established."

While translating, Shashank stopped at the word meaning "through." In the Chinese original, the term could mean "route," "communication path," or "delivered by someone."

The Indian representative grew impatient. "Give a simple translation."

The old fear rose inside Shashank—if he wrote the ambiguity, people would say he was making the work complicated; if he selected one easy meaning, the meeting would move faster.

He said, "The original term is not univocal. I will write: 'send through/by the lawyer'; in brackets I will note that the original can also mean a communication path."

Raghav nodded.

Displeasure appeared on the Indian representative's face, but he said nothing.

The next message contained one sentence: "Share only the necessary part of the old conversation."

The sentence deepened Shashank's fear.

Necessary for whom? Necessary for a legal question? Or merely enough that fewer questions would arise?

Raghav asked, "Context?"

The accounting adviser said, "The two preceding messages are missing."

"Then this one sentence does not establish the purpose," Raghav said. "The missing context must be found."

A rule from the earlier chapter rose in Shashank's mind—limited access $\neq$ control. A new rule was now being added: limited quotation $\neq$ complete intention.

Raghav then placed before him one of Shashank's old notes. A year earlier Shashank had written: "Language softened for legal review."

Shashank's chest grew slightly heavy.

Raghav asked, "Is this your handwritten note?"

"Yes."

"What did 'softened language' mean?"

Before answering, Shashank held his breath. This was the point at which fear could become self-defence.

"I translated harsh commercial terms into less confrontational words."

"On legal advice?"

"I do not remember any explicit legal advice for this particular note."

The Indian representative interrupted: "But this was found in the legal-review folder."

Shashank looked at him. "The folder name is one fact about the source. It is not complete proof of my purpose."

Raghav asked calmly, "Why did you soften it?"

Two answers fought inside Shashank. One protected him: 'style.' The other hurt him: 'the desire to reduce questions.'

He chose the second.

"Sometimes I wanted the Indian side not to ask too many questions. Making the language easier seemed useful to me."

The room fell silent.

Raghav said, "This admission establishes that you softened the language. It does not by itself establish that you were concealing a crime. But the purpose still requires examination."

Shashank nodded.

His fear did not diminish. But its shape changed. Earlier the fear was: if I admit this, everything will be destroyed. Now the fear was: if I abandon the boundary of truth, I myself will be destroyed.

In the second part of the meeting, a new request came. The Indian representative said, "There is an old operational message. If we place it in the legal-review chain, the sequence will look cleaner."

Raghav's expression did not change. "First tell me why the message was created."

"There was a discussion about changing the name of the payment recipient."

"Was legal advice requested?"

"No. It was an operational decision."

"Then its original nature is an operational message. Sending it to me later does not change the nature it had when it was born."

A cold sensation ran down Shashank's spine. Had he heard such a sentence in earlier days, it would probably have made him uncomfortable. He would have wanted the danger to diminish merely by writing: "Lawyer will review."

Raghav looked at Shashank. "Translate it, but do not add the words 'legal instruction.'"

"They are not in the original," Shashank said.

"Then they will not be in the translation."

Such a simple sentence. Yet for Shashank it was a deep lesson.

The first rule of inference: do not add, for convenience, what is not present.

When the meeting ended, Raghav stopped him.

"Are you afraid?"

Shashank did not try to laugh. "Yes."

"Of what?"

"Less of the investigation. More of the question of how much of my old work was language and how much was influence over decisions."

Raghav said, “That is a proper question. But the answer will not be one colour. In some places you may have been only an interpreter. In some places you may have added your own view. In some places the boundary may be blurred. Examine each context separately.”

“And confidentiality?”

“Do not turn confidentiality into a veranda for fear. Where there is genuinely an exchange of legal advice, respect its boundary. Where there is actual conduct, do not try to hide it merely by changing the name.”

Shashank was silent for a few moments.

Raghav continued, “I am not omniscient either. Whether a communication is protected depends on facts, purpose, and the applicable process. That is why I look first at the source, not at the classification.”

Shashank liked the sentence. Raghav too was acknowledging the limits of his own role.

After leaving the office, Shashank wrote to Mrinal: “Can we meet?”

Mrinal replied: “Evening.”

They sat on the veranda of a quiet tea shop. Shashank did not disclose the confidential details. He spoke only about the shape of his fear.

“I am afraid that in the past I sometimes moved operational matters closer to legal language.”

Mrinal asked, “Knowing?”

“Not always. Sometimes for convenience. Sometimes to make myself appear important. Sometimes to reduce questions.”

“And now?”

“Now I understand that changing the name does not change the nature of the act.”

Mrinal placed the teacup on the table. “Then fear can be useful.”

“Fear useful?”

“If fear takes you away from truth, it is poison. If it shows you the boundary, it is a warning.”

Shashank smiled. “You have started speaking like Juliana.”

Mrinal laughed for the first time. “And sometimes you have started listening.”

That night the meeting with Juliana in Pitampura was brief. Shashank said, “Today I understood that confidentiality too can become a net made of words.”

Juliana asked, “Why the word ‘net’?”

“Because the mind wants to say: once I give it a name, everything inside is safe.”

“Is that inference or desire?”

“Often desire.”

Juliana wrote two words on a sheet: “name” and “nature.”

“The same?”

“No.”

“Then a legal label?”

“Not proof of the nature.”

“And something marked confidential?”

“Not by itself proof of innocence.”

“And something marked open?”

“Not by itself proof of crime.”

Juliana smiled. “You are learning inference.”

Shashank said, “More than inference, I am learning to stop inference.”

“Method matures on the day a person learns not only to make conclusions, but also to stop improper ones.”

The next day there was a short formal question-and-answer session in Aditya’s office. Raghav was present. Shashank first submitted his role in writing: linguistic assistance, not determination of facts.

Aditya showed him a message whose subject line read: “Legal review.” Inside, the original text discussed an operational change to the payment recipient.

“What would you call this message?” Aditya asked.

Shashank replied, “The subject line says ‘legal review.’ The text inside is an operational discussion. Those are two facts. I will not decide the legal status of the communication from those two facts alone.”

“Why?”

“Because name and nature need not be the same. Purpose, context, sender and recipient, time, and actual use all have to be examined.”

Aditya asked, “Your inference?”

“The classification of this message raises a question. The existence of the question is not the answer.”

Raghav said nothing, but there was agreement in his eyes.

A second record contained an old translation by Shashank: "Send through the legal route." The Chinese original was broader: "Send through the designated medium."

Aditya asked, "Why did you add the word 'legal'?"

Shashank did not remain silent for long.

"Because there was discussion involving a lawyer in the surrounding context. I merged the context into the original term."

"Was that proper?"

"No. The translation should have kept the original term and the context separate."

"Was this an attempt knowingly to conceal something?"

Shashank replied, "That is not established by this single record. My error is established—I added meaning that was not in the term. A conclusion about purpose requires other evidence."

Aditya wrote it down.

Shashank's fear rose again, but this time fear was not writing his answer for him.

At the end of the questioning, Aditya read out three lines:

"One: in Shashank's old translation, the word 'legal' is more specific than the original term."

"Two: the reason for this additional specificity remains under examination."

"Three: this translation difference alone does not establish criminal participation."

Shashank said, "Correct."

Aditya asked, "Anything to add?"

"One line."

"Go ahead."

"I take responsibility for this error; but please keep the error within the boundary where the evidence places it."

Aditya looked at him. "Are you asking that for yourself, or for everyone?"

Shashank paused for a moment.

"For everyone."

As he left the office, a message from Mrinal arrived: "What happened?"

Shashank wrote: "There was fear. But because of the fear, the boundary became clearer."

Mrinal replied: "That is a good fear. Only do not let it become your master."

Shashank smiled as he read it. His attention stopped on the word "master." Language, confidentiality, advice, translation—human beings want to become masters of everything. Perhaps fear was the reverse face of that desire: wanting control over everything one was trying to protect.

That night he wrote in his notebook:

"Marked confidential ≠ confidentiality established."

"Presence of a lawyer ≠ legal advice established."

"Legal advice ≠ a device for renaming actual conduct."

"Interpreter ≠ adviser, unless that role has been explicitly given."

"Inference requires a relationship, not a label."

"Hiding truth because of fear = slavery to fear."

"Writing the boundary because of fear = caution."

He wrote the final line:

"Do not make the word that protects me larger than the truth."

As he closed his pen, a new message from Aditya arrived. An officer of the lower commissionerate had stated in writing that examination of certain records should continue; at the same time, an oral instruction from a higher level to reduce the priority had again been recorded.

Shashank read the message.

After the fear of confidentiality, the shadow of betrayal had returned.

CHAPTER 46

THE CANTONESE DOOR 7

Shashank read the final message three times through the night. An officer of the lower commissionerate had stated in writing that the examination should continue. On the same day, an oral communication from a higher level had been recorded: reduce the priority.

Two lines. Two directions. The same matter between them.

Shashank's first reaction was anger. The second—fear. The third, and the most uncomfortable, was memory.

How many times had he himself softened language because he wanted fewer questions? How many times had he turned a hard phrase such as “verification remains pending” into something lighter like “the matter will become clear”? Now, seeing such alteration in institutional papers, he saw the shadow of his own former hand.

At dawn a message from Aditya arrived: “Come at eleven. We have to compare two versions.”

Shashank arrived on time. Three files lay separately on Aditya's desk. The first was labelled: “Vivo-related service contract.” The second: “Separate betting-based application vendor.” The third: “Internal summary.”

Aditya said first, “We will not treat all three as one.”

Keeping a physical distance between the first two files, he said, “What is in the record of the Vivo-related service contract is limited to that record. What is in the separate betting-vendor file has its own boundary. The same translator, some similar technical terms, or meetings in the same city do not by themselves establish ownership, a payment relationship, or a criminal connection between the two institutions.”

Shashank said, “But what if the name of a third payment recipient appears in both?”

“Then the name is verified. Name ≠ person; person ≠ role; role ≠ ownership. A documentary link is needed to establish a relationship.”

Shashank liked the severity of this separation. It reminded him of his own old habit—seeing two similar words and building an entire story.

“I know,” Shashank said.

Aditya looked at him. “Knowing and accepting are two different things.”

Shashank did not reply.

The first file contained the old service-contract records whose language Shashank had examined many times: payments, repairs, language assistance, representation—all within limited contexts. The second contained the meeting with the separate vendor, a demonstration, names of payment recipients, and several ambiguous technical comments. The third contained a summary prepared by an officer of the lower commissionerate.

Aditya read the first version: “No direct ownership relationship between the two commercial pathways has yet been established; verification remains pending regarding certain similar linguistic terms and the mention of a third payment recipient.”

Shashank nodded.

Aditya placed the second version before him. The sentence had changed: “No relationship was found between the two commercial pathways.”

Shashank's eyes remained fixed on that line.

“Those are not the same thing,” he said at once.

“Why?”

“‘No direct ownership relationship has been established’ means the evidence is not yet sufficient. ‘No relationship was found’ is broader. The first sentence states the boundary of the inquiry; the second sounds like a conclusion.”

Aditya asked, “Is the second sentence false?”

Shashank paused. Anger was pushing him towards yes.

“I cannot say that yet,” he finally said. “Because the word ‘relationship’ is itself broad. But the caution present in the first version is absent from the second.”

Aditya wrote: “Caution removed.” Then he asked, “Deliberately?”

“That is not established.”

“By whom?”

“I will not say without seeing the version history.”

"Did the language change?"

"Yes. That is a direct fact."

"Purpose?"

"Inference."

Aditya put down his pen. "Good."

Something broke inside Shashank. He had expected Aditya to say: See? There was a compromise. But Aditya did not go as far as the word for which there was no evidence. In that restraint Shashank remembered his own earlier lack of restraint.

"It feels like betrayal to me," Shashank said.

"Betrayal of what?"

"Of the record. Of the inquiry. Of the words."

Aditya remained calm. "A feeling can be recorded, but it cannot become the conclusion. Feeling betrayed is one thing; establishing collusion by an officer is another."

Shashank leaned back in his chair.

Aditya opened the original note from the lower commissionerate. The officer had written: "Do not close the separate vendor file; questions remain concerning the payment recipient's name and actual control."

The clerk who recorded the oral communication from the higher level had written: "Reduce the priority of the matter; the direct tax impact is not clear at present."

Shashank asked, "Was that an order?"

"At present I do not have a written order," Aditya said. "There is a recorded oral communication. Its source, authority, and context will be verified."

"If a senior officer said it orally?"

"Even then we must see whether it was an administrative priority decision or an instruction to stop the investigation. Those are not the same thing."

"But look at the timing. The summary changed on the same day."

Aditya replied, "Similarity in time can provide a reason for inference. It is not pervasion. Two events occurred on the same day—that is a fact. That one caused the other is still an inference."

Shashank remained silent. An old lesson of Navya-Nyaya awakened within him: if the reason is not bound to the probandum by a valid relation, the conclusion stands in the air.

Meanwhile, the officer of the lower commissionerate who had written the first note entered the room himself. His face looked tired, but his voice was steady. Aditya warned him first: "We will ask only about the sequence of the process. No inference against anyone."

The officer opened his own copy. "I wrote: questions remain about the payment recipient's name and actual control. I did not have evidence establishing ownership. Therefore I also had no basis for closing the file."

Shashank asked, "Did you receive a written order to reduce the priority?"

"No. An oral communication came saying that the tax impact was unclear, so resources should be placed elsewhere."

"What did you do?" Aditya asked.

"I recorded that verification remained pending. I also wrote that priority could be an administrative decision, not a factual conclusion."

"After that?"

"In the final summary, my word 'pending' was no longer there."

The room was silent for a moment. Anger rose again in Shashank. There was pain in the officer's voice, and that pain seemed to confirm Shashank's feeling of betrayal. But he remembered a line in his own notebook: feeling is not external evidence.

Aditya asked the officer, "In your view, was it removed deliberately?"

The officer paused. "It feels that way to me. But feeling is not proof."

Shashank looked at him. The answer gave him a strange calm. Resistance here did not mean a heroic declaration; it meant only that the officer was unwilling to abandon the boundary of his original words.

Aditya said, "The original copy, version history, and distribution trail will be attached to this statement. The officer's impression will be recorded separately."

Shashank thought: this patience is why a small note written at a lower level can sometimes become a vast institutional memory.

Aditya showed him the third record. It was a bilingual summary quoting some of Shashank's old translated terms. In the Chinese original, the phrase meant: "further verification required." In the English summary it had become: "further review optional." In a handwritten Maithili note someone had written: "not necessary."

Shashank's face hardened.

"There are three levels here," he said. "Original—'verification required.' English—'further review optional.' Handwritten note—'not necessary.' The meaning has been weakened step by step."

"Was it deliberate?" Aditya asked again.

Shashank almost snapped. "Why do you ask this every time?"

"Because your anger keeps supplying the purpose."

The sentence was sharp, but not insulting.

Shashank took a long breath. "Fine. The change in language is direct. The purpose remains unknown."

"And the translator's past history?"

Shashank looked at him.

Aditya said, "You yourself have softened language. Does that allow us to assume that whoever softened the language here was concealing a crime?"

The question hurt Shashank, but it was fair.

"No," he said. "My old error does not establish such a general rule."

"That is why inference requires discipline."

By noon the version history had been assembled. It showed that the summary had passed through three hands. The first officer had written cautious language. A second officer had shortened the sentence. At a third level the final line had been changed again. But there was no explicit comment explaining why any of the changes had been made.

Shashank stopped when he saw one name. That officer had earlier handled an administrative review in a Vivo-related service matter as well.

"This name means something," Shashank said.

Aditya asked, "What?"

"He was in both matters."

"That much."

"But—"

"That much," Aditya repeated. "One person appearing in two files is a fact. Shared plan, bias, collusion—none of that follows automatically."

Shashank heard his own formula returned to him: same name $\neq$ same role; same role $\neq$ same purpose.

As he stepped out of the office, Mrinal called.

"What happened?"

Shashank said, "The language of the paper was weakened. The edge of the investigation's question was blunted. But I still cannot say why."

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. "How much did it hurt?"

"A great deal."

"Why?"

"Because it feels as though truth was betrayed."

"Or did you see your former self in that paper?"

Shashank fell silent.

Mrinal said softly, "When you softened language to reduce questions, perhaps you too thought you were merely making things easier. Now when someone else does it, you see betrayal."

"Are you saying this is right?"

"No. I am saying: look at the facts first. Do not write another person's purpose with your own guilt."

Shashank's anger eased slightly.

That evening at the Tao temple in Pitampura, he said one sentence to Juliana: "Today I saw my old shadow in someone else's paper."

Juliana asked, "What does a shadow prove?"

"The light?"

"Its direction. Its shape. But not whose body cast it."

Shashank smiled. "You too are teaching inference."

"No," Juliana said. "I am only saying: do not assume the same body because you see the same shadow."

On a sheet she wrote: "Betrayal may be an experience. Collusion is a conclusion."

Shashank read it.

"The difference?"

“The first is born inside you. The second requires evidence outside you.”

That night Shashank wrote in his notebook:

“Verification pending ≠ no relationship.”

“Language weakened = change established.”

“Change made deliberately = still an inference.”

“Same officer in two files = presence.”

“Presence ≠ collusion.”

“Oral change of priority = procedural fact.”

“Purpose of stopping the inquiry = requires separate evidence.”

“Do not dress the feeling of betrayal as an established fact.”

He wrote the final line: “The discipline of inference becomes hardest when the conclusion is morally attractive to me.”

Before he could close his pen, a message from Aditya arrived: “A new problem.”

Shashank read it.

“A cropped extract from the internal summary has reached a media reporter. He is asking for your name.”

Shashank’s hand became still.

A second message followed: “The cropped extract omits the cautionary line. It shows only that ‘the same translator’ was present in both the Vivo-related service contract and the separate betting-based vendor matter.”

Immediately afterwards, a question arrived from an unknown number: “Were you the linguistic link between the two networks?”

Shashank did not reply for a long time.

The shadow of betrayal was now moving towards the shape of public humiliation.

CHAPTER 47

THE CANTONESE DOOR 8

Until half past ten that night Shashank did not reply. The question from the unknown number remained fixed on the phone screen: “Were you the linguistic link between the two networks?”

The question was short, but it contained its conclusion in advance. “Two networks.” “Link.” Two expressions whose truth had not yet been verified.

Shashank’s first impulse was to write: “This is completely false.” His second was to demand the reporter’s name and threaten a defamation case. The third impulse was the hardest: before answering, he would first examine the boundary of his own sentence.

He set the phone aside.

A message from Mrinal arrived: “Did you reply?”

“No.”

“Good. First decide what you can deny, and what you cannot.”

The fire of humiliation rose inside Shashank. “I am being presented like a criminal.”

“It is humiliating,” Mrinal wrote, “but in resisting humiliation, do not deny your old mistakes. You were involved in the Vivo-related service contract. You also met a separate betting-based vendor as an interpreter. Those are two facts. ‘A link between two networks’ is a third claim. That third claim requires separate evidence.”

Shashank kept looking at the screen for a long time.

At that moment he understood that friendship is sometimes not consolation but a boundary.

At dawn an online headline spread with his name: “One Translator, Two Business Circles: A New Link in Sealed Records?”

There was a question mark at the end of the headline, but the paragraphs inside were more definite than the punctuation. The article said that sealed internal material contained Shashank’s name in both the Vivo-related service-contract matter and the matter of a betting-based application vendor. It then referred to a “possible coordinating role.”

Shashank read it three times.

The first time in anger.

The second in humiliation.

The third like a translator.

On the third reading, he saw that the article had blended three levels: his presence by name in sealed records, the meaning of a cropped extract, and the author’s inference.

Meanwhile, his old teacher from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan called. He had seen the news.

“Did one word catch your attention?” the teacher asked.

“Link?”

“Yes. The news says ‘link.’ In ordinary language it suggests a relationship. But from the standpoint of reasoning, the word is not by itself a valid reason. Unless the kind of link—linguistic, commercial, financial, personal—is specified, the reader will fill in the relationship he wants.”

Shashank remained silent.

“That you were present in two places may be a fact,” the teacher said. “But presence in both places does not make an inference of common ownership valid unless the necessary connecting relation between them is established. Journalism may ask questions; but when the grammar of the question begins to sound like a conclusion, the reader must be cautious.”

“Should I make a public statement?”

“First measure your sentence. Humiliation will urge you to write a broad denial. Truth is usually narrow.”

After the call, Shashank remembered his student days: the meaning of a word is formed not only in the dictionary but in its relation to use. Today that same lesson stood between him and his reputation.

He did not call Aditya. He wrote only: “Did this cropped extract come from genuine material?”

The answer came: “Not established yet. Come to the office.”

On the table in Aditya’s room, four papers had been kept apart.

“One,” he said, “the index of the original sealed file. Two, the cropped image published in the media article. Three, an older version of the internal summary available with us. Four, the current verified version.”

Shashank asked, “Is the cropped image genuine?”

“That question is not yet answered.”

“But the letters look the same.”

“Similar lettering does not establish the source.”

Shashank fell silent. He remembered Juliana’s sentence: do not assume the same body merely because you see the same shadow.

Aditya placed his thumb on the cropped image. “Here it says: ‘The same translator was present in two different commercial contexts.’ That sentence was in the old summary. But the next line?”

Shashank read: “‘This presence does not establish mutual ownership, payment relationship, or control.’”

“That line is absent from the published image,” Aditya said.

“It was cut out?”

“Possibly. But ‘it was cut out’ and ‘it was deliberately cut out to defame you’ are two different conclusions.”

Shashank’s face hardened. “But the result is the same.”

“Result and purpose are not the same.”

“Do you people see boundaries all the time?”

Aditya smiled faintly. “That is my job.”

Anger rose again inside Shashank. “My name has been made public. People are calling me the interpreter for a gambling network.”

“I am not investigating what people are saying. I am investigating what material reached outside, who had access, and which parts of the original record were actually sealed.”

“What if someone inside gave it?”

“Then evidence will appear. What if an external reproduction was made?”

Shashank said nothing.

“Then that will require different evidence,” Aditya answered himself. “You too are a student of inference. Do not trap yourself inside one possibility.”

Aditya placed a copy of the access list before him. There were five authorised names. Shashank’s name was not among them.

“Then is it proved that I did not give the material?”

“No,” Aditya said. “It proves that your name was not on the official access list. Unauthorised copying, photography, forwarding—those are separate questions. Do not turn ‘not on the list’ into ‘impossible.’”

Over the past months Shashank had heard many sentences like this. Earlier such caution had seemed to him like unnecessary complication. Today, amid humiliation, the same caution was also protecting him.

By noon three media outlets had sought his response. Raghav Bhasin advised: “Issue a short written statement. Do not deny facts. Do not accept inferences.”

Shashank drafted: “I provided language assistance in the Vivo-related service-contract matter and was also present as an interpreter with a separate betting-based application vendor. No conclusion of ownership, payment relationship, control, or joint operation between those two contexts has been established in any verified record known to me. The source and completeness of the alleged sealed extracts are under examination.”

He read it aloud.

Raghav stopped at one phrase. “‘No conclusion has been established’ is correct. Do not write ‘there is no relationship.’”

Shashank nodded. “I understand the difference.”

“In fear, people usually write the broadest sentence,” Raghav said. “Write the narrow truth.”

The statement was released.

Within an hour half a sentence from it was detached and circulated: “I was present with a betting-based application vendor.”

A burning sensation rose again in Shashank’s chest.

Mrinal came to meet him. In his hands were two earthen cups of tea.

“Take this.”

“Tea will not fix all this.”

“I did not bring it to fix anything.” Mrinal handed him a cup. “You become angry on an empty stomach.”

Shashank laughed unwillingly.

Mrinal looked at the news clipping. “People will circulate half a sentence. You stay with the whole sentence.”

“For how many days?”

“As many as it takes.”

“So this is friendship?”

“No,” Mrinal said. “Friendship is that I will stay with you, but I will not write a false sentence in your place.”

Shashank watched the steam rise from the earthen cup. He remembered an earlier lesson: protecting a friend does not mean hiding truth. Today the other half stood before him—turning an inference into a fact in order to protect a friend from humiliation was not friendship either.

That evening he had a short meeting with Juliana. Shashank told her the whole episode.

Juliana asked, “What hurts you most?”

“That people are seeing me as someone I am not.”

“And what are you, entirely?”

Shashank did not answer.

“In humiliation, a person wants to construct a completely innocent image of himself,” Juliana said. “But truth is not an image. It is a description.”

“What should I do?”

“Accept what is properly admissible. Do not treat the unproved as proved. Refute what is false. But do not merge all three into one sentence.”

“Is that a lesson in inference?”

“It is also a lesson in self-respect.”

That night Aditya called him again. This time there was a new item: an email sent by the media reporter to the investigating officer. The reporter wrote that he had received “reliable extracts from the sealed file” from a source. The source was unnamed. Three images were attached.

Aditya examined separately the timestamp of the first image, the lettering of the second, and the page number of the third.

“There are similarities among all three,” Shashank said.

“And differences?”

Shashank looked carefully. “The page number in the third image does not match the original index.”

“Only that?”

Shashank immediately corrected himself. “Not only that. The spacing between letters is the same in the first two images; in the third it is different. Possibly the third came from a different reproduction.”

Aditya wrote: “Possibly.”

“You will not write ‘forged’?”

“Not yet.”

“But the difference is clear.”

“The difference is clear. A conclusion of forgery is not.”

A strange calm entered Shashank. The method that had once seemed harsh was now protecting his name—without declaring him innocent.

Aditya said, “Tomorrow there will be a limited hearing in court on the authenticity, completeness, and transmission chain of this material. You will need to be present.”

Shashank’s hand became still again.

“Cross-examination?”

“Possible.”

When he stepped outside, the night was cold. The media headline had still not changed. On social media, many conclusions were spreading alongside his name. But for the first time Shashank read them without wanting to answer them all.

After reaching home, he opened his notebook.

“Same name ≠ link established.”

“Cropped extract ≠ complete record.”

“Removal of a complete line = meaning may change.”

“Changed meaning ≠ purpose to defame established.”

“Name absent from official access list = no official access.”

“No official access ≠ unauthorised copy impossible.”

“Humiliation = experience.”

“False allegation = testable claim.”

“Inference = discipline of reason and pervasion.”

He wrote the final line: "In humiliation, the hardest form of truth is the one that neither makes me wholly innocent nor asks me to accept an unproved guilt."

Before closing the notebook, he read the court notice again.

Tomorrow his language would again stand in the dock of questions.

This time the question would not only be what he had said. It would also be how far inference could travel from cropped words.

CHAPTER 48

FROM MANDARIN TO CANTONESE

The courtroom was not full. The hearing had been described as limited, so the rows for spectators were sparsely occupied; yet Shashank felt that every headline from the previous night sat behind each word he spoke. The judge was before him, the government side on one side, and on the other a lawyer challenging the authenticity of the records. Aditya sat in the back row with his file open. Raghav Bhasin was present too, but today there was no eagerness to advise on his face, only caution.

The first question concerned the sealed material. The court asked: did the resemblance between the images that had reached the media and the original file prove by itself that those images had come from the original file?

Aditya said, “No. Similarity is an indicator. To establish the source, we need the chain of transmission, the original copy, timestamps, and other evidence.”

“And the different page number?”

“That is a difference. A difference alone does not establish forgery.”

Yesterday’s sentence rose again inside Shashank—difference clear, conclusion of forgery not yet. The discipline that had seemed harsh during the night of humiliation was protecting him in court today.

Then the cross-examination turned towards him. Counsel placed a record on the table. “Were you the interpreter at this meeting?”

Shashank looked at the paper. The date, time, and a brief note of the meeting were written at the top. “I was present. But not every line on this page was written by me.”

“The question is simple. Were you present or not?”

“I was.”

“Did you understand Mandarin?”

“Yes.”

“Cantonese?”

“In some contexts, sufficiently; in others, only to a limited extent. I learned a great deal of pronunciation and practical phrasing from Juliana, but I have never claimed native-speaker competence.”

Counsel read out a line. It was a translation based on mixed Hindi-English transliteration. “You rendered the meaning of this statement as ‘same side’?”

Before answering, Shashank brought the page closer. “We need to look at the original utterance first.”

“You are an interpreter, not a philosopher. Tell us the meaning.”

The judge intervened. “Answer the question. But if a distinction is necessary to answer it, you may explain that distinction.”

Shashank took a long breath. “Without the sound of the original utterance, this line cannot be treated as final. In the written Chinese characters here, one meaning may be ‘on the same side in this work’; in another context it may be understood more like ‘on the same side in this dealing.’ ‘Same side’ was my short translation. ‘Same network’ was not my translation.”

Counsel immediately lifted another page. “But the later note says ‘same people.’”

“Who wrote that note?”

“You are not here to ask questions.”

Shashank fell silent. The judge examined the page. “The author’s name is not on the record. Reframe the question.”

Counsel lowered his voice. “Can ‘same side’ yield the meaning ‘same people’?”

“In some contexts, possibly. Not automatically.”

“Why?”

“Because the indication can change with the original utterance, the form of address, the context, and the spoken register. A written Mandarin sentence is one thing; the living sentence spoken in Cantonese pronunciation is a second; its transcription is a third; translation is a fourth; the translator’s interpretation is a fifth; and the legal inference drawn from it is a sixth. To call the sixth stage the first would be an error.”

For a moment the courtroom was silent. Aditya wrote six small numbers in his notebook.

Counsel asked, “Did you invent this six-stage theory today?”

Shashank's throat went dry. The question was not merely about method; it was about his character. "No. I understood these distinctions before as well."

"Then why did you not write so clearly in all your earlier work?"

This time objections rose inside Shashank—there was no time, the client wanted a short answer, everyone does it. He remembered all three reasons. Each contained some truth. But put together, they made responsibility disappear.

He said, "Sometimes for speed. Sometimes because I did not want the client to ask too many questions. Sometimes because I was tempted to make my linguistic competence appear more certain than it was. I made the distinctions smaller."

Raghav's face lifted slightly. The government counsel's pen stopped. At the back, Aditya neither wrote nor smiled.

Counsel asked, "So you knowingly made incorrect translations?"

"No. Do not turn what I admitted into another sentence. In many places the core meaning was not wrong, but I did not fully record uncertainty, differences of register, or the limits of context. That is an error. If a particular line is mistranslated, that line must be examined separately."

"You admit your error?"

"Yes."

"And the crime?"

"I will admit what is established. I will not call what is unproved true merely in the fervour of atonement."

The moment the words came out, Shashank himself was startled. Until yesterday, atonement within him had demanded punishment—take every fault upon yourself so that the dispute will end. Now he understood that accepting an unproved guilt was also an injustice to truth. Atonement was not self-punishment; it was looking at the exact boundary of one's real acts without hiding them.

Counsel moved to the next question. "At one meeting, the same Cantonese expression was used in relation to a person from the Vivo-related service contract and a person from the separate betting-based vendor. Does this linguistic similarity establish a relationship between the two institutions?"

"No."

"The same interpreter?"

"No."

"The same Chinese phrase?"

"No."

"The same kind of commercial terminology?"

"No."

"Then what does it establish?"

"Only that a similar expression or similar translation appears. To infer a relationship, we need a reason whose connection with the conclusion is reliably established. Linguistic similarity alone does not prove ownership, control, or conspiracy."

Counsel said with a trace of sarcasm, "And this is Navya-Nyaya?"

Looking not at the judge but at the paper, Shashank replied, "Call it what you like. If the reason does not sustain the conclusion, the inference is weak."

Aditya looked up for the first time. With permission, government counsel asked, "What if along with linguistic similarity we also find payment records, the same chain of instructions, similarity of timing, and independent evidence connecting the persons?"

Shashank said, "Then all the evidence can be examined together. But in that case the conclusion would arise not from linguistic similarity alone, but from the combined force of the evidence."

"So language is neither proof nor irrelevant?"

"Correct. Language is sometimes an indicator, sometimes part of the evidence, sometimes merely coincidence. Context determines its place."

The judge said, "Record that answer."

After that, a short portion of the original utterance was played in court. The audio was not unclear, but the pronunciation differed from standard Mandarin. Shashank felt the old training wake inside his body. Earlier his mind would seize the meaning instantly, and confidence would then smooth the sentence. Today, for the first time, he was afraid of that smoothness.

"What was said?"

He replied, "The first word is closer to Cantonese pronunciation. The second part takes a Mandarin grammatical form. The speaker is probably mixing languages. A literal rendering is possible, but I cannot yet give a definite statement about intention."

"Nevertheless, the translation?"

Shashank translated line by line. "Literally, approximately: 'Make the people on that side understand what is being said on this side.' But whether 'that side' means an institution, individuals, a department, or simply the other party in the meeting cannot be established from this fragment alone."

Counsel immediately said, "But in your old note you wrote 'their people.'"

"Yes."

"So today you are changing your translation?"

"No. 'Their people' was one possible translation. My error was that I did not state who 'their' referred to. A later reader could take it to mean an institution. I left out the uncertainty and gave an appearance of certainty."

"Why?"

Shashank did not close his eyes. "Because definite translations are more in demand. An interpreter who writes limits into every sentence is sometimes considered weak. I was tempted to look strong."

No dramatic lightness followed the admission. Instead an old shame took clear shape. He remembered the early days at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, when a teacher had said: making beautiful what you do not understand is not translation. He remembered Juliana's lesson: uncertainty in tone is also part of meaning. He had known those lessons, yet at times he had hidden limits for the sake of prestige.

Government counsel asked, "Does this linguistic error establish that the two commercial parties were one network?"

"No."

"Does it establish that you participated in a crime?"

"No."

"Is it irrelevant?"

Shashank paused. "No. If later decisions were based on my translation, the accuracy of my words is relevant. If I deliberately removed limits, the purpose and consequences of doing so may also require examination. But that examination is separate; it cannot be called a ready-made conclusion of crime."

Aditya's expression suggested that he had not been waiting for this particular answer so much as for an answer of this kind. Either defending oneself or admitting guilt was easy. The hard thing was not to break the boundary of the sentence.

In the final stage of cross-examination, counsel again raised the media headline. "If you yourself admit that you removed uncertainty, what is your objection to being called a 'linguistic link'?"

Shashank said, "Because 'I did not adequately record uncertainty in some translations' and 'I was the linguistic link between two networks' are not the same proposition. The first may be supported by lines from my work. The second requires independent grounds for all three elements—'two networks,' 'link,' and my role."

"But ordinary people understand ordinary language."

"A court does not turn an ordinary headline into an established fact."

This time the judge looked at counsel. "The witness will not give a legal conclusion. But the core point of the question is now clear."

When the hearing ended, the court gave no immediate final ruling on the authenticity of the sealed material. The order said only that the extracts circulated outside, the original records, and subsequent interpretations must not be treated as interchangeable; further examination of source and chain was necessary. The limits of Shashank's older translations were also placed on record for later examination.

Outside in the corridor, media personnel were waiting. The question came again: "Has the court now found you innocent?"

Shashank did not stop. "No."

A second question: "Then have the allegations been proved?"

"No."

"Then what was decided?"

For the first time, without bitterness, Shashank said, "A question was kept as a question."

Mrinal walked beside him down the stairs. For a long time they were both silent. The sunlight outside was hard.

Mrinal asked, "Do you regret what you admitted?"

"I do not regret admitting it. I regret that I knew the boundaries before, and still made them smaller in some places."

“And now?”

Shashank said, “Now, if a tone changes somewhere between Mandarin and Cantonese, I will call it a change of tone. I will not call it a network. And if my own greed altered the meaning, I will not hide that by calling it linguistic convenience.”

Aditya came up from behind. In his hand was the court’s notice of the next procedural step. “One question became clearer through this hearing, but the file is not finished. Some statements have to be taken again. There are questions about the chain of custody of several digital items.”

Shashank took the paper and read the next date. A shadow of his old ambition rose within him—how many people, records, and decisions had at some time been affected by words he translated. Once he had been proud of that influence. Today, for the first time, he thought: the size of influence is not only the size of prestige; it is also the size of responsibility.

He folded the notice and put it in his pocket.

Next time the question would not concern language alone. It would also be this: when his words were placed beside records, devices, and statements, which inferences would survive—and which would break.

CHAPTER 49

THE CANTONESE DOOR 10

Early on the second morning after leaving court, a message from Aditya arrived on Shashank's phone: "Be present at ten today. Following the court's directions, several statements will be recorded again. The seizure inventory of two digital devices will also be read out in your presence."

Shashank read the message twice. "Be present"—there was less command than weight in those two words. Until yesterday he had been answering questions about his language; today his words, his devices, his old messages, and his own ambition would be placed on the same table.

He was standing before the mirror tying his tie when an old sensation suddenly returned—the thrill of hearing his name called in an important meeting, of someone in a foreign delegation asking, "Where is Shashank?", of a manager refusing to move the papers forward without him. At times that sensation had intoxicated him.

Today a summons was calling his name. But there was no prestige in this call; there was examination.

Mrinal set down a cup of tea and asked, "Are you afraid?"

"Afraid too. But..."

"But?"

Shashank loosened his tie. "There is a foolish pride as well. I will have to answer why my name appears so many times among these files. Once I myself wanted people to believe that work would stop without me."

Mrinal kept looking at him. "Wanting to be important and being a criminal are not the same thing."

"No."

"But the habit of making your role look larger can contaminate a statement."

Shashank did not answer. The reason contained in that sentence had already been present within him.

Aditya was not alone in the examination room. Two officials sat at one side of the table; before them lay two sealed bags, the seizure inventory, and signed pages. After greeting him, Aditya said, "First, the boundary. There will be questions about the ownership, use, and contents of these devices. The mere presence of your name or a message on any device will not be treated as proof of ownership, control, or crime."

Shashank smiled faintly. "Yesterday's lesson again today?"

"Not a lesson. Method."

The first bag contained an old mobile phone seized along with office belongings of an employee of a vendor. The second contained a small computer. Aditya read the seizure inventory—when each object was received, who sealed it, who signed, what serial number it was given.

He said, "At this stage you are not being asked whether whatever is inside the devices is true. The first question is whether you have seen these objects before."

Shashank looked at the exterior of the phone. "This model is common. It cannot be identified from its appearance alone."

"Good."

He looked towards the computer. "There is a scratch on this..." He stopped.

Aditya immediately asked, "Identification from the scratch?"

"No. It only awakened a memory. I once saw a computer with a scratch like this at a meeting. But that is not enough to say that this is the same device."

Aditya wrote: "Memory, not identification."

Yesterday's courtroom came alive again inside Shashank. Earlier, in such a moment, he might have said, "Yes, I saw it." Precision had seemed to diminish his importance; confidence increased his market value.

Today he was making his sentence smaller, but for the first time a smaller sentence was not making him a smaller man.

When the seizure inventory had been read through, Aditya said, "Now the statement."

"A new statement?"

"A supplementary statement. In three places in your earlier statement you wrote, 'I ran the meeting.' I want to understand what you meant by 'ran.'"

Shashank's face tightened slightly. "I was managing the language."

"Then 'ran the meeting?'"

"That was an enlarged version."

"Why?"

The easy answers were available—ordinary speech used by interpreters, conversational shorthand, error of memory. But Shashank knew those were not the whole answer.

"Ambition," he said.

The scratching of pens in the room stopped.

Aditya asked, "Explain."

"I liked people to think the meeting could not happen without me. Sometimes I had only interpreted, but later, when telling the story, I enlarged my role. Instead of 'I interpreted,' I would say, 'I handled the meeting'; instead of 'I clarified the meaning,' I would say, 'I got them to agree.'"

"Do you admit that you sometimes described your role as larger than it was?"

"In some contexts—yes."

"Do you admit that you made the decisions?"

"No. Exaggerating one's role and making a decision are not the same thing."

Aditya looked up. "Good. That distinction will be made explicit in the statement."

Shashank felt that atonement had begun in court the previous day, but today a harder form of it stood before him. Admitting fault is simple when the boundary of the fault is clear. The difficulty begins when the mind has once tasted guilt and then wants to put everything upon its own head.

He said on his own, "Add one more thing. Because I have exaggerated my role, my other statements do not automatically become false. Each statement should be examined separately."

Aditya nodded slightly. "That is all I want too."

The first part of the statement continued until noon. The questions appeared ordinary—who was present at which meeting, in what language the original sentence was spoken, in what language Shashank repeated it, to whom the written copy was given. Yet through those simple questions an old net slowly opened: how often memory, prestige, and language had become entangled with one another.

At one point Aditya asked, "You wrote: 'The vendor agreed.' What was the original sentence?"

Shashank closed his eyes and remembered. "In Mandarin the sense was: 'We can proceed in this form.'"

"Is that the same as 'agreed'?"

"Not always. It can also indicate procedural assent, not final acceptance."

"Then why did you write 'agreed'?"

"It was shorter. More forceful. And... I felt that my translation had made the matter happen."

"Ambition again?"

"Yes."

Aditya wrote it down without comment.

In the second part of the statement, the digital copies were opened. The original devices remained sealed; material from certified forensic copies was shown for examination. Aditya first read the timestamps and file list, then said, "What we are looking at here is the question of whether the material exists. Meaning is a separate question. Authorship is a separate question. Which person used the device is separate."

Shashank said, "And control?"

"That is even more separate."

The first message chain contained Shashank's name. It was two years old. An assistant had written: "Have Shashankji check the Chinese line." The reply contained only one word: "Okay."

Aditya asked, "Is this you?"

"The name is mine. Who wrote the message—I will not say from the name alone."

"Memory?"

Shashank read it carefully. "The wording is the kind of message that could have been sent to me. But I do not remember it."

A second file contained the written form of an audio fragment. Beneath a Chinese sentence the English meaning had been written: "same side, same people."

Aditya said, "Read it."

Shashank looked at the original Chinese line and frowned. "This translation is more definite than the original."

"How much more?"

"The original can carry a sense like 'people on the same side,' but without context, translating it as 'same people'—the same group of persons—is too strong. 'Same side,' 'people on the same side,' 'same work team'—several possibilities remain."

"Then 'same network'?"

"That certainly does not follow automatically from this line."

Aditya drew three lines on the paper: original statement, translation, inference. "Somewhere in the distance between these three, evidence is required."

Shashank said almost involuntarily, "No inference without pervasion."

"And where does the pervasion come from?"

"From additional facts. Not from similarity of words alone."

Aditya's question was hard, but his voice remained calm. "Have you ever translated this line?"

Shashank looked again. There was a small habit in the formatting—the way Cantonese pronunciation was placed in brackets. Something sank inside his chest.

"Possibly," he said.

"Why 'possibly'?"

"I used this style of brackets."

"Then you are the author?"

Shashank immediately remembered yesterday's lesson. "The style is similar. Authorship is not established."

For the first time a faint satisfaction appeared on Aditya's face. "Correct."

But Shashank felt no satisfaction. He was remembering the old days when his ability to move quickly between two forms of Chinese had been his distinction. People praised him; he himself left small marks that announced his presence on the page—the shape of brackets, tone marks, choices of words, all forming a kind of signature.

Ambition does not seek only rank. Sometimes it wants its mark on every page.

In the afternoon the third item was opened—a copy of an old contact list. Many names, many abbreviations. One entry read only: "L-W / vendor." There was no full identification.

Aditya asked, "Do you recognise it?"

Shashank looked at it for a long time. "L-W could stand for many names."

"Li Wenchao?"

Shashank looked up. "Possible. But not from this entry alone."

"Did you know a person named Li Wenchao?"

"I had an introduction connected with a vendor. The first contact came because of language."

"When?"

"Around the time of the Vivo-related service contract."

"The connection between that person and this device?"

"I do not know."

"The connection between that person and the gambling-based application?"

Shashank remained silent. There was a temptation to answer inside the question. Over the past several weeks there had been so much material, so many allegations, so much discussion that the mind wanted to join the relationship immediately. But to place memory, things heard later, subsequent information, and direct experience together would be the same old error again.

"I heard many things later," he said. "But at the time of the first introduction, what I directly perceived was only this: he was presented as a person on the vendor side, he showed interest when he heard my Mandarin and Cantonese, and then proposed a separate meeting. I will not state anything beyond that now as direct experience."

Aditya asked, "Did the separate meeting take place?"

"Yes."

"What happened at that meeting?"

Shashank's throat went dry. He understood that the direction changed here. Here language had ceased to be merely a service; language had become a door.

But Aditya raised a hand. "Not today. The boundary of this statement is the summons, the seizure, and the material presently before us. The next question will be taken in a separate session."

Shashank looked at him in surprise. "You are not going to ask?"

"I will. But not by breaking the boundary. The importance of an investigation also comes from respecting limits."

The sentence struck Shashank in a strange way. Much of his life had been spent wanting to become important by crossing boundaries—from interpreter to adviser, adviser to intermediary, intermediary to the person without whom some people considered a meeting incomplete. How many of those roles had been real, how many self-created—today, for the first time, he understood the need to name them separately.

By evening the statement was complete. Aditya read the final page aloud: “The witness admits that in some earlier descriptions he enlarged his role; this admission does not by itself establish decision-making authority, ownership, control, or criminal participation. The relationship between the devices and the material is independently testable by evidence.”

Shashank said, “Add one line.”

“What?”

“Linguistic similarity too does not establish identity of a person or a network without independent evidence.”

Aditya wrote it. “Good.”

Before signing, Shashank read the entire statement. Earlier he had lacked the patience to read long records; he would look at the lines around his own name and sign. Today every “possibly,” every “I do not remember,” every “admit” seemed important.

Mrinal was waiting outside. When Shashank came out, he asked, “What happened?”

“Today I reduced my own importance.”

Mrinal did not laugh. “And perhaps increased your responsibility.”

Shashank said quietly, “Yes.”

They stopped at a tea stall by the road. Steam rose from the cups. Holding his cup, Shashank said, “Earlier, when someone said a meeting could not proceed without me, I treated it as an achievement. Today I understand—if meaning really could not be made without me, I should have been more careful.”

“Atonement?” Mrinal asked.

“No. Now it is an accounting.”

“The difference?”

“Atonement is inward. An accounting also enters the record.”

That night, after reaching home, Shashank opened his old notebook. On a fresh page he wrote:

“Summons ≠ guilt established.”

“Statement = test of memory.”

“Seized device ≠ user established.”

“Name ≠ authorship.”

“Similarity of style = possibility of source, not proof.”

“Exaggerating one’s own role = error; not proof of decision-making authority.”

“Ambition ≠ reason; but it may be context for understanding distortion in a statement.”

His hand stopped while writing the final line: “L-W / vendor.”

He did not write the full name. What he remembered was a man whose pronunciation moved easily from Mandarin towards Cantonese; whose eyes had lit with commercial interest on hearing linguistic skill; and a proposal that at first had sounded merely like “separate work.”

So far, that was memory—not an established fact.

But the door to the next question stood there.

CHAPTER 50

THE GAMBLING APP VENDOR

On the day of the next session, Aditya Mishra placed only three things on the table—the copy of the previous statement, a copy of the seizure inventory, and a small slip of paper on which was written: “L-W / vendor.”

He looked at Shashank. “Yesterday you stopped here. Today we will begin from here. But one rule—what is direct memory must be stated as direct memory; what you heard later, as later information; and what is inference, as inference.”

Shashank straightened his back in the chair. “All right.”

“Li Wenchao?”

“Yes. I remember the name now. But the ‘L-W’ on this paper does not by itself confirm the name. That I knew him is a separate matter.”

Aditya nodded. “Then begin with the first day of the introduction.”

Memory turned towards that period in Noida when work on the Vivo-related service contract was under way. People connected with repairs and technical inspection came and went through one section of the building; Shashank’s work was principally linguistic—understanding someone’s instructions, making someone’s objection clear, preventing the meaning of someone’s sentence from being distorted. One day, amid that traffic, a Chinese man arrived and was introduced to Shashank as someone acquainted with the external vendor side.

“Who introduced him?” Aditya interrupted.

Shashank closed his eyes and thought for a few moments. “I do not remember exactly. I remember only that he was not wearing the identification badge of a permanent employee. On that basis I will not say that he was the formal representative of any particular institution.”

Aditya wrote: “Formal representation not established.”

At that first meeting Li Wenchao had begun with ordinary conversation in Mandarin. Then, hearing the reply of another Chinese man standing beside him, his speech shifted towards Cantonese. Without thinking, Shashank altered the rhythm of his own reply. Li suddenly looked at his face.

“You understand both?” he had asked.

The old warmth of pride had risen inside Shashank. “I try to understand. Not only the words—the manner of speaking as well.”

Li then spoke one or two sentences in different pronunciations. Shashank pointed out the slight difference in meaning. Li laughed. “Then you are less an interpreter than a door.”

At the time, the sentence had sounded like praise to Shashank. Repeating it today before Aditya, he heard another meaning in the word.

“A door?” Aditya asked.

“Yes. He said that many meetings between different linguistic groups were repeated simply because people failed to catch one another’s cadence. He needed someone who could carry meaning from Mandarin to Cantonese, and from there into English or to the Indian side, without letting it break three times along the way.”

“What did you answer?”

“I told him: if the limits of the work were clear, it could be done.”

Aditya stopped his pen. “Did you ask about those limits?”

Shashank lowered his eyes. “I did. But not as much as I should have.”

The second meeting took place outside the main service premises, at a business meeting venue. Li opened a computer. On the screen were what appeared to be live-streamed gambling tables—cards, wheels, dealers, changing numerical boxes. Shashank saw no hidden technical architecture; before him there was only something like a user interface.

Aditya asked, “Did you understand then that this was gambling-related?”

“Yes. I understood that the games involved wagers.”

“Illegal?”

Shashank did not answer immediately. “That word requires caution. At the time I did not know what permissions existed in which country and what did not. I can say only that it appeared to be a demonstration of an offshore gambling application. I had not then investigated its legal status in India.”

“Was Li its owner?”

“I do not know.”

“Controller?”

“I do not know.”

“He only showed you the interface?”

“Yes. He had access to demonstrate it—that much is direct. Access does not establish ownership.”

Aditya's pen moved again. Shashank understood that the hardest exercise of the past several weeks was this: he himself had to define the limits even of facts that might weigh against him.

Li had said that day that he needed help with “linguistic localisation.” Some Chinese commercial terms were misunderstood by people on the Indian side; some words sounded too harsh; some sentences became ambiguous between customer service and the rules of the game. At first, in his own mind, Shashank placed the work in the ordinary room of language editing.

But at one point on the screen there was an explicit term meaning “wager.” Li asked: “Can this word be expressed in a way that does not make the commercial presentation sound so harsh?”

Shashank had paused at that moment. He understood that softening meaning was not merely a matter of style; sometimes it also blunted the edge of a fact. Even so, he suggested a more general expression—one that, instead of making the nature of the game clear, pushed it towards the language of entertainment.

“What exactly was the word?” Aditya asked.

Shashank shook his head. “My memory is incomplete. I will not invent a word by inference. But I remember the act: I softened an explicit wagering-related meaning into more general commercial language.”

“Why?”

The question was short; the answer was long. All the scenes of that period rose together in Shashank's mind—a chair being kept for him in meetings, people saying on the phone, “Bring Shashank in,” Chinese officials praising his pronunciation, the Indian side postponing signatures until he was present. The rarity of his language skills gave him power.

“Why?” Aditya asked again.

“Because I wanted the work to keep coming to me.”

The room was silent for a few moments.

“Did anyone pressure you?”

“Not at that moment.”

“Threaten you?”

“No.”

“Promise you a special benefit in return for softening the meaning?”

“Not explicitly. But there were signals of new work, more meetings, greater importance. I understood those signals.”

Aditya wrote: “Ambition as context; direct pressure not established.”

Shashank said, “Add one more thing. At the time I was telling myself that an interpreter merely chooses language according to the client's wishes. That was a half-truth. When an interpreter chooses words, he can alter the boundary of meaning. I knew that.”

Aditya looked at him. “You knew that—does that establish criminal intent?”

“No.” Shashank's answer came at once. “But it raises a question of responsibility.”

“Good. Keep the two separate.”

At the end of that meeting Li had sent Shashank a short glossary. Shashank corrected some headings, shortened some sentences, and in two or three places chose language that reduced the explicitness of the gambling. At the time he had called the work “improving the presentation.” Today “softening the meaning” seemed more accurate.

“Were you paid?”

“For the linguistic work, yes.”

“Does that payment establish that you were a partner in the application?”

“No.”

“A participant in the profits?”

“No—no such evidence is known to me.”

“Decision-making authority?”

“No.”

Aditya drew a line across the page. “Then there are three levels here—linguistic service may be established; there is an admission of softening meaning; but ownership, control, and partnership are separate questions.”

Aditya turned the paper towards Shashank. At the top he wrote three small headings: “Seen,” “Said,” “Inferred.” “Now classify them yourself.”

Shashank read the first line: “Saw live-streamed gambling tables on a computer screen.” He placed it under “Seen.” The second: “Li asked for help with linguistic localisation.” He placed it under “Said.” The third: “Li was the owner of the application.” Without hesitation Shashank placed it under “Inferred,” then added: “And on the available material, presently a weak inference.”

Aditya showed him the next line: “Shashank softened explicit wagering-related language.” Shashank was silent for a few moments. “That is my own admission; if the glossary is found, it may also receive documentary confirmation.”

“And this?” Aditya wrote: “Introduction to Li during the Vivo-related service-contract period = Vivo and the gambling application were the same network.”

Shashank rested his thumb on the line. “The reason is incomplete. Proximity in time and the presence of the same interpreter do not establish institutional unity.”

In that small exercise Shashank felt a strange conflict. The method was protecting him from certain accusations, while at the same time making his own admissions sharper. The boundary that stopped conclusions from going too far outward also blocked the path by which he might hide his error inwardly.

“Yes.”

“And Vivo?”

Shashank took a long breath. “At the time of this introduction, the Vivo-related service contract was under way. Li knew me because of the language work I was doing then. But that does not justify treating Li or his gambling application as part of the Vivo institution. No such record was before me. Proximity in time is not an institutional relationship.”

Aditya underlined that sentence twice. “This is important.”

“To protect my name?”

“No. To protect the inference.”

A faint smile appeared on Shashank’s face. Aditya’s answer contained neither a display of sympathy nor pleasure in severity. Only a boundary.

The memory of the meeting moved forward again. As he was leaving, Li had said: “Next time some people from the Indian side will also be there. Different people handle payment and service. If you want, bring someone you trust.”

At the time Shashank had heard only half that sentence—“someone you trust.” His mind had immediately gone to Mrinal. In the glitter of the new work, he liked the thought that he could bring his friend too into the expanding world around him.

That night his old message had been short: “I have found a new language job. Will you come with me to the next meeting?”

Mrinal’s reply had been: “What kind of work?”

Shashank had written: “Language.”

Aditya asked, “Only language?”

Shashank lowered his eyes. “Until then, in my own mind, I had kept it under that name. But after seeing the gambling interface, calling it ‘only language’ was an incomplete truth.”

“Had you told Mrinal about the gambling?”

“Not in the first message.”

“Why?”

“Possibly because I wanted him to say yes first.”

“Possibly?”

Shashank corrected himself. “This is not an inference; it is my memory of my own mind. Yes—I wanted him to say yes first.”

Aditya wrote the sentence exactly as spoken.

By the time the session ended, evening had fallen. Light from outside lay across the table in a long strip through the window. Shashank read his statement. Nowhere had he been declared a criminal; nowhere had his error been hidden. It was still difficult for him to accept that both things could remain true at the same time.

Before signing, he said, “Add one line.”

Aditya lifted his pen.

“Li Wenchao did not open a door for me—he merely showed me an opportunity. I removed the latch myself because I was proud of the importance my language gave me.”

Aditya was silent for a few moments. “That is a literary sentence, not one for a statement.”

For the first time Shashank laughed lightly. “Then write in the statement: the decision to accept the separate meeting was mine.”

“That can be written.”

After coming outside, Shashank searched his phone for the old message. Mrinal’s “What kind of work?” was still there. So was his own answer—“Language.”

He understood that the next inquiry would not concern only Li Wenchao or the gambling application he had seen on the computer screen. The question would also be how a relationship that began with language reached money, service, and friendship—and, along that journey, what was direct fact and what was only inference.

CHAPTER 51

THE CANTONESE DOOR 12

The next day Shashank was not alone in Aditya's room. Mrinal was already seated there. Two separate statement sheets lay on the table—one for Shashank, the other for Mrinal. Between them was a thin file containing old emails, payment receipts, and clippings from service agreements.

As Shashank entered, he looked towards Mrinal. Mrinal merely nodded. No smile, no anger. Shashank had rarely seen friendship wear such a face—closeness without any promise of relief.

Aditya said, "Yesterday's question stopped here—how a relationship that began with language reached money, services, and friendship. Today we will keep those three separate."

Shashank pulled out the chair and sat. "All right."

Aditya lifted the first paper. On it was Mrinal's old message—"What kind of work?"—and Shashank's reply—"Language."

"Mrinalji," Aditya asked, "after receiving this answer, did you attend that meeting?"

Mrinal said, "Yes. But I thought it would be a meeting about translation and business presentation."

"Had Shashank told you beforehand about the gambling application?"

"No."

Shashank wanted to speak, but stopped. Aditya looked at him. "Your turn is coming."

The short sentence displeased Shashank. In front of Mrinal he had never had to wait for his turn to speak. In friendship, people complete one another's sentences; in an investigation, every sentence has a separate owner.

Mrinal continued, "For the first fifteen or twenty minutes, the discussion was about language, customer habits, and the meaning of words. Then payments, service providers, and different accounts were mentioned. That was when I became uncomfortable."

Aditya asked, "What conclusion did you draw from seeing different accounts?"

Mrinal replied, "No definite conclusion at that time. I only asked—why are there so many payment names for language work?"

"The answer?"

"I was told that different institutions handled different services. I was not satisfied."

Aditya turned to Shashank. "Your memory?"

Shashank said, "Approximately the same. There was another man with Li Wenchao. He was showing the payment papers. There were three different names on the same presentation sheet. At the time I took it to be an ordinary commercial division and moved on."

"Ordinary—on what basis?"

Shashank fell silent. The question was not difficult; explaining the reason for his old ease was. "On no particular basis. I did not want to disrupt the meeting."

Mrinal looked at him. Shashank knew that look. It was the same look Mrinal used to give him in the village on examination days after looking at his answer sheet: "You know it, but you make mistakes in haste."

Aditya said, "The wish not to disrupt a meeting is not evidence. But it is useful for understanding the context of the statement."

He took a receipt from the thin file. "This payment is in your name?"

Shashank looked at the receipt. "Yes. For linguistic services."

"Amount?"

Shashank stated it. Aditya wrote it down, but did not pursue the figure on the receipt. The question was not the size of the payment, but the nature of the relationship.

"The payer's name is different from Li Wenchao's," Aditya said. "What does that establish?"

"Only that the payment came through an entity or channel under that name. It does not establish ownership or ultimate control."

"And that Li arranged the payment?"

"He told me that my fee would reach me. But I did not know the actual structure of the remitter."

Beside the receipt Aditya wrote two words—"statement" and "record." "They may correspond, but they do not become each other."

Yesterday's exercise stirred again inside Shashank: seen, said, inferred. Now a fourth level stood before him—money, which people often treat as the final truth. Yet payment too could be not the end of a question, but the beginning of a new one.

Aditya opened the next page. It was a payment-gateway summary listing headings for many transactions. Some looked like linguistic services, some were unclear, some were merely abbreviations.

"Had you seen this file before?"

Shashank said, "Not the whole of it. I saw some lines during the meeting. I was shown only the entry relating to my service."

"Seeing other people's names in this list, did you assume that everyone was part of the same business?"

"No. Now I certainly would not say that. At the time I may have connected them in my mind, but without records."

Mrinal said, "You were not this careful then."

Aditya did not stop him. A friend's sentence was not an investigative question, but it was part of the truth of the context.

Shashank said, "No, I wasn't."

Mrinal's voice did not harden. "I am not angry because you met risky people. I am angry because you took me along saying it was 'language work' when you had already seen gambling on the computer screen."

Shashank's throat grew heavy. "I wanted you first to agree to come."

"Why?"

"Because if you were with me, my own decision would have felt less doubtful."

For a few moments there was silence in the room.

Aditya stopped his pen. "Say that sentence again."

Shashank said slowly, "If Mrinal was with me, my own decision would have felt less doubtful. In my mind I was turning his presence into evidence that I could trust my decision."

"But is a friend's presence proof that a decision is sound?"

"No."

"And if the friend has not been given the complete facts?"

"Then even less so."

Shashank lowered his eyes. There was no legal name for a crime in this admission, but the error within the friendship was clear. He had not merely brought Mrinal along; he had hidden his own hesitation in the shadow of Mrinal's trust.

Mrinal said, "Do you remember, in the middle of the meeting, I once went outside—" He stopped himself and corrected the sentence. "I asked you to come outside?"

Shashank nodded slightly. "Yes."

"Outside I asked: what is this money for? You said: I have nothing to do with the payment structure; I only look after the language."

Shashank's face tightened. "Yes. I said that."

Aditya asked, "How do you see that sentence today?"

"Useful for marking a boundary, but also useful for stepping away from responsibility. If language was part of a service in which the nature of the money was unclear, it would at least have been proper to ask questions. But the fact that I did not ask questions does not establish that I controlled all the accounts or transactions."

"Correct," Aditya said. "Neglect, ignorance, participation, and control are four different things."

He opened another paper. This time there were copies of several messages. One message from Li Wenchao said: "The people on the Indian payment side will remain separate; you people handle language and customer-facing presentation."

Aditya asked, "Who were 'you people'?"

Shashank replied, "Mrinal and me—that is how I understood it then."

Mrinal immediately said, "At that time I had accepted no role."

Shashank looked at him. "Correct."

"Then why did you give Li Mrinal's name?"

Shashank entered the memory. "I had said that I had a trusted friend who understood the language and behaviour of the Indian side. Li possibly assumed that he would work with us."

"Did you correct him?"

"Not explicitly."

For the first time pain appeared on Mrinal's face. "Was I your friend, or your visiting card?"

Shashank searched for an answer, but no clever sentence came. “I made you both. That was improper.”

Aditya entered the fact in the statement: “Friend’s name presented as a potential collaborator; prior consent not explicit.”

Shashank said, “Write ‘improper’ too.”

“The statement will record facts. Evaluation belongs elsewhere.”

The remark hurt Shashank again. He repeatedly wanted to name his fault immediately in moral language, as though using a harsh word would settle the account. Aditya would not give him that convenience.

In the afternoon, the discussion reached entries involving accounts under other names, a payment gateway, and virtual currency. Each time Aditya repeated the same question: “Did you see this directly, hear it from someone, or see it later in the investigative record?”

Shashank answered one by one. He had heard some names in the meeting; others he first saw later in investigative records; some contexts had become mixed in his memory with media reports. Wherever the boundary blurred, he said, “My memory is not certain.”

At one point Mrinal said, “My name is not on this list.”

Aditya nodded. “That fact matters in itself. Friendship, presence at a meeting, or an introduction is not proof of control over an account.”

Shashank looked at Mrinal. The irony was that the same method that protected him from unproved accusations was now separating Mrinal from their shadow as well.

“There is one thing I should say,” Shashank said. “After the meeting I told Mrinal that the work did not look clean, but the fee was good. I remember saying that.”

Mrinal said quietly, “Yes. And I said: good money and good work are different things.”

Aditya asked, “Then what did you do?”

Mrinal replied, “I did not go to the second meeting.”

“Shashank?”

“He went.”

Shashank did not object.

“Why did you go?” Aditya asked.

Many answers rose in Shashank’s mind—the attraction of language, new people, foreign travel, higher fees, the pleasure of feeling necessary. This time he did not want to choose one and hide the rest.

“There was not one reason,” he said. “There was money. There was importance. There was language. And there was the illusion that because I could recognise a boundary, I would not cross it.”

“Did you cross the boundary?”

“In some places linguistically—yes. I softened what should have remained explicit. But on the question of ownership or operation of the financial structure, I will still say only this: what I directly knew was limited.”

Aditya wrote it down. “Keep that distinction intact.”

At the end of the session, before rising, Mrinal said to Shashank, “I have no wish to give testimony against you, and I will not give false testimony in your favour either. I will say what I saw.”

The old hurt rose again inside Shashank, but this time he did not treat it as humiliation. “That much is what friendship requires,” he said.

Mrinal smiled. “Friendship is not only that. Going outside for tea is part of it too.”

They went outside together. As they drank tea at a roadside stall, Mrinal asked, “You went to the second meeting. What happened after that?”

Shashank turned the cup in his hand. “After that came a proposal for foreign travel.”

“Where?”

“Macao.”

Mrinal’s face became serious again. “Did you go?”

Shashank did not answer directly. He said only, “That question is coming in the next statement.”

That night, after reaching home, Shashank opened his notebook.

“Friend ≠ proof of innocence.”

“Friend’s presence ≠ consent.”

“Payment = evidence of a service relationship; not of ownership.”

“Separate accounts ≠ same controller established.”

“Unclear source = question; not automatic conclusion.”

“Good money ≠ good work.”

“A partial truth can push friendship too in a false direction.”

He wrote the final line and looked at it for a long time: "I understand the boundary = I will not cross the boundary—this inference was false."

As he closed the notebook, Mrinal's question returned to him: "Did you go?"

He had gone. On that journey, for the first time, language, money, and the glitter of a distant country stood before him together. And in that glitter, the colour of greed was now becoming clearer than memory itself.

CHAPTER 52

THE CANTONESE DOOR 13

Mrinal's question—"You went?"—kept circling inside Shashank all night.

Early in the morning, a message arrived from Aditya Mishra: "Today we will examine the records relating to the journey—the passport entries, travel reservation, hotel account, meeting messages, and whatever access records are available. Say what you saw; do not infer what you did not see."

Shashank read the message and closed his notebook. The line he had written the previous night—"I understand the boundary = I will not cross the boundary: that inference was mistaken"—was still before his eyes.

When he reached the office, five files lay on the table. Aditya opened them one by one.

"The trip to Macao?"

Shashank said, "Yes. I went."

"At whose invitation?"

"Li Wenchao raised it first. Later, different people made the travel arrangements. I do not remember all their names now."

"The purpose?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments. "At the time I was told—language assistance, a demonstration before clients, and help in understanding some papers."

"Only that?"

"That was all I was told. But that was not my only reason."

Aditya looked up.

Shashank said, "I wanted to travel abroad. I felt that a journey like that would lift me above the level of an ordinary translator. Hotels, meetings, foreign delegations—all of it attracted me."

"Money?"

"That too."

Aditya merely wrote: "Declared purpose of travel: linguistic assistance. Personal motives: prestige, travel, remuneration." Then he said, "Motive and criminal intent are not the same. But context can matter when a statement is evaluated."

Shashank nodded.

The first record was the flight reservation. The name was clear. The date was clear. The source of payment appeared to have been routed through a travel-service agency.

Aditya asked, "What does this source of payment establish?"

Shashank answered, "That the travel arrangement was made through that intermediary. It does not establish that the agency whose name appears here was owned by Li, or that it owned the gambling application."

"Good."

The second record was from the hotel. Three rooms under a single reservation number: Shashank, Li, and a third name.

"One reservation?"

"Yes."

"One organisation?"

"That cannot be said. A single reservation may simply be a matter of travel convenience."

Aditya did not smile, but his pen slowed. "You no longer rush to conclusions."

Shashank said, "I have learned the cost of rushing to conclusions."

The memory of arriving in Macao did not open all at once; it unfolded slowly. The profusion of lights had astonished him as soon as he came out of the airport. Tall buildings, glass walls, blazing advertisements, people in motion, the dense murmur of unfamiliar languages—amid all of it he had remembered the night of his small village, where for a long distance the only lights one could see were fireflies.

At the time, he had made the comparison not with affection but with a sense of triumph: "I have come from there to here."

Remembering it now, he saw in that sentence the first unmistakable shadow of greed.

That night Shashank had stood for a long time at the hotel window, looking down at the glittering city. A short message from Juliana had arrived on his phone: “The mind hears the language of a new place before the ear does. Do not rush to conclusions.”

Shashank had typed in reply: “The work is big.”

Then he had deleted the word “big” and written: “It is important.”

Now he understood the meaning of that small change. At the time, he did not know how necessary the work really was; what he wanted was for his own role to appear important. He had placed his ambition inside a word.

Aditya asked, “Is that message available?”

“Possibly in a backup of the old phone.”

“Then it will be compared with your memory. For now, we have only your statement.”

“Right.”

Shashank admitted to himself that greed had not been only for money. There had also been the greed to watch the story of his life rise swiftly upward.

There had been no formal meeting on the first evening. Li introduced him to two people in the hotel restaurant. One man spoke little English and more Mandarin; the other answered rapidly in Cantonese. Shashank kept the language moving between them.

“Did you understand who those people were?” Aditya asked.

“I wrote down the names they gave. Their roles were vague. One was introduced as ‘technology’, the other as ‘commerce’.”

“Owner?”

“No.”

“Operator?”

“That was not said.”

“Employee?”

“That was not clear either.”

“Then why did you later sometimes call them the ‘technical team’?”

Shashank’s face tightened slightly. “Because they spoke about the interface, the game stream, and linguistic localisation. I inferred their role.”

“An inference?”

“Yes.”

“Good. Write here: ‘Technical team’ was my inference at the time, not an official designation.”

Shashank wrote it down.

The next day he was taken to a place that resembled an office. A company name stood on the plaque at the entrance, but Shashank was unwilling now to repeat it from memory as an established fact. Inside were a meeting room, computers, several screens, and clocks on the wall showing different time zones.

One screen carried a live-streamed game. Another showed lists of phrases in several languages. A third displayed exchanges resembling customer-support conversations.

Shashank had been fascinated then. It seemed to him that language here did not merely translate; it could alter the movement of money.

Aditya interrupted him. “Was that your experience at the time, or an interpretation you are making later?”

Shashank closed his eyes and searched his memory. “My immediate experience was only this: I saw material in several languages, I saw live gambling, and there was discussion of linguistic corrections. ‘Language could alter the movement of money’ is the meaning I am giving that past experience today.”

“Keep the two separate.”

Inwardly Shashank remembered Juliana’s sentence: truth is not an image; it is a description.

At the meeting he was given a guest-access name. He was permitted to view certain pages, suggest changes to some words, and listen to the pronunciation of certain sentences. Once, a man had told him, “Open this section.” Shashank did not know the password; the man entered it himself, then left the screen open in front of him.

Aditya asked, “Did you log in?”

“I viewed the material that had been opened on the screen.”

“The password?”

“I did not know it.”

“Authority over the account?”

“I do not know.”

"Did you change anything?"

"I suggested two or three linguistic variants. I do not have direct knowledge of which changes, if any, were later saved."

"Then if the words 'server access' appear in any record?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "They would need to be read carefully. Material was open on a computer screen in front of me. I cannot say that I had independent control of the server."

Aditya wrote: "Access observed $\neq$ control established. Shared screen $\neq$ independent authority established."

Shashank kept looking at the paper. In the years that followed, he had used the word "access" with pride. Saying "I had system access" made him sound important. Now he understood that an ambiguous boast could later harden into the shape of evidence.

"Have you ever said yourself, 'I had server access'?" Aditya asked.

Shashank fell silent.

"Yes," he said at last. "In one or two places."

"True?"

"Incomplete. I had the facility to view some material. Independent control, administrative authority, or technical operation—no."

"Then why did you say it?"

Shashank did not answer at once. His mind went to the hotel's superior room, the glittering road below, foreign bottles on the dining table, people wearing expensive watches, and the comparison with his own ordinary life. That night it had seemed to him that language had given him an entry pass into a closed world.

"Greed," he said.

Aditya stopped his pen. "For what?"

"Importance. Money. A way of life. When people heard the word 'access', they thought I was more important. I did not correct them."

"That admission is not an admission of a crime."

"I know."

"But it will be put on the record."

"Write it."

After noon, the travel messages were opened. In one message Li had written: "Tomorrow an Indian lawyer may also come; we need someone to look at the language of the papers." There was no name.

Shashank's chest grew slightly heavy.

"Do you remember?" Aditya asked.

"Yes. An Indian advocate was present at a later meeting."

"Name?"

Shashank said, "Raghav Bhasin."

"At the time, what did you understand his role to be?"

"He spoke about the contract papers, confidentiality, questions concerning payment, and the responsibilities of the parties. But I will not say here that he was a partner in the business. I had no evidence of that."

"Did you speak with him separately?"

"A few linguistic clarifications."

"About the nature of the gambling?"

"About certain words. He asked why the distinction in translating 'entertainment service' and 'wagering' mattered."

Aditya asked, "What did you tell him?"

"That changing the word could change the legal meaning."

"And after that?"

"He said, 'Then do not conceal the original word in the translation.'"

Shashank fell silent. There was something uncomfortable in this memory: at a moment when he himself had been using his intelligence to soften meaning, a lawyer had cautioned him in the opposite direction.

"You did not say this before?" Aditya asked.

"The memory has become clear only now."

"A convenient memory?"

Shashank's eyes sharpened. "Possibly. That is why, if anyone has a written record or a message, compare it. Do not accept it solely on my statement today."

Aditya looked at him for a few moments. "That is precisely why the question was asked."

In the evening session, an access log was shown to him. Date, time, guest number, and Shashank's name. That day he had remained in the office for nearly five hours.

"Five hours = five hours of server operation?" Aditya asked.

"No."

"Five hours = only translation?"

"That too is not automatically established. What happened inside would require separate material."

"Your memory?"

"Linguistic discussion, a demonstration, a meal break, preliminary talk about the contract. For some time I was also left waiting alone."

"In other words, duration does not establish role."

"Yes."

With that sentence, an old pride broke inside Shashank. Five hours, a foreign office, a guest pass, an expensive hotel—all of it had seemed like achievement to him then. Now each thing was becoming merely itself; it was his mind that had added the meaning.

When the session ended, Aditya said, "It is easy to draw conclusions both against you and in your favour. The difficult question is what is sufficient to support any one of those conclusions."

Shashank said, "And greed?"

"Greed is part of the context of the mind. It does not take the place of evidence."

"But it can affect a decision."

"Yes. Your decision. Not the court's decision unless and until its connection with an act and with evidence is established."

Shashank stood. Outside, darkness was falling.

Mrinal was waiting by the roadside. The moment he saw Shashank, he asked, "Did you tell them?"

"Yes. I went to Macao."

"And?"

"I wanted to appear more important than I was."

Mrinal said nothing.

The two stood to one side with tea. Shashank said, "I got many things there—a hotel, meetings, foreign people, the hope of money. But the most expensive thing was one word: access. I wore the word like a badge."

Mrinal said, "And now?"

"Now I ask what it means."

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

"Foreign travel ≠ crime established."

"Hotel reservation ≠ institutional unity."

"Same meeting ≠ partnership."

"Guest access ≠ independent control."

"Seeing an open screen ≠ server operation."

"Long presence ≠ role established."

"Greed = motive of the mind; not a substitute for evidence."

"Exaggerating one's own access = an error of pride; but an investigation must establish its actual limits."

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: "In Macao I should have understood for the first time that language is not merely a door; sometimes the papers of a contract stand behind the door."

He tried to remember Raghav Bhasin's face—bent over a file, searching for boundaries between words.

The next question would probably be more about paper than about language.

CHAPTER 53

THE MIRROR OF MACAO I

The next morning, the file Aditya Mishra showed Shashank bore, in red letters across the top: “CONFIDENTIAL: LEGAL REVIEW.” Shashank’s eyes caught first on “confidential,” then on “legal.” The line he had written in his notebook the previous night—“Behind the door stand the papers of the contract”—suddenly seemed very close.

Aditya said, “Today the question is not what seal appears on the paper. The question is what boundary that seal creates—and what boundary it does not.”

Shashank sat down. “Raghav Bhasin’s file?”

“His name appears in this correspondence. But first, one thing must be clear: the presence of a lawyer does not by itself establish participation in a crime. Nor does writing ‘confidential’ on a document automatically place all its contents under attorney-client privilege. We have to look at the purpose of the material, the parties, the context, and its use.”

Shashank’s throat went dry. The first wave of fear came here. He remembered that meeting in Macao, where Raghav Bhasin had opened a file and drawn lines between words, while Shashank, displaying his linguistic skill, had altered sentences here and there. At the time it had all seemed like professional competence. Now each line stood before him as potential evidence.

Aditya opened the first record. It was an early draft of a service agreement. One section referred to linguistic assistance, client communication, and local presentation; another placed payment-related obligations in the name of a separate entity.

“Did you see this draft?”

“Yes. To explain the wording.”

“Did you prepare it?”

“No.”

“Did you suggest changes?”

“In a few places, to the language.”

“The payment section?”

Shashank thought for a few moments. “One word. I was asked what ‘settlement’ meant. I explained its ordinary sense as settlement of payment. Which account, which channel, which person—none of that was part of my linguistic work.”

Aditya showed him the next page. “There are abbreviated names for three accounts here. Some of the accounts stand in the names of individuals or small entities whose primary business appears to be something else. In a later investigation, suspicion was recorded that these were ‘mule accounts.’ Did you know that at the time?”

“No. I did not know who owned the accounts.”

“Then would you call them ‘mule accounts’ now?”

“I can call that an investigative classification. I cannot describe it as knowledge I had at the time.”

Aditya nodded. “Good. Allegation, classification, and established fact are separate things.”

Shashank kept hold of the corner of the paper. His fear was not that he had operated all those accounts—he had never made such a claim. His fear was why his name appeared in so many records. If the translator’s role was only language, why did his presence recur in transcripts of meetings about payments?

Aditya seemed to read his mind. “Postulation may be useful here, but only with care.”

Shashank looked at him.

“One record says your role was purely linguistic. Another shows you present at several meetings where money, services, and accounts were discussed. Both facts exist together. So an explanation is needed. But ‘criminal partner’ is not the only possible explanation. It may be that linguistic assistance was necessary in those meetings, that in practice your role was broader than the written agreement described, or that the records are incomplete. Which explanation survives will depend on other evidence.”

Shashank said quietly, “So the moment we see a contradiction, we do not have guilt.”

“No. A contradiction creates a need for explanation. Postulation is not a licence to fill an empty space with whatever one wishes.”

Something inside Shashank loosened at that sentence, but the fear did not leave him. The next email bore his own name. Its subject line read: "Privileged / legal review only." The sender was Raghav Bhasin; among the recipients were two business names, Li Wenchao, and Shashank.

Aditya asked, "Do you remember this email?"

"Vaguely."

"Were you Raghav Bhasin's client?"

"I don't know. He was never retained as my personal lawyer."

"Then why does the subject say 'privileged'?"

"Perhaps it was an instruction to everyone to keep it confidential."

"Perhaps. But a subject line does not by itself establish a legal relationship. Read the contents."

In the email, Raghav had written that the original commercial terminology, the actual parties to payment, and the description of risk must not be made ambiguous in translation. On one sentence in particular he had commented: "If the original term is wagering, presenting it merely as entertainment may alter the legal meaning."

Shashank lowered his eyes. It matched that old memory.

Aditya asked, "Is that advice about concealing a crime, or about making the language clear?"

"Making it clear."

"Then what does Raghav's presence here establish?"

"Only that he was urging caution in the legal language."

"And if his name later appears in payment records?"

Shashank paused before answering. "Then that requires a separate inquiry. Caution expressed in one email cannot predetermine the meaning of another record."

A faint satisfaction appeared on Aditya's face. "Good."

The next file contained a summary list of Indian accounts. No complete account numbers, only partial identifiers, dates, names of parties, and categories of transaction. Beside some entries was "service," beside others "reimbursement," and beside some only a question mark. One note read "cash equivalent?"; another, "crypto reference mentioned—verify independently."

Aditya placed his thumb on the paper. "These are not operational details. They are investigative relationship-notes. See where your name appears."

Shashank found an entry—fee for linguistic services. The amount was higher than what he ordinarily earned from such work at the time. His chest tightened again.

"Was this payment yours?"

"Yes. Probably after this series of meetings."

"For what work?"

"Translation, terminology lists, assistance in meetings."

"Why was the amount higher?"

The answer was difficult for Shashank. "I didn't ask."

"Why not?"

"Not fear—greed, then." He corrected himself at once. "And pride. I thought that at last someone understood the value of my skill."

"Why fear now?"

For the first time Shashank looked directly at Aditya. "Because now I understand that a larger payment can call for an explanation. I asked no questions then. What meaning someone may now give my silence is no longer within my control."

Aditya said, "This is exactly where postulation and inference must be kept apart. What we see is an amount unusually high compared with the ordinary fee. That may require explanation—extra time, extra services, travel, or some other reason. 'Higher amount = share in a crime' is not a direct conclusion."

"But if other evidence joins it?"

"Then the relationship changes. A web of evidence is not made from a single strand."

A night in Macao rose in Shashank's memory. Raghav Bhasin was seated at the dining table, his file closed. Li Wenchao had laughed and said something Shashank had only half heard: "In India, money finds more routes than paper does." Everyone had laughed then. Shashank too.

He said suddenly, "I remember one sentence."

Aditya raised his pen.

Shashank repeated the sentence, then added on his own, "But I'm not certain whether these are the exact words I remember, or a form shaped by what happened later."

"Then in the statement we'll write: 'memory of the sense, not the exact wording.'"

"Did Raghav say anything then?"

Shashank closed his eyes. "He stopped laughing and said, 'What you cannot put on paper, do not say aloud either.' Perhaps."

Aditya stopped him. "Perhaps, again?"

"Yes. My memory of that sentence is not clear. Please do not treat it as Raghav's statement without independent confirmation."

Aditya wrote: "Unverified memory."

In the midst of fear, Shashank felt a strange relief. Earlier he had believed that in order to save himself he had to deny everything. Now he was beginning to understand that admitting some things, limiting some, saying "I don't remember" to others, and asking for independent evidence for still others—this was not weakness. It was the structure of truth.

After noon, Raghav Bhasin came in person. His face was tired, but his voice remained steady. He greeted Aditya and said, "I am not here to disclose my clients' confidential legal advice. I am here to clarify the boundary of what is not privileged."

Aditya said, "That is precisely the dispute. Some records concern commercial coordination, some legal advice, some are mixed. We are not going to paste the same label over all of them."

Raghav nodded. "Right."

Shashank watched him. Part of his fear was that Raghav would abandon him and say: the translator did everything of his own accord. Another part was that Raghav would do the opposite—cover reality in order to save him. Shashank feared both.

Aditya placed a draft in front of him. "On this page is Shashank's linguistic comment. Below it is your legal comment. Does that make Shashank your client?"

Raghav said, "No. Commenting on the same document does not determine the nature of the relationship."

"Does it make him a member of the legal strategy team?"

"No."

"Does it make him a complete outsider?"

Raghav paused. "That is not so simple either. In some meetings he was present because of the language. Some material was shown to him. He had practical access. But practical access does not mean decision-making authority."

Shashank kept his eyes on Raghav. In that sentence there was neither defence nor abandonment—only a boundary.

Aditya asked, "Can attorney-client privilege conceal material showing participation in a crime?"

Raghav replied, "The limits of privilege depend on the facts, the purpose, and the applicable law. Merely writing 'privileged' on something does not make a commercial act disappear. But an investigation cannot simply seize every piece of legal advice by calling it a cover for crime either."

Shashank's fear stirred again—the way lay open in both directions. Paper was neither a complete shield nor a complete sword.

Aditya took out one final email. This time the sender was a person identified only by an unfamiliar abbreviation. The subject was "India routing summary." The attachment was unavailable, but one line from Raghav survived in the reply chain: "I need the actual contracting and paying parties, not labels."

Aditya said, "The attachment is missing. So what does this line tell us?"

Shashank said, "That Raghav wanted the names of the actual parties."

"Does it tell us that he was operating the alleged mule accounts, hawala, or bitcoin arrangement?"

"No."

"Does it tell us there may have been suspicion or ambiguity that led him to ask who the actual parties were?"

Shashank paused. "Possibly. But without the attachment, the context is incomplete."

Raghav said, "Correct."

Aditya marked the line: "Incomplete context; additional records required."

As evening fell, the session ended. As Raghav rose to leave, he stopped beside Shashank. "Are you afraid?"

Shashank answered, "Yes."

"Of what?"

"Of the fact that my name is on papers whose full meaning I did not ask about at the time."

Raghav said, "Fear can sometimes be useful if it teaches you to ask questions. But do not let fear make you give answers that the record itself does not give."

Shashank could not smile, but he nodded.

Mrinal was waiting outside. The two walked along the roadside. Mrinal asked, “Will the lawyer save you?”

Shashank said, “I understand now—a lawyer is not a shield; he is like a document that tells you where the boundary lies. If the boundary is on my side, it may protect me. If my act crossed the boundary, the seal cannot erase that.”

“And your fear?”

“Earlier I was afraid that everyone would decide I was guilty. Today I’m afraid that I myself may turn my old life into a false story and then believe it.”

That night he wrote in his notebook—

“Marked confidential ≠ automatically privileged.”

“Presence of a lawyer ≠ participation established.”

“Legal advice ≠ ownership of a commercial act.”

“Unusual payment = need for explanation; not a conclusion of crime.”

“Missing attachment = incomplete context.”

“Postulation = holding conflicting facts together and seeking the minimum necessary explanation; not filling the gap with the guilt one prefers.”

“Fear = can distort the boundaries of a statement; not a substitute for evidence.”

Before he could write the last line, his phone rang. It was a short message from Aditya: “Tomorrow we have to look at some internal tax-information notes. We have found two different versions of the same record.”

Shashank stared at the screen for a long time. One record—two versions.

In the mirror of Macao, the reflection of the paper had now split in two.

CHAPTER 54

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 2

The next morning, when Shashank reached Aditya Mishra's office, two files lay side by side on the table. The title at the top was the same on both: "INTERNAL TAX INFORMATION: VERIFICATION OF THE PAYING PARTY." The date too was the same. But the version number in the upper-right corner was different.

Aditya said, "The message I sent yesterday was because of these two copies. The first was preserved in the archive of the lower commissionerate. The second was found in the circulation file of the higher tax-intelligence branch. Both have the same original title, but different conclusions."

Yesterday's fear rose again inside Shashank. He remembered Raghav Bhasin's line: "I need the actual contracting and paying parties, not labels." Until yesterday, the ambiguity of the papers had been a question; today that same question lay before him in the form of two different answers.

Aditya opened the first version. He read the final paragraph: "There is a mismatch among the names of the contracting entity, the paying entity, and the ultimate recipient. An immediate criminal conclusion would be inappropriate; beneficial ownership, delivery of services, and the basis of the funds should be independently verified."

Then he opened the second version: "The available record indicates a commercial basis for the service payment. No direct tax loss is presently established; the matter may be placed at lower priority."

Shashank read the two passages again. "The second version does not directly contradict the first either."

"Correct," Aditya said. "But what does it leave out?"

Shashank's thumb moved to the lower part of the first page. "Beneficial ownership. The ultimate recipient. Delivery of services. All three verification questions are absent from the second version."

"What does that establish?"

Shashank's mind darted at once toward the word compromise. He stopped it. "It establishes that the scope of the conclusion was narrowed. Why it was narrowed—that is not yet established."

Aditya drew a circle with his pen. "In this context, that is exactly the answer I need."

The officer from the lower commissionerate—the same man who had earlier left open the question about the name of the payment recipient—entered the room. In his hand was a thin brown file. As he sat down, he said, "My copy had an attachment with it. That attachment is not in the upper circulation copy."

Aditya asked, "What attachment?"

"A seven-line reconciliation sheet: contracting party, invoice issuer, paying party, declared recipient of the service, name of the bank recipient, available legal comment, and a column marked 'VERIFICATION PENDING.'"

Shashank leaned slightly forward. "My name is on that sheet?"

The officer said, "In one place—as linguistic service provider. That is all."

"Intermediary?"

"No."

"Controller?"

"No."

Shashank let out a long breath. With relief came shame as well—he had spent so long fearing what his name might mean in the record, yet the record described him only as a linguistic service provider. Even so, relief was not evidence in itself, just as fear was not evidence.

Aditya placed a copy of the reconciliation sheet before them. In two rows, the paying party and the contracting party were different. In one row, beside the name of the bank recipient, were the words "explanation pending." No amounts were shown; only the status of the relationships was displayed.

Aditya said, "Different paying party = mule account?"

Shashank said, "No."

"Different bank recipient = hawala?"

"No."

"Foreign-payment reference = crypto?"

"No. Nothing of that kind can be concluded from this sheet."

The officer looked at Shashank. "That is precisely why I wrote 'verification pending.'"

Aditya asked, "Then why is the attachment not in the upper version?"

The officer's face hardened. "I do not know."

"Do you believe it was deliberately removed?"

The officer took his time before answering. "I suspect it. But suspicion is my statement; it is not proof of the purpose for which it was removed."

Shashank was startled by the sentence. Over the past weeks Aditya had taught him that boundary again and again. Now an officer inside the institution was drawing the same boundary around his own anger.

Aditya opened the digital history of the first version: creation time, modification time, circulation time. The second version had been created about three hours after the first. Between them was an entry titled "summary review," but the author's name was not clear; there was only a collective identifier for the branch.

Shashank said, "Then someone edited it in between."

"Someone—or some procedural system," Aditya said. "For now, that is all."

"But how was the second conclusion produced without the original attachment?"

Aditya looked at him. "Postulation may be useful here—but carefully. If the chronology of the two versions is established, and the first contains unanswered questions based on an attachment while those questions are absent from the second, it becomes difficult to understand both states together without accepting that some selection or editing occurred in between. But 'editing occurred' does not automatically yield 'editing occurred to conceal wrongdoing.'"

Shashank said softly, "The minimum necessary explanation."

"Yes. Not the guilt one prefers."

Meanwhile, Raghav Bhasin was brought into the discussion briefly by telephone. Aditya asked him only one question: "In your legal-review note, did you insist that the actual contracting party and paying party be identified clearly?"

Raghav said, "Yes. I wanted the actual parties, not the labels. But I had no authority to determine the final priority of the tax inquiry."

"Did you see this attachment?"

"I remember seeing a reconciliation table, but without seeing the original I cannot say whether it was precisely this copy."

Aditya stopped there. "That is enough."

Shashank thought how easy it would have been, merely on seeing Raghav's name, to say that the lawyer, the payments, and the confidentiality all belonged to one web. Yet a name could appear across many papers simply because that person had reviewed their language; a conclusion of participation required separate evidence of act, authority, and purpose.

Later that afternoon, a new fact emerged. In the lower commissionerate's file there was a signed "reservation note" from the officer: "A reduction in priority should not be treated as extinguishing the factual questions; the original reconciliation sheet should be preserved." The upper circulation file contained no reference to this reservation note.

As Shashank studied the letters of the reservation note, he remembered that night in Macao when the gleaming building, legal seals, and foreign signatures had made him feel that institutional papers would, by themselves, yield a trustworthy meaning. Now he was beginning to understand: a seal does not take the place of truth. Truth also asks which question was recorded, which question was omitted, and which copy survived into the future.

The sense of betrayal cut deeper because he had once regarded institutional discipline as a counterweight to his own private weakness. A person could be greedy; a translator could soften meaning; a merchant could change labels—but the records, he had believed, would put everything back into its proper order. Today that belief itself had become an object of examination.

Shashank's face reddened. "This is clearly a betrayal."

Aditya stopped him at once. "What is clear?"

Shashank clenched his teeth. "What is clear is that the reservation note is not in the upper copy."

"And the betrayal?"

He closed his eyes and sat still for a moment. "My feeling."

"Correct."

Alongside the anger, an old memory rose inside Shashank—how often he himself had shortened a caution in the original sentence for a client's convenience. Sometimes from greed, sometimes from haste, sometimes from the desire to appear important. Seeing the same kind of shortening now in an institutional record, he recognized the shadow of his former self. That shadow angered him all the more because he knew how much meaning could change when words were removed.

The officer said, "That is why I did not send my copy outside. I preserved it only in the archive."

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"I was told orally that the matter had been reduced in priority. But I had no basis for saying 'the questions are closed.' So I preserved the original comment and the attachment."

"Did you register an objection?"

"Not an administrative dispute. Only an archival reservation."

Shashank looked at him. This form of resistance was neither a slogan nor a display of courage. To preserve one line—that was all. Yet sometimes that one line could keep the door of later verification open.

Aditya asked again, "From whom did the oral instruction at the higher level come?"

The officer named a designation, not a person. "The message chain was oral; I cannot identify the direct sender by name with certainty."

"Then we will not attach anyone's name by inference," Aditya said.

Shashank asked, "If the digital record has no author's name, the source of the oral order is unclear, and the reservation note is absent—doesn't that make it necessary to assume a 'system compromise'?"

Aditya answered, "What is necessary is to accept that the version changed, some material did not reach the circulation copy, and the priority was reduced. Those three facts together require explanation. 'System compromise' may be one possible explanation; administrative condensation, confusion over authority, negligence, or some other cause remain testable as well. Until additional evidence makes one option necessary, postulation does not eliminate the alternatives."

Shashank fell silent. He remembered the lesson of Navya-Nyaya: postulation has force only where the available facts remain inexplicable without the assumption. But if several assumptions can explain the available facts, calling the preferred assumption the truth is not justified.

Toward evening, an internal receipt register arrived. It showed that the lower commissionerate had sent the file with the original attachment. The higher branch's receipt register recorded: "Main letter: 1; attachment: 1." The later circulation register recorded only "main letter."

Silence spread through the room.

Shashank said, "Then the attachment was lost in between."

Aditya raised his head. "Say it became absent in between. 'Lost' carries an implication about cause."

Shashank corrected himself. "Right. The attachment was recorded at receipt; it was not recorded at circulation. The intervening state has to be verified."

The officer said, "That is why I preserved my copy."

Shashank kept looking at him. The feeling of betrayal remained, but its shape had changed. Earlier he had imagined that some person had sold the truth. Now he saw that within an institution some hands shorten questions, some preserve them, some people merely obey orders, and some refuse to erase the word "pending." A conclusion of crime or collusion was still distant; the crack in the process was directly visible.

As the session ended, Aditya said, "Write today's conclusions."

Shashank opened his notebook.

"Two versions ≠ two purposes established."

"Cautionary line absent = editing directly observed; cause remains to be tested."

"Attachment in receipt register, absent from circulation register = intervening state open to verification."

"Reduction in priority ≠ factual questions extinguished."

"Different paying party ≠ mule account established."

"Ambiguous payment ≠ hawala or crypto established."

"Lawyer's name ≠ operation or ownership established."

"Reservation note = the lower commissionerate kept the question open—that is all; it does not by itself establish collusion at the higher level."

"Postulation = the minimum necessary assumption when the available facts would otherwise remain inexplicable; not anger's preferred answer."

His hand stopped as he wrote the final line. "Betrayal = a feeling. Documentary gap = direct observation. They are not the same."

He was about to close the notebook when Aditya's assistant came in carrying a new sealed envelope. Across the top were the words: "EXTERNAL CIRCULATION PROHIBITED." The inventory inside referred to that same tax-information note a third time, together with a quotation from a news summary.

Aditya did not open the envelope. He merely read the inventory.

Shashank asked, "A news summary?"

Aditya said, “Tomorrow. First we establish which sentence from the sealed material reached the outside, and which did not.”

The anger inside Shashank rose again, but this time he did not give it a name.

After the two reflections of paper in the mirror of Macao, a third shadow was now about to fall across the screen of the news.

CHAPTER 55

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 3

The next morning, Aditya Mishra placed a sealed envelope on the table. The rim of red wax was intact. Shashank kept looking at the small object as though it held not papers but all the humiliations of the past few weeks.

Aditya said, “First, the rule. We will see what is in this envelope only after we open it. We will not read the material inside as though the news circulating outside were already its truth. It would be equally wrong to force the words inside to mean what the headlines outside say they mean.”

Shashank’s phone had rung all night. One news outlet had written, “CENTRAL ROLE OF INDIAN TRANSLATOR IN MACAO PAYMENT NETWORK.” Another headline had joined his name to the words “legal shield.” One broadcast said he had been “the linguistic conduit between a Chinese vendor, an Indian lawyer, and secret accounts.”

He had shut all the headlines, but the words remained in his ears—central, shield, conduit. None of the three was evidence, yet the weight of public humiliation felt no lighter than evidence.

Aditya matched the number on the envelope with the record, took the signature of the officer present, and then broke the seal. There were three pages inside. The first was an inventory, the second an internal media summary, the third a note: “NO EXTERNAL CIRCULATION; UNVERIFIED NAMES NOT FOR PUBLIC QUOTATION.”

Shashank stopped at the third line. “Unverified names not for public quotation.” His own name had been broadcast all night.

“What does this establish?” Aditya asked.

Shashank’s voice was hard. “That the rule was broken.”

“Which rule, and by whom?”

He stopped. “The non-circulation rule written on this copy. But by whom it was broken—I cannot say yet.”

Aditya nodded. “Go on.”

The internal media summary had two paragraphs. The first raised questions about the mismatch between the paying party and the contracting party. The second said: “The roles of the Indian linguistic assistant and legal adviser present at the Macao meeting require separate verification; presence alone must not be used to infer beneficial ownership, control of payments, or participation in an offence.”

Shashank laid a hand on the page. “This sentence is not in the news outside.”

Aditya placed three published news summaries on the table. One said: “THE INTERNAL INQUIRY TREATS THE INDIAN LINGUISTIC ASSISTANT AND LEGAL ADVISER AS LINKS IN PAYMENT CONTROL.”

Silence spread through the room.

Shashank’s face flushed. “That is a false allegation.”

Aditya said, “Which part?”

“The part that calls us ‘links in payment control.’ The original line inside says the opposite—it is a caution against that conclusion.”

“And were you present at the Macao meeting?”

“Yes.”

“Was the legal adviser present?”

“Yes. Raghav Bhasin was present at one meeting.”

“Was there discussion of payment questions?”

Shashank drew a long breath. “There were questions about the language of the papers and the name of the paying party. I gave linguistic clarification.”

“Then is the entire report false?”

For a moment Shashank’s anger demanded the answer yes. But he remembered the old line in his notebook: humiliation = experience; false allegation = a testable proposition.

“No,” he said. “The meeting, the people present, and the discussion of the paying party all have a basis. But calling us a ‘link in control’ does not come from the original material. That conclusion has been added.”

Aditya wrote down the answer word for word.

Then he opened the second paragraph of the news report. It contained a sentence: “WITHOUT THE TRANSLATOR’S ACCESS, THE FOREIGN PAYMENT SYSTEM COULD NOT REACH THE INDIAN SERVICE SIDE.”

Shashank started. “Where did that come from?”

“That is why you should look.” Aditya showed him the lower part of the sealed page. It said: “Without linguistic mediation, some service instructions did not reach the Indian side clearly; this fact must not be treated as a necessary cause of the flow of funds.”

Shashank read slowly. The original said “service instructions”; outside, it had become “foreign payment system.” The original contained an express prohibition—that this was not a necessary cause of the flow of funds. Outside, that prohibition had disappeared.

He rose from his chair. “They are deliberately turning me into the centre of a crime.”

Aditya’s voice was not harsh, only steady. “What do we have at this moment?”

Shashank stood by the window. Outside was the brightness of afternoon; across his face lay the words of the night’s broadcasts. “Two transformations. In both, the caution is removed. In both, my role is enlarged.”

“And ‘deliberately’?”

He closed his eyes. “Purpose is not yet established.”

“Correct.”

Aditya showed him the third report. This time there was a strange similarity. The internal page used an unusual expression—“label-based inference.” The news report used almost the same expression: “label-based network.”

Aditya asked, “Is this a common expression?”

Shashank did not answer at once. “No. At least not in business reporting. This kind of compound sounds like something translated in my Navya-Nyaya manner.”

“Did you write it?”

Shashank looked at the letters on the page. “I will not say that with certainty. I do use ‘label.’ But there is no author’s name on this copy.”

“If the same unusual expression appears outside as well?”

“The possibility of some shared source becomes stronger.”

“Direct theft from this sealed copy?”

“Not necessarily. There could have been another copy of this line, a draft, an oral repetition, or an earlier circulation.”

A faint satisfaction came into Aditya’s eyes. “Postulation begins here. It does not end here.”

Shashank sat down again. The available facts were these: a public report contained an unusual expression that also appeared in the internal material; in the external version, the cautionary line had disappeared; and his name had been published though it remained unverified. To understand all that, it was reasonable to assume some shared source of information. But which person, which copy, which stage had been the source—those questions were still open.

Aditya drew four columns—“ORIGINAL,” “EXTERNAL VERSION,” “SAME,” “ADDED/REMOVED.” Shashank filled them sentence by sentence.

First: “roles require separate verification” → “link in payment control.” Same: the group of people. Added: conclusion of control. Removed: caution requiring verification.

Second: “linguistic mediation clarified service instructions” → “without the translator, the payment system could not function.” Same: linguistic mediation. Added: economic indispensability. Removed: the prohibition against treating it as a cause of fund flow.

Third: “label-based inference” → “label-based network.” Same: the unusual expression. Added: network. Removed: the criticism of the inference.

Shashank kept looking at the table. Humiliation was no longer mist; it was becoming structure. What had felt like a personal attack in the night now showed its linguistic mechanism on the page—remove the caution, intensify the word of connection, turn possibility into role, role into control.

But the mechanism was not unfamiliar to him. In the first glossary he had prepared for Li Wenchao, he had softened explicit references to gambling. For the client’s convenience he had blunted the edge of the words. Today the opposite process was being used against him—the edge was being sharpened.

The memory mixed a difficult shame into his anger.

Aditya asked, “What is it?”

“I am thinking—when I softened someone else’s sentence, perhaps the person affected by it also felt this kind of helplessness.”

"That is a moral comparison. Not an evidentiary comparison."

"I know," Shashank said. "But the humiliation is no longer only outside me. I can hear my own old words as well."

Raghav Bhasin came in after noon. He was shown only those portions of the sealed material that he was authorised to see. Reading the first page, he said, "My name is in the public headlines?"

Aditya said, "In two places."

Raghav's face hardened. "I was not an adviser on payment control. I was examining contractual obligations and the legal meaning of terms."

Shashank looked at him. A few weeks earlier, he had feared that Raghav's insistence on confidentiality might be a shield for concealing an offence. Today the same man had been joined to him inside the public accusation.

Aditya asked, "Did you see the draft of this internal media summary?"

"No."

"Do you use this unusual expression, 'label-based'?"

Raghav read the page. "No. But Shashank used to coin compounds of this kind."

Shashank felt his chest sink a little.

Aditya asked at once, "Does that establish Shashank as the author?"

Raghav said, "No."

"Why?"

"A habit of wording is an indicator, not authorship—especially when this person has been suggesting language in many meetings."

Shashank heard Raghav's answer in silence. He had been given a defence, but not out of mercy—out of delimitation.

By evening they had examined receipt lists, copy numbers, and permissions for circulation. One important fact emerged: before the sealed media summary was created, one draft had gone into the working files of four officers. That draft contained the expression "label-based inference," but not Shashank's name. In the final sealed copy, his name appeared only in the appendix's reference list.

Aditya said, "So the unusual expression existed in four working files before the sealed envelope was made."

Shashank understood. "Then a story based only on the breaking of the seal is not enough."

"Correct. How the information reached the outside news remains an open question. But the circle of possible sources now extends to four working files, possible copies of the draft, and the later sealed copy."

"And my name?"

"It was not in the early draft containing the unusual expression. So the name may have been joined from another source—travel records, a public contract, earlier news, or someone's statement. We will examine that."

For the first time all day, Shashank abandoned the urge to complete the sentence rising inside him: someone is framing me. It was possible. But the available facts also showed the convergence of several streams of information. It was not yet necessary to assume a planned conspiracy by one particular person.

Even so, the humiliation did not lessen. As he left the office, two reporters surrounded him. One asked, "Were you the chief translator for the Macao payment network?" The other: "Is Raghav Bhasin your legal partner?"

Shashank stopped. Earlier, in anger, he might have said, "It is all false." Today he chose his words.

"I provided linguistic assistance at some meetings in Macao. That fact does not establish control of a payment network. Raghav Bhasin is a lawyer; I had discussions with him concerning language and contracts. The evidence required for an allegation of partnership has not been shown to me. I will not comment publicly on sealed material."

One reporter asked again, "So you are not denying the allegations?"

Shashank said, "What is true, I will not deny. What is not established, I will not accept."

He walked on. Behind him, cameras, voices, and questions continued. The fire of humiliation was still burning inside him, but it was no longer writing the grammar of his answers.

That night Mrinal met him by the roadside. Without showing him the news, he asked, "Was it a hard day?"

"Yes."

"Is all of it false?"

Shashank gave a small laugh—a tired laugh. "No. That is exactly what makes it difficult. Some facts are uncomfortable for me, some conclusions are unproved, and some sentences reverse the original. People want one word—innocent or guilty. The record does not yet give that one word."

Mrinal said, "Then don't give them one word."

On reaching home, Shashank opened his notebook.

“Sealed = not automatically true; source and completeness remain testable.”

“An expression from sealed material found outside = possibility of a shared information source; not a certain sender.”

“Name published = allegation; role not established.”

“Presence at a meeting = direct fact; control of payments = separate question.”

“Lawyer’s presence = possible legal role; partnership not established.”

“Removal of caution = may alter meaning; purpose requires separate evidence.”

“Humiliation = experience; false allegation = a testable proposition.”

“Postulation = the assumption necessary to understand the available facts; not a licence to choose a convenient enemy.”

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: “The words that wounded me in public will return tomorrow as questions before the court.”

At once a message came from Aditya: “Tomorrow, limited judicial hearing. Cross-examination possible on the media summary, the draft chain, and the public transformations.”

Shashank switched off his phone. The mirror of Macao was now about to be lifted from the screen of the news and placed before the court.

CHAPTER 56

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 4

As Shashank entered the courtroom, he understood for the first time how different the noise of the news media was from the silence of a court. Outside, words such as “central link,” “legal shield,” and “Macao payment network” circulated beside his name; inside, the table held only the sealed news brief, its chain of drafts, two internal notes, and a limited set of records.

The judge made the boundary explicit: “Today’s hearing will be confined to the authenticity of the material, the chain of its transformations, and the conclusions drawn from it. No person will be declared guilty or innocent in this limited hearing.”

A strange calm entered Shashank. After the humiliation of public accusation, the word boundary felt almost like shelter. Yet he knew that a boundary would not merely protect him; within that same boundary he would have to name his own errors as well.

The cross-examination began. Counsel opposite lifted the first draft of the news brief. “This page says: ‘The Indian translator served as a regular linguistic bridge between the Chinese vendor and the Indian legal adviser.’ Is this sentence about you?”

Shashank replied, “There is no name. The context may correspond to me, but I would not claim a certain identification from the description alone.”

“You knew the Chinese vendor Li Wenchao?”

“Yes.”

“You knew Raghav Bhasin?”

“Yes.”

“You translated between the two?”

“I provided linguistic assistance in some meetings.”

Counsel put the paper down on the table. “Then what objection can you have to being called a ‘linguistic bridge’?”

Shashank was silent for a moment. “As a description, it may fit some meetings. But if ‘bridge’ is then used to conclude that the two sides shared business ownership, payment control, or a criminal purpose, that is a separate inference. It requires separate evidence.”

“So the word is correct, but the meaning is wrong?”

“No. The word too needs boundaries. How many meetings I attended, what I translated there, and what was said in my presence must each be examined separately.”

Counsel smiled. “You separate everything.”

Shashank’s expression tightened slightly. “I am learning that when everything is fused together, it becomes a story; when it is separated, the limits of the evidence become visible.”

A faint rustle moved through the courtroom. The judge continued writing notes.

The next page bore Raghav Bhasin’s name. Counsel asked, “Mr Bhasin has claimed legal confidentiality and lawyer-client privilege over certain communications. Were you present in those communications?”

“In some of them.”

“Then were you also under the shelter of privilege?”

Shashank did not look toward Aditya. He had to answer this one himself. “I was not a lawyer. I was a translator. When legal advice was being explained across languages, my role was linguistic. If a meeting dealt with ordinary business instructions, practical payment questions, or a list of services, the mere presence of a lawyer would not make all of it legal advice.”

“Where did you learn this legal interpretation?”

“I am not giving a legal conclusion. I am separating the kinds of work I performed and the circumstances of my presence.”

The judge intervened. “The witness will answer only from his own experience. The court will determine whether privilege applies.”

Shashank lowered his head. He felt relief, because in earlier years he had spoken many sentences that exceeded the authority he actually possessed. Knowing language and knowing one’s authority were not the same thing.

The cross-examiner opened another file. "This note contains terms such as 'settlement,' 'service reimbursement,' and 'wallet movement.' In a later Maithili-Hindi summary, the language was softened into 'service payment,' 'adjustment,' and 'transfer of points.' Are some of those translations yours?"

Shashank studied the page carefully. "Some of the word choices resemble my style. If the original records are available, they can be compared. But I do admit that on some occasions I softened explicit language relating to gambling or payment."

Counsel asked at once, "Why?"

The courtroom became utterly still.

"To preserve the work. So that fewer questions would be raised, so the client would continue to find me useful, and so I could enlarge my own role. It was a mixture of those motives."

"So you deliberately altered meaning?"

Shashank's throat went dry. He asked for water and took a sip. "In some places, yes—I blunted the force of explicit words. But I will not say that I changed every record, every payment, or every party's purpose. I will admit only what can properly be admitted."

The cross-examiner sharpened his tone. "Isn't this repentance convenient in court? You concede a portion of fault, then block the conclusion of criminality?"

For the first time Shashank looked directly into his eyes. "If I hid my own mistakes and said everything was false, that would be false. If, without evidence, I said I was the owner or operator of a payment network, that would also be false. Repentance gives me no right to accept more guilt than the truth supports; it obliges me to accept exactly as much as is true."

After that answer, for several moments the only sound in the courtroom was the scratch of pens. Shashank's palms were damp with sweat, yet the fire that had accompanied the humiliations of the past few days was absent. A heavy thing was finding its proper name: responsibility.

Counsel now turned to the chain of drafts. In the first draft, one line read: "Beneficial ownership cannot be determined from the available material." In the second, it had been shortened to: "Ownership under examination." In the public news version, that caution disappeared altogether, replaced by the headline: "Indian Link to Secret Accounts."

"You say the news became false because the cautionary line was removed?"

Shashank said, "Not every part of it. Some facts may remain correct—the trip to Macao, my acquaintance with Li, some linguistic work, the circumstance of Raghav Bhasin's presence. But 'Indian link to secret accounts' does not follow automatically from those facts."

"Then where did the headline come from?"

"I do not know."

"Use postulation."

At the word, an old memory flashed inside Shashank, almost like Gangesha's classroom: the minimum assumption necessary to remove an inconsistency between an unavailable direct fact and the facts already available—postulation. But he knew that necessity and convenience were not the same thing.

He said, "Some assumption may be necessary here: at some stage the draft was turned into a public version; someone did not retain the cautionary line; a headline was created. But the assumption that 'someone deliberately did this in order to frame me' is not necessary. Error, compression, editorial selection, an incomplete copy—there are several possibilities. On the present material, no single cause is yet required."

The cross-examiner asked, "Then can postulation never lead to a guilty person?"

Aditya sat in the row behind, his face unreadable. Shashank answered, "It can, if otherwise the available facts cannot be explained. But if there are five possible explanations, choosing the enemy one prefers is not postulation."

The judge looked up. "That answer will be recorded."

Counsel changed direction again. "There is a note by Raghav Bhasin: 'Do not conceal the original term in translation.' You referred to this in your earlier statement. What does this note establish?"

"That, at least in that context, he gave that caution."

"Does it establish that he is entirely innocent?"

"No."

"Does it establish that he participated in a crime?"

"No."

"Then what use is it?"

"It tells us his recorded role on one specific question. It is not proof of his entire character."

As he spoke, Shashank could hear an older version of his own voice—the voice that had once mistaken complexity for intelligence. Today he was not speaking to display complexity, but to accept limits. There was less brilliance in it, and more weight.

The cross-examiner paused, then asked, “Regarding the allegations of mule accounts, hawala, or bitcoin that have been circulating—did you directly observe the operation of those arrangements?”

Shashank said, “No. I heard those terms later, through the investigation and the news. I have seen some payment summaries and entries relating to digital currency; but who controlled which account, what the actual source of a transaction was, or how far any particular channel properly bears one of those labels—those are questions requiring independent evidence.”

“So hearing the name of an arrangement is not the same as knowing the arrangement?”

“Yes. And seeing one entry is not the same as knowing the whole chain.”

Counsel produced one last paper. “This payment summary contains entries involving three different channels. One refers to your linguistic-service fee, another to an Indian service entity, and a third to a digital-currency address abroad. Can you say that all three formed a single chain of funds?”

Shashank studied the page for a long time. “No. Three entries appearing in the same period and in the same file do not establish a single chain of funds. To connect them, one would need to examine source, recipient, instruction, timing, related records, and control.”

“But you were inside that world.”

“I was present at some meetings. I softened some language. I accepted some service fees. Those facts support only the conclusions they support. ‘Inside that world’ is a literary sentence, not a legal conclusion.”

A few people in the courtroom smiled. Shashank did not. He remembered his own sentence: I removed the latch from the door myself. He knew that a literary sentence might help his self-understanding, but a court required a chain—what link was direct perception, what was inference, what was postulation.

After the midday recess, Aditya was permitted a limited set of questions. He asked Shashank, “In your earlier statement, you admitted that you had exaggerated your own role?”

“Yes.”

“Does that make everything you say today automatically unreliable?”

Shashank paused. “My earlier exaggeration raises a question about my credibility. For that reason, my statements should be checked against independent records. But one statement proved false does not automatically make every statement false.”

Aditya asked, “And the public humiliation?”

Weariness settled across Shashank’s face. “It hurt me. But being hurt gives me no right to change the rules of evidence.”

“And your own mistakes?”

Shashank corrected himself before continuing. “My own mistakes: I softened words; I exaggerated some of my roles; I told my friend an incomplete truth. I will take responsibility for those. But I will not accept what is unproved merely to satisfy the public.”

Aditya asked nothing more.

Before the hearing ended, the court directed that the chain of drafts, the related digital communications, the available devices, and the original payment records be preserved. Limited summonses and statements from necessary persons would be considered at a later stage. No broad conclusion was to be recorded yet.

Shashank listened to the directions. “Devices,” “communications,” “summonses,” “statements”—these words were doors into the next stage. Fear rose again inside him, but with it came an old ambition: when investigators examined his old phone, notes, and messages, how many places would they find where he had written himself into a role larger than the reality?

When he came outside, Mrinal was waiting. “What happened?”

Shashank said, “Today, for the first time, I named my own errors in court without taking an additional crime upon myself.”

Mrinal asked, “Was it difficult?”

“Very. When a person has been humiliated, two paths seem easy: deny every fault, or take every fault upon one’s own head and become a magnificent penitent. The truth can disappear on either path.”

Mrinal said softly, “Then the third path?”

“Only as much as there is.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook. He wrote:

“Claim of privilege ≠ immunity from crime; but confidential legal advice ≠ automatic proof of participation either.”

“One meeting ≠ one purpose.”

“Linguistic softening = admitted error; financial control = a separate evidentiary question.”

“A changed draft = grounds to investigate the cause; malice not established.”

“Postulation = the minimum necessary assumption that removes an inconsistency; not the story one prefers.”

“Humiliation ≠ a right to alter the rules of evidence.”

“Repentance ≠ accepting more guilt than the truth supports.”

His pen stopped over the final line: “If the old devices are opened tomorrow, I will meet my own words again.”

He looked at his phone. He did not know how many old messages might still be inside it. But one thing was clear: the next test would not concern only other people’s statements; it would concern the digital imprint of his own ambition.

CHAPTER 57

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 5

On the third morning after the court's direction, Aditya Mishra's team arrived at Shashank's residence. The summons had already been served; today two digital devices, an old mobile phone and a laptop, were to be seized for examination under the court's limited order.

Shashank read the paper in full. In earlier years he would look at the heading before signing and read the remaining pages later. Today he read every line—which device, what period, what kind of material, what limit.

Aditya said, "If you wish, you may inform your lawyer. The inventory will be prepared in your presence, you will receive a copy, and the material will be used only within the limits of the order."

Shashank asked, "What about private matters unrelated to this case?"

"There is a procedure for setting those apart. But during examination it must first be determined what material is relevant. If that determination is disputed, the court will decide."

Shashank's gaze settled on the old mobile phone. It had lain in a cupboard for years. How many messages, how much self-praise, how many half-truths might still be alive inside it—he himself did not know.

Mrinal came in from the veranda. "Is this the phone from that time?"

"Yes."

"When you went to Macao?"

Shashank nodded.

Mrinal looked at the cracked cover on the back of the phone. "You wrote to me on this one: 'I am no longer merely a translator.' Do you remember?"

Something contracted inside Shashank's chest. "I remember it vaguely."

Aditya did not question him immediately. The inventory was completed, the devices were placed in sealed envelopes, and identification numbers were recorded. He said only, "We will look at the record instead of memory."

There was relief in that sentence for Shashank, and fear as well. Memory could be bent in his own favour; old words would show no such mercy.

That afternoon the statement began at the office. The first question concerned ownership of the device.

"The old mobile phone is yours?"

"Yes."

"Were you the principal user during that period?"

"I was."

"Did anyone else have regular access?"

"Not that I know of. An assistant may sometimes have handled the phone, but I cannot say anyone else used it regularly."

Aditya wrote: "Ownership of device and principal use admitted; authorship of each message to be tested independently."

Shashank read the line and said, "Correct."

By evening, a preliminary screening had identified some relevant messages. The full extraction was still under examination; only a few passages from the period specified in the court order were placed before Shashank.

The first message had been sent to Mrinal: "The work is expanding. The Chinese side and the Indian paperwork—both get stuck without me."

Shashank closed his eyes as soon as he read it.

Aditya asked, "Did you write this?"

"Yes, probably. The language is mine."

"Probably?"

Shashank read it again. "Yes. Now I remember clearly."

"Both get stuck without me'—fact?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "Exaggeration."

"How much?"

"In some meetings, language became easier because I was there. But that the entire Chinese side or the Indian paperwork would stop without me—that is not true."

"Why did you write it?"

Shashank's answer was not difficult; saying it aloud was. "To make myself look important."

Mrinal, who had been called as a witness for part of the statement, sat silently.

The second message was to an acquaintance: "Direct meetings in Macao with the main people. The language cannot function without me."

Aditya asked, "The main people?"

"I cannot now say who among them were institutionally 'main'. Some presented themselves as decision-makers; others described technical or commercial roles. I wrote it to magnify my own influence."

"The language cannot function without me?"

"That too was a sentence born of pride."

Aditya stopped his pen. "Then what do messages like these mean? Should we dismiss them as self-promotion and nothing more?"

Shashank looked at the paper before answering. "No. They show that I presented my role as larger than it was. They may be useful in understanding my state of mind, my ambition, and the closeness of some relationships. But the sentences do not by themselves establish decision-making authority, ownership, or financial control."

"Why not? The author himself says—the work cannot proceed without me."

Shashank said, "Because the author himself admits that he was inflating his influence, and actual authority requires separate records. My boasting is itself evidence that I boasted; every factual claim made in the boast does not thereby become true."

A faint line appeared on Aditya's face. "We will test that."

The third extract read: "Raghav will handle the payment side, I will handle language, the technical people their part."

Shashank's eyes remained fixed on the line.

Aditya asked, "What do you understand from this?"

"That, at least at that moment, I thought of the roles as separate."

"Did Raghav control payments?"

"The sentence says only that I understood him to be dealing with payment-related matters. It does not establish actual authority, control of accounts, or the source of funds."

"Then why did you write it that way?"

"Questions about payment-related documents and the contract were raised before him in meetings. I generalized from that and wrote it as though it covered the whole matter."

Aditya wrote: "Record of the witness's contemporaneous perception; not independent proof of authority."

The fourth extract was the most uncomfortable. Shashank had written to an unidentified contact: "The Indian line will run through my introductions."

Silence spread through the room.

For the first time Mrinal looked directly at Shashank. There was a question in his eyes, not an accusation.

Aditya asked, "The Indian line?"

Shashank's throat went dry. "That phrase needs context."

"At present I have only this extract. The full conversation is being recovered and examined."

"Then I will not invent a meaning. My possible recollection is that by 'Indian line' I meant linguistic contacts on the Indian client side. But without the full conversation I will not say that with certainty."

"Could it mean an Indian arrangement of alleged mule accounts or payment gateways?"

"It is easy to say it could. It is impossible to say it is established. Look at the full conversation, the preceding and following lines, and the related documents."

Aditya nodded. "Very well. For now I will record: 'meaning unclear'."

Some of the fear inside Shashank loosened. Aditya was not taking his side; he was merely refusing to allow an empty space to be filled with whatever meaning someone preferred.

At this point the question of postulation arose. Aditya placed three pages on the table—the timeline of the Macao trip, Shashank's exaggerated messages, and an entry for a service fee.

"If all three exist together," Aditya said, "is it not necessary to assume at least this much: that you were an active manager of the network? Otherwise how do the trip, the boasting, and the payment make sense together?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments after hearing the question. In his earlier life, he himself had made such leaps—three signs, one conclusion. Today he understood the cost of that habit.

"No," he said. "To explain all three, it is enough at minimum to assume that I was a paid linguistic service provider, that I went to Macao, and that I exaggerated my own role. It would become necessary to assume 'active manager' only if the available records of authority, instructions, decisions, or movement of funds could not otherwise be explained. That necessity has not yet been established."

Aditya asked, "So postulation means the minimum assumption?"

"Yes. The one without which the facts remain incoherent. Not the one that makes the story more interesting."

Mrinal said softly, "Back then you were writing the interesting story yourself."

Shashank looked at him. "Yes. About myself."

There was no cleverness in the admission.

In the second stage of the statement, Mrinal was questioned. "What did Shashank tell you about his work?"

Mrinal answered, "It kept changing. At first he said—it is language work. Later he would say—the big people cannot function without me. Then sometimes he would become afraid and say—I am only a translator."

"Which version did you believe?"

Mrinal said, "I am his friend, not evidence. I had no reason to treat every statement of his as true."

"Did you ever directly see any illegal movement of money, alleged hawala, mule accounts, or digital-currency operations?"

"No."

"Any discussion of unusual payments?"

"He used to say the paperwork was complicated and that payments were handled by other people. But I personally never saw any account or operation."

Aditya added no further conclusion after that answer.

That afternoon an old draft list was found on the laptop in which Shashank had written the names of possible services he might provide—"translation", "meeting assistance", "local terminology", "Indian-side liaison", "travel assistance".

Aditya asked, "Indian-side liaison?"

Shashank said, "It is a broad expression. Connecting clients or people, arranging meetings, making linguistic introductions—I may have written it for all of those."

"Creating a payment network?"

"That is not written in the list. That would require independent evidence."

"But the list shows that you wanted to be more than a translator of words."

This time Shashank did not resist. "Yes. That is true. I wanted to enlarge my role."

"Why?"

"Money, prestige, access. And perhaps—" He stopped, then corrected his own word. "Not perhaps. Quite plainly—I liked people to think they needed me."

Aditya wrote: "Ambition admitted; specific unlawful purpose not established at present."

Shashank read the line and remained silent for a while. In the past few days he had understood that the most uncomfortable sentence in an investigation was not the one that called him guilty; it was the one that named his weakness accurately and then refused to leap to a conclusion.

The last material of the evening was a short note: "R.B. says keep legal paper separate from ops chat." The half-English sentence was characteristic of Shashank's old habit.

Aditya asked, "R.B.?"

"It could be Raghav Bhasin."

"ops chat?"

"Ordinary operational conversation. But what operation—I will not say without the full context."

"Why keep them separate?"

"I do not remember."

Aditya asked, "Was this an instruction to destroy or conceal evidence?"

Shashank answered directly, "Not from this sentence alone. There can also be ordinary reasons for keeping legal papers separate from routine operational communications. If other messages from that time show instructions to destroy material, then the position changes."

"And privilege?"

"The court will decide. I can speak only to the words of the note."

Aditya wrote beneath it: "Meaning disputed; additional context required."

As the session ended, Aditya said, “Your devices may speak against you or in your favour. But in truth devices do not speak—they yield records. We are the ones who make meaning from them.”

Shashank replied, “And while making meaning, we also add our fears and desires.”

“That is why we need rules.”

Outside, he and Mrinal walked in silence for a long time. When they stopped for tea by the roadside, Mrinal asked, “That message—‘I am no longer merely a translator’—did they find it?”

“Not yet.”

“And if they do?”

Looking into the cup, Shashank said, “Then I will read it. If I wrote it, I will admit it. But I will also look at what it means—what I had actually become, and what I was merely acting as though I had become.”

Mrinal said, “There can be a very great difference between the two.”

“Yes. And sometimes the price of that difference is very high.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

“The device is mine ≠ everything in it was written by me automatically.”

“My own boast = evidence of ambition; every claim in the boast ≠ established fact.”

“Service fee = service relationship; ownership or beneficial control = separate question.”

“Travel + payment + self-promotion ≠ necessary postulation of active management.”

“Ambiguous words = no certain meaning without full context.”

“Friend’s memory = supporting statement; not a substitute for independent records.”

“Digital seizure = a potential source of truth; not an instrument for a predetermined conclusion.”

“Ambition = real; criminal purpose = a matter for independent evidence.”

As he wrote the final line, he remembered the draft list on the laptop—“Indian-side liaison”.

He understood that in the next stage the question would no longer be whether he had wanted to enlarge his role. That had already been admitted. The question would be how far the contract papers, the vendor chain, and the records of actual beneficial ownership showed that ambition turning into real authority.

Raghav Bhasin was coming before him again—this time as the lawyer who did not understand Chinese, but whose signature appeared on some of the papers.

CHAPTER 58

THE LAWYER WHO DOES NOT UNDERSTAND CHINESE

On the following day, three people sat in Aditya Mishra's room not opposite one another, but on three sides of the same table—Shashank Jha, Raghav Bhasin, and Aditya. The papers on the table were copies selected from the previous day's digital seizure. On top lay two thick files: one a draft bilingual service contract, the other an Indian legal review with an annex concerning the payment side.

Aditya began, "Today the question is not whether we trust a person; it is whether we trust a text. Mr Bhasin does not understand the Chinese original. Shashank did. For that reason, the translator's role itself becomes a matter of evidence."

Raghav leaned slightly forward in his chair. "I have been saying this from the beginning. I was reviewing the English legal text. The meaning of the Chinese original depended on Shashank or on some other linguistic assistance."

An old pride glimmered faintly inside Shashank. How many times had people in meetings turned a document towards him and asked, "What does this say?" He would read one sentence, and every eye would settle on his answer. In those moments he felt not merely like a translator, but like the owner of meaning.

Aditya opened the first file. "On this page the Chinese original is on the left, the English text on the right. Both versions carry revision marks below them. Mr Bhasin, which text did you comment on?"

"The English."

"Did you verify the Chinese original?"

"No."

"Why?"

Raghav answered without affect. "Because I do not understand Chinese. If Shashank rendered the meaning incorrectly, it was difficult for me to detect that independently. That is why, in several places, I wrote 'comparison with original required'."

Aditya turned the paper towards Shashank. "Did you see this note?"

Shashank identified the line. "Yes."

"Did you carry out the comparison?"

"In some sections. Not all."

"Why?"

Shashank paused before answering. "There was little time—that was one reason. The other was that I trusted my own linguistic judgment more than I should have."

Raghav looked at him. "So what I was treating as verified had not all been verified?"

Shashank answered plainly, "Not all of it."

Silence spread through the room. The old voice of self-defence rose inside Shashank—this happened years ago; everyone was in a hurry; no one stopped me. But now he understood that "everyone was in a hurry" did not erase the measure of responsibility.

Aditya said, "What does this admission establish?"

Raghav answered, "At the very least, that some language in the English contract moved forward without independent verification against the original."

"And what does it not establish?"

Raghav thought for a few moments. "It does not by itself make Shashank the commercial owner of the contract, the beneficial owner, or the controller of payments."

Aditya nodded. "Correct."

He marked a paragraph. In the Chinese original, the context distinguished between payment-related coordination and the obligations of the service side; in the English draft, Shashank's translation had folded both into the broader expression "local service support".

"Why this change?" Aditya asked.

Shashank kept his eyes on the page. "At the time I thought the more specific wording would raise unnecessary questions for the Indian side. I simplified the language."

Raghav's voice hardened. "Simplified—or softened?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "Here—softened."

"Did you tell me?"

"No."

"Then the text I was reading as a legal text had already had its meaning altered."

"Yes."

That "yes" fell heavily in Shashank's ears. This was the darkest form of linguistic pride: the moment when he assumed that skill with words gave him the right to spare other people from questions.

Aditya intervened. "Now the limit of the conclusion. The meaning was softened—Shashank admits it. Mr Bhasin did not understand the original language—that is a fact. But none of that yet tells us who the actual beneficial owner of the contract was."

He opened the second file. Three records from the vendor chain were laid on the table—first, the contracting party; second, the party issuing the service invoice; third, the accounting entry naming the payment recipient. The three names were not identical.

Looking at the page, Raghav said, "It was because of precisely this discrepancy that I asked for a beneficial-ownership declaration."

Aditya showed them a note: "Declaration of actual beneficial ownership awaited." Raghav's signature appeared underneath.

Shashank looked closely. A signature of this kind could look ominous to someone outside the room—a lawyer, a foreign vendor, payment, all on one page. But the full sentence told a different story: the signature was not beneath an approval; it was beneath a record of incompleteness.

Aditya asked, "Mr Bhasin, what does this signature do?"

"It certifies that I had requested the declaration and that it had not been received by that time. It does not certify the identity of the beneficial owner."

"So your signature on the paper = party to the contract?"

"No."

"Shashank's linguistic comment = ownership of the vendor chain?"

"No to that as well."

Shashank felt uneasy. Raghav was not protecting him; he was simply refusing to say more than the paper said. Earlier, that impartiality had felt cold to him. Today it brought relief.

Aditya asked Shashank, "When you saw three different names, what did you understand at the time?"

"That different entities might be involved in service, invoicing, and payment."

"One actual owner?"

"I inferred that there was a connection."

"A connection—or common ownership?"

Shashank paused. "At the time I often treated the two as the same thing."

"And now?"

"Now I would say this: the three records require some commercial chain or reciprocal arrangement, because the service contract, invoice, and payment are difficult to understand unless they are connected in some way. But the nature of that connection—agency, subcontract, common owner, independent service agreement—cannot be determined without additional records."

Aditya's pen stopped. "This is where postulation operates. To remove the inconsistency, 'some relationship exists' may be the minimum necessary assumption. 'There is one secret owner' is not necessary."

Raghav said, "Exactly. And if the beneficial-ownership declaration is missing, the absence enlarges the question; it does not become the answer."

Inwardly, Shashank remembered Gangesha's classroom—postulation where the available facts seem impossible without some further assumption. But human greed leaps most quickly at the very point where the boundary between "necessary" and "pleasing" is thin.

Aditya brought out a third paper. It was a small table recovered from a draft list on Shashank's old laptop. The heading read: "Indian-side contacts". One row gave Raghav Bhasin's name, with "legal/contract" beside it; another gave Shashank's, with "language/local coordination"; a third contained an abbreviation for a vendor-side party.

"Did you make this table?"

"Probably. The style is mine."

"Probably?"

Shashank looked again. "Yes. This is my draft."

"What did 'local coordination' mean?"

"Arranging language-related meetings, delivering documents, carrying questions from one side to the other. Sometimes I described my role in broader terms than it deserved."

"Payment control?"

"Not from this line."

"Vendor selection?"

"No."

"Beneficial ownership?"

"No."

Raghav looked at Shashank. "But you do understand, don't you, how much meaning a phrase such as 'local coordination' can acquire later?"

Shashank lowered his face slightly. "I understand now. At the time I was proud that I could be translator, liaison, meeting assistant—all at once. Writing the roles separately made me feel smaller."

"Linguistic pride," Aditya said.

"Yes." For the first time Shashank admitted it without adding a defence. "I liked the fact that Raghavji looked to me to understand the Chinese original. Li looked to me for the English meaning. People on the Indian side would ask me even how to pronounce names. I mistook that dependence not merely for competence, but for importance."

Raghav's expression did not soften, though his voice was less severe. "Competence can make you important. But when other people cannot read the original, that does not give a translator the right to conceal ambiguity."

"I know."

"You did not know then?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments. "I knew. But I did not live by what I knew."

After that sentence, a long silence remained in the room. Shashank felt that in many earlier statements he had named his errors "time pressure", "presentation", "simplification". Today, for the first time, linguistic pride itself stood before him as a cause.

Aditya moved to the next question. "Is Raghav Bhasin's signature on the final version of the contract?"

Raghav said, "It appears on some legal-review pages. Not as a party to the final commercial contract."

Aditya went through the pages one by one. In one place, above Raghav's signature, were the words "legal comments received"; elsewhere there were only initials. Shashank's name appeared in a translation-verification box, but the field marked "actual beneficial owner" was blank.

Aditya said, "What does this blank field mean?"

Shashank paused before answering. "Only that in the copy available to us, the declaration has not been filled in."

"That no declaration was ever provided?"

"I cannot say that."

"That there was no owner at all?"

"No."

"That Shashank or Raghav was the owner?"

"That neither."

Aditya said, "Filling an absence with the name of a particular person is not postulation. First we have to see whether the declaration exists in another version, which party asked for it, and where the economic benefit of the payment ultimately went—through lawful examination of the records."

Raghav nodded in agreement.

By the time the afternoon session ended, Shashank was exhausted. Mrinal was waiting in the corridor outside. The moment he saw him, Shashank said, "Today I understood how heavy a translator's words can become when a lawyer does not understand Chinese."

Mrinal asked, "Did Raghav blame you?"

"Where blame was due, he did. Where there was no evidence, he did not."

"Did you blame him?"

"No. Earlier, I too used to draw many conclusions merely from seeing his signature. Today I read the whole line."

They kept descending the stairs. Shashank said, "My friend, understanding a language can sometimes feel like power."

Mrinal said, "Not power—borrowed trust."

Shashank stopped and looked at him. "Borrowed trust?"

"Yes. The person who cannot understand the original places his trust in your hands. You do not become its owner."

The sentence entered deeply into Shashank.

That night he opened his notebook.

"A lawyer's signature $\neq$ party to the contract."

"A translator's comment $\neq$ beneficial ownership."

"Three different entities = a question of relationship; common ownership not established."

"Blank beneficial-ownership field = missing information; no right to insert whichever name one prefers."

"Trust placed by one who cannot read the original = translator's responsibility."

"Linguistic pride = competence; but not permission to conceal ambiguity."

"Postulation = the minimum necessary relationship required to remove inconsistency; not a story for filling the empty space of an allegation."

As he wrote the final line, he remembered a message on the old mobile phone. At some point he had written to Mrinal: "Tomorrow we have to look at the money part of the paperwork; stay with me."

Whether that message had been merely an invitation to a friend or the beginning of a new payment-related stage could not be determined without seeing the record.

But the path of the next question was clear: the names on the papers would now have to be matched against the flow of money and against the memory of friendship.

CHAPTER 59

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 7

The last line in Shashank's notebook was still open: "The names on the papers must now be matched against the flow of money and the memory of friendship." When Aditya Mishra called him in the next morning, there was no contract file on the table, only four small records: a payment-gateway summary, a list of names attached to several accounts, an incomplete remittance note, and copies of old messages.

Aditya said, "Today we are not discussing how to open an account or operate any system. I only want to see what relationships these records create with one another, and where the limits of those relationships lie."

Shashank nodded. The sentence brought him relief and fear in equal measure. Relief—because the investigation was not proceeding as though he possessed knowledge of the crime itself. Fear—because he could not know in advance how often his own messages, placed beside names, dates, and amounts, would bring him uncomfortably close.

The first page contained three Indian names. Beside them were ordinary headings such as "service", "promotion", and "customer support". Aditya asked, "Did you know these people?"

Shashank shook his head at two names. At the third he paused. "The name sounds familiar. I am not certain."

"Whose account was it?"

"I do not know."

"Can you say that these were so-called mule accounts?"

Shashank raised his eyes from the paper. "Not from this page alone. Money arriving in someone's account does not by itself establish that the account was a front or mule account. That conclusion would require additional evidence—the account-holder's role, the real beneficiary of the money, the instructions, and the relationship shown by conduct. A list of names does not say all that."

Aditya made a small tick. "Correct. 'Mule' may be an allegation or an investigative hypothesis; it becomes an established fact only when the chain is sufficient."

The second record was a brief payment-gateway report. It contained aggregate totals of numerous transactions, dates, and service codes. No single line stood in Shashank's name. But one note read: "Indian contact for linguistic assistance."

Aditya asked, "Were you the Indian contact?"

"Possibly."

"Why 'possibly'?"

"At that time I did linguistic liaison work. But 'Indian contact' can also be a general designation. My name is not there."

"Postulation?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments. "If the date of the note, the related messages, and the meeting records showed that I was the only Indian linguistic contact there at that time, then it might become necessary to identify me as the person meant. But not from those two words alone."

Aditya did not smile. He merely wrote: "Postulation = the minimum necessary posit required to make the available facts coherent; not selecting a person for convenience."

The third paper was an old message from Shashank to Mrinal: "Tomorrow we have to look at the money part of the paperwork; stay with me." Shashank fell silent after reading the line.

Aditya asked, "Why Mrinal?"

"Trust."

"Legal advice?"

"No."

"Financial expertise?"

"No."

"Then?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "In that new world of mine, I needed someone who was still my own. Someone who knew me not merely as a useful translator, but as the old Shashank."

The answer was difficult for him to give. To place friendship among records of money was like placing something soft upon hard paper. Yet the softness of a truth does not reduce its evidentiary value; it merely makes its nature different.

Aditya asked, "Did Mrinal attend that meeting?"

"Yes, once."

"What did he see?"

"Papers, some payment headings, people talking. But as I remember it, he was not shown the complete records."

"Any source or destination of particular sums?"

"He heard names, but I would not say that he thereby understood who the actual beneficiaries were."

"So a friend's presence = participation in the network?"

"No." Shashank's answer came at once. "Presence, acquaintance, drinking tea, sitting in a meeting—none of those is coextensive with participation."

Aditya looked at him. "Are you making that defence for yourself as well?"

Without smiling, Shashank said, "Yes. But before I say it for Mrinal, it must be true for me too."

That afternoon Mrinal himself arrived. Aditya gave him a separate chair. "Your statement is limited. Say what you remember. You do not need to draw conclusions for or against Shashank."

Mrinal looked at the paper. "This message is mine. I went."

"Why did you go?"

"Shashank said there was new work and some papers to look at. I felt he was running too fast. I thought that if I stayed beside him, at least I might ask questions."

Shashank lowered his eyes. Friendship could mean accompanying someone; it could also mean restraining him. At the time, he had wanted only the first meaning.

Aditya asked, "Was money discussed in the meeting?"

"Yes. I heard discussion about how payments were recorded, under what name a service was entered, and that some amount had come through another party. But I did not understand the full structure."

"Hawala?"

Mrinal thought for a moment. "I heard that word in later discussions. I do not clearly remember it being used in that meeting."

"Bitcoin?"

"Someone said something like 'digital value'. I will not claim the exact words now."

Aditya wrote: "Later-acquired knowledge not to be treated as contemporaneous memory."

A knot loosened inside Shashank. Mrinal was not trying to save him; on the contrary, where his memory was not clear, he was simply refusing to say that it was. It was a harder form of friendship than the friendship of their younger days, but perhaps better for that reason.

Mrinal continued, "One thing I remember clearly. Shashank was very excited. He kept saying, 'I understand the language, so every side needs me.' I asked him, 'Do all sides need you, or do they need your translation?' He became angry."

Shashank's face grew warm. "Yes. That happened."

"Why did you become angry?" Aditya asked.

"Because I did not want to hear the difference. I liked confusing the usefulness of the translator with power centred in the person himself."

Aditya reopened the payment-gateway report. "Here, some transactions appear under the name of an Indian service party, some under a foreign merchant party, and some are linked to other intermediary records. If the ultimate beneficiary of all of them were the same party, the meaning would change. But at present the beneficiary information is incomplete."

Shashank said, "Then writing 'one owner' into the blank space would not be postulation; it would be imagination."

"Correct."

"And if independent records show that the different names were all acting under the same directing person?"

"Then the conclusion may change."

Mrinal asked from between them, "So the blank spaces in the papers are not to be filled with friendship?"

For the first time Aditya smiled faintly. "No. Friendship is not a category of evidence. But a friend's direct recollection may be testimony, and that testimony can be tested."

Shashank looked at Mrinal. In that instant he remembered the old tea stall, the first fear in Noida, Mrinal's hard questions, and all his own anger. Mrinal had been present at many decisions in his life, but presence had

never meant consent. Shashank himself had erased that distinction again and again—‘He was with me, therefore he understood’; ‘He remained silent, therefore he agreed.’

As though reading not Shashank’s mind but the paper before him, Aditya said, “Silence ≠ consent. That too is not automatic.”

Shashank laughed. “Write that sentence for me.”

“In the statement?”

“No. In the notebook.”

The final record of the session was a short summary stating that some sums had been recorded as service fees, some as reimbursements, and some in unclear categories. A separate note mentioned crypto valuation, but contained neither Shashank’s name nor any instruction from him.

Aditya asked, “Did you control any such digital asset?”

“As far as I know—no.” Shashank stopped and corrected himself. “I am not aware of any memory or record showing that I held any such account, key, or means of control under my authority.”

“Any instruction to convert or transmit it for someone?”

“No.”

“Then the word ‘crypto’ appearing in this file = Shashank’s control of crypto?”

“No.”

Aditya said, “Correct. At present there is only a mention. A separate link is required to establish a relationship.”

Mrinal said softly, “You were among all these things then, yet you did not own all of them. Even so, why did you go so far inside?”

Shashank looked at him. It was not a prosecutor’s question; it was a friend’s. The answer would not be evidence. It would be character.

“Because I thought that the more confidential the meeting, the more money there was in the paperwork, the more foreign people were involved—the more successful I was.”

“And me?”

“I took you with me because I wanted you to witness my success.”

A faint shadow of hurt crossed Mrinal’s face. “I wanted a friend. Not a witness.”

For a few moments the room was silent. Aditya did not move his pen. The sentence was not a legal fact; there was no need to force it into the record. But inside Shashank it became the deepest entry of all.

In the evening the statement was read back. Aditya had written in the summary: “The payment-gateway records show the presence of multiple parties; actual beneficial ownership, the nature of the alleged mule accounts, and any hawala or crypto connection remain matters for independent evidence. Shashank’s linguistic/liaison role and Mrinal’s limited presence do not by themselves establish economic control.”

Shashank added, “Write that Mrinal’s presence was at my invitation.”

Aditya wrote it down.

Mrinal asked, “What difference will that make?”

Shashank said, “It will keep the boundary of responsibility correct. I took you there to show you my glittering new world; that is not your fault.”

Mrinal answered, “And I do not need credit for the questions I asked either. Friendship is not bookkeeping.”

Outside, evening was falling. The two of them stepped out of the building and stopped beside the road. Shashank reached for his pocket to pay for tea; Mrinal stopped him. “Today I will pay.”

Shashank smiled faintly. “The beneficial recipient of this payment is clear.”

Mrinal laughed too. “No postulation needed here.”

For the first time in many days, they laughed together.

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

“Money in an account ≠ account-holder established as ultimate beneficiary.”

“Multiple names ≠ one network established; but independent links may change the conclusion.”

“Payment-gateway entry = record of service/transaction; not automatic proof of ownership.”

“Mention of hawala/crypto = question of relationship; control by a particular person requires separate evidence.”

“Friend’s presence ≠ participation.”

“Silence ≠ consent.”

“Friendship ≠ a category of evidence; a friend’s direct recollection = testable testimony.”

“Postulation = the minimum necessary posit that makes the facts coherent; not filling a blank space with the offender one wants.”

At the final line he stopped: “I wanted Mrinal less as a friend and more as a witness to my growing importance.”

He did not cross the line out.

As he closed the notebook, an old Macao message returned to him—another journey, a closed meeting, and a promise of “special access”. Behind the payment papers, the glitter of foreign travel was standing once again.

The next question would not be only where the money went. It would also be how far Shashank himself had advanced into that world of money—and how far his ambition had continued to command his memory.

CHAPTER 60

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 8

Early that morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today the records of the second Macao trip will be shown. Keep everything about the journey, the meetings, and system access confined to the available evidence and to what you directly remember.”

Shashank read the message and remained for a long time with the mobile phone in his hand. He had narrated the first journey almost as a story of prestige; he had never fully told his friends about the second. The reason was that he himself had come to regard that trip as less “work” than “access to the inside.”

This time, on Aditya’s table at the office, lay a passport entry, a travel reservation, a hotel account, a copy of a guest pass, and printouts of three messages.

Aditya lifted the first paper. “You went to Macao again?”

“Yes.”

“At whose request?”

“Li Wenchao proposed it first. Later a coordinator finalized the trip.”

“Was the purpose different from the first journey?”

Shashank was silent for a few moments. “I was told—to review linguistic material for the Indian side, understand some clauses in the contracts, and clarify terminology in a payment-related presentation.”

“And your own purpose?”

Shashank saw his face without a mirror. “Special access.”

Aditya stopped writing. “Was that phrase in the message, or in your mind?”

“Both. Li had written, ‘This time you will be shown more inside material.’ I interpreted that, in my own way, as ‘special access’.”

“More inside material = independent system authority?”

“No.”

“Administrative control?”

“No.”

“Then what?”

“Now I understand—it was only a promise that I would be shown more material. At the time, those words felt like a title bestowed on me.”

Aditya placed the second message before him. It said: “An Indian lawyer will be present; the questions will not be limited to language alone.”

Without reading the name, Shashank understood that it referred to Raghav Bhasin.

“Was Bhasin there?” Aditya asked.

“Yes.”

“Your lawyer?”

“Not at that meeting. He was reviewing papers for some of the parties. He was not my personal legal representative.”

“So everything said with him present automatically fell under lawyer-client confidentiality?”

“No. Which communication constituted whose legal advice would have to be examined separately.”

Aditya nodded. “Correct. That is the next question; today we stay with travel and access.”

An old scene opened inside Shashank. Macao at night seemed washed in fierce light. Riding in a small vehicle from the hotel to the office, he watched the glass buildings pass. He had thought: a young man from Mithila who once learned tones in a small Tao temple in Pitampura was now inside a world where the value of a single word could alter papers worth lakhs.

There was pride in his talent within that thought, but behind it there was also greed for money.

The meeting took place in a closed room: Li Wenchao, two Chinese employees, Raghav Bhasin, an Indian coordinator, and Shashank. There were fewer papers on the table than computer screens.

Shashank said, “I remember—the first presentation was a summary of accounts and payments, but the names were abbreviated.”

Aditya asked, “Did you know the actual owners of those accounts?”

“No.”

“Were they mule accounts?”

“In the language of the investigation now available, some accounts are being described as suspected mule accounts. But at that meeting I did not know the actual role of the account-holders.”

“Hawala?”

“I heard the word. I had no direct knowledge of how the arrangement operated.”

“Bitcoin?”

“I saw a reference to digital currency on one presentation slide. Which transaction, whose, where—I did not know.”

Aditya wrote: “Seeing a term $\neq$ knowing the process; seeing a summary $\neq$ operating it.”

Shashank suddenly said, “But there is one thing I have to admit.”

“Say it.”

“Looking at those pages, I felt less fear than greed.”

“Greed for what?”

“To be among such people. To understand such papers. To become the trusted man for what they called ‘inside material’.”

Aditya did not interrupt him.

“I was not asking for a direct share of the money,” Shashank continued, “but I felt that the more secret material I was shown, the more important I became. That greed was more intoxicating than an ordinary fee.”

“That is a state of mind,” Aditya said. “We will not write it as criminal purpose unless there is evidence of conduct to support that.”

“But it is part of the context needed to understand my decisions.”

“That can be recorded.”

The second presentation slide contained the names of several countries and categories of service. Shashank was asked to clarify the meaning of certain expressions from Chinese into English and then for Indian usage.

At one place, the original expression was close in meaning to “funds adjustment”. In the presentation, the English version read “service adjustment”. At the time Shashank corrected only the grammar; he did not question the legality of the underlying economic transaction.

Aditya asked, “Did your correction of that sentence establish that the transaction was lawful?”

“No.”

“Did it establish that it was unlawful?”

“No to that as well.”

“Then, as translator, what did you know?”

“The meaning of the words, the intention of the sentence, and some of the commercial context. Not the actual owner of the account, the source of the funds, or the ultimate beneficiary.”

In the middle of the meeting, an employee seated Shashank before a separate computer screen. It contained several language tables, customer-support phrases, and lists of service regions. The employee opened a temporary guest login for him.

In Shashank’s memory, that moment still glittered. An abbreviated form of his name appeared at the top of the screen. He thought: “Now I am inside.”

Aditya asked, “Did you create the login name yourself?”

“No.”

“The password?”

“The employee typed it. I was not told what it was.”

“Could you later log in again on your own?”

“I do not know; I never tried.”

“Could you change account permissions?”

“No.”

“Could you add users?”

“No.”

“Did you see the server architecture?”

“No. Only the material available on the screen.”

Aditya wrote in the margin: “Temporary guest access $\neq$ independent server authority.”

Shashank said, “At the time, I knowingly blurred that distinction.”

“Before whom?”

"Before people back home. After I returned, I said: 'I have access to the inside system now.'"

"Why?"

"Display is another form of greed. Greed is not always satisfied by receiving money; sometimes a person wants others to see his closeness to money."

Aditya wrote: "Self-promotional statement; actual authority to be tested independently."

In the next part of the session, a digital access log was shown. The date matched the journey. A temporary user appeared active for almost two hours. The username resembled Shashank's abbreviated name.

Aditya asked, "Was this you?"

"Possibly. The date, meeting, and name match."

"Certain?"

"If the creation log, device information, and other session details also match, the identification can become stronger. The abbreviated name alone is not enough for complete certainty."

"Active for two hours = you personally operated the system for two hours?"

"No. The screen may have remained open, an employee was with me, and I was reviewing language tables. The duration of an active session and the duration of actual activity are not the same thing."

"But what if some linguistic changes were saved during that session?"

Shashank paused. "Then at least the connection would become stronger that those linguistic changes were made in my presence or through the session associated with me. But that still would not establish economic control."

Without smiling, Aditya said, "Keep the boundary."

After noon, an old message was opened. Li had written: "Next time you should understand not only the translation, but the flow as well."

Tension appeared on Shashank's face.

"What did 'flow' mean?" Aditya asked.

"At the time I understood it as 'business flow'—which party comes after which, which paper, which service. In the context of the investigation now, it could also be read as referring to the flow of money."

"Does the original message permit both meanings?"

"Yes."

"Which meaning is established?"

"Neither, without context."

"Then postulation?"

Shashank said slowly, "If later records show that, during that same session, I was shown a payment summary along with the language tables, it would be difficult to reduce 'flow' to the sequence of sentences alone. But to jump straight to 'I was being taught to operate the flow of money' would again go too far."

For the first time Aditya turned the page towards Shashank. "Write that sentence."

Shashank himself wrote: "The available context broadens the possible meaning of 'flow', but does not establish operational authority or criminal participation."

His hand trembled slightly as the pen moved.

At that moment he remembered the hotel in Macao. After the meeting, looking down at the lights through a glass window, he had thought: now that I have reached here, life will never go backwards. His home in Mithila, his father's old cupboard, Mrinal's ordinary tea stall—all had seemed far away.

Today he understood that greed does not merely pull a person forward; it also tries to make the life behind him look small.

Mithila's ordinary life had then seemed to him almost an embarrassment; today that very memory gave him a standard of measure—how often the glitter of prestige enlarges the apparent size of facts.

As evening came, Aditya lifted the final paper—the hotel meeting-room list. One entry contained the names of Raghav Bhasin, Li Wenchao, Shashank, and two unidentified abbreviations.

"Names in the same meeting = same role?"

"No."

"Same meeting = same purpose?"

"No to that as well."

"Same meeting + payment summary + system access = criminal group?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "That conclusion requires more links—role, knowledge, purpose, conduct. The available facts increase the closeness of the relationship; they do not automatically establish sameness of criminal participation."

“And your own role?”

“Linguistic assistance, understanding some presentations, limited guest access, and greed to make myself look more important. Whatever is claimed beyond that must be shown by evidence.”

Aditya said, “Correct.”

Before signing, Shashank read his entire statement. He stopped at one line: “The witness admits that his earlier statement about ‘access to the inside system’ was broader than the actual limits of his authority.”

Shashank said, “Replace ‘witness’ with ‘statement-giver’. Today I am not merely giving evidence against someone else; I am also correcting the limits of my own words.”

Aditya changed the word.

Mrinal was not outside. Shashank walked alone to the tea stall. In that empty space, his friend’s absence itself felt like a question. In the old episode, friendship had anchored his memory; today he had to bear the story of greed alone.

That night he opened his notebook.

“Foreign travel = opportunity; not crime.”

“Closed meeting = confidentiality; not automatically conspiracy.”

“Temporary guest access = not independent server control.”

“Active session = indication of use; not authorship of every action.”

“Seeing a payment summary = not ownership of the money.”

“Hearing the words hawala or digital currency = not operational knowledge.”

“Greed to become an insider = context for decisions; not proof of crime.”

“Postulation = the minimum assumption needed to remove incoherence among the available facts; not a preferred story.”

As he wrote the final line, he remembered an old sentence of Raghav Bhasin’s: “If language changes legal responsibility, a translator must put the limits of his words in writing.”

Shashank closed the notebook. The next question was no longer merely about travel or a screen. The question was this: in the papers Raghav Bhasin had been reading, whose advice was confidential, and whose conduct actually extended into commercial participation.

CHAPTER 6I

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 9

Aditya Mishra's message that morning was brief: 'Under the court's last direction, today we will examine only the list of legal-advice records, the chronology, and the translation-related portions. Confidential content whose examination is not yet authorized will not be opened.'

Shashank remained still for a while after reading the message. The question he had written before closing his notebook the previous night—among Raghav Bhasin's papers, whose advice was confidential, and whose conduct actually extended into commercial participation—was now returning to him in the form of documents.

He was afraid. This time the fear was not merely an imagined arrest; it was the fear that, at some point, his translation might have rendered a legal caution in such a way that someone else had taken it for 'approval'. If language had altered another person's decision, its burden no longer belonged to the dictionary alone.

When he reached the office, there were three files on Aditya's table. Raghav Bhasin was present as well. Before him lay a separate list—date, sender, recipient, a brief category for the subject, number of attachments. Beside several entries, in red, were the words: 'legal advice—disputed'.

Aditya said, 'Today we will not read the advice inside those red-marked entries. First we will see which document arrived at what time, what commercial document was created afterward, and what role the translator played in between. If a dispute arises over the limits of privilege, the court will decide that separately.'

Raghav nodded. 'Good. My only request is that confidential legal advice not be read as though it were a commercial instruction.'

Aditya said, 'And merely calling a commercial act a lawyer's paper does not make it proper to hide that act either. Both boundaries will be tested.'

Shashank said nothing. His own role stood between those two sentences. At times he explained Raghav's legal cautions to the Chinese side; at times he carried the Chinese side's commercial answers back to Raghav. Language moved in both directions through his hands, but it did not follow that the purposes moving in those two directions were the same.

The first list concerned the later Macao meeting. One entry read: 'confirmation of actual beneficial ownership'. Another: 'legal status of the paying party'. A third: 'review of cross-border service contract'. The underlying text was not opened yet.

Aditya asked Shashank, 'Do you remember these subjects?'

'Yes. I remember the terms. Not the full advice inside.'

'Did you translate?'

'Some parts. Not all.'

'Which parts?'

Shashank looked at the list. 'The linguistic rendering of the original Chinese response on the beneficial-ownership question; the identification of the paying party; and a bilingual draft of a meeting summary.'

For the first time, Raghav looked straight at him. 'You prepared the meeting summary?'

Shashank's throat went dry. 'The first draft—yes.'

'Before my comments or after?'

'Before.'

Aditya recorded the sequence. 'Then the first fact is this: Shashank's bilingual summary was prepared before Raghav's legal comments. That does not establish that Raghav wrote the summary.'

Raghav said, 'And after my comments, the summary was changed.'

Aditya opened the second file. It did not contain the text of confidential legal advice, but a comparison of drafts. From the first version, Aditya read the Maithili meaning of Shashank's English sentence aloud: 'The beneficial-ownership details will be clarified later; there is no need to halt the service flow at present.'

Shashank's face tightened. He remembered that sentence.

Aditya showed only the changed line in the next version: 'No payment-related decision should proceed without confirmation of beneficial ownership.'

'Whose change was this?'

Raghav said, 'I had insisted on caution of that kind. But I will not say in this open session how far the confidential advice went in its detail.'

Aditya turned to Shashank. 'Why was your first sentence so much softer?'

Before answering, Shashank drew a long breath. Fear rose in him again. There was an easy route: say that he had not understood the legal meaning. But that would have been false. He had spent too many years between language and contracts to claim he did not understand the difference between 'there is no need to halt' and 'do not proceed without confirmation'.

'I understood the meaning,' he said. 'But when I prepared the first summary, I felt the meeting's work should not stop. I wanted to preserve commercial momentum. So I pushed the uncertainty to the back.'

'On whose instruction?'

'I do not now remember any explicit instruction.'

'Li Wenchao?'

'I remember that he wanted speed. But I cannot say that I wrote this particular sentence at his instruction.'

Aditya wrote: 'Purpose of preserving commercial momentum admitted; direction by any particular person not established at present.'

In a calm voice, Raghav asked, 'Did you present me here as though I had given legal approval?'

Shashank lowered his eyes. 'In the first summary I wrote: "There is no immediate impediment from the legal side."'

'Did I say that?'

'Not in those words.'

'Then?'

Under the table, Shashank's hand tightened into a fist. 'I understood your questions as delay, not prohibition. And I wanted the meeting not to appear stalled because of me.'

Silence settled over the room. Shashank felt his old ambition being written on the wall once more. The translator who had prided himself on building a bridge between two languages had sometimes assumed, as well, that he possessed the right to speed the traffic across that bridge.

Aditya asked, 'How justified was the conclusion: Raghav's legal caution = commercial approval?'

'Not justified.'

'Now apply postulation. The available facts are these: the first summary said there was no impediment; after the later legal comments, caution against proceeding was added. What is the minimum we must posit to explain that inconsistency?'

Shashank thought for a few moments. 'Only this much: the first summary was not a complete and reliable expression of the legal position. But not that the first summary was knowingly prepared to protect a crime.'

'And Raghav was a participant?'

'On the contrary, the available change shows, at least on this point, his caution. But one cautionary line does not prove that every role of his was innocent either. The conclusion goes only as far as the records go.'

A faint weariness showed on Raghav's face. 'I like that sentence today.'

Aditya opened the third file. This time it was only a communications list. The subject of one message was: 'Legal approval?' The sender was an unidentified abbreviation; the recipients were a group. The reply line read: 'Linguistic text approved; legal comments incorporated.'

Aditya asked, 'Did you write this reply?'

Shashank studied the line. 'The first part—"linguistic text approved"—could be my style. But authorship of the entire message is not established merely by style.'

'Did you use such wording?'

'Yes. When the linguistic text was complete.'

'"Legal comments incorporated"?'

'That too may have appeared in drafts. But "comments incorporated" and "legal approval obtained" are not the same thing.'

Aditya said, 'That distinction is the centre of this issue.'

The shape of Shashank's fear shifted slightly. Earlier he had feared that confidential papers would be opened and would make him a criminal. Now he feared more that his own short phrases—'language cleared', 'comments added'—might later have been understood by others to mean 'law cleared'.

That afternoon, under the court's direction, only the external details of a 'privilege log' were shown. Three documents had been created on the same day—Raghav's legal comments, Shashank's bilingual summary, and a commercial payment summary.

Aditya asked, 'Same day = same purpose?'

'No,' Shashank answered.

'Same file = same author?'

'No.'

'Lawyer present = every paper privileged?'

Raghav answered for himself. 'That depends on the nature of the material and the relationship involved, not on the name alone. The court will determine the final boundary.'

Aditya nodded. 'And commercial papers existing around a lawyer's legal advice = the lawyer participated in the commercial activity?'

Shashank said, 'Not automatically. Conduct, instruction, benefit, decision-making authority, and knowledge must be examined separately.'

Aditya slid a page towards Shashank. It was only the heading portion of a payment summary; amounts and identities were masked. Three categories were visible—service fee, third-party payment, and digital-asset-related entry.

'Raghav authored this summary?'

'I do not know.'

'You?'

'No. I may have translated some headings, but I did not prepare the summary.'

'Li?'

'I will not say without evidence.'

'These three categories = one chain of funds?'

'No. They are grounds for examining a relationship, not a conclusion.'

Aditya closed the page. 'Good. The operational details of this financial part are not today's subject.'

Shashank felt no relief. Instead, a new fear arose—as though behind every answer stood another question. Then he remembered Juliana's old lesson: language marks not only what has been said, but also the boundary of what has not been said.

In the evening session, Aditya constructed a chronology. First Shashank's softened summary. Then Raghav's caution. Then the revised draft. Then the group message: 'comments incorporated'.

'Is there any inconsistency in this sequence?'

Shashank said, 'Yes. If the group later understood that there was "legal approval", then either there was some separate approval that is not now in the record, or the meaning of the caution was softened later. Both possibilities remain open.'

'What is the postulation?'

'At minimum, this much: the available papers alone do not yield "full legal approval". To explain that conclusion, we need either an additional event or a distortion of meaning. But it would be improper to choose which one without evidence.'

Raghav said, 'Correct.'

Aditya looked at Shashank. 'What are you afraid of?'

The question came suddenly. Shashank almost laughed, but did not. 'That one sentence of mine may have become someone else's shield. And that later, seeing that shield, people will say I made it knowingly.'

'Are those two the same thing?'

'No. Consequence and intention are different.'

'Then they will remain separate in the record as well.'

Shashank said softly, 'But I do not become free of responsibility for the consequence.'

Raghav said, 'Name responsibility carefully. Faulty translation, negligence, knowing distortion, commercial participation, criminal purpose—these are not one word.'

Shashank looked at him. There was the lawyer's severity in that sentence, yet also, strangely, a kind of mercy—not the mercy that erased fault, but the mercy that demanded its true dimensions.

Before the session ended, Aditya read the statement aloud: 'The deponent admits that in the initial bilingual summary, the force of the legal caution was not preserved with sufficient strictness; the available material does not at present establish that this change was made on any specific criminal instruction. The roles of legal advice, commercial papers, and financial records are separately testable.'

Shashank said, 'Add one line.'

'What?'

'Confidentiality ≠ absence of truth. But breaking the limits of confidential material and filling them with inference is not truth either.'

Raghav thought for a few moments. 'Write it in statement language: "A claim of confidentiality does not by itself establish either guilt or innocence."'

Aditya wrote exactly that.

When they came out, Mrinal was standing beside the stairs. He had not come the previous day; seeing him today loosened the tightness inside Shashank a little.

Mrinal asked, 'Were you frightened?'

'Yes.'

'Of what might be opened?'

'No. Of what I had written.'

They went outside. There was a faint dust in the evening air. Shashank said, 'I used to think the lawyer carried responsibility for the papers and the translator for the words. Today I understood that when the lawyer cannot read the original language, some legal weight rests upon the translator's words. But that does not make the translator the lawyer or the commercial owner.'

Mrinal said, 'You have come back to the boundary again.'

'Without boundaries, fear writes stories.'

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

'Confidentiality of legal advice ≠ evidence of crime.'

'Presence of a lawyer ≠ commercial participation automatically.'

'Translator's softened summary = linguistic responsibility; criminal instruction = separate evidentiary question.'

'Comments incorporated ≠ legal approval.'

'Three documents on the same day ≠ one purpose.'

'Seeing a financial summary ≠ control of funds.'

'Fear ≠ a basis for inference.'

'Postulation = the minimum necessary assumption that removes inconsistency; not choosing the preferred guilty person from among available alternatives.'

As he wrote the final line, his hand stopped: 'If caution had been written inside the institution, where did that caution disappear from the later papers?'

He closed the notebook. It was not necessary that the answer to this question lay in Raghav Bhasin's confidential file. Perhaps the answer lay in those versions of the tax inquiry, the chain of circulation, and the internal resistance whose shadow had already appeared once before.

The next question would move away from the boundary between language and law and into the institution's own trust—who preserved the caution, who diminished it, and who understood whom as having betrayed that trust.

CHAPTER 62

A NIGHT IN MACAO

When Aditya Mishra called Shashank in the next morning, there was no new contract on the table. There were three old records—the dispatch list for the lower commissioner's reservation note, the later circulation list from the higher tax-intelligence branch, and a chain of messages recovered from Shashank's mobile phone from one night in Macao.

Aditya said, "Today the question is not only what was written in the papers. The question is—who knew what, and when."

An old night opened inside Shashank's chest. A high hotel window, Macao glittering below, electric light stretching into the distance, and the mobile phone in his hand. That night his life had seemed extraordinary to him.

But Aditya stopped him first in the present. "Memory later. Records first."

The first page was the lower commissioner's dispatch list. It recorded that a reconciliation note had been sent upward with reservations concerning verification of the paying party, actual beneficial ownership, and delivery of services. The number of attachments was recorded as well.

The second page was the higher branch's circulation list. The name of the original subject remained, but the number of attachments was lower. A later conclusion said the matter could be placed at low priority.

Aditya asked, "What do these two papers establish?"

Shashank said, "More material was sent from the lower level; less material appears in the higher-level circulation file."

"And compromise?"

"No. Less material = deliberate suppression is still too distant a conclusion."

"Betrayal?"

Shashank paused. "That can be a feeling. Not proof."

Aditya underlined that word—"feeling."

Just then the same officer from the lower commissioner entered—the one who had earlier spoken of preserving the reservation note. His face was tired, but his voice was steady.

He said, "I received confirmation that the pages I sent had been received. Later, when I saw the circulation copy, the attachment was missing. I did not like that. I wrote again that verification was still pending."

Aditya asked, "Can you say someone knowingly removed it?"

The officer did not answer at once. "I can say that the copy I sent and the later circulation copy are not the same. Why they are not the same—I do not have evidence for that."

Shashank looked at the officer. He remembered the same restraint from the earlier day. A person could be angry without turning anger into evidence.

Aditya opened the third record. "Now—Macao that night."

Li Wenchao's name appeared in the chain of messages on the mobile phone. The timestamp preceded India's official circulation list. The message itself was brief; its sense was simply this: "Questions on the India side are softer now; the next paper will be lighter."

Shashank fell silent as soon as he read the line.

Aditya asked, "Did you read this message at the time?"

"Yes."

"What did you understand it to mean?"

"That the tax-related inquiry in India was becoming less serious."

"On what basis?"

"On Li's message."

"Li's source?"

"I did not ask."

After that answer, the night in Macao came alive again inside Shashank. The meeting had ended. Raghav Bhasin had left earlier. Mrinal was in India. Shashank was alone in the hotel room. The city lights fell upon the glass and doubled his own reflection.

The mobile phone vibrated. Li had written: "India-side questions softer. Next paper lighter. No worry."

At the time, Shashank had taken the sentence as good news. His first thought had not been, How does he know this? His first thought had been, The work will not stop.

He replied, "All right. Then should we keep the language from becoming too severe as well?"

Li answered, "Preserve the original meaning, but do not create panic."

That night Shashank had treated the sentence as a business instruction. Reading it now, he saw in his own answer something more than greed—assent. Instead of asking questions, he had been trying to clear the road ahead.

Aditya asked, "In this exchange, did anyone send you any internal tax record?"

"No."

"The name of any internal officer?"

"No."

"Any operational instruction concerning an amount, an account, hawala, or bitcoin?"

"No."

"Then what is the direct fact here?"

Shashank said, "Li sent a message suggesting that India's tax questions were becoming softer. I did not ask his source, and I accepted the suggestion that the language should be kept softer."

Aditya nodded. "That is all. Up to this point."

The officer from the lower commissionerate said carefully, "My reservation note had not yet been officially circulated at that time."

Shashank looked at him. The weight of the sentence increased at once.

Aditya raised a hand. "This difference in timing is important. But we will not jump from it directly to 'internal information leaked outside'."

On a sheet of paper he wrote four possibilities: "One: the message was based on other public or commercial information. Two: an error in the timestamp or confusion between time zones. Three: someone was predicting an internal change. Four: someone possessed internal information."

Then he added, "Which of these is true requires separate evidence."

Shashank asked, "What would postulation say here?"

Instead of answering, Aditya turned the paper towards him.

Shashank looked at it for a long time. "Two facts exist together—before the official circulation, Li writes 'the questions are softer'; in the later circulation copy, the scope of the questions does in fact appear reduced. Some intermediate explanation is needed for that similarity. But 'internal corrupt compromise' is not the only necessary explanation. The minimum posit is only that one among internal information reaching outside, prediction, some other information, or confusion in timing explains the similarity."

"Correct," Aditya said. "Postulation fills a gap; it does not choose the accused."

Hearing that, the lower officer released a long breath. "At the time it felt like betrayal to me."

Aditya asked, "Whose betrayal?"

"The system's. I wrote the questions, dispatched them, received confirmation. Later the questions disappeared. It felt as though someone had lightened what I had tried to preserve."

"That feeling can be recorded," Aditya said, "but who that 'someone' is remains an open question."

Without smiling, the officer said, "That is all I want."

Inside Shashank, the meaning of betrayal was changing. Earlier he had thought betrayal occurred when one friend sold another, or when a partner ran away with the money. Today he could see that even the removal of a single line might feel like betrayal to someone, if that line was the only surviving sign of his caution, labour, and responsibility.

Aditya opened the next page. After the Macao message, Shashank had written in a working note of his own: "India questions softer; keep language balanced."

"Is this yours?"

Shashank looked at the handwriting. "Yes."

"Had you independently verified 'questions softer'?"

"No."

"Then you wrote another person's statement in your own note as though it were a fact?"

Shashank's throat grew heavy. "Yes."

"Why?"

"Because I wanted the work to continue. And perhaps—" He stopped, then corrected himself. "No, not 'perhaps' here. I remember—I felt relieved. I thought the danger of the investigation was receding."

Aditya wrote: "Unverified repetition of a third-party statement."

Shashank said, "Does that establish that I participated in leaking confidential information?"

"No."

"That I spread something false?"

"If you wrote it without verification, the question may be negligence or repetition of an unverified statement. Knowingly writing a falsehood is different."

"And if the later paper actually did become softer?"

"Then the similarity is worth investigating. Purpose remains a separate question."

Shashank lowered his head. The method was cutting him from two directions again—protecting him from an unproved crime, but refusing to make his actual carelessness smaller than it was.

That afternoon Mrinal was called as well. He was shown a message from the Macao night that Shashank had sent him: "The India-side questions seem to be settling down; the work will probably move ahead."

Aditya asked Mrinal, "What did you understand from this message?"

Mrinal said, "Shashank was happy that the obstacle in the matter was diminishing. I did not know the source."

"Did you ask?"

"I had written, 'Who told you?'"

The next line was shown. Shashank's reply had been: "People there are saying it."

Mrinal looked at him. "You did not name anyone."

"Because I did not know the name myself."

"Then how did you believe it?"

Shashank searched for an answer. At last he said, "Because believing it suited me."

The room remained silent for a few moments. In that one sentence, another form of betrayal opened up—whether someone had betrayed Shashank's trust, or whether Shashank himself had betrayed his duty towards evidence, were two different questions.

Aditya said, "Convenience is not a substitute for verification."

Mrinal said, "Nor is friendship."

In the evening session, the chain of transmission was examined again. The lower officer's reservation note had a receipt mark. Its attachment was absent from the higher circulation list. An intermediate register contained only the words "revised file"; the available copy did not clearly identify who had made the revision.

Aditya asked, "Postulation here?"

Shashank said, "If the attachment existed upon receipt and is absent from the later file, then something happened in between—it was removed, set aside, replaced, or lost through a record-keeping error. Saying 'nothing happened' does not make the two states compatible."

"And deliberate suppression?"

"One among the available possibilities, not a necessary conclusion."

"Who benefited?"

Shashank said, "Benefit can be a useful question; benefit = perpetrator is not established."

For the first time, the lower officer looked at Shashank with close attention. "Did you understand this from before?"

Shashank gave a faint, bitter smile. "I had studied logic. I kept forgetting to apply it to life."

For an instant there was compassion on the officer's face; then he left.

Before the session ended, Aditya prepared a new page. Its heading read: "Timeline: Limited Circulation". He said, "This page contains the identities of certain internal sources. It will not be made public without the court's permission."

Shashank's body tightened suddenly. "Sealed?"

"Yes. Because source identities, internal examination, and unverified hypotheses are all together here. Sealing it does not establish guilt; it only limits circulation."

Shashank remembered the humiliation—the clipped extract, the sentence that had reached outside, the conclusions drawn by the press. What rose in him now was not sudden fear, but a hard suspicion.

"What if one line gets out again this time?"

Aditya looked directly at him. "Then we will examine the chain of circulation, not the line alone."

Mrinal was waiting outside. When Shashank came out, he asked, "What did you find?"

“Not proof of betrayal.”

“Then?”

“A reason for trust to break.”

“The difference?”

“A great one. Broken trust can make someone guilty in the mind; not in law.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook. The lights of the Macao night returned to him—the city glittering below, and himself taking an unverified message as good news.

He wrote:

“Reservation note sent = not automatically incorporated into the later circulation.”

“Receipt mark = later use of the material not established.”

“Similar information before official circulation = confidential information leaked is not established; timing, source, and alternatives require examination.”

“Writing an unverified statement in one’s own note = carelessness; knowingly writing a falsehood is different.”

“Questions became softer = does not answer why they became softer.”

“Betrayal = feeling; criminal compromise = evidentiary conclusion.”

“Postulation = the minimum necessary bridge between two discordant facts; not the name of the preferred culprit.”

He paused for a long time before writing the final line: “That night in Macao I received no confidential paper; I received one sentence, and without asking its source I dressed it in the clothing of truth.”

As he closed the notebook, he remembered Aditya’s heading, “Limited Circulation”. The next danger no longer lay only in what the paper contained. It also lay in which part of a sealed paper would reach outside—and whose name would run ahead of its meaning once it did.

CHAPTER 63

THE MIRROR OF MACAO II

Shashank's mobile phone kept vibrating throughout the morning. The first message was from Mrinal: "Do not open the news; call me first." The second was from an old acquaintance: "Is all this true?" The third came from an unfamiliar number: "Are you the translator who channelled the country's money to a Chinese gambling group?"

Shashank switched off the screen. But the words did not switch off. They kept sounding inside his ears—"the country's money", "Chinese gambling group", "translator". Three separate nouns bound into one sentence; no one seemed to need the evidence that lay between them.

A little later Mrinal arrived in person. In his hand were two printed pages of news. Across the top ran a bold headline: "Indian Linguistic Conduit of the Macao Network?" There was a question mark, but the sentences below were written not as questions but as verdicts.

Mrinal placed the pages on the table. "Read them, but take each sentence separately."

Shashank read the first paragraph. It said that in sealed investigative material the name of the "Indian contact" was Shashank Jha, and that he coordinated alleged mule accounts, payment gateways, and transfers connected with digital assets. The second paragraph described the Macao journey as an "operations meeting". The third presented Raghav Bhasin's presence as evidence of "legal protection".

Shashank's face grew hot. "This is false."

Mrinal asked at once, "All of it?"

Shashank paused before answering. He had learned the habit of pausing over the past few weeks. "No. I went to Macao—that is true. I provided linguistic services—that is true. I saw some payment summaries—that is true. I softened some words—that is true. But coordination of mule accounts, control of funds, ownership of a gambling business—I know of no evidence establishing those things. Those conclusions do not follow from these facts alone."

Mrinal said, "Then answer the humiliation in full sentences too."

When Shashank reached the office, two reporters were waiting outside Aditya Mishra's room. One raised a camera, but Aditya's staff member said, "No statement at present." Shashank went inside. On the table lay a sealed envelope, printed copies of the public reports, and the court's latest order.

Aditya said, "Today we will keep two questions separate. First—how far the material circulating in the press corresponds to the sealed record. Second—if there is correspondence, how it reached outside. Finding the answer to the first question will not automatically answer the second."

Shashank looked at the paper. "The news says I coordinated the money."

"The news report is one thing. The sealed material is another. Compare first."

With the court's permission, the envelope was opened. Not the entire original material, only the disputed passage, was read. The line said: "Translation of payment-related headings by the Indian linguistic contact; actual control of the accounts subject to separate verification."

Shashank read it once, then looked at the line in the news report: "Payment coordination by the Indian contact; indications of actual control over the accounts."

His thumb stopped on the page. "Two changes."

Aditya asked, "Which?"

"'Linguistic' has disappeared. 'Translation of headings' has become 'payment coordination'. And 'actual control subject to separate verification' has been reversed into 'indications of control'."

"And from that?"

"The public sentence is not a summary of the original. Its meaning has been changed."

Aditya said, "Correct. But we will not yet write 'a deliberate conspiracy to defame'. The meaning changed—that is a text-based fact. Purpose is a separate question."

For a moment Shashank's humiliation rose into anger. "Thousands of people are reading this sentence beside my name. While we wait for purpose to be proved, will my reputation return?"

Aditya's voice did not harden. "Damage to reputation may be real. But if the investigation begins to move at the speed of anger, we will commit against someone else the same error that was committed against you."

Shashank did not like the answer, but he understood its truth. Expecting immediate consolation from justice was itself a kind of greed.

A second disputed passage was opened. One version of the sealed draft read: "Translator present at Macao meeting; financial decision-making authority not established." In the public report it had become: "Principal Indian representative present at Macao financial meeting."

Shashank said, "The word 'translator' has disappeared again."

Aditya nodded. "And so has 'decision-making authority not established'."

Mrinal, who had been allowed to sit on a chair at the back, said, "Twice the same kind of caution has disappeared."

Aditya looked at him. "That is an observation. The conclusion?"

Mrinal paused. "Someone selected a form in which the role looks heavier."

"Possible. But who? When? One source? Editorial intervention by the news outlet? An intermediate summary? Those remain open."

Aditya then produced a third paper. It was the external index of the sealed file, showing only draft numbers, dates, and circulation marks. In the title of one draft was an unusual spelling error: instead of the ordinary form for 'beneficial', an aberrant inflected form had been used. The very same unusual form appeared unchanged in one sentence of the news report.

Shashank leaned closer. "Coincidence?"

Aditya said, "It may be. But if an unusual word order, the same spelling error, and the omission of the same cautionary sentence occur together, the probability of a textual lineage between the documents increases."

"Postulation?"

"Say it."

Shashank thought for a few moments. "If the public text contains three markers that occur together in one particular draft, then it may be difficult to explain the public text without assuming that someone involved in its creation saw that draft or some descendant of it. The minimum posit is that there is a textual relationship between the two. But 'Officer X leaked it' does not follow yet."

Aditya wrote: "Possible textual lineage; source attributable to no particular person at present."

A strange pain rose inside Shashank. On one side, he felt relief that the language of the public accusation was not the language of the original material; on the other, knowing that the shadow of a sealed paper could truly have reached outside made him feel exposed.

Aditya said, "Now the third allegation in the news—Raghav Bhasin provided 'legal protection'."

Raghav Bhasin was connected by telephone. Only the public allegation was read to him, not the confidential material. He said, "If my presence, advice, or legal caution is to be called criminal protection, that requires an independent basis. If there is evidence of my direct instruction, benefit, decision-making authority, or knowledge of criminal conduct in any business activity, that should be examined separately. Being a lawyer is not a shield; but being a lawyer is not a crime either."

That earlier session returned to Shashank's mind. He said, "And my translation?"

Raghav replied, "You are responsible for what you softened. But calling that my 'legal approval' is not justified unless I actually gave such approval."

After the call ended, Aditya ordered the sealed envelope closed again. Before signing, Shashank asked, "What am I allowed to say publicly?"

"Whatever the judicial limit permits. For now you may say that the published allegations are under examination and that you will respond on the basis of evidence. Do not quote the sealed text."

Bitterness came over Shashank's face. "They can publish half a document, and I cannot even name the whole document."

"That asymmetry is difficult," Aditya said, "but breaking a sealing restriction in your own defence can later damage the evidence as well."

The moment he stepped outside, the cameras rose again. Questions came at once—"Are you the Indian conduit of a Chinese gambling group?" "Did you operate accounts in Macao?" "Did you create the hawala and bitcoin routes?"

Shashank wanted to answer sharply. Then he stopped. "I provided linguistic services, I travelled to Macao, and I have acknowledged some errors in my translations. But I have not yet seen evidence establishing that I owned the money, controlled alleged mule accounts, or operated hawala or digital-asset transfers. The investigation is continuing. I will answer whatever is proved, and I will challenge false allegations on the basis of evidence as well."

A reporter asked, "Then are you innocent?"

Shashank replied, "That question will not be answered by a slogan. Evidence will answer it."

Standing at a distance, Mrinal watched him. Shashank understood how much boasting, fear, and shame he had had to cut through within himself to arrive at that one sentence.

On the way home, the old acquaintance called again. "People in the village are asking. What should I tell them?"

Shashank's throat filled, but he steadied his voice. "Tell them the matter is under investigation. Not everything that has been printed is an established fact."

"Will people believe that?"

"I do not know. But I will not defend myself with false certainty."

After he ended the call, the humiliation arrived for the first time with its full weight. In the courtroom, method had been his shield; in the silence of home there was no shield. He remembered the faces of his parents, the questions in the village, Juliana's stern gaze, and all the moments when he himself had exaggerated his own importance. He understood that his old boasts were now helping public falsehoods appear believable. That was not justice, but it was a consequence.

In the evening Mrinal came again. This time he carried no newspaper, only a blank sheet. He drew four headings: "Established", "Admitted by me", "Under investigation", "Distorted statement". The Macao journey went in the first column; the admission that Shashank had softened linguistic meaning went in the second; actual control of the payment chain in the third; "conduit coordinating funds" in the fourth. Shashank kept looking at the list. Public humiliation painted every boundary the same colour; on this small page, the boundaries became visible again.

Mrinal asked, "Why don't you deny every allegation at once?" Shashank said, "Because then I would hide my own truth together with the false accusations. What I did, I will admit; what has not been proved, I will not treat as proved; and what was created by changing the original sentence, I will contest." Mrinal folded the page. "Then this time, before saving your reputation, save the sentence." Shashank did not answer, but he felt that amid the humiliation, this was one thing still within his hands.

That night he opened his notebook.

"Sealed material ≠ automatic verification of a public allegation."

"Cutting the original sentence = may change meaning."

"Same unusual word order and spelling = indicator of textual lineage; does not establish the identity of the leaker."

"Translator present ≠ financial decision-maker."

"Lawyer present ≠ criminal protection."

"The record contains the words hawala/digital asset ≠ Shashank operated them automatically."

"My old boasting = context for understanding public suspicion; not proof of the accusation."

"Humiliation = real experience; retaliation ≠ substitute for evidentiary method."

"Postulation = the minimum necessary textual bridge when available facts remain discordant; not a licence to fill in the name of the culprit."

He paused for a long time before writing the final line: "I will not make my own errors smaller; but neither will I let their size be altered in order to make someone else's accusation larger."

As he closed the notebook, he remembered the court's next date. Aditya had said there would be cross-examination on the textual lineage of the sealed material, its public transformation, and the alleged economic relationship.

Shashank stood before the window. The mirror of Macao no longer showed the city's glitter; it showed two versions of the same sentence—one that existed in the record, and another the world had already heard.

The next question in court would be how much of the distance between those two versions could be measured by evidence, and how much had been filled by anger, shame, or atonement.

CHAPTER 64

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 12

The courtroom was less crowded today, but the weight of words was greater. The judge made one thing clear at the outset: only those portions of the sealed material would be shown that were necessary for comparison with the public rendering, the textual lineage, and the alleged economic relationship. The substance of confidential legal advice would remain outside the present scope.

Shashank sat near the witness enclosure. Before him three piles had been made—the original sealed summary, the passages circulated in the media, and a list of economic headings gathered during the investigation. It seemed to him that several years of his life had been compressed into three piles: what had actually been written, what the world had heard, and what everyone wished to fill into the space between the two.

The government counsel asked the first question: “Do you admit that you provided linguistic services in Macao?”

“Yes.”

“Did you see gambling-related material?”

“Yes, some material.”

“Did you translate payment-related headings?”

“Some headings.”

“Does your name appear in messages concerning several meetings?”

“Yes.”

Counsel paused for a moment. “Then why should the court not conclude that you were not merely a translator, but an active Indian coordinator of the network?”

Before answering, Shashank looked not at the judge but at Aditya. Aditya’s face was expressionless. Shashank said, “Because the fifth conclusion does not follow automatically from the first four statements. Linguistic service, seeing material, translating headings, and having one’s name in meeting records may all be facts. ‘Active Indian coordinator’ is a separate conclusion; it requires independent evidence of decision-making authority, instructions, control, benefit, or acts.”

Government counsel said, “Postulation? Is it not necessary, for the available facts to cohere, to assume such a role?”

A faint tremor rose inside Shashank. Navya-Nyaya was no longer on the page of a book; its word had entered a question in court. He said, “Postulation applies where the known facts remain incoherent without a minimum additional assumption. Here the facts can remain coherent even if I am taken to have been a linguistic service provider. Therefore it would not be proper to treat ‘coordinator’ as a necessary assumption.”

Government counsel immediately read out a line that had circulated in the media: “Indian contact used as funds coordinator.” Then, with permission, the court heard the corresponding line from the sealed material: “Use of Indian linguistic contact; role as funds coordinator subject to independent verification.”

Counsel asked, “Do the two not share the same basic words?”

“They do.”

“Then how can the public statement be wholly false?”

Shashank said, “I did not say it was wholly false. I am saying that once the cautionary phrase is removed, a role under investigation sounds like an established role. The original says ‘subject to independent verification’; the public version does not.”

The judge made a note. “Record this: the witness does not deny the existence of the underlying text in its entirety; he objects to the effect of removing the qualifying portion in the public rendering.”

Government counsel changed direction. “You wrote to your friend Mrinal: ‘I am looking at the money part.’ Is that your sentence?”

Shashank’s throat tightened. “Yes. Such a sentence appears in an old message.”

“Then you admit a financial role?”

“No. That sentence was boasting. I exaggerated the fact that I had seen some payment headings and summaries. If the court wishes, I accept responsibility for the exaggeration.”

“It is easy to escape by calling it exaggeration.”

Shashank's face flushed, but his voice held steady. "I am not saying it to escape. Because of that boasting, suspicion against me looks credible today. That consequence is of my making. But the boast does not become proof of actual control unless the records also show that authority."

Raghav Bhasin, seated at a separate table, spoke with the court's permission. "That distinction is necessary—the credibility of self-description is one question; actual legal or economic authority is another."

Government counsel turned towards him. "Your presence too is recorded in several meetings. Why should the court not conclude that a legal cover was being prepared?"

Raghav answered, "Because a lawyer's presence alone does not establish a criminal cover. If any specific record shows that I instructed the execution of a crime, that is a separate matter. Giving legal caution, reading a contract, or identifying legal risk in language does not by itself amount to participation."

Counsel lifted a paper. "This note contains the words hawala and bitcoin."

Raghav said, "The presence of the words raises a question; it does not establish authorship of the acts."

The judge intervened. "At this stage the court will hear no operational detail. The question is only this: who knew what, which record connects whom, and what are the limits of the conclusion?"

Aditya was called to the witness enclosure. Government counsel asked, "You are the investigating officer. Did you find a textual relationship between the sealed summary and the public passage?"

"Yes. Some unusual word order, punctuation, and one spelling error are the same."

"Then the leak is proved?"

"There is a strong indication of textual lineage. But which person, by what means, and at what time the passage went outside are separate evidentiary questions."

"Why should postulation not allow us to conclude that someone among those who had access supplied it?"

Aditya said, "'Someone among the group with access' may be a broad possibility, but selecting a particular person requires additional material. Postulation does not fill an empty space with the name one prefers."

Government counsel sharpened the question. "You are excessively cautious. In a criminal investigation, does so much division not risk allowing the truth to slip away?"

For the first time Aditya leaned slightly forward. "A truth constructed by breaking its limits collapses more quickly in court. Our task is not to accelerate the conclusion, but to preserve its foundation."

For a few moments the room was still. In that sentence Shashank saw the reverse image of his own life. All his life he had accelerated meaning—so the meeting would end quickly, so the foreign side would remain pleased, so his own importance would grow. Aditya was saying that some meanings were better made slowly.

The second part of the cross-examination turned to Shashank's translations. Government counsel showed an old bilingual summary. The original term made the gambling risk explicit; in Shashank's summary it had been softened into something like "entertainment service."

"Is this your translation?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "Yes."

"Knowingly?"

"The word choice was deliberate. Criminal purpose? I do not admit that, because neither my memory nor the available material confirms it. But I do admit that, out of concern for the client's convenience, my own importance, and my greed to keep the work alive, I softened the harshness of the risk contained in the original."

"Then it was deception?"

Shashank was silent. The question entered deeply. "In some contexts it was more than style. I knew I was softening the words. If by 'deception' you mean that I reduced the edge of the original meaning and did not tell the other side its full consequence, then it was not merely a linguistic error—it was a moral error. But if by the word you mean that the purpose of an economic conspiracy is thereby established, that is an additional conclusion."

Raghav looked at him. Mrinal sat in the back row. Shashank felt that after this admission the air in the room had grown heavier, yet something within him had become lighter. Atonement, perhaps, was not making one's story smaller; it was accepting the true dimensions of one's fault.

Government counsel returned to the economic list. "Alleged mule accounts, hawala references, digital-asset entries—all are found around the same commercial group. You too attended meetings of that group. What does postulation say here?"

Shashank replied, "It says that the relationship among the available records requires explanation. But first it would have to be established that the facts remain incoherent unless I am treated as an operator. If linguistic service, travel, and presence in meetings are sufficient to make the facts coherent, then my economic control is not a necessary assumption."

"Your payment?"

"I received payment for linguistic services—I do not deny that."

“Then a financial relationship?”

“A service-fee relationship. Beneficial ownership, profit sharing, control of accounts, or operation of alleged hawala or digital-asset transfers require separate facts.”

The judge said, “Both will remain on the record—the admission of payment, and the dispute over any broader financial role.”

In the afternoon, the defence began its questions. Raghav was not acting as Shashank’s lawyer, so a separate counsel conducted the examination. The first question was simple: “What do you want from this court? A declaration of complete innocence?”

Shashank had not expected it. “Not at this stage. I want what is proved to be called proved; what I have admitted not to be concealed; and what is inference not to be turned into established fact.”

“Do you accept the consequences of your distortions as a translator?”

“Yes.”

“Do you wish to make them smaller because of the public accusations?”

“No.”

“And because of public humiliation, will you accept accusations that have not been proved?”

“No to that as well.”

Counsel placed the original sealed line and the public line together once more. “If ‘subject to independent verification’ has been removed, does the meaning change?”

“Yes.”

“Did Shashank make that change?”

Aditya answered, “There is no evidence of that at present.”

“Raghav?”

“There is no evidence of that at present.”

“The officer from the lower commissionerate?”

“There is no evidence of that at present.”

Counsel looked towards the court. “Then there is textual lineage, while the source person remains uncertain.”

Government counsel objected. “The defence is turning uncertainty into proof of innocence.”

The judge said, “No. Uncertainty is not proof of innocence; but it is equally improper to write certain guilt where uncertainty remains. The court will preserve both distinctions.”

That sentence echoed within Shashank for a long time. He remembered the people of his village, the questions from the press, the cameras, the glitter of Macao, Li Wenchao’s proposal, Raghav’s caution, Mrinal’s blank sheet—all at once. No single scene made him wholly innocent; no single scene made him wholly guilty either.

Before the hearing ended, the judge issued two directions. First, the separate inquiry into the chain by which the sealed material had been transformed into the public version would continue. Second, there would be a limited re-examination of messages, translation drafts, and payment references recovered from Shashank’s old digital devices, so that it could be seen whether there was any real connection between his admitted linguistic distortions and the alleged economic role.

Aditya made a note. Shashank understood—the next phase would return again to summons, statements, and digital seizure. But this time his old sentences of ambition would return as harder questions.

When he came out of court, the media surrounded him again. One question came at once: “Did you confess to a crime today?”

Shashank stopped. “I admitted that in some translations I softened the force of the risks expressed in the original, and that this is not free of moral responsibility. But nothing happened in court today that established that I exercised economic control, operated alleged mule accounts, or operated hawala or digital-asset transfers.”

“Then what are you atoning for?”

Shashank replied, “For what is mine.”

He moved on. This time he neither enlarged his sentence to make it impressive nor softened it.

In the evening Mrinal walked beside him along the roadside. After a long while he asked, “Do you feel lighter?”

“No,” Shashank said. “But I am beginning to understand the name of the weight.”

“The name?”

“My own error. Someone else’s accusation. They are different.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

“Cross-examination = not merely forcing an admission; testing the limits of a statement.”

“Admission of linguistic distortion ≠ admission of economic control.”

“Service fee ≠ beneficial ownership.”

“Presence at a meeting ≠ operation of mule accounts/hawala/digital assets.”

“Textual lineage ≠ source person established.”

“Uncertainty ≠ proof of innocence; nor does uncertainty permit certain guilt.”

“Atonement = accepting the true size of one’s proved error; not placing an unproved guilt upon one’s own head.”

“Postulation = the minimum necessary assumption that removes incoherence from the known facts; not abandoning an available simpler explanation in favour of a heavier accusation.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped his pen: “Every time I exaggerated my own importance, those sentences are now cross-examining me; perhaps that is just. But I will answer them with evidence again.”

He closed the notebook. The prospect of another summons was no longer merely a source of fear; he knew that the old mobile phone, the translation drafts, and the payment references would return to the table.

The twelfth reflection in the mirror of Macao had shattered in court. The thirteenth reflection would perhaps be found in the digital imprint of his own ambition.

CHAPTER 65

THE MIRROR OF MACAO 13

This time the summons did not arrive in the morning, but in the evening. Along with a copy of the court order came a short message from Aditya Mishra: “Tomorrow there will be a limited re-examination of the digital devices. Only messages, translation drafts, payment references, and statements concerning role. Nothing beyond what the court has permitted.”

Shashank sat for a long time with the mobile phone in his hand after reading the message. At the end of the previous episode he had written: every time I enlarged my own importance, those sentences are now cross-examining me. Tomorrow those sentences would no longer be lines in a notebook; they would stand before him on a computer screen with date, time, and sender attached.

Mrinal asked, “Fear?”

Shashank said, “More shame than fear. Some things I truly did write in exaggerated form. At the time it felt like style; now it is part of the record.”

“Style has consequences too.”

“Yes. But let the consequence be called what it is; not what it is not.”

The next day, two sealed packets lay on the table in the examination room. Aditya first read out the details of the seals, then said, “The original devices will not be operated again. We will work from certified forensic copies. The court order is limited. Today I am not examining everything you have done in your life; only four questions—which messages are yours, which drafts you prepared, what the payment references meant, and how far you exaggerated your own role in writing.”

Shashank nodded.

The first image was from the old mobile phone. A message thread was opened. Most of it was ordinary—meeting times, linguistic lines, travel, food. In the middle one sentence stood out: “I handle the Indian side; leave language and local coordination to me.”

Aditya paused the screen. “Yours?”

Shashank did not answer immediately. The words felt like his. “Probably mine.”

“Why probably?”

“I used to write ‘leave it to me’ very often then. But authorship cannot be established from style alone. Look at the sender record, device usage, and time as well.”

Aditya said, “The sender account is in your name. The device-usage log shows no other user at that time. Now?”

Shashank drew a long breath. “Then there is strong support that it is mine. My memory also matches. Yes, I wrote it.”

“What did ‘I handle the Indian side’ mean?”

Shashank lowered his eyes. “At the time I liked the foreign side to think of me as the person without whom the India-side work could not proceed. The reality was not that broad. I handled language, meeting times, some contacts, and clarity of documents. ‘I handle the Indian side’ was a sentence that enlarged my role.”

“The financial side too?”

“Not from that sentence alone. If another record shows that I controlled payment decisions, accounts, beneficiaries, or the direction of funds, that would be different. But the words ‘Indian side’ do not by themselves say all that.”

Aditya wrote a note: “Admitted self-expansion; financial control independently testable.”

The second message was from Li Wenchao’s group. One person had written: “Have the list of names corrected for Indian reading.” Shashank’s reply: “Send it; I’ll reconcile it.” After that came an image attachment containing several names and general payment headings. The amounts had been masked.

Aditya asked, “What did ‘reconcile’ mean here?”

“Roman forms of names, Devanagari/English spelling, and the language of service descriptions.”

“Account verification?”

“No.”

“Beneficiary identification?”

“No.”

"Then if a later summary says, 'Indian payment list verified by Shashank?'"

Shashank raised his face. "Then we have to ask what 'verified' means. I may have done a linguistic reconciliation; I did not verify the bank account or the actual beneficiary. If someone treats the two as the same, that is an expansion of meaning."

Aditya said, "That is precisely why the original conversation is being examined today."

Then a translation draft was opened. In the margin appeared a comment by Shashank: "This heading is harsh for an Indian reader; use service-language instead." He recognized the digital annotation as his own. For a few moments he remained silent.

"Yours?"

"Yes."

"Why 'harsh'?"

"The original term made the gambling nature more explicit. I suggested a softer form for the client's convenience."

"Digital confirmation of what you admitted in court today?"

"At the very least, this comment confirms that I suggested choosing softer words. But it does not establish an economic role, ownership of funds, or operation of alleged mule accounts."

Aditya nodded. "The admission and the limit will both be recorded."

In the third file were several messages referring to payments. In one place Shashank had written: "Keep my fee separate; do not send me the accounting for the other payments."

As soon as he read the line, a strange relief rose inside Shashank, but he did not let it show on his face.

Aditya asked, "What does this establish?"

Shashank said, "That at that moment I wrote that my fee should be kept separate from the other payments."

"Does it establish that you never saw any other payment?"

"No."

"Does it establish that the other payments were illegal?"

"No."

"Does it establish that you were entirely unrelated to them?"

Shashank paused. "Not entirely. Levels of connection can differ—seeing something in a meeting, translating a heading, being sent a list, or making a decision. This one sentence only suggests an absence of decision-making authority; not complete disconnection."

For the first time, Aditya smiled faintly. "You sound less like your own lawyer now and more like an examiner of your own statements."

Shashank said, "I have been learning that for a long time."

In the afternoon, the forensic image of the old laptop was opened. One folder was named "India coordination". Shashank's chest tightened again. Inside were translation drafts, travel schedules, copies of meeting notes, and an image of a payment summary.

Aditya asked, "Did you name this folder?"

"Probably."

"If someone reads that name now, what might they assume?"

"That I coordinated India."

"Would that be accurate?"

"Partly. In language and meeting liaison, yes. In the entire business, money, or ownership, no."

"Then why did you choose such a broad name?"

Shashank searched for an answer for a while. "Ambition. Giving my work a bigger name made me feel that I myself was becoming bigger."

"The consequence of that name?"

"If someone sees this folder by itself tomorrow, they may understand my role to be larger than it was."

"And postulation?"

After a few moments Shashank said, "If the folder contains language, travel, and meeting material, then the minimum meaning of 'coordination' may be coordination of those things. It is not necessary to assume financial control, because the available contents remain coherent without that assumption."

Aditya noted: "Folder name = context; not proof of role."

In an old text file they found a translation of a question concerning beneficial ownership. The original asked: "Who receives the ultimate benefit?" Shashank's translation was unexpectedly severe; there he had not softened the meaning.

Aditya asked, "Why not here?"

Shashank kept looking at the line. "It may be a draft from after Raghav Bhasin's caution. He had said that the question of actual beneficial ownership should not be made ambiguous."

"So you did not soften meaning everywhere?"

"No. In some places I did; in some places I preserved the original severity. That is why it would be improper to impose one identical purpose on every translation."

Aditya said, "And that is why admitting one error does not make every line false."

The sentence went deep into Shashank. His ambition had carried him across the boundary in several places; but the task of the investigation was not to paint his entire life in a single colour.

Then a short message thread was opened. The sender's name had been redacted; only the sequence number of the certified forensic copy was visible. The message read: "Indian guests will be special at the birthday banquet. Stage list later. S.J. at the front table." A second message read: "Indian Idol performer confirmed?"

Aditya paused the screen. "Remember this?"

For a moment an old gleam returned to Shashank's face and disappeared again. "Yes. There was a birthday banquet. A great deal of expense, many people, a stage, singers... I was impressed by all of it then."

"Its relationship to the economic investigation?"

"I do not know yet."

"Then today?"

"Context only. Context for my lifestyle and ambition. If a link emerges with the vendor trail, contracts, or actual beneficial ownership, that would require separate examination."

Aditya closed the message. "Correct. This part will be examined in the next session. Today's summons is limited to the digital material and your statement."

Shashank laughed involuntarily. "You stopped again at the boundary."

"A boundary does not weaken an investigation. Without boundaries, an investigation begins writing its own story."

The statement was read back. It recorded that Shashank had described his role in some old messages in terms broader than reality; that in some translations he had softened the original language of risk; that he admitted receiving payment for linguistic services; but that the available digital material did not by itself establish financial control, beneficial ownership, operation of alleged mule accounts, hawala operations, or digital-asset transfers. Each asserted connection remained independently testable by evidence.

Shashank said, "Add one line."

Aditya raised his pen.

"My ambitious language raises legitimate questions for the investigation; but a question is not itself an answer."

Aditya wrote it down.

Outside, Mrinal was waiting. As soon as Shashank came out he asked, "The thirteenth mirror?"

Shashank said, "The names I gave myself."

"Broken?"

"Some of them. 'Indian side', 'coordination', 'I handle it'—those words made me larger. Now I understand: once a word becomes a title, one day it may also be placed on the evidence table."

Mrinal asked, "Do you remember that birthday banquet?"

Shashank stopped while walking. "Very clearly. That night I felt I had finally entered a world where language sat at the same table as money, fame, and power."

"And now?"

"Now I have to see whether at that table I was a translator—or whether, in my own mind, I had become a god."

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

"A name on a digital device = a question of authorship; not an automatic answer."

"My account + time + style + memory = can form strong support for authorship."

"'I handle the Indian side' = admitted self-expansion; financial control remains a separate evidentiary question."

"Linguistic reconciliation of a list ≠ bank/beneficiary verification."

"Folder name = context; not ownership."

"Service fee = service relationship; not beneficial ownership."

"Softening meaning in some lines = established linguistic/moral error; not proof that every line had the same purpose."

“Ambition = context for why a statement became larger; not independent proof of a crime.”

“Postulation = the minimum necessary posit that makes the available facts coherent; a broader role only when a smaller explanation becomes impossible.”

As he wrote the final line, he remembered the birthday-banquet message—the front table, the stage, talk of a famous singer, expensive lighting, and his name on the list of special guests.

He closed the notebook. The thirteenth mirror of Macao had not yielded a verdict of crime; it had yielded the signature of Shashank’s own ambition.

The next mirror would not open in Macao, but in the blaze of a banquet—where linguistic pride, the glitter of money, and the shadow of the court would fall before him in the same night.

CHAPTER 66

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION I

The first paper Aditya Mishra placed on the table in the next session was not a bank summary. It was a digital image of a thick cream-coloured invitation card. Across the top, in a shadow of golden lettering, were the words: Special Birthday Banquet. Below were small indications of guest categories, stage programme, food, and accommodation.

The moment Shashank saw the page, he remembered an Indian night very different from the glitter of Macao. An expensive event venue in Delhi. A long procession of cars outside. Inside—flowers, glass, electric light, music. Foreign guests. Local businessmen. A few people from the entertainment world. And he—Shashank Jha—at a front table, his name entered on the guest list as “Special Linguistic Guest.”

Aditya asked, “Do you recognize it?”

“Yes.”

“Whose banquet was this?”

Shashank paused. “It was a birthday event within the vendor side’s commercial circle. I did not directly know the full details of the personal relationships. So I will not infer and name anyone as the actual owner or principal person.”

Aditya nodded. “Good. Today I am not interested in the glitter of the event. I want to look at the contracts and the vendor trail.”

On the second page was a summary of the event-services contracts. An Indian event company, a hospitality-services vendor, an artist-coordination agency, and a separate company under another name that made payments. In the margin was an old pencil note: “Who bears the ultimate cost?”

Shashank looked at the note. “That is not my handwriting.”

“At present I am saying only that the note exists in the record. Authorship is a separate question.”

Aditya opened the next paper. “What work did you do at this event?”

“Linguistic assistance for foreign guests. A few introductions from the stage. Explaining the meaning of two or three short sentences between the artist and the organizer side. Checking the pronunciation of Chinese names on the guest list.”

“The contract?”

“Not the whole contract. I saw the language of a few service descriptions.”

“Payment?”

“My linguistic-service fee was separate.”

“And the entire expense of the event?”

“I did not know it.”

Aditya drew the first line: “Presence ≠ knowledge of expenditure.”

Then an artist-related extract was shown. The draft invitation said: “A special performance by a popular singer known from the Indian Idol programme.” The artist’s name was masked here, because the question under investigation concerned the booking chain, not the artist.

Aditya said, “Does the artist’s presence establish a commercial relationship between that person or programme and the parties under investigation?”

“No,” Shashank answered at once. “The artist gave a performance—that is the direct fact. Singing at someone’s birthday does not mean knowing or endorsing the event’s economic structure.”

“Did you introduce the artist on stage?”

“Yes.”

“In Chinese?”

“First in Mandarin, then one short Cantonese sentence. Not in Maithili after that—a general introduction mixing Hindi and English, because the audience was mixed.”

Shashank stopped there. He remembered that moment of the night clearly. The microphone in his hand on stage. Many faces before him. A foreign guest applauding when he heard Shashank’s Cantonese pronunciation. The singer smiling. An organizer touching his shoulder and saying, “You are the bridge.”

For how many days those four words had intoxicated him.

“What is it?” Aditya asked.

Shashank said, "That night I was proud of my language. The pride grew so large that I began to feel all these people were connected because of me."

"In reality?"

"Not all of them. I connected language. I was not the cause of the event, the money, the artist, the contracts, or the guests."

Aditya said, "Reasoning?"

Shashank looked at him. The direction had changed. After postulation, now came reasoning—carry an assumption through to its consequences and see whether it holds.

He said, "If we assume that because I was a linguistic bridge on stage I was therefore the operator of the entire event, then the event company's contract, the artist coordinator's separate agreement, the hospitality vendor's invoices, and the payer's separate records would all have to be treated as unnecessary. The available facts do not require such an assumption. So the broader role is logically too heavy."

Aditya made a small tick. "And the reverse?"

"If we assume that I was merely an ordinary guest, then my linguistic-service fee, my stage messages, and my translation drafts become inconsistent. So 'only a guest' is incomplete too. The correct boundary is linguistic service and some stage coordination."

"Correct."

After this answer, Aditya opened a summary of the vendor trail. One event contract was with Indian entity A. Artist arrangements were through entity B. Hotel arrangements through C. But reimbursement of some expenses was recorded through a company named D. Beside D was a question mark: "Beneficial ownership verification pending."

Shashank's eyes remained fixed on the line.

"Did you know D?"

"The name looks familiar, but I do not remember a direct role."

"Was D actually Li Wenchao's company?"

"That cannot be said from this page."

"Part of the gambling-related vendor chain?"

"Possibly an investigative question. Not an established fact."

"The ultimate beneficial owner?"

"It says verification pending. That is not an answer."

Aditya said, "Assume D paid some of the event expenses. What follows?"

Shashank thought. "At minimum, that some economic relationship existed between D and the event. But the nature of that relationship—sponsorship, reimbursement, payment for services, payment on someone's instruction—requires separate evidence."

"And if D's beneficial owner turned out to be someone from that foreign commercial circle?"

"Then the relationship would become stronger. But even then, everyone present at the banquet would not thereby become a participant in that business activity."

Without smiling, Aditya said, "Do not use reasoning only as a defence."

Shashank understood. "Yes. If I claim I had no connection at all with the event's money, but the records show that my service fee came through the same event-expense chain, then the statement 'no connection' collapses. The correct statement would be: there was a service relationship; broader ownership or control is a separate question."

"Exactly."

In the afternoon, an old picture folder was opened. Under the court's permission, only public photographs from the event were shown. Shashank on stage. Beside the singer. Behind them a vast floral arrangement. In one photograph Li Wenchao could be seen at a distant table. In another, someone resembling Raghav Bhasin appeared at the edge, but the image was unclear; Aditya himself said, "Identity not verified."

One of those photographs had already circulated in the media. The headline: "Indian Coordinator at Birthday Banquet of Gambling Empire."

Shashank's jaw tightened. The old gust of humiliation returned, but this time the feeling was not humiliation alone. Strangely, pride was there too—the same stage, the same clothes, the same applause. Two Shashanks stood facing one another inside him: one ashamed to see the picture, the other still believing he had shone that night because of language.

Aditya asked, "What does the photograph establish?"

"That I was there. That I was on the stage. That I gave the introduction."

"Indian coordinator of a gambling empire?"

“Not from the photograph alone.”

“Linguistic pride?”

For the first time Shashank smiled faintly. “The photograph is not proof of that, but my memory is. I was proud—genuinely, deeply, and in places to the point of arrogance.”

“How is pride tested?”

“A state of mind is not directly a record. But look at my later messages—‘Today all the foreign tables listened to me’, ‘The stage would stall without me’, ‘Even the artist’s team was looking for me.’ I wrote all that. It shows how much I inflated my own importance in my mind.”

Aditya showed him an old message: “The banquet could not have happened without me.”

Shashank closed his eyes and sat still for a moment. “That was an exaggeration.”

“False?”

“If taken as a literal statement of fact, yes—the banquet would have happened without me. But I was boasting to a friend. The boast shows my state of mind; it does not establish actual control of the event.”

“Reasoning?”

“If the banquet were truly impossible without me, there should be some record showing that the contracts, event company, stage management, artist team, and hospitality staff all depended on my instructions. No such broad dependence appears at present. Therefore the literal meaning of my message does not fit the available structure.”

Aditya wrote: “Self-praise = context for state of mind; not independent proof of control.”

Then the question of beneficial ownership arose again. One contract page named the declared director of the company making the event payment, but the field for actual beneficial owner was blank. An old note from the lower commissioner read: “Vendor trail incomplete without verification of actual beneficiary.”

Shashank said, “This line is important.”

“Why?”

“Because the glitter of the banquet is not evidence of a relationship, but the source of the expenditure and verification of the ultimate beneficial owner are real economic questions. The blank field deserves more investigation than the applause I received on stage.”

For the first time Aditya smiled slightly. “From linguistic pride to accounts?”

Shashank said, “Pride put me on the stage; the truth may be in the empty box on the page.”

In the evening, Mrinal too was shown an old message because he had been the recipient of Shashank’s reply at the time. Shashank had written: “Brother, today Chinese, Cantonese, Hindi, English—all were in my mouth. The stage was mine.” Mrinal’s old reply contained only two words: “Be careful.”

Aditya asked Mrinal, “What was that warning about?”

Mrinal said, “His pride. I knew nothing about the financial structure. I felt Shashank was listening to people praise him and forgetting his limits.”

“Suspicion of a crime?”

“Not then. At least not as I remember it.”

“And today?”

Mrinal looked at Shashank. “Today I want whatever error is his not to be hidden. But what is not his should not be placed on his head in the name of friendship either.”

Shashank said nothing. There was a hardness to friendship in that one sentence.

Before the session ended, Aditya read the day’s summary: there was material supporting Shashank’s presence at the banquet, his linguistic service, his stage role, and his service fee; payment relationships among the event’s different vendors remained under examination; the question of actual beneficial ownership remained open; the artist’s presence or public photographs did not by themselves establish business participation; Shashank’s exaggerated messages provided context for ambition and linguistic pride, but not independent proof of ownership.

Shashank said, “Add one thing.”

“What?”

“I had the right to be proud of my talent that night. My error was that I mistook talent for power.”

Aditya said, “In the language of the statement?”

Shashank thought and said, “I understood and described my linguistic role as broader than it actually was.”

“That can be written.”

Night was falling outside. Walking with Mrinal, Shashank said, “At that banquet I felt language had made me a god.”

Mrinal asked, “And the humiliation?”

“What remains when the illusion of being a god breaks.”

“Will you give up being proud of language?”

Shashank answered at once, “No. Why should I give up pride in language? I will give up only the reasoning that because I know language, I am therefore the owner of everything.”

That night he wrote in his notebook:

“Presence at a banquet $\neq$ ownership of the event.”

“Stage role $\neq$ control of the contract.”

“Artist performance $\neq$ artist’s business participation.”

“Multilingual talent = real talent; broader power does not follow from it.”

“Lavish expenditure $\neq$ proof of crime; source of funds, contracts, and beneficial ownership are separate testable questions.”

“Vendor trail = not a list of names; it is the relationship among contract, service, payment, and actual beneficiary.”

“Blank beneficial-ownership field = not a guilty person; it is a need for verification.”

“Self-praise = may be evidence of ambition; not of economic control.”

“Reasoning = carry an assumption to its consequences—if it makes the available facts unnecessary or contradictory, the assumption is too heavy.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank looked again at the old message: “Brother, the stage was mine.” Mrinal’s answer: “Be careful.”

He wrote slowly: “The stage was not mine; for a few minutes, the voice was mine.”

CHAPTER 67

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 2

The memory of the day after the banquet would not leave Shashank all night. Mrinal's two words—"Be careful"—had once seemed to him like unnecessary worry from a friend. Now he understood that those two words had not foretold a crime; they had asked him to remember a boundary.

In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: "Today the banquet-related payment records, old messages, and Mrinal's statement will be examined together. No operational method—only relationships and limits."

When Shashank reached the office, Mrinal was already there. Five pages lay on the table—a summary of the event expenses, a consolidated table linked to a payment gateway, abbreviated names of several accounts, old messages between Shashank and Mrinal, and a note that read: "Final beneficiary verification pending."

Aditya said, "Today friendship too will come to the test of evidence. Being a friend is neither a crime nor proof of innocence. We will look only at what the papers say."

Shashank looked at Mrinal. Mrinal's face was calm.

The first document was a payment summary of the banquet expenses. There were several service vendors, different dates, different headings. Some payments had passed through a payment gateway. The second document contained abbreviated identifiers for several Indian accounts, which investigators had marked as "possible intermediary accounts."

Aditya asked, "Why the word 'possible'?"

Shashank replied, "Because an account appearing to be intermediary does not by itself establish that it is a mule account. We need the account-holder's actual role, instructions concerning the funds, the beneficiary, and the context of the transactions."

"And if two or three payments later moved towards another name?"

"Then the relationship in the flow of funds is worth investigating. But 'moved onward' does not mean 'the account-holder knowingly acted as a front'."

Aditya nodded. "Reasoning?"

Shashank thought for a few moments. "If we assume in advance that every intermediary account is a criminal front, we eliminate lawful service payments, reimbursements, or ordinary third-party expenses without justification. If we assume the opposite—that all are lawful—then verification of the actual beneficiary becomes meaningless. Both extreme assumptions distort the available facts."

"Correct," Aditya said. "Reasoning is not there to hand us a conclusion; it shows us where an over-heavy assumption breaks."

On the second page there was an entry marked "M.K." Beside it were the words: "guest assistance." The amount was redacted.

Aditya looked at Mrinal. "Is this you?"

Mrinal looked at the page. "I cannot say from 'M.K.' alone."

"Your full name is Mrinal Karn?"

"Yes."

"Were you present at the banquet?"

"I arrived for the final part. Shashank had invited me."

"Did you receive any payment?"

Mrinal tried hard to remember. "I do not remember any payment for attending the banquet. There may once have been something like reimbursement for a car fare or food, but I do not remember clearly. Look at the records."

Shashank wanted to say something, but stopped himself. Friendship did not give him the right to answer in Mrinal's place.

Aditya said, "That is what I want. Shashank will not answer for you."

Over the past few years Shashank had often spoken of Mrinal as "my man", "someone I trust", "someone who stays with me". At the time these had been ordinary expressions of friendship. On the table of an investigation, the same words could be read as though they described an organizational role.

Aditya opened an old message. The day after the banquet, Shashank had written: “Yesterday I figured out all the money people. Stay close; the work will move ahead.”

Shashank’s face hardened.

“Did you write this?”

“Yes.”

“‘Figured out all of them?’”

“Boasting.”

“‘The work will move ahead?’”

“I thought there might be more work. Not that I understood the entire financial structure.”

Aditya asked, “Mrinal, what did you understand this message to mean at the time?”

Mrinal said, “I thought Shashank was going to get new work. I did not know the money chain or the economic structure of the gambling business. I asked him again: ‘What work?’”

The next message was shown. Mrinal’s question was: “What work?” Shashank’s reply: “Language, people, payment papers—I can help with all of it.”

Shashank lowered his eyes.

Aditya asked, “What did that sentence mean?”

“I meant language papers, introductions between people, and explaining payment headings. But by writing ‘all of it’ I enlarged my role again.”

“Did you give payment instructions?”

“I have no established memory of doing so.”

“Did you choose accounts?”

“No.”

“Did you decide the ultimate recipient of funds?”

“No.”

“Did you translate some headings?”

“Yes.”

Aditya wrote: “Linguistic assistance admitted; payment decision-making authority unestablished.”

Mrinal said softly, “Back then you told me: ‘Don’t understand the names; understand the flow.’”

Shashank started. “I did?”

“Yes. At a tea stall. I asked why one company was making the payment while the service was in another name. You said—don’t go by the names, understand the flow.”

Silence spread through the room.

Aditya asked, “How certain is that recollection independently?”

Mrinal said, “I am certain of the sense. Whether those were the exact words, we would need to search the old messages.”

Shashank said, “I could have said something like that. At the time I was proud of being able to understand a complex structure. But saying ‘understand the flow’ does not mean I controlled the flow.”

Aditya drew two columns on the page—“knowledge” and “control”.

“Today we will keep these two words separate,” he said. “Did you know something of the economic structure?”

Shashank answered, “Some headings, some paying parties, some ambiguities—yes.”

“Did you know the actual role of the alleged mule accounts?”

“Not in that form.”

“Had you heard the word hawala?”

“In some later discussions.”

“On the day after the banquet?”

“I have no direct memory of that.”

“Entries related to digital assets or crypto?”

“I saw some lists later. I will not say I fully understood their meaning on the day after the banquet.”

Aditya said, “Good. If the chronology breaks, the boundary of knowledge breaks with it.”

There was something unusual on the consolidated payment-gateway page. Beside one portion of the banquet expense were the words “third-party service”, but the original vendor path ran towards a different name. Beneath it was a tax-investigation note: “Reason requires verification.”

Shashank said, “There is a question here.”

“An answer?”

“No.”

“Apply reasoning.”

Shashank placed his thumb on the page. “If this was only an ordinary third-party service, there should be a service description or a basis for reimbursement. If no such basis appears and the money repeatedly moves towards unrelated names, an alternative explanation becomes stronger. But this single line still does not establish hawala or a mule-account structure.”

Aditya said, “And if the investigator writes ‘hawala’ in advance?”

“Then the heading puts an inference in the place of proof.”

“And if fear makes the investigator write ‘nothing’?”

“Then a real discrepancy is being concealed.”

Mrinal said, “Where is friendship in all this?”

Aditya looked at him. “In this question. If Shashank brought you to a meeting as someone he trusted, did that make you a participant in the financial structure?”

“No.”

“If you saw payment papers?”

“Seeing them does not establish a role.”

“If you asked questions?”

“Asking questions is not participation.”

“If you were ever reimbursed?”

Mrinal paused. “Then the fact of reimbursement would be established. Not a broader economic role.”

Shashank kept looking at Mrinal. His friend was not defending him; he was stating the boundary. That made his words more credible.

In the afternoon, a new digital copy was shown. In an old note by Shashank were the words: “M will stay with me; people will take me more seriously.”

Aditya asked, “M = Mrinal?”

Shashank said, “Possibly. But without the original context I cannot be certain.”

Mrinal did not laugh. “Were you using me as a shield?”

A shadow of shame crossed Shashank’s face. “Not a shield. Prestige. I thought that with two Indians together, rather than one translator alone, people would see me as a ‘team’.”

“Did you tell me that?”

“No.”

“Then you used the friendship.”

Shashank did not answer. This accusation was not a legal one; there was no easy place to hide from it behind evidentiary terminology.

After a few moments he said, “Yes. In some places.”

Mrinal’s eyes hardened, though his voice remained steady. “Here, between you and me, this is not a debate about proof. This concerns my life.”

Aditya stopped his pen. “This private part will enter the statement only if it is relevant to the investigation.”

Shashank said, “It is relevant—I used my friend’s presence to increase my own importance. But that fact does not establish Mrinal’s economic participation.”

Aditya wrote again: “The declarant admits using a friend’s presence as a means of enhancing prestige; the friend’s financial participation remains a matter for independent evidence.”

Towards evening, a high-level summary of alleged crypto-related entries was shown—only dates, categories, and record sources; no operational method. One date fell around the week of the banquet.

Aditya asked, “Temporal proximity?”

Shashank said, “A reason to investigate. Not a conclusion.”

“If the banquet, the payment gateway, and a digital-asset entry all fall in the same week?”

“Then it is reasonable to look for a connection. But one week does not equal one plan.”

“Reasoning?”

“If they were all part of one plan, there should be some coherent record of instructions, benefit, contacts, or authority connecting the roles. If that is absent, proximity of dates alone cannot carry the heavier conclusion.”

Aditya read the day’s summary: some payment paths for the banquet expenses remained under examination; the nature of the intermediary accounts was not yet determined; terms concerning hawala and digital assets appeared in investigative hypotheses or later records, but no operational role for Shashank or Mrinal on the day

after the banquet had yet been established; Shashank's linguistic and liaison role was real; Mrinal's friendship and occasional presence did not automatically imply economic participation; and Shashank had himself admitted using his friend's presence to enhance his own prestige.

Before signing, Mrinal said, "Add one line for me."

Aditya asked, "What?"

"I have not come here to save Shashank. I want his boasting not to be turned into his crime, and I do not want his real errors made smaller because of friendship either."

Aditya wrote it down.

After they left the building, the two friends walked some distance without speaking. A tea stall appeared by the road, but neither stopped.

Shashank said, "I used you."

Mrinal answered, "Yes."

"Forgive me."

Mrinal did not answer at once. After a few steps he said, "An apology may save a friendship. It does not alter the record."

Shashank said softly, "That is why the two were kept separate today."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Friendship $\neq$ participation."

"Trusted person $\neq$ economic representative."

"Reimbursement $\neq$ broader benefit."

"Intermediary account $\neq$ mule account automatically."

"Flow through a payment gateway $\neq$ ultimate beneficiary established."

"The words hawala/digital asset $\neq$ operational role established."

"Temporal proximity = reason to investigate a relationship; not proof of one plan."

"Using a friend's presence for prestige = moral error; not the friend's crime."

"Reasoning = accept an assumption and test its necessary consequences; if the consequences do not fit the record, lighten the assumption."

As he wrote the final line, he remembered an old travel message that had arrived after the banquet: "The next meeting is abroad; there will be special access."

He stared at the sentence for a long time. The wound concerning friendship from the banquet was still fresh, but the old Shashank had heard the words "special access" and been drawn in all over again.

He wrote: "The friend kept warning; greed kept listening."

The notebook closed. The next question would turn again towards travel, a Macao meeting, and the true limits of that "special access."

CHAPTER 68

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 3

The last message—"The next meeting is abroad; there will be special access"—flashed again in Shashank's memory. At the time, the words "special access" had sounded not like a warning but like a reward. A few hours of praise on the banquet stage had awakened a new hunger in him: merely knowing languages no longer felt sufficient; he wanted people to regard him as a man of the inner circle.

That morning three records lay on Aditya Mishra's table—the entry-and-exit details of the foreign trip, the list of participants in the Macao meeting, and a record of limited system access. Aditya first made one thing clear: "Today we will not discuss methods of operating any system or breaking security. The only questions are where you went, whom you sat with, and how much access you were actually given."

Shashank looked at the page. The journey had taken place about two weeks after the banquet. The ticket had been paid for by a travel-management entity on the vendor side. The accommodation had been booked by a separate service vendor. The invitation message read: "Closed meeting on linguistic assistance and regional user feedback."

Aditya asked, "Foreign travel = crime?"

"No."

"Another party paid the expenses = ownership?"

"No. Sponsored travel, service work, meetings—there can be many reasons. The reason for the payment is a separate matter for investigation."

"Macao = knowledge of gambling?"

Shashank shook his head. "A place-name does not establish what a person knew. But in my case I had already seen some gambling-related material—that is a separate fact."

Aditya stopped his pen at that answer. "Correct. You cannot preserve a boundary by hiding a fact that goes against you."

An old greed took shape again inside Shashank. On the night of the banquet he had written to Mrinal, "The stage is mine." When the invitation to Macao arrived, he told himself: now it was no longer the stage; the inner door itself was opening. Juliana's lessons, the delicacy of language, the translator's humility—he remembered all of it, but intoxication with praise had drawn a fine veil over those memories.

Li Wenchao's name appeared on the meeting list. Two Chinese managers, one technical employee, one business coordinator, Shashank, and two other guests. Raghav Bhasin's name was not on that meeting list. A note in the margin read: "Limited guest access for demonstration."

Aditya asked, "You were told you would have 'special access'. The record says 'limited guest access'. Are the two the same?"

A faint shadow of shame crossed Shashank's face. "No. The person who sent the message used the word 'special'. The formal record says 'limited guest'."

"Which did you choose to treat as true at the time?"

"The one that made me feel more important."

Aditya looked at him but made no comment.

The old scene opened inside Shashank. They were seated in a closed room in a glass building in Macao. On the computer screen appeared user-facing sentences in several languages, service headings, and customer information. Some sections related to games and wagering. A technical employee opened a guest account and said, "Only look here and make language comments."

Shashank had asked then, "Can I make changes directly?"

The answer had been: "No. Write a proposal; approval happens at another level."

The same sentence appeared in the meeting note now lying on Aditya's table: "Guest user: visual review and linguistic comments; no publication rights."

Aditya asked, "Then 'server access'?"

Shashank was silent for a few moments. "Later I told friends, 'I have access all the way to the server.' Literally, that was an exaggeration. I was shown some screens through a limited guest account. I did not have independent administrative control."

"Password?"

"The guest-account credentials were provided during the meeting. What rights those credentials actually allowed is for the records to show; I will not make a broad claim from memory."

Aditya said, "Good. Technical examination of the credentials belongs to another team. Here we will look only at the recorded permission list."

Three permissions were active on the list—view text, write comments, upload proposed translations. The inactive items included publication, payment structure, user administration, and system configuration.

Shashank said softly, "Then the record is smaller than my boast."

"And perhaps the truth is smaller too," Aditya said. "But smaller does not mean zero. You did upload proposed translations—that was a real role."

"Yes."

"Did you soften some risky words in those translations?"

Shashank's throat dried slightly. "In some places. I have already admitted that in court."

"Then there was real work inside the guest access?"

"Yes—linguistic work. But not publication or economic control."

Aditya drew a line. "That boundary will have to be made by evidence again and again, not by your preference."

That afternoon an old message thread was opened. Shashank had written to an acquaintance from the banquet: "Saw the inner system in Macao; now understand, I am no longer only a translator." The reply had been: "Wow! Big man." Shashank's next sentence: "Soon the whole India-language side will be in my hands."

As he read the line, Shashank's ears grew hot. Mrinal was not present; only Aditya sat before him.

"Did you write this?"

"Yes."

"True?"

"A palace of greed built on half a truth. My work on the language side was increasing. 'The whole thing in my hands' was not a fact."

"Why did you write it?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "After the banquet I wanted admiration. After Macao I wanted power. I wanted people to think—the foreign side cannot function without me."

"Was your greed economic or for prestige?"

"The two were not separate. More work, more fees, more access—each increased the others. But 'I was greedy' does not establish 'I operated unlawful money'."

Aditya said, "Correct. Greed may be context for a possible motive; a specific act must be established by evidence."

At this point Navya-Nyaya reasoning came back onto the table. Aditya asked, "Suppose the phrase 'server access' were literally true—that is, suppose you had independent administrative control. What would happen to the available permission list?"

Shashank answered, "A contradiction would arise. Either the permission list would be incomplete or false, or my statement would be exaggerated. At present the permission list, the meeting note, and the actual limited work fit one another. So the literal meaning of my boast is the heavier assumption."

"And suppose you were only a passive observer?"

"That breaks too, because there are records of translation uploads and linguistic comments."

"Then?"

"The middle proposition: I was a limited linguistic user doing real work, but there is as yet no evidence of independent administrative or economic control."

Aditya wrote: "Reasoning = test the necessary consequences of two extreme assumptions against the available facts."

Then came a page concerning payments. Travel expenses, accommodation, and linguistic-service fees were listed under separate headings. Beside one entry were the words "special assistance". Shashank's name was not clearly shown.

Aditya asked, "Is this an additional payment to you?"

"I cannot say from the heading alone."

"The timing matches your journey."

"Matching time is a reason to investigate. It is not identification."

"If later bank records match it to your account?"

"Then I will accept that. But whether it was a service fee or an unlawful benefit would still remain a separate question."

Aditya nodded. "Correct."

In the evening Mrinal was called for a limited statement. He was shown Shashank's old message about "special access". After reading it, Mrinal said, "At that time I tried to stop him."

"Why?" Aditya asked.

"Not because he was going abroad. Because he was intoxicated by the word 'special'. He believed that people who invited him inside were making him one of their own."

Shashank said, "You were right."

Mrinal replied directly, "Being right and being able to stop you are two different things."

"You could not stop me."

"Because you were in no condition to listen to anyone telling you to stop."

At that sentence, the banquet applause, the glass of Macao, the computer screen, the guest account—all flashed together inside Shashank. He was talented; that was not false. His language truly opened doors between people. His error was that he mistook an opened door for ownership of the house.

Aditya asked Mrinal, "Did you know the actual limits of his system access?"

"No. He used to say 'server access', 'inside team', 'India language is in my hands'. I never technically verified any of that."

"Did you believe him?"

Mrinal looked towards Shashank. "Some of it. Some of it I understood was his boasting. But it was not always easy to separate which sentence was fact and which was boast."

Aditya said, "That is why old private messages may be useful context, but they are not by themselves a complete account of truth."

Aditya then showed a public photograph—Shashank, Li Wenchao, and two other guests at the entrance of the Macao building. An old news clipping had captioned it: "Confidential Server Meeting." Shashank said, "The photograph establishes the meeting; it does not establish the full meaning of the phrase 'confidential server meeting'." Aditya asked, "Then is the caption false?" Shashank answered, "The meeting was closed and a system was shown—those two facts give the caption some basis. But if 'server meeting' is taken to mean administrative control, that is not supported by the records."

Mrinal said, "Earlier you would have been delighted by a caption like that." Shashank looked at him. "Yes. Because it made me look bigger. Today the problem is not that the world sees me as small; the problem is that I myself once wrote my size larger than the evidence allowed." Aditya wrote beside the sentence: "Admitted exaggeration: context for evaluating statements." Then he clarified: "This admission does not by itself make every other allegation true; but it increases the need to compare your old self-descriptions against independent records."

The final summary of the day was read aloud—foreign travel established; Shashank's presence at the Macao meeting established; limited guest access and linguistic work supported by the available records; independent administrative/publication/economic control not supported at present by the available permission list; Shashank's old messages contained claims of a broader role, some of which he admitted were exaggerated; greed and the desire for prestige were context for his statements, not independent proof of a specific crime.

Shashank said, "Add one line—I knowingly presented limited access in a broader form because I thought it would increase both my prestige and my work."

Aditya asked, "Are you certain about 'knowingly'?"

Shashank lowered his eyes. "Yes. At least in these messages."

"It will be recorded."

Outside, Mrinal asked, "So, a god now?"

Shashank smiled, though the smile was tired. "A god with a guest account."

Mrinal too laughed, very softly. "Remember that sentence."

Shashank said, "I will—because there is truth in the joke."

That night he wrote in his notebook:

"Foreign travel ≠ crime."

"Macao meeting ≠ operation of a broader network automatically."

"Guest access ≠ independent administrative control."

"Linguistic upload = real work; publication rights are separate."

"Saying 'server access' = a claim testable against the recorded permission list."

"Boasting = a question about the reliability of a statement; not independent proof of actual authority."

"Greed = desire for prestige, work, and money; specific unlawful action is a separate evidentiary question."

"Linguistic talent = real power; not institutional authority."

“Reasoning = accept an assumption and examine its necessary consequences; if the consequences collide with the record, reduce the assumption.”

He stopped while writing the final line: “I had the art of opening doors; how often I assumed that the house inside was mine as well.”

He closed the notebook. But the next question would no longer stop at the boundary of language and access. Raghav Bhasin’s name also appeared in some Macao meetings, and some communications lay in the shadow of legal advice. The investigation now had to test where the cover of confidential legal consultation ended, and where actual participation began—if it had begun at all.

CHAPTER 69

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 4

In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today only three classes of material will be examined: the external timeline of legal consultation, business messages circulated separately, and your translated summaries. Where a claim of legal privilege still stands, the substance will not be opened without the court’s permission.”

Shashank sat for a long time with the mobile phone in his hand after reading the message. That night he had written—where does the cover of confidential legal advice end, and where does actual participation begin? Today the same question was drawing him into his own words.

Raghav Bhasin was present at the office. Before him was not a thick file but a thin list—date, sender, recipient, general subject category, and a mark indicating which communication was claimed to be privileged.

Raghav said, “Let me make this clear again. Confidentiality of legal advice is not a shield for crime. But neither is it proper to expose confidential advice merely for the convenience of an investigation. First we must determine which communications were truly legal advice and which were business activity.”

Aditya replied, “That boundary is the purpose of today’s session. The mere appearance of a lawyer’s name in a copy does not make every message privileged; nor does seeing a lawyer’s name establish participation in a crime.”

Shashank’s fear increased slightly. He himself had often been the linguistic bridge between those two boundaries.

The first record on the table concerned the arrangements for the birthday banquet. The artist team associated with a well-known singing programme, the event vendor, the foreign guest side, and legal review—four separate categories of communication appeared on the same day’s timeline.

Aditya asked, “Did you read the artist team’s contract?”

“Not in full. Some linguistic portions, the stage introduction, and service descriptions relating to the foreign guests.”

“Raghav?”

Raghav said, “The legal questions sent to me had a different scope. Commercial decisions about the artist’s performance, fee, or stage management were not mine.”

Aditya looked at Shashank. “At that time you wrote a message: ‘The lawyer side has cleared it; the programme is safe.’ Is that yours?”

The moment Shashank saw the line, his shoulders lowered slightly. “Yes. From both the style and my memory, it appears to be mine.”

“What did ‘cleared’ mean?”

“At the time I compressed a complex caution into a short sentence.”

“What was the caution?”

Raghav raised a hand. “If that concerns the substance of the original confidential advice, do not go inside it.”

Aditya nodded. “Correct. Not the original advice. Tell us only this—was Shashank’s statement ‘everything is clear’ your official conclusion?”

Raghav said firmly, “No. At least in the available record, no such broad approval appears in my name.”

Shashank’s throat went dry. He remembered the lights of the banquet—the artist team arriving on time, the foreign guests remaining pleased, Li Wenchao’s people praising his efficiency. That night, making obstacles look smaller had seemed to him a mark of competence.

Aditya asked, “Did you knowingly shorten the sentence?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“So that the programme would not stop. So people would find me useful. And perhaps—” He stopped. “—I believed that announcing a conclusion was more impressive than explaining legal complexity.”

“A conclusion the lawyer had not given?”

“Not in that breadth. My sentence was more definite.”

Silence spread through the room.

Raghav said slowly, “There is linguistic responsibility here. But that does not establish that the translator was the legal decision-maker, or that the lawyer accepted every meaning contained in his compressed sentence.”

Aditya said, “Nor does it establish that the lawyer’s caution was followed. That must be examined through separate business records.”

Then Navya-Nyaya reasoning came onto the table.

Aditya asked, “Suppose we assume that every message containing a lawyer’s name is privileged. What follows?”

Shashank replied, “Then business and event matters such as the artist’s arrival time, food list, guest transport, and service payments would become confidential merely because a lawyer’s name was attached. That does not fit the nature of their purpose.”

“And suppose the opposite—that wherever the lawyer appears in a communication, he is a participant in every activity mentioned there.”

“Then giving a caution about risk would itself become participation. Advising compliance with law would become evidence of crime. That is also incoherent.”

Aditya said, “Reasoning breaks both extreme assumptions. Classification must depend on purpose, subject matter, and role.”

Shashank remembered an old lesson from Juliana—the meaning of a word is not created by every word attached to it, but by the type of relationship among them. Perhaps legal boundaries worked in the same way.

The second record was the external timeline of a Macao meeting. There was one legal consultation, a business meeting half an hour later, then a linguistic summary, and then a separate discussion concerning the payment side.

Aditya asked, “Same day?”

“Yes.”

“Same purpose?”

Shashank said, “That cannot be assumed. Temporal proximity raises a question of relationship; it does not establish unity of purpose.”

“Was Raghav in the business meeting?”

Raghav replied, “For some of the opening portion. But look to the record for the limit of my presence. I will not make my memory the final proof.”

Aditya placed the attendance list on the table. Times were recorded beside some names. Raghav’s name appeared through the opening section. It did not appear for the later payment session.

Shashank looked at the page. The direction of his fear changed. Earlier he had thought—Raghav was present, therefore everything was safe. Now he understood that he himself had written sentences that erased the limits of Raghav’s presence.

An old group message was produced: “The legal side is with us. Move ahead.”

Aditya asked, “Whose is this?”

On the forensic copy, the sender name was linked to Shashank’s old account.

Shashank closed his eyes. “Mine.”

“What did you mean by ‘the legal side is with us?’”

“That people from the legal side were in the meeting and questions were being reviewed.”

“Move ahead?”

“A signal to the business people to continue the work.”

“Did Raghav give such an instruction?”

“I do not now remember those words as his. They do not appear in the available external record either.”

Raghav’s face hardened, though his voice remained controlled. “You turned my presence into your instruction.”

Shashank’s fear became shame. “Yes. I can see that now.”

“Then was I participating in a crime?”

Shashank answered immediately, “No. Not from this message. It is my statement. Your actual instructions require separate evidence.”

Raghav remained silent for a few moments. “That is the correct answer.”

Aditya wrote in the margin: “Statement of translator/liaison ≠ statement of lawyer automatically.”

Then only the headings of the economic records were opened. Event-service fees, expenses relating to foreign guests, one third-party payment, and a separate entry referring to a digital asset. Amounts and operational details were not yet the subject.

An officer for the government side, present as an observer, asked, “If the payment structure changed immediately after legal advice, is an inference of participation not natural?”

Aditya countered, “How long is ‘immediately after?’”

"The same day."

"And how many business decisions occurred in between?"

The officer looked at the list. "Three."

"Then would it be proper to choose an author or cause merely from temporal proximity?"

The officer said, "No. An additional link is required."

Shashank saw another form of reasoning within the question. If Raghav's legal review had caused the change in payment structure, some trace of that should appear in the instruction for the change, the related reply, or the chain of decision-making. Without such a trace, the coincidence of timing alone did not establish causation.

Raghav said, "And if the legal advice identified a risk, and afterward the business side changed something in its own way, that does not turn the advice into an instrument of crime. But if what was called 'legal advice' actually concealed business instructions, privilege cannot automatically protect it. The boundary depends on content and purpose."

Aditya said, "That is why courts classify; they do not worship persons."

The phrase "worship persons" disturbed the old illusion of gods from the banquet inside Shashank. That night language had made him feel like a god; later he kept adding proximity to famous people, the presence of a lawyer, and the praise of foreign businessmen to his own halo.

Aditya suddenly asked, "What are you afraid of?"

Shashank had not expected the question. "That because of my sentences, the shadow of guilt may have fallen on innocent people."

"Only Raghav?"

"Raghav, the artist, Mrinal—everyone whose closeness made me look bigger."

"And your own fear?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "That if I admit this, people will say—look, now he is spilling everything."

"Then what will you do?"

"Say what is mine. Not what is not mine."

For the first time, Raghav's expression softened slightly. "If fear changes the boundary, it will be the same old error again."

In the afternoon, the draft statement was read out: Shashank admitted that on some occasions he had presented the meaning of legal presence more broadly than reality; phrases such as "the legal side is with us" were his own compressed or exaggerated statements; the available material alone did not establish Raghav Bhasin's alleged economic or criminal participation; claims of privilege remained separately testable according to the nature of each communication; and a business activity did not become privileged merely because a lawyer's name was attached to it.

Shashank said, "Add one line—I also wrote such sentences in order to enlarge my own importance."

Aditya asked, "Certain?"

"Yes. After seeing the messages from after the banquet, I cannot step back from that."

"It will be recorded."

Before the session ended, Aditya showed only the heading of the next file—payment reservations from the lower commissioner, a summary from the higher tax-intelligence branch, and beside them two words: "Hawala?" "Digital asset?"

Shashank's stomach tightened again.

Aditya said, "Look at the question marks. These are not conclusions."

"But the question marks will not survive in the media," Shashank said.

"I do not write records for the media."

Raghav added, "And legal confidentiality exists neither to turn that question mark into a full stop nor to erase it."

Mrinal was waiting outside. Shashank said to him, "Today I understood—I used to wear people's names like armour."

"Armour?"

"A famous artist, a lawyer, a foreign businessman, a friend. Whoever stood near me, their prestige made me look larger."

Mrinal asked, "And when the armour broke?"

"I became afraid that all the blows would fall on them."

"And now?"

"My own wounds on my own body."

Mrinal said, "And your own crime?"

“Only what is proved.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

“Legal privilege ≠ shield for crime.”

“Presence of a lawyer ≠ participation in crime.”

“Lawyer’s name in a copy ≠ every communication privileged.”

“Translator’s ‘legal approval received’ ≠ lawyer’s official statement automatically.”

“Legal and business communications on the same day ≠ same purpose.”

“Temporal proximity ≠ causation established.”

“Breaking the limits of confidential material ≠ seeking truth; hiding business activity by calling it confidential ≠ law.”

“Reasoning = examine the necessary consequences of both extreme assumptions; reduce the assumption that erases real categories.”

“Fear = not a reason to change the boundary of one’s statement.”

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: “I sometimes turned a lawyer’s caution into a seal of my own prestige; now it is time to break the seal and read the original letters.”

He closed the notebook. He remembered the next file—the lower commissionerate’s reservation, the tax-intelligence branch’s separate summary, and two question marks: hawala? digital asset?

The banquet’s illusion of gods had now crossed the shadow of law and was moving towards the shadow of money.

CHAPTER 70

HAWALA AND BITCOIN

When Shashank reached Aditya Mishra's room in the morning, he saw three slips of different colours on the table. The first was a copy of the lower commissioner's original reservation note, the second a condensed summary from the higher tax-intelligence branch, the third a reconciliation sheet relating to payments. Beside the first slip the two question marks still remained—"Hawala?" "Digital asset?"

Aditya began, "Today we will not turn question marks into full stops. The words you see here indicate directions of inquiry; they are not proved offences."

The fear from the previous night tightened again inside Shashank. He remembered the headlines—how quickly question marks disappeared once they left the record and entered the media.

The officer from the lower commissioner's office was present as well. He was the same officer who had earlier recorded that verification of beneficial ownership and the ultimate recipient remained pending. A copy of the old dispatch receipt lay before him.

The officer said, "I did not write those two words as accusations. Some payment flows did not fit the ordinary sequence of invoices, and one entry appeared to contain a reference connected with a digital asset. That was the only reason I asked for verification."

Aditya asked, "What was the basis for writing 'Hawala?'"

"Some money-related statements used language suggesting adjustment outside the formal banking route. But the account-holder, the person giving instructions, the actual beneficiary, cash or equivalent exchange—none of that had been established. Hence the question mark."

"And 'digital asset?'"

"One short line contained what looked like an identifier resembling a digital address. Its ownership, control, or transaction purpose had not been verified."

Shashank listened silently. He understood: names can be frightening; the work of evidence begins with a name, it does not end there.

Aditya opened the higher branch's summary. It discussed a commercial basis for the payments, but the two question marks from the lower slip were absent. At the end it said: "Direct tax loss not established at present; the matter may be placed at low priority."

Aditya looked at Shashank. "The difference?"

Shashank answered, "The first note keeps verification open concerning a potentially opaque payment route and the digital-asset reference. The second says that tax loss has not been established. Logically, the two are not direct contradictions, but the second does not mention the first note's questions."

"Does that establish a compromise?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because questions may disappear for many reasons—summary, limits of jurisdiction, prioritisation, unavailable additional material, or deliberate softening. Choosing the last explanation requires an independent link."

Aditya said, "Apply reasoning."

Shashank turned the page. "If we assume that the higher branch deliberately suppressed the matter, certain consequences should be expected—instructional communications, some identifiable benefit, a clear sequence showing unnecessary removal of the attachment, or conduct that cannot be explained by ordinary summarisation. If none of those appear, the 'compromise' assumption becomes too heavy. But if we assume it was merely routine summarisation, then we must still explain why the important verification questions in the first note disappeared altogether. Both assumptions demand consequences."

The lower officer said in a slightly harder voice, "That was my only problem. Questions were asked, and then the questions were no longer on the paper."

Shashank looked at his face. There was more in that hardness than administrative anger—the mark of broken trust.

In the second stage, the payment reconciliation was opened. The banquet's event vendor, a third-party service entity, a payment gateway, and a later consolidated account—four separate headings. Beside some entries was "reimbursement", beside others "service", and in one place "external adjustment:"

Aditya said, "Do not go into the operational meaning of the term. Only the evidentiary boundary."

Shashank nodded. "External adjustment? written in the record ≠ a criminal money route outside the formal records has been established. It says only that the recorder found the ordinary classification insufficient."

"And the payment gateway?"

"Use of a payment gateway ≠ the actual owner of the account or the ultimate beneficiary has been established."

"The digital address?"

"Seeing a digital address ≠ its ownership, control, source, or purpose has been established."

Aditya did not close the page. "And if banquet expenses, a service reimbursement, and a digital entry appear on the same date?"

"Then a relationship is worth investigating. But temporal proximity does not automatically create a single chain of funds."

The lower officer said, "That is the limitation I had written."

Aditya read his original note: "No consolidated conclusion from temporal similarity alone; actual beneficiary, delivery of services, instructions, and reason for the funds to be verified separately."

A shiver passed through Shashank. The structure of the sentence felt familiar.

"What is it?" Aditya asked.

"I seem to remember once making a short Chinese summary of a caution like this."

"When?"

"Some time after the banquet. Possibly after tax-related questions had arisen."

"For whom?"

Shashank paused. "In a linguistic message group on Li's side. But I cannot be certain without the full context."

Aditya took out a page from an old digital copy. "That is why I called you."

The line clearly carried Shashank's style: "The tax side is not saying direct loss at present; some payment questions remain, but there is no immediate crisis."

The moment he read it, Shashank's face grew hot.

Aditya asked, "Did you write this?"

"Yes. It seems so—yes."

"Source?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "My memory is unclear whether I had an official copy of the higher summary at that time. Possibly I made the short summary from someone's oral statement, discussion in a meeting, and a few fragments together."

"Whose words were 'no immediate crisis'?"

"Mine."

"Were they in the original reservation?"

"No."

Silence spread through the room. The lower officer kept looking at Shashank. His gaze held not accusation, but hurt.

He asked quietly, "Did you soften my questions?"

Shashank's throat dried. "If this line belongs to the same context, then yes—I retained 'questions remain', but I reduced the weight of the risk."

"Why?"

Shashank did not answer at once. Before him flashed the banquet stage, the window in Macao, photographs with famous people, the praise of foreign businessmen—all at once. "Because I liked people to think of me as someone who made difficult things simple. And in simplifying, I sometimes reduced the caution as well. I was greedy to preserve my usefulness."

The lower officer's face remained hard. "I was writing notes to preserve the questions. You were making the questions smaller."

The sentence entered Shashank like betrayal. But he immediately understood—betrayal is not only something another person does; reducing the edge of someone's caution for one's own convenience can also damage trust.

Aditya intervened. "Feeling is separate from conclusion. Shashank's softened summary may be established; that does not automatically establish that the higher tax-intelligence branch entered into a compromise."

The officer said, "I am not saying that now either. But I have the right to know whether my reservation reached the people it was meant to reach."

“And that will be investigated,” Aditya said.

In the third stage, the transmission chain was laid out. The lower note had reached the higher level; there was a receipt mark. One attachment was absent from the later file. But it was not clear when the attachment had become separated—after dispatch, during copying, or at the time of archiving.

Aditya asked, “Reasoning?”

Shashank said, “If it was removed deliberately, one would expect some trace of the decision to remove it. If it was only a record-compilation error, similar missing attachments may appear in other files. Comparison is needed.”

“And if only this one sensitive attachment is missing?”

“Then suspicion becomes stronger; but the person or the purpose is still not established.”

Aditya wrote: “Stronger suspicion ≠ proved compromise.”

In the afternoon Raghav Bhasin came in for a short while. The substance of legal advice was not opened; there was only a question about the timeline. Raghav said, “‘Tax loss not established’ may be a separate legal or accounting conclusion. Questions about the lawfulness of payments, beneficial ownership, or other offences do not automatically disappear with it.”

Shashank looked at him. “Then what I wrote—‘no immediate crisis’—was broader?”

Raghav said, “If the original material narrowed only one tax question, then yes. You may have merged different categories of risk into one sentence.”

“Does that mean participation in a crime?”

Before answering, Raghav looked at Aditya. “It raises a question of linguistic responsibility. Criminal purpose, instruction, or benefit require separate evidence.”

Shashank heard the same boundary again, but today it did not feel like a defence; it stung. Because even if no crime were proved, his language could still have reduced someone else’s caution.

In the evening session, Aditya wrote two possibilities on a sheet. First: “Summary / change of priority.” Second: “Improper influence / compromise.”

“What supports each?”

Shashank said, “For the first—direct tax loss had not been established; the other branch may have had a narrower remit; a short summary need not contain every investigative question. For the second—an important reservation disappeared; an attachment is absent; the risk reached the commercial side in a softened form; the timeline raises questions.”

“And against each?”

“Against the first—we need an explanation for why only the sensitive verification line was omitted. Against the second—there is still no independent evidence of anyone’s benefit, instruction, communication, or direct intervention.”

Aditya nodded. “This is where reasoning is useful. Before choosing an accusation, look for its necessary consequences.”

When Mrinal arrived in the evening, Shashank was unusually quiet. The two walked along the roadside outside.

Mrinal asked, “What did you find?”

“Question marks.”

“Question marks have made you this quiet?”

“Because I once made question marks smaller.”

Mrinal looked at him.

Shashank said, “An officer wrote a caution. I told other people—there is no immediate crisis. I thought I was explaining things. Perhaps I was reducing the edge of his work.”

“Knowingly?”

“I chose the words knowingly. Did I intend to suppress anyone’s investigation? That is not established. But the greed to preserve my work and the desire to appear useful—those were there.”

Mrinal said, “Are you looking for betrayal only in the higher branch?”

Shashank stopped. The question was simple; the answer was hard. “No.”

“Then?”

“My language too sometimes broke trust.”

Mrinal said, “That admission will not prove someone else’s compromise.”

“I know.”

“And taking someone else’s unproved guilt onto your own head will not wash away this error.”

Shashank smiled faintly. “You are beginning to sound like that judge.”

“No. I only want you to give up the greed to become either hero or villain.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

“‘Hawala?’ = investigative question; hawala not established.”

“Digital address = ownership/control not established.”

“Payment gateway = not the ultimate beneficiary.”

“Question omitted = compromise not established; the reason for omission is worth investigating.”

“Receipt mark = not proof of later use.”

“Attachment absent = not automatically deliberately removed.”

“Tax loss not established = other economic/criminal questions not extinguished.”

“Translator’s ‘no immediate crisis’ = not the institution’s official conclusion.”

“Betrayal = feeling; improper influence = evidentiary conclusion.”

“Reasoning = accept an assumption and look for its necessary consequences; if the consequences are absent, reduce the assumption, not erase the question.”

He paused for a long time while writing the final line: “Whether someone suppressed the questions, I do not yet know; but I did sometimes lower the volume of a question.”

He closed the notebook. The next day, under the court’s direction, some sensitive portions would remain sealed. Aditya had made it clear: “If incomplete investigative questions reach outside, their meaning may be altered again.”

Shashank stood before the window. He was afraid that the question marks on the paper would once again become full stops in the news. The glitter of the banquet, the word hawala, the name bitcoin, and the shadow of the court could combine into a story half of which still existed in the record only as questions.

CHAPTER 71

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 6

In the morning Shashank's mobile phone filled all at once with messages. One friend was sending questions, an old acquaintance silent sympathy, and several unfamiliar numbers the same news link. The moment he read the headline, his chest tightened—"Indian Conduit of the Hawala-Bitcoin Banquet."

He opened the first link. An old photograph from the banquet—Shashank on the stage, electric lights behind him, and beside him an artist associated with the well-known singing programme Indian Idol. The caption read: "Hawala and digital-asset links in sealed tax inquiry; role of Indian linguistic conduit at centre of investigation."

Shashank's thumb went still. He remembered what he had written in his notebook the previous day—"Hawala? = investigative question; hawala not established." In the public headline, the question mark had disappeared.

The second link was more bitter. It placed the banquet expenses, the artist's performance, foreign guests, the Macao trip, and his old boast of "special access" together in a strip of images. No single sentence looked plainly false, yet arranged together they produced a meaning as though the banquet itself had been a celebration of crime and Shashank its Indian organiser.

He called Mrinal.

Mrinal asked only, "What was in the original sealed paper?"

"Two question marks."

"And in the news?"

"Two full stops."

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. "Then anger later. First put the original and the public version side by side."

The advice angered Shashank too. He felt his friend did not understand the heat of his humiliation. But at once he remembered the lesson he had learned before: feeling is not evidence. The humiliation was real; source and purpose were separate questions.

When he reached Aditya Mishra's office, a sealed envelope, the court's direction, and three copies of news reports were already on the table. Aditya's first sentence was stern: "Today we are not drafting a reply to the news. First, comparison."

Shashank said, "The question marks in the original have been removed."

"We will see," Aditya said. "And first we will not assume that the media obtained the sealed copy. Another source may contain the same sequence of words."

Under the court's direction, only the portion necessary for comparison with the public rendering was opened. The original line read: "Possibility of adjustment outside the formal banking route? Verification pending." The second read: "Identifier resembling a digital-asset address; ownership/control unverified."

In the news, the first had become: "Adjustment outside the formal banking route." The second: "Digital-asset link." Four cautionary elements—"possibility", "verification pending", "resembling", and "unverified"—had disappeared.

Aditya looked at Shashank. "Fact?"

"The public lines reduce the caution contained in the original."

"Leak?"

Shashank's mind was screaming yes. But he said, "There is a strong indication of textual relationship. A specific source person has not yet been established."

"Apply reasoning."

Shashank placed his thumb on the page. "If the public lines came directly from this sealed passage, the rare word order, the two subjects in the same sequence, and the matching removal of cautionary terms are explained. But if there was an intermediate summary or an oral account, the similarity could have come through that as well. So 'same line = a particular person leaked it' is too heavy an assumption."

Aditya wrote: "Possible textual lineage; specific source requires independent evidence."

Beside the banquet photograph in the third news copy were the words: "Hawala-Bitcoin link in confidential tax note; Shashank Jha, special coordinator of the banquet."

Shashank's face reddened. He had never seen the phrase "special coordinator" in any official paper.

Aditya asked, "Were you a special linguistic guest at the banquet?"

"Yes."

"Did you give introductions from the stage?"

"Yes."

"Did you translate some sentences relating to the artist?"

"Yes."

"Then 'special coordinator'?"

"A conclusion. Broader than the role shown in the available record."

"False allegation?"

Shashank paused. "If 'coordinator' means the decision-maker for the event contract, payments, artist team, or guest arrangements, no such role is established by the available record. In that sense the allegation is unsupported. But it would be false for me to deny that I was on the stage and provided linguistic services."

A faint sign of approval appeared in Aditya's eyes. "That distinction is difficult in the midst of humiliation."

"Difficult?" Shashank's voice rose. "People are sending the picture all the way to the village. Someone is asking whether I operated bitcoin. Someone else is adding the artist's name. A person I remember only introducing for a song is now being placed in the shadow of crime."

Aditya remained calm. "That is why the boundaries must be written. The artist's stage appearance ≠ participation in an economic network. A public photograph ≠ ownership of a contract. A photograph with you ≠ instruction concerning funds."

Shashank's anger loosened slightly, though the humiliation did not. He suddenly remembered the night when, after coming down from the stage, he had written to Mrinal: "Everyone is looking for me." Today the same photograph made him look like someone who, because he was among everyone, must also have been inside everything.

In the afternoon a new record was shown—a copy of an internal news draft preserved before publication. Its earlier headline had been: "Name of Linguistic Contact in Payment Inquiry into Lavish Banquet." In the later version, "linguistic contact" had become "Indian conduit".

Shashank asked, "Did someone make that change deliberately to defame me?"

Aditya said, "We cannot say yet. Editorial exaggeration, an incomplete source, competitive pressure, or deliberate sensationalism—there are several possibilities. Purpose requires communications, instructions, or other evidence."

"But the result?"

"The result may be humiliating. Purpose is a separate question."

Shashank leaned back in the chair. The distinction was just, but unbearable to the mind. It seemed to him that people were ruining his life by altering words, yet he could not even complete his anger until their purpose was known.

Then Aditya showed an early draft of the old sealed summary. It contained the lower commissioner's line: "No consolidated conclusion from temporal similarity alone." The public report contained the reverse formulation: "Payments, banquet expenses, and digital-asset entries at the same time indicate one network."

Aditya asked, "Reasoning?"

Shashank answered at once. "If same time = same network, then without testing we eliminate the possibilities of independent service payments, lawful banquet expenses, a separate digital entry, and unrelated people. That is too heavy an assumption. But temporal similarity is not wholly irrelevant either; it gives a reason to investigate a relationship."

"Correct. The news conclusion may be an investigative hypothesis; it is not an established fact."

Another line wounded Shashank more deeply: "The translator used his multilingual access to conceal the payment chain."

He almost laughed, but the laugh was bitter. "I did soften some risks. That is admitted. But what supports 'concealed the payment chain'?"

Aditya read from the list: "Your softened summaries, linguistic service, translation of some payment headings, and your presence at the banquet and in Macao."

"That is all?"

"At present, that is all that directly appears in support of the public allegation. Economic control or a knowing instruction to conceal a payment route requires separate evidence."

Shashank said slowly, "Then my real error is giving fuel to a false allegation."

“Yes. But that neither erases the error nor makes the false part true.”

Aditya then placed his thumb on the artist’s photograph in the news strip. “Do I have any economic or criminal material concerning this person in the record?”

Shashank answered at once, “No. At least not in anything shown to me. The person came for a stage performance. Their name appears with mine in one photograph; that is all.”

“Then, while answering your own humiliation, would it be proper to drag that person into the story as well?”

Shashank felt ashamed. On reading the first headline that morning, he had thought: let everyone know who else had been on the stage. Now he understood that such a response would repeat exactly the error of which he accused the media—turning proximity into participation.

He said, “No. Standing together in a photograph $\neq$ economic relationship. If the artist’s name is being attached to mine only for sensation, I will not taint that person in the name of defending myself.”

Aditya wrote: “Unrelated attendee—no adverse inference.” Then he said, “Reasoning is not only for your own defence. It also works against drawing someone into the circle of accusation when no allegation is supported against them.”

A strange change came over Shashank. Years earlier, he had treated proximity to famous people as an extension of his own prestige. For the first time he understood: proximity gives no right to borrow another person’s reputation, and in crisis it gives even less right to turn that proximity into shared guilt.

On a blank page of his notebook he immediately wrote one sentence: “It is also unjust to drag into my story of humiliation a name that is not in the evidence.”

In the evening a brief direction came from the court. Because limited portions of the sealed material had public parallels, the chain of sources was to be preserved; no party was to present the public allegations as judicial findings; and at the next hearing there would be cross-examination on the original text, the public rendering, and the boundaries of Shashank’s admitted linguistic distortion.

Shashank read the direction and remained silent for a while. “Court again.”

Aditya said, “This time the question is not only who wrote what. It is also where your own error ends and the external allegation begins.”

Outside, members of the media were waiting. A young man asked, “Are you the Indian conduit of the hawala-bitcoin banquet?”

The fire of humiliation rose inside Shashank. He wanted to say—everything is false. But the word “everything” stopped him. He said, “I was a linguistic guest and stage assistant at the banquet. I did present some economic and risk-related terms in softened language—that is an error I have admitted. But there is no judicial finding that I operated hawala, controlled digital assets, or economically owned the banquet.”

The young man asked again, “So the news is false?”

Shashank said, “Where a question mark has been removed and guilt made certain, the evidence must be examined. Not all facts are the same colour.”

He moved on. Voices continued behind him, but this time he did not stop.

Mrinal met him by the roadside. He had two small cups of tea in his hands. Shashank took one.

Mrinal asked, “Did you say everything was false?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because not everything is false. I was there. I softened words. I boasted. But in the anger of humiliation, it would be equally wrong to admit or deny what I did not do.”

Mrinal said, “This time you applied reasoning to yourself.”

Shashank smiled faintly. “If I assume ‘everything is false’, my admitted errors disappear. If I assume ‘everything is true’, an unproved economic role becomes established. Both assumptions collide with the record.”

“And the humiliation?”

Shashank watched the steam rising from the cup. “Humiliation is not a category of evidence. But the body does not understand reasoning. It burns.”

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Sealed question mark $\neq$ public full stop.”

“Textual similarity = reason to investigate the source chain; specific leaker not established.”

“Banquet photograph $\neq$ economic ownership.”

“Performance by a famous artist $\neq$ economic/criminal participation.”

“Linguistic contact $\neq$ Indian conduit automatically.”

“Temporal similarity = reason to investigate a relationship; not proof of one chain of funds.”

“Softened translation = admitted moral error; operation of hawala/digital assets is a separate evidentiary question.”

“News exaggeration ≠ purpose to defame automatically established.”

“Humiliation = real experience; crime = evidentiary conclusion.”

“Reasoning = take both extreme assumptions to their necessary consequences and test them—neither ‘everything false’ nor ‘everything true’.”

His hand stopped as he wrote the final line: “When a question mark is erased, the court must have the courage to put it back on the paper.”

He closed the notebook. At the next hearing, the original sealed line, the public headline, the banquet photograph, and his own admitted linguistic error would all be placed in the same courtroom. Shashank knew that there he would have to do more than answer humiliation; he would also have to define the boundaries of his atonement.

CHAPTER 72

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 7

For the first time that day in the courtroom, the photograph from the banquet was not projected on a screen but placed among the papers. On one side lay the sealed original passage; on the other, the public headline; in a third pile were Shashank's old bilingual summaries, stage messages, and translations of several payment-related headings. At the outset the judge made it clear: "The scope of this hearing is the meaning of the evidence and the limits of the statements. No final determination of anyone's guilt or innocence will be made today."

Shashank sat beside the witness enclosure. It seemed to him that the glitter, shame, and greed of the past several years had become three piles of paper before him. On the night of the banquet he had mistaken his voice for power; on the day the news broke he had wanted to mistake his humiliation for proof of truth. Today the court was the place where a line had to be drawn between both illusions.

Government counsel lifted the first page. "Were you a special linguistic guest at the banquet?"

"Yes."

"Did you give stage introductions?"

"Yes."

"Did you facilitate communication with foreign guests?"

"Yes, within linguistic limits."

"Did you travel to Macao?"

"Yes."

"Did you translate some payment-related headings?"

"Yes."

"Did you knowingly soften some risk-related terms?"

Shashank's throat dried slightly. "Yes. I have already admitted that."

Counsel paused. "Then why should the court not conclude that you used language as an active Indian conduit between the banquet, Macao, and the payment chain?"

Shashank began to answer, then stopped the old reflex of self-defence rising inside him. He said, "Because every fact you have listed may be true, but 'active economic conduit' is not their necessary conclusion. My linguistic role was real. My exaggeration was real. Softening some words was also a real moral error. But control of accounts, instructions over funds, actual beneficial ownership, or operation of hawala or digital assets require separate evidence."

Government counsel said, "You are dividing everything again. Criminal arrangements do not always leave written letters of authority."

"Correct," Shashank said. "That is why I am not claiming innocence merely because there is no written authority. But one cannot say, 'written authority is unnecessary', and then assign a person an unlimited role. Reasoning must ask what consequences we would expect if the broader role were true."

"What consequences?"

"For example, if I were the actual operator of the payment chain, it would be natural to expect some independent link in the available record—account instructions issued by me, distribution of benefits, payment decisions, indications of control, or something of that kind. The absence of such a link does not automatically prove innocence, but it weakens the reasoning that tries to establish operation from linguistic presence alone."

Counsel immediately showed the old messages: "Brother, the stage is mine." A second: "There will be special access." A third: "The lawyer side has cleared it." "Are all these yours?"

"Yes."

"False?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "The first two contain boasting and ambition. 'The stage is mine' was not literally true; for a while I was a linguistic voice there. I later understood that 'special access' meant limited guest access. The third sentence—'the lawyer side has cleared it'—is an example of improperly compressing a legal caution. I do not diminish my responsibility for any of the three."

"Then deceit?"

The courtroom fell silent. Shashank did not look towards Mrinal. "Where I knew the original caution was severe and, out of greed to preserve my usefulness, prestige, or work, reduced its edge, it would not be right to call

that merely a stylistic error. It was moral deceit. But admitting that does not automatically establish the purpose of an economic conspiracy.”

Government counsel said, “You are choosing the size of your own offence.”

Shashank’s face flushed, but his voice remained controlled. “No. I want the evidence to choose the size. Atonement gives me no right to hide a proved error of my own; but atonement also gives me no right to place an unproved guilt upon my own head.”

The judge stopped writing. “Let that sentence remain clear on the record.”

Government counsel now lifted the sealed line: “Possibility of adjustment outside the formal banking route? Verification pending.” Then the public headline: “Hawala-Bitcoin Link.” “Do you accept that there is a relationship between the original material and the public language?”

“Yes. There is a strong indication of textual relationship.”

“Then the sealed material went outside?”

“It is worth investigating whether the same information, in some form, reached outside. But whether this very copy went out directly, through whose hands, and at what time—those are independent questions.”

“Why so much caution? The same unusual sequence of words appears in both.”

Shashank said, “That is precisely where reasoning is needed. If we assume that the public text could have come only from the sealed original, we erase without testing the possibilities of an intermediate summary, oral account, earlier draft, or another similar source. If the record shows that such alternatives existed, an additional link is needed to choose a particular source.”

Aditya Mishra was called to give evidence. Government counsel asked, “Does your investigation show textual lineage?”

Aditya said, “There is sufficient similarity to investigate the source chain. No specific leaker has yet been established.”

“Does this caution not weaken your investigation?”

“The work of an investigation is not to choose the heaviest story,” Aditya said. “If we choose a person first, every later record begins to look like material for proving that choice. We have to do the reverse—go only as far as the records take us.”

Defence counsel rose. His first question was not to Shashank but to Aditya: “Is there any adverse economic material concerning the artist shown in the banquet photograph published in the news?”

“Not in the material before this hearing.”

“Then standing beside Shashank on the stage?”

“A fact of presence. Not of economic participation.”

“And the foreign guests present at the banquet?”

“Each person’s role must be proved separately. A group photograph does not establish a collective crime.”

A strange shame rose inside Shashank at that answer. Years earlier, he had displayed photographs with famous people to enlarge his own importance. Now the thought that the same image might drag someone else’s name into his crisis was unbearable. His atonement was beginning not only for his words, but also for his misuse of proximity.

The defence then showed Shashank’s old linguistic summary. “Did you soften the sense of ‘high risk’ into something like ‘special service?’”

“In some contexts, yes.”

“Are you hiding that from the court?”

“No.”

“Then if the news says you concealed the payment chain, is that true?”

“No. Not from this admission alone. Softening the language of risk and knowingly concealing the route of money are two different acts. I admit the first. The second requires evidence.”

“And if evidence is found one day?”

For the first time Shashank looked directly at the judge. “Then I will answer for whatever is proved. Truth is not subordinate to my convenience.”

Silence spread through the courtroom again. Mrinal sat in the back row. There was neither relief nor fear on his face—only gravity.

Government counsel resumed. “Your service fee falls around the same time as the event-related expenditure. Does that not establish a relationship?”

Shashank said, “It may establish one level of relationship—I provided a service and received payment. But if we assume ‘service fee = economic ownership of the event’, every independent vendor becomes an owner.

Reasoning shows that consequence to be incoherent. Even so, the service fee is not irrelevant; its source and purpose should be examined.”

“Access in Macao?”

“Limited access. If I were the actual owner of the system, why would there be guest access and a shared demonstration? A broader authority would require separate indicators.”

“Mule accounts?”

“A name on a list, or money moving onward, ≠ the account-holder knowingly served as a front. We need links concerning instructions, knowledge, beneficiary, and conduct.”

“Hawala?”

“In the sealed paper it was a question. In the public headline it became a conclusion. If the court reaches that conclusion, it will reach it through evidence.”

“Bitcoin?”

“There was an identifier resembling a digital-asset address; the record said ownership and control were unverified. To treat me as its operator from that would be a leap in reasoning.”

The judge intervened. “Let the record make clear that the witness is not answering as an expert in technical or economic operations, but only within the limits of material he saw or translated.”

The clarification brought Shashank both relief and pain. Once, he had been desperate to be called an expert. Today the court was writing down the limits of his knowledge, and it felt not humiliating but liberating.

At the end of the hearing the judge read a brief observation: “The witness has admitted linguistic softening, exaggeration of role, and improper compression of certain contexts. The legal effect of those admissions will be considered at a later stage together with the evidence. On the material presently available, no final conclusion shall yet be recorded as to economic control, alleged hawala operations, ownership of digital assets, or actual beneficial ownership of the banquet. Public similarity to sealed material is sufficient reason to investigate the source chain, but no specific source person has yet been established.”

Then the judge added: “Atonement is not a substitute for the court’s law of evidence. Admission as far as it goes; evidence as far as it goes.”

For a moment Shashank lowered his eyes. In the sentence he heard not punishment, but a boundary.

As he came out of court another question was shouted: “Did you admit deceit today?”

Shashank stopped. “I admitted that in some places I knowingly softened the force of the original risk, out of greed to preserve my usefulness and prestige. That was moral deceit. But economic operation, or alleged control of hawala or digital assets, is a separate allegation; evidence must decide it.”

Another voice came: “Then are you innocent?”

Shashank said, “Today’s hearing did not give a final answer to that question.”

He moved on. For the first time in many days, the word “innocent” felt as heavy to him as “guilty”. Both demanded the court’s final conclusion; his soul was still at the stage of accounting for smaller truths one by one.

Mrinal was waiting below the steps. They walked some distance in silence.

Mrinal asked, “You called it deceit?”

“Yes.”

“Were you not afraid?”

“Very.”

“Then?”

“Earlier I understood atonement in two extremes—either deny everything, or take everything onto my own head. Today I understood that the difficult form of atonement is to give things their correct names. What is error, call error. What is deceit, call deceit. What is allegation, call allegation. What has no proof, do not call a crime.”

Mrinal said, “This time reasoning did not operate only in court.”

Shashank smiled. “No. It operated on my own soul as well.”

That night he opened his notebook.

“Admitted linguistic softening = real moral responsibility.”

“Moral deceit ≠ economic conspiracy automatically.”

“Banquet photograph = proof of presence; not economic ownership.”

“Proximity to a famous person ≠ that person’s participation; using proximity for one’s own prestige is a separate moral question.”

“Service fee = service relationship; beneficial ownership requires separate examination.”

“Limited system access = not broad control.”

“Sealed question = not public conclusion.”

“Textual similarity = investigation of source chain; a specific person requires an independent link.”

“Reasoning = look for the necessary consequences of a hypothesis; if those consequences are absent from the record, reduce the weight of the hypothesis.”

“Atonement = make the truth neither smaller nor larger.”

As he wrote the last line, he remembered the judge’s words: “Admission as far as it goes; evidence as far as it goes.”

Closing the notebook, he looked at his mobile phone. The court had permitted a limited re-examination of old messages, drafts, and digital devices in the next stage. Shashank knew that his ambition would speak there again: old boasts, half-truths, sentences that made his role larger than it was.

This time the next test would not be the court’s question mark, but his own digital signature.

CHAPTER 73

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 8

Two days after the court's last order, a message came from Aditya Mishra in the morning: "Appear for limited re-examination. The old mobile phone, computer, and digital copies previously secured during the investigation will be compared. No new broad seizure; only the material already within the limits of the order."

Shashank stood by the window for a long time after reading the message. At the previous hearing he had admitted his linguistic deceit. Now his fear was not that some unknown crime would suddenly emerge from the devices; it was that his old ambition would still be alive in words—sentences in which he had cast a shadow two hands longer than his actual role.

When he reached the office, three objects lay sealed in separate bags on the table—his old mobile phone, a laptop, and the collection of digital copies made earlier. At the outset Aditya said, "A device being yours, an account being in your name, or a file being found here—those three facts do not lead to the same conclusion. Authorship, use, knowledge, control, and the truth of a statement will be examined separately."

Shashank tried to smile. "I remember that now."

Aditya said, "Remembering it and accepting the meaning of an old sentence are still different things."

The first comparison concerned messages from the night before the banquet through the next three days. Some were to Mrinal, some to foreign contacts, some to colleagues. One line said: "Tomorrow the stage will not run without me." Another: "The payment side too will be clarified through me." A third: "The lawyer side is through me."

Aditya read all three together. "Were these sent from your account?"

Shashank replied, "The available copy says so. I was using that account at the time. I have no basis for denying authorship."

"Then all three were true?"

Old shame rose again in Shashank's face. "No. Accepting authorship $\neq$ accepting the literal truth of the statement. 'The stage will not run without me' was boasting. The stage would have run without me too. By 'payment side' I meant that I was explaining the language of some payment headings; the payment decisions were not mine. By 'the lawyer side is through me' I meant Raghav's linguistic dependence on me to understand the Chinese original, not that I possessed legal authority."

Aditya wrote: "Authorship of a statement may be established; its factual truth remains independently testable."

Shashank kept looking at the line. He understood that ambition is most dangerous when it chooses not a wholly false fact but a half-truth. "Payment side" had not been entirely false—he had translated payment headings. But upon that half-truth he had built a new title for himself.

Aditya opened a second message: "The Chinese team is waiting for me." Below it was Mrinal's reply: "You are a translator, not a king."

Shashank's eyes dropped involuntarily. "That one is mine too."

"Was the Chinese team actually waiting for you?"

"In some meetings the discussion stalled without linguistic assistance, so they did wait for me. But the spirit of the sentence was that every decision depended on me. That was not true."

"Reasoning?"

Shashank thought for a few moments. "If every decision depended on me, we would expect signs of my independent decision-making in contracts, payments, system rights, distribution of benefits, or final approval. The available records do not show such broad dependence. So deriving decision-making authority from the linguistic need for me in meetings is too heavy an assumption."

Aditya nodded. "And the opposite extreme?"

"To say that I was only an inert dictionary would also be wrong. I chose words, softened some things, and people relied on my summaries. The linguistic influence was real."

The next material on the table was an old file list from the laptop. The titles included event, guests, translation, legal comment, vendor, payment summary. One file name stood out: "Birthday Expense Adjustment—Final."

Aditya asked, "What do you understand merely from seeing that name?"

Shashank said, “Only that it may be some summary concerning banquet or birthday expenses. The meaning of ‘adjustment’ depends on context. I will not call it hawala, unlawful adjustment, or anything else merely from the file name.”

“The file was on your laptop.”

“Yes.”

“Then you knew about it?”

“Presence $\neq$ knowledge automatically. Whether it was seen, opened, sent, edited, and which version it was—all of that must be separated.”

Aditya read the technical assistant’s brief report—the file had been received through a group message, a local copy had been created, and later it had been opened once. The named author was a different entity. The report contained no sign that Shashank had altered the original contents.

Aditya asked, “Now?”

Shashank drew a long breath. “Now it is proper to say that the file was received by me and opened at least once. It would be difficult to say, ‘I never saw it.’ But that does not establish authorship, truth, or authority to make payment decisions.”

“Your memory?”

“Faint. I may have seen headings relating to the banquet expenses. But I will not use weakness of memory as though it were absence of evidence.”

Aditya drew a line in the margin. “That statement is useful.”

Shashank said, “Not useful. Inconvenient.”

“Truth is often both.”

The second section contained a message thread in which, after the banquet, Shashank had written: “I am also bringing the finance-side people into the discussion.” Aditya asked, “Whom did you mean by ‘finance-side people’?”

Shashank ran a hand over his forehead. “At that time, probably people explaining the language of bills, reimbursements, and vendor payments. But ‘I am bringing them into the discussion’ is again boastful in my style. I could connect meetings; I could not make the decisions.”

“If you were connecting people, could you be called a coordinator?”

“In some contexts, a limited linguistic or meeting coordinator may be fair. But ‘operator of the economic network’ is something else. The boundary of the word must remain clear.”

At that answer Aditya began to—then stopped himself and said, “I will not write an immediate conclusion. First, the other records.”

Shashank smiled faintly at the correction. Language was no longer only his examination; everyone in the room was measuring the weight of words.

On the next page there was a reference to a digital-asset address. It had appeared in an attachment to the banquet payment summary. Beside it was an old investigative note: “Ownership unverified.”

Aditya asked, “What did you know about this address?”

“At the time, only that I had seen such an identifier on a list of payment options. Whose ownership, whose control, the source of the funds—I did not know.”

“One of your old messages says ‘digital side arranged’.”

Shashank’s face hardened. “Show me the sentence.”

The line appeared. It was from the week after the banquet. The recipient was a foreign contact. The surrounding lines discussed a linguistic draft. Shashank read it for a long time.

“It sounds like my language,” he said. “But see from context what I meant by ‘arranged’. The next line says: ‘Headings translated; legal comment pending.’ Possibly by ‘digital side’ I meant that the language of the digital-payment headings had been put in order, not the payment arrangement itself.”

Aditya asked, “Is that not a defensive interpretation?”

“It may be. That is why reasoning is needed. If ‘digital side arranged’ meant that I had organized the transfer of funds, the necessary consequences would be some independent sign of whom the money was sent to, how much, on whose instruction, under whose control. If the following line speaks only of translation of headings, the linguistic meaning is the lighter assumption. But if other records support the heavier meaning, I will answer accordingly.”

Aditya checked the technical report. No transaction instruction, account-operating detail, or material resembling a private key had been attached to the message. He said, “For now we will write only this: meaning disputed; linguistic context available; no independent link to economic control here.”

Relief came to Shashank, but shame came with it. His own vague, grandiose language was now creating extra labour even for his defence. If he had written ‘headings translated’ at the time instead of ‘digital side arranged’,

how much confusion would have been avoided. Ambition is not always a crime, but in evidentiary papers it can produce a great deal of smoke.

In the afternoon the statement began. Aditya first read Shashank's previous admissions—softening linguistic risk, overstating his role, using proximity to famous people to enhance his prestige. Then he asked, "After this new material, do you change anything?"

Shashank replied, "Yes. Saying 'I was only a translator' is no longer sufficient. In some contexts I coordinated language, connected meetings, forwarded drafts, and explained headings. But the limits of those acts must be written. I will not make what I did smaller; nor will I enlarge what I did not do on the basis of ambitious messages."

Aditya asked, "What does your ambition prove?"

"My state of mind, self-promotion, and the context for the unreliability of some statements. Not independent proof of external economic facts."

"And your false statements?"

"Where I literally boasted falsely, that raises a question about my credibility—and it should. But from one false sentence it does not follow either that all my statements were false or that every accusation against me was true."

Mrinal was called for a limited statement. He was shown two old messages—"The stage is mine" and "The payment side cannot move without me."

Aditya asked, "What did you understand from these sentences at the time?"

Mrinal said, "That Shashank was inflating his role again. That is why I warned him. I did not know the internal workings of the economic system."

"Did you understand his boasting to be false?"

"The literal meaning of some sentences, certainly. But I knew people depended on his language. The problem was that he was mistaking that dependence for power."

Shashank looked at Mrinal. His friend's words were hard, but this time they did not humiliate him. It felt as though, after so many years, Mrinal was saying in the language of evidence the same thing he had once said in two words: "Be careful."

In the final section of the technical copy, a draft appeared: "Vendor Master List / Birthday Event." It contained multiple service vendors, contract references, billing parties, payment parties, and a column: "Actual beneficial owner: verification pending."

Aditya showed Shashank only the headings. "Why was this file on your laptop?"

"It may have been sent for linguistic reconciliation. I may have checked the Chinese-English names of some columns."

"Did you create this vendor path?"

"The authorship information presently available does not establish that. My role may have extended only to the column language."

"Did you see the column for actual beneficial owner?"

Shashank fixed his eyes on the page. "Possibly. The term was familiar to me. But a familiar term $\neq$ knowing the answer."

"Did you ever question why that field was blank?"

Shashank was silent. "I do not remember. And if I did not, I now understand that while taking pride in language I should have paid more attention to this gap in meaning."

Aditya said, "That will be the next question—the names in the contracts, the vendor path, and actual beneficial ownership. Today it will only be recorded that the file was present on your device, that there was a linguistic-work context, and that economic authorship or ownership remains independently testable."

Before the session ended, Aditya read the day's summary: in the limited re-examination of the old devices, numerous self-promotional messages by Shashank were found in certified copies; Shashank admitted authorship of some of them; role exaggeration was clear in the statements; some materials had been received and opened by him; nevertheless, the available material alone did not establish control of accounts, operation of hawala, ownership of digital assets, or beneficial ownership of the banquet. Shashank's linguistic and meeting-coordination role was somewhat broader than previously framed, but an independent link remained necessary for a conclusion of economic operation.

Shashank said, "Add one line."

"What?"

"Let my old boasting be a subject of investigation; do not hide it. But do not treat boasting as truth and use it to fill an evidentiary blank in an accusation."

Aditya wrote: “Self-promotional statements are context for credibility and state of mind; external facts require independent verification.”

By the time they came out, evening had fallen. Mrinal walked beside him. After some distance Shashank said, “I learned languages to build my future. Then, at some point, I began using language to increase my own height.”

Mrinal asked, “And today?”

“Today I am reducing the height.”

“Does truth become smaller?”

Shashank shook his head. “No. Only the shadow becomes smaller.”

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Device mine = not every item on it authored by me.”

“Account mine = not every statement true.”

“Authorship of a message = factual truth of the message is separate.”

“File received/opened = not file created or decision made.”

“Linguistic coordination = not zero role; not automatically economic control either.”

“Self-promotion = evidence of ambition; not independent proof of an external transaction.”

“One false boast = credibility question; not admission of every accusation.”

“Seeing a digital-asset address = not ownership.”

“Vendor file on device = not authorship of vendor path or beneficial ownership.”

“Reasoning = seek the necessary consequences of the broader assumption; if independent expected signs are absent, reduce the assumption, but do not hide relevant facts.”

Shashank paused for a long time before writing the final line: “The sentences I wrote to enlarge my importance are making me smaller today; perhaps this is not punishment, but measurement.”

He closed the notebook. The name of the next file before him was now clear—contracts, vendor path, actual beneficial ownership. After the lights of the banquet, the access in Macao, and the digital boasting, the question would no longer be about names, but ownership.

CHAPTER 74

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 9

The last line—"Now the question will no longer be one of names, but of ownership"—was still open in Shashank's notebook. The next morning, when Aditya Mishra called him in, there were no digital devices on the table, but four separate files: the event contract, hospitality-vendor records, a payment-routing summary, and the verification sheet for actual beneficial ownership.

Aditya said, "Today there will be less glitter in the words and more relationship among the names. But do not infer ownership merely on seeing a name. Contracting party, service provider, payer, ultimate beneficiary, and actual beneficial owner are all different positions."

Shashank leaned towards the papers. The lights of the banquet night flashed again in his memory—the stage, the artist, the foreign guests, the glass walls, the applause. That night he had known nothing of the structure behind all those names. He had known only who needed which language. Today that ignorance lay before him like a blank column.

The first contract was for the event venue. The service provider was an Indian entity. The payer was another company. Beside the principal burden of the event expenses was a third name. On the final page was a box: "Actual beneficial ownership: verification pending."

Aditya asked, "When you saw these three names, what did you understand?"

"At the time?" Shashank said. "I did not read names as roles. To me they were all simply the 'organizer side'. In my desire to make the language easy, I compressed separate entities into a single word."

"The consequence of that compression?"

"Later readers could think that payment, organization, and ownership were all in the same hands, when the papers do not yet support that conclusion."

Aditya drew three circles with his pencil. "That linguistic problem has now become an economic question."

Old pride rose inside Shashank. "But sometimes everyone in the meeting would ask me, 'Why is this name different from that one?' I would explain it."

Aditya said, "You are entitled to be proud of that. But explaining a distinction and determining ownership are different things."

Shashank nodded. He was not going to abandon his pride in language. He knew his talent for catching meaning across Mandarin, Cantonese, Hindi, and English was real. The error began where he derived authority from talent.

The second file contained hospitality-vendor records. Hotel, transport, food, security, stage décor—separate service vendors. Some invoices went directly to the paying company, some to the event entity, some to a third service organization.

Aditya asked, "Why so many payment paths for one banquet?"

Shashank replied, "Large events can have separate service vendors. But in this particular matter, the records must show whose instructions led to which payments. Multiple paths ≠ crime; multiple paths = need for investigation."

"And if some vendors existed only on paper?"

"Then one must examine evidence of service, employees, delivery, tax records, and the actual recipient. Names alone are not enough."

Aditya said, "Reasoning?"

After thinking briefly, Shashank said, "If we assume that every vendor actually provided services, that assumption fails where no sign of service exists. If we assume from the start that all of them were fronts, we would have to ignore direct services such as hotel, transport, or artist-related work. Reasoning tests both extremes by carrying them to their consequences."

Aditya wrote: "Vendor path = relationship among service, payment, recipient, and control; not merely a chain of names."

The third file contained a brief timeline of several banquet payments. One line was Shashank's linguistic-service fee. The amount was separate, the description clear: "Multilingual stage / guest assistance."

Aditya said, "Do you deny this?"

"No. That was my service fee."

“Does that establish an economic relationship?”

“Yes—a service relationship. If I said I had no relationship at all with the banquet’s money, that would be false. But service fee ≠ beneficial ownership of the event.”

“This time you are accepting a fact against yourself easily.”

Shashank laughed faintly. “Earlier I thought defence meant cutting every connection. Now I understand that giving each connection its correct name is harder.”

On the fourth page was an entity that appeared to share a registered contact address with the paying company. Beside it was an investigative note: “Relationship verification pending.”

Aditya asked, “Shared address = shared owner?”

“No. There can be many reasons for a shared address—a service provider, group administration, a registration facility, or a real corporate relationship. Ownership requires independent records.”

“Shared director?”

“That would be a stronger link, but beneficial ownership would still require separate examination, especially if a nominee director is possible.”

Aditya looked at Shashank. “How well did you understand the expression ‘beneficial ownership’ then?”

Shashank paused at the question. “I understood the linguistic sense—who ultimately benefits, who controls. But the legal definition, limits of disclosure, the paper structures of different entities—those were not my expertise. Yet sometimes I spoke as though I knew all of it.”

“Why?”

“Pride in language. When people asked me the meaning of a difficult Chinese term, I wanted to answer not merely as the owner of the word, but as though I owned the whole world behind it.”

At that admission, the room remained silent for a moment. Aditya’s question had not been harsh, but it pierced Shashank more sharply than the applause at the banquet.

Aditya showed him another old message. Shashank had written to a colleague: “I know whose real money it is; I know everything.”

Shashank closed his eyes as he read the line. “That is a sentence of my ambition.”

“Meaning?”

“I knew the names of some paying parties, some contracting parties, and some stage arrangements. ‘I know everything’ was a false exaggeration.”

“If taken literally?”

“Then one would expect me to possess the name of the beneficial owner, confirmation of the ultimate recipient of funds, decision-making authority, or internal instructions. Instead, many places in the record say ‘verification pending’. So treating my boast as literal truth conflicts with the record.”

Aditya said, “That reasoning helps your defence. But there is another direction too. If you repeatedly said such things, why should an investigator not ask whether you actually knew something more?”

Shashank did not answer immediately. After a few moments he said, “It is proper to ask. A boast should not be treated as nothing. It is a reason to investigate. But a reason for a question = not the answer. Then examine from whom and through what channel I could have received additional information.”

“That is the balance required,” Aditya said.

In the afternoon, the Chinese portion of the event contract was opened. There had been an old dispute over one expression—whether the company was the ‘ultimate sponsor’ or merely the ‘party bearing the expenditure’. In his old translation, Shashank had written ‘principal organizer’.

Aditya asked, “Why?”

Shashank said with embarrassment, “For stage language I wanted something short and bright. ‘Party bearing the expenditure’ sounded awkward. ‘Principal organizer’ was easier to hear.”

“Did the meaning change?”

“Yes. At least the role became broader.”

“Knowingly?”

“The word choice was knowing. I did not understand the full economic consequence of that choice. But saying that does not free me from responsibility.”

Aditya placed the original expression, Shashank’s translation, and the later event brochure side by side. The same phrase ‘principal organizer’ had passed into the brochure.

For a few moments Shashank could not speak. This was the other face of linguistic pride—a convenient word could become the apparent reality of later papers.

Aditya said, “What does this establish?”

“That my wording influenced later records.”

“And actual beneficial ownership?”

“No. An incorrect title being repeated $\neq$ that entity was the actual owner. On the contrary, it makes it even more necessary to return to the original contract.”

“Reasoning?”

“If the phrase ‘principal organizer’ correctly reflects actual ownership, independent ownership records should support it. If they do not, repetition of the phrase cannot itself become the source of the fact.”

Aditya nodded. “Language does not create evidence here; it can distort or clarify the direction in which evidence is sought.”

Shashank repeated the sentence inwardly. He remembered Juliana’s lesson—the translator joins two banks; the river is not his. How often he had stood on the bridge and raised his hand as though he owned the river.

Mrinal was called in for the evening session as well. He was shown an old message in which Shashank had written: “The real people behind this banquet know me.” Mrinal had replied: “Knowing people does not make you the owner.”

Aditya asked Mrinal, “What did you understand by ‘the real people’?”

Mrinal said, “I did not know. I thought Shashank was proud of being close to prestigious people. I knew nothing of the financial structure.”

“Did you try to stop him?”

“Yes. But stopping a friend’s pride and suspecting an economic crime are different things.”

Shashank looked at Mrinal’s face. Friendship had come to the evidence table many times in the previous episodes. This time Mrinal was not defending him; he was simply stating the limit of what he knew at the time.

Aditya read the day’s summary: Shashank’s linguistic and stage services at the banquet were established; his service fee was established; some old translations showed word choices that broadened roles; the vendor path contained multiple entities and payment routes; beneficial ownership remained under verification at several points; Shashank’s boasts raised questions about possible additional knowledge, but did not establish independent economic control.

Shashank said, “Add one line.”

“What?”

“The consequences of the titles I simplified out of pride in language should be examined. Do not assume that because I changed only a word, the effect on meaning was zero.”

Aditya wrote: “The effect of the translator’s word choice is independently testable; effect $\neq$ ownership.”

Outside, Mrinal said, “What happened to your pride today?”

Shashank replied, “It did not become smaller. It changed its place.”

“How?”

“Earlier I was proud that I understood everything. Today I feel pride when I can say—I understand up to here, and not beyond.”

Mrinal smiled. “The education in that boundary has been very expensive.”

“Yes,” Shashank said. “The applause at the banquet, the lights of Macao, the questions in court—all of them were tuition.”

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Contracting party $\neq$ paying party.”

“Paying party $\neq$ actual beneficial owner.”

“Service vendor $\neq$ front automatically.”

“Multiple payment routes = reason to investigate; not conclusion of crime.”

“Service fee = economic relationship; not ownership.”

“Shared address/contact = indicator of relationship; not shared ownership automatically.”

“Blank beneficial-ownership field = verification pending; not an invitation to insert a preferred name.”

“A broader title in translation can influence later papers; it does not replace original ownership records.”

“Self-praise = reason to investigate additional knowledge; not literal truth automatically.”

“Pride in language = respect for talent; erase the boundary and it becomes arrogance.”

“Reasoning = accept a claim and seek its necessary independent indicators; if the indicators are absent, reduce the weight of the claim, not erase the question.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I knew how to pronounce the names on the paper; claiming to know where the money behind those names finally went was an extra letter added by my pride.”

He closed the notebook. He remembered the next list Aditya had given him—payment gateway, intermediary accounts, ultimate recipient, and one familiar set of initials. After the banquet contracts, the next question would once again fall between friendship and the flow of money.

CHAPTER 75

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 10

The last sentence was still open in Shashank's notebook—"After the banquet contracts, the next question will again fall between friendship and the flow of money." In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: "Today we will examine the payment-gateway summary, the review list of intermediary accounts, indications concerning the ultimate recipient, and the identity behind familiar initials. No operational method—only relationships, chronology, and the limits of the evidence."

When Shashank reached the office, Mrinal Karn was already seated there. Before him was not a charge-sheet but a limited file of five pages. The first page contained a consolidated summary from the banquet's payment gateway; the second, abbreviations for several Indian accounts; the third, a lawful service reimbursement; the fourth, an incomplete note concerning a digital-asset reference; the fifth, a timeline of old messages between Shashank and Mrinal.

Aditya said, "Today one mistake would be very easy: seeing familiar initials and immediately choosing the familiar person. 'M.K.' appears in three separate records here. First we have to establish whether all three refer to the same person."

Mrinal looked at the page. "My name is Mrinal Karn. The initials match. But that alone does not make all three entries mine."

A tightness rose inside Shashank. In an earlier episode, Mrinal's name had already appeared in the context of a legitimate reimbursement for guest assistance. Now the same two letters stood again inside a complicated summary of money. That was the difficulty of friendship—the mind recognizes the person first and asks for evidence afterward.

Aditya showed the first entry: "M.K. / guest assistance / reimbursement." The date was the day after the banquet. With it were a small expense summary for event travel and a guest list bearing Mrinal's name. Aditya asked, "Is this yours?"

Mrinal said, "Yes. On the day of the banquet, while I was with Shashank, I paid some local travel and guest-assistance expenses. I was reimbursed later. The original records can show the amount and purpose."

Aditya looked at Shashank. "Did you know this?"

"Yes. I do not deny this part."

"Then Mrinal's economic relationship?"

Shashank answered, "A limited reimbursement relationship. That does not establish control of an account, benefit from the event, or participation in any alleged intermediary chain of funds."

Aditya opened the second entry. It contained only an abbreviated identifier like "M.K.-2", consolidated data from a payment gateway, and beside it the words "ultimate recipient verification pending." There was no full name.

"Mrinal?" Aditya asked.

Shashank's mind said: perhaps. But he stopped. "I cannot say yet. Same initials ≠ same person. The date, account identifier, service context, recipient, and other records have to be matched."

Aditya said, "Reasoning?"

Shashank replied, "If we assume that the M.K. in this entry is Mrinal, we should expect at least some independent connection with Mrinal's legitimate reimbursement record, the same service context, or an identifying link. Without such a connection, an assumption based only on matching letters is too heavy."

Mrinal looked at him. "There is less friendship and more method in that answer."

Shashank said softly, "Today method is what friendship needs in order to survive."

On the third page was an old message. On the evening of the banquet, Shashank had written to Mrinal: "Stay. The foreigners will understand that my Indian side is strong." Mrinal had replied: "I am your friend, not your side."

Shashank lowered his head as soon as he read the line. "That was mine."

Aditya asked, "Meaning?"

"I wanted to use his presence for my own prestige. Not to make him an economic representative—at least that was not my intention. But what I wrote was wrong. I was tempted to use a friend like a display-board instead of treating him as a person."

Mrinal's voice hardened. "That night you told me only to stay with you. Later I understood that you wanted my presence to mean something else."

Shashank replied, "Yes. In that, I betrayed your trust."

Aditya interrupted. "Betrayal of trust = financial participation?"

"No," both of them said almost at once.

Aditya wrote: "Prestige-based use of a friend's presence: admitted moral error. Economic representation: independent evidence required."

The fourth page was an investigative summary of the alleged intermediary accounts. Some accounts had received banquet-related service payments; some funds had moved onward to other entities; for some entries, verification of the ultimate recipient remained pending. In an earlier stage an investigator had written "mule?" in the margin.

Aditya said, "Look at the question mark."

Shashank said, "Meaning the classification is not yet established."

"If money entered one account and moved quickly elsewhere?"

"Then the relationship is worth investigating. But to say the account-holder knowingly acted as a front requires independent evidence of knowledge, instructions, benefit, actual service, and control."

"And if there is a service on paper, but no real service?"

"Then the front-account hypothesis becomes stronger. But if evidence of actual service exists, the weight of the allegation changes. Reasoning works in both directions."

Aditya turned the page. The next note read: "Hawala-like adjustment." Beneath it: "Digital-asset address—ownership unverified." Shashank's eyes stopped for a moment. The media had already circulated those two expressions as though they were final conclusions.

Aditya said, "Today we are not discussing how any such arrangement operates. I only want to see how far the available records connect you, Mrinal, or the banquet's service vendors to it."

Shashank said, "I do not know the operational source of these notes. I have heard some of the words during the investigation and seen some in summaries. Seeing a term ≠ operating the arrangement."

Mrinal asked, "And my name?"

Aditya replied, "At present, your verified entry is the legitimate reimbursement. The identity behind the other M.K. entry is under separate verification. I will not merge the two."

There was no relief on Mrinal's face; fatigue and hardness settled there together. "When a name enters a record because of friendship, the record does not understand friendship."

Aditya said, "That is why records need boundaries."

In the afternoon the old messages on the fifth page were read. In one place Shashank had written to Mrinal: "I have understood the money side of these people." Mrinal had replied: "Understood it—or heard about it?"

Aditya asked, "Your answer today?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "Very often I converted something I had heard into something I claimed to understand. I had read some payment headings, knew some names, and had been present at some meetings. From that I wrote, 'I understand it now.' That was ambition."

"False?"

"The broad literal claim was false. But my knowledge was not absolutely zero either. The accurate sentence would have been: 'I saw some payment-related material; I did not understand the complete financial structure.'"

Aditya said, "That is the difficult part. An investigator cannot simply throw away your boasting, because it raises the possibility of additional knowledge. But the boast cannot simply be accepted as complete truth either."

Shashank nodded. "Reasoning would say: if I truly understood the entire money side, there should be necessary signs of that in my messages, records, or chain of decisions. If there are only scattered headings, a service fee, and stage-related connections, the weight of the claim decreases. But the investigation does not end."

Mrinal said, "Your greatest error was not understanding the money. It was making people believe that you understood everything."

Shashank looked at him. "And your greatest kindness was not saving me, but trying to stop me."

"Did you stop?"

"No."

"Then why calculate the kindness now?"

Shashank smiled faintly. "Because a truth understood late is still truth."

Aditya did not enter their private exchange. He opened a separate list—three payment routes, two verified service vendors, one uncertain intermediary entry, one digital-asset reference, and three separate checks of

ultimate recipients. He said, "It is easy to call all of this one 'chain'. But it should be called one chain only when the relationships among instructions, flow of funds, and benefit are sufficiently connected."

Shashank said, "And it is equally easy to call everything separate. If the timing, parties, and payment relationships repeatedly overlap, saying 'everything is separate' without examining the actual connection would also be a shallow defence."

Aditya smiled faintly for the first time. "Reasoning is no longer merely a tool of defence."

"No. If an assumption I prefer breaks, it should break too."

Before the session ended, Aditya also placed the banquet guest list and a public group photograph on the table. In the photograph Mrinal stood behind Shashank; beside them were employees of the event entity and people from the artist's team. Aditya asked, "Proximity in the photograph = economic proximity?"

Shashank said, "No. The photograph can prove presence. Not role."

"Name on the guest list?"

"Evidence of planned attendance. Not authority over an account."

Mrinal said, "That night I believed I was at a banquet with a friend. If someone later looks at the photograph and calls me a man from the payment side, the photograph cannot carry the weight of that sentence."

Aditya looked at Shashank. "And if you yourself had sent that photograph around to display your influence?"

Shashank said with embarrassment, "Then it could be evidence of my hunger for prestige. Not of Mrinal's economic role."

"Reasoning?"

"If the photograph established financial participation, then the artist, guests, and employees present at the banquet would all have to bear the same responsibility. That consequence is plainly improper. So the proper limit of the photograph is presence; a broader role requires separate evidence."

At the end of the session, Aditya read the statement: Mrinal's limited banquet-related reimbursement was supported by available records; the other entry with matching initials was not yet established as Mrinal's; Shashank admitted using his friend's presence for prestige; classification of the alleged intermediary or mule accounts remained under verification; hawala and digital-asset references existed, but no operational role of Shashank or Mrinal had yet been established; the interrelationship among the payment routes remained independently worthy of examination.

Shashank said, "Add one line."

"What?"

"Friendship is not an account to be used whenever needed."

Aditya said, "That is not a fact for the statement."

Mrinal said, "Write it in the notebook."

When they came outside, the evening light was dim. Mrinal remained silent for a long time. Then he asked, "What if that other M.K. turned out to be me?"

Shashank replied, "Then whatever the facts were, I would accept them. Friendship will not take the place of evidence."

"And if it is not?"

"Then guilt should not be attached to you merely because you are my friend."

Mrinal said, "It took a great many banquets, a great deal of applause, and a great deal of humiliation for you to reach that answer."

Shashank said, "And one friend who kept writing, 'Be careful.'"

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Same initials $\neq$ same person."

"Lawful reimbursement $\neq$ mule account."

"Friend's presence $\neq$ economic representation."

"Prestige-based use of a friend's presence = moral error; economic participation is a separate question."

"Intermediary flow of funds = reason for investigation; a knowing front role requires additional evidence."

"The words hawala/digital asset = question of relationship; not operational role automatically."

"Multiple payment routes at the same time $\neq$ one chain automatically; their interrelationship requires examination."

"Self-praise = possibility of additional knowledge; not literal truth."

"Reasoning = assume the claimed role and seek its necessary independent signs; if those signs are absent, reduce the claim, not the investigation."

"Friendship = neither a shield for defence nor a shortcut for accusation."

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I once used Mrinal to increase the numbers on my side; today, for the first time, I gave his name the right to evidence separate from me.”

He closed the notebook. He remembered the heading on Aditya’s next list—foreign travel, Macao meeting, limited system access. After the path of money through the banquet, the story would return again to the stage where the words ‘special access’ had tempted Shashank.

CHAPTER 76

THE BIRTHDAY STAGE

Aditya Mishra's message that morning was brief: "Today we will again examine the records of foreign travel, the Macao meeting, and limited system access. Material from the banquet stage will be used only where it connects to the claim of travel or access."

Shashank stood still for a few moments after reading the message. The last line was still open in his notebook—the story, after tracing the banquet's money path, would return to the stage where the words 'special access' had tempted him. Those words held the glitter of his old life: applause, foreign guests, a famous singer, expensive lights, and the feeling that language could carry him through every door.

When he reached the office, four things lay on the table—a public visual recording of the birthday stage, the timeline of the foreign trip, the guest list for the Macao meeting, and a summary of limited system access. Aditya began, "Today I am not interested in the dazzle of the word 'server'. I want to see the actual boundary of authority."

Shashank nodded. "All right."

In the first visual recording the stage blazed with light. A singer associated with the Indian Idol programme stood at the side of the stage after finishing a performance. Shashank was introducing foreign guests. In that segment someone from the organizer side could be heard laughing and saying, "Next time in Macao we will give Shashank special access." The crowd broke into applause.

Aditya stopped the recording. "Did you hear that sentence?"

"Yes."

"What did you understand 'special access' to mean then?"

Shashank smiled with embarrassment. "That I would be shown more of the internal system. But that night I did not leave the meaning there; I enlarged it in my own mind."

"How far?"

"Far enough that I wrote to Mrinal: 'On the next trip I will see the real inside.'"

Aditya opened the second page. "What did that sentence mean?"

"Boasting. Some hope. Some greed. Not verified authority."

Aditya said, "A promise made on a stage = actual system rights?"

"No. It could be a social or business assurance. The real boundary of authority has to be seen from access logs, permission categories, and usage records."

Mrinal's old reply was also on the list: "Be careful of the word special." Shashank read the line and his shoulders dropped.

"You heard that promise too?" Aditya asked Mrinal.

Mrinal said, "I heard it on the stage. Even then I felt Shashank was enlarging the meaning of the sentence most of all inside his own mind. I did not know the actual limits of the system."

Aditya moved to the next paper. The travel record showed the ticket from Delhi to Macao, the hotel booking, the meeting date, and the return journey. "What does the foreign trip establish?"

Shashank said, "That I went. It confirms the date and place. Travel ≠ crime. Travel ≠ every purpose of the meeting either."

"Hotel booking?"

"Context for presence. Not partnership."

"Partial hospitality from the banquet organizer side?"

Shashank paused. "One form of economic relationship. If someone bore the expense, its reason and contractual basis should be examined. Hospitality ≠ beneficial ownership, but saying there was 'no relationship at all' would also be wrong."

Aditya made a small tick. "That is the balance required."

On the Macao meeting guest list, beside Shashank's name were the words: "linguistic review / guest access." Beside some other names were categories such as "business review", "legal review", and "technical presentation".

Aditya asked, "Your category?"

"Linguistic review / guest access."

"The stage's 'special access'?"

Shashank kept looking at the page. "The record says guest access. So the literal expansion of the stage phrase was not accurate."

"But you did have access?"

"Yes. Denying that would also be false."

Aditya said, "Reasoning?"

Shashank replied, "If I had no access at all, the guest category, time markers, and meeting visuals would contradict that. If I had broad administrative control, we would expect signs of permanent rights, independent approval authority, the power to change configuration, or long-term use. The available summary shows none of that. So the proper statement at present is: there was limited access; broad control is not established."

Aditya smiled faintly for the first time. "Both ends of the reasoning."

The next page was the system-access summary. A temporary identifier in Shashank's name appeared active for a fixed period. The category read: "guest linguistic review." Beside it was a general description of permitted actions: view content, give linguistic comments, participate in a presentation session. There was no mention of approving payments, changing user rights, altering configuration, or exercising independent administrative authority.

Aditya said, "You had said, 'I had access all the way to the server.'"

Shashank lowered his eyes. "Yes. I understand now that the sentence was far too broad."

"False?"

"If taken literally to mean 'administrative control of the server', yes—the claim is unsupported. If it means only that I was allowed to view limited material inside the system, then there was some factual basis. My error was that I expressed a limited fact in an impressive, expansive phrase."

Mrinal said quietly, "What happened on the stage happened on the journey too?"

Shashank looked at him. "Yes. I was given a voice, and I assumed the stage was mine. I was given guest access, and I assumed the house inside was mine."

Aditya returned to the records. "Your identifier was active during one session. Does that make every action during that period yours?"

Shashank began to answer immediately, then stopped himself. "No. An active session ≠ complete proof of who performed every specific action. If there is a separate marker for a specific action, that should be examined. And if the identifier was shared or a supervisor was present, authorship remains a separate question."

Aditya asked, "Was your identifier shared?"

"Not permanently, as far as I remember. During the presentation, local staff were present. Without a specific record, I cannot say whose hand performed which action."

Aditya said, "Good. Leave the guesswork."

In the afternoon a brief meeting record was shown. It contained a list of linguistic terms, translation of warnings related to games, brief meanings of payment headings, and language for user messages. Shashank's comments appeared in many places. In some, his word choices were again softer.

Aditya asked, "Yours?"

"Yes, some of the comments are mine."

"Does that establish technical access?"

"It may establish access to linguistic material. Not technical control of the system."

"And economic knowledge?"

Shashank stopped at a line explaining the linguistic meaning of a general payment heading. "I saw some payment-related terms. But seeing a heading ≠ knowing the source of funds, the ultimate recipient, or any alleged hawala or digital-asset arrangement."

Aditya said, "Run the reasoning in reverse. Suppose you really were the operator of the financial arrangement?"

Shashank replied, "Then linguistic comments alone would not be enough. We would expect independent financial instructions, account rights, authority to choose recipients, approvals, or signs of benefit. In the records examined so far, there is my service fee and linguistic role; no independent marker of broad economic control has yet appeared."

"And if you claim you knew nothing at all?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "That would be wrong too. I saw some risk terms, payment headings, and game-related material. I softened some words. I met some people in Li Wenchao's circle. I saw the guest system. Saying 'I knew nothing' would conceal my real proximity."

Aditya said, "Reasoning is not only for defence."

"I understand."

Towards evening the second recording from the birthday stage was opened. The singer had finished and left. Shashank was on stage translating thanks to the foreign guests. The camera lingered on his face. His expression shone with pride.

Shashank himself said, "Even now, watching this, I feel proud of my talent."

Aditya asked, "Where was the greed?"

"Behind that pride. I thought the people listening to me on that stage would take me into their inner circle. I treated applause as opportunity; opportunity as authority; authority as power."

"And money?"

"Money too. Higher service fees, travel, hotels, prestige—all of it attracted me. If I say now it was only love of language, that would be false."

Mrinal said, "That night you told me: 'Once I get inside, the work will come on its own.'"

Shashank closed his eyes. "Yes. That was greed."

Aditya asked, "Admission of a crime?"

"No. Greed is a state of mind. Crime requires act, purpose, and evidence. But I will not minimize the fact that greed weakened my judgment."

Aditya wrote in the statement: "The declarant admits that stage prestige, foreign travel, higher service fees, and the attraction of 'special access' influenced his business decisions; the available records support limited linguistic/guest access; questions of broader administrative or financial control remain dependent on independent evidence."

Shashank said, "Add one line."

"What?"

"I used expansive phrases such as 'server access' and described my role as larger than it actually was."

Aditya wrote it down. "That is important."

When they came out, evening light lay on the distant dome of the court building. The next hearing was not far away. Shashank felt that the birthday stage and the shadow of the courtroom were no longer very distant from one another. In one place applause enlarged a sentence; in the other, every word was weighed.

Mrinal asked, "If they had not said 'special access' to you that day, would you still have gone to Macao?"

Shashank remained silent for a while. "Probably. There was work, money, curiosity. But the word 'special' made the decision easier for me."

"Reasoning?"

Shashank smiled faintly. "If removing a single word changes a decision, the word had influence. But that the word was the only cause is not established. Life is not an equation with a single cause."

At that moment Shashank understood that greed does not always arrive as a direct demand for money. Sometimes it slips into the mind as an adjective—'special guest', 'special access', 'special trust'—and the mind turns that adjective into a noun called authority.

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

"Promise on a stage ≠ actual system authority."

"Foreign travel ≠ crime; purpose of travel and conduct are separate evidentiary questions."

"Hospitality = one form of economic relationship; not beneficial ownership."

"Guest access = fact of access; not administrative control."

"Active session = not automatic authorship of a specific action."

"Linguistic comment = linguistic access; technical or financial authority is separate."

"Boast of 'server access' = context of ambition and greed; measure actual authority from records."

"Greed = not proof of crime; certainly a moral context for decisions."

"Reasoning = seek the necessary markers of both extreme assumptions—'no access' and 'full control'—and accept only as much as the records support."

He stopped while writing the final line: "On the birthday stage they called me 'special'; in Macao they wrote 'guest'. My fall began on the staircase I built in my own mind between those two words."

He closed the notebook. He remembered the next list Aditya had given him—legal consultation after the Macao meeting, Raghav Bhasin's name, and several communications over which privilege was claimed.

After the greed of special access, the next question was fear: in the papers translated before a lawyer, where did language end and the allegation of participation begin?

CHAPTER 77

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 12

The last line kept circling inside Shashank all night—after the greed for special access, the next question was fear. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today we will examine the external timeline of legal consultation after the Macao meeting, Raghav Bhasin’s presence, your linguistic summaries, and separate business communications. The substance of legal advice will not be opened without the limits set by the court.”

Shashank held the mobile phone in his hand for a few moments after reading the message. His fear was not merely the fear of admitting a crime; he was also afraid that his own boasting, half-truths, and sentences such as ‘everything is fine’ might have displaced someone else’s genuine legal caution. Language, once his pride, could now create unjust meanings against him on the table of evidence.

Raghav Bhasin was already seated in the office. Three separate files lay on the table. The first was marked: “Legal consultation: substance protected; external details only.” The second: “Business communications.” The third: “Shashank’s linguistic summaries / independent messages.” Aditya said, “Today we will not blend these three into one another.”

Raghav said calmly, “Legal privilege does not mean that wherever a lawyer’s name appears, everything becomes untouchable. But neither does a meeting with a lawyer mean that the lawyer or the client participated in a crime. Purpose, nature of the material, recipient, and actual role are separate questions.”

Aditya opened the first page. It contained the external details of a meeting held two days after the return from Macao—time, place, persons present, and a general subject heading: “India-related legal risk and contractual precautions.” Beside Shashank’s name were the words: “linguistic assistance.”

“Were you present?” Aditya asked.

“Yes.”

“What was your work?”

“To explain some questions between Mandarin and English, and to clarify the linguistic meaning of Raghavji’s general cautions. I did not frame the complete legal advice, nor was I qualified to give it.”

Raghav said, “I can confirm that much—he provided linguistic assistance. The legal conclusions of the consultation were my professional work.”

Aditya moved to the next page. About an hour after the meeting, Shashank had sent Li Wenchao a short message: “The lawyer side has cleared it; the India work can proceed.”

Shashank lowered his face as he read the line. “That is mine.”

“An accurate summary?”

“No. Far too soft and broad. The legal caution had many conditions. I turned it into one sentence serving my prestige.”

Raghav looked at Shashank but said nothing immediately. After a few moments he said, “I will not disclose the words of confidential advice. But I can say this much: an absolute sentence such as ‘everything is clear’ was not my professional language.”

Shashank’s throat dried. “I accept that.”

Aditya asked, “Why did you write it?”

“Fear and ambition together. I wanted the foreign side to see me as an indispensable bridge. If I had said, ‘The lawyer has identified many limits and further checks are needed,’ my shine would have diminished. So I wrote caution as though it were approval.”

“Was that deceit?”

After a while Shashank said, “Linguistically, yes. I did not merely shorten the meaning; I made it favourable. But that admission does not automatically establish that I devised a criminal plan.”

Aditya said, “Apply reasoning.”

Shashank looked at the three files on the table. “If we assume that my message ‘the lawyer side has cleared it’ was actually an authorised legal approval, we would expect Raghavji’s official written opinion, the general conclusion of the meeting, or later lawful records to support that unqualified approval. At present there is no such support. On the contrary, the records repeatedly mention limits, cautions, and further checks. So my sentence is stronger evidence of my boasting than of official legal approval.”

“And the other extreme?” Aditya asked.

"If we assume that everyone present at a legal meeting participated in a crime, presence alone is not enough. We would need an independent connection to instructions, shared purpose, benefit, control, or a specific criminal act. Lawyer, translator, client, businessman—their roles are not the same."

Aditya took out a page marked with a red line. It was not from the legal file, but a separate business communication. After the meeting, an employee was discussing a change in the wording of a service description. The original author had not yet been identified with certainty. Only one sentence had been forwarded to Shashank for translation.

"Did you translate it?"

"The linguistic form of this sentence is probably mine."

"Was the business decision yours?"

"No. But if I had knowingly made the meaning misleading, my responsibility would have been separate."

Aditya placed the original and the translation side by side. This time their meanings were nearly the same; the old tendency to soften risk did not appear here.

Shashank looked at the page in surprise. His first response was relief, but immediately he remembered the rule he had written in his notebook—where there is no error, there should be no manufactured guilt either. He said, "In this line, I did not distort the language."

"Evidence for that conclusion?"

"The correspondence of meaning between the original and the translation."

"And does that prove your character?"

"No. One correct translation does not cancel earlier improper softening; one improper softening does not make every translation defective either."

For the first time Raghav smiled slightly. "That distinction matters greatly in a court of law."

In the afternoon, the classification list was examined under the court's earlier order. Some communications were categorized as "potentially privileged legal advice", some as "ordinary business communications", and two mixed communications as "judicial determination pending". Aditya made it clear: "Classification itself does not mean guilt or innocence; it tells us only by what process the material may be examined."

Shashank asked, "If a business message was sent immediately after the legal meeting, should it be treated as a result of the legal advice?"

Aditya said, "Temporal proximity can raise a question. It does not establish causation."

Raghav added, "A person may hear advice and later make a business decision of his own. Decision and advice are not the same thing. And if someone uses my name to give legitimacy to his own decision, that use of my name does not become my actual opinion."

Shashank felt his own message stab him again—"The lawyer side has cleared it." He understood that he had not merely softened the language; he had turned Raghav's professional name into a seal for his own ambition.

"Raghavji," he said, "I used your name to add weight to my own sentence."

Raghav replied, "You must understand the moral weight of that. The legal weight will be determined by the records."

"Will you forgive me?"

"Forgiveness is a personal question. It is not the answer to an investigation."

Shashank fell silent. Fear had another form too—even if someone forgave him, the record would not change; and if forgiveness did not come, guilt would not thereby be proved.

Towards evening Aditya showed an old public photograph. At the edge of the banquet stage there was a figure resembling Raghav, previously considered unclear. A second, clearer record showed Raghav's name on the guest list, but assigned him no role in the financial decisions of the event.

Aditya asked, "What follows from this?"

Shashank said, "Presence. Possibly the social context of acquaintance or legal association. Not economic participation, unless independent evidence shows it."

"And if the media writes: 'The lawyer was also at the banquet, therefore the legal cover had been prepared in advance?'"

"That would be an allegation. It would require evidence of purpose, prior plan, specific advice, and a link to criminal conduct. The photograph alone is not enough."

Raghav looked at Shashank. "You can say that now. Could you have said it on the night of the banquet?"

Shashank smiled bitterly. "On the night of the banquet I counted everyone's proximity as an increase in my own stature."

Mrinal's voice rose in his memory, though Mrinal was not present that day: "You paid for that greed in fear."

On the final page Aditya showed an old internal note. The officer from the lower commissionerate had written: "Keep the privileged portion of legal consultation separate; independent examination of business communications is necessary." Beside it was a brief note from another branch: "Legal review completed."

Shashank looked at the two lines for a long time. "The second line is narrowing the boundary again."

"Possibly," Aditya said, "but not yet a conclusion of 'compromise' or 'pressure'. Why the summary changed, on whose instruction, and how the original reservation moved through the later file—those are the next questions."

Along with fear, an old uncomfortable memory rose inside Shashank. Similar softening had appeared before in the tax-intelligence summary—question marks vanished, reservations became shorter, the language of risk grew thinner. But this time he did not immediately call it 'betrayal'.

He said, "If the lower commissionerate's reservation was genuine, and the higher summary repeatedly reduced its force, the reason is worth investigating. But difference alone $\neq$ deliberate compromise."

Aditya said, "Reasoning?"

"If we assume it was merely summarisation, we would expect the original reservation to remain preserved in other attachments, the decision-maker to have access to it, and there to be some neutral reason for the change. If we assume deliberate compromise, we would need independent indicators of instruction, benefit, pressure, unusual contact, or concealment of the original material. A conclusion becomes too heavy unless both assumptions are carried to their consequences."

Aditya wrote a note: "Next stage: lower commissionerate resistance versus tax-intelligence summary; version sequence; circulation list; authorised alteration."

The moment Shashank saw the page, he understood that the shadow now lay directly ahead. Using Raghav's name to increase his own importance was Shashank's private deceit; who altered the force of an institutional record, and why, was a separate question.

As they came out, Raghav said, "In fear, people make two kinds of errors—they either want to hide everything, or expose everything and pile it onto themselves."

Shashank said, "And the right path?"

"Respect the boundary of what is confidential. Let business facts be investigated. Take responsibility for the sentences that are yours. Do not write what is not mine in my name."

Shashank bowed his head. It felt less like advice than an accounting.

That night he opened his notebook.

"Legal privilege $\neq$ shield for crime."

"Lawyer's presence $\neq$ participation in crime."

"Linguistic assistance $\neq$ legal decision."

"The lawyer side has cleared it' = my exaggeration; not automatically the lawyer's official opinion."

"Legal and business communications at the same time $\neq$ same purpose."

"Temporal proximity = question of causation; not proof of causation."

"A correct translation $\neq$ erasure of all earlier errors; an earlier error $\neq$ corruption of every translation."

"Respecting the limits of confidential material $\neq$ hiding truth; covering business facts by calling them confidential $\neq$ privilege."

"Fear = no right to alter the boundary of meaning."

"Reasoning = seek the necessary consequences of both extreme assumptions—'everything privileged' and 'everyone participating'—and accept only as much as the record supports."

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: "I made my sentence heavy with the lawyer's name; today, for the first time, I returned the weight of that name to the hands of its owner."

He closed the notebook. He remembered the title of the next file—resistance from the lower commissionerate, changing summaries in the tax-intelligence branch, and question marks disappearing between versions.

After fear, the next emotion was betrayal. But this time Shashank knew that before he could call it betrayal, reasoning would have to establish that something more than mere summarisation had occurred.

CHAPTER 78

THE BANQUET, THE GODS, THE HUMILIATION 13

The last sentence kept circling inside Shashank all night—before calling it betrayal, one would have to establish that something more than mere summarisation had occurred. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today we will examine the version sequence of the lower commissionerate’s original note, the intermediate draft, the final tax-intelligence summary, and the softened linguistic passage that reached the business side. No version is, by itself, proof of a crime.”

The same officer from the lower commissionerate was sitting in the office, the one whose reservation lines had surfaced again and again in earlier sessions. Four copies lay before him. First, the original note; second, an intermediate draft; third, the final summary from the higher branch; fourth, a short linguistic note that had reached the business side, written in a style resembling Shashank’s translations.

The officer placed not his thumb but the tip of his pen on the first page. “This is my original copy. It says: actual beneficial ownership to be verified; unusual portions of the payment path to be examined separately; ‘Hawala’ and ‘Digital asset?’ are questions only, not conclusions.”

Aditya turned to the second copy. The line about beneficial ownership was still present in the intermediate draft, but two sub-clauses concerning the payment path had become shorter. The question marks remained. In the third, the final summary, it was written that direct tax loss had not been established; the line about beneficial ownership had shrunk almost into a footnote; the two question marks had disappeared.

Aditya asked, “Your first conclusion on seeing these three versions?”

Shashank said, “The change is gradual. There is no single abrupt leap. But some cautions become lighter in each version. This may be editorial condensation; improper influence may also become a question. The version sequence alone does not establish purpose.”

“Reasoning?”

“If it was only ordinary summarisation, we would expect details to be reduced in other drafts of the same kind too, not only in these sensitive lines. If there was improper influence, we would expect independent signs such as someone’s instruction, benefit, unusual intervention, a reason for changing the version, or prior knowledge on the external side.”

Aditya said, “Good. Now the fourth copy.”

Shashank’s throat tightened slightly. The short linguistic note read: “The India side does not presently see an immediate tax crisis; some verification remains, but there is at present no reason to stop business.” Reading the last clause, he remembered his old sentence. In the earlier session he had already admitted that “no immediate crisis” was his own expansion.

Aditya asked, “Is this note yours?”

“The style is mine. The original digital copy was also found in my old files. I have no reason to deny authorship.”

The officer looked at Shashank. “I wrote: verification pending. You wrote: no reason to stop business.”

Shashank drew a long breath before answering. “Yes. Those are not the same thing. I enlarged the meaning beyond the caution.”

“On whose instruction?” The officer’s voice hardened.

“I do not now remember any written instruction from anyone for this note. I wanted business to continue. I also wanted people to find me useful.”

The room remained silent for a few moments. In earlier days, in such silences, Shashank would search for two sentences with which to defend himself. Today he made no effort to reduce the size of his own error.

Aditya said, “What does that admission establish?”

Shashank replied, “That I converted the original caution into more reassuring language. That my ambition and my greed to preserve my work contributed to the softening. But it does not automatically establish that the higher tax-intelligence branch made a compromise with anyone, or that I was part of an internal conspiracy.”

The hurt remained on the officer’s face. “But your note went outside.”

“Yes.”

“And my question became lighter inside.”

“Yes.”

“Then why should it not feel like betrayal to me?”

Shashank looked into the officer’s eyes. “It may feel that way. The feeling is not false. But your sense of betrayal and proof that someone committed an offence are different things. And my part—softening the language—is a separate moral responsibility.”

Aditya wrote three phrases separately: “systemic change”, “Shashank’s linguistic softening”, “allegation of compromise”. Then he said, “Do not merge these three into one sentence.”

In the second stage they examined the timestamps of the versions. The original note came first; the intermediate draft a few hours later; the final summary the next day; Shashank’s softened note appeared to have been created between the intermediate draft and the final summary. That one fact made the room heavy again.

The officer asked, “Before the final summary was prepared, how did you get a basis for saying ‘no tax crisis?’”

Shashank remembered an old night in Macao—Li Wenchao’s message: “The India-side questions are softening.” He said, “I received a statement from the business side that the questions were becoming softer. I did not ask for the source. Possibly I also mixed in oral discussion from a meeting. But I do not clearly remember whether I had seen the final official summary at that time.”

Aditya stopped him at once. “Keep ‘possibly’ within its boundary. What you do not remember clearly must not become fact.”

“Correct. The proved facts are only these: I received a business-side message saying something like ‘the questions are softening’; I did not ask for its source; and I softened the risk further in my own note.”

“And the timing?”

“Worth investigating. The source is not established.”

Aditya applied the test of reasoning again. “Suppose someone inside sent information about the draft to the business side. What would we expect?”

Shashank said, “Some communication link, a recipient, a time match, the same distinctive wording, access rights, or a relationship of benefit. The fact that the business side said ‘softening’ first and the later summary was softer is an indication, not complete proof.”

“And suppose no internal information went out?”

“Then we need an alternative source for the business side’s earlier statement—commercial inference, public discussion, separate oral information, or coincidence. If a distinctive line matches the later draft word for word, the coincidence hypothesis becomes weaker.”

Aditya placed two sentences side by side on the fourth page. The intermediate draft said: “No conclusion of direct tax loss is presently available; other verification separate.” A business-side message said: “No direct tax loss at present; the rest is separate.” They were not word-for-word identical, but the structure was close.

Shashank said, “This textual proximity is reason to investigate the source chain. But the same idea could also have arisen independently. It is not enough to choose a specific person.”

For the first time, the lower officer’s patience slipped slightly. “If every time you say ‘not enough’, when will the truth be found?”

Aditya did not answer him; Shashank did. “When what is enough is not called too little, and what is not enough is not called more. Your original note was received—the receipt mark exists. Some of it became lighter in the later summary—the comparison shows that. My separate softened note exists—I admit it. But there is still no identified person who knowingly sent internal material outside.”

The officer leaned back in his chair. “I do not want a name if there is no evidence. I want the paper to answer why the questions I wrote disappeared.”

“The investigation will move in that direction,” Aditya said. “Next we will examine the version structure, access list, and records showing reasons for revision. But we will not give a person to an inference.”

Aditya then produced a new page—the version-access list. It did not show operational details; it showed only which departmental accounts had access to the draft. The lower officer’s account up to dispatch of the original; three departmental roles in the higher draft group; one review account; and one automated archive entry. Shashank’s name did not appear on the internal access list.

The officer said immediately, “Then someone inside must have told the outside party.”

Aditya stopped him. “Not yet. The list says only that Shashank’s direct internal access is not recorded. Information could have reached outside by many routes—meetings, oral discussion, another record, inference. This list does not directly establish that ‘someone leaked it’.”

Looking at the list, Shashank said, “But if the allegation is that I myself opened the draft, read it, and passed it to the business side, this list is one fact against that allegation.”

“Against it, but not final,” Aditya said. “Because we must also verify whether the list is complete. No direct access ≠ information could not have reached you from anywhere.”

Reasoning appeared again in its harsher form. Shashank said, "If I had directly read the internal draft, expected traces might include an access log, a transmitted copy, the original file on my device, or a copy carrying distinctive draft markers. No such direct trace appears at present. But my softened note exists; the question of its source remains."

Aditya nodded. "That is why 'missing expected signs' will matter in the next stage. But today we are not yet drawing a conclusion from absence; we are only writing what reasoning would lead us to expect."

One box on the version sheet was blank: "Reason for revision". Between the original and the intermediate draft there was a short note: "Condensation". Between the intermediate draft and the final summary, the reason box was empty. The officer stared at the blank space for a long time.

"Why is this blank?" he asked.

Aditya said, "Blank box $\neq$ improper influence. But if the rules require a reason to be recorded, its absence becomes a fact for further investigation. First we have to establish whether recording a reason in this kind of revision was mandatory or ordinary practice."

Something changed inside Shashank. Earlier, whenever he saw a blank, he filled it with a story. Today he wrote: "A blank is not a story; it is a question."

Mrinal arrived in the afternoon. Shashank did not tell him every detail, only his own part. "Again I am finding that someone's caution reached my hands and became softer."

Mrinal asked, "Do you think everyone betrayed you?"

Shashank thought for a while. "Earlier I did. Now I understand that the story of betrayal is not one-sided. Something improper may have happened in the system; the evidence still has to be found. But I reduced the force of the officer's questions—that was my doing. I cannot hide my part by saying only, 'I was betrayed.'"

"And if someone inside really sold it?"

"Then the evidence for that will belong to that act; my guilt will not be its proof."

A faint hardness came over Mrinal's face. "You learned that late."

"Yes. Glitter taught me very quickly; boundaries, very slowly."

In the evening Aditya read the day's summary: sequential linguistic changes were visible across the lower original note, the intermediate draft, and the final summary; some cautions were reduced in the final form; Shashank admitted authorship and broader wording in his independent softened summary; the business-side message saying "questions softening" existed before the official final summary; textual proximity and temporal similarity were worth investigating; but internal information flow, improper influence, compromise, a specific officer, instruction, or benefit were not yet established without independent evidence.

Shashank said, "Add one line—the lower officer's resistance is a real recorded fact. He wrote again to preserve the questions."

Aditya wrote it down. For the first time the officer looked at Shashank without hardness. "At least do not soften this line."

Shashank replied, "I will not."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Original note $\neq$ final summary."

"Gradual linguistic change = purpose not established; but version sequence is worth investigating."

"Resistance from the lower commissionerate = recorded fact; 'compromise' is a separate allegation."

"Earlier statement from the business side = question about source; the source itself is not established."

"Textual proximity = indicator of relationship; a specific person requires an independent link."

"My softened summary = my responsibility; not independent proof of institutional compromise."

"Sense of betrayal = real; guilty person = evidentiary conclusion."

"Reasoning = carry both stories to their necessary consequences—the 'ordinary summarisation' story as well as the 'improper influence' story."

"My guilt = not proof of another person's wrongdoing."

As he wrote the last line, Shashank stopped: "I sometimes softened other people's questions; now I will let the question remain with its full weight."

He closed the notebook. The lights of the banquet, Macao's special access, legal fear, and the disappearing question marks in the tax-intelligence papers had all gathered at one point. The section on reasoning felt as though it was ending here; in the next section the question would reverse. Not only what was found, but what ought to have been found in the proper place and was not—the absence itself would speak.

Shashank looked towards the window. He had seen the first title of Part Seven on Aditya's list: "Cracks in the Compromise." He knew that the next examination would begin not with the voice of accusation, but with the silence of missing signs.

CHAPTER 79

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE I

The last line was still sounding inside Shashank—the next test would begin not with the voice of accusation, but with the silence of missing signs. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today, three questions: why did the lower commissioner’s objection shrink in the final summary, how did the language of sealed material reach the media, and where are the expected signs of the internal-collusion allegation made against you? The principle—non-apprehension.”

When Shashank reached the office, he saw that this time there were not many papers on the table. One thin file, two timelines, a certified copy of an access record, and three printed pages from the media. The officer from the lower commissioner was also present. The hardness from the previous session was gone from his face, though a quiet disagreement still remained.

Aditya began, “Non-apprehension does not mean that because something was not found, the event therefore did not happen. First we must establish that if the event had happened, a particular sign would, under ordinary circumstances, have been fit to be found. Only then does its absence become meaningful.”

Shashank said, “So before absence can function as evidence, we must establish the fitness of the sign to have been available.”

“Correct. And if the record system itself is incomplete, it would be improper to force silence to speak loudly.”

The officer opened a copy of his original note. “I had raised three questions—beneficial ownership, an unusual payment path, and two external indicators. In the final summary the questions became smaller. I was not told on whose instruction.”

Aditya asked, “If your objection had been removed through a regular editorial process, what signs would normally remain?”

The officer replied, “A reason for the revision, an approval note, or at least a version comment. It is not identical every time, but when a serious objection is removed, some reason is usually recorded.”

“Here?”

“The reason box is blank.”

Shashank looked at the paper. The blank reminded him of the empty beneficial-ownership field. But now he knew—a blank box does not identify a guilty person.

Aditya said, “What conclusion can we draw at this stage from that non-apprehension?”

Shashank replied, “A regular reason-recording process was expected, and it is absent—that much makes the process worthy of question. But it does not establish a particular internal saboteur.”

The officer nodded. “That is where my complaint began. Later the media wrote that ‘an insider had been bought’. That was not my sentence.”

Aditya placed the first printed page before Shashank. The headline was heavy: “GST Intelligence Cleared from Inside for Foreign Gambling Network: Indian Translator the Main Bridge.” Beneath it was again the photograph from the banquet stage—Shashank beside a famous singer—and the text claimed that his “internal contacts” had removed the sealed questions.

The old heat of humiliation rose through Shashank’s body. A moment on the stage had once again become an image of crime. He looked not at the artist in the photograph, but at himself. Earlier, a headline like this would have filled him only with anger. Now the question was different—what expected signs should exist if the writer’s claim were true?

Aditya asked, “The news claim is that you got the questions removed through internal contacts. If that claim were true, what kind of independent links should an investigator look for?”

Shashank said, “An identifiable contact, instruction, communication, benefit, a credible chronology of meetings, or material showing access to internal decision-making separate from my external linguistic work.”

“In the court-approved digital re-examination of your material?”

“So far no such link has been shown to me.”

Aditya opened the copy of the access record. “In the known official digital repository, no entry has been found showing that the sealed file was opened under your name or under any identifier verified as yours.”

Shashank almost spoke in triumph, but the first lesson of non-apprehension stopped him. “That becomes meaningful only if this record system reliably records all possible access of that kind.”

Aditya said, "Exactly. That is why we are not calling this complete proof of innocence. Non-apprehension is significant on this particular digital route; questions concerning printed copies, authorised extracts, or other lawful or unlawful human sources remain separate."

The officer added, "My original note could also be seen in printed form by a limited number of people. So the source question does not end merely because digital access was not found."

Shashank said, "Then the media claim that 'Shashank got inside' is at least unsupported on this digital route."

"State it within the proper boundary," Aditya replied. "No support was found for that claim in the known official digital access records."

In that fine distinction, one portion of Shashank's humiliation became lighter, but instead of restored pride he felt a stern calm. The answer to a false allegation had to be given not with excitement, but with a bounded sentence.

Aditya then placed a small table on the desk. It listed Shashank's known mobile numbers, email identifiers, and the time range of communications found in the court-authorised seizure. "If, as the report claims, you had regularly been directing some internal officer, then across this extended period one would expect at least some identifiable trace of contact. So far none has been found. But this statement applies only to the identifiers that were examined."

Shashank said, "So non-apprehension reduces the weight of the question against me, but it does not establish that an unknown channel was impossible." Aditya replied, "Yes. The honesty of the investigator lies in writing the limits of the search. 'We did not find it' and 'there is no such thing' are not the same sentence." The lower officer said, "The absence of that distinction gives birth to many false accusations."

On the second printed page, a sentence from the sealed note appeared almost word for word, but the question mark had been removed. The article said: "According to an internal source, foreign payments through hawala and digital assets are confirmed." The original material contained no such confirmation; it contained only questions.

Aditya asked, "What does this textual proximity establish?"

Shashank said, "It raises the question whether someone had access to the original language or to language close to the original. But it does not by itself identify the writer, the source of the leak, the medium, or Shashank."

"Where is the non-apprehension?"

The lower officer showed the dispatch list. "There is a receipt for every authorised recipient of the sealed copy. For one copy there is a receipt, but no later mark of physical return."

Aditya immediately said, "Absence of a return mark $\neq$ the copy was stolen."

"Yes," the officer said. "Under the older system not every return was recorded uniformly. Here the absence increases suspicion; it is not an established fact."

Shashank listened carefully. Non-apprehension was not a simple weapon; it was conditional evidence. When the expected record is reliable, silence can speak. When the record system itself has holes, the language of silence remains ambiguous.

The third page was the most humiliating. It said that Shashank had held a "secret banquet with a GST officer", and a group photograph from the birthday event had been cropped so that a distant figure appeared to resemble a government officer.

Shashank looked at the photograph. "This person is not that officer."

The officer himself said, "No. I did not attend that banquet at all."

Aditya asked, "Your official presence on that date?"

The officer showed a certified list from a public departmental programme. "I was in another city at a departmental review. Entry, meeting list, and travel records are all available."

For the first time in this episode, Shashank felt clear anger. "Then the 'secret banquet' is a false allegation."

Aditya said, "As regards this specific officer, the available positive records conflict with the claim. This is not merely non-apprehension; there is affirmative evidence of presence elsewhere."

Shashank placed not his thumb but his pen on the news photograph. "And the famous artist's image has been used again. The stage performance has no established connection to this allegation."

"That too will be recorded," Aditya said. "Proximity to a public figure cannot be used as a supplementary image of crime where there is no independent relationship."

Inside the humiliation, Shashank suddenly remembered his own old deceit. How often had he himself used famous names, a lawyer's caution, a foreign meeting, and the phrase 'special access' to enlarge his own prestige. The media was now using the same disease against him in a gigantic form—turning proximity into authority, a photograph into participation, a question into a conclusion.

He said, "I used a smaller version of this method in my own life."

Aditya asked, "Meaning?"

"Standing beside someone and making my role sound larger. Turning a limited fact into 'everything is clear'. Knowing languages and creating an illusion of control. That is why this false allegation hurts more—the method is familiar to me. But my old exaggeration does not make the media's false claim true."

"That distinction matters."

Mrinal arrived in the afternoon. He read the headline, then looked at Shashank. "Do you feel humiliated?"

"Yes."

"Why? Because of your name?"

Shashank remained silent for a while. "Earlier, only because of my name. Now because an officer who resisted was turned into an imaginary participant in a secret banquet; because an artist's stage presence was turned into the shadow of a crime; because question marks were removed and turned into conclusions. It was not only I who was humiliated. The evidence was humiliated too."

Mrinal said, "And your own part?"

"I am not hiding the softened translations I made or the boasts I made. But accepting a false accusation in the name of atonement would itself be an insult to evidence."

In the evening Aditya read the day's summary: when the lower commissioner's serious objection was reduced, the regular sign of a recorded reason was not available; this made the process worthy of question but did not establish a specific internal saboteur. No official digital-access record had been found linking Shashank's known identifiers to opening the sealed file; this weakened the claim regarding that particular digital route, but did not automatically exclude other sources. The textual proximity between the sealed language and the media report justified investigation of the source chain; a specific source required an independent link. For the lower officer named in the alleged "secret banquet", contrary official presence records were available; the specific allegation was not merely unsupported but contradicted by evidence.

Shashank said, "Add one line—failure to find a record becomes strong only after it is first established that such a record was fit to exist."

Aditya wrote: "Qualified non-apprehension."

The officer said, "And one line more—my objection was reduced, that is a fact; that I was bought is a false allegation unless independent evidence establishes it."

Aditya added that as well.

That night Shashank opened his notebook.

"Non-apprehension = not merely 'not found'."

"Qualified non-apprehension = where, under proper circumstances, a sign ought necessarily or ordinarily to have been found, but after a reliable search it is not found."

"Silence in an incomplete record system = not decisive absence."

"Reason for revision absent = process worthy of question; actor not established."

"No known official digital access = weakens the claim through that route; does not negate every possible source."

"Sealed language in the news = investigation of source chain; does not automatically identify Shashank or the officer."

"Proximity in a photograph = not participation."

"Contrary official presence records = direct challenge to a specific false claim."

"My old exaggeration = moral fault; not proof of someone else's false allegation."

"Humiliation = injury to the mind; established fact = boundary of evidence."

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: "Before listening to the silence of what is absent, one must first know whether a voice ought to have been there."

Closing the notebook, he remembered Aditya's next notice—the court wanted cross-examination on these non-apprehensions. In the next session the question would not be merely, 'Was anything found?' It would be: 'Was what was not found something that ought to have been findable, and how far does its absence reduce the weight of whose claim?'

CHAPTER 8o

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 2

This time there were no glittering photographs in court. No banquet stage, no Macao hotel, no media headline. Before the judge lay four plain tables—the access record, the revision history, the access list for the protected file, and the version sequence of the lower commissioner's objections. The previous question had now become the court's question: was what had not been found something that ought to have been findable?

Government counsel lifted the first table. "The lower commissioner's objection became progressively lighter. Some questions disappeared from the final summary. If this was an ordinary editorial process, why is there no note giving the reason for the revision?"

The officer from the lower commissionerate replied, "In our branch's regular process, when a serious objection is removed, some sign of a reason or approval generally remains. In this file, I did not find that sign."

"Then internal sabotage?"

The officer paused. "Not from that alone. The qualified non-apprehension of a reason-marker raises a question of procedural deviation. Whether someone knowingly sabotaged the process, exerted pressure, or acted on another person's instructions requires separate evidence."

Government counsel said, "But the reason-marker disappeared—"

An old sensitivity to words rose inside Shashank. He stopped himself at once. The judge looked towards the officer. The officer said, "It is proper to say the reason-marker disappeared only if it is first established that it had been recorded. What I am saying is this: something that should have been present under the process is not available. 'It was there before and later erased' is a separate claim."

The judge drew a line with his pen. "Qualified non-apprehension and an allegation of destruction are separate."

Raghav Bhasin now rose. He placed a sheet before Shashank. "No official access record for the sealed file has been found through your known identifiers. Should the court therefore conclude that the material did not go outside through you or anyone known to you?"

A ready-made defence rose inside Shashank—yes, conclude that. For months of humiliation he had been waiting to hear such a sentence. But his notebook stopped him.

He said, "No. I can say only this much: among the known official digital routes that were examined, no access record through that route was found. If it is separately established that the system recorded every possible route, then the non-apprehension becomes stronger. But if the system's capacity to record every other lawful or unlawful route is not established, this does not prove my complete innocence."

Government counsel looked slightly surprised. "You are weakening your own defence?"

Shashank said, "I am not weakening my defence. I am correcting the boundary of the statement."

For a moment the courtroom was silent. Raghav looked at him but did not intervene.

Government counsel raised the second question. "If there is no official access, but the news text is close to the sealed language, is the natural conclusion not that there was an informal, unauthorised dissemination?"

Aditya Mishra was sitting near the witness row. With the court's permission he said, "Textual proximity is a reason to investigate the source. But to identify a source person we need an independent link—communication, access, transfer, device evidence, or something similar. Similar language does not select the person by itself."

Government counsel asked, "And if no link is found?"

Aditya replied, "Then first we ask whether such a link was fit to be found. Some communication systems keep records; some do not. Some records survive only for a limited period. Before using non-apprehension, the retention policy, scope of the search, and reliability of the system must be established."

Shashank thought to himself—Navya-Nyaya was becoming not a weapon of defence but a discipline of sentences. Earlier he bent the edge of words to suit himself. Now every word was telling him its own boundary.

Government counsel lifted the third paper. "You have admitted that you softened some risk-related translations?"

"Yes."

"You sent exaggerated summaries such as 'the lawyer side has cleared it'?"

"Yes."

"You presented your access as broader than it really was?"

“Yes.”

“Then is it not possible that some language from the sealed material also went forward through you?”

Shashank took a long breath before answering. “The word possible has a very wide boundary. My earlier deceit raises questions about me; it does not establish this specific act. If the claim is that I forwarded sealed material, that claim requires appropriate evidence. And if such evidence is not found, the value of that non-apprehension depends first on establishing what signs ought to have existed.”

“So you neither admit nor completely deny?”

“I admit what I did. What I do not remember, or what is not established, I will not place on my head merely out of a feeling of atonement.”

The judge asked, “A feeling of atonement?”

For a moment the shame of so many previous episodes appeared on Shashank’s face. “I softened language. I boasted. I used proximity to famous people for my own prestige. I described limited access as though it were broad. I have atonement for all of that. But earlier I thought true atonement meant accepting every allegation. Now I understand that accepting an unproved allegation is also an escape from truth.”

Raghav turned the page slowly. “Then what does non-apprehension do within your atonement?”

Shashank said, “It teaches me not to make silence speak in my favour. What is not found should not become a servant for saying, ‘I am innocent.’ First ask whether it ought to have been findable.”

Government counsel turned again to the lower officer. “Your objection was reduced. There is no reason-note. The media wrote in your name that you later met at the banquet. Here there are contrary presence records. Putting all this together, would you say there was internal sabotage in the agency?”

The officer’s voice was steady. “I would say there are signs of cracks in the process. Contrary records rebut the specific media claim made about me. But the actor or purpose behind any internal sabotage is not established yet. If, because of my humiliation, I draw a larger conclusion than the evidence permits, I will commit the same error the media committed.”

Shashank kept looking at him. He saw his own reflection in the sentence. Humiliation gives a person two paths—either become a stricter servant of evidence, or turn one’s wound into evidence. The officer had chosen the first.

A technical officer was now called to court, one who understood only the general behaviour of the record systems. He explained that some access logs were retained for a fixed period, some systems had limited user-level detail, and some older records could be incomplete because of migration. He accused no particular person.

The judge asked, “So if an old record is not found = access did not occur?”

“No, Your Honour. First we must see whether that system at that time recorded that kind of access, what the retention period was, and whether the search was complete.”

“And if all three are established?”

“Then non-apprehension of the expected sign can significantly weaken the relevant claim.”

Government counsel said, “Weaken—not eliminate?”

“It depends on context. One must also see whether alternative routes were possible.”

The judge’s note was brief: “Non-apprehension is not nothing; neither is it omniscience.”

Shashank repeated the line inwardly. Non-apprehension is not nothing; neither is it omniscience. He remembered so many blank places in his own life—places where without evidence he had filled in his own importance, and places where after humiliation he had wanted to fill in other people’s conspiracies. In both places the blank had become a servant of his imagination.

In the second stage of cross-examination, government counsel produced Shashank’s old messages: “The matter has gone all the way up,” “I understand it from inside the system,” “Don’t worry, the path will be cleared.”

“Are these yours?”

“Yes, some are mine.”

“Then ‘inside’?”

“Very often boasting. Sometimes information at the linguistic or contact level. Those sentences were broader than my actual institutional access.”

“Why should the court not infer from these messages that you had an internal source?”

Shashank said, “The court may infer that I had some contacts and information sources. But if ‘internal source’ means an unauthorised source for the sealed file, an independent link is required. My boasting establishes authorship of the boast; it does not establish the sealed source.”

Government counsel asked, “And if no such link is found in the search?”

Shashank replied, “Then the same question returns—was it fit to be found? I cannot change the rule of non-apprehension for my own convenience.”

In Raghav's cross-examination, a subtler question arose. "If a reason-note for the revision was ordinarily required, but none exists in this file, is it not possible that the reason was oral?"

The officer said, "Possible. But in a formal process removing a serious objection, an oral reason alone is not the usual method. So the absence carries weight, but it does not establish the person or purpose behind any oral intervention."

Raghav asked again, "If an oral instruction was given, then perhaps no record of it would be expected?"

The officer said, "Then non-apprehension of a direct record becomes less useful; but other signs can still be sought—approval, later notes, meetings, communications, or conduct."

The judge said, "That is why non-apprehension must be read not alone, but within the evidentiary field."

During the lunch recess, Mrinal met Shashank outside the court. He asked, "You had the chance to end your defence by saying, 'Nothing was found.' Why didn't you?"

Shashank said, "Because from that day onward I would have become the old Shashank again—the man who turned an incomplete sentence into complete victory."

"And atonement?"

Shashank remained silent for a few moments. "Perhaps this is atonement: if a rule saves me, I must accept the same rule when it raises questions against me."

Mrinal said, "This time your philosophy is not your lawyer."

"No. Not the judge either. Only the boundary."

In the evening session, the court read its interim directions: a limited re-examination of available sources for the revision history; verification of the relevant retention policies; clarification of the archival capacity of the alleged official access route; an independent link before attaching a person's name to the textual source chain of the sealed material; and keeping specific media allegations separate from the original records.

At the end the judge said, "This order does not declare anyone guilty or exonerated. The court holds only that before absence becomes evidence, the expected presence of the missing sign must first be established."

As Shashank came out of court, he looked at the sky. The humiliation inside him had not diminished. Nor had the memory of his own deceit. But atonement no longer felt like self-punishment; it felt like the labour of cleaning language.

That night he opened his notebook.

"Non-apprehension = absence after establishing expected availability."

"No reason-note = process question; not automatically an erased reason."

"No official access record = weakens the claim through that established recorded route; does not negate every source."

"Textual proximity = source investigation; an independent link is required to identify a person."

"Boasting = evidence of state of mind and authorship; not of a specific confidential source."

"Contrary presence records = affirmative challenge to a specific claim."

"Incomplete record system = reduces the weight of non-apprehension."

"Atonement = accepting one's proved errors; not placing unproved crimes on one's own head."

"Navya-Nyaya = the rule that protects me is the same rule that examines me."

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: "Do not fill a blank space with desire; first ask whether a letter ought to have been there."

Closing the notebook, he remembered the court's next direction. The question of non-apprehension would now turn towards digital devices and statements—the old summons, seized devices, preserved copies, and the signs that either should or should not have remained. Shashank knew that in the next examination his ambition would again cast its digital shadow.

CHAPTER 8I

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 3

Three days after the court's previous direction, Shashank received another summons. This time the wording was more restricted than before—only material from the relevant period in the preserved digital copies of the old seized mobile phone and computer would be re-examined: the period in which the lower commissioner's objection, the final summary, the public rendering of sealed material, and Shashank's alleged "inside access" lay close to one another.

As he read the summons, the old voice of ambition rose inside Shashank again. At that time he had wanted clients, foreign acquaintances, organizers, and friends all to believe that his reach extended far beyond language. Now that same pride stood waiting for him as fixed letters in the digital copies.

When he reached the office, Aditya Mishra set the boundary in his very first sentence: "Today we are not searching the entire life of the devices. Only the period and subject authorised by the court. And one more thing—whatever is not found will not immediately be treated as proof of innocence. First we will ask whether that sign could reasonably have been expected to remain on this device."

The technical officer placed a verification summary of the sealed digital copies on the table. The original devices had not been reopened. The preserved copies, date of examination, search limits used, and list of available applications were on a separate sheet. Some old message histories were complete, some partial; the local record of one application survived only for a limited period.

Shashank said, "Then if nothing is found in that application, the weight of non-apprehension will be lower."

The technical officer said, "Correct. If preservation is incomplete, the meaning of absence is incomplete too. But where a medium is fully preserved, failure to find an expected sign carries a different weight."

The first search focused on Shashank's own name, general references to the lower commissioner, the tax-intelligence branch, "sealed", "above", "inside", and several predetermined phrases. The results produced a great deal of ordinary material—news clippings, public orders, service descriptions, linguistic notes he had made himself, and boasts exchanged with friends.

Aditya stopped at one message: "The matter has reached all the way up; don't worry."

"Yours?"

Shashank lowered his head. "Yes."

"Who did 'up' refer to?"

"At the time I wrote it deliberately vaguely. I wanted to look more influential than my actual authority allowed."

"Any specific officer?"

"Not from this sentence alone. As I remember it, there was talk at the time of a general contact channel, but I framed the language so that the reader would think I had direct institutional access."

Aditya said, "Ambition?"

"Yes. And deceit too. I used to create a fog around my limited information."

The technical officer opened the next result. One message had been sent after a public news report appeared: "See, the inside matter has come out." The timestamp was clear: two hours after the news had been published.

Aditya asked, "Proof of prior knowledge?"

Shashank said, "No. At least according to this timestamp, it is a reaction after seeing the news. But the language is again such that a reader could think I already knew the inside matter beforehand."

"Why did you write it?"

Shame appeared on Shashank's face. "Because I liked remaining, in other people's eyes, an 'inside man'. Language was my profession; performing influence was my vice."

The technical officer said, "Here non-apprehension is useful. If the claim is that before the news was published you had already received a copy of this particular sealed passage and communicated through this preserved medium, then one might expect some related sign in the pre-publication period. In this fully preserved message archive, no such direct passage was found."

Aditya did not draw an immediate conclusion. "But?"

“But this does not eliminate every possible medium. Another device, oral communication, an unavailable application, or an external medium remains a separate question. So it weakens the claim concerning this particular preserved route; it does not eliminate the entire possibility.”

Shashank wrote inwardly: non-apprehension also demands a boundary. How much an empty space can say depends on whether every door of the room was examined, or only one.

The second stage concerned statements. In an earlier summons, Shashank had said in one place: “I had no private contact with any officer.” The digital copies contained two short telephone contacts with a general number at a government office.

Aditya placed the paper before him. “Will you maintain that broad statement?”

Shashank remained silent for a long time. “No. It was too broad a denial. I was afraid that the moment any contact appeared, people would call it an ‘inside source’. So I made the truth smaller.”

“What were the two calls about?”

On the computer there was an old meeting invitation from the same day—scheduling for linguistic assistance. A public email list and the general subject of the meeting were available. Shashank said, “This was administrative scheduling contact. Calling it a private confidential source would be improper. But saying ‘no contact at all’ was also a false overstatement.”

Aditya wrote: “Statement revised: general administrative contact admitted; confidential internal source is a separate allegation.”

A bitter laugh rose inside Shashank. Earlier ambition had turned limited contact into a mountain; later fear wanted to call that same mountain nothing. Both times the truth had been crushed in the middle.

At that point Aditya raised an old media claim—that before the seizure Shashank had “deleted all messages”. The technical officer clarified that in the protected local copies for the specified period, no direct sign of a broad mass deletion had been found that would automatically support that claim. But the history of some applications was incomplete because of retention policies, and external storage or unsecured media lay outside the scope of these copies. Therefore saying “nothing was deleted” would also be too broad. If the allegation was specifically that the available local history on these preserved devices had been broadly cleared immediately before seizure, non-apprehension of the expected signs weakened that specific claim; it did not yield a final conclusion about every possible medium. Shashank said, “Earlier I would have called such an absence immediate victory. Today I would say only this: it is limited negative evidence, nothing more.”

Mrinal, who was present for the later part of the session because of witness recollection, said, “Your problem is always the same. Earlier you made your shadow larger than your body; now, to save the body, you want to say there is no shadow.”

Shashank looked at him. “Today, for the first time, I am saying—the shadow exists, but its size depends on the light.”

A slight smile appeared on Mrinal’s face. “This time it is not reasoning, but non-apprehension.”

“Non-apprehension also needs light.”

The third stage concerned files on the seized computer. There were many linguistic drafts created by Shashank—risk summaries, meeting notes, translations of public news, contract language, and some vendor lists. The name of one file itself sounded like one of his old boasts: “Route to the Top”. When opened, it contained no confidential government instructions, but a Chinese-English glossary of public procedures and Shashank’s own notes.

Aditya asked, “Why such a name?”

Shashank said, “The name too was part of the performance. I used to give my files titles that made me feel important to myself.”

“Then the non-apprehension inside the name?”

“The allegedly confidential material one might expect from the title was not found inside—this is a useful fact regarding this particular file. But it does not establish that nothing existed anywhere else.”

The technical officer nodded. “That is the correct boundary.”

In another draft, three sentences drew special attention: “The objection is still open”, “Beneficial ownership verification pending”, “No hard conclusion until the final summary arrives.” The language resembled the lower commissioner’s initial caution, but the file’s creation time was after the relevant public records had become available.

Aditya asked, “If someone looked only at textual similarity?”

Shashank replied, “They could say I had an internal copy. But the timestamp and public availability show an alternative source. Here the absence of a pre-publication copy is important—if the first creation date in the preserved file is reliable.”

“And if the date could have been altered?”

The technical officer said, "Then a single date is not decisive. That is why the timeline is checked across multiple sources."

Aditya turned back to Shashank. "What does your ambition establish here?"

Shashank said, "That I wanted to appear influential. That I chose vague language. That I enlarged some lawful contacts when speaking of them. All that makes me suspect; it does not by itself establish the specific act of stealing and passing on sealed material."

"And non-apprehension?"

"If a sign corresponding to the allegation should ordinarily have remained in this preserved medium and is not found, the weight of the allegation falls. If the medium is incomplete, the absence is weaker. If contrary positive evidence appears, the role of absence changes again."

Before the session ended, Aditya read a short summary: the digital copies contained numerous exaggerated messages by Shashank; general administrative contacts were present; no pre-publication copy of the sealed material or sign of direct transfer had been found in the specified fully preserved routes; some media were incomplete, so absence did not justify a universal conclusion; the statement "no contact at all" was revised; an independent link remained necessary for the specific allegation of internal sabotage.

Shashank said, "Add one thing to that summary—I wrote sentences to inflate my own importance, and those sentences later became soil for accusations. That is my responsibility."

Aditya asked, "Responsibility for false allegations too?"

"No. Whoever enlarged an accusation without evidence bears responsibility for that. But my deceit gave them an opportunity—I will not evade that moral part."

Walking out with Mrinal in the evening, Shashank said, "Ambition is a strange thing. Earlier I wanted people to say—this man knows everything. Now the investigation asks—if you knew everything, where are the signs?"

Mrinal said, "And your answer?"

"Whatever signs exist are signs of my boasting. What does not exist depends on context. An empty space does not make me a god; it does not make me an innocent god either."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Summons = order for investigation; not declaration of guilt."
 "Digital seizure = preservation of available media; not a complete replica of every possible life."
 "No expected direct sign in a fully preserved medium = may weaken a specific claim."
 "Absence in an incomplete medium = limited non-apprehension."
 "'Inside matter' written after publication = not prior knowledge automatically."
 "General administrative contact = not confidential internal source; but 'no contact at all' is an erroneous statement."
 "Ambitious file name = state of mind; contents require separate examination."
 "Similar language created after public sources became available = not automatically a confidential pre-publication copy."
 "My deceit = my responsibility; another person's false allegation = separate responsibility."
 "Non-apprehension = absence has meaning only when expected presence and reliability of the search are clear."

Shashank stopped while writing the final line: "In the performance of influence I filled the air around myself with too much noise; now the investigation is searching within that noise for the genuine silence."

Before closing the notebook he remembered the last open file from the computer examination. It contained several drafts of vendor-related contracts, a service chain, and a box: "Ultimate beneficial owner: verification pending." No owner's name had been found in the digital copy. But the new lesson of non-apprehension made him cautious—name not found = no owner was not a valid conclusion. The next inquiry would have to ask, in the questions of contracts, vendor paths, and actual beneficial ownership, where a name ought to have appeared—and where it did not.

CHAPTER 82

THE AGENCY THAT COMPROMISED

The last line was still fresh inside Shashank—the digital copy contained the words “Ultimate beneficial owner: verification pending,” but no name. Earlier, whenever he saw such a blank, he would fill it with pride in his own knowledge; now the lesson of non-apprehension stopped him. Name not found = no owner was not a valid conclusion. The question was this: if the owner’s identity had actually been verified, where should the ordinary documentary signs of that verification have been expected to appear?

In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today only contracts, the vendor path, ownership declarations, and the agency’s documentary sequence. No person’s name will be added by inference.”

The officer from the lower commissionerate was also present in the office. Four files from separate sources lay on the table—the event vendor’s contract, details of the service recipient, the declaration of the paying entity, and the tax-intelligence branch’s verification list. Aditya first recorded the independence of the sources, then said, “The same blank does not mean the same thing in four different documents. First determine what each document is capable of proving.”

The first contract clearly identified the event vendor. The second page gave the name of the service-providing entity, the scope of work, and the nature of the fee. The third showed the declared directors of the paying company. But in the box marked “actual beneficial owner” were the words: “verification pending.”

Looking at the page, Shashank said, “I have translated this phrase so many times.”

Aditya asked, “And what did it mean in your mind at the time?”

Shashank was slightly embarrassed. “The literal meaning was clear—the ultimate beneficial ownership had not yet been established. But in front of clients I often spoke as though I privately knew the actual owner and only the formal paperwork remained.”

“Did you know?”

“I had heard some names, seen some acquaintances, inferred some relationships. Saying ‘I know’ was too much.”

The lower commissionerate officer opened an old note: “Re-examine after receipt of beneficial-ownership declaration, identity verification, and supporting records of the ownership chain.” A date appeared below the note; beside it was a list of materials received. The list contained the contract, director details, and service details, but no supporting ownership declaration.

Aditya said, “Whose non-apprehension do we have now?”

Shashank replied, “That of the ownership declaration. But it carries weight only if it is established that such a declaration was requested, that the prescribed procedure required it to be kept in this file, and that the file was sufficiently preserved.”

The officer said, “The request letter is available. The receipt list is available. The rule assigning a separate attachment number to material of this category is also available.”

Aditya lifted the next page. “Was there any attachment number?”

“No,” the officer said. “At least in the protected register there is no separate attachment number for an ownership declaration accompanying this contract.”

Shashank said, “Then the claim ‘the declaration arrived and was later torn out’ is weakened, because if it had actually been received, one would ordinarily expect some trace of receipt or attachment.”

Aditya added, “Weakened—not eliminated.”

“Yes. If someone took the paper outside the system, or if it was never registered, the absence is not decisive. But that would require independent evidence.”

At this point the question of the tax-intelligence branch’s alleged compromise arose again. The public narrative said that the agency knew the beneficial owner’s name but suppressed it because of an internal compromise. Aditya read the sentence and said, “That is an allegation. Now let us see what the record should contain if ‘the agency knew’ were true.”

A general verification-process checklist was placed on the table—beneficial-ownership declaration, supporting identity material, ownership percentage or basis of control, review note, and final status. In the protected file for this matter there was a review note, but it said “verification pending”. The final ownership status had not been filled in.

Shashank said softly, "If the agency had formally verified the owner, then in this kind of process one would ordinarily expect at least some sign of a final status or supporting material."

The officer said, "There is none here."

"Then the claim 'formal verification had already been completed' is weakened."

Aditya asked, "There was no actual owner at all?"

Shashank almost answered immediately, then stopped. "That is not the conclusion. Who actually controlled the company is a separate question. All that can be said here is this: formal verification is not established in the protected agency record."

Aditya smiled. "What would the old Shashank have said?"

"He would have said—I know the name."

"And now?"

"Now I say—I had heard some names; a heard name ≠ a verified beneficial owner."

There was an old wound to his pride in language inside that admission. Shashank remembered that after the banquet he had boasted to a client: "Write whatever you like on the paper; I understand who the real owner is." Aditya pulled that very message from the digital copy and placed it on the table.

"Yours?"

"Yes."

"Who was the real owner?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "There is no name in this message. In a few later messages two or three people are referred to, but there is no clear declaration of ownership. I merged relationship, influence, language, and proximity and used the word 'owner' for all of them."

"A linguistic error?"

"Not merely an error. I knowingly chose a heavy word for prestige."

The lower commissionerate officer said, "That distinction matters. A mistaken translation is one thing; knowing the proper boundary of a word and still giving it a broader meaning for effect is another."

Shashank admitted, "Yes. My talent made me understand subtle differences between words. That gives me less excuse in some places."

Aditya wrote that sentence into the statement, but immediately added the next limit: "Shashank's exaggerated statement 'I know the real owner' establishes his state of mind and claim; it does not establish the actual identity of the alleged owner."

Then an unusual absence appeared in the vendor path. Documents were available from the event entity to the service vendor, and from the service vendor to the paying entity. But for the entity described in the public report as the "ultimate foreign controlling entity", no direct contract, letter of authority, or ownership declaration was found in the protected file.

Aditya asked, "What does this non-apprehension tell us?"

Shashank said, "First we must ask whether it is reasonable to expect such a direct document to exist. The relationship may have been indirect; control may have operated through ownership rather than through contract. In that case, failure to find a direct contract would say very little."

"And if the report claims that this very entity directly issued payment instructions?"

"Then the expectation of independent signs becomes stronger—messages of instruction, letters of authority, approvals, or accounting references. If a reliable search finds none of those, the claim of direct instruction is weakened."

Without opening the actual operational details of the payments, Aditya showed only the documentary summary. The service basis for some payments was clear; supporting pages for others were incomplete. He said, "Incomplete ≠ crime. But incomplete ≠ complete verification either."

Shashank said, "Non-apprehension restrains me in both directions. What has no proof should not be called established. But where a document has not been found, I must not fill the blank with whichever name I prefer."

At that point one line from an old message from Mrinal appeared: "You keep saying you know all the names, but have you seen the papers?" Shashank smiled faintly as he read it.

Aditya asked, "Your reply?"

In the digital copy, Shashank's reply was: "Papers later; know the people first."

Mrinal was not present, but his old caution echoed in the room. Shashank said, "That sentence sounds harsher to me today. I was trying to give personal acquaintance the place of documentary proof."

"Pride in language?"

“Yes. I thought that if I could catch people’s subtle signals through language, then I had understood the structure as well. In reality, understanding conversation is a talent; establishing beneficial ownership is a separate method.”

Shashank added, “The word ‘owner’ itself does not always have one meaning. Sometimes it means legal ownership, sometimes actual control, sometimes merely an influential person. I knew these distinctions, yet in boasting I compressed all of them into one word. Now the meaning of every claim must be separated.” Aditya wrote: “Linguistic skill reveals boundaries; knowingly erasing a boundary is a separate moral responsibility.”

The lower commissionerate officer took out his old resistance note. It said: “Final conclusion on vendor path deferred pending ownership verification.” Aditya asked, “Was this line in the later summary?”

“In shortened form,” the officer said, “but no final name appears anywhere.”

Shashank said, “Then the absent name in this line is itself significant. It is not established that the officer was hiding a name; on the contrary, the line says verification was incomplete.”

Aditya cautioned him again: “‘No name’ also does not automatically mean ‘no one hid anything’.”

“Correct. If improper pressure is alleged, independent signs of pressure are needed—instructions, benefit, unusual contact, intervention in the version, or other consistent evidence. A blank ownership box alone does not establish pressure.”

By evening the investigation summary was prepared: vendor contracts were available; some service relationships were clear; beneficial-ownership verification was marked pending; the request letter was available, but no supporting ownership declaration was marked in the protected receipt register; no independent record of direct instruction or ownership by the alleged ultimate controlling entity was found in this file; Shashank’s statement “I understand who the real owner is” was available, but there was no named evidence supporting it.

Aditya asked, “Among all this, what is your responsibility?”

Shashank said, “I increased my own importance by claiming to know what I did not know. That is moral deceit. I softened risk-related words in some service descriptions—that is a separate responsibility. But nothing so far shows that I had verified the name of the beneficial owner.”

“Had the agency compromised?”

Shashank looked at the officer, then at the papers. “At present, that is an allegation. Some procedural blanks raise questions; failure to find some expected signs weakens certain claims; but proving that someone knowingly compromised the process requires independent evidence.”

The officer said, “For me it is enough that my ‘verification pending’ is not turned into ‘verification completed’.”

A strange calm came over Shashank at that sentence. For years he had filled blank spaces with the speed of language; today language was teaching him the discipline of leaving a blank blank.

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Vendor path = record of service relationships; not independent proof of ultimate ownership.”

“Beneficial owner: verification pending = name unknown / incomplete verification; not ‘there is no owner’.”

“Request letter + receipt register + prescribed attachment procedure, but expected declaration not found = weakens the claim ‘the declaration had already been received’.”

“Blank box = not automatically pressure or internal sabotage.”

“‘I know the real owner’ = my boast; not named ownership evidence.”

“Understanding language = catching relational signals; proving beneficial ownership is a separate evidentiary method.”

“Claim of direct controller = ordinarily requires independent signs of instruction, authority, ownership, or benefit.”

“Non-apprehension = weight of an absent expected sign; the expectation itself must first be established.”

“My pride = may prove my own deceit; not another person’s crime.”

As he wrote the last line, Shashank stopped: “Earlier I filled a blank ownership box with a name; now I ask whether the rules required a name to be there.”

He closed the notebook. He remembered the heading on Aditya’s next file—payment gateway, intermediary accounts, hawala reference, digital asset, and an old message from a friend. After the blank ownership in the contracts, the next question would concern the signs found and not found along the path of money.

CHAPTER 83

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 5

The last line was still open in Shashank's notebook—after the blank ownership field in the contracts, the next question would concern the signs found and not found along the path of money. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today: the payment gateway, alleged intermediary accounts, hawala references, digital assets, and old messages connected with friendship. No operational method; only relationships, expected signs, and the limits of non-apprehension.”

When Shashank reached the office, Mrinal Karn was already seated there. Five separate files lay on the table—a lawful banquet-related reimbursement, the consolidated payment-gateway summary, abbreviated identifiers for several accounts, an investigative note containing the words hawala/digital asset, and old messages between Shashank and Mrinal. Aditya fixed the boundary in his first sentence: “Friendship is neither proof of guilt nor a defence. Today we will see whether the expected links exist.”

Shashank looked at Mrinal. In the previous episodes he had learned that Mrinal's name had to be kept separate from his own story. Once he had used his friend's presence to enhance his credibility. Now that same friendship sat before the papers as an independent person.

The first page concerned a lawful reimbursement. On the day of the banquet, Mrinal had paid some local travel and guest-assistance expenses; later the organizer side reimbursed that limited expenditure. The date, purpose, and receipt references were available. Aditya asked, “Any dispute about this relationship?”

Mrinal said, “No. I was reimbursed for expenses I had paid. That is all.”

Aditya opened the second page. It contained an abbreviated identifier resembling “M.K.-2”, but no full name. In an old investigative note the entry had been placed within a group labelled “possible intermediary account”.

Shashank said, “We have seen the question of these initials before. M.K. alone does not establish Mrinal.”

“And what does non-apprehension add now?” Aditya asked.

Shashank read the investigative checklist in the margin—verification of the account-holder's identity, purpose, beneficiary relationship, source of instructions, unusual contacts, and questions of benefit. “If the claim is that this was a front account knowingly used by Mrinal, one would ordinarily expect some independent sign connecting it to him—identity, instructions, benefit, contact, or at least some economic context separate from the lawful reimbursement. Is there such a link in the protected file?”

Aditya showed the pages one by one. “Not so far. The lawful reimbursement link is separate. The full identity behind M.K.-2 is not in this file.”

Mrinal said in a slightly harder voice, “Then why did my name keep circling?”

Aditya replied, “Because the initials matched and you are Shashank's close friend. That can be a reason to investigate; it is not a conclusion.”

Old shame rose inside Shashank. “I am partly responsible too,” he said. “After the banquet I often told people, ‘Mrinal knows everything.’ In reality you did not know many things.”

Mrinal looked at him. “Did you make me a friend, or a seal for your story?”

The question went straight into Shashank. “Many times, a seal,” he said. “When I wanted to make my role look larger, I would invoke your presence. That made people think there was another witness to what I was saying.”

“And the financial matters?”

“You did not know all of them. Some banquet expenses, some guest assistance—that was all. I never explained to you the full meaning of the payment-gateway material, the hawala references, or the digital-asset terms that surfaced later.”

Aditya recorded the admission separately: “Prestige-based use of a friend's presence admitted; economic participation does not follow automatically.”

The third file contained a consolidated payment-gateway summary. Numerous service vendors and payment headings had been compressed into one place. For some entries, the underlying service records were available; for others, the supporting pages were incomplete. In public allegations, this consolidated summary had been called a “mule chain”.

Aditya asked, “If the whole group were in fact a knowingly operated chain of front accounts, what would you expect to find?”

Shashank said, “Not necessarily the same sign in every account. But for a group-level claim there should be at least some consistent independent evidence—account-holder roles, instructions, beneficiary relationships, unusual coordination, or support for a common purpose. A name appearing in one payment gateway ≠ a front account.”

“And if no such signs are found?”

“First see whether the records are complete. If the searchable sources are preserved and the expected links are absent, the claim is weakened. If the underlying detail itself is unavailable, saying ‘there is no link’ would go too far; the correct statement is only, ‘No link was found in the protected records available to us.’”

Mrinal said, “That distinction is what keeps a name from becoming a verdict.”

At this point Aditya produced an old internal summary. Three separate entries had been placed under one heading: “close circle of friends”. But no such category appeared in the protected underlying table; there were only separate entries. Nor did the lower commissionerate officer’s note contain the phrase “circle of friends”.

“Who added this heading?” Mrinal asked.

Aditya said, “The author is not established yet. If this was a formal analytical category, one would ordinarily expect a basis note, analyst name, or source reference. No such support was found with the protected copy.”

Shashank said, “Then ‘circle of friends’ is itself a statement, not an underlying fact. The absence of support for that heading reduces the weight of the claim.”

Aditya did not answer immediately; then he said slowly, “But again, keep the boundary. It may have been an informal working heading for which no separate note was mandatory. Therefore no supporting note found ≠ the heading was knowingly fabricated.”

Mrinal placed not his thumb but the tip of his pen on the page. “Sometimes a single heading can change a person’s life.”

Shashank replied, “Language brought me close to the same kind of wrongdoing. Earlier I made one word heavier to enlarge my importance; someone else can make one heading heavier and turn three separate entries into one story. In both cases the question is the same—what supports the word?”

Shashank answered, “Not a name—the size of the truth is what survives.”

The fourth page concerned the hawala reference. There was no operational method, only an old investigative note: “Suspicion of alternative settlement relating to funds; independent confirmation required.” Beneath it were categories of expected confirmation—clear identification of the relevant parties, an independent economic link, a consistent chronology, and beneficiary verification. The protected file showed some temporal proximity, but the clear beneficiary link remained incomplete.

Aditya asked, “The allegation?”

Shashank said, “In the investigative note, hawala appears as a suspicion. Not as an established fact. If a public report says ‘hawala established’, that is a heavier statement than the source text.”

“Non-apprehension?”

“If the allegation concerns a particular person, failure to find the expected independent link connecting that person is significant. But with an informal structure such as hawala, the assumption that every sign must necessarily appear in formal records is itself unproved. So the weight of absence is limited and context-dependent.”

Aditya nodded. “That is the difficulty in this section. Where something may exist outside the records, non-apprehension speaks more softly.”

The fifth page concerned a digital-asset reference. An old summary mentioned an identifier resembling an address, but the protected file contained no direct verification of its ownership. Some media reports had already linked it to Shashank by name.

Reading the page, Shashank said, “I cannot say I owned this digital identifier. On what basis was my name attached to it?”

Aditya said, “In one old message you wrote: ‘I understand the digital route too.’”

Shashank closed his eyes and laughed faintly, but the laugh carried shame. “The same boasting again. I understood terminology; I translated; I heard some general discussions. Later ‘I understand’ became ‘I operate’.”

“If you really had been the operator of that digital asset?”

Shashank replied, “Then one might expect at least some direct sign of control, ownership verification, benefit, instruction, or a clear connection on the protected devices—if those devices and sources were adequate for such a search. So far the seizure examination has not shown such a direct sign.”

“Then you are innocent?”

“Not from this one absence. Only this particular allegation remains unsupported at present.”

Mrinal said, “You would not have answered like that before.”

“Earlier I either denied everything in self-defence or claimed everything out of pride.”

“And now?”

“Only as much as is found. As for what is not found, it becomes non-apprehension only when a proper expectation that it should have been found is established.”

In the afternoon Aditya opened an old message from Mrinal: “If you understand the money path, draw it on paper.” Shashank’s reply at the time had been: “Papers do not show everything; I know the people.”

Mrinal said, “That is why I kept warning you. You saw relationships and immediately assumed a structure.”

Shashank said softly, “And I placed your name among those relationships to increase my own credibility.”

“In what record will the accounting for that use of friendship appear?”

“In no bank page. In my memory and in my admission.”

Aditya stopped writing there. “Not every truth lives in an economic record. But a moral admission cannot take the place of proof of an economic offence either.”

By evening the summary was prepared: Mrinal’s lawful reimbursement was established; the full identity behind the alleged M.K.-2 entry was not in the protected file; no independent economic link connecting it to Mrinal had been found; some supporting records for the consolidated payment-gateway entries were complete and some incomplete; matching initials or consolidated payments alone were insufficient for the claim of a “mule chain”; the hawala reference remained at the level of suspicion, with the beneficiary link incomplete; a digital-asset identifier was available, but Shashank’s ownership or direct control was not verified in this file.

Aditya looked at Mrinal. “What do you want recorded in the statement?”

Mrinal said, “Only what I know. Also that Shashank often used my name to increase his credibility. But do not place on my head, because of friendship, money, accounts, or digital things I did not know about.”

Shashank said, “And if independent evidence is ever found?”

Mrinal replied, “Then friendship will not stop the evidence.”

Shashank’s throat did not tighten; this time the emotion was calm. Friendship did not promise to save him, only to measure correctly. He understood: a true friend is not someone who fills a blank with words on your side; a true friend is someone who says, ‘My knowledge ends here.’

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Lawful reimbursement = limited economic relationship; not automatically a front account.”

“Same initials = not the same person.”

“Alleged intermediary/mule role = requires independent signs such as identity + instructions/benefit/relationship.”

“Consolidated payment-gateway entry = not automatically one criminal chain.”

“Hawala suspicion = not established hawala.”

“Digital-asset identifier = not Shashank’s ownership without an independent sign of control.”

“Non-apprehension = reliable search + reasonable expectation + absence; absence in an incomplete source carries less weight.”

“Using a friend’s presence for prestige = my moral deceit; not my friend’s economic guilt.”

“Friendship = not a substitute for evidence; courage to accept the boundary of evidence.”

As he wrote the last line, Shashank reread Mrinal’s old sentence: “Draw it on paper.” He wrote: “Earlier I looked at people’s faces and drew a path; now, if the path is not found, I will not make the people guilty.”

He closed the notebook. The heading on Aditya’s next file was: foreign travel, Macao meeting, special access, system records. The measure of friendship had become clear; in the next examination greed would return—this time with the question: if the alleged broad server control were true, what expected digital signs ought necessarily to have remained?

CHAPTER 84

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 6

The last line was still open in Shashank's notebook—if the alleged broad server control were true, what expected digital signs ought necessarily to have remained? In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: "Today: foreign travel, the Macao meeting, special access, and system records. The question is not whether you went there; the question is what the real boundary of 'special access' was, and what signs would be expected if the claim of broad control were true."

This time there were no glittering banquet photographs on the office table, only the travel records: flight details, hotel records, the external timeline of the meeting, visitor-pass entries, a temporary access list, and a limited extract from the protected system records. Aditya began: "Foreign travel is not a crime. Presence at a meeting is not a crime either. But if the claim is that the journey was for broad control of a system, we will also look for the signs that ought to accompany such a claim."

As soon as Shashank saw the Macao dates, he remembered his old state of mind. He had received applause on the banquet stage; not long after came the foreign trip. Li Wenchao had once said, "This time you will see the work inside." In Shashank's mind the word "inside" had become "important". Language had brought him as far as the door of the room; greed had filled him with the fantasy that once he crossed the door, the whole building would be his.

Aditya placed his thumb on the travel list. "You went?"

"Yes."

"You were at the meeting?"

"Yes. For linguistic assistance and in connection with some presentations."

"Special access?"

Shashank paused. "I received temporary access in a visitor category. More than an ordinary guest, less than a permanent officer. At the time I treated it as a very big thing."

"Server control?"

"On the evidence presently available, it would not be proper to call it broad control."

Aditya opened the second page. The heading read: "Access category: limited demonstration / linguistic support." A time limit appeared beside it. The box for permanent user identity was blank. In the administrative-role box was written: "No."

Shashank stared at the page for a long time. "I did not see it this clearly before."

"Is the paper new?"

"No. My vision is new."

"Meaning?"

"At the time, the word 'special' sounded louder to me than all the others. 'Limited', 'temporary', 'linguistic support'—all of those seemed small."

Aditya asked, "Why?"

"Greed. Not only for money. The greed to be called an insider."

Shashank's voice was low in that admission. He remembered an old message sent to Mrinal from Macao: "This time I saw not the outside desk, but the panel inside." Mrinal had replied: "Saw it = operated it?"

Aditya had printed that very message. "What was your answer to Mrinal's question then?"

Shashank read the page. "I wrote: 'Few people understand the difference.' I evaded the answer."

"Why?"

"Because saying 'I operated it' would have been false, while saying 'I only saw it' would have made me look small."

Aditya stopped writing. "That sentence matters. Fear of looking small and greed to look large both change language."

Shashank said, "Yes. I knew the boundary, but I did not want to reveal it."

The third record on the table was the system-access summary. Some dates were complete; some portions were incomplete because of the age of the records. In the protected material that remained, Shashank's name did not appear as a permanent administrative user. One temporary visitor identity matched the meeting time. The class of material viewable through that identity was limited.

Aditya asked, “Non-apprehension?”

Shashank replied, “First establish the fitness of the expected sign. If broad server control is alleged, one might ordinarily expect a permanent or high-privilege identity, approval for privilege elevation, an administrative-role entry, signs of regular use, instructions, or some comparable link. But not every system records everything in the same way, and an older period may be incomplete. So absence in the available portion can reduce the weight of the claim; it cannot make it wholly impossible.”

“And in the portion that is complete?”

“There the weight of non-apprehension is greater—if it is established that a high-privilege event of this kind would ordinarily and reliably have been recorded.”

Aditya read a verification summary from a technical officer. It said that during the preserved period of the meeting, records of high-privilege changes were automatically retained; no sign of such a change appeared under Shashank’s name or temporary identity.

“What follows from that?” Aditya asked.

Shashank said, “For this specific period, the claim ‘I was given high administrative privileges’ is weakened. But it does not mean I was not at the meeting. Nor does it mean I did not receive limited access and view material.”

“Meaning?”

“Presence established. Limited access established. The expected signs of broad authority are absent from this preserved period.”

Aditya nodded. “That is non-apprehension—expectation before absence.”

In the afternoon an old presentation summary was placed on the table. In Shashank’s translated heading, he had used “management panel” instead of “administrative panel”. He said, “I chose that word.”

“Why?”

“The audience was not technical. I wanted to give a general meaning.”

“Does that word increase your authority?”

“No.”

“Reduce it?”

“No. The word is only a description. Authority is a separate question for the records.”

On the next page Aditya showed one of Shashank’s old messages: “Now I understand the real panel from inside.”

Shashank’s face flushed. “That was boasting.”

“‘Understand’ or ‘control’?”

“I wrote ‘understand’. Later people turned the sentence into ‘he operated the internal system’.”

“Why did you not make that distinction clear at the time?”

“Because I liked being called an ‘insider’.”

Aditya said, “Then greed was not only about money.”

“No. Prestige, access, secrecy, a place among select people—all of those were forms of greed too.”

After that sentence, silence filled the room. Shashank understood that if he minimized his own moral error, the doctrine of non-apprehension would become merely a tactic of defence. He added of his own accord, “I will not say that because signs of broad authority are absent, my conduct was therefore innocent. I knowingly described limited access as something larger. That deceit is separate.”

Aditya said, “Correct. Moral deceit ≠ administrative control; but the deceit is real.”

Then came the page concerning travel expenses. One portion had been borne by the vendor side; another was marked as event-related service reimbursement. Aditya asked, “If someone paid for your foreign trip, what does that establish?”

Shashank said, “An economic relationship. But payment ≠ ownership or server control. The nature of the travel work, contract, instructions, and actual benefit require separate examination.”

“Greed?”

“The fact that the trip was free or convenient was attractive too. I treated the convenience as proof of my importance.”

“What do the papers say?”

“That part of the travel expenditure was borne in a service context. They do not say ‘important officer’.”

Aditya now placed a disputed allegation before him—an old media line: “Indian coordinator given full access up to the server room in Macao.”

Shashank looked at it questioningly. “What is the original source of the phrase ‘server room’?”

Aditya said, "Not clear at present. The available travel records refer to a 'system demonstration area' and a 'meeting area'. No supporting record for the words 'full access' has yet been found."

"Then a false allegation?"

"For now, say: support is incomplete. If no reliable source chain is found, and the records we do have show limited access, the public claim is weakened. But the source inquiry continues."

Shashank said, "I want the statement to make this clear. I myself wrote 'inside panel'. My boast may have become the seed for a journalist's phrase 'full access', but seed $\neq$ truth of the whole sentence."

Aditya said, "And not authorship either."

"Yes."

Aditya showed another visitor record. Entry into the meeting building was fully logged, but there was no rule requiring separate logging for every interior area. Only one sensitive area required an access entry. The public article claimed that Shashank had reached that area. Aditya asked, "How much weight does non-apprehension carry here?"

Shashank read the rule. "If entry into this area required a mandatory log, and the log for this date is completely preserved, the absence of my name is significant. But only for the claim about this specific area. It does not establish that I never went into other parts of the building."

"And if someone says your name was deliberately removed?"

"Then we need independent signs of removal—revision history, an anomalous gap, a conflicting copy, or other evidence. Name not found = name was erased would be a reversed inference."

Aditya said, "Correct. Non-apprehension must never become a device for filling an empty space with a crime." At that, Shashank remembered his own old habit—he himself had filled empty spaces with importance. Now he had to learn the discipline of leaving a blank space blank.

By evening three categories had been created. First—established: foreign travel, Macao meeting, temporary special access, linguistic/presentation support, partial payment of travel expenses, Shashank's self-promotional messages. Second—unsupported or incomplete: permanent administrative role, broad server control, the public claim of "full access", signs of high-privilege change. Third—open questions because of incomplete sources: some older system records, the source of the public wording, and all sub-details of the meeting.

Aditya asked, "In these three categories, where does your greed belong?"

Shashank said, "Inside the first category. I went, became a special guest, received limited access, received facilities, and turned all of that into a story about my importance. Greed is not outside the evidence; but the existence of greed is not proof of broad server control."

"And non-apprehension?"

"Against the claims in the second category—where the rule concerning expected signs is established. In the third category, caution—because the sources are incomplete."

Aditya wrote: "Non-apprehension = not silence; silence against a rule-governed expectation."

As he left the office, Shashank remembered the glass elevator in the Macao hotel. Watching the city lights while rising, he had thought: the higher I go, the further inside I go. Today he understood—height and authority are different things. Sometimes only the elevator rises; the mind turns it into power.

That night he spoke with Mrinal. Mrinal asked, "So did you have special access or not?"

Shashank said, "I did. But special $\neq$ unlimited."

"Why did you not say that then?"

"Because stating the boundary would have made the story smaller."

"And you wanted the story to be large."

"Yes."

Mrinal was silent for a few moments. "And now?"

"Now a small truth is more bearable than a large falsehood."

"Is that atonement?"

Shashank said, "Perhaps the beginning. Atonement will be when I accept a boundary when it saves me, and also when the same boundary makes me responsible."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Foreign travel = not a crime."

"Presence at a meeting = not server control."

"Special access = not unlimited authority."

"Temporary visitor identity = not permanent administrative role."

"High-privilege claim = test by qualified non-apprehension only when such privilege would ordinarily leave reliable records."

“Expected sign absent from a complete-period record = reduces the weight of the claim.”

“Absence in an incomplete period = limited weight.”

“My boasting = evidence of greed and self-promotion; not of literal control.”

“Payment of travel expenses = economic relationship; ownership or system authority is a separate question.”

“Public claim of ‘full access’ = requires an independent source.”

“Non-apprehension = absence, after a reliable search, of something fit to be found; absence of what would not ordinarily be recorded is not evidence.”

“Greed = knowing a boundary and writing it smaller; truth = statement only as large as the boundary.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I had gone inside; I was not the owner of the inside.”

He closed the notebook. The heading on Aditya’s next file was: legal consultation, privilege, alleged participation in crime. After greed, the next emotion would be fear. The question would again be this: if lawyer and translator had together planned a crime, what expected signs would cross the boundary of legal confidentiality and appear in independent business or operational records?

CHAPTER 8

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 7

The last question kept circling inside Shashank all night—if lawyer and translator had together planned a crime, what expected signs would cross the boundary of legal confidentiality and appear in independent business or operational records? In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today we will not open the substance of legal advice. We will examine the external timeline, the roles of participants, separate business messages, payment or instruction links, and non-apprehension in the records.”

Raghav Bhasin was already seated in the office. There was no thick legal file on the table, only a thin timeline. Beside it was written clearly: “Privileged substance not displayed.” Shashank felt slightly at ease when he saw the line, then fear rose immediately. In his old messages he had often compressed complex caution into short phrases—“legal side clear”, “lawyer agrees”, “we can proceed.” Now those little sentences felt heavy against him.

Aditya began, “Legal confidentiality protects against two errors. First—opening protected advice for the convenience of an investigation. Second—seeing confidentiality and assuming that a crime must be hidden inside it. Today we will do neither.”

Raghav said, “And there is a third error—seeing a lawyer’s name copied somewhere and treating every message as privileged. Business instructions, event organization, payments, service coordination, or ordinary introductions do not become legal advice merely because a lawyer is present.”

Shashank said, “And if a translator like me writes, ‘the lawyer agrees’, that is not automatically the lawyer’s official statement.”

Aditya looked at him. “It is easy to say that now. Why did you write it then?”

Shashank’s throat dried. “Because I valued a short answer too highly. Clients grew impatient with complex cautions. I wanted my translation to sound decisive. The old disease of attaching power to talent.”

The first record was from after the Macao trip. On one date there was a legal consultation; later that same day, in a separate business group, a short message appeared: “Legal side clear, move the process forward.” The substance of the legal advice was not opened. Aditya showed only the time. “Is this business message yours?”

“Yes.”

“Source of the sentence?”

“My interpretation.”

Raghav said calmly, “I can confirm only that legal consultation took place. Whether ‘everything is clear’ was my wording cannot be answered without opening privileged substance. But as a general principle, legal caution is often conditional; complete commercial approval is a separate matter.”

Shashank lowered his eyes. “I shortened the conditions.”

Aditya asked, “Deceit?”

Shashank was silent for a few moments. “In some places, yes. I knew the boundary of the words, but out of greed to make my usefulness look greater I wrote broader sentences. That is a moral error. But it does not prove that the lawyer participated in a crime.”

“And you?”

“My linguistic deceit may be established. Economic or operational participation requires separate evidence.”

Aditya opened a second table. Its heading was: “Expected independent signs of alleged joint plan.” Beneath it were five categories: operational instructions outside legal advice; distribution of money or sharing of benefit; source indicators for confidential government material; administrative access or control rights; non-legal messages allocating crime-specific tasks. Beside each category was space for available / unavailable / incomplete.

Looking at the page, Shashank said, “This is the test of non-apprehension.”

Aditya said, “Yes, but carefully. If the alleged participation was of a kind that would ordinarily leave independent operational records, then after a reliable search their absence can reduce the weight of the allegation. But if communication could have been oral, the record system incomplete, or some media unavailable to the investigation, the weight of absence falls.”

In the first category, “ordinary business coordination” was marked available; beside crime-specific instruction was written: “not found so far.” In the second, records of Shashank’s service fee were available; sharing of benefit or a share in criminal proceeds—“not found.” In the third, textual proximity to sealed material remained under investigation; a direct source instruction through Raghav or Shashank—“not

established.” In the fourth, Shashank’s limited visitor access was recorded; broad administrative authority —“expected signs absent.”

Aditya said, “None of this declares you innocent.”

“I know,” Shashank replied. “It only weakens the necessary indicia of the broader allegation.”

For the first time Raghav looked directly at Shashank. “What are you afraid of?”

Shashank tried to laugh, but his face remained hard. “That because of one defective little sentence of mine —‘the lawyer agrees’—your name will be tied to things in which you had no independent role at all.”

Raghav said, “So now you are defending me?”

“No. I am defending the boundary. For me too, and for you too.”

“Why did you not defend that boundary earlier?”

Shashank did not answer. He remembered the banquet stage, the Macao meeting, praise from foreign guests, the glitter of the dinner. In all those places he had loved to appear larger than the boundary. Now that same expansion had returned as fear.

Aditya opened the third page. A public report said: “Network decisions under cover of legal consultation.” Beneath it, the source was described only as “investigation-linked source”. Aditya asked, “What would be required to establish this statement?”

Shashank said, “Not merely the existence of a legal meeting. Even without opening privileged substance, there should be an independent operational link—crime-specific instructions after the meeting, benefit, access, allocation of work, or some consequence distinct from ordinary legal advice.”

“At present?”

“At present the public statement is broad; the available independent indicia are limited.”

Aditya said, “Non-apprehension?”

“If the report claims that operational orders were regularly generated under legal cover, then one would expect consequences in some external records—business task lists, non-legal instructions, payments, changes in authority. If a reliable search does not find those classes broadly, the claim is weakened. But the substance of privileged advice has not been examined, so I cannot say ‘nothing happened at all’ either.”

Raghav nodded. “That boundary matters.”

Then Aditya showed an old mobile-phone message. Shashank had written to Li Wenchao: “I have spoken with the legal people; now there is less reason to worry.”

Aditya asked, “Is there a crime in this?”

“No. It may be ordinary to feel less worried after taking legal advice.”

“And if the next line had said, ‘The method for stopping the government investigation has been decided?’”

“Then the nature would change. That would be an independent indicator of crime-specific purpose.”

“Found?”

Shashank looked at the page. “Not in this file.”

Aditya opened a page beside it. It contained only the external record of the legal meeting—the date, duration, names of participants, ordinary accounting for a service fee, and an indication of which business group each person was active in after the meeting. The words of the advice appeared nowhere.

“What does this external record establish?” Aditya asked.

Shashank said, “That the meeting happened, that certain people were present, how long it lasted, and that there were some ordinary service relationships. It does not establish that a criminal plan was made in the meeting.”

“And if the alleged plan were true?”

“Then some consequence would appear outside legal confidentiality somewhere—allocation of crime-specific tasks, unusual sharing of money, alteration of access rights, direct use of sealed material, or explicit instructions in non-legal messages. I cannot say such consequences must always be written down; but the more regular and organized the alleged scheme is said to be, the greater the expectation of external indicia.”

Raghav said, “Do not turn confidentiality into reverse evidence here. Because the original advice has not been examined, it would be improper to fill the blank and write ‘crime’; and because it is confidential, it would be equally improper to write ‘innocence’.”

Aditya wrote in the table: “External consequences: partially available; crime-specific consequences: not presently established; completeness of records: differs by category.” Shashank looked at the three short lines. Amid fear, for the first time he felt relief not because the answer favoured him, but because the boundary of the question had been written down.

Aditya said again, “‘Not found’ and ‘does not exist’ are different.”

“Yes.”

Fear was slowly changing form. At first he had been afraid the papers would declare him guilty. Now he feared that his own exaggerations would distort the boundaries of other people. For the first time he understood that language was not only about his defence or prestige; it could also become a weight upon another person's legal position.

Raghav said, "Let me make one thing clear. If a lawyer ever steps outside the boundary of legal advice and enters the operation of a crime, privilege is not a magical shield. But to establish such participation, proximity of names or the existence of a confidential meeting is not enough."

Aditya said, "And for an investigator, non-apprehension is not an excuse for laziness. If an expected sign is not found, first ask: was the search sufficient? Were records ordinarily kept? Was the medium available? Only then assign weight."

Shashank wrote three sentences in his notebook: "Confidential ≠ criminal." "Confidential ≠ automatically innocent either." "Absence of independent indicia can reduce the weight of an allegation if the indicia were expected and the search reliable."

At the end of the session Aditya read the draft statement: "Shashank Jha admits that in some business messages he presented certain legal cautions as though they were broad approvals. That linguistic and moral question is independent. On the basis of the available external records, the alleged crime-specific joint operational role of Raghav Bhasin or Shashank Jha is not presently established; the investigation will respect the boundary of legal privilege and focus on independent non-legal indicia."

Shashank said, "Add one word—'presently'."

Aditya said, "It is already there."

"Good. I have begun to like that word."

"Why?"

"Because it gives a conclusion the boundary of its time and evidence."

Outside, Mrinal was waiting. He asked, "Who were you afraid of today?"

Shashank said, "At first, the lawyer. Then my own words."

"And in the end?"

"The blank space where I wanted some sign to appear so that everything would become clear."

Mrinal said, "Non-apprehension is not merely a blank if the place truly ought to have been filled."

Shashank smiled. "And if there was no rule requiring it to be filled?"

"Then do not turn the blank into philosophy."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

"Legal confidentiality = lawful boundary; not a magical shield for crime."

"Lawyer's presence = not participation in crime."

"Translator's broad summary = not automatically the original legal statement."

"Linguistic deceit = moral responsibility; joint economic crime requires separate evidence."

"Alleged joint plan = independent operational indicia may be expected."

"Qualified non-apprehension of expected indicia = may reduce the weight of a broad allegation."

"Incomplete medium or possibility of oral communication = reduces the weight of non-apprehension."

"'Not found' ≠ 'does not exist'."

"Existence of a confidential meeting = does not establish a crime inside the meeting."

"Fear = do not run from the consequences of my own words; correct their boundary."

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: "Earlier I sold legal caution as a seal; now I am learning to measure the weight of what is absent outside that seal."

Closing the notebook, he remembered the heading on Aditya's next file—resistance from the lower commissionerate, versions from the tax-intelligence branch, and alleged internal compromise. After fear, the next emotion would again be betrayal. But this time the question would not merely be what changed; if resistance had truly been crushed, what institutional signs ought to have existed—and which of them were absent?

CHAPTER 86

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 8

The last question stayed with Shashank through the night—if the resistance of the lower commissionerate had truly been suppressed, what institutional signs ought to have remained? In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today we will look not at persons but at process. Orders, notes, reassignments, meeting records, reasons, version sequence. We will state what exists; for what does not, we will first establish whether its absence is meaningful.”

The same officer from the lower commissionerate was present in the office, the one whose lines of caution had surfaced again and again in the earlier sessions. This time before him lay not four pages but a complete chronological summary. One column contained his original objection, the second the intermediate revisions, the third the final tax-intelligence summary, the fourth the levels through which the file had passed.

The officer said, “My objection is in the record. It is also a fact that some of it became softer in the final summary. But I am still not saying that a particular person pressured me. What I experienced is one thing; what I can prove is another.”

Shashank looked at him. In that sentence he heard the lesson of his own recent years—experience and evidence are not the same. The feeling of betrayal may be real, but naming the guilty person requires a record.

Aditya put the first question: “If a formal resistance had been made to be withdrawn, what would ordinary process normally show?”

The officer replied, “It depends on the nature of the file. Sometimes a written note, sometimes a senior’s approval, sometimes a change in allocation of work. The same sign is not mandatory in every case.”

“So if no written order is found, it would not be proper to conclude that no pressure could have occurred?”

“No.”

“And if no written order is found, it would also not be proper to conclude that the order was erased?”

“No.”

Aditya looked at Shashank. “Non-apprehension?”

Shashank said, “First establish that if the alleged event had occurred, a sign of that kind would ordinarily have remained in this record system. Only then does absence after a reliable search acquire weight. Failure to find a sign that was never necessarily required says very little.”

The next page was placed on the table. In the five days after the officer’s original note, the file had passed through three levels. Comments appeared at the first two; in the digital history for the third, only the word “reviewed” appeared, while the text explaining the reason was blank.

Old anger rose inside Shashank. “This blank space itself—”

Aditya interrupted him. “The blank is a question, not an answer.”

Shashank fell silent. He remembered Mrinal’s sentence—do not turn an empty space into philosophy.

The lower officer asked, “Is this reason field normally filled in?”

The technical assistant said, “For some types of change, yes; for others it is optional. For this particular category of entry a reason was expected, but the older version of the system allowed the field to be left blank.”

Aditya said, “Then this is not complete qualified non-apprehension, but it is more significant than an ordinary absence. A reason was expected, though the system did not compel it.”

Shashank wrote: “Expected, but not mandatory.”

The next record concerned work allocation. The officer who had made the original note had not suddenly been removed from the matter. Even seven days later, he had added two supplementary comments.

There was another fact on the following allocation page. During those same seven days the officer had also been assigned two other matters; his ordinary responsibilities had therefore not suddenly been reduced. But one specific analytical note in this matter had been prepared by an officer from another branch instead of him. Aditya paused over the distinction. “Ordinary responsibilities remained = no pressure at all would be too heavy a conclusion. One specific task moved to another officer = retaliation proved would also be too heavy. We will look for the reason-marker.” No separate order explaining the reason was found; the allocation list merely said “special review”. The lower officer said, “Such reassignment was unusual, not impossible.” Shashank understood—institutional cracks often do not leave one dramatic wound; sometimes they leave a series of small changes. But joining small changes into a definite conspiracy would also violate the discipline of non-apprehension.

Aditya asked, "If the claim is that the officer was completely sidelined immediately after objecting, what do these two later comments mean?"

Shashank replied, "That claim is weakened. Later active comments by an allegedly sidelined officer conflict with a necessary consequence of complete exclusion."

The officer himself said, "I am not saying I was sidelined. I am saying it felt as though the weight of my words was reduced."

"There is a difference between the two," Aditya said.

"A great one."

The feeling of betrayal rose again inside Shashank, but now its direction was blurred. If the officer had not been removed, where had the betrayal occurred? In the gradual softening of words? In priorities of decision-making? Or in Shashank's own translation, which had reassured the business side too early?

Aditya opened the third file. It contained the meeting list for those days. One meeting recorded two officers from the tax-intelligence branch, a representative from the lower commissionerate, and a member of the legal cell. The short conclusion of the meeting said: "Additional verification continuing."

Shashank asked, "If the compromise had already happened, why was additional verification continuing?"

Aditya said, "That is a useful question, not an answer. A compromise and an investigation can continue together; or there may have been no compromise. Now look—do we have any separate sign of the alleged improper instruction?"

In the seven days after the meeting there were three pieces of correspondence. One requested beneficial-ownership records; the second asked for clarification of the payment path; the third asked for the source of the digital-asset reference. The language was softer in some places, but the investigation had not stopped.

Shashank said, "Then the claim 'all questions were stopped' does not match the available record."

"Yes," Aditya said, "but 'no influence at all' is not established either. Whether the language of the questions softened, whether priority changed, what effect there was on the decision—those are different levels."

The lower officer said quietly, "That is where my sense of betrayal lies. The questions remained, but their edge diminished."

Shashank flinched at the sentence. He himself had done the same thing so many times—reduce the edge while leaving the words in place.

Aditya produced an old linguistic note. It had reached the business side, and its style resembled Shashank's translation. Its meaning was roughly: "No immediate principal tax risk; subsidiary verification continues."

Shashank lowered his eyes. "That style is mine."

"Authorship?"

"Not from style alone. But similar sentences exist in my old records."

"And the meaning?"

"More reassuring than the original objection."

"Knowingly?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "Sometimes I softened risk to prevent clients from panicking. Sometimes to make my own usefulness look greater. That was my deceit."

The lower officer looked directly at Shashank. "Do you understand how an officer feels when such a softened sentence reaches the outside?"

"Yes. I understand now."

"Then did the betrayal come only from the institution?"

The question sank into Shashank. He said, "No. If my softened summary made your real reservation seem lighter in the client's eyes, then I too acted unjustly toward your caution."

For a few moments the room was silent. In making that admission, Shashank was not placing an institutional crime upon himself; he was accepting the boundary of his own linguistic responsibility.

Aditya said, "Keep that distinction intact. Your softened summary = your responsibility, if authorship and context are established. Internal compromise by the branch = a separate claim, requiring separate evidence."

The next page contained an important absence. A public allegation said that after the lower commissionerate's objection, a "secret instruction" had been issued, after which the direction of the investigation changed. But no identifiable such instruction was found in the searched official letter register, protected email records, meeting sequence, or work-allocation records.

Shashank's mind immediately wanted to say—then no such instruction existed. But he stopped. "How much weight does this absence carry?"

Aditya looked towards the technical assistant.

The assistant said, "If it was a formal instruction, one would ordinarily expect at least one record among these four. Not necessarily for an oral instruction. Not necessarily for an unauthorised external message either."

Shashank said, "Then the claim of a formal secret instruction is weakened; the possibility of oral or informal influence is not eliminated merely by this absence."

"Correct," Aditya said. "Non-apprehension reduces the size of the claim. It does not manufacture the conclusion one prefers."

In the second part of the session, an old media headline was shown: "Instructions from Inside, Money from Outside, Investigation Suppressed." The headline had three parts; the record did not support all three at the same evidentiary level. Some payment references concerning "money from outside" remained under examination; version changes existed regarding "investigation suppressed"; no formal sign was available for "instructions from inside".

Shashank said, "The news sentence bound three different evidentiary levels into one rhythm."

"And people remember the rhythm," the lower officer said, "not the levels."

There was no humiliation on Shashank's face this time, but shame and betrayal together. He remembered how he himself had constructed sentences like that for clients—compressing three separate risks into one short reassurance.

Aditya asked, "Who are you angry with now?"

Shashank said, "Earlier I was angry with the institution. Now I am angry with myself too. But because of my guilt I will not say the institution is innocent, nor that it is guilty. Only as far as the signs go."

"That is the difficult discipline of non-apprehension," Aditya said. "Do not complete the story merely because you see an absence."

The lower officer gathered his original note and said, "I want justice, not a story. If my objection was improperly softened, let the evidence show it. If it was only an editorial decision, let that become clear. But do not turn me into a hero and create another false story."

Something broke inside Shashank. For months he had made the officer into a symbol of moral resistance. The officer himself was refusing to become a symbol.

Mrinal met him as he came out. "What did you find today?"

Shashank said, "Some signs were found. Some were not. The hardest part is not immediately giving the name of truth to what was not found."

Mrinal said, "At least this time let the empty space remain named only as an empty space."

"Betrayal?"

"A feeling. Whether a person or institution is guilty—still a question."

"And my part?"

"Responsibility for the softened words you gave."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

"Existence of resistance = recorded fact."

"Reduction in the edge of the resistance = question visible in the version sequence; purpose requires separate evidence."

"The officer's later active comments = weaken the claim of 'immediate complete sidelining'."

"Expected record of a formal instruction absent = carries weight against the formal-instruction claim; not against oral influence."

"Reason-text expected, but not mandatory in the system = limited non-apprehension."

"Correspondence showing investigation continuing = contrary sign against the claim 'all questions were stopped'."

"Softened language = does not erase the question; but it can reduce the social and commercial weight of the question."

"My softened summary = my responsibility; not proof of institutional compromise."

"Feeling of betrayal = real; guilty person or institution = evidentiary conclusion."

"Non-apprehension = absence of an expected sign; do not turn the absence into a story."

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped. "I once softened the edge of questions; now I will not sharpen an absent answer into a blade."

He closed the notebook. The heading on Aditya's next file was: sealed material, public allegations, humiliation in the news. The question of institutional betrayal remained open; in the next stage they would examine how something that was not in the record became a complete sentence in the public narrative.

CHAPTER 87

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 9

Aditya Mishra's message came in the morning: "Today we will measure the distance between public allegations and sealed material. The question is not what the media said; the question is which part of its statement could have come only from the sealed record."

Shashank held the phone in his hand for a long time after reading the message. He had tasted this question before. Pieces of his birthday photograph, foreign guests, the singer's stage, the Macao journey had once been joined into a public story. Then his humiliation had flared into anger. Now he understood that humiliation's first response often creates two extremes—"everything is false" or "everything is an inside conspiracy". Non-apprehension demands a silent discipline between those two extremes.

In the office room sat Aditya, the officer from the lower commissionerate, and Shashank. The papers were arranged in three groups. First—the index of the sealed material permitted under the court's order, showing subject headings but not the original sensitive text. Second—records already public, travel information, stage photographs, vendor lists, and general portions of old contracts. Third—copies of media statements from that period.

Aditya said, "The court has fixed the boundary of the original sealed text. We will not cross that boundary here. But if someone claims that a particular news report came directly from sealed material, we should expect some feature in the report that was not available from public sources."

The lower officer asked, "For example?"

"The index contains one entry—Internal Note, No. 14. The news report said: 'Note No. 14 identifies Shashank Jha as the principal coordinator of the payment route.' If such a sentence truly appears in the original sealed note, the question of a leak becomes serious. But the judicial summary has so far established only that Note No. 14 bears the heading 'Questions concerning the payment route'; no person-specific conclusion is public."

Shashank's face tightened slightly. He remembered the bold headline from that time—"Translator Was Coordinator of Money Network." Some people from the village had carried questions all the way to his father. One acquaintance had laughed on the phone: "You learned languages and went very far indeed." That humiliation had not been words that day; it had become heat in his body.

Aditya looked at him. "There is no need to write the emotion, Shashank. First the text."

"Emotion does not change the text," Shashank said, "but it can change the temptation with which one reads it. I want to say immediately—everything was false."

"Will you say it?"

"No. First, what is available."

The copy of the news report was opened. The first claim contained three elements—Shashank's Macao trip; links with a foreign vendor; and 'mention of financial control in a sealed note'. The first two were already available in public sources by that date. The language of the third was vague; there was no number, no quotation, no specific amount, no specific account, no words attributed to a specific officer.

The lower officer said, "Then what is absent here?"

Shashank replied, "If the source truly was the sealed note, and the report claims that the note contains concrete proof of my financial control, one would ordinarily expect some specificity—an exact statement, identifiable detail, a reference number, or some fact that could not have been inferred from outside sources. That specificity is absent here."

Aditya added, "But the source may have been kept confidential; an editor may deliberately have removed the details. So absence of specificity alone does not prove that 'there was no leak'."

"But it reduces the evidentiary weight of saying 'proved from sealed material'," the lower officer said.

"Yes," Aditya said, "if there is no independent sign."

The second news line was more painful: "Internal tax-intelligence letter proves translator had administrative access to a foreign server." Shashank now understood the sentence better than he had in earlier episodes. The available access records showed a limited visitor role; the expected signs of high-level authority had not been found. Where had the word "administrative" come from?

Aditya made two columns. In one he wrote words available in public material: 'special access', 'Macao', 'access up to the server'—including Shashank's own boasts. In the other he wrote the news phrase: 'administrative access'.

“Look at the linguistic distance,” he said. “The media could convert someone’s phrase ‘access up to the server’ into ‘administrative access’ without ever seeing a sealed record. Therefore the existence of the same conclusion ≠ the same source.”

Shashank lowered his head. “My own exaggeration was also in the seed of this false allegation.”

The lower officer said at once, “A seed does not mean guilt. If the news turned your boast into a technical fact, that is a separate responsibility.”

“But the responsibility for my boast is mine.”

“Yes.”

With that brief admission, the tone of Shashank’s humiliation began to change. Earlier he had wanted the court to declare that everything written against him was false. Now he could see that some of the public narrative had been built from pieces of his real arrogance, travel, language work, and proximity; the error arose where indications were turned into established facts. It was difficult to mark the boundary of a false allegation without accepting his own fault.

The third news report claimed that the sealed material recorded ‘direct secret contact between the lower commissionerate officer and Shashank’. The officer’s face hardened.

“I had never had a private conversation with this man before the investigation began,” he said. “The records after formal questioning are separate.”

Aditya asked, “If the alleged prior contact were true, what signs would we expect?”

Choosing each word carefully, the officer said, “Contact logs for my office number, appointment entry, correspondence, or at least a chronology consistent with ordinary administrative records. Not every medium is mandatory; a personal oral meeting is possible. But the news says ‘recorded secret contact’. Then where is the record?”

The available search contained no specific sign of such prior contact. But Aditya again wrote the boundary: “Office contact records complete; completeness of private external means not established.”

Shashank said, “So non-apprehension carries more weight against the word ‘recorded’; less against ‘there was never any contact’.”

“Correct,” Aditya said. “The more precise the wording of a claim, the more precise the expected sign becomes.”

After lunch they read a copy of an earlier court order. It clearly directed that the contents of the sealed material were not to be made public; the parties’ legal teams could inspect it only in a limited way and under judicial conditions; public comment was not to declare conclusions from it. The news report had been published after that order. The fact ignited Shashank again.

“Then is this not like contempt of court?” he asked.

Aditya stopped him. “We will not give that conclusion. There is an order; there is a news report; the source is uncertain. The person, if any, who violated the order must be identified by independent evidence. The intensity of your humiliation does not identify the source.”

The sentence hurt Shashank. He felt Aditya was diminishing his pain. He said sharply, “For someone whose house people reach, whose father has to answer questions, whose name is printed beside ‘money network’, identifying the source is not a scholastic exercise.”

Aditya was silent for a few moments. “No. The humiliation is real. But the work of investigation is not to place pain in the position of evidence; it is to find evidence worthy of giving justice to the pain.”

Silence spread through the room. The lower officer looked at Shashank. “They also wrote in my name that I was the ‘lone honest officer’ and that every senior officer had been bought. I did not like that headline. My resistance is a recorded fact, but the crimes of all the others are not proved by that.”

For the first time Shashank saw the symmetry of their humiliation. The news could write a simple story by making him the criminal; the same news could write another simple story by making the other officer the hero. Both stories reduced the complexity of the evidence.

Aditya showed the fourth paper—a questionnaire had been sent to Shashank’s old office address before the news report was published. The system showed a dispatch record, but no confirmation of receipt. The article said: ‘No response was given.’

Shashank said, “I did not receive this questionnaire at the time.”

“How do we test that statement?”

“If confirmation of receipt was expected and is absent, then the claim ‘he read it and remained silent’ is weakened. But that the letter was sent is a fact.”

“Good,” Aditya said. “Non-apprehension can be useful in your favour here, but only as far as the system has been established.”

A strange shame rose inside Shashank. The doctrine of non-apprehension he was learning to use against accusations also showed him his own conduct. How many times had he treated a client's silence as 'agreement'; the absence of a lawyer's objection as 'approval'; a friend's failure to protest as 'support'. He wrote: "Silence ≠ consent when no expected sign of consent has been defined."

By evening three conclusions had been separated. First—some media claims could have been constructed from public material and Shashank's own exaggerated statements; therefore a sealed leak was not a necessary cause. Second—some claims used words such as "recorded" or "proved", but the expected specific signs were unavailable; the evidentiary weight of such claims was weak. Third—whether there had in fact been an unauthorised disclosure of sealed material, and if so by whom, remained open.

Shashank asked, "Then is the false allegation against me established?"

Aditya replied, "For specific claims, where the available evidence does not support them or shows a contrary boundary, we can call them false or unsupported. But do not stamp the entire public narrative with a single word."

"Why?"

"Because inside it are your real journey, real vendor relationship, real boasting, real linguistic softening; alongside them are unsupported expansions. Justice will give each piece its own name."

Shashank remembered his birthday stage. Amid the applause he had thought prestige could be made in a single sentence. Now he understood—humiliation too is made in a single sentence; justice takes the sentence apart again, piece by piece.

Outside, evening had fallen. Mrinal was waiting at the foot of the stairs. Seeing Shashank's face, he asked, "News again today?"

"Yes."

"Anger?"

"Yes. But I will no longer treat anger as a source."

"Humiliation?"

"That too."

"Then what remains?"

Shashank said, "I will accept what is true about me. What is not established, I will not call established. What is false, I will call false. But where the source has not been found, I will not place the name of whichever culprit I prefer."

Mrinal smiled. "Is that difficult?"

"Most difficult after humiliation."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

"Sealed material = not automatically the source of a public allegation."

"Public facts + exaggeration = can create a story even without an inside leak."

"A claim that something is 'recorded' = requires a search for the expected record."

"Absence of a specific non-public marker = may reduce the weight of a direct-leak claim."

"Source confidentiality or editorial omission = limits the force of non-apprehension."

"Erroneous expansion by the news = does not erase the real journey or relationship."

"Real proximity = not alleged financial control."

"Humiliation = fact of suffering; not identification of the culprit."

"Silence = not consent when the expected sign of consent has not been defined."

"Non-apprehension = no permission to write a desired name into a blank space."

As he wrote the last line, Shashank stopped: "The public sentence that made me a criminal will not be answered by another public sentence; the answer will be only as large as the evidence."

Closing the notebook, he saw the heading on Aditya's next file—"The Investigator from Another Village." An officer from the lower commissionerate, from another village in Mithila, had remained at the edge until now; the next day he had proposed reading the Gangesha method in the opposite direction, against Shashank's own method of wrongdoing. Shashank understood—non-apprehension would no longer be only a tool of his defence; now it would turn into a question and follow the trail of his own acts.

CHAPTER 88

THE INVESTIGATOR FROM ANOTHER VILLAGE

When Shashank reached Aditya Mishra's room in the morning, the officer from the lower commissionerate was already seated on the other side of the table. In several earlier meetings he had appeared quietly, preserving the original note, the version sequence, and the question marks; today there was no thick file before him, only five sheets and an empty notebook. The emptiness unsettled Shashank. An officer who carries fewer papers, he thought, may be carrying more questions.

Aditya did not repeat the introductions. He said only, "Today the file will not ask what was not found against Shashank. The officer wants to see what happens when the same method Shashank uses in his defence is turned around and applied to Shashank's own actions."

The officer looked at Shashank. His voice was neither harsh nor sympathetic. "You were born in Mithila; so was I. Different villages. Both of us have heard the name of Gangesha. But hearing a name is not a method. When we speak of non-apprehension, we must first ask whether the thing was fit to be found, whether the place searched was appropriate, whether the search was sufficient. You demand those limits when allegations are made against you. I want to see how often you made use of other people's silence, blank spaces in documents, and the absence of questions for your own benefit."

A slight resistance rose inside Shashank. "Not everything in my work as a translator was recorded."

"Correct," the officer said. "For that very reason, we will not turn 'not found' into 'did not happen'. But neither will you turn 'not said' into 'there was consent'."

On the first sheet lay a summary of Raghav Bhasin's old legal caution and Shashank's later, brief business message. The original caution contained conditions, risks, and a limited conclusion. In Shashank's message it had become: "The legal side is clear; we can proceed." The officer moved his thumb between the two lines as though measuring their distance. "No crime is proved here. But one linguistic act is visible: the conditions disappeared and the conclusion grew broader. The question is this: if the original advice contained full approval, where are the explicit words?"

Shashank replied, "They are not there."

"Then on what basis did you write 'clear'?"

"Commercial urgency. The client wanted a short answer."

"That may be a reason. Evidence for it?"

Shashank fell silent. The officer said, "Look, I am not reading your mind. There is no evidence of the reason. There is evidence only of the alteration. So I will say only this much: your version reduces the boundary of the original. Purpose is a separate question."

For the first time Shashank understood that the officer was using grammar against him, not indignation. He was given no convenient enemy against whom to become angry.

On the second sheet were the Macao meeting's visitor access record and Shashank's old boast: "I have access all the way inside." The officer asked, "If there had in fact been broad administrative authority, would one ordinarily expect signs of a high-privilege role, permanent permission, independent power to make changes, or long-term use?"

Shashank said, "Yes, if the system was reliable."

"What do the records available so far say?"

"Temporary visitor access."

"Then your boast?"

"Larger than the boundary."

"A crime?"

"Not necessarily."

"Deceit?"

Shashank paused. "If I knew that the listener would understand it as real authority, then yes—misleading self-promotion."

For the first time the officer wrote something in his notebook. "Here non-apprehension both protects you and exposes your deceit. The expected signs of broad authority are absent; therefore broad control is not

established. But authority equal to the scope of your statement is also absent; therefore the exaggeration in your statement becomes visible.”

On the third sheet was Mrinal’s name. A lawful reimbursement, an image from a public function, and Shashank’s old message: “My people are everywhere.” The officer asked, “Signs of a crime by Mrinal?”

“Not found.”

“Friendship?”

“Established.”

“Reimbursement?”

“Consistent with lawful expenses.”

“Then ‘my people’?”

Shashank’s throat dried. “I was manufacturing prestige.”

“Meaning that you were selling another person’s real presence as evidence of your own influence?”

“Yes.”

“You have already admitted this. Today, look at its method. The expected economic signs of wrongdoing by Mrinal are absent; therefore the weight of an allegation against your friend falls. But the expected language of your own self-promotion is available; therefore your moral responsibility increases. The same non-apprehension does not protect everyone in the same way; its object changes according to the person and the claim.”

Nothing broke inside Shashank; instead, something settled into its proper place. Until now he had treated non-apprehension as a shield made out of blank space. The officer was showing him that one must first determine for whom, and in relation to what, the space is blank.

The fourth sheet showed the version sequence in the tax-intelligence branch. Question marks in the original note; condensation in the intermediate draft; some cautions softened in the final summary. The officer said, “The public allegation about my branch is that there was an internal compromise. Assume for the moment that this is true. What signs might be expected?”

Before answering, Shashank looked at Aditya. Aditya remained silent.

Shashank said, “A formal order, a reason for changing responsibility, an instruction to remove a note, unusual access, or some independent contact linked to an outside party.”

“Are all of those mandatory?”

“No. Some would depend on the process.”

“What was found?”

“Version changes were found; reassignment of one specific task was found; but no direct instruction applying pressure.”

The officer said, “Then should we say ‘the compromise is proved’?”

“No.”

“Should we say ‘the compromise was impossible’?”

“No to that as well.”

“Our method does not end here. For what was not found, examine the capacity of the search. Is this file complete or fragmentary? Were meeting notes always made? Could oral instructions have been given? If the record system is weak, the weight of non-apprehension is weak too.”

Shashank remembered his clients from so many previous years. How often had he taken advantage of weak records. He had ended questions merely by saying, ‘There is no paper.’ For the first time he understood that the absence of a paper is meaningful only when there was a meaningful system under which that paper ought to exist.

On the fifth sheet was a short list of Shashank’s linguistic alterations: changes such as ‘prohibited’ to ‘limited’, ‘risk’ to ‘review’, ‘verification pending’ to ‘under process’. Not every change was criminal; some reflected business language, some a client’s demand, some Shashank’s own softening. The officer read the lines one by one but placed no stamp of guilt on any single word.

He asked, “Your method of wrongdoing—if we use that expression here—was it only the writing of false sentences?”

Shashank said, “No. Half-truths. A broad meaning given to a correct fact. A smaller name for risk. Giving another person’s silence a meaning in my favour.”

“And sometimes making your own role appear larger.”

“Yes.”

“Then what is the method for reading it in reverse?”

Shashank answered slowly, "For every sentence, ask: what sign is fit to accompany the claim being made? Of the signs found, how much of the claim do they support? For what was not found, is the non-apprehension qualified? And when a word changes the boundary, what did the original text say?"

The officer did not smile. He said only, "That is why this method works against you too."

The officer turned another page. "Now a difficult non-apprehension. Today you say that 'access all the way inside' was only a boast, not real administrative authority. Assume that explanation is correct. At the time, when clients or friends could have understood your role as broad, did you ever state the limit clearly—'I am only a linguistic guest', 'I have no independent control'? Do we find any contemporary correction like that?" Shashank searched his memory. In some places he had written 'translation', but he could not remember any clear correction cutting down his larger claims. "Not in the material presently available," he said. The officer did not immediately draw a conclusion. "This absence does not prove that you deliberately deceived everyone. People do not always record corrections to their own boasts. But it raises a question about your later claim that 'I always understood the limits clearly'. Your present explanation has to be compared with your contemporary language." Shashank lowered his head. This form of non-apprehension against him was sharper, because there was no external enemy here—his own former silence had become the question.

Aditya had listened until then. He said, "One thing more. The investigator does not own this method. If we too see 'not found' and write whichever conclusion suits us, our error will be just as great."

The officer agreed. "Navya-Nyaya is not a weapon belonging to one side. Its limits must apply equally to all sides."

Shashank asked, "Then what do you think I am?"

The officer replied, "It is not my job to answer that question. I see certain acts—linguistic softening, boasting, expansion of boundaries, some real services, some real relationships. For some allegations, the expected signs are not found; some faults appear in your own records. A one-word judgment on a person belongs to the court or to final proof. In an investigation, we will name the acts, not the human being."

The sentence gave Shashank an uneasy peace. He had not been forgiven; nor had he been given the abbreviated name of a monster. There were only separate acts. Perhaps that was the hardest mirror of all.

As the meeting ended, the officer turned half a page of his empty notebook towards Shashank. Four lines were written there: "What is available? What ought to have been available? Is the non-apprehension qualified? How far does the claim extend?" Beneath them was a fifth: "Compare the boundary of the word with the original record."

Shashank asked, "Where did you learn all this?"

The officer remained silent for a few moments. "In Mithila, a university seal is not compulsory for learning how to ask questions. But reading Gangesha gave me one advantage—I have learned to fear my own certainty."

Aditya laughed softly. "That fear is good for an investigation."

As Shashank came out, he saw that Mrinal was not in the veranda. Today he would have to carry this alone. He sat at a tea stall by the road, opened his notebook, and wrote: "Non-apprehension protects me when an accusation grows larger than the expected evidence; non-apprehension also exposes my fault when no real basis is found for my own large claims."

He wrote again: "No sign of wrongdoing by a friend = allegation against the friend weakened; language showing that I sold my friend's name is available = my self-promotion established."

"No sign of broad server authority = control not established; boast of 'access all the way inside' available = enlarging my role established."

"No original sentence of full legal approval = 'the legal side is clear' was not the original advice; my short message is available = the act of reducing the boundary is established."

"No direct indicator of institutional compromise = compromise not established; version changes available = the question of alteration remains alive."

"Non-apprehension = not a blank space for defence; it is a qualified expectation belonging to a claim."

His pen stopped at the final line: "Gangesha's method gave me power over language; today the investigator from another village showed me that the same method can cut through the shadow I made with language."

That night a message came from Aditya—the next day there would be a new comparison of the summons, the statements, and the seized digital material. In some old messages Shashank had again magnified his role, while some expected operational signs were again absent. The story was not ending; its direction was changing. Now ambition itself would speak in the record, and non-apprehension would ask his claim: if you possessed the power you said you had, where are its signs?

CHAPTER 89

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE II

The summons for the next day was shorter than the earlier ones. It concerned only three things—two lines from an old statement, four messages from the seized digital material, and one period in which Shashank had described his role as “decisive”. Aditya Mishra had already written that the inquiry would not spread again across the whole device or the whole of Shashank’s life; it would examine only the points where the statement and the contemporary record collided.

Reading the summons, Shashank understood that this time his ambition stood before him not as an accusation made from outside, but in the form of his own words. Once, sentences such as “decisive”, “inside”, “access all the way up”, “nothing will move without me” had seemed to him tools for increasing his value. Now the question had reversed—if all those claims were literally true, where were the signs fit to accompany them?

In the office, the investigator from the other village was there with Aditya. The officer placed four sheets on the table. “Yesterday we read the method in reverse. Today we will compare the formal statement with the seized material. What is absent in your favour, we will record; what is present against you, we will record as well. Ambition is neither a crime nor innocence. But when ambition changes the size of a sentence, the record can show that change.”

On the first sheet was Shashank’s later statement: “I provided limited services in language and coordination; independent business decisions were not in my hands.” On the second was a message from three years earlier: “The final decision will not be made without me.” Aditya asked, “Can both be true together?”

Shashank read the line again. “The first sentence is closer to my actual role. The second was boasting.”

“What is the basis for calling it boasting?” the officer asked.

“Because I had no formal authority to make the decision.”

“What are the signs that you did not have that authority?”

Shashank said, “My position is not in the contract, my name is not on the approval list, I had no independent authority to approve payments or pricing, and in the meeting records available so far I am not recorded as the final decision-maker.”

The officer wrote. “Good. Here non-apprehension supports one part of your present statement. If you had real institutional authority over the ‘final decision’, it would be reasonable to expect some markers of that authority. They are not found in the reliable records available. Therefore broad decision-making authority is not established. But the old message does exist—and that establishes that you presented your role as larger than it was.”

An ugly memory of an old pleasure rose inside Shashank. After that message, the client had replied: “Then speaking with you is enough.” At the time the reply had felt like victory. Shashank had not corrected the client by saying that the decision was not his to make. Today that silence reminded him of the previous day’s lesson—the non-apprehension of a contemporary correction of the boundary.

Aditya asked, “Did you clarify the boundary to the client at that time?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Shashank’s answer did not come at once. “I wanted him to think I was indispensable. The value of knowing languages seemed too small to me; the value of appearing influential seemed greater.”

The officer said, “That admission establishes ambition. Criminal purpose does not automatically follow from it. But it becomes difficult later to say, ‘the other person simply misunderstood me’, when there was an opportunity to correct the misunderstanding and no correction is found.”

On the second sheet was a sentence from a formal statement: “I never had advance knowledge of the internal proceedings of the tax-intelligence branch.” Opposite it was an old message from the seized material: “Once the report goes upward, the language will change.”

Shashank’s face hardened. He had forgotten the sentence. Aditya said, “Now, reading this, what would you say?”

Shashank read the timestamp and the surrounding messages. The preceding line discussed the public process—a draft would go upward and a shorter summary would be prepared. There was no name of a specific officer, no confidential passage, no wording of a coming revision.

He said, "The sentence sounds like advance knowledge, but in context it can also be a general inference. I often said that language becomes shorter when a paper goes upward. But 'I never had any advance knowledge' is too broad a statement. I should have said: the material available so far does not establish that I had advance knowledge of a specific confidential revision."

Aditya struck out the line and wrote the new statement. "That correction was necessary."

The officer asked, "If there had been specific advance knowledge, what signs would you expect?"

Shashank thought. "Mention of a specific change before it occurred, a non-public sentence from the draft, a copy sent before its time, an explicit instruction from someone—something of that kind."

"Found?"

"Not so far."

"Then non-apprehension?"

"It weakens the allegation of specific advance knowledge, if the media and period searched were adequate. But the message expressing a general institutional inference is present."

For the first time the officer smiled faintly. "Now you can place your defence and your fault in the same sentence."

The third sheet concerned the digital seizure. In an old folder there was a note by Shashank titled "Role". It listed his services—Mandarin-Cantonese linguistic assistance, meeting summaries, contract text, client messages, conversion of risk-language. At the end was one line: "All the principal people communicate through me."

Aditya asked, "This line?"

"A half-truth," Shashank said. "Some people communicated through me because of language. By writing 'all the principal people' I was trying to make myself look like the centre of the network."

"If all major communications really passed through you, what would one expect in the seized material?"

"A continuous chain of messages, regular instructions, a sequence of meetings, repeated contact around decisions."

In the two communication media for which the available period was complete, the technical summary did not show such continuous centrality. There were some intense periods and some months with almost nothing. Some foreign clients used Shashank for linguistic communication, but a great deal of business communication also proceeded without him.

The officer said, "So the signs for 'all through me' are absent. But the evidence that 'some important linguistic communication passed through me' is present. Your ambition turned a plural into a universal."

Shashank smiled involuntarily. "How much damage language can do with such a small word."

"Do not turn 'damage by language' into a penal code," Aditya stopped him. "What we have here is misleading presentation. A crime requires separate elements."

Shashank nodded. "Correct. My linguistic deceit."

The fourth sheet was not a photographic summary of the seized material, but a timeline: before the summons was issued, after the first questioning, and before the devices were surrendered. An old media claim said that during this period Shashank had "cleaned out all the internal sources". Earlier sessions had already noted the absence of direct signs of wholesale deletion. Today the officer reversed the question: "If you really wanted to preserve your boast of influence, would you have erased every boast?"

Shashank was startled. Many of his embarrassing boasts were still preserved in the seized copy. "No. A great deal remains."

"Does that prove you innocent?"

"No."

"But does it fit a broad claim that 'all signs of influence were systematically cleaned out'?"

"Poorly."

Aditya added, "The absence of some material is also affected by retention limits. So we will not write 'nothing was deleted'. Only this: a great deal of self-promotional material survives in the available complete copies; the uniform pattern one would expect from a universal, planned clean-up is not found."

Shashank felt a strange shame. Part of his defence rested on the fact that he had not even managed to erase his foolish boasts properly. But the officer made no attempt to read his face. He only wrote the boundary on the sheet.

Then the formal statement resumed. The question was: "Did you knowingly present your role as larger than it was?"

Shashank said, "Yes, many times."

"Why?"

“To get work, increase my fees, obtain foreign travel and special invitations, and remain necessary in other people’s eyes.”

“You admit all these ambitions?”

“Yes.”

“Did those ambitions make you a participant in a crime?”

Shashank looked at the officer. A year earlier he might either have denied everything or, in self-loathing, accepted everything. Today he said, “I cannot say that. Ambition was the reason for some linguistic deceit, for narrowing boundaries, for enlarging my role. The specific allegations of criminal participation require separate elements and separate evidence. Where the evidence exists, I will accept it; where it does not, I will not call it proved merely because I am ashamed.”

The room was silent for a few moments. The officer said, “That is the difficult part. Guilt can sometimes produce a false confession as well.”

Aditya wrote into the statement: “The declarant admits that professional ambition led him on multiple occasions to present his influence and access as larger than they were; the available digital material supports the existence of these self-promotional statements. However, the expected independent signs of broad decision-making authority, specific confidential advance knowledge, or pervasive internal control have not been established in the investigative material presently available; each allegation remains subject to separate proof.”

Shashank read it and said, “Keep ‘have not been established’, not ‘did not exist’.”

Aditya looked at him. “This time you are not asking for the boundary only when it favours you?”

“No. Because some media are incomplete.”

The officer said, “Then non-apprehension has reached its proper boundary.”

At the end of the statement Shashank was asked: “Do your earlier broad denials—‘no contact’, ‘no inside information’, ‘only translation’—still stand?”

Shashank paused over each phrase. “No. There was ordinary administrative contact. I saw some internal linguistic material. I made some risk summaries. ‘Only translation’ is also too small a sentence because I also coordinated and summarised. But none of those admissions should automatically be equated with financial ownership, a confidential government source, or administrative control.”

The officer said, “For the first time your statement is becoming not smaller, but the right size.”

Evening had fallen. The veranda light came on outside. Mrinal had not come that day. Descending the stairs alone, Shashank remembered the old messages on his phone. Ambition had not merely wanted large work for him; it had wanted a large story in which he himself was the centre. Now the digital seizure was breaking that story into pieces—some truth, some performance, some fault, some false allegation.

At the tea stall by the road he opened his notebook and wrote:

“Summons = not proof of guilt; an occasion to test the boundary of a statement.”

“Seized digital material = evidence of what has been preserved; not the silence of media that did not survive.”

“‘The final decision will not happen without me’ = surviving self-promotion; independent signs of decision-making authority absent.”

“‘The language will change after the report goes up’ = may be a general inference; specific confidential advance knowledge requires specific prior signs.”

“‘All the principal people communicate through me’ = some linguistic centrality is present; pervasive centrality is absent.”

“Absence of a contemporary boundary-correction = raises a question about a later explanation; not automatic proof of crime.”

“Ambition = reason for making language larger; criminal elements are separate.”

“Guilt = no permission for false confession.”

“Non-apprehension = the qualified shadow of a claim; not an empty space for ignorance.”

Writing the final line, he held the pen still for a long time: “I wanted power, so I wrote the language of having power; now the record asks—leave the language aside, where was the power?”

He closed the notebook. He remembered Aditya’s next list—contracts, vendor path, beneficial ownership. In this episode the sentences of ambition had been examined; in the next, pride in language would again collide with the words of contracts. The question would remain the same: if knowledge of, or authority over, the actual beneficial owner is claimed, where is the record fit to support it—and if it is not found, how much weight should that non-apprehension carry?

CHAPTER 90

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 12

The previous question was still open in Shashank's notebook—leaving language aside, where was the power? The next morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today we will examine the contracts, the vendor path, and beneficial ownership again. But this time the question is not merely about names. We will see where ownership language first entered the documentary chain, and whether it had an independent basis behind it or the same sentence was merely repeated in several places.”

The officer from the lower commissionerate who had read Shashank's Gangesha-based method in reverse the previous day was also seated in the office. Five things lay on the table—the original service contract, a brief vendor-registration letter, Shashank's bilingual summary, a later internal risk note, and the request letter for beneficial-ownership verification.

The officer said, “Today we will not begin with ‘whom should we regard as the owner’. First we will see where the word ‘owner’ came from.”

Shashank's old pride in language stirred within him. Once he had believed that other people merely read words, while he could read the power behind them. In Chinese business language he could often distinguish among position, relationship, representation, control, coordination. His pride in that talent had not been improper. The error began when, along with talent, he started selling his certainty as well.

Aditya opened the original service contract. The contracting party was clear. The service-provider entity was clear. The nature of the fee was stated. The paying party appeared on a separate page. In the box for ultimate beneficial ownership was again the same phrase: “verification pending.”

“We have seen this before,” Shashank said.

“Yes,” Aditya replied, “not to repeat it. This time look at how language of definite ownership entered the later records.”

The second page was a brief vendor-registration letter. One person was recorded there as the “main business contact”. There was no percentage of ownership, no declaration of shares, no beneficial-owner certificate. The third page was Shashank's old bilingual summary. Beside the same name were the words: “principal decision-making party.”

The officer asked, “How did you move from ‘main business contact’ to ‘principal decision-making party?’”

Shashank remained silent. The line was his. He said, “At the time I added the context of the conversations. The person answered all the questions in meetings, changed schedules, and other people looked towards him. I felt that the practical decisions were in his hands.”

“You felt?”

“Yes.”

“In the contract?”

“No.”

“In an ownership declaration?”

“No.”

“In anyone's written instruction?”

“Not in this file.”

The officer put down his pen. “So the translator mixed a behavioural inference with lexical meaning.”

Shashank wanted to object—he was not merely a dictionary translator; reading context was part of his work. But the reverse question stopped him. Reading context and declaring legal ownership were not the same thing.

He said, “Yes. I enlarged the boundary of the designation. Seeing the behaviour behind ‘main contact’, I wrote ‘principal decision-maker’. But even ‘principal decision-maker’ is not the same as ‘beneficial owner’.”

Aditya opened the fourth page. The internal risk note said: “According to the linguistic summary, principal decision-making party identified; beneficial-ownership inquiry required.”

Shashank was stunned for a moment. “So my summary became the basis of the later note?”

“At least in this line it is cited as a source,” Aditya said. “But note carefully—the note itself does not say beneficial ownership is established. It says inquiry is required.”

The officer took out the fifth page. In a still later brief summary, the wording had grown heavier again: “Beneficial-ownership verification pending for identified main controller.” The source reference cited the number of the earlier risk note.

Shashank looked back and forth across the pages. Original registration—“main business contact.” His summary—“principal decision-making party.” Risk note—“principal decision-making party identified; ownership inquiry required.” Later summary—“identified main controller.” At each stage a word had become slightly harder.

“Now non-apprehension?” the officer asked.

Shashank replied, “If the later phrase ‘main controller’ was truly based on independent verification, an independent basis for it should be found—an ownership declaration, shareholding, control rights, a letter of authority, a relationship of benefit, or at least some source separate from my summary.”

“Found?”

Aditya said, “Not in this limited file. The source chain of both later lines circles back to your summary. There is a request for ownership verification, but no complete declaration is marked in the protected receipt register.”

Shashank’s face grew hot. He understood that the same sentence appearing in several papers did not become several pieces of evidence. If all the lines were descendants of one initial summary, repetition increased the number of documents, not the number of independent foundations.

The officer said, “Read this in reverse. Five papers are visible. Someone in a hurry will say—five sources. But if four lines are rewritings of the first line, where is the independence?”

Shashank said, “The non-apprehension here is of an independent source.”

“Its limit?”

“Not that there was no actual owner. Only that in this available chain no independent ownership evidence for the alleged controller has been found. If another protected source exists, that is a separate matter.”

Aditya nodded. “Correct. And the reverse side too. It is also not yet established that your original summary was merely an innocent lexical mistake. You knowingly wrote a behavioural inference into it.”

Pride and shame rose together inside Shashank. He said, “I was proud of language. I thought I understood the signals in Chinese conversation that others missed. In front of clients I often said: ‘I do not read words; I read people.’”

The officer asked, “Did that sentence make you a capable translator, or a self-appointed adjudicator?”

“There was a boundary between the two,” Shashank said, “and many times I erased it.”

“Why?”

“Because certainty sold. Saying, ‘this designation has three possible meanings’ made less impact. Saying, ‘I know what it really means’ made people look at me.”

Aditya said, “So pride in language had economic value too?”

Shashank replied, “Yes. Prestige, more work, higher fees, greater proximity. But this admission ≠ knowledge of the actual beneficial owner.”

“I am recording the same distinction,” Aditya said. “Selling linguistic certainty may be a moral or professional question. Criminal implication concerning ownership requires separate evidence.”

After lunch, the lower commissioner officer made a new table. First column—original designation. Second—Shashank’s rendering. Third—later institutional form. Fourth—whether an independent basis was available.

First row: “main business contact” → “principal decision-making party” → “main controller” → independent ownership basis unavailable in this file.

Second row: “paying entity” → in a later summary, “principal party in the funds path” → beneficial ownership separately subject to verification.

Third row: “vendor coordination” → in one draft, heavier language resembling “integrated control”, though no such wording appeared in the original contract.

Shashank stopped at the third row. “This ‘integrated control’ is not mine.”

Aditya said, “Correct. The author is not yet established. Mere similarity of wording does not make it yours.”

The officer added, “Your responsibility in this episode extends only as far as your own line is proved. Someone else’s heavier wording will not be placed on your head.”

For the first time that day Shashank felt something like relief, but his first line cut him again at once. Fairness was protecting him; precisely for that reason he could not reduce the size of his own error.

He said, “But my phrase ‘principal decision-making party’ may have influenced the later language.”

Aditya replied, "It may have—that is an inference. What is direct is only that the later note cites your summary. Whether the later author was influenced by your wording or by an independent conversation is not fully established yet."

The officer smiled. "You are learning—not even your own guilt should be allowed to cross the boundary of inference."

Shashank said, "Earlier I turned inference into fact to enlarge my importance. Now, out of a desire for atonement, I will not make the same mistake merely to enlarge my guilt."

In the second part of the session, the vendor path was examined. The contracting party was one entity, the paying party another, the service recipient a third in the relevant context, and some expenses were reimbursed through a fourth route. Earlier, this complexity had been called in the public narrative "a network of one secret owner".

Aditya asked, "Complex structure = secret owner?"

Shashank said, "No. Complexity is a reason to investigate. Ownership requires an independent link such as shareholding, control, benefit, instruction, or something comparable."

"If the beneficial-ownership declaration is not found?"

"First see whether such a declaration was ordinarily mandatory, whether it was requested, and whether the receipt register is complete. Here the request letter is available and no complete declaration is marked in the receipt register. So it is proper to say verification was incomplete. It is not proper to say 'there was no owner'."

The officer asked, "And 'the owner was hidden'?"

"That goes too far as well. A claim of concealment requires independent signs such as deletion, a false declaration, contradictory records, or deliberate obstruction. Declaration unavailable $\neq$ deliberate concealment."

For a few moments the room was silent. In that silence Shashank remembered Juliana's old lesson—language does not merely reveal meaning; it can also conceal the speaker's intention. At the time he had regarded that as an art. Now he understood that if a translator's intention changes the boundary of a word, later readers may take the altered boundary as the original fact.

He said to Aditya, "My error was not merely boasting. At times I gave a definite shape to a possibility. If other people relied on that form, my linguistic responsibility increases."

Aditya said, "Yes. But the type of legal responsibility depends on consequence, purpose, knowledge, and use. We will not convert a moral admission into a criminal conclusion."

The lower commissioner officer said, "The Gangesha method restrains you twice here. First—do not cross the boundary of the meaning of a word. Second—do not treat multiple copies from the same source as multiple pieces of evidence."

Shashank wrote in his notebook: "Repetition $\neq$ independent confirmation if the source is the same."

Aditya read the day's summary: "The available contracts show several distinct roles in service, payment, and representation. Beneficial-ownership verification remains incomplete. In one bilingual summary by Shashank, the meaning of 'main business contact' was extended, on the basis of conduct, to 'principal decision-making party'; some later notes use this summary as a source. Within this chain, no independent ownership evidence for the alleged ultimate controller is available. Shashank admits enlarging the linguistic boundary; that admission does not automatically establish actual ownership or participation in a crime."

Shashank said, "Add one line—the meaning of the original designation was known to me, but I mixed in a behavioural inference and made it sound more definite."

The officer asked, "Why do you want that added?"

"Because it would be easy to escape by calling it a 'translation error'. This was not merely a dictionary mistake. It was pride."

Aditya added the line.

As they left the office, Mrinal was waiting at the foot of the stairs. Shashank told him what had happened during the day. Mrinal asked, "You always used to say—language is your power."

"It was."

"And now?"

"It still is. But power and authority are not the same thing. I understood language; that did not give me the authority to declare who owned people or companies."

Mrinal said, "Will you give up pride?"

Shashank thought for a few moments. "No. Giving up pride in talent would be false humility. But I will give up selling certainty from behind that pride."

"Difficult?"

“Very. Because people often buy not meaning from a translator, but confidence. And confidence demands a firm voice. But if the original matter is uncertain, a firm voice can itself become deceit.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote:

“Contracting party ≠ paying party ≠ service recipient ≠ beneficial owner.”

“Main business contact = not actual owner.”

“Behavioural influence = not automatic proof of legal control.”

“Translator’s contextual inference = not the original record.”

“Multiple rewritings of the same summary = not multiple independent sources.”

“Ownership declaration requested + complete declaration not found in receipt register = verification incomplete; absence of an owner not proved.”

“Non-apprehension of the declaration = not proof of deliberate concealment unless there is an independent sign.”

“Pride in language = may be acknowledgement of talent; when it becomes false sale of certainty, responsibility follows.”

“My heavy wording = my responsibility; someone else’s heavy wording = separate question of authorship.”

“Non-apprehension = look for absence of an independent basis; do not turn echoes of one source into a crowd of evidence.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I used to search for power inside words; now I understand that without evidence, a word can itself dress in the costume of power.”

Before closing the notebook, he remembered Aditya’s next list—intermediary accounts, payment gateway, hawala references, digital assets, and friendship. After the words of the contracts, the next question would return to the path of money. But this time it would not be merely Mrinal’s name or familiar initials; they would examine which independent signs of instruction, benefit, control, and relationship expected for the alleged layered money chain were actually available, and which were merely echoes of the same old story.

CHAPTER 9I

CRACKS IN THE COMPROMISE 13

The previous question stayed with Shashank through the night—if the path of money moved through several layers, where were its independent signs, and how much was merely an echo of the same old story? In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today: intermediary accounts, payment gateways, hawala references, digital assets, and friendship. Not names—links.”

When he reached the office, five small files lay on the table. The first contained a payment-gateway summary; the second, limited details of bank remittances; the third, old messages; the fourth, records of travel expenses and service reimbursements; the fifth, a sealed list, only parts of which could be seen with the court’s permission. Mrinal Karn was not present at today’s meeting.

Shashank sat down and asked, “Mrinal wasn’t called?”

Aditya said, “Not yet. Records first. Friendship will not be the starting point of the inquiry.”

The officer from the lower commissionerate, who in the earlier episodes had been reading Shashank’s language in reverse, placed a sheet of paper before him. “The allegation is that the path of money was concealed through layers of multiple payment gateways, intermediary accounts, and digital assets. Your friend’s name has also been inserted into this allegation. The question is—how much is actually available?”

Shashank read the page. Some accounts were marked with coded identifiers, some with initials, some only with the name of a payment-gateway entity. In one place appeared ‘M.K.’ His chest tightened slightly.

The officer asked, “First reaction?”

“I will not say Mrinal merely because I see M.K.”

“Why?”

“Initials can match. Identification requires the account-holder, bank identity, contact, beneficiary information, instruction, or some other independent link.”

Aditya turned over the second page. “What is available with this ‘M.K.’ entry?”

The list contained one amount, one date, and a brief description—‘expense adjustment’. The bank’s full name was not on that copy. Verified identification of the recipient was unavailable.

Shashank said, “This could match Mrinal’s lawful travel-expense reimbursement, but resemblance is not identification. Conversely, if this were an unlawful intermediary account, what independent signs would be expected?”

The officer smiled. “Now you are learning to ask questions.”

Aditya replied, “At least something of this kind—account identity, relationship with the person giving instructions, flow of benefit, unusual frequency, a link with other alleged layers, or an operational role. Not all of them, but some independent basis.”

“And here?”

“Here there is one entry. Independent identification is not presently available.”

A faint wave of relief rose inside Shashank, but he stopped himself. “Then we should not say ‘Mrinal is innocent’ from this one record either?”

The officer said, “Correct. One ambiguous entry does not establish guilt, and its ambiguity does not establish complete innocence either.”

Aditya opened the third file. It contained the old receipts for Mrinal’s lawful reimbursements—travel, food, translation assistance, some shared expenses. Each had a date, a reason, and a brief description of the approved expenditure.

“These have already been examined,” Shashank said.

“Yes,” Aditya replied, “but today for comparison. If an alleged unlawful intermediary-payment path had operated through Mrinal, one might expect some sign different from the pattern of lawful reimbursement—an unusual amount, vague purpose, repeated transfers, retention of benefit, or onward transmission to another beneficiary. No such independent pattern has yet been established in the available material.”

Shashank kept looking at Mrinal’s name. He remembered all those evenings spent with his friend, when Mrinal laughed at his boasting, warned him, sometimes spoke harshly. Suddenly he felt guilty—how often he had used his friend’s presence to increase his own credibility.

The officer looked at his face. “What are you thinking?”

"I used his name like a shield for my prestige. I wanted people to think that if Mrinal was with me, I must be trustworthy."

"Does that establish economic participation?"

"No. But it was an improper use of friendship."

Aditya said, "That distinction will be recorded."

The fourth file contained a payment-gateway summary. Several business entities, service providers, and routes for consumer payments were listed separately. Some names had appeared earlier in the contract path; others were new. Attached to one line was an old linguistic comment by Shashank: "Not one route; separate channels."

The officer asked, "What does this comment establish?"

Shashank said, "That I knew there were multiple payment channels."

"Hawala?"

"No. Multiple channels $\neq$ hawala."

"Digital assets?"

"No. A plurality of payment gateways $\neq$ use of digital assets."

"Layered path of funds?"

"Not that either, unless there are independent records showing money moving from one channel to a second, a third, and a fourth link."

Aditya drew a line on the page. "Correct. The linguistic comment is available. A specific criminal structure requires separate evidence."

The court-authorised portion of the fifth file contained two kinds of references. First—indications from some external sources raising the possibility of unlawful fund transfers. Second—an internal summary in which 'Hawala' and 'Digital asset' were written with question marks.

Shashank said, "The question marks are there again."

The officer said, "And their absence appeared in a later version. But today we will look at something else. If the answer to those questions was 'yes', where are the independent economic signs?"

Aditya read from the list: "Some unusual payments are available; some sources are incomplete; identification of some recipients is incomplete; but in the available file there is not yet a complete chain that independently establishes one particular friend, one particular translator, or one alleged owner as the controller of every layer."

Shashank asked, "Then the allegation is false?"

"Careful," the officer said. "Some allegations may be exaggerated or unsupported. But the complete inquiry into the entire path of funds is not over. The weight of non-apprehension is only as strong as the reliability of the search, the completeness of the records, and the certainty of the expected sign."

Shashank lowered his head. "Meaning that even for what was not found, we must write the boundary."

"Yes."

This time the officer placed an old message before him. Shashank had written to Mrinal: "These people are making the money route more complicated; I feel there is a bigger game inside." Mrinal had replied: "Feeling it and having evidence are two different things."

A line of shame appeared on Shashank's face. "He was stopping me even then."

Aditya asked, "What did you mean by 'bigger game'?"

"Uncertainty. Some unclear payments, many entities, higher service fees, people from abroad. But I used my language to make it sound larger."

"Then is this message an admission that you knew about hawala?"

"No. It is a mixture of suspicion and boasting. If I had known a specific hawala or digital-asset path, one would expect a specific link in this message or some other contemporary record—who to whom, on what basis, which beneficiary. That is not here."

The officer said, "Again the same point—the non-apprehension of specific signs weakens the claim of broad knowledge. But it would also be wrong to say 'there was no suspicion at all', because the message exists."

"Yes," Shashank said. "I was suspicious. Sometimes I gave suspicion the language of prestige."

In the afternoon Mrinal was called. He came and sat not beside Shashank, but across the table. There was some formality in that distance, and some hurt.

Aditya asked directly, "Your lawful reimbursement records are available. The identity of a separate entry marked 'M.K.' is still incomplete. Do you know anything about this entry?"

Mrinal looked at the page. "No. The date falls near one of my journeys, but the amount does not match. I will not connect myself to it on that basis."

"Did you ever forward anyone's money at Shashank's request?"

“No.”

“Did you ever arrange for anyone’s account to be used?”

“No.”

“Did you coordinate with anyone in a digital-asset or hawala-like money path?”

“No.”

Aditya stopped the questions. “Those denials will be independently checked. A friend’s word alone is not the end of the evidence.”

Mrinal said, “Let it be checked.” His voice was calm.

Shashank could not bear that calm. “Mrinal, I—”

Mrinal raised his hand. “Not friendship now. Records first.”

Shashank fell silent. The sentence struck him like a blow. Slowly he understood that Mrinal was right—if friendship changed the weight of evidence, it would cease to be friendship and become bias.

The officer asked, “If the allegation against Mrinal is not established, what does your friendship prove?”

“Nothing, in the economic matter.”

“And if it is established?”

Shashank’s throat dried. “Then friendship will not rebut the evidence.”

For the first time Mrinal looked at him. “Remember that.”

At the end of the meeting, Aditya read a draft conclusion: “The available material shows multiple payment channels and some unclear economic entries. Some external sources raise questions about the possible use of hawala or digital assets, but in the records presented, the alleged complete layered chain, a specific controller, or the alleged intermediary role of Mrinal Karn is not independently established. The identity of the ‘M.K.’ entry remains incomplete. Separate records of Mrinal’s lawful reimbursements are available. Shashank’s old messages show suspicion about financial complexity and self-promotion; they do not automatically establish knowledge of a specific unlawful route.”

The officer added, “And write that incompleteness of some sources limits the conclusion from non-apprehension.”

Aditya wrote it down.

Shashank said, “One more line.”

“What?”

“I used Mrinal’s presence to increase my own credibility. That is not evidence of economic participation, but it is my moral error.”

Mrinal kept looking at him. “Why do you want that written?”

“Because I took the benefit of your name. The punishment of the name should not fall on you.”

Mrinal’s face remained hard. “That sentence will not restore the friendship.”

“I know.”

“Then?”

“Only this—that the correct fact should remain in the correct record.”

Mrinal said nothing. This time his silence was not consent; it was only silence. Shashank could now understand that distinction even without words.

By evening the office began to empty. As the lower commissionerate officer gathered his notebook, he said, “This entire section on non-apprehension is reaching its end here. You people often used absence to build whatever story was already in your minds—sometimes guilt, sometimes defence. The actual method first makes the absence qualified.”

Shashank asked, “And the next principle?”

“Decision.”

The word was small in the room, but its weight was large. The officer said, “Direct perception, inference, analogy, testimony, postulation, reasoning, non-apprehension—even after all of them are gathered, one must finally decide. Decision does not mean a hasty conclusion; it means accepting the available limits and weighing the two sides separately.”

That night Shashank returned home and opened his notebook. He wrote:

“Initials = not a person.”

“Lawful reimbursement = not an unlawful intermediary account.”

“Multiple payment gateways = not hawala.”

“Multiple channels = not digital assets.”

“Layered path of funds = requires an independent sequential chain.”

“Suspicion = not specific knowledge.”

“Friendship = not proof for the defence; not a shortcut for accusation either.”

“Prestige-based use of a friend’s name = moral error; economic participation requires separate evidence.”

“Qualified non-apprehension of expected account identity, instruction, benefit, control, or relationship = may reduce the weight of a broad allegation.”

“Incomplete sources = limited weight of non-apprehension.”

“The same old story repeated in many papers = not independent financial confirmation.”

“Non-apprehension = not a blank space; a failed search for a qualified expectation.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I will not make the evidence smaller to save Mrinal; I will not make his name larger to make him guilty.”

Closing the notebook, he understood that the seventh section had truly ended. Non-apprehension had relieved him of the weight of some broad allegations, but the same principle had also exposed his boasting, half-truths, and use of friendship. The first heading of the next section was: “From Friendship to Enmity.” The new principle would be “Decision”. The question would no longer be merely what was unavailable; all that was available and unavailable would have to be placed together, and one would have to determine what conclusion was valid.

CHAPTER 92

FROM FRIENDSHIP TO ENMITY

The last line kept sounding inside Shashank all night—do not make the evidence smaller to save Mrinal; do not make his name larger to make him guilty. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today, not the money path. We will look again at Macao, foreign travel, and special access. This time, not non-apprehension—decision.”

When Shashank reached the office, the officer from the lower commissionerate was already seated there—the one from another village in Mithila who had been reading Shashank’s language in reverse over the past few days. Three files lay on the table: the travel sequence, the Macao meeting records, and the summary of limited system access. Seeing Shashank, the officer said in Maithili, “Less argument today; more settling.”

An involuntary feeling of closeness rose inside Shashank. The same geography, the same cadence of language, a shared memory of Gangesha’s formulations—for a moment he felt that this officer, at least, would understand him. In the past few days this was the first person who had made him neither a monster nor an innocent saint. Shashank mistook that balance for proximity to his own side.

Aditya opened the travel sequence. “Delhi to Macao trip established?”

“Yes.”

“Presence at the meeting?”

“Yes.”

“Temporary visitor access?”

“Yes.”

“Viewing linguistic material and giving comments?”

“Yes.”

“Permanent administrative authority?”

Shashank said, “Not in the available records.”

The officer put down his pen. “No decision yet. Only established facts.”

Shashank was slightly irritated. It seemed to him that all this had already been settled repeatedly in earlier sessions. The officer read his face. “Looking at the same fact again is not repetition when the question changes. Earlier the question was—what is absent? Today we ask—when what is available and what is absent are taken together, what conclusion is valid?”

The first paper contained the guest list for the Macao meeting. Beside Shashank’s name were the words “linguistic review / guest access”. The second paper showed the activation and expiry times of the temporary identity. The third listed some categories of activity—viewing material, linguistic comments, participation in a presentation session. In the categories of payment approval, changing user rights, system configuration, and independent administrative orders, there was no mark against Shashank’s name.

The officer asked, “If we had to decide from only these three papers?”

Shashank said, “I went to Macao, attended the meeting, had limited access, and viewed linguistic material. Broad administrative control is not established.”

“And if we read only your old messages—‘on the next trip I will see the real inside’, ‘I have access all the way to the server’, ‘the people inside listen to me?’”

Shashank remained silent.

The officer asked again, “Then?”

“Then my role appears larger than it really was.”

“Decision does not mean choosing one of those two,” the officer said. “Decision means giving each its own evidentiary value. The records speak to the boundary of your authority; your messages speak to the boundary of greed and self-promotion in your mind.”

The sentence stung Shashank. He had thought that shared Maithili and a shared method might preserve the subtlety of his account. Instead, using that very subtlety, the officer gave his boasting a place that was not equal to crime, but was more serious than innocent joking.

Shashank said, “Why do you keep adding greed? Greed is not a crime.”

“Correct,” the officer said. “That is why we will not write greed as a crime. But if the question is why you described limited access in larger language, then service fees, foreign travel, prestige, the attraction of being

called 'special', and the desire to present your role as larger are contextual reasons. In a decision, reasons and elements of an offence are not the same thing."

Aditya intervened. "And exaggeration on the side of the accusation?"

The officer opened the second page. One public allegation said that Shashank was the "controller of the internal server". The officer said, "For that statement, the expected records of high privileges, independent changes, long-term use, or approval markers have not been found. In the available preserved period, the claim of broad control is unsupported."

A slight relief rose inside Shashank. But the officer immediately read the next line: "Limited access to internal material, linguistic review, and presence at the meeting are established; therefore the declarant's broad denial—I was only an external translator and never saw anything inside—is also unsupported."

The relief turned bitter at once. Shashank's face hardened. "You cut both ways every time."

"The method is no one's friend," the officer replied.

"I thought you understood me."

"Understanding and taking a side are not the same thing."

A childlike anger rose inside Shashank. Village, language, Gangesha—the things that had given him a momentary sense of belonging now felt like deception. He felt that the man was deliberately striking at his most private weakness. In a hard voice he said, "Then you too are on Aditya's side."

The room went silent. Aditya said nothing. The officer asked only, "Which 'side'?"

Shashank did not answer.

The officer said, "What is not proved against you, I have not written. What is not available in your favour, I have not invented either. And when your own messages show your greed, why should I erase them? If that makes me an enemy, then the work of evidence is difficult."

Shashank's anger rose again. "I was greedy, I admit that. But you people use that word everywhere."

"No," the officer said. "The first discipline of decision is this: do not extend one attribute across every fact. Your greed may help explain why you accepted the journey; it does not automatically establish system control. Your linguistic talent may have enabled you to understand internal material; it does not automatically establish criminal purpose. Your false boasting may reduce your credibility; it does not automatically make every allegation true. And exaggerations against you may be false; that does not automatically erase everything you have admitted."

Hearing this, the first crack appeared in Shashank's anger. The officer was protecting him too—but not in the form Shashank wanted. Shashank wanted someone to compress his whole story into a single sentence: innocent, framed, or guilty. The officer would not easily give him any of those words.

An old birthday photograph was placed on the table—foreign guests, a glittering stage, the famous singer's performance already over, Shashank translating. On the back of the photograph was an old note: "Special access in Macao next time."

The officer asked, "This sentence?"

"Stage talk."

"Its effect?"

After a few moments Shashank said, "I liked it. I felt I was no longer merely an external service provider; I was going inside."

"So greed was not only about money?"

"No. Status too."

"Decision?"

For the first time Shashank himself said, "The stage phrase 'special access' is not proof of actual authority. But it can be evidence of its effect on my mind, because in later messages I increasingly described my role in that direction."

The officer nodded. "The principle is working here."

"Decision?"

"Yes. After doubt, fix the conclusion by setting the boundaries of the available evidence. Neither hunger for accusation nor hunger for defence."

Aditya opened the third file. It contained a brief note after the Macao meeting in which Shashank had softened some risk-related words. The officer asked, "Did this happen within your limited access?"

"Yes."

"Then 'I did nothing inside'?"

"Would be incorrect."

"I operated the system?"

"That too would be incorrect."

"Then the sentence in between?"

Shashank drew a deep breath. "Using limited linguistic access, I viewed some material, gave comments, and softened words in some places. My role is proved only to that extent. Turning it into administrative or financial control would be an exaggeration; reducing it to zero would also be an exaggeration."

Aditya wrote the sentence down.

Shashank looked at the officer. A short while earlier the man had seemed like an enemy. Now Shashank understood that the feeling of enmity had probably arisen because the officer would not give him the completeness he preferred. In his mind Shashank had treated their shared region and language as a promise of partisanship. That too was a form of greed—not only greed for money or access, but greed for a favourable decision.

He said softly, "I had taken you for one of my own."

The officer smiled. "I am one of your own. Does that mean I should distort the boundary?"

"No."

"Then where did friendship and enmity occur?"

Shashank answered, "In my mind."

The officer folded the page. "In a method of justice, a friend is not the person who takes your side; a friend is the person who corrects the size of your sentence. But we will not put that philosophical line into the statement."

For the first time a light laugh rose in the room. Aditya smiled too. The tension did not disappear entirely, but something inside Shashank loosened.

At the end of the meeting, the draft joint conclusion was read: "Foreign travel, the Macao meeting, limited guest/linguistic access, and linguistic comments on some internal material are established from the available records. No independent sign of broad administrative or financial control is available. There are examples in which the declarant previously presented his role as larger than it actually was; these are contextual indications of ambition/status-greed, but do not by themselves establish broad criminal control. Conversely, a broad denial such as 'there was no internal access at all' is also inconsistent with the available facts."

Shashank read the draft and remained silent for a long time. The page contained things in his favour and things against him. Earlier he would have called such a document half victory, half defeat. Today he understood—decision is not a sum of wins and losses; it is a conclusion anchored to the boundary of the evidence.

When he came out, Mrinal was waiting in the veranda. Seeing him, he asked, "What happened?"

Shashank said, "I found a friend. In the middle he became an enemy. Then I understood—he was neither."

Mrinal raised an eyebrow. "Who?"

"The investigator."

"When was he a friend?"

"When I thought he would take my side."

"When did he become an enemy?"

"When he did not."

"And now?"

Shashank smiled. "Now he is on the side of the evidence. I like that, and it hurts too."

Mrinal said, "Your illness is old—you give people names larger than their roles."

Shashank laughed. "A server guest becomes an owner, a friend becomes a shield, an investigator becomes friend or enemy."

"And yourself?"

Shashank's laughter stopped. "Sometimes larger than a translator, sometimes smaller than my own fault."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote:

"Decision = a conclusion fixed by setting the mutual boundaries of the available evidence."

"Foreign travel = travel; a criminal conclusion requires independent evidence."

"Presence at the Macao meeting = the type of participation must be tested separately."

"Limited linguistic access = a real fact; not broad administrative control."

"No independent sign of high privileges = broad-control claim unsupported."

"Old boasting = indication of ambition/greed; the object of the boast is not automatically true."

"No internal access at all' = false broad denial because limited access is available as fact."

"Greed = can appear as money, status, access, or desire for a favourable decision."

"Shared language or village = not partisanship."

"Investigator = neither friend nor enemy; his statements too must be tested by evidence."

“Decision = the same measure for accusation and defence.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I wanted evidence to be my friend; evidence gave me a boundary.”

Closing the notebook, he remembered the next heading—“Two Navya-Nyayas 2”. The next question would concern Raghav Bhasin, legal privilege, and the boundary of participation in crime. The first lesson of decision had been about access in Macao; the second would concern the silence lawfully protected between lawyer and client, and the external signs that, if there were actual participation, might still appear outside confidentiality.

CHAPTER 93

TWO NAVYA-NYAYAS 2

The last line stayed inside Shashank for a long time—I wanted evidence to be my friend; evidence gave me a boundary. The next day the boundary stood before him again, but this time it was not the boundary of paper; it was the boundary of silence. Aditya Mishra's message was brief: "Today: Raghav Bhasin, legal advice, confidentiality, and alleged participation. Decision."

Raghav was already seated in the office. Two stacks lay before him. On the first was written: "Legal consultation: substance protected." On the second: "External records: time, participants, fees, subsequent business communications." The officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila sat near the window. He was not turning pages; he was reading Shashank's face.

As soon as Shashank entered, Raghav said, "Today do not save me and do not condemn me. What is mine is mine; what is yours is yours."

Shashank's throat dried. "I understand."

The officer said softly, "Understanding it and keeping it in the decision are different things."

Aditya placed his hand on the first stack. "The substance of this material will not be opened without the court's direction. But when the meeting happened, who attended, who paid the fee, and what separate business messages followed the meeting—those are external facts that can be examined."

The old fear rose inside Shashank. So many times he had told clients: "The lawyer side is clear," "There is no legal obstacle," "Raghav has looked at it." Now the echoes of those sentences felt like a hand around his own throat.

The officer asked, "Have you ever turned Raghavji's caution into a definite approval of your own and passed it onward?"

Before answering, Shashank looked at Raghav. There was neither anger nor help on Raghav's face. Only waiting.

"Yes," Shashank said. "In some places. His statement was conditional. In my summary, I reduced the conditions."

"Example?"

Shashank said, "The sense of his advice was—if the service is genuine, the parties' identities are verified, and the payment path is clear, then some provisions of the contract may be read in the ordinary way. At one point I wrote: 'The legal side is clear.'"

Raghav spoke for the first time. "And that sentence was not mine."

"No," Shashank said. "It was mine."

Silence filled the room. The officer said, "Now hear the first cut of decision. The translator's broad sentence is not the lawyer's original legal opinion. But neither does the translator's sentence become insignificant merely because the lawyer's name was attached to it."

Aditya opened the second stack. It contained the external details of the meeting—the date, time, people present, service fee, and Shashank's name as linguistic assistant. Not a single page described Shashank as financial owner, payment approver, or system administrator.

The officer asked, "If Raghavji were a participant in a crime, what signs might be expected outside confidential legal advice?"

Shashank answered carefully, "Business instructions that are not legal questions; an independent relationship to payment or benefit; operational decisions; shared communications reflecting a criminal purpose; or some act that cannot be explained merely as legal advice."

"And if none of those is found?"

"Then the broad allegation of participation is weakened."

"Finished?"

Shashank paused. "No. If the external records are incomplete, oral contact was possible, or other sources of evidence remain, absence does not amount to final innocence."

The officer smiled faintly. "The decision is here—confidentiality is neither a magical shield for crime, nor does an accusation of crime magically destroy confidentiality."

Raghav leaned slightly back in his chair. "Write that sentence down."

Aditya lifted the next page. Two days after the meeting Shashank had sent a message: “No objection from Raghav’s side; proceed.” The message had gone to a business group; Raghav was not a member of that group.

“This?” Aditya asked.

Shashank lowered his face. “My summary.”

“Raghavji’s instruction?”

“No.”

“Then why his name?”

Shashank’s answer did not come at once. Inside himself he saw the younger man he had once been, turning famous names, foreign guests, special access, and the presence of a lawyer into steps for making himself look taller. At last he said, “The greed to borrow credibility.”

Raghav’s face hardened. “You turned my caution into your seal.”

“Yes.”

“And now that the matter has become serious, you are afraid the seal will fall around my neck?”

Shashank raised his eyes. “Yes. That fear is selfish, and it also comes from guilt.”

The officer intervened. “No decision from emotion here. Shashank’s fear does not establish Raghavji’s participation; Raghavji’s displeasure does not erase Shashank’s wrongdoing.”

Aditya made a four-part list: “legal advice”, “Shashank’s summary”, “business action”, “criminal allegation”. He said, “Every sentence in its own box.”

First row: the substance of Raghav’s legal advice—protected. Second: Shashank’s sentence “the legal side is clear”—his own business summary. Third: the service fee—recorded payment for legal services. Fourth: alleged shared criminal purpose—still subject to independent proof.

Shashank kept looking at the list. He understood that fear often erased the boundaries between boxes. The sentences he had once merged for convenience were now being separated again by justice.

The officer asked, “Your old statement was: ‘Raghav saw everything.’ What did ‘everything’ mean there?”

Shashank took a long breath. “A literally false expansion. He saw some legal issues. Not every operational or payment decision.”

“Why did you write it?”

“To make my access look larger.”

“Then is this admission against you?”

“As far as it goes, yes. It shows that I used to enlarge roles when writing about them. But the false expansion ‘he saw everything’ does not establish that Raghavji actually participated in everything.”

Raghav looked at Shashank. This time his voice was slightly softer. “At least now you are giving me the burden of my own name, and keeping the burden of your sentence with yourself.”

Shashank said, “It is late.”

“Lateness is not a decision,” the officer said. “Lateness is a fact about time.”

The sentence made Shashank tremble inwardly. Perhaps this was the ruthlessness of decision—it hears remorse, but does not move the place of evidence because of remorse.

After lunch Aditya placed another chain of messages on the table. A business person had written: “A copy has been sent to the lawyer, therefore it is protected.” The officer asked, “Does copying a lawyer automatically turn a business instruction into legally confidential material?”

Raghav answered himself. “No. One must examine the purpose, context, and relationship to legal advice. The mere presence of my name in the copy list is not enough.”

“And the moment a crime is alleged, does every old piece of legal advice automatically become unprotected?”

“No to that as well.”

The officer turned towards Shashank. “Do you understand the two Navya-Nyayas?”

Shashank said, “One side decides everything from the label on the word—if ‘lawyer’ is written, everything is protected; if ‘crime’ is alleged, everything is unprotected. The other method examines relationship, purpose, limits, and independent evidence.”

“And which method did you use more in your own life?”

A faint shame appeared on Shashank’s face. “The label method. ‘Special’, ‘principal’, ‘real’, ‘clear’—small words, large consequences.”

Raghav said, “You know language, but sometimes in the intoxication of adjectives you used to forget the noun.”

Shashank tried to smile, but no smile came. “I understand that today.”

The officer said, “Not ‘today’—at this moment. Decision is made on present evidence; write the autobiography afterwards.”

Meanwhile Aditya opened an old business file. At the top of one page, in bold letters, was written: "Legally approved." Shashank's chest thudded again. The officer asked directly, "Who wrote this heading?"

They examined the page's version sequence. The final copy belonged to an employee on the business side; the heading had not appeared in the employee's first draft. Before that, a short summary message had been added: "No objection from Raghav's side; proceed." That was Shashank's message. The officer said, "There are two documents here, but not two independent sources. The second document hardens the first sentence into a title."

Shashank said, "Then 'legally approved' is not independent evidence of Raghavji's opinion."

"Correct," the officer said, "but it is certainly evidence of the effect of your sentence. Your small expansion became a large seal in someone else's hand."

Raghav said calmly, "That is why the boundary of words is not merely a scholarly question. Once you wrote 'no objection', someone else wrote 'approved', and a third person might have said 'fully approved'. The error at the beginning of a chain does not make its author responsible for every later wrongdoing in the chain; but the initial error does not disappear either."

Shashank kept looking at the page. For the first time his language appeared to him as something that travelled. The author changed, the title changed, the weight increased; but for decision, merely reading the final heavy word without tracing the source backwards would be deceptive.

The officer asked, "Then the decision?"

Shashank said, "Raghavji's independent approval is not established. My broad summary is established. Later rewritings of that summary are established. Each rewriting is not independent legal support."

"And your responsibility?"

"For what I wrote. Not for what someone else added; but I will not run from the fact that my words gave them an opportunity."

By evening a brief statement had been prepared: "The available material establishes the existence of legal consultation, Shashank's linguistic assistance, and subsequent business summaries. Broad statements by Shashank such as 'the legal side is clear' and 'the lawyer saw everything' were not accurate quotations of the original legal opinion, but his own extensions. The available external records alone do not establish the advocate's participation in a crime; such participation would depend on independent acts, shared purpose, or other evidence. The boundary of legal privilege will remain subject to judicial determination."

Shashank read it and said, "Write 'my extension', not 'the extension'. Let the responsibility remain visible."

Aditya moved his pen.

As they came out, Raghav stopped. "Shashank."

"Yes?"

"Do not hide behind my name again out of fear."

Shashank said, "I will not."

"And do not make me guilty in order to defend yourself either."

"I will not."

Raghav walked away. Shashank stood on the stairs for a few moments. Friendship, profession, fear, and evidence seemed to be moving in four different directions; the work of decision was not to force them into one direction, but to mark their boundaries.

That night he met Mrinal. Mrinal asked, "Was the investigator from the other village a friend today or an enemy?"

Shashank replied, "Neither."

"Raghav?"

"Neither. He is standing within his own boundary."

"And you?"

Shashank remained silent for a long time. "Earlier I broke boundaries to create relationships. Now, whether the relationship survives or breaks, I will not break the boundary."

He opened his notebook and wrote:

"Legal advice = not participation in crime."

"Lawyer's name in a copy list = business message not automatically privileged."

"Allegation of crime = not every piece of legal advice automatically unprotected."

"Translator's broad summary = not the lawyer's original opinion."

"The lawyer saw everything" = my role-inflation; not the lawyer's universal participation."

"Actual participation = requires evidence such as independent acts, shared purpose, benefit, or instructions."

"Substance of confidentiality and external facts are separate."

"Fear = no reason to erase the boundary of a relationship."

“Decision = not a label; a joint settlement of relationship, purpose, evidence, and limits.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I borrowed the lawyer’s name to increase my courage; now decision teaches me that a borrowed name neither reduces a crime nor increases the evidence.”

Closing the notebook, he remembered the next heading—“Two Navya-Nyayas 3”. Now the gaze would turn back inside the institution—the altered tax-intelligence summary, the lower commissionerate’s resistance, and the experience of betrayal. But this time the test of decision would fall not on a person, but on an institutional act.

CHAPTER 94

TWO NAVYA-NYAYAS 3

The previous sentence kept circling inside Shashank all night—a borrowed name neither reduces a crime nor increases the evidence. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: “Today, not a person but an institution. The altered summary, the lower commissionerate’s resistance, and the final decision.”

The officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila was already seated in the office. This time there were not merely four copies before him, but the complete version sequence: the original note, the intermediate drafts, the final tax-intelligence summary, the work-allocation order, the note sheets, and the meeting records from those days. Aditya said, “In the earlier episode we asked: if the resistance had formally been crushed, what signs would be expected? Today the question is reversed—taken together, what decision follows from what is actually available?”

Shashank looked at the stack of papers. He remembered his own old softened summaries, in which question marks had gradually grown smaller until the text began to read like assertions. He knew it was easy to be angry at institutional betrayal; harder to admit that his own language had often practised the same softening.

The officer read the original note: “Actual beneficial ownership to be verified; unusual portions of the payment path to be separately examined; ‘hawala?’ and ‘digital asset?’ to remain in question form.” Then the intermediate draft. Then the final summary.

“What changed?” he asked.

Shashank said, “The line on beneficial ownership became shorter. Two cautions concerning the payment path disappeared. The question marks vanished. The line ‘no direct tax loss established’ became prominent.”

“Are those facts?”

“Textual facts.”

“And ‘the branch compromised?’”

Shashank paused. “That is a conclusion. It is not established by textual difference alone.”

There was neither satisfaction nor disappointment on the officer’s face. “The first rule of decision—what was seen, was seen; the meaning drawn from it needs a separate basis.”

Aditya placed the work-allocation order before them. One specific task had later been taken from the lower commissionerate officer and given to another branch, but his regular workload continued. His objection note remained in the record; there was no written order removing the objection.

Shashank said, “Then the resistance was not destroyed.”

The officer replied, “Say it this way—the written existence of the resistance was not destroyed in the available record. Protect the wording in a decision.”

Shashank shortened his sentence. “Yes. The written resistance remained.”

“And one task was taken away?”

“Yes.”

“Does that prove retaliation?”

“We need the reason. Reassignment alone does not.”

Aditya showed the explanatory note. Its language was ordinary administrative language—workload balancing, deadlines, coordination. The officer said, “This language may be true; it may also be a cover. Which of those possibilities will decision choose?”

The old haste rose inside Shashank—the word ‘cover’ attracted him. The pleasure of explaining an entire conspiracy with one word. But he remembered the officer’s lesson: expected signs, available records, the boundary of words.

“Neither, for now,” Shashank said. “An ordinary reason is available. There is no independent sign proving it false. But the reassignment and the objection note are close in time, so the question is legitimate.”

For the first time the officer smiled. “Decision begins here—keep the question alive; do not give birth to the conclusion prematurely.”

Then Aditya opened the meeting record. In one meeting the lower commissionerate’s objection had been read out. The response said: “Focus on high-priority conclusions; unverified hypotheses should not be in the main summary.” Shashank read the line twice.

“Fault in that?” Aditya asked.

"Not by itself. Keeping an unverified hypothesis out of a main summary can be a legitimate editorial policy."

"But if risk information, marked with a question, was necessary for later investigation?"

"Then removing it entirely could amount to narrowing the meaning."

"Narrowing the meaning = crime?"

"No."

"Narrowing the meaning = error?"

Shashank said, "It depends on the context. If the user reads only the main summary and the risk information is not readily available elsewhere, the effect of the conclusion may change."

The officer said, "That sounds like an argument for my side."

Shashank looked at him. "Not your side. The reader's effect."

"Good. In decision, less person; more structure."

Aditya took out another page. The final summary had an appendix list. The list mentioned the original question paper, but in one later file the copy that should have been attached to the main document was absent. In the earlier episode, questions had been raised about that absence. Today Aditya asked, "Now?"

Shashank said, "The main summary makes the risk smaller; the appendix list shows that the original question paper existed; in one file, the copy was not found. This is a mixed situation. Saying 'the questions were completely erased' would go too far, because their existence survives in the list. Saying 'the caution continued to reach readers unchanged' would also go too far, because the copy is absent."

The officer placed not his thumb but his pen on the table. "Why can this collision be called 'two Navya-Nyayas'?"

Shashank remained silent.

Then he said, "One Navya-Nyaya uses the edge of words to cut the story on the other side. The second lets the same edge cut its own side as well. If I looked only at 'the copy is missing', I would say conspiracy. If I looked only at 'the name appears in the list', I would say everything was fine. Decision keeps both together."

The sentence seemed to apply to Shashank himself. His life too had two files—one in which he was a talented translator, a reader of difficult language, a bridge across foreign business; another in which he reduced cautions to increase his importance, borrowed names, and inflated his role. Read only one file, and he would be either innocent talent or a complete fraud. The truth was harder than either.

Aditya asked, "Shashankji, what did you earlier believe about the tax-intelligence branch's 'compromise'?"

"That some influence had operated at a higher level because the questions became softer."

"And today?"

"The possibility of influence remains as a question. Some textual softening is established. The lower commissioner's resistance is established. Reassignment of one specific task is established. But broad collusion within the branch, a shared plan knowingly to suppress the objection, or direct collusion with an external party is not established by the records currently available."

Silence spread through the room. The officer asked, "Is this your defence?"

"No."

"My defence?"

"No."

"Then?"

Shashank said, "The present size of the available evidence."

The officer's eyes softened for a moment. "That is all decision is."

Then he threw a question at Shashank: "In your translations you repeatedly shortened sentences about risk. If another translator had done the same thing in this institutional summary, what would you call him?"

Shashank's throat caught. "Not a criminal without context. But someone who reduced the weight of meaning."

"And yourself?"

"In some places I reduced the weight of meaning."

"Knowingly?"

Shashank took time before answering. "In some places there was the greed to keep the client satisfied. In some places I called it making the language easier. The purpose was not the same everywhere."

"Then within the institution?"

"There too, purpose requires separate evidence for each change."

The officer said, "Exactly. Here the two Navya-Nyayas restrain each other. The rule you apply to yourself must also apply to the institution; the rule you apply to the institution must also apply to yourself."

After lunch Aditya read a draft conclusion: “The available material establishes the lower commissionerate’s objection, later textual compression, and one specific reassignment of work. This material does not establish broad criminal collusion at the institutional level or direct compromise with an external party; nevertheless, an independent administrative review of the narrowing of risk information and consistency of the records is warranted.”

Shashank stopped at the words “independent administrative review”. “That is not a criminal conclusion.”

“No,” Aditya said.

“And it does not mean everything was fine either.”

“No.”

The officer said, “The difficulty of decision is this—people want either guilt or purity. Institutions are rarely that simple.”

The old fire of betrayal rose again inside Shashank. It seemed to him that if a complete conspiracy were not proved, his experience would become false. He said, “But the loneliness of the person who resisted from inside was real.”

The officer looked directly at him. “Yes. The truth of an experience and the conclusion of a crime are different. I can read that my objection was softened. Why, by whom, through a shared purpose or through ordinary editorial judgment—the evidence for those is different.”

“Did it not feel like betrayal to you?” Shashank asked.

“It did.”

“Then why are you so restrained?”

The officer said, “Because my experience of betrayal is not my evidence. If I turn my pain into the conclusion, what difference will remain between your method and mine?”

Something broke inside Shashank. He remembered the moment when he had turned this officer from friend into enemy simply because the man would not give him the conclusion he wanted. Now he understood—the man would not grant privilege even to his own pain.

In the evening Mrinal was waiting outside. Shashank told him everything. Mrinal asked, “Then the branch is innocent?”

Instead of answering immediately, Shashank stopped. “Not that. Some institutional errors and questions are established. Broad collusion is not.”

“And the officer?”

“His resistance is real.”

“And betrayal?”

“His experience of it is real. Identifying the guilty party is separate.”

Mrinal laughed. “Your sentences are getting smaller now.”

“Not smaller,” Shashank said. “The right size.”

That night he opened his notebook and wrote: “Textual softening = established change; purpose requires separate evidence.”

“Lower commissionerate’s written objection = established fact.”

“One specific reassignment of work = established administrative act; not automatically retaliation.”

“Narrowing of risk in the main summary = reviewable; not automatically criminal collusion.”

“Mention of the original questions in the appendix list = limits the claim of complete deletion.”

“Absence of the copy in one file = question about the transmission chain; deliberate erasure not automatically established.”

“Experience of betrayal = truth of the character; not a criminal conclusion.”

“Institutional error, improper influence, and criminal collusion = three separate categories.”

“The standard applied to myself applies to the institution; the standard applied to the institution applies to myself.”

“Decision = not closing the question; fixing the present boundary of the evidence.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “The two Navya-Nyayas become one only when the blade is permitted to cut the hand that holds it.”

Closing the notebook, he remembered the next heading—“Two Navya-Nyayas 4”. Now the gaze would turn from the institution back towards public accusations—the media, humiliation, sealed material. The next test of decision would be this: of what was said publicly, which part was allegation, which part available fact, and which part had been enlarged in the name of a sealed source.

CHAPTER 95

TWO NAVYA-NYAYAS 4

The last line—"The two Navya-Nyayas become one only when the blade is permitted to cut the hand that holds it"—stayed inside Shashank all night. In the morning a message came from Aditya Mishra: "Today we will decide the public allegations. Keep four things separate: the media's sentences, the court's summary of the sealed material, the available external facts, and your own old statements."

The officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila was already seated in the office. This time there was no thick file on the table, only a seven-page chart. Across the top were four headings—"Established fact", "Inference", "Unsupported expansion", "Source unresolved". Shashank understood at once that the method of decision would now cut not his emotions, but sentences.

The officer said, "Last time we drew a boundary around institutional action. Today we will draw the boundary around what was said publicly about you. One thing must be clear at the outset—humiliation is a real experience, but it is not evidence for a decision. Second, if some things in a news report are erroneous, that does not make everything in the report false. Third, if some things are true, that does not make every conclusion attached to them true."

Aditya read the first line: "Shashank Jha travelled to Macao."

Shashank replied, "Established fact."

Second: "He had business contacts with people on the foreign vendor side."

"Established fact, but the distinct roles within the 'vendor side' remain separate."

Third: "He viewed limited internal linguistic material and prepared some risk summaries."

Shashank's face tightened slightly. "That too is established."

The officer placed the tip of his pen over the first column. "Will you deny these three because they caused you humiliation?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because they may hurt me, but they cannot be removed from the available records."

The officer moved to the next line: "Administrative super-control over a foreign server."

Shashank replied, "Unsupported expansion. There are records of limited visitor access; there is no independent sign of broad administrative authority."

"Should we call it 'unsupported' or 'false'?" Aditya asked.

Shashank paused. "To the extent that the available access records conflict with the claim of broad authority, the claim is erroneous to that extent. But the entire technical history is not before me; so I will say only as much as the records show."

The officer from Mithila smiled faintly. "This is the difficult part of decision. Humiliation wants revenge in a single word. Evidence says—only as far as proved."

Aditya read the next statement: "The sealed tax inquiry proved Shashank Jha to be the Indian mastermind of a money network."

For a moment the room was silent. This was the heavier form of the sentence whose taunts had reached Shashank's village. Acquaintances had gone to his father with questions. The photograph from the birthday stage, the performer, the foreign guests, the Macao trip—everything had been placed on one screen as a story of crime.

Shashank said, "The word 'proved' needs a basis."

Aditya opened the judicial summary. "The original sensitive text of the sealed material remains within its restricted boundary. The public summary issued by the court refers to questions about the payment path, verification of beneficial ownership, limited access, and some linguistic interventions. It does not contain a final conclusion such as 'Indian mastermind' or 'financial controller'."

The officer asked, "Then the decision?"

Shashank said, "The public claim that such a thing was 'proved' in the sealed material is not supported by the available judicial summary. But not every part of the sealed original is available to me, so I will not say that there is nothing adverse anywhere in it."

“Good,” the officer said. “Decision must rest on what can be seen. Do not turn unknown material into either a spear for accusation or a shield for defence.”

The next page on the table was a photograph from the banquet. A familiar performer from a well-known musical programme stood on the stage; Shashank was beside foreign guests. An old news headline called it: “Celebration of a Criminal Network.”

Aditya asked, “What does the photograph prove?”

“A banquet took place. I was present. The performer appeared. Foreign guests were there.”

“And a criminal network?”

“Not from the photograph.”

“Expenses?”

“The records showing the source of the expenses must be examined separately.”

“Foreign guests?”

“Presence. Not ownership, partnership, or participation in a crime.”

The officer from Mithila said, “Here the two Navya-Nyayas are clear. The first sees a photograph and then pastes the story already in one’s mind onto it. The second takes only what the photograph actually shows and asks for an independent basis for every further relationship.”

Shashank said, “But my boasting made that story easier to construct.”

“Which boasting?”

“Sentences such as ‘special access’, ‘the principal people come through me’, ‘the legal side is clear’, ‘I know the real owner’. I wrote them to make my role appear larger.”

The officer looked at him. “Then every fault in the public story belongs to outsiders?”

Shashank lowered his gaze. “No. My deceit with language gave them ready material. But it is also improper to treat my boasts as literal truth and thereby establish financial control.”

Aditya wrote in the chart: “Self-promotion: established. Content of self-promotion: requires independent verification.”

The line hurt Shashank. It seemed that the story of his public humiliation had come back to his own hands again. This time he did not run from it. “Keep that,” he said. “I will not place the entire weight of my humiliation on the media.”

The next statement was subtler: “Internal sources already knew Shashank’s role.”

The officer asked, “What do we have here?”

Aditya placed three kinds of material on the table. First—general portions of public contracts. Second—Shashank’s own business profile and old messages. Third—only the index of the sealed file. No available page showed the name, date, or statement of any specific “internal source” that independently confirmed the broad media claim.

Shashank said, “‘Internal sources’ goes into the source-unresolved category.”

The officer asked, “Not false?”

“The existence of an unknown source is not impossible. But there is presently no basis for treating it as established.”

“That is the language of decision,” the officer said. “Do not colour what you do not know according to preference.”

Then Aditya placed an old headline on the table: “Money Reached Abroad Through the Translator.” Shashank’s breathing grew heavier. So much inquiry had passed over payment paths, intermediary accounts, hawala references, and digital assets, yet in this one line everything had again become a terrifying full stop.

The officer asked, “Decision on the available material?”

Shashank chose each word. “I was shown some linguistic material relating to payments. Some economic relationships through service fees and travel expenses are established. Some unusual payment paths were examined as questions. But there is no available evidence of my independent authority as owner, instructor, beneficiary, or controller of the money path. Therefore the broad conclusion ‘money went abroad through me’ is unsupported.”

“And if new evidence appears tomorrow?”

“The decision can change.”

For the first time a slightly stern satisfaction appeared on the officer’s face. “A decision is not a statue. If evidence changes, the decision changes. But when a decision is made first at the speed of news and the evidence is made to run after it, that reverses the method.”

Humiliation rose again inside Shashank. He asked, “Then what about the responsibility of those who printed my name in large letters?”

Aditya said, “That is a separate question—the basis of publication, sources, caution, purpose, applicable law. In this file we are classifying facts only. It is natural to seek justice for humiliation; do not turn this inquiry into an instrument of revenge.”

The answer did not comfort Shashank immediately. He wanted someone to say plainly: injustice was done to you. But the officer said, “What was said erroneously about you, we will call erroneous. What you actually did, we will also call true. If justice becomes only consolation, it is no longer decision.”

Shashank’s face grew hot. “You keep cutting me all the time.”

“We cut your accusation,” the officer said, “and your defence as well. Cutting the person is not our work.”

At that sentence Shashank fell silent. He remembered his old illusion—seeing shared Mithila, shared language, shared Gangesha tradition, he had first taken the officer as ‘one of his own’; when he encountered a hard boundary, he had experienced him as an ‘enemy’. Now the same test had returned.

The officer turned the last page of the chart. All four columns were filled. Established facts: travel, business contacts, limited linguistic access, risk summaries, boasting, some linguistic softening. Inference: how deep the role was, whose decisions were influenced, how much knowledge existed. Unsupported expansion: administrative super-control beyond the limits of the available record, established financial control, automatic beneficial ownership. Source unresolved: alleged disclosure of sealed material, some claims attributed to unnamed internal sources.

Aditya asked, “Where does ‘false allegation’ belong in this table?”

The officer said, “Lack of support alone is not enough to call something a false allegation. If the claim clearly conflicts with the available evidence, or if facts were knowingly altered in making it, the category changes. At present some public statements are erroneous or unsupported; for some, the source is unresolved. A decision about purpose requires a separate basis.”

Shashank said softly, “Then if I say ‘everything was false’, I would repeat the same error the media made when it said ‘everything was proved’.”

“Yes,” Aditya said. “The two Navya-Nyayas meet again.”

After lunch a brief direction came from the court. The original boundary protecting sensitive material remained unchanged; no meaning beyond the judicial summary was to be attributed in public debate; the investigating side was to write facts, inferences, and unproved conclusions separately. It was neither exoneration nor conviction. It was the court’s boundary on procedure.

Shashank read the paper. At first he was disappointed—there was no emotional answer to his humiliation. Then he understood—the court was not measuring his pain; it was measuring the authority of words. How much an institution could say, how much meaning a document could carry, what evidentiary weight could support which allegation.

Mrinal was waiting outside. He held two cups of tea. Shashank took one.

Mrinal asked, “What was decided?”

“No final criminal decision yet. But a boundary has been drawn around the public statements.”

“Did you like it?”

Shashank thought for a few moments. “Half.”

“Why?”

“I wanted everything to be declared false. But some things are true—the journey, the contacts, the linguistic access, my boasts, my softening. I wanted the water of humiliation to wash them all away. It did not.”

Mrinal said, “And what you did not do?”

“The heavy words placed on top of those things were cut away.”

“Then why only half?”

Shashank looked at the steam rising from the tea. “Because decision does not give me the convenience of being only a victim.”

Mrinal replied, “Perhaps that is why a decision is a decision.”

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote—

“Public fact = may become a cause of humiliation; humiliation does not erase the fact.”

“Public exaggeration = does not give real facts the right to become a complete story of crime.”

“Name of sealed material = no licence to draw preferred conclusions about unknown content.”

“Judicial summary = only what is public can serve as the public basis of meaning.”

“Boasting = evidence of self-promotion; the content of the boast requires independent verification.”

“Photograph = presence; ownership or participation requires separate evidence.”

“Unsupported claim = not automatically a false allegation; clear contradiction or knowing distortion is a separate question.”

“Source unresolved = not a blank space in which to write the culprit’s name.”

“Humiliation = experience; decision = classification of evidence.”

“Decision = giving the sentences of accusation and defence their proper size.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “The words enlarged to defame me must be cut back; but no justice will be complete if I protect the words I myself enlarged in my own life.”

Closing the notebook, he remembered the next heading—“False Allegation”. The sentences of public humiliation had now been classified; the next day that classification would collide with cross-examination in court. The question would no longer be merely whether an allegation was false, but who was responsible for which part of which sentence, and how much Shashank had the authority to accept in the name of his atonement.

CHAPTER 96

FALSE ALLEGATION

The court's list that day was short, but Shashank felt as though all the old sentences had gathered in one place. In the earlier proceedings, the public allegations had already been classified; now, in cross-examination, the question was who had the right to call something a "false allegation", and up to what limit. At the outset the judge made it clear: "The court is not a place for measuring pain; it will examine the relationship among statement, basis, and responsibility."

The government counsel lifted the first record. Its headline read: "Shashank Jha: Financial Controller of a Foreign Gambling Network." He asked, "Do you call this headline false?"

Shashank's mouth went dry. Earlier he would have answered with a single word—"yes". But now he remembered the sentence in his own notebook: there is a difference between an unsupported claim and a knowing distortion.

He said, "The 'financial controller' part of the headline is not established by the available evidence. My travel, vendor contacts, linguistic coordination, and some risk summaries are real. But independent signs of financial control—decision-making authority, distribution of benefit, account instructions, or beneficial ownership—have not yet been proved. So it would not be proper to classify the whole headline with one word."

The government counsel smiled. "Meaning you cannot say the allegation is false?"

The officer from the lower commissionerate sat near the witness row. With the judge's permission, he said, "The question is being turned upside down. If one specific part of a statement conflicts with the evidence, that part must be tested on its own. 'Everything true' and 'everything false' are two extremes."

"Are you a lawyer?" the government counsel asked.

"No," the officer said. "I read the boundaries of records."

A faint murmur rose in the courtroom. The judge said, "Keep the question on method, not personality."

The government counsel lifted a second paper. "You yourself wrote in a message: 'All the principal people come through me.' Is that not an indication of financial control?"

Shashank replied, "That was my boasting, and an exaggeration of some linguistic centrality. In those two earlier episodes no independent sign of decision-making authority was found. But I did write the sentence—that is a fact. I bear the moral responsibility for it."

"You now want to escape by calling it boasting?"

"No. By calling it boasting I am not reducing its criminal value; I am only correcting its evidentiary value. If independent records of authority matching that sentence had been found, the conclusion would have been different."

The government counsel moved to the third paper. This time it was a news sentence: "Sealed government material regularly reached the translator."

"Did you ever see sealed material?"

Shashank paused. "I saw some internal linguistic material. I do not accept the broad claim that 'sealed government material regularly reached me'. My name does not appear in the known official access records, and the source chain has not been established. But it has also not been proved that every possible medium was fully recorded. So I will not say 'it was never possible'."

The government counsel asked sharply, "Is your atonement nothing more than adding a 'but' to every answer?"

The question struck Shashank. It seemed that all his efforts of the past months were being made to look like a tactic in court. He remained silent for a few moments.

"No," he said. "For me, atonement means two things. I must accept, without excuse, the errors that are proved. And I must not place an unproved crime on my own head merely because I am ashamed. If I abandon the second part, it becomes self-punishment, not justice."

The judge stopped writing. "Let that answer be recorded."

Raghav Bhasin rose. His tone was ordinary. "My Lord, the focus of cross-examination should remain on the wording of the allegation, not on the defendant's inner emotion. I would like to place three sentences separately."

The first sentence: "Shashank travelled to Macao." The second: "Shashank acted as a linguistic intermediary in some contacts with foreign vendors." The third: "Shashank became the source of sealed government material and operated a financial network."

Raghav asked, "The first?"

"Established fact," Shashank said.

"The second?"

"Supported by some records, but not 'all contacts'."

"The third?"

"Not established by the evidence presently available."

Raghav turned towards the court. "If these three sentences are merged into one headline, the reader transfers the weight of the first two truths onto the third. In testing a false allegation, that linguistic leap must be examined."

The government counsel objected. "To call it false, intention is required. The state of mind of the journalist or source has not yet been proved."

The judge said, "Correct. Keep three levels separate: a part contrary to fact, an unsupported part, and a knowingly false presentation. The court will not make a final decision on intent at this stage."

Then came the turn of the officer from the lower commissionerate. Raghav asked, "When do you use the expression 'false allegation' in an investigation?"

The officer said, "Very cautiously. First we identify the concrete content of the statement. Then its source. Then whether the available records agree with it or conflict with it. Then whether contrary facts were available to the person making the statement. Merely failing to find proof does not, by itself, establish knowing falsehood."

"And if contrary records existed?"

"Then the question becomes harder. For example, if someone wrote that 'Shashank had full administrative authority', while an access list available to that person clearly showed limited visitor access, the claim of 'full authority' would be contrary to the record. But one would still need to examine whether the writer had seen that list and understood its context."

The government counsel asked, "So are you protecting the accuser too?"

The officer said calmly, "I am not protecting a person. I am defining the limits of the decision."

Shashank looked at the officer at that sentence. In the earlier episode those very words had felt like hostility. Today he understood—the same sentence stood in his favour and against him.

Another old message was then read in court. Shashank had written: "The legal side is clear; proceed." Raghav's original advice remained protected within the boundary of confidentiality, but the external record established that Shashank had broadened the meaning of the caution.

The government counsel asked, "Was this sentence of yours not a false assurance to the other side?"

Shashank drew a long breath. "Yes. It was my linguistic deceit. Whatever legal caution existed, I presented it as a more definite approval. I accept that."

"Then you yourself were a maker of false statements?"

"In some contexts I knowingly made sentences larger. But that admission does not mean every heavy allegation against me is true. The answer to my false sentence cannot be another false sentence."

For a moment the courtroom fell silent. Remorse rose inside Shashank, but this time he did not allow it to become a flood of words. It seemed to him that perhaps atonement meant naming his fault, not naming his entire self as a crime.

The judge asked the officer, "How should the Navya-Nyaya concept of 'decision' apply to this dispute?"

The officer said, "After doubt, when the reasons on both sides have been examined and a conclusion becomes stable on sufficient grounds, that is decision. But stability does not mean exaggeration. If the evidence reaches only 'linguistic role', the decision will not leap to 'financial control'. If the evidence reaches 'knowingly softened legal caution', the decision will not say 'he devised every criminal plan'."

"And false allegation?"

"Decision first fixes the boundary of the statement. Then it asks whether the statement is contrary to the evidence, merely unsupported, or distorted with intent. Those three are not one word."

The judge wrote for some time. Then he read an interim observation: "The linguistic exaggerations admitted by the defendant during cross-examination are relevant to testing his moral and possible legal responsibility. However, without independent evidence, such admissions shall not be treated as admissions of unrelated financial control, status as a source of sealed material, or a wider conspiracy. The source, factual basis, and knowledge of the maker shall be examined separately for each disputed part of the public statements."

The government counsel rose. "My Lord, the defence will use this observation as an acquittal."

The judge replied, "That too would be an error. This is not an acquittal; it is classification."

Raghav also rose. "And will the prosecution call it an obstacle to conviction?"

"That too would be an error. The decision extends only as far as the evidence."

Shashank's eyes lowered involuntarily. He remembered a teacher in his village once saying: whether an answer is short or long, if it becomes larger than the subject, it is not an answer but vanity. Since coming to Delhi, Shashank had made his answers larger than their subjects many times. Now the court was measuring that vanity.

During the recess Mrinal met him in the veranda. He asked, "What did you admit today?"

"That I gave some people legal caution in the erroneous form of definite approval. That I wrote my role larger. That I bent language for prestige."

"And what did you not admit?"

"That I controlled a financial network, that I was a regular source of sealed material, that every plan ran under my instructions—because there is no independent proof of those things."

Mrinal asked, "What does your guilt say now?"

Shashank answered softly, "Earlier it said—take everything onto your head; then you will find peace. Now I understand that even that is a form of ego. I am not so large that every fault can be mine."

Mrinal smiled. "Atonement needs humility too."

In the evening session, the court called for evidentiary lists for two public statements. One gave the correct dates of Shashank's travel and meeting, but added the words "confidential government partner". The second called his limited linguistic access "complete digital control". The court directed that, for every mixed sentence, the true portion and the disputed extension be placed in separate columns.

A strange lightness came over Shashank. This was not victory. Real material against him still existed—boasting, softened warnings, business coordination, greed, hunger for prestige. But now each of those things was receiving only the name the evidence could bear.

As he came out, the officer from the lower commissionerate stopped beside him. He said, "Today you did not cut away the evidence against yourself."

Shashank said, "There was no reason to cut it away."

"And you did not enlarge the boundary merely to gain an advantage for your side."

"If I had, it would have been the old habit again."

The officer said, "Then the practice of decision has begun."

That night Shashank opened his notebook and wrote—

"False allegation = not pain alone; test of statement, basis, and knowledge."

"Unsupported = not automatically knowingly false."

"Part contrary to the evidence = separate examination."

"True fact + unproved extension = mixed sentence; the whole sentence is not one colour."

"Accepting my linguistic deceit = not accepting unrelated crimes."

"Atonement = the full name of proved guilt; rejection of unproved guilt."

"Boasting = evidence of state of mind; the content of the boast requires independent verification."

"Judicial classification = neither acquittal nor conviction."

"Decision = stable conclusion up to the boundary of the evidence."

"The sentence that protects me must also give my fault its correct size."

As he wrote the final line, he stopped: "I will not make myself smaller than my crime, but I will not make myself larger than my crime either."

Closing the notebook, he remembered the next heading—"Two Navya-Nyayas 6". The boundaries of the sentences had been fixed in cross-examination; the next stage would return to the summons, the statements, and the seized digital material. But this time the question would not merely be what had been found—which propositions could become stable decisions in a formal statement, and at what points did Shashank's ambition make his own words credible evidence against him?

CHAPTER 97

TWO NAVYA-NYAYAS 6

Two days after the previous cross-examination, Shashank was summoned again for a supplementary statement. The paper was short—clarification only on those sentences found in the seized digital material that were being read in different ways in court. Reading the summons, Shashank understood that today the dispute would not be about the number of facts, but about the size of the decision.

Aditya Mishra, the officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila, and the records assistant were already seated in the office. Three thin files lay on the table. The officer said, “Today we will not try to discover new evidence. We will see how far the material already available can validly support a sentence of decision.”

Shashank asked, “Meaning we will go over what has already been said?”

“Not go over it,” the officer said. “Stabilise it. See where the distance between doubt and decision ends.”

The first file contained an old message from the seized phone: “The matter has reached all the way up; don’t worry.” In the earlier episode Shashank had already admitted that the word “up” had been deliberately left vague so that his influence would appear larger than it was. Aditya placed the first question: “What stable decision follows from this sentence?”

Shashank said, “That I wrote the sentence.”

“And?”

“That I wanted to appear influential.”

The officer asked, “Direct confidential access to a senior official?”

Shashank remained silent, then said, “Not from this sentence alone.”

The records assistant read out the timestamp, recipient, and message chain. The chain named no specific officer, contained no confidential instruction, and contained no reply identifying who “up” referred to.

The officer drew three lines on the paper—

“Authorship—established.”

“Language intended to display influence—supported by context.”

“Specific confidential access—not established.”

Shashank asked, “Is that the decision?”

“For this proposition,” the officer said. “Not for your entire life.”

A flicker of irritation rose inside Shashank. He wanted one large sentence—“the allegation is not proved.” But the officer kept building small boundaries, proposition by proposition.

The second file was opened. The sentence was: “All the principal people come through me.” The earlier inquiry had established that some important linguistic communications did pass through Shashank, but a great deal of business communication also proceeded without him.

Aditya asked, “Decision on this sentence?”

Shashank said, “I handled some important linguistic coordination.”

“All?”

“No.”

“Through me?”

“In some contexts.”

The officer said, “Then one part of the sentence is an exaggeration of experience, but the whole sentence is not empty theatre. This is where a second misuse begins.”

Shashank looked at him.

The officer said, “One method will seize your word ‘all’ and say: look, this man was the centre of the entire network. Another method will say: it was boasting, therefore it has no evidentiary value at all. Both are wrong. Boasting can be evidence of state of mind; it can also reflect some real linguistic centrality. But pervasive control requires separate signs.”

Aditya added, “Decision does not wash evidence away; it places its weight in the correct place.”

Shashank said softly, “Earlier I used to make the language larger. Now I am afraid the inquiry will turn that enlarged language into fact.”

“That fear may be reasonable,” the officer said, “but the answer is not to shrink all the language by calling it performance.”

The third file contained an old line from his statement: “I had no private contact with any officer.” The digital records showed two brief communications with a general government-office contact number; Shashank later amended his statement and accepted that there had been ordinary administrative contact.

The officer asked, “After this erroneous broad denial, should your entire statement be treated as unreliable?”

Shashank wanted to answer at once, but stopped himself. “No—but my credibility on this subject is reduced.”

Aditya looked at him. “By how much?”

“By as much as this denial affects it. Other matters should be tested on independent evidence.”

The officer smiled. “This time your answer is close to decision.”

Shashank asked, “If I made a false overbroad statement in one place, the prosecution can say that I am lying elsewhere too.”

“It can say that,” the officer replied, “but for decision it is only a reason for caution, not an automatic conclusion. Credibility becomes a question; the truth of each proposition still requires its own basis.”

Shashank did not find the answer comforting. He wanted the officer to say, “One error changes nothing.” But the officer did not say that.

The records assistant opened the next page. There was another old message from Shashank: “Once the report goes upward, the language will change.” In the earlier episode the timing and context of the sentence had been examined. No direct sign of specific prior knowledge of sealed material had been found; a general procedural inference remained possible.

Aditya asked, “Decision on this?”

Looking not at Shashank but at the record, the officer said, “The sentence exists. The report may go upward and its language may change—such a general experience or inference is not impossible. But a decision that ‘this man knew a specific internal revision beforehand’ requires specific prior markers. That has not been established in the available protected route.”

Shashank said, “Then that helps me?”

The officer raised his head. “Again you are looking for advantage.”

Shashank felt embarrassed.

“Decision is not an account book of advantages,” the officer said. “What is not established will not be written as established. What is established will not be weakened for your convenience.”

For a few moments the room was silent. From outside came the bell of a cart selling water. Shashank suddenly remembered his old days—practising language by speaking with Chinese tourists near the Red Fort, the Tao temple in Pitampura, Juliana’s exacting lessons in pronunciation. Then he would spend hours getting a word right. After entering business, the same man began deliberately blurring meaning. Ambition had been the fire with which he learned language; later the same fire became a tool for burning meaning.

The officer put the next question. “You repeatedly say that ambition made you present your role as larger than it was. Is this explanation merely a defence invented afterwards?”

Shashank took a long breath. “It may be that some parts are clearer to me in hindsight. But the contemporary messages repeatedly contain boasting, while independent records of authority do not match the scale of those boasts. That is as much as I can say.”

“Ambition established?”

“Sufficiently supported by my conduct and words.”

“Purpose of a specific crime?”

“A separate question.”

“Desire for economic gain?”

Shashank paused. “I wanted to earn more, gain prestige, and remain close to important people. But a specific distribution of criminal benefit or ownership still requires independent evidence.”

Aditya wrote: “General disposition of greed admitted; decision on specific unlawful benefit separate.”

Shashank kept looking at the paper. He felt that the word ‘decision’ was now protecting him and cutting him at the same time. Earlier, non-apprehension had taught him the boundary of empty spaces; decision was teaching him how to give the empty and the filled spaces their proper distance within the same sentence.

After lunch the supplementary statement was drafted. Reading the first draft, Shashank stopped at one line: “The seized material proves Shashank Jha’s broad claims of influence false.”

He said, “That is too large.”

The records assistant asked, “Why?”

“Because some influence was real. Write: ‘The claim of broad decision-making authority is not supported by independent records.’ Not all my influence was false.”

The officer looked at him. “Are you preserving something against yourself?”

“Yes,” Shashank said, “because if we write that all influence was false, my actual coordination disappears as well.”

The line was changed.

The second line read: “Shashank’s boasts were merely self-promotion.”

Shashank stopped again. “Not ‘merely’. They were self-promotion, but some sentences enlarged a real limited role. If we write ‘merely’, I make my own responsibility smaller.”

For the first time Aditya smiled faintly. “Which direction is your ambition moving now?”

Shashank did not answer.

The officer said, “Earlier your ambition was to enlarge your role. Now perhaps it is to obtain a perfectly clean character certificate. Cut both with the method.”

The sentence went deep inside Shashank. He truly wanted some final record to say: “Shashank Jha is innocent.” But the file was not that simple. It contained real acts, moral fault, misleading language, some heavy unsupported allegations, and some incomplete investigation.

“Then what will I get?” Shashank asked.

The officer said, “Not a character certificate. A statement of propositions. Each point only as far as proved.”

The final form of the supplementary statement was prepared—

“Certain contemporary messages written by Shashank Jha present his influence, access, and centrality more broadly than his actual role; these support a pattern of self-promotion and ambition. The available digital records establish some linguistic coordination, risk summaries, and ordinary administrative contacts. However, those messages alone do not establish a specific confidential government source, broad administrative decision-making authority, financial control, or beneficial ownership. The earlier broad denial of ‘no contact’ has been amended and will remain relevant to the assessment of credibility on the related subject. Every serious allegation requires independent evidence.”

Shashank read the entire paragraph twice. It contained neither praise nor condemnation. It seemed the opposite of his old world of language, where everything was either “fully approved”, “no problem”, or “all through me”.

Before signing, he asked, “Will the court accept this as the decision?”

Aditya said, “The court will give its own decision. This is the limited conclusion of the investigation.”

“So there are levels even within decision?”

The officer said, “Certainly. Investigative conclusion, prosecutorial claim, judicial observation, proved fact—they are not the same. Navya-Nyaya is not merely the art of giving things names; it is the discipline of not distorting relationships.”

In the evening Mrinal was waiting for him. He asked, “Did they save you today or trap you?”

Shashank remained silent for a few moments, then said, “Neither.”

“Then?”

“They gave my sentence its proper size.”

Mrinal laughed. “Did that hurt?”

“A great deal. I wanted a large decision.”

“Earlier you wanted a large title, large access, large connections. Now a large innocence?”

A bitter smile came to Shashank’s face. “Perhaps ambition changed form and returned.”

That night he opened his notebook and wrote—

“Summons = another opportunity; not mechanical repetition of an earlier conclusion.”

“Seized sentence = may prove authorship and state of mind; truth of its content requires separate testing.”

“Boasting = neither zero evidence nor total evidence.”

“Amendment of one broad denial = question of credibility; not automatic falsity of every statement.”

“Ambition = reason for role-inflation; elements of a specific crime are separate.”

“Real limited influence = acknowledged; broad decision-making authority = requires independent evidence.”

“Decision = not a character certificate; the proper size of a proposition.”

“Investigative conclusion = not a judicially proved fact.”

“Calling it ‘mere performance’ for the advantage of my own side can itself be deceit about meaning.”

“Navya-Nyaya = only as much as is proved.”

Writing the final line, Shashank stopped for a long time: “Earlier I gave a small authority a large name; if now I give a large fault a small name, the method will not have changed—only the direction will.”

Closing the notebook, he saw the heading on the next file: “Two Navya-Nyayas 7.” Contracts, the vendor path, and beneficial ownership were about to return. Pride in language had been his old strength; the next test would ask how decision becomes stable between a single word in a contract, a single name in a vendor list, and the many meanings of ‘owner’.

CHAPTER 98

TWO NAVYA-NYAYAS 7

The next morning only three words were written on the file: contract, vendor path, beneficial ownership.

When Shashank entered the room, Aditya and the officer from another village in Mithila were already seated. Three separate records lay on the table—a service contract, a vendor-registration file, and a customer-identification form. All three papers related to the same business relationship, but each had a different purpose.

The officer opened the first page. “You translated this paragraph?”

Shashank read it. The paragraph said that the service provider would retain rights over its software, name-mark, and specified technical material. In his own old Maithili summary, the word “owner” appeared at one point.

“Yes,” Shashank said, “here ‘owner’ meant the rights-holder.”

Aditya placed the second page before him. It was an internal summary from the vendor-registration file. Someone had later written by hand: “Ownership relationship clear from prior contract.”

Shashank was silent for a moment. “I did not write that sentence.”

“I am not saying that you did,” Aditya said. “The question is whether the ‘prior contract’ actually clarified the company’s beneficial ownership, or only rights in intellectual property.”

Shashank’s old pride in language stirred within him. Once he would have answered such a question at once: “I understand the true meaning of this word in Chinese.” Now he read the page again.

“This paragraph alone does not establish beneficial ownership,” he said. “The objects are different. Who owns the software, and who is the natural person ultimately receiving the company’s economic benefit—those are two separate questions.”

The officer did not smile. “Then if someone sees the word ‘owner’ and immediately says the beneficial owner has been identified?”

“An erroneous decision.”

“And if the defence says the word ‘owner’ is polysemous, therefore no ownership-related record has any evidentiary value?”

Shashank looked at the page again. “That would also be wrong. A polysemous word takes its meaning from context.”

The officer said, “This is where the two Navya-Nyayas diverge again. One seizes a word and enlarges the relationship; the other displays ambiguity and erases the relationship. In both, language becomes sovereign over evidence.”

The third record was the customer-identification form. Its question was explicit: who is the natural person receiving the company’s ultimate economic benefit, or the person exercising control? Two names were written down, but identity verification was incomplete for one. The other had an address and identification number, but the proportion of control was blank.

Aditya asked, “What does this form establish?”

Before Shashank could answer, the officer raised a hand. “One proposition at a time.”

Shashank said, “It establishes that two persons were named on the form. It also shows that identity verification for one was partial. But this page alone does not fully establish who the actual ultimate beneficial owner was.”

“Why?”

“The proportion of control is blank. The update date is also old. And whether anything changed after this page would require separate records.”

The officer looked towards Aditya. “That is decision. Do not make the record smaller; do not make it larger.”

The next file on the table was opened. There were four entities in the vendor path. The first had signed the contract, the second issued invoices, the third provided technical support, and the fourth appeared only in a note about payment coordination. Shashank had served as translator in meetings involving two of the four entities.

Aditya asked, “The public allegation says all four entities were shells for a single hidden ownership. What do the available records show?”

The officer placed a table before them. “Separate the markers of relationship.”

Same office address?—not for two of the entities; one old correspondence record showed a common contact address.

Same director?—not in the available file.

Same bank beneficiary?—no.

Same telephone or email administrator?—some shared business contacts, but no proof of ownership.

Same verified declaration of ultimate beneficial owner?—not available.

Contractual right for one to control another?—not clear.

The officer said, “Does this prove that a single hidden ownership was impossible?”

Instead of answering immediately, Shashank stopped. “No.”

“Does it prove a single ownership?”

“No to that as well.”

“Then?”

“Some operational relationships are established. The broader claim of common ownership still requires independent records.”

Aditya asked, “You once wrote in a message: ‘They are all people from the same house.’”

Shashank’s ears grew hot. He remembered the message. He had written it after a meeting to make his own importance seem greater.

“It was a business idiom,” Shashank said, then stopped himself. “No—that would be another small defence. I deliberately wrote the sentence to create an impression. I saw some shared contacts and gave them a meaning close to common ownership.”

The officer asked, “Was your sentence disinformation?”

Shashank remained silent for a while. “It went beyond the extent of my knowledge at the time. But I cannot say that I definitely knew the opposite to be true. So it is more accurate to call it self-promotion and misleading expansion; proving a knowingly false ownership story would require more evidence.”

A faint approval appeared on the officer’s face. “For the first time, pride in language is placing a boundary on its own sentence.”

To Shashank this felt less like praise than a wound. Language had been his strength. After coming to Delhi he had made a living from subtle distinctions in words; he had astonished people by catching nuances of Mandarin and Cantonese; he had saved meetings by opening up ambiguous clauses in contracts. Now the same language was telling him that understanding the subtlety of a word and knowing the truth of a relationship were not the same thing.

Aditya took out an old bilingual note. Beneath the Chinese original, Shashank had written a Maithili rendering of an internal summary prepared through English: “The final decision will come from the owner side.”

“Who was the ‘owner side’ here?” Aditya asked.

Shashank read the following portion of the page. The original context concerned licence rights in a technical platform. “Not the company’s beneficial owner. The party holding the platform rights.”

“But in a later internal note this sentence was quoted and rewritten as: ‘The final decision is made by the real owner.’”

Shashank lowered his head. “The relationship changed there.”

The officer asked, “Who changed it?”

“That cannot be determined from this page.”

“Proved that Shashank changed it?”

“No.”

“Proved that Shashank’s original wording became a source for the later erroneous decision?”

“Looking at the chain, yes—at least this page shows that the later note relied on the original summary.”

“Then responsibility?”

Shashank wanted to answer slowly, but stopped the word inside himself; then he said softly, “I am responsible for my word choice. If someone later enlarged the relationship, that responsibility is theirs. But I cannot say that my ambiguous ‘owner side’ was entirely innocent.”

Silence spread through the room.

The officer said, “That is the difficulty of decision. A chain of causation breaks into pieces. The first ambiguity, another person’s exaggeration, a third person’s accusation—neither can all of it be placed on one person, nor can everyone be excused by saying each act was separate.”

Aditya opened the next part of the beneficial-ownership verification sheet. One note read: “Re-verification required.” No complete re-verification report appeared in the file after it.

Shashank said, "Then beneficial ownership remained uncertain."

The officer immediately asked, "Could the file be incomplete?"

"Yes."

"Could re-verification have occurred in another system?"

"Possible."

"Then the word 'uncertain'?"

Shashank corrected himself. "On the basis of this file, complete re-verification is not established."

"That is the language of decision," the officer said. "Decision does not erase uncertainty; it writes its boundary."

Then Aditya put a difficult question. "Suppose the prosecution says: Shashank was the translator, knew the vendor path, and used the word 'owner'; therefore he must have known the real beneficial owner."

Shashank answered first. "That is a leap."

The officer asked, "Why?"

"Because linguistic access $\neq$ ownership verification. Knowing the vendor path $\neq$ knowing the ultimate economic beneficiary. Reading a contract $\neq$ having full access to customer-identification records."

"And if the defence says: he was only a translator, therefore he could not possibly have known any part of the business structure?"

Remembering his own old sentence, Shashank smiled. "That too is a leap. I did know parts of the structure. I knew some of the meetings, contacts, risk summaries, and vendor relationships."

The officer said, "Then again the distinction between two Navya-Nyayas. One method infers omniscience from a role; the other shrinks the role until knowledge becomes zero. Decision cuts away both and stops where knowledge is actually proved."

By afternoon the five pages of the file carried marks in three colours—established, incomplete, unsupported. Shashank saw that his life too seemed to be dividing itself among those three words.

Established—he was a talented translator; he had a role in foreign vendor relationships; he understood some contracts and meetings; he wrote about his own influence in enlarged terms.

Incomplete—how deeply he knew ownership information; how certain his knowledge was of any person's actual ultimate beneficial ownership; whether he knew of later changes in ownership.

Unsupported—to infer control of an entire hidden ownership network merely from his use of the word "owner" or from his presence in meetings.

Shashank asked, "Then is language saving me or making me guilty?"

The officer said, "Language does nothing. You people write relationships with language. Justice asks whether the relationship actually existed."

"But an erroneous translation?"

"That can itself be a fact."

"Knowingly erroneous?"

"That requires separate evidence."

"And if its consequences were serious?"

"Consequences may change the weight of responsibility; they do not automatically prove the state of mind."

For the first time Shashank felt that the opposite of pride in language was not humiliation of language, but discipline in language. The word had not become smaller; its authority had become bounded.

In the evening he met Mrinal. Shashank told him everything.

Mrinal asked, "What hurt you most?"

"That I may have translated the word 'owner' correctly and yet the later conclusion could still be wrong."

"Then getting the word right is not enough?"

"No. The question is also: owner of what—the software, the mark, the company, the benefit, or the decision?"

Mrinal laughed. "When a bull is sold in the village, 'owner' is clear enough."

Shashank laughed too. "In a Delhi file, one word has five courts."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote—

"One word = not one relationship."

"Owner of software rights in a contract = not automatically the company's beneficial owner."

"Polysemy = not every ownership record meaningless."

"Vendor path = operational relationship; ownership requires separate markers."

"Shared contact = not automatically shared control."

“Name on a customer-identification form = nomination; full beneficial ownership requires verification, control, and current information.”

“One ambiguous summary can become the source of later exaggeration; later exaggeration is not automatically the original writer’s intention.”

“Linguistic access = not omniscience.”

“Only a translator = not zero knowledge either.”

“Decision = examine together the meaning of the word, the purpose of the record, and the external relationship.”

As he wrote the final line, Shashank stopped: “I used to take pride in catching the true meaning of a word; now I understand that justice asks beyond the meaning of the word—how does that meaning truly connect to this person, this authority, and this record?”

Closing the notebook, he saw the next heading: “THE FINAL TEST OF NAVYA-NYAYA.” The money path would return—intermediary accounts, payment gateways, hawala references, digital assets, and friendship. But now the question would not be merely which signs existed or did not; one test remained—whether, in a final decision, a human being could keep the same standard between his friend, his own fault, and his evidence.

CHAPTER 99

THE FINAL TEST OF NAVYA-NYAYA

In the morning Aditya Mishra said only this much to Shashank on the phone: “Today is the final financial classification. If you wish, you may inform Mrinal as well. His name has come into the file again because of an old set of initials.”

Shashank’s hand went still for a moment. In that earlier episode, the question of the initials ‘M.K.’ had arisen, and it had then become clear that initials are not a person. A lawful reimbursement record relating to Mrinal had also already been identified separately. Yet as soon as the shadow of the name rose again, old friendship reached Shashank first; reasoning came afterwards.

He phoned Mrinal. “Your name has come up again.”

Mrinal remained silent for a few moments. “Has my name come up, or evidence?”

Shashank heard his own old lesson spoken back to him. “At present, a possible indication of the name.”

“Then do not go there to save me. Go there to examine me.”

The sentence hurt Shashank. The friend who for years had stood beside him through humiliation, fear, and ego was today asking not for defence, but for the same standard.

In the office, Aditya, the officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila, and two files were already waiting. One file was titled “Payment Path”; the other, “Person-Link”. Without any preamble, the officer said, “Today we will investigate neither friend nor enemy. We will investigate relationships.”

Aditya opened the first record. It contained payment details from different periods, separately showing service payments to the vendor side, some intermediary payment gateways, and translation and coordination fees linked to Shashank’s name.

The officer asked, “What does this establish?”

Shashank stopped before answering. “That I received service fees—that is established. That the vendor side used multiple channels—that too is recorded. But multiple channels do not, merely by existing, establish hawala, proceeds of crime, or beneficial ownership.”

“And your fees?”

“They establish an economic relationship; not automatically a share in criminal proceeds.”

The officer placed a finger along one edge of the paper. “Correct. But do not say that there was no economic relationship either.”

Shashank nodded. “That would be false.”

On the second page was an old internal summary: “Coordination with M.K.” After that line, some later comments had treated ‘M.K.’ as Mrinal Karn. Aditya asked, “Basis for identification?”

The file contained three things: first, the initials; second, Mrinal’s contact in Shashank’s phone; third, a lawful reimbursement from a different period. But the disputed payment path did not establish Mrinal’s account identity, instructions, benefit, control, recipient relationship, or any crime-specific message.

The officer looked at Shashank. “If you wish, on the basis of friendship you can say—Mrinal is innocent.”

Shashank’s face flushed. “I want to. But I will not.”

“Why?”

“Because friendship is not proof of innocence. The available record says only this much: there is not yet sufficient independent basis to identify ‘M.K.’ as Mrinal, and the lawful reimbursement is not evidence of the disputed payment path. If other evidence is found, it can be examined then.”

For the first time a faint satisfaction appeared on the officer’s face. “And if I say that Mrinal must be guilty because his initials match?”

“That too would be an erroneous decision.”

“Even though he is your friend?”

“Even then.”

For a moment silence spread through the room. Shashank understood—the question was not about Mrinal; it was his own test. For years he had widened and narrowed the meanings of words according to convenience. Now a beloved person’s name had been placed before him and he was being asked: will you change the standard or not?

Aditya opened the third file. It contained many uses of the word ‘hawala’: some in media summaries, some in internal risk notes, some in question form. The officer read the lines one by one and asked, “Here, is ‘hawala’ an established fact or an investigative possibility?”

Shashank saw that in one place the question mark from the original note had disappeared in a later summary. He said, “A possibility in the original note. In one later summary the word became harder. Repetition alone does not turn it into an established fact.”

“Digital assets?”

“There are references in some external payment contexts. But whose control, whose benefit, whose instruction—those are separate questions. Merely hearing the name does not establish the chain.”

Aditya said, “In this matter we have repeatedly encountered two kinds of error. One: seeing an instrument and immediately declaring a crime. Two: saying that because the instrument can also be lawful, every risk must be denied.”

The officer added, “Decision is not laziness between those two. Decision requires us to determine the form of the relationship.”

He wrote four words on the paper: “identity”, “instruction”, “benefit”, “control”. Then he said, “If an intermediary account was a crime-specific channel for someone, one would expect some independent sign among these four. Not necessarily all four every time, but similarity of name or type of channel alone is not enough.”

Shashank asked, “And if the records are incomplete?”

“Then the language of the conclusion becomes smaller. Incompleteness gives no right to prove guilt; it gives no right to prove innocence either.”

The sentence sank deep into Shashank. He had practised this limit in the episodes on non-apprehension; now, in decision, it was time to accept the consequence of that limit.

Aditya read an old message in which Shashank had enlarged his reach before the foreign side by writing: “I will handle the local payment people.” Shashank’s face fell.

The officer asked, “What is this?”

“Boasting.”

“Only boasting?”

Shashank remained silent. He remembered his own answer from before—it was also an error to escape by calling everything performance. “No. It contains both a real capacity for coordination and the desire to make my role look larger. I did linguistically handle some lawful payment communications. But there is no independent sign that ‘all local payments’ were under my control.”

The officer said, “In that answer, did you reduce your fault?”

“No.”

“And enlarge it?”

“No. Only as far as it goes.”

At that moment Mrinal’s phone call vibrated in Shashank’s pocket, but he did not answer. His mind first ran ahead—his friend must be worried. Then he asked himself: am I about to hurry the decision because of friendship? He silenced the phone.

Before moving on, the officer placed Shashank’s own service-fee records before him again. “Your name is clear, the amount is clear, the service description is clear as well. If you wish, you can say: these are lawful service fees, therefore every economic question is closed.”

Shashank kept looking at the paper. “No. Lawful service fees do not establish criminal proceeds, but they do establish an economic relationship. After that, questions can still arise: what was the nature of the service, did the amount match the service, and are there separate signs of benefit-sharing or instruction? In the available record my fees are linked to translation and coordination; no independent sign of additional criminal benefit has yet been established.”

The officer said, “Then you kept the same rule even in your own favour—legality does not automatically close every question, and a relationship does not automatically establish a crime.”

Shashank understood how contrary this small answer was to the habits of his past years. Earlier he either enlarged a relationship to sell power, or when crisis came, shrank it into ‘only translation’. The difficulty of decision was to accept the true size of the relationship—neither more nor less.

Then the officer asked, “Suppose Mrinal himself says his name should be removed entirely from the file because he has been humiliated by this matter?”

Shashank replied, “Where his real name appears in a lawful reimbursement record, the name should not be removed. Where his identity was inferred only from ‘M.K.’, his name should not be attached as certain. Changing the record for the sake of dignity would also be an injustice to truth.”

Aditya and the officer looked at each other. This time Shashank understood—friendship does not only tempt one to shield a friend from blame; sometimes it tempts one to erase truthful traces merely to remove a beloved person's discomfort. Both temptations had to be restrained by the same standard.

Aditya read the final summary: "The available material establishes Shashank Jha's economic service relationship with the foreign vendor side, his linguistic/coordination role, and some risky self-promotional statements. Intermediary payment gateways and digital-asset references show an economic background warranting inquiry. However, on the basis of the independent records presently available, alleged control of a 'mule account', direction of hawala, a share in criminal proceeds, or beneficial control of digital assets by Shashank Jha or Mrinal Karn is not established. Identification of the initials 'M.K.' as Mrinal Karn is not established. The final legal conclusion will remain a matter for the court."

The officer asked, "Your objection?"

Shashank looked at the lines for a long time. At first his mind wanted the phrase 'risky self-promotion' removed. Then it wanted 'economic background warranting inquiry' removed as well. Both sentences reminded him of public humiliation. But the question was not whether the sentence hurt; the question was whether the evidence could bear it.

He said, "One correction. Put 'mule account' in quotation marks, because it is a category of allegation, not an established classification."

Aditya made the correction. "And anything else?"

"No."

The officer asked, "Anything for Mrinal?"

Shashank closed his eyes and opened them again. "No. Friendship is not the reason to remove his name; the reason is only that identification from initials is not established."

This time the officer closed the file. "Then the final test was not about money."

"What was it about?"

"The standard. When the standard fell upon your friend, did you change it or not?"

Shashank did not answer. A strange peace and pain rose within him together. Friendship had offered him a short road to defence; he had left it unused. Yet in refusing it there was not distance from Mrinal, but respect.

Outside, he opened his phone. There were three missed calls from Mrinal. Shashank called back.

Mrinal's first question was, "What happened?"

"The evidence presently available against you is not sufficient."

"That is all?"

Shashank smiled. "And also that I did not save you by declaring you innocent."

There was silence on the other end for a few moments. Then Mrinal said, "Then friendship survived today."

"Why? I did not take your side."

"That is why. If you had taken my side, you would have treated me as your man; by keeping the same standard, you treated me as a person."

Shashank stopped by the roadside. The crowd of a Delhi morning kept moving. He remembered an old lesson from Mithila—decision is not the killing of doubt; it is the proper ending of doubt. A question closed by evidence must be closed; one that remains open must not be closed by prestige, fear, or friendship.

In the evening Mrinal came to see him. The two sat in the veranda with glasses of tea. Mrinal said, "Did your Navya-Nyaya save you?"

Shashank shook his head. "From some allegations. In some places it showed me guilty too."

"Then did you pass the final test?"

"The court still remains."

"I was not asking about the court."

Shashank looked at him.

Mrinal said, "I asked whether you managed to apply the standard you created to yourself."

Shashank placed the glass of tea down. "Not earlier. Now I am trying."

That night he opened his notebook and wrote—

"Friendship = not a reason to reduce the weight of evidence."

"Initials = not a person."

"Lawful reimbursement = not automatically the disputed money path."

"Multiple payment media = not automatically hawala."

"Digital-asset reference = not automatically beneficial control."

"Service fee = economic relationship; a share in criminal proceeds requires separate evidence."

“Boasting = may show state of mind and some role; objective control requires independent markers.”

“Incomplete records = smaller decision.”

“Not taking a friend’s side, but applying the same standard to the friend = respect for friendship.”

“Decision = the courage to accept what is proved, not add what is unproved, and call what remains open by its true name.”

As he wrote the final line, his hand did not tremble: “The final test of Navya-Nyaya is not whether I can use reasoning to save my own name; the test is whether, even when a beloved name stands before me, I refuse to change the rules of reasoning.”

Closing the notebook, Shashank saw the final heading: “THE TRANSLATOR’S DECISION.” Now two Navya-Nyayas would stand before the court: one he had used for years, enlarging and shrinking words for his own advantage; the other that accepts the boundary of words, the weight of evidence, and silence where proof is absent. The next day the decision would concern not only the case, but the language inside the translator as well.

CHAPTER 100

THE TRANSLATOR'S DECISION

There was no unusual noise in the courtroom that morning. On a day of judgment people usually expect commotion, but what Shashank found most unbearable was the ordinariness of the place—the wooden benches, the sound of papers turning, the tips of pens, the steady hum of the fan. For months the story had spread through the media, statements, files, friendship, and fear; today it was to be given shape in a few limited sentences.

Mrinal sat at the back. Raghav Bhasin was some distance from him, his file closed. Aditya Mishra and the officer from the lower commissionerate in Mithila sat in the front row. For a moment Shashank thought—not everyone in this room had come carrying his own truth; everyone had come carrying his own record. Whether truth would be larger than their wishes, or smaller, would be decided by the discipline of judgment.

The Bench first made one thing clear: “The court does not decide upon a public narrative. The court decides upon the elements of the allegations, the available evidence, its reliability, and the conclusions that can validly be drawn from it.”

Something trembled inside Shashank. For a long time he had lived the opposite of that sentence. He looked at the effect of words, not their elements; at the impression made on the listener, not at the boundary of the statement.

In the first part of the judgment, the established facts were read out. Shashank had linguistic and business contact with foreign vendor-side entities; he had travelled to Macao; he had attended some meetings; he had received limited technical access; beyond translation he had also carried out coordination, risk-summary, and business-communication work; he had received service fees; in some of his own messages he had presented his role as larger than it really was. Lines such as “the legal side is clear”, “all the principal people come through me”, and “the final decision will not happen without me” appeared in his own records.

Shashank did not lower his head. Earlier, the moment he saw such lines, he would have searched for a way to alter their meaning. Today he merely listened.

The Bench continued: “In some business summaries, language of caution was presented as though it were broad approval. The accused himself has admitted that at times he shortened the original caution or made it sound decisive because clients wanted quick answers and he was tempted to display his authority over language. That conduct carries moral and professional weight. But this admission does not by itself establish that he was the owner, administrator, or criminal director of the entire economic structure.”

For a moment the room became completely still. Shashank understood—even his guilt was being given a boundary. The boundary was not forgiveness; the boundary was truth.

The second part turned to the broader allegations. Beneficial ownership. Administrative super-authority. Broad control of the server. Direction of intermediary accounts. Operation of a hawala route. Beneficial control of digital assets. The alleged proxy account of Mrinal Karn. The alleged criminal participation of Raghav Bhasin. Regular sourcing of sealed government material. Complete collusion within the tax-intelligence branch.

The Bench did not use the same language for every point. In some places it said “not proved”; elsewhere, “available evidence insufficient”; elsewhere, “absence of independent corroboration”; elsewhere, “suspicion warrants investigation but not conclusion.” The distinction struck Shashank as extraordinarily important. Earlier he used to melt everything into a single word—clear, certain, inside, ours. The court was keeping the words separate because the states of proof were separate.

The Macao trip was proved; the Macao trip did not prove ownership of the server. Limited access was proved; limited access did not prove administrative control. Service fees were proved; service fees did not prove a share in criminal proceeds. The initials “M.K.” were found; the initials did not prove that the person was Mrinal. The legal meeting with Raghav was proved; the meeting did not prove joint participation in a crime. The written objection of the lower commissionerate was proved; the record also showed that some cautions had become softer in the final summary; but the criminal cause of that change and the person responsible had not been established by independent evidence.

The Bench said: “A gap in evidence cannot be filled by imagination in favour of the accused; nor can the accused’s sense of guilt be filled by imagination in favour of the prosecution.”

For the first time Shashank looked towards Aditya. There was no victory on Aditya’s face. There was fatigue, and within that fatigue a kind of satisfaction—like someone who had measured a field and placed the boundary ridge exactly where it belonged.

Reading its decision on the prosecution's broader narrative, the Bench said: "Linguistic centrality and economic or administrative control are different relationships. Representation and ownership are different relationships. Access and control are different relationships. Similar wording and the same source are different questions. Multiple rewritings of one initial summary do not increase the number of independent confirmations."

Juliana's old voice rose inside Shashank: catching the meaning of a word is not enough; catch its relationship. He remembered the day in Pitampura when language had seemed like power. Then the crowd at the Red Fort, the classroom at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, the first Chinese sentence, the first contract, the first opportunity—all appeared for a moment like distant light. Talent had not been his crime. Making talent into a throne had been the beginning of his fall.

The third part of the judgment was the hardest for him. The Bench came to Shashank's own statements.

"The court does not accept that every exaggeration was merely innocent performance. The available records show that the accused knowingly broadened some statements in order to make his influence appear greater. In some places he presented caution as approval; in some places he sold his coordination role as decisive influence; when the crisis came, he also tried to shrink the same role excessively by calling it 'only translation'. This contradiction has judicial significance. It is an adverse fact in assessing his credibility, intention, and responsibility."

Shashank's chest grew heavy. This was the part from which he could not run. The broad false allegations were being cut away, but his own false enlargements were not being protected along with them.

The Bench continued: "But adverse credibility does not by itself prove every external allegation. The elements necessary for a punishable conclusion must be independently established. Moral deceit, professional exaggeration, and criminal conspiracy are not the same category."

Raghav slowly put down his pen. Shashank looked at him. For months one fear had remained inside him—that his language of 'the lawyer agrees' might leave a burden on Raghav's name greater than Shashank's own guilt. The judgment was clear: responsibility for Shashank's summary belonged to Shashank; Raghav's criminal participation required separate evidence, and that had not been established.

The decision concerning Mrinal was brief, but for Shashank it carried enormous weight. The records of lawful reimbursement were available. Independent confirmation identifying the disputed 'M.K.' as Mrinal did not exist. The Bench said: "Friendship proves neither innocence nor guilt. A punishable relationship cannot be determined from an inferred identity."

Shashank's eyes filled, but he neither suppressed the tears nor displayed them. Mrinal remained seated at the back; in that moment there was no need for drama between them.

The final conclusion was read. The allegations of broad financial control, beneficial ownership, direction of proxy accounts, operation of hawala, control of digital assets, criminal participation by the legal adviser, regular sourcing of sealed material, and pervasive institutional collusion were not proved by the available evidence. Shashank's real linguistic-coordination role, service relationships, limited access, some risk summaries, self-promotion, enlargement of role, and some misleading broad presentations were established by the records. Where the legal elements of an allegation were satisfied by that established conduct, responsibility was accepted to that extent; where the elements were not satisfied, the court refused to fill the gaps with the broader narrative.

The Bench's final comment was very short: "Justice does not write the complete story of an accused person's character. Justice says only as much as the evidence gives it the authority to say."

On hearing the sentence, nothing inside Shashank broke; something settled into place. For months he had imagined judgment as either liberation or destruction. It was neither. Judgment was shape. Some guilt would remain with him. Some humiliation too. The media headlines might never be fully rewritten. The story people had attached to his name would not disappear in a day. But the court denied him one convenience—he could not declare all his disgrace false and pronounce himself pure. And it denied him one injustice as well—it would not turn his shame into evidence and place unproved crimes upon his head.

The courtroom began to empty. Outside was the long court veranda, where people were already constructing different meanings from the judgment. A journalist tried to ask a question, but Shashank did not stop. Aditya came near him.

Shashank asked, "Did you win?"

Aditya shook his head. "An investigation does not win. It either respects the boundary, or breaks it."

"And me?"

"The court gave you the question. Your life will give the answer."

The officer from the lower commissionerate also came over. Looking at him, Shashank said, "At one time I thought you were one of my own. Then you seemed like an enemy."

The officer smiled. "And now?"

Shashank thought for a few moments. “Now I understand—the standard that protects me is the same standard that must cut me as well. To call it friend or enemy would be the old error again.”

Raghav greeted him from a distance and left. There was no triumph on his face. Shashank understood that inserting someone’s name wrongly into one’s own story is also a form of violence; later saying ‘I was only giving a summary’ does not lessen its burden.

Mrinal came last. They walked some distance without speaking. As they descended the stairs, Mrinal asked, “So what happened?”

Shashank said, “What was proved remained. What was not proved was cut away.”

“Was your name saved?”

“No.” For the first time Shashank smiled without bitterness. “The stains on my name that were mine remained. What others had added without proof was cut away.”

Mrinal said, “Then justice was harsh.”

“Yes. That is why there is peace.”

Outside, the morning light had grown strong. Shashank remembered the veranda of his village, where as a student he used to separate one relationship from another in order to understand Gangesh’s sentences. At the time he had thought that if a definition were subtle enough, the world could be caught. Delhi had given him another lesson—subtle definition can also become an instrument of deceit if a person cuts and trims it according to his own advantage. For Navya-Nyaya to become a method of truth, discipline of character must come before reasoning.

That evening he sat down to write in the notebook one last time. On its pages were very old formulations—perception, inference, analogy, testimony, postulation, non-apprehension, reasoning, decision. Beside each word some event from his life had become attached. He opened a fresh page.

“Translation = not authority over the original; responsibility towards the original.”

“Talent = not privilege; a duty of greater care.”

“Linguistic centrality = not economic control.”

“Shame = not a reason to accept an unproved crime.”

“Atonement = not making my proved fault smaller.”

“False allegation = not an excuse to erase my real fault.”

“Decision = accepting the boundary of evidence and restraining the mind’s partiality.”

“Navya-Nyaya = not the art of winning with words; the discipline of not breaking the boundary of relationships.”

For a long time he could not write the final line. Earlier he would have wanted the final sentence to be beautiful. Then he laughed. Beauty was another temptation. Truth was enough.

He wrote: “I was a translator; I thought that bending words towards my own side was authority over language. Now I understand—the translator’s decision begins on the day he keeps a word not on his own side, but within its proper boundary.”

He put down the pen and closed the notebook. Outside, the sounds of Delhi continued. Inside there was no proclamation of victory, no complete release. There was only the hard quiet after justice—in which a person neither runs from his own fault nor carries the weight of another person’s accusation without evidence.

THE TRANSLATOR

From Mithila to Delhi, from language classrooms and vendor rooms to Macao and the courtroom, Shashank Jha learns that translation is never merely the movement of words. A gifted interpreter of Chinese and a student of Navya-Nyaya, he rises through precision—then begins to fall when precision becomes performance, access becomes prestige, and careful distinctions are made to serve ambition.

The Translator is a literary novel about language, evidence, friendship, moral responsibility and the discipline of saying only what the facts permit. Its final reckoning asks whether a person can apply the same standard to his own guilt, to the accusations made against him, and to the people he loves.

“Justice says only as much as the evidence gives it the authority to say.”

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